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MAĀANI ABU AL-MAKAREM IBN BARAKAT

This man was among the prominent Copts in the time of the Ayyubid dynasty (1171-1260 AD). He was a Coptic scribe from the city of El-Maḥala el-Kubra. Most probably, he was of a Syrian origin and became a Copt through mixed marriages when his folks came to settle down in the land of Egypt. At the time, there was in the cities of Sunbat and El-Maḥala el-Kubra, a large congregation of Syrians, who mixed with the Copts through marriages and their offspring, became Egyptian Copts.

Abu al-Makarem lived long; and wrote down the biographies of the 73rd Pope Marcus III (Ibn Zarāa: 1166-1189 AD) and the 74th Pope Yoannes VI (1189-1216 AD). He also wrote at length about the events of the Ayyubid wars in the history of those patriarchs.

[The Patriotism of the Coptic Church and its History, p. 177]

MACARIUS, BISHOP OF JERUSALEM, ST.

His Role in Finding the Glorious Cross:

Emperor Constantine the Great (306-337 AD) wrote a letter to St. Macarius the bishop of Jerusalem (314-335 AD), in which he entrusted the bishop to build a church on the location where the emperor's mother Empress Helena (312-330 AD) discovered the Cross of the Lord Jesus Christ around the year 327 AD. The content of that letter was kept in the book of Eusebius¹: 'The Church History.' The emperor tasked the bishop with the responsibility of selecting the design, the workers, and the tools needed to build that church. St. Macarius lived long enough until he finished building that magnificent cathedral. According to the testimony of the 20th pope of Alexandria St. Athanasius the Apostolic (328-373 AD), this St. Macarius was an upright faithful man, filled with the true apostolic spirit. He succeeded bishop Hermon (300-314 AD) in the year 314 AD on the seat of Jerusalem, at the time when the heresy of Arius started to threaten the church. From the

¹ 'Eusebius' (~260-340 AD), the bishop of Caesarea was a 4th century pioneer who gave a chronological account of the development of Early Christianity from the 1st century to the 4th century...

testimony of St. Athanasius, we also know that St. Macarius proved to be one of the heroes of faith; and he was the head of the Palestinian bishops' delegation who attended the Nicene Council in 325 AD.

According to the tradition, St. Macarius was not only present when the glorious Cross was discovered, but he positively helped to identify it. When the workers uncovered three crosses during the excavations and could not distinguish which one was the Cross of the Lord among them; they checked with St. Macarius who was the bishop of the city at that time, and it happened that near-by in Jerusalem; there was a sick person on the brink of death. So, St. Macarius brought the ill person from the city and said: "Bring the three crosses over here, and the Lord will tell us which of them is His Cross," that was while Empress Helena and the others were standing next to him. Then, he approached the sick person, knelt on the ground praying: "My God, who through Your Son, You inspired the hearts of Your servants to discover the Holy Wood, by which was our Salvation; show us which of them is Your Cross, by which was You saved Your servants. Once it touches this person, grant him the healing, and save him from death." After finishing his prayer, they carried the person and let her touch the first and second crosses, but his condition did not change. However, when he touched the third and final Cross, he suddenly recovered and was restored to his strength, glorified God. St. Macarius and empress Helena declared that the Cross with which the sick person had been recovered to be the True Cross.

Building the Holy Sepulcher Church and His Departure:

Being sure that this was the right Cross, Empress Helena gave the order of building a magnificent Cathedral on that location. That Cathedral was completed on the 13th of September 335 AD; the same year St. Macarius reposed after he supervised its building until the end.

[Butler: March 10]

MACARIUS I, The 59th POPE OF ALEXANDRIA

Pope Macarius I (932-952 AD) was born in a village called Shubra-Khit near Alexandria. However, he left his parent's house to enjoy the tranquility of the desert and became a monk in the monastery of St. Macarius the Great by the name of Macary. His fame spread as being a monk of great asceticism and contemplation, characteristics that impressed the hearts of all who came to know him. When the 58th Pope Cosmas III (920-932 AD) reposed in the year 932 AD, the whole congregation unanimously chose to ordain him as a patriarch. A delegation of bishops and archons went to the monastery of St.

Macarius the Great, got hold of him, and took him to Alexandria, where he was ordained in the year 932 AD (648 AM).

His Pastoral Visits:

The first step he made was arranging a pastoral trip to visit his people and get to know their conditions on first-hand bases. During that trip, he passed through Shubra-Khit, his home town and went to the house where he spent his childhood. There, he found his mother sitting by the door weaving wool. He greeted her warmly, but she responded to his greeting even without raising her eyes toward him. He said to her: "Peace on you mother. Don't you know who I am? I am your son who left you to spend my life in the monastery as a worshipping monk, but the Divine grace granted me to sit on the seat of St. Mark our beloved preacher." His mother then raised her eyes and looked at him, with a flood of tears flowing from her eyes. He became very disturbed and asked her what was wrong. Then, she answered him: "Yes. You have indeed got a great honor, yet its responsibility is so enormously serious. When you were a simple monk, you were only responsible for yourself, but now, sitting on the seat of St. Mark the Apostle, you became accountable for the whole people of the See of St. Mark. I could not help crying, supplicating to the Almighty God, who entrusted you with such an enormous task, to cover you with His grace and to help you carry your vast responsibilities." Abba Macarius was shaken to the core for his mother's remarks, which he was sure of their truthfulness. So, he spent the rest of his life teaching the people and urging them to keep reading the Bible and the teachings of the fathers.

During his papacy, a new governor came to Egypt as a vassal of the Abbasid caliphate, and his name was Muḥammad ibn Tughj al-Ikhshid (935-946), he arrived in August 935. At that time, Egypt has reached the climax of chaos and confusion because of the intense competition between the ruling princes and what their soldiers caused by robbing, confiscating, and murdering without mercy. Al-Ikhshid managed to restore tranquility, stability, and prosperity; and to establish order during the eleven years of his rule.

The Pope's Care for Construction:

During a period of stability which dwelt on the land, the pope carried out a second pastoral trip in which he visited the wilderness of the Scetis. There, he stayed for several weeks. His heart was rejoiced to see the increase in the number of monks, despite some chaos and tribulations, but the pope was disturbed the most by observing that the elder fathers of the monastery of Abba Yêhnes Kama regularly traveled to pray in the church of the monastery of Abba Yoannes the Short because they had no church in their monastery.

There and then, he decided to build a church for them in their monastery and instantly started the project. While the work was going on, the pope had to go back to his headquarters to celebrate the glorious feast of Epiphany. Once those celebrations came to an end, he returned to the Scetis to consecrate the church of Abba Yehnes Kama.

Taking the chance of the peace dwelling on Egypt, the pope of Alexandria got busy with constructing many churches. St. Macarius I spent twenty years caring for his flock and striving hard, yet he never forgot the tears of his mother and her words when she received him at the beginning of his papacy.

[The Story of the Coptic Church, Bk 2, p. 486]

[The Coptic Encyclopedia: Macarius I, by Subhi Y. Labib; p. 1487]

MACARIUS II, the 69th POPE OF ALEXANDRIA

Pope Macarius II (1102-1128 AD) was a monk in the monastery of St. Macarius. He was ordained as a patriarch in the year 1102 AD. Even though he sat on the throne of St. Mark for about twenty-six years, yet during that long period, only two significant events took place:

1. After he sat on the throne, the bishop of Cairo departed, and this pope planned to join the bishopric of Cairo under him, rather than ordaining another bishop on it. Therefore, the archons of Cairo assembled and declared to the pope: “As long as a Christian cannot have two wives, then it is not allowed for a bishop to have two bishoprics. Abba Macarius is the bishop of Alexandria, so how could he be the bishop of Cairo as well?”

In their gathering, they thought about who would be fitting to become the bishop of Cairo, a position which was considered the second-ranking after the patriarch. They ended up choosing four men; the most prominent among them was Marcora al-Ĥebby of Abiar. They performed a Divine Liturgy, then made a lot between the four candidates and asked a very young deacon to pick up one of the names. The deacon picked the one which carried the name of Yoannes Ibn Senhout. They recorded the incident in a special report, which they sent to the pope along with a message from Cairo's congregation. In that way, the ordination of the bishop of Cairo was officially done. This incident demonstrated the people's right to choose their bishop, a matter which was recognized by the patriarchs.

2. During his papacy, the first Crusade Campaign attacked Egypt; when Baldwin, the king of the Latin Jerusalem, invaded Egypt in the year 1106 AD. He reached Al-Farama on the eastern border of Egypt and killed its people without discrimination between Muslims and Christians. He set the city ablaze and then continued his advance until he reached Tanis. However,

he returned because he got inflicted with a fatal illness.

An exciting event was recorded by the biographer¹ in the 'History of the Patriarchs' from the 5th year of the patriarchate of Pope Macarius II that had a direct bearing on the history of the Crusades. What was significant about this was the evidence of the feeling of the Copts toward the crusading movement and specifically Baldwin's expedition. He wrote: "God protected us from his deeds. We asked Him, whose Name is great, to perpetuate His mercy and His grace; and to inspire us to give thanks to Him and to cause us not to forget the remembrance of Him through His goodness and glory."

The papacy of Abba Macarius II was almost identical to that of the 10th Fatimid caliph Al-Aamer bi-Ahkam Allah (1101-1130 AD). The last significant event of the caliphate to be cited by the 'History of the Patriarchs' was an attempt at the end of the year 1121 AD by three youths from the east to assassinate the caliph's minister Al-Afdal ibn Shahinshah. That minister was a wise man who treated the Copts well. However, the jealousy of the caliph towards the vast influence of that minister, caused him to conspire on that crime. Two of those youths were cut down by the swords of his bodyguards, but the third managed to strike Al-Afdal with a sharp knife, and he was carried home to die of his wound. The caliph, who participated in his funeral, returned to seize the immense wealth he left behind, which included jewels, gold and silver objects, precious textiles and robes, the furniture that filled his palace and bags filled with four million gold dinars.

It is to be also mentioned that the caliph Al-Aamer, used to often visit the Nahya² monastery northwest of the Giza district, to spend several days there, and every time he visited the monastery, he used to grant its monks 1,000 dirhams. He also gave on his first visit to the monastery about thirty acres of land for cultivation. The sum of what he donated to the monastery had reached 30,000 dirhams. Pope Macarius II reposed in the year 1128 AD.

[The Patriotism of the Coptic Church and its History, p. 142]
[The Coptic Encyclopedia: Macarius II, by Subhi Y. Labib; pp. 1487-8]

MACARIUS III, The 114th POPE OF ALEXANDRIA

Pope Macarius III (1944-1945) was born in El-Mahalla el-Kubra in the year 1872. He became a monk in the monastery of Abba Bishoi in the Natron

¹ This big historical document began by 'Severus Ibn al-Muqaffa'. It was continued by others including 'Michael', bishop of Tinnis (11th century, writing in Coptic, covering 880 to 1046), 'Mawhub ibn Mansur ibn Mufarrig', deacon of Alexandria and pope 'Mark III' of Alexandria (for 1131 to 1167).

² The Coptic Encyclopedia: Dayr Nahya, by Rene-Georges Coquin & M. Martin; p. 843-4.

Valley by the name of Ābdel-Messiḥ in the year 1888. He was ordained as a priest in the year 1892. In the year 1895, the 112th Pope Abba Kyrillos V (1874-1927), raised him to the rank of hegomen and appointed him as his secretary. Then, he ordained him as the metropolitan of Assiut in the year 1897 by the name of Abba Macarius.

He was characterized by great asceticism. He needed money to buy the necessary food, for he distributed all that he would get of offerings on constructing schools, churches, and helping the poor. In the year 1911, Abba Macarius called for holding a Coptic convention in Assiut for ecclesiastical reform, and in the year 1920, he presented to Pope Kyrillos V a document listing an ambitious plan of improvement, incorporating the following points:

- 1- Setting up a theological college in one of the monasteries to provide the church with suitably qualified clergy.
- 2- Establishing a supreme council to run all the Coptic properties given to the church.
- 3- Organizing ecclesiastical affairs under the direction of the pope and in collaboration with a group of bishops and spiritual leaders.
- 4- Forming an education committee at the patriarchate to supervise the teaching of the Coptic language and religious instruction.
- 5- Keeping an up-to-date register of low-income families.

After he continued serving in his diocese in Assiut for about forty-seven years, he was ordained as a patriarch in the year 1944, two years after the repose of the 113th pope Abba Yoannes XIX (1928-1942).

A Controversy between the Pope and the ‘Melli Council’¹:

During his short papacy, a controversy about the reforms irrupted between the pope and the Melli Council. Unable to reconcile with the opposing camp, the embittered pope withdrew to the monastery of St. Antony in the eastern desert. A few months later, at the request of some bishops and men of goodwill in the government, he agreed to return to his seat. However, the controversy continued until the pope reposed on the 31st of August 1945.

Of the eighteen months that formed his patriarchate, Pope Macarius III spent six months in retreat in the desert monastery as a result of this schism that prevented him from undertaking his long-hoped-for reform.

[The Patriotism of the Coptic Church and its History, p. 410]

[The Story of the Coptic Church, Bk.6, p. 140 & 174]

[The Coptic Encyclopedia: Macarius III, by Mounir Shoucri; p. 1488-9]

¹ A Council of Coptic Archons Chosen by the people of the church in Cairo. Another council, the Archons Chosen by the people of the church in Alexandria.

MACARIUS MAGNES

This saint was among the men who lived at the beginning of the 5th century. He was one of the apologists who advocated for Christianity. He probably was the bishop of Magnesia. He was the author of the work ‘Apocriticus,’¹ which was written in the form of a dialogue between a pagan and a Christian. His work included the lost material generated by Porphyry,² who attacked the Christian Faith and the Scriptures in detail. The reproduction of Porphyry's material in the ‘Apocriticus’ preserved for us a form of anti-Christian literature in a fullness that had no parallel.

[E. Ferguson: *Encyclopedia of the Early Church*]

MACARIUS OF ALEXANDRIA, ST.

This father was a contemporary of St. Macarius the Great, the father of monks; hence, he sometimes was called Macarius Minor. This saint became a monk in a monastery near Alexandria, and because of his advanced asceticism, he came to be the father and guide of all the cell-dwellers in Nitria, near Alexandria. He was called ‘The Father of the Cells.’ His recluse followers reached 5,000 in number, and they benefited greatly from his virtue, sanctity, and wisdom. When the place got full of monks, the saint left Nitria to a new location, the Scetis, which was situated a little deeper into the western desert and has a stricter nature than the previous one. He was followed there by a number of his closest disciples.

His Upbringing:

He was born in Alexandria around the year 300 AD to poor parents. He was short, beardless, with a thin mustache, and earned his living by working as a baker for several years.

The saint was baptized when he reached forty years of age. Then, he decided to forsake everything in the world. So, he went to see St. Anthony the Great (251-356 AD) in the eastern desert and became one of his disciples for a short while. Then, he became a monk in the Natron Valley in the days of St. Macarius the Great (295-392 AD). He then set forth to Kellia³ in the desert to the south of Alexandria, a desolate place, with no roads of any kind, no trace of any living creature. It was located between Nitria and the Scetis, fifteen kilometers south of Nitria, and 120 kilometers north of the Scetis.

¹ [www.tertullian.org/fathers/macarius_apocriticus.htm] ‘The Apocriticus of Macarius Magnes’ By T. W. Crafer, D.D. Society for Promoting Christian Knowledge, London, The Macmillan Co, NY, 1919.

² ‘Porphyry,’ was a famous Neoplatonist philosopher in the 3rd century...

³ See: *The Coptic Encyclopedia: Kellia*, by Marguerite Rassart-Debergh; p. 1397...

His Asceticism and Worship:

He practiced several worship schemes, had great virtues, and trained into exalted asceticism, such as remaining for a whole five days with his mind entranced in heaven.

After spending some time managing schools for the seekers of baptism, he retreated to the desert of Nitra, where he became the Abbot of the monasteries over there. That area used to be called 'The Place of Cells.'

It happened once that while walking in the wilderness along a strange road, he kept poking sticks in the ground to help him find his way back, and when he tried to go back, he found out that the devil removed those sticks hoping that he would get lost. He spent so much time until he found his way back, in the process, he got so thirsty, but God sent him a cow, to drink from its milk. Then, He helped him find his way back to his cell.

Encouraging the Pachomian Monks to Work:

Later on, St. Macarius heard about the Pachomian monastery in Tabansin near Luxor in Upper Egypt, and how its monks serve the people with the spirit of piety under the guidance of the great Abba Pachom, the father of the Cenobia (Monastic Fellowship). So, he changed his clothes to those of a farmer; then, he set forth to that monastery on foot. It took him about fifteen days to get there. When he arrived, he asked to meet with St. Pachom, whom God hid from him the identity of St. Macarius.

Then, he told St. Pachom: "Father, I beg you to accept me in your monastery, for I might probably become a monk." Abba Pachom answered him: "I see you are an aged man and your body is frail, you might not be able to practice the harsh piety along with the ascetic brethren or to endure the continuous training they go through. You most probably would tumble and leave us, and then you end up talking against them. You rather go and stay in our hospitality house, remain there, and you will be fed until you decide to return." So, St. Pachom refused to allow him to live among the monks on the first day, the second day, until the seventh day. During those days, St. Macarius did not eat any food. Then, he went to see St. Pachom, and told him: "Accept me father; and if you find that I do not fast, practice asceticism or do my hand-work; then you may kick me out of your monastery."

St. Pachom sent him to live among the brethren monks, who were almost 1,400 in number. There, he spent with them the Holy Forty days. During those days, he was never seen eating nor sitting down; but always standing weaving the palm-leaves. Then, the brethren monks complained to Abba Pachom saying: "Where did you find such a person? Send this man away, for he has nobody. Did you bring him here to humiliate us? Send him away;

otherwise, we all shall escape from here.” St. Pachom answered them: “Just wait for a little while until God reveals to us his identity.” Then, St. Pachom requested from God to reveal to him the identity of that man, and God informed him that he was Macarius of Alexandria.

Then, after the Holy Liturgy, Abba Pachom brought St. Macarius to their gathering spot so that all the monks would see him. Then, he said to him: “Come over here, you honorable elder. How could that happen? You have hidden from us that you are Abba Macarius. For a long time, I have heard about you and longed to see you in person. In any case, I do thank you for teaching us, particularly, the young monks, how not to boast about their pious deeds even if they did their best; for they will never reach the measure of the Forty Days spent by our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ the Son of the Living God; or the standard of your pious deeds. Now man, go back in peace to your place, for you have taught us and guided all of us enough. Pray on our behalf.” The monastery's monks, greatly rejoiced, sought the saint's blessing and prayers for them. Then, Abba Macarius left them to go back to his monastery.

With Lydia the Recluse:

On hearing about this saint, a hermit called Lydia, who was an ascetic writer, came to see him from Thessalonica in Greece. She remained for a whole year in a cave near-by. She used to meet with Abba Macarius, to have the benefit of the guidance and the prayers of this saint. However, she was not seen by anyone in the mountain until the day she left the wilderness to go back to her country glorifying God.

His Struggle:

In the meantime, St. Macarius strove to humiliate himself more than all the other hermits, proclaiming that he was the lowest among them. Hearing that some monks refrained from eating any cooked food during Lent; he did the same and sustained himself by vegetables for seven years, and understanding that a monk kept crumbles of bread in a pitcher, from which he ate only what his hand would get through its narrow opening; he decided to follow suit. If he would hear that someone was practicing a specific virtue that he did not try, he would not have peace until he would master it more than the others. Once, he decided to overcome sleep, so he refrained from entering into his cell for ten consecutive days and nights without any rest.

He considered the virtue which would become known and publicly proclaimed, as useless. He had three cells in the Scetis: The first was in the middle of the tremendous inner desert, with no door, for nobody could reach it anyway, and it was too narrow to stretch his feet while asleep. The second

was in the middle of the wilderness of the Scetis, and the third was not far from the inhabited area.

His Transparency:

The disciple of St. Macarius narrated about him, saying: “I was told by my spiritual father: ‘No Saturday or Sunday pass without me seeing the altar angel near me, while I am offering the Sacrifice.’” Besides, it was repeatedly said that whenever the saint used to enter the Holy Sanctuary to consecrate the Holy Sacraments, he would see how it was full of angels and saints, and he used to become overwhelmed by profound fear and awe.

His Fight against the Vainglory:

Troubled by thoughts of pride and love of vainglory, as the evil planted thoughts that kept provoking him to go to Rome, the land of the emperors, to heal their sick, he sat at the entrance of his cell and dared the demons, saying: “If you have enough power, move me by force from here.”

Also, when the demons pressed him harder, he cried out in anger: “I have already told you that I do not have legs anymore; if you have the power, carry me to Rome. Otherwise, I shall stay here until sunset.”

Again, when he was disturbed by these same evil thoughts in the middle of the night, he got out of his cell carrying a big basket he filled with about eight gallons of sand, and he kept wandering in the desert while carrying that big load. Then, when the brethren saw him, they asked: “O father, why should you do such a thing? Why would you tire yourself?” The saint answered them, “I tire who tires me; because if I give him comfort, he would bring vain thoughts to my mind, and provoke me to go outside.” He then kept walking in the desert all night and came back to his cell, dead tired.

The Bunch of Grapes:

It happened once that someone brought to St. Macarius a splendid bunch of grapes, which he has not tasted for so long. Yet he overcame his desire and gave the bunch to a sick brother, who, in turn, gave it to another, counting him more in need for it. The bunch of grape kept on being carried from one cell to another until finally it was brought back intact to St. Macarius, who rejoiced in the lovely relationships between the monks. (Some believe that this incident happened to St. Macarius the Great).

His Miracles:

The saint managed to heal a countless number of sick people and those who were possessed by evil spirits. He was granted that power that by merely making the sign of the Holy Cross on those people, they would get healed.

Once, a hyena came to his cell and attempted to drag him by his robe. He followed it to its cave, where it brought its three handicapped cubs to the saint. Amazed at the wisdom of that beast, he prayed, put his hand on the three cubs, healed them, and went his way to his cell. After a while, the hyena came back holding by its mouth a piece of leather hide, which the saint kept using as a floor-mat until the day he reposed.

When it happened that there was no rain in Alexandria for an extended period, he was called over by the pope. Once he reached the papal residence, the rain started pouring and kept on until they sought from the saint to stop it. He then prayed, and it did.

Healing a Priest from Cancer:

Once, a priest who was afflicted with Cancer which caused the bones of his face to be exposed and made him look extremely horrible; came to St. Macarius, and cast himself down at his feet, asking him to pray on his behalf, but the saint turned his face away from him. Those present implored the saint, saying: "Father, have mercy on the man, look at him and respond to his request." The saint answered them, saying: "Leave him alone, he does not deserve to be healed, for he enters into the Holy Place of Sacrifice while he is defiled." The priest kept begging the saint for three days until he finally had compassion upon his tears. The saint called him and said: "Do you know why God brought this punishment on you?" The priest answered him: "Yes, I do, father." The saint said: "As long as you perceive your sins, then repent to be saved," and he sought from the man to forsake his priesthood work to be saved from the eternal torment. When the man promised that he would do that, the saint anointed his face and head with holy oil, and God healed him. The man then sought permission to go, saying: "I shall stay among the people as a layman until the day I die."

His Cell was Robbed:

When a famine dwelt on the land, some Libyan thieves wandering in the desert came to the saint's cell, while he was not there. They took all his hand-work made of palm leaves, and the vessels he used to give hospitality to his guests. When they were about to go their way, their camel could not stand up on its feet and kept moaning until the morning.

Abba Macarius in his way back to his cell, saw them and he assumed that they came to provide him with the needs of the monks, but soon he realized that they were thieves. They prostrated themselves to the ground before him, and he did not get angry, but entered into his cell and brought them a vessel of pickled olives, which they missed because it was hidden behind the door. He said to them: "Do you want to know why your camel could not get up?"

They said: “Yes!” He told them: “Because you have forgotten to take with you this jar of pickled olives.” He insisted on giving it to them, in addition to all that they had already taken. Putting all that on the camel, it did stand up, and the saint let them go in peace.

On the next day, some brethren came from far away and sought from Abba Macarius something to eat. As there was nothing left in his cell; he told them: “There are four loaves of bread in your bags, bring them here, for us to eat; for what was in the cell, God gave to some laymen, to feed their poor wives and children in the current famine.”

His Mind Taken Up to Heaven:

St. Macarius entered into his faraway cell in the inner desert, in order not to encounter anyone. However, the enemy-of-good kept viciously attacking him, sometimes in the form of a lion about to tear his flesh with his claws, and other times in the form of snakes winding themselves around his legs, and also as tongues of fire that were burning everything around him, but God rewarded him by letting his mind enjoy heaven for a whole five days. Then, he resumed his healthy life to avoid falling into the sin of pride.

In the ‘Doxology’ sung on his feast (6 Bashons), it says: “The dark caves where you dwelt, O Abba Macarius, testify to how you are worthy to stand before God for five days and five nights, while your mind was in heaven, singing praise together with the angels, the heavenly hosts and all the hosts of saints glorifying the Holy Trinity. Pray on our behalf, O Abba Macarius, and all your children the Cross-Bearers, that God may forgive our sins.”

His Exile and Repose:

St. Macarius was exiled at the age of seventy-three by the Arian Emperor Valens (364-378 AD), to one of the Nile islands in Upper Egypt, along with St. Macarius the Great. In their exile, they suffered much torture for three years by orders from the evil emperor. The inhabitants of that island were idol-worshippers, and their highly respected pagan priest happened to have his daughter possessed by an unclean spirit. When the prayers of these two saints promptly healed her, many inhabitants on the island believed in the Lord Jesus Christ, and these two saints taught the inhabitants the Christian Faith until they returned to their monasteries.

St. Macarius continued his life in this spiritual path until he reached the right old age of ninety-five years. Then, he reposed in peace in the year 395.

St. Palladius, the historian, visited him with whom he had a close friendship. At the time of his repose, St. Palladius sat at the door of his cell to hear what he had to say. He heard him addressing himself, saying: “What do you want, O evil old man Macarius? You are already drinking wine and using

oil. What else do you want?" Then, he was addressing a devil, saying: "Do you have anything against me? No! You will not find in me anything belonging to you. Get away from me." Then, he addressed his body, saying: "Come on, O traitor horse. Do not be scared, as long as I am in you."

His Writings:

He had so many laws, published in Paris in the year 1637. He also had letters about 'The Souls of the Righteous after Death,' published in Switzerland in the year 1696.

Of his Words:

- Since the day I became a monk, I never ate bread to satisfaction, nor slept to delight. None of the brave fathers fell ill; because they controlled their bodies, according to the reasonable limits.

[The Synaxarion: 6 Pashons]
[Yousef Habib: St. Macarius of Alexandria; 1970]

MACARIUS, THE BISHOP (The martyr)

He was the bishop of Edku, in the district of Rosetta in the province of Beheira, Egypt. He was one of the three saintly Maqars. He was exiled along with the 25th Pope St. Dioscorus (444-454 AD), after the Chalcedonian Council. He showed such a great zeal on the Orthodox Faith, and he held fast to the Orthodox doctrines, that Pope Dioscorus secretly smuggled him from his exile and sent him back to Alexandria to support the believers.

On his arrival there, he found a delegate of Emperor Marcian (450-457 AD), carrying the 'Leo's Tome,' trying to convince the fathers to accept it and sign it. When the delegate sought from St Macarius to do so, he refused and provoked the others not to accept it and to hold fast to the faith of their fathers. Provoked to anger, the emperor's delegate kicked him with his foot, so strongly, that the old saint fell instantly dead.

[The Martyrdom in Christianity; p. 80]

MACARIUS, THE GREAT, ST.

St. Macarius (~ 295-392 AD) was the founder of monasticism in the wilderness of the Scetis. He was influenced considerably by St. Anthony the Great, whom he visited twice.

He was called by the historian Socrates (380-450 AD) 'The Chosen Vessel,' and Palladius (364-425 AD) said about him that he was worthy to

possess such great discernment at the age of thirty, that he was called the 'Aged Youth.' He was granted the gift of healing the sick and the gift of foreseeing the future. Based on a decree issued by Emperor Valens (364-378 AD), the Arian bishop Lucius exiled the saint to an island in the Nile in Upper Egypt. As the saint was at a very advanced age, he reposed shortly after returning from exile.

His Upbringing and Marriage:

This saint was born in Shubshir in the district of Menouf to pious and righteous parents. His father, Ibrahim, had no children. Then one night, he saw someone sent by the Lord, who told him that the Lord will give him a son whose fame would spread around the whole world and whom God will give spiritual children. After a little time, he was given a boy he called Macara, (meaning the blessed), who was obedient to his parents, and on whom the grace of God dwelt since his childhood.

The young man Macarius was chosen by the priests and the people of the village to be a reader in their church. Once he reached maturity, his father got him married against his will. So, Macarius pretended to be ill for a few days, then asked his father's permission to go to the wilderness to recover. He prayed to the Lord Jesus Christ to help him proceed according to His will. In the wilderness, he saw a vision, as though a Cherub with six wings held his hand, brought him up to the top of the mountain, and showed him the entire wilderness, north, south, east, and west. Then, he told him: "God says to you that he has granted you and your spiritual children this whole mountain, to dedicate all your time for worship. Many leaders will come to this wilderness. Watch then, and remember what I am telling you: If you walked uprightly, I shall appear to you, and proclaim God's words to you." It was said that this Cherub accompanied St. Macarius almost all his life.

When Macarius returned from the wilderness, he found out that his wife has died while still a virgin. He gave thanks to the Lord Jesus Christ, and when his parents died, he distributed all his inheritance to the poor and the needy. The people of Shebshir noticed his purity and chastity and took him to the bishop of Ashmon, who ordained him as a priest on the village church. They built for him a place outside the town, to which they came to get his blessings; and assigned someone to sell his handwork, and to get him his needs.

After a little while, he went to another village, for he counted himself unworthy of the priesthood or the honor his people were giving him.¹

¹ Some manuscripts mentioned that St. 'Macarius' did not get the grace of priesthood until he went to the Scetis.

In The Scetis:

On observing how virtuous the saint was, the devil brought on him a horrible trial; that he provoked a girl who committed evil with a young man to claim that it was St. Macarius who did it to her. Her folks insulted and beaten him violently, while he endured in silence. When it was time for that girl to deliver, she remained suffering in backbreaking labor for four days; until she confessed that she has falsely accused the innocent saint and proclaimed the name of the young man who seduced her. On hearing this, the relatives of the girl went to the saint, asking for his forgiveness for their aggression against him. St. Macarius escaped from them, to avoid the worldly glory. He was then in his thirties. Then, he decided not to return to his cell, so the angel of the Lord appeared to him, took him for a walk for two days until they reached the Natrun Valley. There, the saint said to the angel: "O master, designate a place for me to live." The angel answered: "No! Lest you decide to leave it later on and would be considered disobedient to the Lord. The whole wilderness is yours; dwell wherever you want." He dwelt in the inner wilderness, in the location where the monastery of St. Maximus and St. Domitius was built. It is known nowadays as the Baramus monastery.

When he went to visit St. Anthony the Great, he said about St. Macarius when he saw him: "Behold, an Israelite indeed, in whom there is no deceit." Then, St. Anthony set him with the holy Eskeem¹ and he returned to the Scetis. Later on, when the number of the monks who gathered around St. Macarius became too many, he built for them a church. His fame spread that even the kings heard about him because of the many miracles which he was performing. The angel of the Lord then appeared to him, brought him to the top of the mountain, at the western salt-water lake, and asked him to move there for a while. The angel guided him in building a cell for him and a church for the multitudes, which would be coming to see him.

His Love for Seclusion:

St. Macarius asserted that the wilderness of the Scetis would lose its monastic meaning once civilization would infringe upon it. He said: "When you see the cells became too close to the cultivated land, then you should know that the end of the Scetis is approaching, and when you start seeing trees, then know that it is at the gates. Also, when you start seeing kids, then you should carry your leather clothing and run."

Even in the wilderness of the Scetis, St. Macarius used to flee away from

¹ The "Eskeem" is a Coptic word which means 'shape'... It is a string of plaited leather adorned with crosses; it surrounds the chest and the back. Only the hermits who have reached high levels of spirituality could wear it.

the crowds. According to St. Palladius, the saint dug for himself an underground tunnel that extended from his cell and ended in a small cave at a distance of almost half a mile. So, when too many people would come to visit his cell, he would secretly go through the tunnel to that cave, and nobody would find him. According to one of his devoted disciples, the saint used to recite twenty-four prayers on his way to the cave and twenty-four prayers on his way back.

The Man of Love:

St. Macarius discovered that the real concept of seclusion, was not merely the isolation away from people, but rather the sincere desire to unite with God, the Lover of All humanity. So, the real recluse may physically flee away from people, yet he truly loves every person.

The spirit of love and compassion prevailed among his monks as a reflection of his love for them. St. Rufinus told us the story about the bunch of superb grapes which was presented to the saint, which he, in turn, gave to a sick monk, and how that bunch of grapes moved from one monk to another without being touched by any of them.¹

This saint was known for covering up the sins of others. About him, it was said: “He came to be as a god on earth. For, as the true God protects the world and covers up the sins of men, so St. Macarius covered the sins he saw or heard as if he did not see or hear.”

By his love, he gained many pagans to the faith. About him, it was said that he once was going from the Scetis to Nitria accompanied by his disciple who went ahead of him, and when the disciple encountered a pagan priest who was running, he told the pagan: “Where are you going, O devil?” The pagan priest stopped and beat the disciple so violently that he left him between life and death. Then, when the same priest encountered St Macarius, the saint praised him, saying: “May the Helper accompany you, O active man.” Amazed to hear those words from the saint, the pagan priest was pierced in the heart, and he did not let the saint go until he accepts him as one of his monks.

St. Macarius once went to cut palm leaves along with his disciples, but when they asked him the first day to stay and eat with them, he did. Then when they sought from him the same thing on the next day, he declined their invitation, and said to them: “You need to eat, my children, because you are still with bodies; but now I have no more desire to eat.”

When St. Macarius went to visit Fr. Pachom of Tabansin, the latter asked him: “When we have bad brethren, should we punish them?” St. Macarius

¹ *This same story was told by some to have happened with St. ‘Macarius of Alexandria.’*

answered him, saying: “Punish and judge fairly, those under your control, but never judge those who are from the outside; for it is written: *“Do you not judge those who are inside? But those who are outside, God judges”* (1 Corin. 5:12-13)”. St. Macarius used to visit daily one of the brethren for four months; in each time, the saint would find him having finished his prayers. The saint was amazed and told the brother: “You are an earthly angel.”

His Gifts:

The ‘Apophthegmata Patrum’ (Sayings of the Fathers)¹ referred to the saint's wrestling against the demons. According to St. Palladius, the saint was granted the gift of performing miracles. He raised someone from the dead to save a heretic who did not believe in the resurrection of the bodies.

St. Macarius and the Two Saintly Women:

When he once sought from God to show him someone equal to him in his behavior, a voice came to him from heaven, saying: “So far, you have not reached the level of two women in Alexandria.” He inquired until he reached their house. They welcomed him and washed his feet. Inquiring from them about their story, one of them said to him: “We were not related to each other in the flesh before we were married to two brothers. We sought from them to let us be nuns; and when they refused, we vowed to spend our lives fasting until the evenings, and to practice continuous prayers. Each of us got a boy; when one of those boys would cry, one of us would hasten to embrace him and nourish him, even if he is not her own. We go through our lives in unity of views, unity in our ways, and the unity of our hearts is our goal. Our husbands work in shepherding; we are poor, but we are satisfied with our daily bread, and what remains, we give to the poor.” On hearing this, the saint cried out, saying: “Indeed, God looks at the hearts; and grants His Holy Spirit to whoever seeks Him.” He bid them farewell and returned to the wilderness. Also, in Osim, there was a monk who led some people astray by claiming that there was no resurrection from the dead. When the bishop of Osim came to the saint and told him about that monk, the saint went to see him and managed to bring him back from his vanity.

His Departure:

On the day of his departure, St. Macarius saw St. Anthony, St. Pachom, and a group of saints and angels. He delivered his soul when he was ninety-seven years old, on the 27th of Baramhat 392 AD. He commanded his

¹ The ‘Apophthegmata Patrum Aegyptiorum’ is the name given to various collections popularly known as ‘Sayings of the Desert Fathers’, consisting of stories and sayings attributed to the Desert Fathers and Desert Mothers from approximately the 5th century AD.

disciples to hide his body, but some people of Shebshir came and stole it, built a church, and buried him in it for some 160 years; then, it was eventually brought back to his monastery.

Among his Sayings:

- While you are rebuking someone, if the anger moves within you, then you are fulfilling your evil desire. So, in your attempt to save your brother, do not lose yourself.
- If we kept remembering the people's faults against us, then we are destroying our ability to remember God.
- The long-suffering is perseverance, and perseverance is winning, and winning is life, and life is the kingdom of heaven, and the Kingdom of Heavens God.
- The well is deep, but its water is kind and sweet. The door is narrow, and the road is rough, but the city is full of joy and gladness. The tower is high and fortified, but inside there are precious treasures. Fasting is severe and burdensome, but it leads to the kingdom of heaven. Doing good deeds may be difficult and hard, but it saves from hell through the mercy of our glorious God.

[Hegomen Tadros Y. Malaty: *The Coptic Orthodox Church; a Church of Asceticism*; 1986]

MACARIUS, THE SON OF BASILIDES (The martyr)

This St. Macarius was a member of a holy family which sent to heaven so many heroes of the faith like St. Basilides, the minister of Emperor Numerian (283-284 AD), St. Bector the son of Romanos, St. Abadir, St. Irene, St. Yustus the son of Romanos, St. Theoklia, St. Abali, and St. Akladius, who was a relative of Emperor Diocletian (284-305 AD) himself.

St. Macarius left the palace of Diocletian, so the angry emperor sent him accompanied by some soldiers to Alexandria to be tortured and killed there, but he first bid his mother farewell in Antioch. Then, when he reached Alexandria, he was left in jail for some time. Then, he was brought before Armenius, the governor of Alexandria. The saint confessed his Christ with Evangelic courage and rebuked the governor on worshipping the senseless idols. Armenius ordered his men to torture him. They chained him, cut his fingers and put vinegar on his wounds, rolled him over hot iron nails, and poured boiled tar over his head. The saint fell unconscious and saw the Lord Jesus Christ in a vision surrounded by a crowd of saints. He was comforted, and the Lord restored him to a sound and healthy condition. Although the

governor was amazed, he resumed more tortures, by forcing two hot rods through the saint's throat.

Later on, the governor Armenius sent him to the city of Bshati. On their way, one of the soldiers fell dead after being knocked down by the governor's chariot. St. Macarius prayed on his behalf, and by the power of the Lord, the soldier was raised from the dead. After that miracle, the soldier and all the inhabitants of Bshati proclaimed their faith in the Lord Jesus Christ.

They took the saint to the city of Shatanof, then made him drink a cup of mixed poison, which did not harm him. Then, after he was subjected to so many other sufferings, he completed his great struggle by having his head cut off by the sword.

[Martyrdom in Christianity, p. 123]

MACARIUS, ST.

The Unintended Murder:

It happened that this St. Macarius when he was eighteen years of age, unintentionally killed a man while he was attending to his sheep near the lake of Marriott. Then, he fled to the desert, where he became a monk with the fear of God filling his heart. He spent three years in the open desert, without a roof on his head to protect him from the heat of the sun in summer or the cold of the night in winter. Finally, he built for himself a cell in which he lived for twenty-five years. God granted him the inner peace, and he was happy in his fellowship with God.

Once, he was asked whether he was still thinking about the unintentional murder he has committed. He answered that he was no longer disturbed by remembering it. Also, he added: "Because that sin led me to know the way of the Redeemer Christ. The Holy Bible contains so many testimonies about how God accepts sinners. As an example: The prophet Moses was not qualified for the grace and the Divine apparition in Sinai until after he escaped following his involuntarily killing of the Egyptian and his repentance to God." He often said: "I keep mentioning this to confirm that God forgives sin whenever the sinner repents, no matter what his crime was."

His Departure while Praying:

St. Macarius always used to pray with his arms crossed in the likeness of the Cross. After a long illness, when it was time for him to depart from this world, he crossed his arms and kept praying. Then, it happened that someone approached him after waiting for a long time for him to finish his prayer. He addressed him, saying: "O blessed father," but the saint did not respond and

he found that the saint already reposed while kneeling with his arms in the likeness of the Cross. When the brethren failed to bring his arms to his sides, they dug for him a grave in the form of a Cross.

[The Paradise of the Saints, p. 21]

MACARIUS, THE LIBYAN (The martyr)

This saint was raised in one of the five western cities (Pentapolis) in North Africa. When he reached the age of maturity, he longed to have the blessing of visiting St. Mark's church in Alexandria, which has the head of St. Mark the Apostle, and God granted him his wish. He was characterized by zealously, in helping his brethren who were under the Roman persecution. Also, he was courageous in strengthening their will and in supporting their faith. Above that, he was a living example of what he proclaimed about Christian teachings. His contemporaries, like the 14th Pope of Alexandria St. Dionysius the Great (246-264 AD), revered him during his life and said that his name that meant: the blessed, applied indeed to him and his works. These characteristics, however, made him a target for the wrath of the persecutors, who issued an order to arrest him. The judge tried many times to seduce him to burn incense before the idols, to save his life from execution. However, the saint held fast to his loyalty to the Lord Jesus Christ, and the judge ordered to burn him alive; and he received the crown of martyrdom in the year 250 AD.

[The Faithful Synaxarion: 4 Hator]

MACARIUS (The martyr)

On the 30th of Hator, the church celebrates the feast of St Macarius, the martyr.

[The Synaxarion: 30 Hator]

MACEDONIUS, ST.

This saint was a Syrian monk who lived for forty years on barley soaked in water. When he realized that his health was getting worse, he started to eat bread, believing that he had no right to neglect his own life. The saint was able to convey that belief to mother Theodora and convinced her that she should eat the proper food when her health would fail as a form of medical treatment. Mother Theodora has told many stories about the numerous miracles of healing performed by St. Macedonius, among which was healing

his mother by water on which he made the sign of the Cross.

The birth of St. Macedonius was, in itself, a miracle, through the prayers of a saintly hermit, after the saint's mother remained thirteen years without a child. The saint reposed in the year 430 AD when he was ninety years old.

[Butler: January 24]

MACEDONIUS, THE HERETIC

An Arian at First:

Macedonius was an Arian man who managed in the year 342 AD, through his influence with the Arian Emperor Constantius II (E: 337-361 AD), to remove the existing, legitimate Orthodox archbishop of Constantinople Paul I (337-9/341-2/346-51 AD) to be ordained as an archbishop in his place. When Macedonius entered the city as its archbishop (342-6/351-60 AD) for the first time surrounded by soldiers, a riot erupted between the believers and the Arians, in which so many people were killed. Macedonius persecuted the followers of the legal archbishop Paul I, and it was said that he, later on, sent someone and had Paul I strangled. After a while, he provoked Emperor Constantius II to anger, because he moved the body of his father Emperor Constantine the Great from one grave to another without his permission; and he ordered in the year 360 AD to expel him from his post and to exile him.

An Enemy of the Holy Spirit:

When Macedonius became an archbishop, he preached only the teachings of Arius, but after he was expelled, he intended to have his new heresy.¹ As the heretics before him denied the Divinity of the Son, he, on his turn, decided to reject the Divinity of the Holy Spirit. He claimed that the Holy Spirit is a sort of Divine work which is dispersed in the universe and not a Hypostasis. He considered the Holy Spirit as a creature like the angels, yet of a higher rank. He spread his vanity among so many until he was exiled to a location called Billy, where he grew old and eventually died. However, his heresy endured even after his death, mainly through his disciple Marathonius bishop of Nicomedia, and spread to many monasteries in Thrace and Bithynia. The followers of Macedonius were called by the believers: the enemies of the Holy Spirit.

When the 20th Pope of Alexandria St. Athanasius the Apostolic (328-373

¹ It was called the "Pneumatomachi" (Combators against the Spirit) heresy... It was distinct from, but in some regards reminiscent of, Arianism. Church commentators assert that they denied the Divinity of the Holy Spirit, and regarded the substance of Jesus Christ as being of "similar substance" (homoiousios) but not of the "same essence" (homoousios) as that of God the Father.

AD) came back from his exile to his seat in the year 362 AD, he held a Council in Alexandria, in which he condemned this heresy, and some of the bishops elsewhere followed suit. Then, when the Emperor Theodosius I (379-395 AD) heard about that heresy, he ordered holding an Ecumenical Council in Constantinople of 150 bishops, in the year 381 AD. This Council condemned Macedonius and put an end to this heresy.

[History of the Coptic Church, p. 351]

MACRINA THE ELDER, THE WIDOW, ST.

In more than one of his letters, St. Basil the Great mentioned Macrina, his grandmother (on his father's side). It seems that St. Macrina the Elder¹ was the one who raised him and cared to provide him with the sound religious teachings without any deviations, which he followed all his life.

During the persecution of Emperor Galerius (305-311 AD), St. Macrina the Elder and her husband suffered much and had to forsake their house and to hide from the persecutors in the forests of Pontus for seven years, during which they endured hunger for long periods. They had to feed on wild beasts, which according to St. Gregory the Nazianzus, most probably miraculously changed their fierce nature to make it easy for them to be caught and slain.

After that persecution, there was another one in which all their possessions were confiscated, and because of what they have gone through of tribulations and anguish, they were counted among the confessors for the sake of faith.

St. Macrina the Elder lived after her husband reposed, and the date of her departure is not precisely known, yet it is most probably was in the year 340.

[Baring-Gould: January 14]

MACRINA THE YOUNGER, THE VIRGIN, ST.

The biography of St. Macrina the Younger² (330-379 AD), which was written by her brother St. Gregory, bishop of Nyssa, is a living open gospel before our eyes, which lifts our souls to heaven, to let the believer enjoy the true Divine promises. Her biography powerfully reveals the role of the Christian woman within the life of the church. The church has always presented to us some rare leadership personalities due to its' help for them to develop.

¹ 'Macrina the Elder' (before AD 270 – c. 340) was the mother of 'Basil the Elder', and the grandmother of 'Basil the Great', 'Gregory of Nyssa', 'Peter of Sebaste' and 'Macrina the Younger.'

² 'Macrina the Younger' was the granddaughter of 'Macrina the Elder.'

Her Upbringing:

She was born around the year 330 AD, to wealthy, well-known pious Christian parents, in the city of Caesarea of Cappadocia. Her parents' names were Basil the Elder and Emmelia, and her grandmother was St. Macrina, the Elder. Her father was a lawyer and an orator of a prominent position in society. Their family had five sons and five daughters, and Macrina the Younger was their eldest.

In the days of the persecution stirred up by Emperor Diocletian (284-305 AD), her grandparents fled to the mountainous region of Pontus' for the sake of security. However, they did suffer so many troubles, and her grandfather (on her mother's side) lost all his possessions and was martyred, but it seems that after few years, the family returned to the capital Caesarea of Cappadocia (the New Caesarea) in the region of Pontus, where they settled down. Although her mother Emmelia desired for her to keep her virginity; however, both her parents soon died and left her parentless, and because she was very beautiful and famous; she had the fear of the possibility of being raped. Therefore, she gave her consent to get married to the pious man Basil the Elder, Macrina's father.

When it was time for her to deliver her first child, in a night vision, Emmelia saw herself holding her daughter before a revered-looking elderly who called the baby Thekla. Waking up, she delivered Macrina the Younger who carried the traits of St. Thekla. She was raised by her parents in the Christian way, educated her on reading the Holy Bible, and on caring for the domestic chores and commitments. She kept reading the gospel, in particular the books of Wisdom and Psalms. According to her brother, she used to recite the Psalms when she would start doing any work and when she would end it; before, during, and after having her meals; before she would go to bed, and after she would wake up. The Psalms of David were on her lips all the time, a companion of her life.

Becoming a Nun:

The father of Macrina the Younger arranged for her to marry, but her fiancé died before the wedding. After having been betrothed to her fiancé, Macrina the Younger did not believe it was appropriate to marry another man but saw Christ as her eternal groom. Instead, she devoted herself to her faith and became a nun.

Her Wide-Open Heart:

Since her youth, St. Macrina enjoyed the heavenly heart, which was always wide open with unceasing practical love to the last breath of her life.

Her father Basil the Elder passed away at a young age and left his sons and daughters under the care of their grandmother Macrina the Elder and their mother Emmelia, both of whom were known for their Christian life, which was flared up with spirit and piety. With the two of them, the daughter Macrina the Younger, who carried the name of her grandmother, participated in caring for and educating her siblings; to be called by them: 'The Angel of the Family.' She dedicated her life to help her mother Emmelia in caring for her younger brothers and sisters, among whom were: St. Basil the Great, St. Peter, bishop of Sebastea, and St. Gregory of Nyssa. She had an active role in their lives, through what she had of thoughtful, pious, and ascetic gifts. She succeeded in teaching them to despise the vanity of the world, to love praying and reading in the Holy Bible.

Her Impact on Her Siblings:

Her brother St. Basil the Great, the shining star in the church of Christ, was indebted to her by so much. It was said that after he thoroughly learned in school, he returned with much arrogance, and his sister had the credit of teaching him humility.

As for St. Peter her youngest brother, to whom she was the figure of the father, the mother, the teacher, and the guide, he used to look up at her as a role model and example for everything right. Because his father died directly after he was born, she cared for him, and he came to be a handyman at a very young age, without a teacher or a guide.

Concerning St. Gregory of Nyssa, at a time when all glorified him and commended him for his philosophical prominence; his saintly sister Macrina the Younger managed to approach him and redirected his heart towards the true living philosophy, to make him long for monastic life. He was so attached to her, to call her his teacher, and dedicated to her a book in which he recorded her biography, in particular the hour of her departure, which he lived through. Later on, he wrote a dialogue after that of 'Phaedo by Plato,' which included a discussion about the soul and the Resurrection. He indicated that this dialogue happened between him and his sister in her last moments on earth.

Her Impact on Her Mother:

Her brother Naucratus (the second after St. Basil the Great), who was characterized by his natural talents, perfect and healthy body, as well as having a sharp mind; he became famous while still twenty-two years of age. He preferred to live on a desert spot, near the river Iris to serve the near-by elders, poor and the sick. Five years later, it so happened that on his way to the river to catch fish as he used to do to feed the elders, he suddenly

collapsed and died without having any prior illness. Macrina the Younger, by her wisdom, managed to console and comfort her mother and get her out of her deep sorrow.

Her Mother Became a Nun:

Macrina the Younger practiced an ascetic life in her own house and came to be a role model to her pious mother Emmelia. After being free of her responsibilities to raise her children, Emmelia longed to be like her daughter, removed from any worldly care, and pursue an exultant angelic way of life. Macrina and her mother had their continuous interest in the study of Divinities, perpetual prayers, and praise, day and night without ceasing. Eventually, she and her mother settled down in a house close to the river Iris in Pontus, where they were joined by other women, in a life of fellowship and asceticism.

Together with her mother Emmelia, they established a nuns congregation on their property in Pontus in the region of Annesis on the banks of the river Iris. Her brother St Basil the Great, follow suit and dedicated his life and came to be a hermit in the same region. There, he was joined by his friend St. Gregory the Nazianzus. They concentrated on worship and the study of the writings of Origen. They also established a monastery there.

When their mother Emmelia got very old, she reposed in the Lord surrounded by Macrina the Younger her firstborn and her son St. Peter her last born. Before she died, she put her hands on their heads and said: “To You, O Lord, I present my first and last. For all the first-fruits and the tithes of all the fruits, are yours according to the law.”

After the repose of her mother, Macrina the Younger left her house to the poor and made her living from her handwork. When her brother St. Basil the Great reposed in the year 379 AD; she fell ill for nine months, during which her brother St. Gregory of Nyssa was so much preoccupied with the events stirred up by the Arians, that he could only manage to visit her after eight years. However, he was so comforted to see the courage and joy, by which she prepared herself for death.

Her Repose:

St. Macrina the Younger led an extreme way of asceticism that she slept on two wooden boards, and after she reposed, they only found a worn-out scarf and robe by which to cover her body for burial. There, Araxius, the bishop of the region, and her brother St. Gregory of Nyssa carried her coffin while singing Psalms and hymns, followed by a multitude of the congregation, particularly the women, to bid her farewell.

The Last Moments:

God allowed St. Gregory of Nyssa, her brother, to attend her last moments, to provide us with her true feelings of longing to cross over to heaven.

After long eight years, it so happened that in the night preceding his arrival to her monastery, that, in a night vision, he saw himself as though holding the relics of some saints, from which a beautiful light shone, so strong that it hurt his eyes. That vision was repeated three times on the same night, and he could not figure it out.

Arriving at the monastery, hermits from the monastery of the men came to receive him; and the nuns stood at the door of the church waiting for him. However, he noticed that his sister, the mother-superior was not among them. He set forth to her cell to find her stretched on the ground, on a wooden board, unable to stand up to greet him, but he saw how that extremely frail body could not destroy the soul flared up by the love of the celestials. About that St. Gregory said: “She started to say sweet words about the soul; brought joy to me by her questions, and when we came to mention the repose of our brother Basil the Great, and she noticed how my countenance came to reflect the great sorrow in my heart, the blessed Macrina was too far away from being as sorrowful.

She talked long about the next life, as though enlightened by the Holy Spirit that I felt her words lifted my mind; and that I came out from my human nature, up to heavens, guided by her words. If the illness managed to exhaust her and to bring her near death, yet, her mind was too preoccupied with the lofty matters, not hindered by any disease.”

Her Burial:

She departed from this world with her face toward the east, made the sign of the Cross on herself, prayed by her heart, and unable to talk, she barely moved her lips. When St. Gregory of Nyssa inquired in what will they shroud her, Lampazia, the first among the nuns, and a deaconess replied:

“As the clothes of the righteous are nothing but her pure and virtuous life; this was her adornment while living; so let it be now her clothes in her repose. All that she possessed are displayed here before you. This is her robe, and that is her scarf; these are her sandals, and those are her riches and her wealth. She possessed nothing more, not in a box or a closet. She knew no other place to treasure her things, other than heaven.”

Being a brother and a bishop, St. Gregory sought something more for her burial, but it so happened that her face suddenly displayed a fantastic beauty and splendor that brought to his memory the vision he saw the other night.

Here, one of the widows present said: “It is far better for the saint not to appear in the eyes of the nuns so adorned like a bride. I happen to have a black robe of your mother, which I see most suitable to cover her holy body with; to hide her extraordinary beauty that the present strange dress has given her.” Yet the splendor of her face continued to shine from her countenance, even after covering her with that black robe.

[Butler: July 19]

MACROBIUS, ST.

Quitting his Civil Job and Becoming Monk along with his Brothers:

St. Macrobius (Macrophius) was the son of the governor of the city of Kao, and when St. Severus of Antioch (512-538 AD) reached the town of Kao while he was traveling through Upper Egypt, the young Macrobius accompanied him and served him in his visit to the monastery of Abba Moses, near the region of the Āaraba el-Madfuna.¹ There, Macrobius was impressed by the sanctity and the asceticism of the monks, and he asked the Abbot Abba Moses to accept him as a monk. However the Abbot indicated to him how harsh was the monastic life; primarily he was raised in luxury and family wealth, and the one that slept on silk, could not take the rough life, but seeing how persistent was Macrobius, the Abbot sought from him first to quit his job, which he received after the death of his father, and to forsake all his possessions. Macrobius went to Kao appointed his brother in his place, returned and was clothed in the monastic attire. On hearing about what their brother did, his three brothers: Paul, Elias, and Joseph, followed him and were ordained monks by Abba Moses.

Establishing Monasteries and Convents:

After some time, Abba Macrobius built several monasteries, and about 1,000 monks occupied them. He also made several convents and were occupied also by about 1,000 nuns. He used his wealth to build so many houses to sustain thousands of people who were not strong enough to be monks; and sought from Abba Moses to send him brethren to ordain monks from those who were able among the men gathering around him. Many Christians from the cities of Assiut, Shotb, and the surrounding towns came to him and offered so many gifts and a lot of money to help him build the churches and the monasteries. He accepted their donations, and he blessed them. St. Macrobius struggled to excel in virtue, in asceticism, offering alms

¹ Located about 7 miles west of ‘El-Balyana’ on the Nile river in the province of ‘Sohag’...

to the weak, the needy, the widows and the orphans, and his donations were from his own money and not from the church treasury.

The Gift of Healing the Sick:

God granted St. Macrobios, the gift of healing the sick. So, the sick of all kinds were brought to him, and he used to improve them by the power of God and according to their faith. When the 33rd pope of Alexandria St. Theodosius I (536-567 AD) heard about him, he wrote to commend him and to encourage him to hold fast to his virtues, asceticism, and the love of strangers. The pope also invited him to come to Alexandria to let its people get his blessings. Then, when St. Macrobios came, the pope rejoiced, gathered the congregation to greet him and then he ordained him as a priest.

Macrobios returned to his monasteries, where the people of Assiut Shotb, Abu-Serga, and El-Balyana received him with hymns until he reached his monastery, and on his hands, God performed so many miracles.

Once he completed his good strife, he reposed in peace and was shrouded by his brother Abba Joseph (Yosab), whom he chose to succeed him in overseeing the monasteries.

The Appearance of His Body:

After 733 years of his departure, his body was revealed on the 7th of Toba. The body was discovered by a deacon named Los al-Talawy, a minister of the church of his monastery, in the days of AbbaYosab, the bishop of Akhmim and the archon Ishac the scribe of prince Äzzel-Din al-Ĥamawy. The bishop exhumed the body from his grave on the mountain and brought it down to the church of the monastery, where they buried him with hymns and praise.

[The Synaxarion: 7 Baramouda]

MAGNA, THE VIRGIN, ST.

St. Magna was born in the city of Ancyra in Turkey. She had her heart flared up with the Divine love, that she was spending most of her nights praying and praising God. Her father was arrested when she was young. Then, a young man asked to marry her, and her mother wanted to give her in marriage, but Magna tried to proclaim her desire for a life of virginity and that she dedicated her life to her Heavenly Groom. However, her mother did not approve and forced her to get married.

A Life of Virginity:

After the wedding, Magna prayed to God to grant her the wisdom and to help her keep her virginity. She kept giving excuses to her husband to keep

him away. Then, God allowed for him to get seriously ill and eventually to pass away.

A Life of Monasticism:

Magna distributed all that she inherited from her husband on the poor and the needy and then joined a convent in Ancyra which included about 2,000 nuns. Magna believed in the necessity of the continuous handwork that she chose to clean the lavatories with great joy, besides practicing prayers, fasting, calm sessions of reading the Holy Bible, and eating only one meal in the evening. She was the object of amazement and love of the other nuns, that when she was inflicted with severe illness, the nuns came to her cell, where, with great difficulty, she managed to ask them to continue their unceasing strife to get to enjoy the heavenly crown. She then put her arms on her chest in the form of a Cross and delivered her pure soul in the hands of her Creator and Savior.

MAHARSAPOR (The martyr)

St. Maharsapor was a Persian of noble origin, known for his intense zeal on the Christian Faith. When the Persian king Yazdegerd I (399-420 AD) started his persecution of the Christians because of the destruction of the Mazdean Temple of the Magi, this saint was among the first to be arrested, along with Narses (Parses) and Sabutaka. St. Narses and St. Sabutaka stood before the judge Hormisdavrus, who was previously a slave, and that judge condemned them to death after they were subjected to a long series of tortures. St. Maharsapor stood before the same judge, who ordered to torture him too. Then, he cast him for three years in a dark, filthy dungeon and regularly was tortured. When he stood again before the judge, and he persisted on confessing to the Lord Jesus Christ, the judge ordered to cast him back in the dungeon with no food or drink to let him die out of hunger and thirst. After several days, the persecutors opened the dungeon to find him dead and saw his martyred body radiating splendid light, while he was kneeling on his knees in a position of prayer. In this way, the martyr showed that by the spirit of prayer, he overcame all of his persecutors. His martyrdom took place in the year 421

[Butler: October 10]

MAJESTERIANUS (The martyr)

It happened that a beautiful girl from the city of Corinth dedicated her

virginity to the Lord Jesus Christ. Then, she was accused before the governor that she despised the Roman government and emperors, blasphemed against the gods, and hated the pagan sacrifices. Once the governor saw her, he was burnt with lust and tried to seduce her by all kinds of crafty ways. When he failed to get what he wanted from her, he delivered her to be tortured. He ordered his men to scourge her, and then to force her to work in a house of harlotry. The governor gave her to a man of bad reputation and ordered him to bring him whatever money she would get from her customers.

That pure virgin who dedicated herself to the Lord kept proclaiming to those evil men coming to sin with her that she was afflicted with a bad venereal disease and kept sending them away. She prayed to God, kneeling on the ground for an extended period to rescue her and help her keep her chastity.

The Wise Youth Majesterianus:

The Lord responded to her prayers and sent to her a wise young man called Majesterianus. He approached the evil man responsible for her and gave him a significant fee to allow him to spend the whole night with her. On entering into her room, he addressed her, saying: "Get up and save yourself." He gave her his outer manly attire to put on, and he covered her up with his overcoat. She made the sign of the Cross on herself, and then she fled away.

In the next morning, when the situation was revealed, they delivered the young man Majesterianus to the hungry beasts, and he received the crown of martyrdom and chastity; for rescuing his sister in Christ.

[The Paradise of the Saints, p. 39]

MAJORINUS

After the repose of Mensurius (303-311 AD), bishop of Carthage in the year 311 AD, a Council of the bishops of Numidia was held and ended up by choosing Majorinus for the throne in the year 312 AD, instead of Caecilianus¹ who was initially chosen. This started dissension in the church that led later on to the Donatist movement. Majorinus sat on the throne only for a short while, for he reposed in the year 315 AD, to be succeeded by Donatus Magnus, the real founder of Donatism².

[E. Ferguson: Encyclopedia of the Early Church]

¹ 'Caecilianus', was at the First Council of Nicaea and was opposed by the Donatist bishop Majorinus.

² 'Donatism' was a schism in the Church of Carthage from the 4th to the 6th centuries. Donatists argued that Christian clergy must be faultless for their ministry to be effective and their prayers valid...

MAKRAWY, THE BISHOP (The martyr)

St. Makrawy (Macrobius) was one of the prominent personalities in the city of Ashmun Graïs (Ashmun Kharirat). He was ordained as a bishop on Nikiu (Nakiyos). When persecution was stirred up against the Christians, Euphаний, the governor of the region called him to appear before him. However, before he went to see him, he first went to his church. He stood before the holy altar, prayed, then put the utensils of the altar and the service vestments in a place in the altar and prayed to the Lord Jesus Christ to guard His church. Then, he went with the soldiers to stand before the governor. The governor asked about his name and city, and after getting to know that he was the bishop of the town, he ordered his men to beat him up and insult him. Then, they mixed lime with vinegar and poured it down his throat. Nevertheless, God guarded him and he was unharmed.

Before Armenius, the Governor of Alexandria:

That governor sent him to Armenius the governor of Alexandria, who put him in jail. In prison, God performed through the saint so many signs. One of these miracles was that Eucharistus, the son of Julius el-Aqfahasi, was inflicted with paralysis; and by the prayers of this saint, God healed him. Then, the saint celebrated the Holy Liturgy in the house of Julius, gave the Holy Communion to all the household members, and asked Julius to care for his body and to write his biography.

On hearing about the signs God performed on the hand of this saint, the governor Armenius ordered torturing him with every possible tool. They cut his limbs off, cast him before wild beasts, put him in a fiery furnace, and then threw him into the sea. However, the Lord strengthened him to endure all of these without being harmed.

This saint had a virgin sister called Mary who was serving the church and two brothers called Yoannes and Isaac, who came to him in prison crying and said to him: “You were a father to us after our father. How would you go and leave us fatherless?” He comforted them and encouraged them and then sent them away in peace. Finally, Julius el-Aqfahasi advised the governor, saying: “Write the decree of this old man and get rid of him.” The governor went along and ordered to cut off the saint's head.

Buried in Ashmun Graïs:

Julius took the saint's body, wrapped it in precious linens, put a golden cross on his chest, and sent him on a boat, accompanied by his servants, to his throne in Nikiu. However, after the boat reached the city of Ashmun Graïs, it stuck and did not move, as though anchored by chains. While

attempting to move it, a voice came out of the body, saying: “Here is the place where the Lord is pleased to bury my body.” When the inhabitants of Ashmun Grahis heard about that, they came out carrying palm leaves and brought his body with great honor to their city.

The saint reached 131 years of age: thirty years as a priest, and thirty-nine years as a bishop. Then, he completed his admirable strife and received the crown of martyrdom.

[The Synaxarion: 3 Baramhat]

MALACHI (The martyr)

On the 12th of Baramhat, the church celebrates the martyrdom of the righteous saint Malachi, who was martyred in Palestine.

[The Synaxarion: 12 Baramhat]

MALATY, THE MUÅALLEM (The martyr)

Muåallem Malaty, muåallem Ibrahim el-Gohary, muåallem Guirgis el-Gohary, muåallem Yaåqub, muåallem Ghaly, and other muåallems; these great personalities were not known in history by the names of their families fathers, but they became themselves the heads of their families.

The name of muåallem Malaty was connected to the French Campaign in Egypt (1798-1801). The Egyptian historian Al-Jabarti (1754-1822) witnessed the events of that campaign and recorded his observations in various accounts. Among what he wrote, were segments related to muåallem Malaty, such as the following:

“He was a scribe working for Ayyub Bek el-Daftar-Dar, one of the Mamluks of Mohammed Bek Abu el-Dahab, who became a prince after the death of his mentor. He was a crafty man who pretended to defend the truth and to love the elites and the scholars, and he was killed in a fight between the French and the Egyptian princes in the battle of El-Ahram.

The job of El-Daftar-Dar was like a minister of finance, and his scribe Malaty was like a general manager of the accountants. When the French occupied Cairo and started to organize its affairs; they set up a commission to establish some tax on every individual, according to his ability, to provide funds for the French occupation. The Egyptians revolted and fought against the French, so fiercely, that ended up in killing so many natives and scholars, and the activity of the commission was halted completely. When it was peaceful again, the French formed another commission of twelve members, instead of the sixty in the first one. The French called it ‘The Court of

Justice,' and they installed muâallem Yaâqub as its head since they detected in him the vast knowledge and intelligent reasoning.

Together with others, muâallem Yaâqub set up a tariff for registration fees; and he was entrusted by the French to judge the cases of commercial nature, inheritance, and general suits. He set steady bases for all of these matters. They sought from everyone to register their possessions within sixty days; otherwise, the registration fees would be doubled. They, as well organized the inheritance matters, which was required to be established after twenty-four days from death; and whoever claimed that the deceased owed him something, had to prove his case within a specified period, etc.

The goal of these systems was to protect the weak from the dominion of the powerful and to secure the means to expand the trading circle.

The great Diwan (consulting office) was annulled on the 23rd of October, 1798, and it was restored after just two months on the 26th of December. In the new Diwan, only fourteen permanent members were elected from among the old Diwan members, and they were headed by muâallem Malaty.

The new Diwan was consulted about the inheritance arrangements, and the French stated that they do not give the boy the right to inherit in France, but only the girl, on account that the boy is more capable of earning than the girl, but Michael Kahil el-Shami said that both the Muslims and the Copts divide the inheritance on both; and sought from the religious scholars to establish the rules of inheritance, which they promised to do.

That matter caused quite a bit of chaos among the people; some submitted to the actual system, and the others refused. The mob joined forces with some wearing the turban, causing the first revolt in Cairo, where they robbed the houses and confiscated the treasuries. At this point, the French forced their way into the Azhar mosque.

It is important to mention that it was the custom that the governor coming from Al-Asetana (Istanbul) to rule Egypt, used to have a committee composed of the princes of the Mamluks (the Beks); to look into the general affairs of the country, also called the 'Diwan,' but when the French entered into Egypt, they got rid of the Mamluks, including the members of that Diwan. Also, they formed government divisions headed by Frenchmen with some local nationals; to incite the hate toward the Mamluks. Then, they called it the 'National Diwan,' and they set a system to define the functions of that Diwan. Later on, on Wednesday the 4th of the month of Rabiâ I, 1216 AH (July 15, 1801), the French departed from the Qasr el-Äiny, El-Roda, and El-Giza; together with almost all the English soldiers. Then, on Thursday the 27th of Muharram 1218 AH (May 19, 1803), the mob captured muâallem Malaty, who was one of the elite Coptic scribes and was a judge in the days

of the French, and they chopped his head off at Bab Zoweila. Also at Bab el-Khalq, they beheaded muâallem Hanna el-Sobhâni, the brother of Yousef el-Sobhâni; both brothers were Syrian merchants.

[Tewfik Iscaros: *The Prominent and Famous Copts in the Nineteenth Century*,
1913]

MALCHUS, ST.

This saint lived in the 4th century AD; his biography was told by St. Jerome (347-420 AD), who went as a young man to Antioch in the year 375 AD, and visited Maronia in Syria, thirty miles from Antioch, where his attention was drawn to a reverend old man called Malchus (Melek), who narrated to him his own story.

His Seclusion:

Malchus was born in Nisibis¹ to a Christian family, and he was his parents' only child. When he reached the age of maturity, his parents planned for him to get married, but having dedicated his life to serving God, he fled away and joined a group of hermits in the wilderness of Chalcis (Khalkis) between the Imma and the Bersa.

Returning to His Mother:

After spending several years in the monastery there, the evil tempter put in his mind to go to comfort his mother after the death of his father. He wanted to sell the possessions he inherited from his father, to distribute the proceeds on the poor and help restore his monastery with the rest. Those thoughts came so hard on him that he went to his spiritual father the Abbot and told him about his plans. The Abbot said to him: "Son, do not lend your ears to these thoughts, for they are a trick from the devil, who craftily managed to push so many monks far away from the way of God, like a dog which goes back to its vomit, and they fell into that pit and lost the inheritance of the kingdom of heaven. Remember that Adam himself has fallen in a similar temptation; and that our Savior gave out the commandment *"No one, having put his hand to the plow, and looking back, is fit for the kingdom of God."* (Luke 9:62)." Here, Malchus brought to his attention that he came to be a heir of a wealth that could be handy to improve the buildings of the monastery, but the Abbot was so sure of his point of view, that he was not ready to change his mind and sought from Malchus not to depart from the

¹ 'Nisibis' is a city in Mardin Province near the traditional boundary of Anatolia and Mesopotamia in nowadays Turkey's border with Syria.

monastery without prior permission.

Seeing how Malchus was adamant in holding up to his decision, his Abbot told him: “My son, your heart has gotten attached to the love of money. Remember that the little lamb that goes far from the shepherd will easily fall prey to the wolves,” but as Malchus was equally convinced by his point of view, he departed from the monastery without permission, listening to the devil who told him: “Your Abbot has advised you that way because he wanted to be glorified by more monks under his supervision.”

His Captivity:

For fear of the dangers of the mountain roads; Malchus went to Edessa (El-Roha) to wait for a caravan to join them in their journey across the desert, but as the caravan of many men and women was traveling, they were attacked by a gang of nomad robbers (Saracens), and they were taken as captives between Aleppo and Edessa. They distributed the captives among the Saracens, and Malchus and a young married woman fell to the share of a Saracen chief. The woman's husband was allotted to another captor. The two were carried on camels to the arid desert beyond the Euphrates. For fear that they would fall off the camel, they held onto one another tightly. His Arab master then led him to his tent, ordered him to pay homage to his wife and children. Then, his Arab master ordered him to shepherd his sheep, which was a comfortable assignment in his misery, for it took him away from those evil men. He also felt being like St. Jacob and St. Moses, the prophet. He was feeding on dates, cheese, and milk, and he prayed from the depth of his heart, sang the Psalms he learned from the monks in the monastery, and gave God thanks for giving him this light punishment on his disobedience to his Abbot. He remembered the words of St. Paul the apostle: *"Bondservants, obey in all things your masters according to the flesh"* (Col 3:22), *"Bondservants, be obedient to those who are your masters according to the flesh,"* (Eph 6:5).

Forcing Him to Marry:

His master was content with him for not being like the other non-obedient and hostile people who happen to fall into captivity. So, to reward him for his faithfulness, his master planned to have him get married to the young woman who was captured with him. This plan caused much disturbance to the saint, not only for being a monk but because he knew that she was already married. He answered his master: “I am a monk, and cannot do such a thing.” The Arab warned him, saying: “If you do not marry her, I shall kill you with this sword.” Then, the master confined them together in a cave. The saint profusely wept, saying: “Woe is me, a sinner. What happened to me? Where my mother is and where are the possessions I inherited? All this is because I

did not obey my Abbot. Endure, then, my miserable soul, for you forsook the Lord.” He then took a sharp dagger in his hand, and said: “O, miserable woman; I prefer to die a martyr rather than to break my oath and become a husband.” Terrified from his words, she said to him: “I implore you, in the name of Jesus Christ, not to kill yourself for my sake. You have to know that; I am just like you, wish to keep my purity in Christ. Let us then hold fast to God’s help, and let us love one another a spiritual love as a brother and a sister. Let us, before our master, the Arab, pretend to have a physical relationship.” According to St. Jerome, that is what they did.

Amazed at the wisdom of that woman, the saint received her counsel with joy. He did not look at her or touch her for fear of the temptation. The Arab master left them together for a full month, not fearing that they would escape from him, and whenever he visited them and saw how the saint took good care of the flock of sheep, he returned happily.

His Escape:

Once, the saint while remembering his past spiritual life in the monastery, he observed a congregation of ants working as a group, going to and fro, carrying more than their weight to store food for the winter. Contemplating about what these ants were doing, and remembering how Solomon the Wise counseled us to learn from the ants, those weak creatures (Proverbs 6:6). Then, remembering his life of fellowship in the monastery, he was overwhelmed with a feeling of loneliness, and longing for his past happy life among the monks in the monastery.

On seeing these signs of depression on his countenance, the woman asked him about the reason. He told her about his feeling and about his intention to escape to go back to his monastery. She asked him to take her with him, and put her in a convent nearby; for she has lost hope in re-joining her husband. Praying with tears, seeking help from God, they made a plan for escape; slew two goats and blew up the air in their flog to make floats by which they could manage to cross the Euphrates safely.

After traveling for five days, they were horrified by seeing from a distance their Arab master and his helper, riding two camels holding swords in their hands. Terrified, they sought help from the Lord, entered into a cave full of snakes and scorpions which were taking refuge from the intense heat of the sun. Tracing their footmarks, the Arab master and his servant companion came to the cave and dismounted from their camels. The Arab ordered his servant to enter into the cave, and having walked for long in the bright sunlight, and the servant was not able to see them. He wanted to bring fear unto them, so he said in a loud voice: “You, two evil slaves who are worthy of death, come out quickly, for your master is outside waiting for you. At this

moment, a lioness with her cub charged against him and got rid of him, for which the two glorified God. The Arab master on the outside got impatient and shouted in a loud voice: "Hasten to bring them to me to kill them." Then, he entered the cave, and he was killed as his servant by the lioness. They both glorified God more and more for rescuing them. The lioness took her cub and forsook the cave. In the morning, the two escapees came out, led the two camels loaded with the provisions of the Arab and his servant, ate and drank, and gave thanks to God. Then, they went in their way, hoping to reach St. Malchus' monastery.

A Return to the Monastery:

After traveling for ten days, they arrived at a Roman camp in Missa. They told the officer in charge their story, and he sent them to Edessa (El-Roha). From there, Malchus managed to go to the region of the hermits in Chalcis (Khalkis). Then, he went later on to Maronia to spend the rest of his life there; and that was where he encountered St. Jerome who recorded his story.

As to his woman companion, after searching for her husband and not being able to find him, she thought about her companion who shared her life in bondage and their escape so she went to him and he placed her in a convent close to his monastery; while they were reciting the words of the Lord: "*He who endures to the end shall be saved*" (Matthew 24:13). There, she dedicated her time ministering to the Lord; and reposed at right old age.

[Baring-Gould: October 21]

MALLONUS, THE BISHOP, ST.

St. Mallonus (Mellanius) was the first bishop of the city of Rouen. He lived at the beginning of the 4th century AD. Not much is known about his life, other than it was said that he was a pagan, then converted to Christianity in Rome; and that the Roman Pope Stephen I (254-257 AD) ordained him and sent him to preach in the land of Gaul (France).

[Butler: October 22]

MAMADIUS (The martyr)

St. Mamadius was a young man who lived in Egypt in the era of the Circassian Mamluks (1382-1517 AD). By his name and behavior, he seemed to have been a Muslim, and then he converted and believed in the Lord Jesus Christ and got the seal of Baptism, and his name changed to Michael. Whenever the persecutors questioned him, he used to answer: "My first name

given to me by my parents was Mamadius, but the one with which I live and die is Michael.” He persisted on this answer until they cut his head by the sword, and he received the crown of martyrdom.

[The Patriotism of the Coptic Church and its History, p. 250]

MAMAS (The martyr)

The Martyrdom of his Parents:

The parents of this saint: John Theodotus and Rufina were highly spiritual Christians, keen on worship, and they used to visit the other families to hold them fast to the faith. They used to serve the poor and the needy that the people loved them very much. However, Satan provoked some evil men to report them to the governor Alexandros. The governor called them in and ordered them to worship the idols. When they refused, he scourged them and cast them in prison. Seeing how they held fast to their faith, he sent them to Fustus, the governor of Caesarea, who threatened to kill them, but they did not care. Because of their hard and long march on foot without food, Theodotus fell dead, and his wife Rufina delivered a male infant just before she also died, even before she was able to give him a name.

Being Called ‘Mam’ or ‘Mamas’:

A pious rich widow believer called Ammia, saw a vision while praying, urging her to go to the prison and inquire about a newly born parentless baby. So she did, and by God's help, she could receive the baby, as well as his parents' two dead bodies. She buried the corpses in a garden she possessed, while a sweet fragrance spread from them.

Ammia took care of the baby and counted him as a gift to her from God. Growing up, the child used to call her Mama (Mammas in Greek); and for her immense joy to have him, she used to call him Mama.

The boy enjoyed the word of the Gospel, learned prayers, and was thrilled to listen to the biographies of the saintly martyrs, in particular those of his parents. In his five years of age, he joined the preschool of the church, where he learned much about the Holy Bible. In his twelve years of age, his adopting mother Ammia died, and he gave all that he inherited from her to the church, and the church distributed it on the poor. St. Mamas testified to the Lord Jesus Christ among the pagans, and he managed to draw so many young men among them to faith.

Called for Martyrdom:

According to St. Basil and St. Gregory the Nazianzus, St. Mamas

(Mammas) earned his living as a shepherd of sheep, drank their milk, and ate from the cheese he made from it. Since his youth, he sought the kingdom of God from all his heart, dedicated himself to God's service. Many gathered around him, and he testified among them to the Lord Jesus Christ, preached the message of salvation, and cared as well for their physical needs. Because of his faith, he endured vicious tortures with joy, until he received the crown of martyrdom around the year 275 AD.

According to the tradition of the east, St. Mamas was martyred in the days of Emperor Aurelian (270-275 AD) by being stoned to death, while he was still a young man, but according to the western tradition, he was exposed to very long torture that lasted from his youth until his old age.

He was reported by the families of some young men who received faith in his hands, to the new governor Democritus, who called him and vainly tried to lure him to deny his faith. Then, he sent him to the emperor, who despised him because of his young age. The emperor ordered to strike him with the rod until his body was torn off, then they cast him in prison. They made a big fire to terrify him, but he longed to be offered as a burnt sacrifice to the Lord. However, the emperor did not order it. Instead, the emperor ordered his men to cast him chained into the sea; but by God's care, the waves threw him on the shore; and from there, St. Mamas set forth to the hills around and dwelt among the beasts and became like their friend.

Accused of Sorcery:

The devil stirred up some people against him, and they reported him to the local governor, citing him of sorcery. The governor sent soldiers to arrest him, whom Mamas received with love and cheerfulness. The soldiers testified before the governor that they found Mamas, neither a sorcerer nor an evil man. The angry governor sent him again to the emperor, who ordered to gang him and to comb his body with sharp iron combs, then to cast him in prison. The Lord, however, healed his wounds, and, when the prisoners came to him moaning from hunger, he prayed on their behalf, and the Lord sent them someone with food. Then, the gates of the prison opened, and all of the prisoners were released.

Then, the emperor ordered to cast him into a fiery furnace; but heavy rain fell and put it off. Finally, the emperor ordered to cut the saint's head off, and he delivered his soul when he was just fifteen years old. Then he was buried in the city of Caesarea of Cappadocia in Asia Minor.

According to Orpheus, while St. Mamas was dwelling among the beasts, he was fed on the milk and honey, and when he was brought before the hungry beasts in the arena, the beasts treated him like a shepherd among his flock, they lied under his feet in submission, and when they set against him a

huge lion, it licked his feet, then caught the persecutors and cast them at the saint's feet.

He is celebrated by the Coptic Church on the 4th of Tout.

This saint is the patron saint of the city of Caesarea of Cappadocia, where his honored relics were kept, and as he was the shepherd of the speechless sheep in his temporal life, he came to be the shepherd of the souls of the inhabitants of the whole region by his intercession and blessings through his prayers.

[St. Basil and St. Gregory Nazianzus]

[Butler: August 17]

MAMMATY, THE MUĀALLEM

This muāallem's name was Abu el-Maliḥ, known as Mammaty. He lived in the 11th century AD during the Fatimid caliphate of Al-Mustansir bi-Allah (1036-1094 AD), and the vizierate of Badr el-Din al-Jamali the prince of the army (1073-1094 AD). He was known for his wealth, comfortable living, and his charity activities. The reason behind being so-called Mammaty was that he used to distribute what he had on the needy during one of the harsh famines in Egypt; and it happened that when the hungry Muslim children would see him on the streets, they would follow him begging him and crying out: "Mammaty! Mammaty!"¹ Also, he used to have compassion for them and grant them grain and food to satisfy their hunger.

Mammaty was the grandfather of Asāad ibn Mohazab ibn Zakaria, who converted to Islam during the rule of Shirkuh, in the days of the Fatimid caliph Al-Āadid li-Din Allah (1160-1171 AD).

[The History of the Coptic Church, p. 455]

MANĤA (The martyr)

St. Manḥa was the maidservant of El-Ĥareth ibn Kaāb, the noble head of the Najran tribes in Yemen, which was ruled by the Jewish king Dhu-Nuwas (520-530 AD) who hated the Christians. However, El-Ĥareth ibn Kaāb was among the Himyarite martyrs during this king's persecution of the Christians. St. Manḥa used to be such an evil woman in most of her life and she was so daring, that she was feared even by her masters, but it happened that right after she experienced the slaughter of the Christians in her city; she came down in haste to the streets and cried out saying:

¹ 'Mammaty' in Arabic could mean: "I am dead hungry..."

“O Christian men and women: It is now the time for you to pay Christ back what you are indebted to Him. Come out and die for the sake of Christ, as He died for your sake. Whoever refrains from coming out today for the sake of Christ, he or she is not His, and whoever does not respond to Christ today, He will not respond to him or her tomorrow.

Tomorrow, the door will be closed, and you cannot enter anymore.

I know for sure that you hate me, but from now on, I shall be your enemy, no more. Look at me closely! You will find no more evil around or behind me.”

Before the King:

The Jews who used to know her, on seeing her so talking, they informed their Jewish king Dhu-Nuwas. They told him: “This woman is the devil of the Christians.”

Daringly, she told that king: “To you, O slayer of the Christians, I say: Come on and slay me as well for I am now a Christian. I have been the maidservant of El-Hareth ibn Kaab, whom you killed yesterday. Do not think that you have overcome my master, but he surely has defeated you. Yes, you lied, but my master never lied, nor denied Christ.”

Her Martyrdom:

When the king ordered to bare her naked, she said to him: “You do so for your shame and that of the Jews your companions. As for me, I so often did on my own, on account of that I am created a woman by God, but you, on the other hand, when you were fighting against the Ethiopians, you sought the help of Gahshoun the merchant, who swore on your behalf by the Holy Bible that you were a Christian; by this way, you were saved from being killed, O Jew.” At that point, the king ordered to bring an ox and a donkey and to tie one of St. Manha's legs to each of the animals. Then, the Jews beat the two animals with whips to make them gallop and run, dragging the saint in different directions along with them on the streets of the city; until she got completely torn apart and delivered her soul for the sake of the Lord Jesus Christ. Then, her torn body was brought over to the northern gate of the city, in front of the palace of her master El-Hareth, and they hanged her body upside down from a huge tree until the evening. While her body was hanging on the tree, the Jews kept throwing stones and arrows on it. That night, they brought her body down, dragged it again, and then cast her dead body in the valley. St. Manha's martyrdom took place around the year 523 AD.

[Martyrdom in Christianity, p. 270]

MANI, THE GNOSTIC

Mani (Manes/Manichaeus) appeared in the 2nd half of the 3rd century (216-274 AD). He was a Persian philosopher who attempted to create a new religion to conform to three existing religions: the Persian (Zoroastrianism), Christian, and Buddhism. He was welcomed first by the king of Persia; then, the Magi priests were stirred up against him; and he had to escape from his country. By the way, the word Mani means a crazy man¹.

Mani managed to have a large number of followers. He sent some delegates to Papos and Thomas in the land of Egypt. They settled down in Lycopolis (nowadays Assiut), north of Thebes on the banks of the Nile river. There, they managed to take away some of the disciples of the Platonian philosopher Alexander of Assiut. Therefore, the philosopher wrote an essay attacking them. It seems that they also translated some of Mani's books, which have been recently discovered near the city of El-Maâady in the years (1930-1). These manuscripts were written in the Coptic language in the Akhmim dialect, which was normally used by the people of Lycopolis and the surrounding area. When Mani returned to his country, he was followed by a great multitude. However, he was condemned to death by the king Bahram I (Vahrans I: 271-274 AD) in the year 274 AD.

The Spread of his Sect:

Surprisingly, Manichaeism spread quickly among Christians, and it remained that way for many generations. Somehow, it was admired by some scholars, including St. Augustine before his repentance, on account of the vagueness of its teaching scheme and its seemingly finding a solution for the problem of evil. They liked the pretention of its followers of being holy and involved in practicing asceticism.

Manichaeism most Prominent Principles:

- 1- The existence of two gods: the god of goodness and the god of evil; or the god of light and the god of darkness.
- 2- Everyone has his guardian angel who grants knowledge to whoever conforms to him or agrees with him. At the same time, everyone is in need to belong to either a woman or a man, for he/she cannot enter into the Pleroma (the Spiritual World) without his/her other half.
- 3- Every follower of Mani has two persons, who inspire him and guide him to light, and even Jesus the eternal and the everlasting, Himself suffers from the material and is saved by the Gnostic concept.

¹ Manichaeism is a dualistic philosophy dividing the world between good and evil principles or regarding matter as intrinsically evil and mind as intrinsically good...

The historian Eusebius of Caesarea wrote about Mani:

- At that time, this crazy man appeared; his name derived from his crazy heresy. He supported himself by turning his mind upside down; and was set up by Satan, the enemy of God, for the destruction of many.
- His life was wild in words, deeds, and devilish crazy nature. He claimed to have a status like that of Christ, and in his exploding craziness, he went so far as to claim that he, himself, was the Paraclete (the Holy Spirit). In his imitation for Christ, he chose for himself twelve disciples as partners in his new teaching.
- He mixed up false and infidel teachings; he managed to gather from the writings of the pagan fathers, those who already became extinct since a long time. These teachings, he sent as deadly venoms from Persia to this part of the world in which we live.

[Eusebius of Caesarea: *Church History*, 31:7 – Translated by Fr. Marcus David]
[Fr. Tadros Y. Malaty: *The School of Alexandria*, Bk 1, 1995, pp. 150-1]

MANIA, ST.

So many saintly virgins used to live in Ancyra in Turkey. They lived in convents following a strict blessed ascetic life. Their numbers reached about 2,000 virgins. One of them, her name was Mania, was quite well known. She was forced by her mother to get married. However, she kept on excusing herself from any physical relationship with her husband, by claiming illness. After a little while, her husband died, and she dedicated her whole life to Christ.

She lived such a holy life in the fear of God that the other virgins used to seek her blessing. They felt ashamed of their sins whenever they see her around. She was always compassionate toward the poor and the strangers, and she worshipped the Lord from her whole heart until she reposed in peace.

[The Paradise of Saints, p. 44]

MANSUR IBN BUTROS & HIS COMPANIONS (The martyrs)

Ibrahim the Syrian was initially a Christian, and then he denied his faith in Egypt during the days of the Circassian Mamluks (1382-1517 AD). Then, Ibrahim traveled to the wilderness of the Scetis and dragged from over there two people: Mansur ibn Butros and his companion Daoud and forced them to go with him to Cairo, in an attempt to make them deny their faith.

However, when Ibrahim saw the great faith and perseverance of these two saints and their courage in overcoming the evil and how they did not hesitate

in receiving the crown of martyrdom; their actions pierced the heart of Ibrahim that he repented over his denial of faith, and to atone for his sin; he followed them on the path of martyrdom.

[The Patriotism of the Coptic Church and its History, p. 250]

MARCELLA (The martyr)

The Mother of Potamiaena:

St. Marcella (Marcel) was an Egyptian martyr from Alexandria at the beginning of the 3rd century AD. Marcella was a virtuous Christian woman who had only one daughter called Potamiaena (whose biography could be found under the letter 'P.' She raised her on the Christian principles of chastity and educated her with all the Divine teachings. She always used to take her along to the Theological School of Alexandria, to listen to the spiritual sermons of the saintly fathers of the church. There, they were active participants in asking and inquiring about anything that they could not understand from the texts of the Holy Bible.

Supporting her Daughter during her Martyrdom:

When the governor arrested Potamiaena, and tortured her in every possible way, before which she remained steady and robust, he ordered to arrest her mother Marcella as well, hoping that she would seduce her daughter to change course before the intense torture. He gave the mother all promises to set her daughter free; but was shocked to hear the mother cry out to her daughter, saying: "I have betrothed you to the Heavenly Groom Jesus Christ. Stand fast in His love, for He prepared for you a heavenly crown and a true wedding, which surpass in beauty all the weddings and pleasures of the earth. Do not be afraid Potamiaena from those who kill your body, yet unable to touch your soul."

On hearing Marcella encouraging her daughter with those words, the angry governor, ordered to drop Potamiaena into boiling tar in front of her mother. St. Marcella persisted on encouraging her daughter to raise her eyes high, where her crown was waiting for her, the moment her soul would come out; to be wedded as a pure bride to her Heavenly Groom Jesus Christ.

The Martyrdom of St. Marcella:

After prolonged torture, St. Potamiaena delivered her soul. Then, the evil governor ordered to put her mother Marcella inside a fiery furnace, where she gave her soul in the hands of the Heavenly Father. This lady saint left behind an incredibly beautiful example of Christian motherhood and of the genuine

compassion which surpasses every physical and human one. Together with her daughter, they both gained the real wedding, the perpetual eternity in the Paradise of joy.

[The Martyrs: Lucy, Cicil, Marcel and Aghaby, p. 35]

MARCELLA, THE WIDOW, ST.

St. Marcella (Marcel) was called by St. Jerome: ‘The Pride of the Roman Women.’ When her father passed away from this world while she was still young, her mother Albina cared for her and raised her in the fear of God. Then, after being married for only seven months, St. Marcella lost her husband, and being from one of the elite families in Rome, the Roman Consul Cerealis, who was advanced in age and very wealthy, proposed to marry her and let her eventually inherit him. Yet Marcella refused, since she vowed, as a widow, to dedicate her life to the Lord.

She begged her mother not to pressure her in doing what she did not want to, and she decided not to get preoccupied with the affairs of this world, but to dedicate all her life to her immortal Heavenly Groom. In asceticism, she imitated the style of worship of the Eastern Church. She refrained from eating meat and drinking wine; she spent her time reading the Holy Bible, praying, visiting churches, and did not talk to any man in private.

A House of Virgins:

St. Marcella paid a lot of attention to serving the widows. She advised them on the holy life in the Lord and had the Holy Bible as the only subject of her talks. So many virgins and elite widows followed her in Rome. They were imitating her approach; they distributed their wealth on the poor and the needy, dedicated their lives to worship and placed themselves under her supervision and guidance.

When St. Jerome came to Rome, accompanied by St. Epiphanius and St. Polinus, St. Marcella sought from him to interpret for them some verses of the Holy Bible; which he did. After he left to Jerusalem, she took upon herself to interpret the Holy Bible to the women. Eleven letters from St. Jerome were found, including answers to her inquiries about religion.

For her love for a life of seclusion, St. Marcella left Rome, and having read about the role played by St. Pachomius the Great in establishing convents for women in Upper Egypt; she dressed in the monastic attire and drew to that lifestyle so many of the Roman women. Then, they established many houses for the virgins and nuns in Rome.

However, when the Gothic barbarians entered into Rome in the year 410

AD, they burned and destroyed the city and killed whomever they encountered. They entered into the houses of the virgins, and they scourged St. Marcella to force her to hand in her possessions, which she had long before distributed among the poor and the needy. She did not care for their bad treatment, as much as she cared for a virgin by the name Principia, who was the only one who stayed behind with her after all the other virgins had escaped. Falling at the feet of the soldiers and begging them to do them no more harm; God let the soldiers have compassion on them and left them safe at St. Paul's church. St. Marcella lived a short period after that, then reposed in the hands of Principia her spiritual daughter at the end of August 410, and she is celebrated by the Western Church on the 31st of January every year.

[Butler: January 31]

[Fr. Butros the Jesuit: Pastures of the Pious in the Biographies of the Righteous;
Beirut 1880; 31 Kanon II]

MARCELLINA, THE VIRGIN, ST.

Taking Care of her Two Brothers:

St. Marcellina was the older sister of St. Ambrose (Ambrosius), bishop of Milan. That virgin deaconess belonged to a family rich in wealth and faith. Her father was the governor of France in the days of Emperor Constantine II (337-340 AD). Early in her life, she went to Rome along with her family, and in such a young age, she started to dedicate her heart to seek God alone. Taking on herself the responsibility of caring for her two brothers, she filled them with the love of virtue, not as words or appearance, but as a holy and virtuous life. She lived as a spiritual mother to her brother Ambrose, who eventually became the bishop of Milan (374-397 AD).

A Dedicated Virgin:

Marcellina's heart was so flared up with the Divine love, that she used to spend her late nights in spiritual readings and to stand for long hours in prayers with no boredom. Besides, she used to help her mother in the daily chores of the house, until she crowned her love for God by deciding to forsake the world refusing to get married and dedicating all her life to her Heavenly Groom.

Then, in the feast of Nativity in the year 353 AD, the pope of Rome Liberius (352-366 AD), set her as a deaconess dedicated for worship and service in the Cathedral of St. Peter in Rome. On that occasion, the pope in his sermon urged her to love the Lord Jesus Christ from her whole heart; and to live in a perpetual prayer having full control on her body, and sanctifying

the honorable church.

St. Marcellina used to lead a highly spiritual life, she fasted daily until sunset; and spent most of her day and night in prayers and spiritual readings. After her mother reposed, she remained in Rome, living in a private house together with another pious woman. She also outlived her brother St. Ambrose, the bishop of Milan.

She used to help her brother the bishop in the church, in serving the poor and the needy, in visiting the girls and women, and in assisting in the baptism of the female believers who accepted the Christian Faith.

Many virgins became attached to her, and many of them entered into the field of spiritual dedication and service; some of them eventually joined convents.

St. Ambrose dedicated his writings about the honor of virginity to her, and after he was ordained as the bishop of Milan, she visited him several times to discuss with him some spiritual issues and to help him to manage the affairs of the dedicated virgins. St. Marcellina reposed in peace around the year 398.

[Butler: July 17]

MARCELLINUS AND PETER (The martyrs)

St. Marcellinus was one of the most prominent priests of the city of Rome during the days of Emperor Diocletian (284-305 AD). At the same time, St. Peter was known for having the gift of driving the evil spirits out. They were both arrested and put in prison together with the Christians who were persecuted because of their faith.

St. Marcellinus and St. Peter became known for their zeal on holding the imprisoned believers fast to their faith while preaching to the non-believers. Among those who proclaimed their faith on their hands were Arthemius, the jail-keeper, his wife and daughter, who ultimately received the crown of martyrdom on the hands of the governor Serenus.

As for Marcellinus and Peter, they were individually taken to a forest called Sulva Nigra, where they were executed. Their executioners had the intention of hiding their burial location. However, the location was soon declared, most probably by the swordsman who converted to Christianity. Over their grave, a church was built by Emperor Constantine the Great (306-337 AD), in which his mother St. Helena was buried later on.

The martyrdom of St. Marcellinus and St. Peter was in the year 304 AD. In the year 827 AD, the Roman Pope Gregory IV (827-844 AD) moved their relics to the monasteries he established.

[Butler: June 2]

MARCELLINUS, THE BISHOP, ST.

St. Marcellinus was the first bishop on the city of Embrun in Gaul (France). He was originally from North Africa, and with the help of two of his companions: St. Vincent and St. Domninus, they managed to preach Christianity in a large district, which was later known as Dauphine.

Marcellinus made his headquarters in Embrun, where he set a podium for giving Christian sermons. Then, he built a great church to accommodate all the people who converted from paganism to Christianity by the effort of St. Marcellinus and St. Domninus. In that church, there was a font of baptism through which so many miracles of healing took place. Both of St. Gregory of Tours and St. Ado of Vienne testified that even during their days, the font of baptism used to get filled with water by itself in certain feasts; and its water had a mighty power of healing.

Marcellinus the Bishop:

Because of his faithfulness and zeal, St. Eusebius of Vercelli, ordained him as a bishop on Embrun. However, during his last days, Marcellinus suffered much persecution from the Arians that he had to get out of town and to spend the rest of his days as a fugitive in the mountains. Now and then, though, he managed to crawl by night to Embrun, to guide and encourage the clergy and congregation. Finally, he reposed in the year 374 AD.

[Baring-Gould: April 20]

MARCELLINUS, POPE OF ROME, ST.

Pope St. Marcellinus (296-304 AD) sat on the seat of Rome as a successor of Pope St. Caius (283-296 AD), and he remained for about eight years.

According to Theodoret (393-458 AD), he gained great glory in the difficult times through which the church passed during the persecution stirred up by Emperor Diocletian (284-305 AD), but according to another version during the middle ages, that there was a strong assumption that the pope weakened before the persecution, handed in the Holy Bible and burned incense before the idols. However, he repented and atoned his sin and declared the forsaking of his position. Then, he got the honor of martyrdom in the year 304 AD and was buried in the grave of St. Priscilla.

[Butler: April 26]

MARCELLINUS (The martyr)

St. Augustine dedicated so many of his works, including 'The City of

God,' to his friend St. Marcellinus, the secretary of Emperor Honorius (395-423 AD). St. Augustine and St. Jerome kept the bulk of the saint's works after his martyrdom.

A Controversy with the Donatists:

In the year 409 AD, the emperor gave the freedom of worship to a dissented sect of Christians called 'The Donatists,' who had extreme views, like refusing to accept the repentance of those who greatly sinned after being baptized or those who could not hold fast to their Christian Faith during the time of persecutions and martyrdoms. The Donatists in North Africa used that imperial decree of freedom as a chance to persecute the Orthodox believers who did not go along with their views. When the persecuted believers went to seek the help of the emperor, he sent St. Marcellinus to Carthage, where he headed a council attended by the bishops of the universal church as well as the Donatists' bishops. He tried to be an intermediary between the two parties. However, after three days of meetings, the council issued a verdict against the Donatists to annul all the privileges given to them and to order them to resume fellowship with the rest of the believers. Then, it was the assignment of Marcellinus and his brother Apringuis to execute the council's verdicts, which they did with firmness, according to the Roman law. Yet, their actions brought the protest of St. Augustine and stirred up the Donatists against them, and they were accused of plotting a revolt against the emperor by helping the Count of Africa Heraclian.

His Martyrdom with his Brother:

They were arrested and put in prison by orders of the emperor's leader Marinus. There, they were visited by St. Augustine, who vainly tried to get them released. Then, they were executed without trial in the year 413 AD.

Later on, Emperor Honorius firmly blamed his leader Marinus and described St. Marcellinus as a man of glorious history, and his name was added to the book of the martyrs by cardinal Baronius.

[Baring-Gould: April 6]

MARCELLUS AND HIS COMPANIONS (The martyrs)

Seventeen Christian people, the inhabitants of Oxyrynchus in El-Minya governorate in Egypt, were accused of opposing the imperial orders to worship the pagan gods. This group of believers consisted of the elite Marcellus, his wife Mammaea, their two sons, bishop Miletius, three priests, a soldier, seven other men, and a woman. They were brought chained before

the governor of Thumuis, who ordered to throw them before hungry wild beasts when he could not force them to sacrifice to his idols. On the execution day, while they were walking down into the arena, the governor cried out to them: “Are you not ashamed to worship a convict who was killed and buried, so many years ago, by the order of Pontes Pilate?” However, they were not shaken by his words; and bishop Miletius recited to them a confession of the Divinity of the Lord Jesus Christ. Then, when the beasts were brought to devour them, they miraculously refrained from touching them. So, the governor ordered them to be cast into a fiery furnace, which was instantly put out. Finally, their heads were cut off by the sword around the year 287 AD.

[Baring-Gould: August 27]

MARCELLUS AND VALERIAN (The martyrs)

The Escape of the Priest Marcellus:

During the slaughter set by Caesar Marcus Aurelius (161-180 AD) in Lyons, bishop Pothinus was martyred; whereas, by a Divine intervention, the priest Marcellus escaped to one of the towns, where he was given hospitality by a pagan man. When Marcellus saw his host offer worship before pagan idols, he discussed the matter with him, convinced him of the vanity of such a practice, and he believed in Christ and got baptized.

Then, Marcellus headed north, and in the way, he encountered governor Priscus who invited him to a celebration he held in his house. There, when he found out that the celebration included pagan rites, he excused himself for being a Christian. Yet his stand stirred up those present, who intended to kill him. So, they tied him up into the trunks of two trees they brought forcibly close together, and then they released them. Afterward, they buried him still alive down to his waist in a pit close to the river, where he died after three days out of injuries, hunger, and thirst, and he received the crown of martyrdom in the year 178 AD.

Some researchers link St. Marcellus to another martyr called Valerian, who escaped from the prison at about the same time; and had his head cut off by the sword in Tournus for the sake of his faith.

[Butler: September 4]

MARCELLUS I, POPE OF ROME, ST.

The pope of Rome St. Marcellus I (308-309 AD) was a priest in the days

of Pope St. Marcellinus (296-304 AD). He succeeded him on the seat of Rome, in the year 308 AD, after the throne remained vacant for as long as three and a half years. About him, the Roman Pope St. Damasus I (366-384 AD) said that his firmness in applying the divine chastisements brought on him the hatred of so many vain people. Then, when he was extremely firm against one of the apostates; Caesar Maxentius (306-312 AD) exiled him to an unknown location where he reposed in 310 AD.

Also, it was mentioned that a widow in Rome named Lucina converted her house into a church after his departure, and called it after the pope's name. The early church considered this pope as one of the martyrs, because of his strife, and his body was buried underneath the main altar in an old church which carried his name.

[Butler: January 16]

MARCELLUS, THE BISHOP (The martyr)

Emperor Theodosius the Great Spreads Christianity:

In the year 380 AD, the righteous Emperor Theodosius the Great (379-395 AD) planned on spreading Christianity all over the Roman Empire. The emperor sent a decree which urged everyone to confess the true Christian Faith taught by the popes of Rome and Alexandria. Eight years later, the emperor sent his deputy to Egypt, Syria, and Asia Minor, to make sure that the imperial order to destroy all the pagan temples was carried out in the whole Empire. This action naturally provoked the anger of the pagans.

When the imperial deputy arrived at Apamea in Syria, he sent soldiers to destroy the city's temple of the god Zeus. However, because the temple was huge and was very well built, the soldiers were unable to destroy it. The bishop of the region who was called Marcellus was observing what the deputy was trying to do, and he suggested to him to take his men to his next assignment and to leave the responsibility of destroying the temple of Zeus to him. On the next day, a contractor came to see bishop Marcellus and agreed with him to do the job if he would be paid double. The bishop approved, and the man and his workers started to dig underneath the main foundations of the temple, which caused the whole building to collapse. Bishop Marcellus repeated the same approach in destroying all the other temples.

Then, bishop Marcellus and his people reached a temple that the pagans decided to defend to their last man. So, while the bishop was trying to hide from the arrows aimed at him, some of the pagans charged against him and managed to throw him into a fire pit. In that way, he received the crown of martyrdom in the year 389 AD.

When his sons – as he was a married man – decided to avenge the death of their father, the pious governor stood in their way saying: “It is more befitting for you to rejoice that God found your father worthy to die for His sake.”

[Butler: August 14]

MARCELLUS, THE CENTURION (The martyr)

St. Marcellus was a centurion in the Roman army dispatched in Spain, and he was martyred in the year 298 AD in the days of Emperor Diocletian (284-305 AD) even before the great persecution that he stirred up.

Believing that the military service contradicted with his Christian Faith, even though he was not forced to sacrifice to the idols or to practice any other pagan rituals; he decided to abandon the army.

In the city of Tingis (in Morocco), at the time of the leadership of the leader Fortunatus, during a celebration of the birthday of Emperors Diocletian and Maximian, the centurion Marcellus stood in the arena and cried out, saying: “This celebration is paganist,” and he took off his military attire before his soldiers; and loudly proclaimed: “I am a soldier of Jesus Christ the Eternal King. I do not serve the emperor and refuse to worship your mute gods made of stones and wood.”

Marcellus was instantly arrested and led to the leader Fortunatus, who, after a trial, turned him to his superior Agricolaus. Before that superior, the saint confessed his faith and persisted on that he was a Christian, who was serving Jesus Christ, and not any of the armies of the world. Before his persistence, he was condemned to have his head cut off by the sword; and he walked in the way to martyrdom while praying on behalf of Agricolaus.

[Butler: October 30]

[David Farmer: Oxford Dictionary of Saints]

MARCELLUS, BISHOP OF PARIS, ST.

This saint was born in Paris, and he lived a life of sanctity since his youth. He dedicated himself to prayers and to grow in virtue. He seemed as though he did not belong to this world. Due to his charismatic personality and his advancements in holiness, Prudentius, the bishop of Paris ordained him as a reader, then as an archdeacon. Since then, God granted him the gift to perform so many miracles; that, after the repose of bishop Prudentius, this saint was unanimously chosen to succeed him on the diocese of Paris.

Because of his prayers, his people were saved from the attacks of the Barbarians, and many miracles were attributed to him, one of which was protecting the city from a huge beast. Finally, he reposed in peace at the

beginning of the 5th century AD and was buried on the bank of the river Seine, at a location which is now a suburb of the city, known as St. Marceau.

[Butler: November 1]

MARCIA, ST.

This blessed saint was a prominent man in Alexandria. He was longing to dedicate his life to God in purity **as a virgin**. So, he became a monk in a monastery near Alexandria, where he dwelt a long time in great asceticism, watching the nights, fervently praying and singing praises.

The Battles of Evil Desires:

The devil kept attacking him with evil desires for fifteen years without ceasing. However, the saint fought those battles with the grace of Christ, armored with prayers, fasting, tears, and perpetual worshipping with a contrite heart. After that many years and unceasing battles, the saint thought in his heart, saying: “O miserable Marcia, you have already spent fifteen years fighting against evil desires. Now, get up and go to the city of Alexandria and pretend to be an idiot and hope, by the grace of Christ, to have conquest in those unceasing battles.”

Marcia did so and went to Alexandria. He acted like an idiot (silly) and kept walking along the streets of the city, followed by scorning children and other half-wits. The saint became well-known in the town as the strange idiot. Many people had compassion on him and gave him alms, which he took from them, and gave to the poor while fasting all day. Most of the people believed that he was out of his mind, and sometimes other idiots would go after him.

Revealing his Sanctity:

God planned to show the sanctity of St. Marcia before his departure, so on the feast of Resurrection, He sent Abba Daniel to Alexandria to get the blessing of the pope, as he used to do. There, Abba Daniel encountered that saint while he was walking along the streets, almost naked, and was followed by some crazy people. On seeing him, Abba Daniel asked his disciple to inquire about where that idiot lived. Then, Abba Daniel went to meet the pope, and while he was leaving, he encountered that half-wit. So, he caught him and cried out: “Come forth now, you the inhabitants of Alexandria, and look at the servant of God.” When the people warned Abba Daniel, that the idiot might probably harm him, he proclaimed: “I am the half-wit. For nowhere in the wilderness or the city, you may find such a saint, whom the whole world is not worthy of.” He then took him by the hand to the pope, and

said to him: “Father, no one in this era, is like this saint.” The pope instantly knew that God revealed to Abba Daniel the truth about that saint.

Then, they kept pressuring him to tell them his story. He reluctantly ended up telling them: “I am a monk who, for fifteen years, was attacked by thoughts of evil desires. Then, I thought of coming to this city and pretending to be an idiot for the sake of God. It is now my 8th year in that way, while perpetually holding fast to my prayers, fasting and watching the nights.

On hearing his story, they cried. Abba Daniel spent the night in the patriarchate, and in the morning, he said to his disciple: “Son, go and call St. Marcia to pray on our behalf before we go back to the wilderness.” When the disciple went, he found out that the saint has already reposed. He returned and told Abba Daniel, who informed the pope. This happened on the 10th of Hator. Then, a great multitude gathered and brought the body of St. Marcia, and they prayed over it with great respect. From his body, many miracles took place, from healing the sick to driving the evil spirits out. They buried him while glorifying God, who honors those who honor Him and act according to His will.

[The Paradise of the Pure, p. 137]

MARCIAN AND LUCIAN (The martyrs)

These two saints studied the black magic, and then they earned their living practicing it. Later on, they converted to Christianity when they discovered that their magic has lost its power before a Christian virgin girl. They were later martyred in the persecution stirred up by Emperor Decius (249-251 AD) against the Christians. Their biography could be found under the letter “L.”

MARCIAN AND NICANDER (The martyrs)

These two saints lived in the 4th century AD, most probably in Durostorum in Bulgaria. They served in the military for some time, but once the persecution started against the Christians, they left the military. This was the reason for them to get arrested, and they were brought to trial before the governor Maximus.

The judge informed them about the imperial order that everybody has to offer incense before the idols. Nicander answered that this would not apply to the Christians, for they would never deny the living God to worship stone and wooden items. In the meantime, when Maximus noticed how Daria the wife of Nicander, kept encouraging her husband, he shouted at her: “You evil woman! Why do you wish the death for your husband?” She answered him: “No! I do not wish him to die. On the contrary, I wish for him to live in God

and never die.” When she heard Maximus claim that she wanted her husband to die to marry another man, she said to him: “If you have such a doubt, please kill me ahead of him.”

Again Maximus turned to Nicander, and said: “Make up your mind now, and decide whether you want to live or die.” Nicander answered: “I have already decided where my safety is.” This gave the judge the wrong impression that Nicander has decided to burn incense before the idols to save himself. However, the saint disappointed him when he stood praying in a loud voice, proclaiming his joy to depart from the anguish and tribulations of this world. The judge asked him: “How could this be when I just heard you proclaim your wish for life, and now you seek death?” The saint said: “The life I seek is the eternal life and not the temporary one in this world. Now I deliver my body to you to do with it whatever you choose, for I am a Christian.” Then, the judge addressed the other prisoner, saying: “Now! What do you say, Marcian?” He proclaimed holding fast to everything his friend said in the trial. Then, the judge ordered to cast them both in prison, where they remained for twenty days.

Brought again before the judge, who asked them again whether they were going to obey the imperial order; to which Marcian answered: “Anything you say will not make us deny our belief or deny our God who we believe is within us and that He is calling us to go to Him. So, we beg you to hasten to send us to Him, for He is the One who was crucified for our sake.” The governor was then obliged to issue his order to cut their heads off by the sword. For that, the saints gave him thanks, saying: “May God's peace be with you, O kind judge!”

They walked with joy to the execution site, while they were glorifying God. They were followed by Daria, the wife of Nicander, his infant Papinian carried by Pasirates, the saint's brother. The wife of Marcian was also following, but she was crying and making a strong attempt to change her husband's mind by reminding him of his little son. At the place of execution, Marcian kissed his little son and looked up to heaven, saying: “My God and Lord! The Almighty! Take this child under Your care and protection.” He then rebuked his wife for her weak faith and sought from her to go in peace because she would not have the courage to watch his execution.

Nicander's wife remained beside him, encouraging him to holdfast by saying: “Have courage master! Ten years I lived with you, and now, knowing that you are heading to glory, I am proud to be counted as the wife of a martyr. Go on offering God the testimony befitting His Holiness, and seek from Him to take me away, as well, from the eternal destruction.”

Finally, the executioners covered the eyes of the martyrs, then cut their heads off by the sword.

[Butler: June 17]

MARCIAN, BISHOP OF HERACLEA (The martyr)

He was the bishop of Heraclea (the metropolis of Thrace), and he was martyred in the year of 304 AD, during the persecution stirred up by Emperor Diocletian (284-305 AD).

[Butler: October 22]

MARCIAN, ST.

This saint was born in the city of Cyrrhus, Syria to noble parents. Because this saint had in his heart the intention not to be occupied with God and the world at the same time, he abandoned his friends and his city and retreated to the wilderness of Chalcis between Antioch and the Euphrates. He chose the farthest location and built for himself a cell so small that he could barely stand or lie without bending his body.

His seclusion, however, was as though a paradise, in which he spent most of his time singing Psalms, reading, praying, and working. He ate only a small piece of bread, just enough to give him the strength to do God's will. God shone His Divine Light on him to comfort him and granted him the grace of knowing the great secrets of faith. His reputation and his holy behavior spread around everywhere that many people asked to be his disciples, the foremost of whom were Eusebius and Agapitus.

One day, Flavian, the patriarch of Antioch, came to visit him, along with some of his bishops and sought from him to give them a word of wisdom. He stood silent for a long while, and when they persisted on their request, he said: "God talks to us every day through His creations and the universe around us and in His Gospel, to teach us what we should do to ourselves and the others. Now! Can Marcian add to that anything of value?"

God granted this saint the gift of performing miracles. One day a monk came to him on behalf of someone whose daughter was seriously ill, seeking from him a small amount of holy oil. Although he firmly refused to give him any, yet the girl was healed from that moment.

This saint lived a long life; and in his last days, he was disturbed by the wish of many people to have his body buried in churches they built primarily for this purpose. St. Marcian then gave a commandment to his disciple Eusebius and made him vow to bury him in secret, which he did later on. Fifty years after his repose which was in the year 378 AD, the location of his grave was discovered and was moved with great honor to where he was visited by multitudes.

[Butler: November 2]

MARCIANA, THE VIRGIN (The martyr)

This lady St. Marciana was an inhabitant of Rusuccur (Rosso) in southwestern Mauritania, and during the persecution of Emperor Diocletian (284-305 AD), she despised the glory of the world for the sake of acquiring the heavenly grace. So, she proclaimed her rejection of the pagan gods in front of the rulers. She was severely beaten and was insulted by being offered to the Roman soldiers to defile her, but God rescued her and miraculously kept her virginity, by a Roman soldier who came to protect her and proclaimed his faith too in the Lord Jesus Christ.

Finally, she was martyred by being torn into pieces by the horns of a wild ox and a leopard in the execution arena at Caesarea in Mauritania; about 100 miles away from the nowadays city of Algiers. Her martyrdom took place in the year 303 AD.

[Butler: January 9]

MARCIANUS AND MARCORIUS (The martyrs)

St. Marcianus (Marcian) and St. Marcorius (Mercurius) were disciples of St. Paul I the martyr, the patriarch of Constantinople (337-339 AD). It happened that Emperor Constantius II (337-361 AD), the son of Emperor Constantine the Great (306-337 AD), embraced the heresy of Arius, and when the patriarch opposed him, he exiled him to the land of Armenia and then sent somebody to strangle him there.

Those two saints wept on their patriarch on the day he was exiled, and they declared that the emperor has followed the faith of the excommunicated Arius. Somebody reported them to the emperor, who called them in, ordered to kill them by the sword, and to bury them wherever they were. Their bodies remained there until the days of St. John Chrysostom the patriarch of Constantinople (397-407 AD), who on hearing about them, he moved their bodies to the city of Constantinople, built an altar in their name, and put their bodies under it; and designated an annual celebration for them.

They were martyred on the 28th of Baba in the year 351 AD.

[The Synaxarion: 28 Baba]

MARCIANUS, The 8th POPE OF ALEXANDRIA

This pope (143-154) was born in Alexandria; he was the dean of its Theological School. After the repose of the 7th Pope of Alexandria Abba Eumenius (129-142 AD), the bishops unanimously chose and ordained

Marcianus to sit on the patriarchal throne. He walked on the way of his predecessors, as a teacher and a guide for the flock of the Lord. He was known for his good virtues, for his vast knowledge, piety, and humility.

Pope Marcianus sat on St. Mark's throne in the month of Hator 143 AD, in the days of Emperor Antoninus Pius (138-161 AD). He achieved the hopes of those who chose him; despite the intense persecution against the Christians at the time. The pope did not care about the persecution, but showed courage in all situations, preaching, giving sermons, teaching his flock and guarding them against the strange teachings and pagan philosophies; until he reposed in peace, as he lived in peace, on the 6th of Toba 154 AD. Pope Marcianus was succeeded, as head of the Theological School of Alexandria, by the very famous and prominent philosopher, the scholar Pentinus.

[The Great Patriarchs of Our Coptic Orthodox Church, Part 1; p. 42]

[The Coptic Encyclopedia: Marcianus, by Aziz S. Atiya; p. 1526]

MARCORIUS AND EPHRAIM (The martyrs)

St. Marcorius (Mercurius) and St. Ephraim (Ephraem) were brothers in spirit and relatives in flesh. They were born in Akhmim in Upper Egypt, and then became monks in a monastery near-by for twenty years.

When the persecution was stirred up against the Orthodox Church, and the Arians happened to enter to offer sacrifice on one of the altars of an Orthodox Church; these two saints came forth daringly and removed the bread and the wine from the altar, saying: "He who has not been baptized in the Name of the Holy Trinity is only fit to offer up an offering on the altar of idols."

There, the Arians caught them and beat them up so violently that they delivered their souls in the name of the Lord and received the crowns of martyrdom.

[The Synaxarion: 30 Abib]

MARCORIUS AND MARCIANUS

cf. "Marcianus and Marcorius" the martyrs.

MARCORIUS, THE MUĀALLEM

The muāallem Marcorius was one of the most prominent Coptic archons in the days of the 104th Pope St. Botrus VI (1718-1726), who was known by the title 'The White Rooster.' Marcorius was a clerk of Ibrahim el-Sabongi, one of the Mamluk princes (amir. Marcorius was appointed by Pope Botrus

VI, as an overseer on the church of the Virgin St. Mary, known as El-Āadawya, which muāallem Marcorius cared to renew, mend and adorn. He also cared to do likewise in other churches and to help the needy during his life, until he reposed in peace.

[The Patriotism of the Coptic Church and its History, p. 284]

MARCOS, BISHOP OF ESNA AND ASWAN

His Love for Knowledge:

Abba Marcos was raised in the village of Deir Tassa in Upper Egypt. When he reached the age of twenty-three years, he became a monk in the Moharraq monastery in the days when hegomen Boules al-Delgawy was the Abbot (he became later on the saintly Abba Abraam, the bishop of Fayyum). Abba Marcos traveled to Cairo in the year 1867, and he stayed for a while in the papal residence. Then, when the 112th Pope of Alexandria Abba Kyrillus V (1874-1927) asked him to go to the Baramus monastery to teach the monks there, he instantly left to the monastery and spent three years in his teaching mission, and as that pope admired those who have knowledge; he chose him as a bishop on Esna and Aswan by the name of Abba Marcos in the year 1879.

His Love for Construction:

God granted him the grace to see all the projects he worked on being completed; which were:

- 1- Renewed the monastery of St. Mina in the region of Ho, in Farshut, Qena.
- 2- Built a church in the name of the Virgin St. Mary in Aswan, a church of St. George in , Armant Waborat, a church of the Archangel Michael in Kamola. a church of Abba Pachom in Edfu, a church of the same saint in Aswan, a church of the same saint in Zeneia Bahary (Luxor), and a church of St. George in Armant al-Ĥeet.
- 3- Did some repairs on the monastery of the martyrs in Esna, and its three churches. And he built a new church in the name of the martyrs inside their monastery. Also he did some repairs on the monastery of St. Matthew, known as Al-Fakhoury in mount Asphon.
- 4- Established two schools: one in Esna and the other in Aswan.

[The Story of the Coptic Church, Bk 5, p. 98]

MARCURA, THE BISHOP, ST.

The church celebrates this bishop on the 1st of Baramhat.

MARCUS, THE APOSTLE, ST.

The apostle St. Marcus (Mark) has been called John; also, his name has been mentioned repeatedly in the Book of Acts and the Epistles. The two names he carried: John, a Hebrew name meaning: Jehovah is Compassionate, and Marcus (Mark), a Roman name meaning: A Hammer.

Mark was born in Cyrene, one of the five western cities (Pentapolis) in North Africa, in a town called Apriatolus. His parents were Jewish, belonging to the tribe of Levi. His father's name was Aristopolus, and his mother's name was Mary, a pious woman who was prominent among the early Christians in Jerusalem. He managed to learn and master three languages: the Greek, Latin in addition to his mother-tongue the Hebrew.

When some barbarian tribes attacked their land and their possessions, they abandoned Cyrene and moved to Palestine, their original home, and they settled down in Jerusalem. His pious family was one of the first families to adopt the Christian Faith and serve the Christian community.

His Relationship with the Lord Jesus Christ:

St. Mark enjoyed with his mother Mary the company of the Lord Jesus Christ since she was among the women who served the Lord with their money. Mark was a relative of St. Peter the Apostle (his father was a cousin of St. Peter's wife); a nephew of St. Barnabas the Apostle (Corinth 4:10) and also a relative of St. Thomas the Apostle.

St. Mark's mother opened her house to the Lord to eat the Passover along with his disciples in the Upper Room, which became one of the most famous locations in the early history of Christianity. There, the Lord washed the feet of His disciples and handed them the Sacrament of Eucharist. So, that room became the first Christian Church in the world (Acts 12:12), consecrated by the Lord Himself, who performed the first Eucharist Sacrament in it. In that same Upper Room, the disciples used to get together after the resurrection; and in it, the Holy Spirit came down on them (Acts 2:1-4). Accordingly, St. Mark's house was the first Christian Church in the world where Christians gathered at the time of the Apostles (Acts 12:12).

St. Marcus saw the Lord Jesus Christ, sat and lived with Him, and he was one of the seventy apostles chosen by the Lord and sent to preach, as testified by Origen (184-253 AD) and St. Epiphanius (310-403 AD). Hence, the church gave him the title: 'The Viewer of God.'

St. Mark was in attendance with the Lord at the wedding of Cana of Galilee. He also was the man carrying a pitcher of water, who was met by the

two disciples sent by the Lord to prepare the Passover for the Lord (Mark 14:13-14; Luke 22:11). Also, he was the young man who followed the Savior, and *"having a linen cloth thrown around his naked body, and the young men laid hold of him, and he left the linen cloth, and fled from them naked."* (Mark 14:51-52). This last episode was only mentioned in St. Mark's Gospel, which was a good indication that it happened personally to him.

His Preaching:

St. Mark started his ministry with St. Peter the Apostle in Jerusalem and Judea. Then, according to the Book of Acts, he set forth together with the two apostles Paul and Barnabas, in the first preaching trip, and preached with them in Antioch and Cyprus, then, in Asia Minor (Acts 13:4-5), but it seems that, because he fell ill in Perga in Pamphylia, he returned to Jerusalem, cutting his trip short. Later on, he resumed his cooperation with St. Paul in founding some churches in Europe, the foremost of which was the one in Rome. On starting his second preaching trip, St. Paul the Apostle refused to take St. Mark along with him. So, St. Paul and St. Barnabas parted from one another: Paul took Silas with him; while Barnabas took Mark and they preached in Cyprus (Acts 15:39); then went again to Cyprus after the council of Jerusalem.

Afterward, the mention of St. Mark has disappeared from the Book of Acts since he traveled to Egypt and founded the Church of Alexandria.

He headed first to his home town in the Five Western Cities in Libya, and from there, he set forth to the Oases, then to Upper Egypt, and entered into Alexandria, most probably through its eastern gate in the year 61 AD.¹

Here, history tells us the episode of his encounter with Anianus, the shoe-maker, who was the first Egyptian in Alexandria to receive the Christian Faith. The sandals of St. Mark were torn out because of the long journey, and he went to Anianus, the shoe-maker to fix it for him. While he was repairing it, the awl pierced his finger, and Anianus shouted in Greek saying "ο ένας Θεός," which means: O, One God. St. Mark took some clay, spat on it, and applied it to Anianus' finger, saying: "In the Name of Jesus Christ the Son of God;" and the wound healed immediately as if nothing happened to it. Then the apostle started talking to him about the true One God. At that point, Anianus and his entire household proclaimed faith and became a vigorous center of preaching for his new faith. Then, when Christianity started to spread in Alexandria, St. Mark ordained Anianus as a bishop and ordained three priests and seven deacons to serve with him.

¹ Most probably, St. 'Mark' entered into 'Alexandria' through its western gate, coming back from the 'Five Western Cities' in the year 60 AD...

At this stage, the pagans were stirred up against the Christians, and St. Mark left Alexandria and went to the Five Western Cities; Barqa, Libya. From there, he went to Rome, where he provided significant preaching effort, by which he helped St. Paul the Apostle. However, he soon returned to Egypt to follow up the development of the work he started over there. He returned to Alexandria in the year 65 AD to find the Christian Faith flourished further; then, he went to visit the Five Western Cities, then came back to Alexandria to be martyred in the quarter of Bokalia, on the seashore east of Alexandria.

Concerning St. Mark's preaching, we could add the words of St. Paul:

- In his epistle to Philemon, in which he mentioned St. Mark as one of his prominent helpers (Phil. 1:24);
- In his epistle to the Colossians (Col. 4:10-11), as one of the few who kept working together with him for the sake of the Kingdom of God, while he was going through his first captivity in Rome, as well as in his second captivity: *"and the time of my departure is at hand"* (2 Timothy 4:6).
- Then he wrote to Timothy to ask him to send Mark to him, *"for he is useful to me for ministry"* (2 Timothy 4:11).

His Martyrdom:

It happened that St. Mark the Apostle was celebrating the holy Sacraments on the feast of the Resurrection on the 29th of Baramouda, which fell on the same day as that of the pagan god Serapis feast. On that day, the pagans attacked the church, which the believers have built on the seashore, in the quarter known by the name of Bokalia, meaning: the House of the Cows. The pagans caught St. Mark and dragged him along the streets of the city, crying out: "Drag the dragon in the house of the cows;" until his flesh was torn off and his blood scattered all around. By the evening, they cast him in a dark dungeon. At midnight, the angel of the Lord appeared to him and told him: "O Mark, the good servant, rejoice for your name has been written in the book of life, and you have been counted among the congregation of the Saints." The angel disappeared, then the Lord Jesus Christ appeared to him, gave him peace, and the saint's soul was exalted.

The next day, the pagans came and resumed their torture by tying his neck with a thick rope and dragging the saint along the streets of the city until St. Mark delivered his soul in the hands of its Creator on the 30th of Baramouda the year 68 AD. The saint received the crown of martyrdom, the apostolic crown, the crown of evangelism, and the crown of virginity.

The pagans ignited a great fire and placed the saint's body on it to burn it; however, heavy rain poured down and put the fire out. The believers took the body, shrouded it, and buried it with great honor.

Stealing the Saint's Body:

Knowing how great St. Mark's fame was across the whole world at the time, some Venetian traders stole the saint's body from Alexandria in the year 827 AD, and they built a magnificent church on it in their city Venice to attract the pilgrimage and flourish the finances of their city. However, the head of the saint remained in Alexandria, and a great Cathedral in Alexandria was built over it. Lebanon believes that St. Mark has preached there. He also preached in Colossae (Colossians 4:10). Both Venice and Aquila consider St. Mark as their patron saint.

His Gospel:

St. Mark wrote the gospel which carries his name; and the Liturgy known as the 'Liturgy of St. Cyril'; referring to St. Cyril the Pillar of Faith, the 24th pope of Alexandria (412-444 AD), who was the first to document it, after adding some other prayers to it.

Establishing a Theological School:

St. Mark was credited for establishing the Theological School of Alexandria, whose fame spread all over the Christian world east and west; and presented excellent services to the Christian world, through the efforts of the scholars and philosophers among the multitudes of its graduates.

St. Mark and the Lion:

St. Mark is always represented by the Lion. Therefore, we find the people of Venice, who consider St. Mark as their patron saint; have made the lion his symbol, and set a winged lion in the great St. Mark Square in their city. Some explain the reason for this in the following way:

1. It was said that while St. Mark was walking with his father Aristopolus on their way to the Jordan river; a lion and a lioness confronted them. The father asked his son to escape, while he would try to distract the two beasts, but the son (St. Mark) put his heart in peace, prayed to the Lord Jesus Christ, and the two beasts were split open and died. The father instantly proclaimed his faith in the Lord Jesus Christ.

2. St. Mark started his gospel by saying: *"The voice of one crying in the wilderness"* (Mark 1:3); as though it is the sound of a lion roaring in the wilderness, by which the king of beasts prepares the way for the true King, our Lord Jesus Christ. As this gospel came to proclaim the dominion of the Lord Jesus Christ, it was befitting to be symbolized by the lion; for, about the Lord Jesus, it is said: *"Behold, the lion of the tribe of Judah"* (Rev. 5:5).

3. According to St. Ambrose (340-397 AD), St. Mark started his gospel by

the proclamation of the dominion of the Divinity of the Lord Jesus Christ the Server, saying: *"The beginning of the gospel of Jesus Christ, the Son of God"* (Mark 1:1); hence he is symbolized by the lion.

[Fr. Tadros Y. Malaty: *The Gospel According to St. Mark*]

[*The Church in the Era of the Apostles*, p. 341]

[*The Synaxarium*: 30 Baramouda]

[*The Coptic Encyclopedia: Mark-Saint*, by Aziz S. Atiya; pp. 1528-33]

MARCUS II, The 49th POPE OF ALEXANDRIA

In the Monastery of St. Macarius the Great:

During a pastoral visit by the 48th pope of Alexandria Abba Yoannes IV (777-799 AD), he discovered a dedicated deacon called Marcus among the youth of Alexandria, who was versed in his spiritual knowledge and God has granted him with a sweet spiritual voice. The pope was pleased with him and appointed him as his secretary. Later on, the pope took him along to the monastery of Abba Macarius, where he became a monk and was clothed with the holy Eskeem. Then, right after that holy procedure, an elderly hermit shook the hand of the new monk and proclaimed: "This deacon is worthy to sit on the throne of his Father, the great St. Mark."

Ordained as a Patriarch (799-819 AD):

When the bishop of Babylon reposed, the congregation sought from the pope to ordain monk Marcus, his secretary, as a bishop for them. The pope rejoiced for their request, knowing how worthy Marcus was for that honor. On hearing about the pope's intention, Marcus disappeared, and nobody knew where he was. Finally, the pope ordained another monk in his place. Marcus remained in hiding, even after the ordination of the new bishop was over, which caused the pope to be angry with him. As his conscience rebuked him, the pope sent a message to a saintly elder hermit, a monk at the province of Burullus in the Nile delta, to tell him how he was angry with his disciple. The elder hermit responded to the pope saying that God revealed to him that He kept his disciple to be able to sit on the throne of St. Mark the Apostle at the proper time. Pope Abba Yoannes IV rejoiced to receive that response. Then, when the pope's departure approached, and the people started to ask him about whom he would recommend to succeed him, he told them that an angel came to tell him that his disciple Marcus has been the one chosen by the Lord. However, once the pope reposed and Marcus heard about the intention of the bishops, again, he escaped to the wilderness. Finally, a group led by Abba Mikhael bishop of Misr (al-Fustat) was sent, and they captured him and

took him to Alexandria in chains, where he was ordained in the year 799 AD.

Friendship with the Governor:

After he was ordained, the new pope visited the governor of Egypt, Labib el-Dawla. Once the governor got to know the pope, a close friendship grew between the two of them. Then, when the governor told the pope that he could seek whatever he would want; the pope asked him to allow for building the churches required to serve the people and to allow repairing what needed to be repaired, and his request was instantly granted.

A Message of Fellowship to his Brother the Patriarch of Antioch:

The new pope also sent a message of fellowship to his brother, the patriarch of Antioch, who replied by a similar message, expressing his happiness for the unity of the Orthodox Faith.

The Decisions of the Chalcedonian Council:

Only a few number of people among the Copts approved the decisions of the Chalcedonian council. The new pope prayed day and night with tears for the sake of their return to the upright faith. God, responding to his prayers and tears, moved the heart of their leader, who was called Abraham, as well as the heart of his father George to true repentance. Pope Marcus welcomed them back into the Orthodox faith with all their followers, and he gave them the Holy Sacrament and ordained George and his son Abraham as bishops on their congregations.

Corrupt Politics and Sufferings:

In the time of the Abbasid caliph Harun al-Rashid (786-809 AD), his reign from Baghdad was marked by scientific, cultural and religious prosperity, but once he died, there was a fierce fight between his sons: Al-Ma'mun and Al-Amin for the caliphate, and a significant part of this fight was on the portion of Egypt. Also, Egypt suffered from accommodating about 15,000 refugees expelled from the land of Andalusia (Spain), after they attempted a revolt against the independent Umayyad caliphate there, but were defeated and exiled to Egypt. When they arrived, these exiled trouble-makers created chaos, burned the houses of worship, and disturbed the peaceful residents of Egypt. To comfort and strengthen his people, the pope kept wandering among them in Alexandria, until the exiled Andalusian made life very difficult for him. The pope finally had to forsake Alexandria and moved from one city to another. This kept going for about five years to avoid falling into their hands. Finally, prince Abd al-Aziz the governor of the eastern provinces managed to bring peace to the land.

The Bitterness of his Soul, and his Repose:

When those tribulations were about to end, a new calamity came on the pope, when the barbarian tribes invaded Wadi el-Natrun, vandalized the monasteries, killed most of their monks and the few who escaped from their hands were scattered over the vast desert. Extremely grieved, pope Marcus II bitterly mourned the monasteries and their dwellers and supplicated to God to make that calamity the last in his life, because all those events have completely broken his heart and filled him with heavy grief. Responding to his supplication, God sent an angel to tell him: "Don't be disturbed, O perseverant servant, for you, are going to depart to the heavenly places on the feast of the glorious Resurrection, and the sign will be, that once you finish praying the Holy Liturgy on the eve of the feast and have communion from the holy Sacraments, your soul will set forth from the captivity of your body." On waking up the next morning, the pope told the bishops who were with him about the dream he saw, and his vision was realized in all its details, and his soul set forth to the church of the firstborns.

[The Story of the Coptic Church, Bk 2, p. 403]

[The Coptic Encyclopedia: Mark II, by C. Detlef G. Muller; p. 1533-4]

MARCUS III, The 73rd POPE OF ALEXANDRIA

Pope Marcus III (1166-1189 AD) was chosen to be the patriarch in the year 1166 AD, after the repose of the 72nd pope Abba John V (1147-1166 AD). At the time, there were internal and external turmoil all over the land.

He was a merchant, deacon, virgin, and ascetic. He was called by the name: Marcus Abi el-Farag ibn Abi el-Saâd, known by the title 'ibn Zarâa.' He was of Syrian nationality and following the Coptic doctrine. He was ordained in Alexandria as it was the custom.

Great Tribulation:

This pope lived the emotions of his congregation, sharing their joys and sorrow, so he wandered all around the country to comfort the souls, to bandage the wounds, and to strengthen the weak hearts. This action was particularly important when he felt the great anguish which came upon the Copts, because of the tyranny of the Kurdish ruler Asad al-Din Shirkuh¹ (1163-1169 AD) and his minister Baha al-Din Qaraqush. They killed, robbed, and raped, in addition to their hateful policy against the Copts. With the pope resorting to prayers and fasting, God looked upon his tears, and Shirkuh

¹ He was the uncle of Sultan 'Salah ad-Din' ...

suddenly died.

The scholar Subḥi Y. Labib wrote the following paragraphs in his article about pope Marcus III in 'The Coptic Encyclopedia':

"Then, in the early years of the reign of the Ayyubid Sultan Salāḥ al-Dīn al-Ayyubī (1174-1193 AD), the Copts suffered heavy calamities, for Saladin decreed that their role in the financial administration of Egypt should be ended by their dismissal and their replacement by Muslims. On the other hand, the establishment of the feudal system¹ under the Ayyubid dynasty and the appropriation of land estates by the leading aristocracy offered the Copts the opportunity to serve in this new field, where their expert knowledge was sorely needed. In other words, the Copts left the government positions to control the growing feudal system established by the Ayyubid sultans.

On the religious scene, the situation of the Copts was worsened by the issuance of new decrees by Saladin, which mandated the removal of all crosses from churches as well as painting all the churches black. Bells were also silenced, and the Copts were forbidden to conduct their religious processions in the streets as they were accustomed to do, especially during the Holy Week, when they moved between churches carrying olive branches and candles. Saladin reinstated previous orders that required Copts to wear distinguishing dark clothing, blue turbans, and girdles (*zunnars*). He forbade the Copts to ride horses or mules, thus restricting them to the use of donkeys. The wine was forbidden, and this implied interference with their use of sacramental wine on their altars, although it was stated that this restriction was confined to the open use of alcohol. The decrees also prevented prayers from being voiced loud enough that the public could hear them.

The Islamic sources of this age record the particulars of this fresh wave of persecution, especially the works of the Muslim historian: Taqīy al-Dīn al-Maqrīzī about the Copts. The repression was so intense that Copts feared that the Muslim authorities harbored ideas of exiling them from Egypt and laying hands on the dwellings of all the 'People of the Covenant' (*Ahl al-Dhimma*). This action did not come to pass because the authorities feared that such a measure might lead to the collapse of the economy of the country, which was controlled by the Copts.

The immediate consequence of such trials and tribulations was the enhancement of the process of Islamization, and the pope looked upon these developments with alarm, taking solace in prayers.

Nevertheless, the skills of the depressed Copts were directed toward the

¹ The feudal system was based on getting land as a reward for service rendered... And a lot of the "Feudatories" were those land properties taken over by the government in exchange of military services or paying taxes...

vocations of commerce and agriculture, where they were able to build up back their wealth and recover their economic prosperity. Also, their active penetration into the Ayyubid feudal system gradually helped them recover what might be considered the equivalent of their lost places in the state administrative system. It is unclear when the humiliating measures imposed by Saladin began to disappear, but with the patience and fortitude of the Copts, their position began to improve even before Saladin's death. It appeared that the forces of nature collaborated with these factors in the improvement of the situation of the Copts. The Nile flood resumed in its fullness, and that together with the return of rain made the crops produce, and the increasing commodities created a world of plenty in place of former famine and disease.”

Near the End of the Ayyubid Caliphate:

Near the end of the reign of Salah al-Din al-Ayyubi, the country and consequently the Copts; entered a new phase of calm, justice, tolerance, and generosity, which was felt by all the Egyptians. Saladin ordered to re-build all the destroyed churches; and chose prominent Copts for high positions in the government, such as Al-Sheikh el-Raeis Safi al-Din ibn Abi el-Maali. Of the evidence of that peace was that Saladin having admired the Byzantine design by which the Coptic churches were built; he appointed two Coptic architects: Abu-Mansour and Abu-Mashkour to supervise the construction of his famous Citadel in Cairo. Once it was built, he made it the headquarters of his government, and it continued that way for the following 666 years (until the year 1874) when khedive Ismaail Pasha built Aabdeen palace and moved his government headquarters into it.

In the era of pope Marcus III, the Crusade wars flared up; and there was a controversy between him and Marcus ibn Qanbar the heretic. Yet the end of the days of this pope appeared calm to a great extent, even though their beginning was so difficult. That righteous man reposed in the year 1189 AD.

[The Coptic Encyclopedia: Mark III, by Subhi Y. Labib; p. 1534-6]

[Revealing the Secrets of the History of the Righteous Patriarchs; Bk 2; p. 33]

[The History of the Coptic Church, p. 466]

MARCUS IV, The 84th POPE OF ALEXANDRIA

Ordained as a Patriarch (1349-1363 AD):

This pope was originally a priest-monk serving in the church of the Virgin St. Mary known as The Hanging Church in Old Cairo. He was also among the clergy who took part in the preparation of the Holy Myron Oil during the

papacy of the 83rd Pope Botrus V (1340-1348 AD). Initially, he was a native of Qalyub in the Nile Delta, and his name was Al-Asâad Faraj, and as a monk, he carried the name of Gabriel, the angel of the good news. He was universally chosen to become the top shepherd of the striving church, and he was ordained in 1349 AD, during the reign of the Mamluk Sultan An-Nasir Badr ibn Qalawun (1347-51+1355-61 AD); and was also a contemporary of both his son As-Saliḥ Salāḥ ibn Qalawun (1351-1354 AD) and Al-Mansur Salāḥ ibn Qalawun (1361-1363 AD).

Tribulations and the Spaniards:

Among the prominent events during the papacy of Pope Marcus IV, was that persecution arose in the latter days of the first rule of Sultan An-Nasir Badr ibn Qalawun (1347-1351 AD). The Spaniards had requested the reopening of the Melkite Catholic churches (which were closed at the time) and demanded the release of a Spanish prisoner. After the sultan had agreed to these requests, he came back and asked for a hefty ransom for the prisoner, and Spain rejected his request. A dispute arose. Somehow, the Copts bore the afflictions of this dispute, and persecution ensued. Of the mercies of God was that this persecution was cut short by the removal of Sultan An-Nasir in 1351 AD, by the powerful Mamluk princes (amirs). He was succeeded by his son As-Saliḥ Salāḥ (meaning the good), who was not at all related to his name.

Tribulations and the Plague¹:

The wrath of heaven was proclaimed too by the spread of a plague, which reaped so many victims. At least one-quarter of the population died and certain cities such as Bilbays were completely vacated. The plague and the depletion of the population resulted in an economic collapse. Many feudatories² lost their labor force, and agricultural products became scarce. Within the towns, industries also suffered on account of the death of skilled craftsmen. Revenues of the state were depleted, and the church was hardly able to pay the land tax. The Islamic administration had to prey upon individual fortunes, and what made matters even worse was the failure of the Nile floods; the fertile lands were desiccated and resulted in diminished productivity. The Mamluk amirs became restless and violently deposed one sultan after another. To make matters even worse, the Bedouin tribes from the desert descended into the valley, especially in the distant and unprotected parts of Upper Egypt, and caused further havoc.

¹ This section is taken mainly from "The Coptic Encyclopedia: Mark IV, by Subhi Y. Labib"...

² "Feudatories" were the land properties taken over by the government in exchange of military services or paying taxes... These land properties were given by the government (to the Copts) as a payments for service rendered.

Amid this confusion, a Copt from the country came to Cairo, crying moralistic statements and urging people to reform their character. He was arrested by the authorities and brought before Islamic justice. Here he declared that he warned the Copts who had apostatized to Islam. The judge tried to deflect him from this policy and invited him to become a Muslim, which he adamantly refused, preferring martyrdom for Christ. Finally, he was beheaded, and his body was burned.

The law-abiding Copts, who did not make a noise about religion, did not suffer during those times, and the Islamized Copts, who chose to abide by their new religion, prospered and occupied high positions in the administration. They included Ālam al-Din Ābdallah ibn Zanbur al-Qibtī and Fakhr al-Din Majid ibn Qarunyah al-Qibtī.

Even though the non-Copts endured the plague, the Copts, on the other hand, suffered both the plague and the persecution.

Destroying and Burning the Churches:

During those tribulations, it became normal for the mob to destroy, burn, and rob the churches. The wealth of the Copts was confiscated; they were committed to wear the blue clothes assigned for the non-Muslims, and the pope was tortured and cast in prison. The mercies of God came from outside, from Ethiopia and Nubia, who threatened to treat their Muslim citizens in the same manner. Because of that external threat, the persecution calmed down to some extent.

Pope Marcus IV spent the rest of his life among his people, strengthening them, keeping their faith, and accepting those who returned to their faith and confessed their sins. He raised prayers to God, along with the congregation's loving hearts, to remove the calamity from his people. Heaven responded and relieved him of the oppression and tyranny after he remained on the throne for about fourteen years. He reposed on the 31st of January 1363 AD and was buried in Deir Shahrān.

[Fr. Raphael Farid: *Revealing the Secrets of the History of the Righteous Patriarchs; Part 2*]

[The Coptic Encyclopedia: Mark IV, by Subhī Y. Labib; p. 1536-7]

MARCUS V, The 98th POPE OF ALEXANDRIA

Ordained as a Patriarch (1602-1619 AD):

This pope was from the monastery of St. Macarius the Great in the wilderness of the Scetis. The bishops and the archons unanimously chose the monk Marcus of St. Macarius, who was originally from the town of

Bayadiyya in Beni-Sweif province. He was ordained in the church of St. Marcorius (Abu-Seifein) by the name of St. Mark the Apostle, on the 26th of Paona 1327 AM (1602 AD), to become the 98th of the popes of Alexandria; in the days of the Ottoman Sultan Mohammed III (1595-1603 AD). He also was a contemporary of the Sultans Aĥmad I (1603-1617 AD) and Mustafa I (1617-1618 AD).

The new pope started his papacy by visiting his people everywhere in the country. He also visited Jerusalem. In his travels, he wanted to strengthen his congregation's will and urge them to hold their faith fast. He was using what God granted him of vast knowledge, particularly concerning the Church doctrines.

Troubles from Within the Church:

It was surprising that the troubles that faced this new pope were from within the church. The problem originated when some of the rich Copts started to get married to more than one wife. Also, when the pope rebuked them and then excommunicated them for acting against the Christian doctrines, they were provoked to anger and incited the Ottoman governor to arrest and imprison the pope. Aspiring to replace the pope on the throne, the bishop of Damietta joined forces with those immoral individuals. However, the congregation was united and stood firm, and pressured the governor to release their pope.

Afterward, a holy Council was held, excommunicated those who married to more than one wife, together with the bishop who took their side. It was strange that the Muslim governor himself acted against those deviants, drove them out of their jobs, and dispersed them everywhere after confiscating their wealth.

Troubles with the Turks:

The Copts showed their patriotism, when they refused to take part in the revolts against the Turkish governor, stirred up in the area from the city of Tanta to the city of Cairo. Yet, when the Turks put those revolts down, they did not distinguish between those who were on their side or against them.

Troubles from Rome:

The Roman pope succeeded in drawing the king of Ethiopia to his side and convinced him to close the Coptic churches there and to force those baptized by the Copts to be re-baptized, and to re-consecrate their churches. However, the people in Ethiopia rebelled against him, with the support of the Coptic metropolitan. Civil war flared up, which lasted for six years, with so many victims among the Ethiopians. Finally, those Roman plans could not

hold for long in Ethiopia; the way the Ottoman tribulation could not hold for long on the Copts of Egypt.

His Departure:

Amid that Divine support on the church of the fathers and the grandfathers; Pope Marcus V departed in the 1619 AD, in the days of Sultan Osman II (1618-1622 AD) and the Governor of Egypt Ĥamidi Mustafa Pasha (1619-1620 AD). The funeral service on his body was performed in the church of the Virgin Mary in Ĥaret Zoweila – the papal residence in those days – after which his body was moved to his monastery in the wilderness of the Scetis.

[Fr. Raphael Farid; Revealing the Secrets of the History of the Righteous
Patriarchs; Part 3]
[The Coptic Encyclopedia: Mark V, by Subĥi Y. Labib; p. 1537]

MARCUS VI, The 101st POPE OF ALEXANDRIA

Ordained as a Patriarch (1650-1660):

Just twenty days after the departure of the 100th Pope Abba Metthaos III (1631-1646), a monk from St. Anthony's monastery named Marcus al-Bahjuri was chosen according to a recommendation by a prominent archon called Bishara. A delegation went to his monastery and brought him to Cairo, where he was ordained in the holy days of the Pentecost, to become the 101st pope on the See of Alexandria. That was in the days of the Ottoman Sultan Ibrahim I (1640-1648) and Ĥaydarzad Mehamed Pasha(1646-1647), the governor of Egypt.

Ordering the Monks to Return to their Monasteries:

At the beginning of the papacy of Pope Marcus VI, he issued an order that all monks have to return to their monasteries, according to the ecclesiastical laws and the monastic by-laws. Some monks, who got offended by that decree, complained to the governor that the pope was persecuting them. This accusation gave the Ottoman governor a chance to put the pope under arrest, and to keep him in prison, but after a little while later, the head of those prodigals, called Qudsy, went back to his senses and reversed the accusations made against the pope and sought his release. The governor accepted that request, but after forcing the church and the prominent Copts to pay a huge penalty for his release.

Collecting Money and the Persecution of the Copts:

This pope wandered all over Egypt for four years, yet not to care for his

people, but to pressure them in collecting money from the churches and the prominent Copts, even by unethical and forceful ways. In turn, the governor found it a good chance to pour more wrath on the Copts, and he issued orders that they should not ride horses or wear colored attire, but only blue ones. Besides, he imposed the ruling that the governor would inherit any dead Copt; depriving his widow and his orphans of their legal and natural rights, and to take the maximum advantage of that new rule and increase his wealth, he viciously plotted to kill a Copt or two every day; until the number of those killed in his days for the sake of inheritance, reached 1,200 men.

The Pope's Departure:

This pope departed from this world on the day of the Great Friday of the Holy Pascha while everybody was occupied with the events of the crucifixion of the Savior. However, he was prayed over, as usual, during one of the hours of the Pascha, and then his funeral service was performed on the Saturday of Light. Then, he was buried in the church of St. Marcurius (Abu Seifein) in the year 1656, during the reign of the Ottoman Sultan Muḥammad IV (1648-1687). This pope sat more than ten years on the papal throne; after which his post remained vacant for four years, seven months, and sixteen days.

[Fr. Raphael Farid; *Revealing the Secrets of the History of the Righteous Patriarchs; Part 3*]

[The Coptic Encyclopedia: Mark VI, by Subḥi Y. Labib; p. 1537]

MARCUS VII, The 106th POPE OF ALEXANDRIA

Elevating the Believers from Earth to Heaven:

This pope's original name was Simāan. He forsook the world, became a monk in the monastery of Abba Paul, the First Hermit. Because of his eloquence, works of mercy, love for all, and the kindness in his voice, he was ordained as a priest by the 105th Pope Yoannes XVII (1727-1745). When the monk Simāan prayed he used to raise the souls and minds of the believers from earth to heaven, to enjoy the praise of the Seraphim; confirming what came in the Liturgy of St. Gregory: "Receive from us also our voices together with the Invisibles. Count us with the heavenly hosts."

Ordained as a Patriarch (1745-1769):

After forty days from the departure of Pope Yoannes XVII, the bishops, clergy, and archons, unanimously chose the monk Simāan to be the 106th pope by the name of Marcus VII. This happened on the day of the celebration of the entrance of the Lord Jesus Christ into the land of Egypt.

On account of that Pope Marcus was a man of prayer and did not experience the bitterness and tribulations of life; the Divine Providence provided him with two peaceful years to give him a chance to get ready to confront the difficulties of his mission. During these two years of relative peace, the pope managed to meet and got acquainted with his congregation, prayed with them, and for them, and they prayed for him that God would support him. Then, it happened that peace came to an end with a fight between the Mamluk princes and their Mamluk soldiers, which lasted for eight months.

The First Bishop of the Coptic Catholic Congregation:

As soon as the outer tribulation came to an end, another one started from within the church. The Coptic Catholics congregation ordained their first bishop, and the irony was that they gave him the name Athanasius. They made his residence in Jerusalem, while his deputy, by the name of Yestus al-Maraghy, was operating in Egypt.

Pope Marcus VII, like his predecessors, continued to struggle with the foreign missionaries from the Roman See, who swamped the country and attempted to convert the Copts by offering them a quality education which was lacking in the first Coptic schools in the villages at the time. In the meantime, both Jesuits and Franciscans were active in the establishment of regular schools in a considerable number of districts spread throughout Upper Egypt. These kinds of difficulties, both internal and external, were faced by the majority of the Coptic popes during the 17th and 18th centuries.

His Writings:

In the midst of all that, the true shepherd kept watching over his flock against the wolves. Pope Marcus VII put a lot of effort to reach the individuals through his valuable writings on so many important topics:

‘Baptism; Confession and Repentance regulations; Interpretation of the Divine commandments; How to Purify your heart; Fasting; Prayers; Benefits of attending the Divine Liturgies; Death; Resurrection and the End of Time; and on Hades and its Sufferings.’

Also, for the first time, the church had a book documenting ‘The Ecclesiastical Services.’ This book covered so many prayers for Church Rituals, including readings on the Font of Baptism; on the woman who gives birth to a son, and who gives birth to a daughter; and prayers for the sake of the catechumens. In that way, the sermons, as well as the papal messages and the ritual books, became treasures of knowledge that filled the congregation's souls with happiness and joy amid the tribulations of this world.

In the church of the Virgin St. Mary in El-Ādawya, where he loved to retreat, his soul met those of the heavenly spirits, on the feast of the Archangel Michael and that of St. Damiana the martyr, and in the hour of his departure, appeared the two luminous great saints: Abba Paul the First Hermit and Abba Anthony the Great. This happened in the year 1769 after about a quarter of a century of his strife on the papal throne.

This enduring pope, who knew by the spirit the hour of his departure from this world, did not want to leave the church in confusion after his death; so he assigned Abba Butros the metropolitan of Girga who was the most senior among the metropolitans of Upper Egypt, to take care of his flock, until his successor would be chosen.

[Fr. Raphael Farid; Revealing the Secrets of the History of the Righteous
Patriarchs; Part 3]
[The Coptic Encyclopedia: Mark VII, by Aziz S. Atiya; p. 1537-8]

MARCUS VIII, The 108th POPE OF ALEXANDRIA

This pope was born in the middle of the 18th century in the town of Tema in Girga's province and was given the name John. Longing for the monastic life, he joined the monastery of Abba Anthony in the eastern desert. When the 107th Pope of Alexandria Abba Yoannes XVIII (1769-1796) reposed, the throne remained vacant for four months. Then, this father was chosen as a patriarch by an altar lot; and was ordained in the church of the virgin St. Mary in 'Haret el-Room on Sunday 28 Tout 1513 AM (1796-1809), in the days of the Ottoman Sultan Selim III (1789-1807) and Egypt's Mamluk chieftain governors Ibrahim Bek (1735-1817) and Murad Bek (c. 1750-1801). Pope Marcus VIII managed to steer the affairs of the Coptic Church and the Coptic community with great wisdom and much diplomacy during the significant events of the French Expedition (1798), which was followed by the French occupation of Egypt. He also was still the pope of the Coptic Church when Muḥammed Āli Pasha (1805-1848) became the governor of Egypt.

Moving the Patriarchate's Headquarter:

At the time pope Marcus VIII was ordained, the Mamluk governors ruled Egypt, and they were appointed by and under the control of the Ottoman sultan in Istanbul. This pope and his people had suffered the hardships of three administrations: from the Ottoman governors, then from the invasion of Egypt by the French (two years after his ordination), then from the return of the Ottoman rulers. In his days, so many unfortunate incidents of subjugation of the church and the Copts took place, including burning both the upper and

lower churches of Haret el-Room.

However, the period of this pope was full of great personalities; they were distinguished in the fields of religion and politics. They included: Abba Yosab el-Abah, bishop of Girga and Akhmim; el-muâallem Ibrahim Al-Gohary; el- muâallem Guirgis Al-Gohary; el- muâallem Malaty Yousuf; and General Yaâqub. In his days, the patriarchate's headquarter was moved from Haret el-Room to El-Azbakiyyah; that was because, when the French entered into Egypt, the Copts and their pope were bitterly persecuted by the Muslim mobs who accused the Copts of aiding the invaders. The pope had to move his headquarter to a place which was planned by el-muâallem Ibrahim Al-Gohary before he died. El- muâallem Ibrahim managed to get from the sultan a decree to build a great church in El-Darb el-Waseâ.

The way he got that decree was as follows: He was then the head of the scribes of all Egypt. In his official capacity, he was able to organize a pilgrimage to Mecca for one of the sultan's ladies, and in the meantime, he offered to her valuable presents. In recognition of his services, she asked him to submit a wish that she would carry to the sultan. Ibrahim at once requested a decree for building the church, which was granted without delay. The building, however, was constructed by his brother Guirgis Al-Gohary, who succeeded him in the diwan after his death. The cathedral was named after St. Mark the Apostle and was built on a land which belonged to General Yaâqub and Malaty Yousuf, and that area became the seat of the new patriarchate.

History of the Patriarchate's Headquarter: (Seat of the Coptic Pope)

- At the time of the foundation of Christianity in Egypt on the hands of St. Mark the Apostle, the throne was in Alexandria. [from 60 AD]
- In the days of the 66th pope of Alexandria Abba Christodolus [the Servant of Christ Ābd el-Messiĥ] (1046-1077 AD), the headquarter in the year 1047 AD was moved to the church of the Virgin St. Mary in Qasr el-Sham (The Hanging Church). [1047- c.1300 AD]
- Then to the monastery of St. Mercurius (Abu-Seifein), after the foundation of Cairo on the hand of the leader Gohar in the days of the Fatimids. [1300-c. 1400 AD]
- Then moved to Haret Zoweila. [1400-1600 AD]
- Then to the Lower Church of Haret el-Room. [1660-1800 AD]
- Later to El-Azbakiyyah in the days of this pope Marcus VIII, who was the first to be buried in the tombs of the patriarchs in that church. [1800-1968]

The French Campaign:

During the papacy of Abba Marcus VIII, the French campaign came to

Egypt, and the army of Napoleon Bonaparte occupied Egypt in the year 1798. When the French invaded Alexandria, the Muslim mobs became out of control and viciously attacked the Copts despite the assurances and declarations of their Muslim princes that the Coptic Christians were fellow citizens, and that whoever would harm them, would harm the Egyptian State itself. Yet, that declaration did not affect them, nor they feared the authority of Napoleon.

When the French defeated the Ottoman Mamluks, the Muslims gathered in the Azhar Mosque and paraded on the streets calling: "Whoever believes that God is One, should go to the Azhar Mosque. This is the day of the Strife to fight and take revenge on the infidels." The whole city was in an uproar, assuming that the French invasion was through treason by the Copts and with their secret cooperation. So, the Muslim mobs robbed the houses of the Christians of all races, and they killed whomever Christians they encountered; men, women, elders, or children.

When the treaty between the French General Kléber and the Ottoman vice-Sultan El-Sadr al-Aâzam was broken by orders from the sultan in Istanbul; the war was ignited between the two sides in El-Matariah, and the Muslims used the chance that the French soldiers got out of Cairo, and they turned viciously against the Christians. At the time, Nasif Pasha, one of the Ottoman Generals, arrived at the city with a group of Mamluks, and he proclaimed that they have defeated the French. Then, he called for annihilating whoever remained alive among the Christians. So, they mercilessly slaughtered them, and they did not distinguish between Copts, Syrians, or foreign nationals. This massacre kept going, until Āuthman Bek, one of the Turkish officers, alerted Nasif Pasha saying: "It is not fair to shed the blood of the citizens of the State, for it would be against the will of the high command." Finally, an order was issued to put an end to the slaughter of the Christians.

The French Persecuted the Copts:

When General Menou took over the leadership of the French army (1800-1801), after the assassination of Kléber, he converted to Islam and gave himself the name Ābd Allah, and he drove the Copts out of the government's positions; and entrusted the Muslims to collect the taxes.

The Pope's Departure:

Pope Marcus VIII reposed in the year 1809.

[Fr. Raphael Farid; *Revealing the Secrets of the History of the Righteous Patriarchs; Part 3*]

[*The Coptic Encyclopedia*: Mark VIII, by Mounir Shoucri; pp. 1538-9]

MARCUS IBN QANBAR, THE DISSENTER

This man lived in the 12th century AD. He was ordained by the bishop of Damietta, as a priest on one of the churches in one of the cities of Upper Egypt. This man had good knowledge and mastered the Coptic and Arabic languages. He also had some knowledge about the Greek language, that he translated some of the Greek books into Arabic.

Yet, he also wrote several books, in which he called for some principles contradicting the well-established principles of the Coptic Church. One of those contradictions was about banning the raising of incense since he felt no benefit from doing that. The Coptic bishops and congregation asked the 72nd Pope Yohanna V (1147-1166 AD) to excommunicate him. However, the pope preferred to be a little patient with him, in the hope that he would retreat from his vanity. However, when the pope heard that Marcus the priest has forsaken his wife and became a monk, on the hope that he would be elevated shortly to the rank of a bishop, the pope excommunicated him from the fellowship of the church after having confirmed his ulterior motives. However, Marcus ibn Qabar did not care and continued to preach his views, and when he was followed by a multitude of people, he also taught them to oppose the custom of circumcision, as being a Jewish and not a Christian custom.

Once the 73rd Pope Marcus III-Ibn Zarâa (1166-1189 AD) sat on the patriarchal throne, the bishops and scholars of the church wrote seeking from him to do something to keep the church safe from the vanities caused by Marcus ibn Qanbar. The pope brought him in and advised him, and he consented and confessed his mistakes. The pope absolved him, and he went back to his home town.

Yet, Marcus ibn Qanbar soon went back to his earlier evil ways. So, the pope held a Council of sixty bishops, and the council excommunicated him and defrocked him of his priesthood rank.

Then, Marcus sought the intervention of the Egyptian government, which was more than willing to do so. However, the pope and the bishops rejected the idea of letting the government interfere in the church's matters. They were ready, instead, to receive the judgment of Abba Michael the patriarch of Antioch, who did his best to resolve the problem, yet in vain.

Marcus ibn Qanbar then chose to join the Chalcedonian church, but finding out that it was then of weak influence, he forsook it. Then, he tried to return in remorse to the Coptic pope while his followers already returned to their mother church, but the Copts despised him for his constant instability of faith. So, he chose to return to the Chalcedonian church, which rejected him too, and he spent his whole life dismissed by all.

[The History of the Coptic Church, p. 476]

MARCUS MINUCIUS FELIX

Marcus Minucius Felix was from north Africa and lived during the 2nd and 3rd centuries AD. He studied Law and became a prominent lawyer in Rome. He was initially a Stoic¹, but he accepted the Christian Faith, and his heart was so motivated to preach among the educated pagans.

He composed a hypothetical dialogue between his friend Octavius and some pagan named Caecilius, whom Octavius led earlier to the Christian Faith. In that dialogue, Marcus Minucius Felix presented all the objections of Caecilius about Christianity and all the answers of his friend Octavius for those objections.

In his writing to the pagans, Marcus Minucius Felix did not depend in his dialogue on the Holy Bible, but on some philosophers such as Cicero (75-43 BC) in his letter concerning the Divine Nature and another one about Divinity, and two essays written by Seneca (4 BC-65 AD) on the Providence and Fantasy.

Anyway, Marcus's dialogue was so harmonious and has an imposing style. The Christian apologist Arnobius during the reign of Emperor Diocletian (284-305 AD) quoted from this dialogue in his response to the pagans in his 8th book 'The Octavius.'

MARCUS OF ST. ANTHONY, ST.

A Prophecy about his Holiness:

This St. Marcus has lived in the 14th century AD. He was a contemporary of the 87th Pope of Alexandria St. Mattheus I (1378-1408 AD), who was known as Mattheus the Poor. Marcus was raised in the town of Menshat el-Nasara in Upper Egypt. When he was five years old walking with his mother, they met Abba Severus, the bishop of Assiut. The bishop carried the boy on his arms and asked him about his name. Answering: "My name is Marcus." The bishop exultantly said to him: "Indeed, my son, you will be like Marcus the Preacher of Egypt." He blessed him, gave him back to his mother, and told her to take good care of him.

His Fasting:

Since he was five years old, Marcus was raised on the custom of fasting

¹ He was a member of the ancient philosophical school of Stoicism. 'Stoicism' taught that the path to happiness for humans is found in accepting the moment as it presents itself, by not allowing oneself to be controlled by the desire for pleasure or fear of pain, by using one's mind to understand the world and to do one's part in nature's plan, and by working together and treating others fairly and justly...

the whole day until sunset, like his parents. He used to stand still behind them until they finish their prayers, and as his parents were poor, he had to work since his childhood in farming, and he used to distribute the food given to him by his mother on those he would see more in need for it. Then, he would remain fasting until he would return in the evening to his mother.

His Monastic Life:

When Marcus reached the age of twenty-three years, he was longing for a life of monasticism, so he asked for his mother's permission; since his father already reposed, then he set forth to a monastery near-by. There, he was surprised to see how the monks were not fasting for the whole day and how they were even lazy in their prayers. Not feeling comfortable in this environment, he returned to his mother. On seeing him coming back, his mother screamed at him, saying: "I presumed that you have died to this world. Now, why do you come back? Beware, my son, that he who puts his hand on the plow, should not look back, lest he would not be worthy of the Kingdom of Heaven." On hearing what she has said to him, he instantly left her and set forth to the monastery of Abba Anthony, the star of the wilderness. Then, hegomen Raphael el-Neânaây, his future spiritual father, who happened to be in the monastery when he arrived, rejoiced to see him. He put him under his care for few days; then he took him along to the nearby monastery of Abba Paul the First Hermit, where there were just a few monks in that monastery, which would allow Marcus to live in more seclusion, not hindered in his spiritual strive by too much interaction with others.

There, Marcus dug for himself a cave in the garden of the monastery, where he trained himself to retreat. He also trained himself to fast two then three days at a time, until he could reach a whole week without food. Yet, fasting did not keep him from work. He used to gather firewood from the wilderness. So, he lived in that way for six years in the monastery of Abba Paul, until his body was so frail; that the monks had to carry him to the monastery of Abba Anthony and sought from the monks there to take care of him and to feed him with what would sustain his body.

Prince Yalbogha Persecuted Him:

When the Mamluk prince Yalbogha mistreated Pope Abba Matthaëus I and confined him to the monastery of Abba Anthony; that evil prince drove a large number of monks away from their monastery including that old monk Marcus, regardless of his sanctity and old age. The saint was beaten and dragged on the ground and refused to be given water to drink when he sought it from the prince. St. Marcus then raised his eyes toward heaven and said to the prince: "As long as you refuse to give us water, God Himself will do it

and will satisfy our thirst by His own hands.” At the moment, he said that; heavy rain came pouring in, even though it was summertime. Yet, that did not soften the heart of that cruel prince. He kept on abusing those saints and forcing them to walk until they reached Atfieh on the eastern bank of the Nile, in the province of Giza. However, he had to release them there, by an order from the Ottoman sultan.

Extending his Age by Two More Years:

St. Marcus lived until he reached a right old age. He used to gather the monks around him to urge them to practice the brotherly love and the life-giving advice. Then, when he saw them crying after he talked about his imminent departure, he told them: “My children! Do not cry, because I saw the two shining stars: St. Anthony and St. Paul, worshiping before the Divine throne and seeking from the Lord Jesus Christ to let me stay a little longer with you, and the Lord of Glory, responding to their request, told them He will grant me two more years.” So the saint lived those two more years, although he was bed-ridden, yet mentally alert. Then, he quietly departed, leaning his head on the shoulder of his disciple.

According to one of the monastery hermits, at the time of the departure of this saint, he saw a congregation of heavenly hosts coming down to the monastery. They surrounded the saint, until a woman carrying an infant came with a majesty which exceeded the light of the sun, sat beside him, received his soul and took it up to heaven. Abba Roweis (died: 1405 AD), who was his contemporary, by the spirit knew the moment this saint departed and addressed him from his place in Deir el-Khandaq.

[The Story of the Coptic Church; Bk 3, p. 351]

MARCUS, THE GOVERNOR (The martyr)

This St. Marcus was the governor of the districts of Burullus and Zaâpharan, and the father of the virgin martyr Damiana. He and his wife were Christians, and Damiana was their only child, whom they raised very well.

In the persecution stirred up by Emperor Diocletian (284-305 AD), he was called to accompany the emperor with all the other governors, to burn incense in the temple before the idols. Weakening and fearing that he might lose his job, Marcus did comply. On hearing about it, St. Damiana left her isolation and came to face her father and rebuked him. She lovingly said: “It would have been easier for me to hear the news of your departure to the house of eternity than to hear that you did deny our beloved Redeemer.”

Those words ignited the fire in her father's heart, and he instantly went to

Diocletian, and before him, he proclaimed remorse on what he did and confessed his Christian Faith. The tyrant ordered to cut the saint's head by the sword.

[Martyrdom in Christianity; p. 131]

MARCUS, THE HERMIT, ST.

St. Marcus the hermit is considered as one of the most prominent among the glorious Egyptian desert fathers. Although we do not know much about his life; yet St. Palladius¹ (363-425 AD) who enjoyed meeting him in person, described his meekness and tranquility, as beyond comparison. According to Palladius, since his youth, St. Marcus was so fond of studying the Holy Bible; that he memorized all the books of the Old and New Testaments. Marcus could recite the entire Holy Bible by heart while he was still a young man. Yet, he was humble to a great extent, as well as pure in body and mind.

St. Marcus reached a high level of spiritual perfection by living an upright life with a pure heart. He was called St. Marcus the Weeper, because of his sensitivity and his closeness from God. St. Macarius of Alexandria testified to that since he had seen a sign during giving the Holy Communion, which gave testimony by the Divine grace, showing the greatness of the faith of St. Marcus the hermit, and the extent of his love for God and his deep humility.

St. Palladius Narrated:

“I was told by the blessed St. Macarius since he was a priest: ‘During giving the Holy Communion, that while I did not give the Holy Sacraments to Marcus the hermit, but it was rather an angel who gave them to him from the altar. I only have seen the serving hand’.”

St. Marcus lived more than 100 years; and probably reposed at the beginning of the 5th century, after he lived with the early group of believers who followed the example and teachings of St. Anthony the Great. St. Marcus most probably has met St. Anthony in person. By the Divine grace and from his own life experience and the study of the Word of God, St. Marcus was granted the kind of deep knowledge in the secrets of the spiritual life. This gift he did not hide, but he taught about it and wrote about it, even though what reached us of what he wrote was just a few fragments.

From His Writings:

- **Baptism and Human Freedom:**

¹ St. Palladius of Galatia is the author of “*The Lausiac History*” about the saints in the 4th & 5th centuries.

The Holy Baptism grants us complete freedom. Yet, the human being has absolute freedom to do as he/she wills, whether to be enslaved again to the evil desires; or to live free in observing the commandments. In case an evil desire gets attached to our mind; it would be of our own choice and not imposed on us against our will; according to the Holy Bible that we have been given the power "*casting down arguments*" (2 Corinthians 10:5).

The evil thought for those who overcome it is a sign of their love for God and not for the sin, for the mere presence of the evil thought is not a sin, but the sin lies in how the mind converse with it in a friendly attitude.

As long as we are not fond of the evil thoughts; why then, would we keep lingering in it? For what we hate by our whole heart, we should never let our hearts converse with for long; unless we have an evil fellowship with that thought.

- **Every sin delivers us to another sin:**

There is a strong bond between our lusts and the evil thoughts which are bothering us. As though an evil relationship binds them together. Every thought would have deep roots in him who welcomes it; which delivers him to the next thought; that he would keep drifting from one evil habit to another against his will.

Who could manage to flee away from pride, if he is already filled with vainglory?! How could he not submit to the defiled thoughts, he who sleeps long and deliver himself to evil desires? How would he not be captivated by cruelty and absence of mercy, he who chooses to take things by force? How would he be able to escape from anger and wrath, he who enjoys them all?!

[The Paradise of the Saints, p. 57]

MARCUS, THE HERMIT, ST.

Marvelous Meeting between two hermits!

The biography of that hermit was mentioned in an ancient Greek manuscript¹. It could be summarized as follows:

St. Serapion was the father of 6,000 monks who lived as hermits in the caves of Arsinoy (nowadays El-Fayyum). Then, St. Serapion decided one day to visit another monk in the wilderness of Libya.

After a long journey, he had some rest at a place belonging to a monk called John. There, St. Serapion saw in a night-vision two angels in monastic attire, talking to one another about an elder hermit who was living on Mount

¹ Dr. Michael Max Eskander: *The History of the Church in Pentapolis...* He referred to a "Manuscrit grec de Bibliothèque de Digoïn d'après Chéneau: 'Les Saints d'Egypte', tom. 1, p. 409."

Barqua. They said that he was 130 years old, and for 95 years, he did not see the face of any man. Also, he will be departing this world within the coming forty days, to join the congregation of hermits who already left to heaven after they completed a long life of strife.

Awaking from his sleep, St. Serapion told his dream to his friend, monk John. John said that he knew several places in Libya, but never heard about Barqua. Then, he advised Serapion to travel to that old saint, bid him farewell asking God to lead him on the way, and sought from him to ask the old saint to pray on his behalf when he would arrive there.

St. Serapion headed to Alexandria, where he met with a caravan guide, and he asked him: "Is the Libyan Mount Barqua far from here?" The guide answered him: "Yes, but the travel by the sea is much faster; whereas by the land, it might take about thirty days, possibly by riding camels."

St. Serapion, however, did not hesitate but decided to go by land on foot. He filled his pot with water, sought God's help and guidance, and walked into the desolate Marmarick desert. He kept walking for twenty days through the desert without encountering any bird or animal.

When he had no more water, he started to feel thirsty and was on the brink of death. He cast himself on the sand and supplicated to God to rescue him. The two angels he saw in his dream came back and approached him, saying: "Get up, O man of God, and follow us." One of them said to him: "Look there, and drink from the water coming out from the sand; eat some of the dry herbs and go on your way, trusting in God, but you have to hurry up because Abba Marcus wants to see you before his repose." Then the angels disappeared.

St. Serapion resumed his walk for another seven more days, without feeling tired any more until he reached the foot of Mount Barqua. There, he saw beautiful flowers covering the high plateau above the blue sea water down below. He ate some dry herbs, and the gentle breeze made him go to sleep. The saint spent the next few days searching for that fantastic recluse between the desert and the green forest. St. Serapion raised his heart to heaven, asking for help to find him. At midnight, he suddenly saw the angels of God coming down on a spot near-by, and he heard them singing: "Blessed are you, Abba Marcus, who found such favor in the sight of God, that Abba Serapion, whom you wanted to see, is here now. Go and meet him cheerfully." Then, St. Serapion heard the recluse singing: "O Lord, one day in Your presence, is better than 1,000 years in the palaces of men." Then, he heard him talk to himself, saying: "Exult, O Marcus! because, neither your spirit nor your body were defiled by dwelling in this place, all along a century, because your body never knew evil desires; nor your eyes, which the devil could not defile by outer evil scenes; nor your hands, which did not

possess nor touched any earthly things. Your soul got satisfied with the food of the spirit, and your body got sanctified through mixing with the angels. Bless the Lord, O my soul, and never forget His goodness.”

The recluse Abba Marcus then came out of his cave, with his face wet with tears, and called with a loud voice, saying: “Come on, Abba Serapion, I know that you have safely arrived. Come near me, O my son.” He emotionally hugged him, saying: “Blessed is the name of the Lord, who brought you here. For the last 95 years, I saw no man's face; you are the first one. Please have a seat.”

St. Serapion took the chance to ask the saintly father some questions, which the elder St. Marcus responded to all of them with humility, saying: “For 95 years I lived in this cave and dwelt on this holy mountain; I tasted no human food or put on any clothes other than what is on me now. During the first thirty years, I suffered much from hunger, thirst, and nakedness. Yet, what would all that labor be, compared to the snares of Satan? I fed on the mire of the drain and drank the water of the sea. The demons vowed a thousand times to strangle me, to cast me down from the high cliff, and they produced horrible sounds, saying ‘Get out from this region, which you took from us by force. Since the creation of this world, no man dared to share it with us,’ but after such prolonged temptations by the devil, God had compassion on me. He covered me with His shadow, granted my body a special power, and the angels kept accompanying me. My son, I tasted the joy of Paradise. I witnessed the glory of the kingdom prepared for those who live in virtues. I also saw the Garden of Eden, the Tree of the Knowledge of Good and Evil, from which Adam and Eve ate; saw Enoch and Elijah in their unknown dwelling place on earth. In short, God never denied any of my requests to dig deep into the knowledge and into spiritual matters.”

Then, St. Serapion asked the elder St. Marcus: “How did you come to this mountain?” The saint replied: “My son! I was born in Athens, where I spent my early years and was educated in its great schools of philosophy. When my father died, followed by my mother, I said to myself: ‘Since you will eventually die as well, what would be your need for knowledge which provides you with a prominent position in this mortal world? Let me then live for the Lord alone, and let me get untied from all the bonds of this world. Let me focus only on spiritual practices.’ Then, I instantly sailed to the Libyan shores. However, I do not know for sure how I came to this place.”

Then, the elder St. Marcus the recluse asked his guest about the conditions of the world and its rulers; about the spread of the Christian Faith; about the troubles which the Christians have to endure from authorities and the heretics, and he ended his questions to St. Serapion by asking him: “Are their

saints living in the present days? Are there wonder-makers as the Lord Jesus Christ proclaimed in His Gospel?" St. Serapion answered him: "The Christian Faith is spreading and growing, just like a Mustard seed."

Here, the elder St. Marcus said: "How miserable would the earth be, because the Christians became Christians by name only, and they do not have the faith that the Lord Jesus Christ expects them to have." He added: "I bless You, O my God, because You guided me to this desert, kept me away from getting mixed up with other humans, and from dwelling in a land defiled by iniquities."

Once the sun disappeared beyond the waves of the sea, the elder St. Marcus said: "Abba Serapion, it is now time to praise God and to receive His kindness." He raised his hands toward heaven and started to sing the Psalm: *"The Lord is my Shepherd; I shall not want. He makes me to lie down in green pastures; He leads me beside the still waters."* (Psalm 23:1). How beautiful, O Lord the cup of wine I hold in my hand!"

With tears, he said: "My son! God has set a table for us there. Let us get in and eat the meal He provided us with." Then, on entering into the cave, St. Serapion saw as though a cloud came over the place; and he could distinguish a table covered with a new tablecloth, on which was fresh bread (as white as snow), two fried fish, olives, dates, and honey. After they sat at the table, the elder St. Marcus said: "Abba Serapion, please bless the food we are about to eat." Finding no time to say yes or no, a hidden hand appeared from underneath the table, which made the sign of the Cross on that fantastic meal.

St. Marcus stood up after they ate their meal and addressed his invisible helpers, saying: "My children; Clear the table." Rapidly, everything disappeared. Then, the saint talked to his surprised guest, saying: "My son! Look at the love God grants to his servants, for He used to send me one fish daily to eat, but for your sake, he sent two today. God's food kept me to such an advanced age without any illness, weakness, or labor of any kind. Now, my days are complete; and God brought you here to provide me with the final religious rites. Forgive me for the trouble I shall cause for you. I shall depart this night to eternity; let us then spend it praying together. After I die, bury my body in this cave, then close its entrance by large rocks, then go back to your monastery, for God does not want you to dwell here."

St. Serapion while shedding tears, said to him: "Father! Pray to God on my behalf, to let me follow you wherever you go, and also because I do not know how would I find my way back to my monastery."

The elder St. Marcus replied: "**Do not make me sad, O my son by these tears in the moment of my exalted joy.** Be sure that God will keep you until you arrive safely to your home. Now, I shall go into my eternal place of comfort." All of a sudden, there was a bright shining light in the cave with a

lovely fragrance; and he heard the saint saying:

“Farewell, O precious cave, where I lived together with God, in the spirit and body, and where my body will be buried, until the day of resurrection.

Farewell, O my body, the object of labor and need; because of you, I suffered hunger, thirst, cold, and heat. Get adorned with splendor and glory.

Farewell, O my eyes, which watched the nights; Now! Close your eyelids.

Farewell, O my bare feet, which got tired of standing long in prayers.

Farewell, O my brethren the saintly hermits, who dwell in mountain caves and seclusion in the wilderness.

Farewell, O the imprisoned, and the persecuted for the sake of the kingdom of heaven.

Farewell, O Church believers.

Farewell, O you poor in spirit.

Farewell, O earth; I pray all who live on you, would live in peace and the love of the Lord Jesus Christ.”

He then embraced St. Serapion and said to him: “Farewell, O my son and beloved brother. May the Lord Jesus Christ reward you for your labor on such a long journey. I implore you to keep everything I have on my miserable body; add nothing on it; leave it in the same condition that God created it.”

Then, St. Serapion heard a beautiful voice like music coming from heaven, saying: “Come forth, my son Marcus. Come and have rest in the places of true happiness and spiritual joy.” The elder St. Marcus cried out, saying: “Let us kneel on our knees, and raise our hands toward heaven.”

At this moment, unseen angels came into the cave, and set forth up to heaven carrying the spirit of Abba Marcus crowned with the crown of glory.

St. Serapion kept on singing all night long. Then in the morning, he dug a pit, in which he buried the body of the saint and closed the cave opening with a great number of rocks. Then, he prayed to God to help him find his way back to his cell. He went slowly down to the desert, and when night came, the two angels, whom he has seen in his dream, appeared to him again and said: “This morning you made a grave for a man, the whole world was unworthy of him. You have done a work of mercy that immensely pleased God. Now, please walk by night, when the weather is milder than by day.”

Obedying the two angels, St. Serapion followed the angels, who came to him by night and disappeared by day until he reached the place where his friend the monk John dwelt.

MARCUS, FR (THE DISCIPLE OF ABBA SELWAN)

Abba Selwan had a disciple in the Scetis called Marcus. Marcus was very

obedient, and at the same time, he was a talented scribe. Abba Selwan loved him more than his other eleven disciples. This situation angered the other disciples. When the elders knew about it, they felt terrible, and they all went to admonish Abba Selwan. He took them out and passed through the cells of the eleven disciples, knocked on the door of each of them, and called the one inside by his name, saying: "Brother so and so, come out because I need you." No one among them responded instantly to him, but once he knocked on the door of the cell of Marcus and called him, he jumped out to see him, and the old monk sent him for a task. Then, he told the elders: "Where are the other brethren, fathers?" on entering with them into Fr. Marcus cell, he found out that when he called him out, he was inscribing a particular letter of the alphabet, and the moment he heard the call of his mentor, he did not even finish it. The elders then said: "Actually father, Marcus whom you love, we love as well, and so does the Lord."

It was also said about Abba Selwan, that when he wanted to travel to Syria, his disciple Fr. Marcus told him: "Father, I do not want to leave here, and I implore you not to go as well. Please stay here for three days first." On the third day, Abba Selwan reposed.

[Publications of the Light: Sayings of the Elder Fathers; Lebanon, 1983]

MARCUS, THE EGYPTIAN FATHER

Refraining from Condemnation:

About Fr. Marcus the Egyptian, it was said that he lived in his cell for thirty years, and never got out of it, and a priest used to come to his cell weekly to ask him to make the Holy Bread (Qurban) used to celebrate the Holy Communion.

On seeing how virtuous Fr. Marcus was, the devil wanted to tempt him by the sin of condemnation. So, the devil incited somebody with an evil spirit, to come to the elder saint with the pretention of praying on his behalf. Then, before saying any word, he told the elder: "The priest who comes to you has the smell of sin; so do not let him enter into your cell anymore." The elder, inspired by God, answered him: "Son! While everybody cast their corruption outside before they enter into my cell, you have brought it inside. It is written: *"Judge not, that you be not judged."* (Matthew 7:1). That priest, even if he is a sinner, yet the Lord can save him. For it is also written: *"Pray for one another, that you may be healed."* (James 5:16)."

By those words, Fr. Marcus drove the evil spirit out of the man after he prayed on him. Then, he sent him away, sound, and healed.

As for the priest who used to come to Fr. Marcus, he was always received

with joy and welcome. Then, God wanted to show the priest's innocence to Fr. Marcus, so He allowed for the following sign:

When the priest was standing before the Holy Altar, God let Fr. Marcus sees an angel of the Lord come down from heaven, and put his hand on the head of the priest, and turn him into a pillar of fire. When Fr. Marcus was amazed to see that, he heard a voice saying: "Man! Why are you amazed to see that? If the earthly king never forsakes those who stand before him, how much more would the Divine Power do to purify those who set the Holy Sacraments before the heavenly glory?"

Fr. Marcus the Egyptian, the striver of Christ, was found worthy to have such a gift; because he refrained from condemning the priest.

[Publications of the Light: Sayings of the Elder Fathers; Lebanon, 1983]

MARI AND ADDAI, THE BISHOPS, SS.

These two saints attended the Pentecost Day with the Apostles. Later on, they preached in Syria.

Their biographies could be found under the letter 'A': (Addai and Mari)

MARIAH, ST.

Refer to the biography of 'St. Marina the Hermit.'

[The Paradise of the Saints, p. 83]

MARIAAM, THE RIGHTEOUS, ST.

St. Mariaam, this Ethiopian man was born to a mother called Rommanet El-Dahab, who was the daughter of the Ethiopian king David. His father was Fag, the king of Ethiopia. Horrible persecution by Islamic invaders took place against the church of Ethiopia. At that time, the Muslims caught him and castrated him to make a eunuch out of him. However, the saint counted that as a profit for the sake of his faith in the Lord Jesus Christ. Then, they sent him to the Arab king, who was from a Turkish origin. On the road, they tortured him and hanged him once upside down on a camel; then, they left him naked in the intense heat of the sun while thirsty. However, after the death of the Arab king, he was released and returned to Ethiopia. There, he built several churches, cared for the poor and the needy, and celebrated all the feasts of the saints. When his departure drew near, he set his slaves and

maidservants free. In the Ethiopian Synaxarion,¹ it was recorded that this saint reposed on the 21st of the Coptic month of Baba.

MARIAN AND JAMES, SS.

Those two saints were martyred in Lambesa in Numedia, during the persecution against the Christians stirred up by Emperor Valerian (253-260 AD). Marian (Marianus) was a reader in the church, and James was a deacon, and both of them were arrested in Kyrta (nowadays Constantine in Algeria). They were taken to be heavily tortured. After intense torture, in a night-vision, Marian reported that he saw St. Cyprian, who was martyred in the previous year, calling him to martyrdom, while James saw in a night-vision too that he was very close to the victory.

After they were tried before the governor, they were sent for execution to Lambesa, eighty miles away. That place was like a river's valley, with its banks gradually ascending on the two sides as though they were seats in a huge theater. In that valley, the line of martyrs was so long, and the swords of the executioners kept striking the necks of the believers, one after the other. Before it was Marian's turn, he talked by the spirit of prophecy about the horrible end waiting for the murderers of the believers. They finally cut his head off, and his mother took his body in her bosom, kissed it, and buried it besides that of his companion James. Their martyrdom took place in the year 259 AD.

[Butler: April 30]

MARINA, THE HERMIT, ST.

This is a biography of a girl who challenged the rules of nature. She clothed herself in the attire of men, to be able to practice the tough ascetic life with joy. Also, she was wrongly accused of committing a great sin, which brought on her troubles until the moments of her departure. Without defending herself, she managed to move heaven to defend her after she reposed; and to come to be the cause of the repentance of so many.

Her Upbringing:

Most probably, St. Marina was born in the land of Bithynia on the northwestern part of Asia Minor during the 8th century AD. She was the daughter of a very rich man, and she was called Mary. When her mother died while she was a little infant, her pious father Augatius raised her well and

¹ In its Arabic version...

educated her with all sorts of knowledge. Her father planned on becoming a monk, so he waited until the time came to give his daughter in marriage, then he could start his monastic life. At that point, he said to her: “Now, having reached the age of marriage and all my possession of wealth, land, slaves and cattle will go eventually to you; so, I decided to entrust you and everything you would inherit to the hands of somebody you get married to; a relative or a blessed man who has the fear of God, and from whom you would get blessed children. Besides, I have come to despise this mortal world with all its mortal pleasures and intended to join a monastery to be clothed with the angelic Holy Eskeem and find a chance to weep on my so many sins; hoping to be able to save my miserable self, and get away from my bad thoughts.”

On hearing her father's words, Marina bitterly cried, threw herself in his bosom, and said to him: “Why, O father, do you want to save yourself and bring me to perdition?” He answered her: “What should I do, you know. You are a woman?” She instantly got up, shaved her head, changed her clothes to those of a man. On observing how much she was firm in her will and diligent in her purpose, her father released all his servants, distributed all his possessions on the poor, the needy, the weak, the widows, the fatherless, and the captives. Then, he gave a portion to the church and left nothing for himself or his daughter. Afterward, they stood praying together and then left their house seeking the mercy of God and the forgiveness of their sins.

Augatius took his daughter by the hand and set forth on foot to a monastery. He introduced his daughter to them as his son Marinos, and the monastery Abbot received them with joy and gave them a cell to live in together.¹ After a while, the monks came to the monastery Abbot, saying: “You commanded us, O father, to test these two and teach them. However, we should rather learn from them, particularly from the beardless little boy, who whenever we tell him the commandments of the Gospel, we find him already know by heart; and if we mention the prophesies, he would recite them all; and if we mention the four Gospels, we find him already know all of them.” After being tested, the Abbot put on them the Holy Eskeem of monasticism. They lived together in that monastery for ten years, after which her blessed father got sick, begged the Abbot of the monastery to take care of his son Marinos, and delivered his soul.

Father Marinos:

St. Marina was left alone and she doubled her prayers, fasting, and

¹ In the book: ‘The Pasture of the Righteous’, this part is reported a little differently... It says that the father came first; and having fears about his daughter, he sought from the abbot of the monastery to allow him to get his little son to join him. After having his consent, he brought his daughter over to the monastery, claiming that she was his son, whom the monks called ‘brother Marinos’...

asceticism, and no one knew that he was a woman, but assumed that his delicate voice was caused by his intense asceticism and staying very late at night in prayers. Her fame spread all over the region, and so many came to the monastery because of her.

Sent in a Mission Outside the Monastery:

The Abbot of the monastery sent father Marinos along with three other monks on a business mission outside the monastery, and they all spent the night in a motel. It happened that a royal soldier who was also in the same motel got hold of the motel owner's daughter, raped her, and instructed her to say that it was father Marinos who did it to her.

When she conceived, her father, the motel owner, went to the monastery and started to curse the monks there. The Abbot of the monastery appeased his anger, promised to put everything right and sent him away. Then, he called father Marinos and sharply rebuked him. Father Marinos wept and said: "I am a young man and I have sinned; forgive me, father." The monastery's Abbot, however, insisted on driving him out of the monastery. There, he remained close to the outside gate for a long time.

When the daughter of the motel owner delivered, her father carried the infant and threw him into the saint's lap. She took him and moved around among the shepherds to provide him with goat's milk. She (he) intensified her prayers and fasting for three years outside the monastery until the monks sought with compassion from the monastery's Abbot to allow him to return to the monastery. The Abbot responded to their request and let him in, however, he put on him burdensome laws, from cooking to cleaning, to sweeping the floors, to bringing water from a far-away well outside the monastery. All that, besides the regular monastic duties and laws already, he had to observe.

The Son Ephraim:

St. Marinos sought from the Abbot of the monastery a permission to allow the baptism of the little infant. So, after he made a metanoia, he said to the Abbot: "Please, father, do not punish the infant by the sin of his parents."

When the boy grew up, he was clothed with the attire of a monk and was called by the name Ephraim, and the grace of God dwelt on him. The boy had a lot of compassion for Marinos. He used to say to the saint: "Give yourself some rest father. I am a young man and can do your work." Marinos loved him very much and had comfort in him.

Marinos' Love for Strangers:

St. Marina used to fill her pot with water every evening, carry it to a tree outside of the monastery, with a little of her portion of food. She would leave

these items for the benefit of the passers-by who happen to sit under the shade of that tree in the heat of the day. Coming back to her cell, she kept praying for the sake of her brethren monks as well as for the Abbot of the monastery who accepted her back. Marina remained on such a tremendous pious behavior for forty years.¹ Her son Ephraim also worked with love and cheerfulness, that all the monks loved him.

Her Repose:

St. Marina fell seriously ill, that she could not go to the church of the monastery anymore. Ephraim kept serving her while weeping, but she kept comforting him by quoting from the Holy Bible. When the monks knew about the illness of Marina, they came to comfort him and to pray on his behalf. Thinking that his illness was because of the very firm laws he put on him, the Abbot sent more food and drinks to strengthen him.

Three days later, Marina told Ephraim to keep obeying the Divine commandment, and he gave a farewell to the Abbot and his brethren monks; then, she delivered her soul in peace. Ephraim bitterly screamed, and the monks came weeping to comfort him.

St. Marina's body was carried to the place where they wash the dead body before burial, then they discovered that he was a woman. They all cried out: "Lord have mercy." Then, they told the Abbot, who came and wept with remorse about what he did in punishing her. He called the owner of the motel and said to him that the monk Marina was a woman and not a man. He, as well, bitterly wept. While praying over her body, there was a monk with one eye who happened to put his face on her, and instantly had his lost eyesight regained. When she was buried, God commanded a demon to torture the daughter of the motel's owner and the soldier her partner. He brought them forth to her grave, where they both confessed their sin before all the people.

From her body, God performed so many miracles.

[Yousef Habib: St. Marina the Nun – from a manuscript in the Paramus Monastery]

MARINA (The martyr)

St. Marina was raised in the city of Antioch in Pisidia, in the middle of Asia Minor, in Phrygia, on the border of Pisidia. This Antioch was not the same as The Great Antioch, the location of the Antioch Throne, on the banks of the river Orontes (El-Āsy), fifteen miles from the Mediterranean Sea.

Emperor Diocletian (284-305 AD), ordered that all who worship any other

¹ This period might include the time she spent with her father in the monastery...

god but his would-be executed by being cast to the hungry beasts or by having their heads cut off by the sword. Diocletian organized the worship of idols, established temples, appointed priests, and a high priest. Their most senior ranking priest was called Dacius. He was the father of St. Marina and he had his residence in Antioch in Pisidia. When Marina reached five years of age, her idol-worshipping mother died. Her father chose for her an educator to provide her with the best nurturing possible.

Marina in the House of her Educator:

St. Marina's educator happened to be a saintly pious Christian, and she lived in a small town near-by. The governess kept Marina in her house away from the idols of her father and his practices. The little girl lived with that educator, who had great faith and love for the King Christ and was fond of the biographies of the saints and their teachings. St. Marina enjoyed the blessings of that virtuous woman; she heard nothing from her but prayers and supplications and saw nothing but humility, faith, and hope. The educator raised her on the true faith, not just by words, but also by the excellent role model, the gentle treatment, and the great compassion. In that house, Marina loved her educator and felt so much comfort and joy that made her forget all about her father and mother.

There, she lived for ten years until she became fifteen years of age. When her father died, she preferred to continue living with her educator, who considered it as one of the graces given to her by the Lord Jesus Christ.

The Strife of the Saint:

When St. Marina heard from her educator much about the biographies of the saintly martyrs, their steadfastness on their faith, their courage before the rulers; about how those pure martyrs used to race toward having their bloodshed for the sake of their love for the King Christ; she stood up to pray. She said: "O Compassionate Lord, aware of the weaknesses of humans; I implore You to give me the strength to overcome Your opponents. I give You praise forever, Amen."

When the new governor of Antioch in Pisidia, Alopharnus, was going around, searching for the Christians to arrest and torture, it happened that while he was sitting in his chariot, that he saw Marina passing by along with her educator. He was much impressed by her beauty and he decided firmly to have her as his wife, whatever it would take. When he sent his soldiers to bring her over to him, she prayed to God, saying: "Have mercy on me, O My God and Savior. Do not let me perish together with the infidels or to share my life with the blood-shedders. Do not forsake me, lest the sinners bring my life to perdition, defile my hearing, and change my understanding. Send to

me from above Your grace to strengthen me to stand without fear and to answer that tyrant properly. Look down on my miserable soul like a goat among wolves, or like a sparrow in the hands of its catchers or as a fish in the nets of fishers. Come, O my Savior Lord Jesus Christ, save me from the hands of this unclean infidel; for to You is praise and honor, forever Amen.”

When she finished her fervent prayer to the Lord Jesus Christ, the soldiers returned to the governor, saying: “We could not arrest her because she kept calling the name of Jesus Christ.” Here the governor was disturbed to hear that the girl was a Christian.

Before the Governor:

The governor was provoked to anger and moved by Satan to bring fear into that little girl's heart. When they brought her before him, he showed her the tools of torture while threatening her with death. Then he argued with her as follows:

- You maidservant! To which race do you belong?
- + I am a Nazerite, and I am not a maidservant.
- To which tribe do you belong, and what is your name?
- + I belong to the tribe of Jesus Christ, and my name is Marina.
- You are called by the name of Jesus of Nazarene, the Galilean, whom the Jews crucified.
- + Yes! I am called by His name, even though I am not worthy of Him pouring His grace on my weak soul and saving me from your infidelity and the uncleanness of your heart.

The governor then gave the order to keep her from entering the city. Later, when the governor went to Antioch and entered into the temple to burn incense before his gods. Then, he ordered his men to bring her before him.

Then, the following interaction took place:

- You should know, Marina, that I have compassion for your youth and splendor. So now! Come and obey my orders, worshiping, and sacrificing to the gods. In this way, you would get from me the greatest reward and you would be the favorite over all the others.
- + I shall never be shaken from worshipping the Living God, and I would give the thanksgiving sacrifice only to my greatest God, the Savior of all, and I shall hold fast to His worship alone forever and ever...
- By such a persistence O Marina! you will bring upon yourself the intense sufferings; your body limbs will be cut off; you will experience my wrath; and there will be no one to save you from my hand, except obeying my orders and forgetting your stubbornness. Worship my gods to

protect yourself and to keep your beauty. For then, I shall pour on you the most valuable of gifts, and lift you to the highest level; take you as my wife and make you a princess.

- + Do you think that I shall be terrified by your threats? I firmly believe that my good God will give me strength and send me help. I know for sure that you have no authority, except on my body; whereas on my soul, you have no influence whatsoever; as my God has said in His Holy Gospel. As for me, I am ready to receive any torture which would qualify me to have comfort together with the wise virgins who were joined with the True Groom – Jesus Christ – and were found worthy of entering with Him into His wedding. For my Lord Jesus Christ, whom I worship, has delivered Himself to death for my sake. I am not even worthy to submit my body and to endure all suffering for His sake.

At this point, the governor ordered to tie her hands and feet with ropes and to scourge her with whips and rods.

The Glory of Pain:

St. Marina raised her eyes toward heaven and said: “To You, O Lord, I lift my soul. *“O my God, I trust in You; Let me not be ashamed; Let not my enemies triumph over me.”* (Ps. 25:1-2). For Your sake, I endure these sufferings because I confessed to Your Holy Name. Send down on me Your mercy and compassion, to turn my sorrow into joy.”

While St. Marina was singing these praises to God, the soldiers kept beating her until her delicate body was torn off, and her blood poured down off her skin. Then, the Archangel Michael appeared to her, saying: “Great is your faith, Marina. Have courage; for by such good confession, your soul will live and you will get the Holy Baptism.”

Those standing around looked over and wept, they begged her saying: “O Marina! Your beautiful body got destroyed by this cruel governor, who put into his heart to wipe your name out of this earth. Obey his orders and worship his gods to save yourself from this torture.”

The saint answered them, saying: “My God helped me, and sent His Archangel Michael who carried those pains away from me, healed my wounds and opened up my eyes to see the wonders of God. What then do you want, you of little faith? If my body would perish, my soul is renewed and would join together with the souls of the wise virgins. Listen to, and believe in the Lord, who listens to all who seek him. As for me, I shall never worship those blind and mute gods, the work of human hands.”

Then, she addressed the governor and said: “Whatever you want to do according to the instructions of your father Satan, do as soon as you can; because my God has comforted me and He is my help, and although you

might have authority on my body, yet you have none on my soul. Only God influences my soul, and He will save me from your hands; while you will get eternal punishment.”

Then, the governor ordered to comb her body with iron combs. The chosen saint raised her eyes toward heaven and sang: *"For dogs have surrounded Me; the congregation of the wicked has enclosed Me; they pierced My hands and feet..... Deliver Me from the sword, My precious life from the power of the dog. Save me from the lion's mouth"* (Ps. 22:16; 20 - 21). Then, the governor ordered to cast her back in prison.

In Prison:

On entering into the prison, St. Marina made the sign of the Cross on herself, saying: “O Holy One! Who sets all good things with Your Hands. From the fear of Your Glory, all the creation is trembling. You are the Hope of the repentant and the Liberator of the captives. You are the Father of the fatherless, and the Judge of the widows. Please, look down on my humiliation and misery; and rescue me, do not forsake me, O my God, for I lifted my soul to You; and have no hope but in You.”

Theophimus, the writer of her biography, used to bring her bread and water from her governess place and receive from her a report of all that happens to her. While she was praying at night, the Archangel Michael appeared to her again, made on her the sign of the Cross, and instantly all her wounds were healed, and her pains vanished. She watched how a splendid light, shining more than the light of the sun-filled the prison and heard the Archangel Michael saying: “Have strength, O bride of Christ the chosen saint Marina; for you will get what you seek; you will fight against Satan your enemy, you will look at him face to face, and overcome him. You will get the Holy Baptism, and your spirit will go up to the eternal joy.” The Archangel Michael gave her peace and ascended to heaven in great glory. St. Marina stood praying until the morning when she was called again to appear before the governor.

More Violent Torture:

On noticing how all her wounds disappeared, the governor said to her: “Marina! Your sorcery became very obvious today.” She answered him: “No, I am not a sorcerer, but I am a maidservant of Jesus Christ.” The governor ordered to sow her flesh with an iron sow, saying: “Let me see, if the Crucified, will come to save you from my hands.?” Then he ordered to cut her flesh off by knives and to cast her in prison until her body would decompose. Yet, once she entered into the prison, the Archangel Michael appeared to her as usual, and said: “Have the courage to overcome your

enemies, and to gain the crown of joy.” He made on her the sign of the Cross, and she was completely healed.

A Dragon:

While standing and praying, a huge horrible dragon came towards her from one corner of the jail. On seeing it, she was terrified and knelt praying: “O, the unseen God, who bound Satan and absolved those bound by him; the Giver of life to the dead, the Breaker of the power of the great dragon; Look down on me, have mercy on me, to overcome this bad beast with Your power.” However, the dragon did approach her, opened its' mouth, and swallowed her. Her hands, lifted in the sign of the Cross inside the beast, split his inside open, and the saint came out unharmed while the dragon died instantly.

Satan:

St. Marina remained standing and praying, then looked at the left corner of the jail to see Satan in the form of a man sitting and putting his hands around his knees. She prayed to God, saying: “O Lord Jesus Christ, the beginning of wisdom, the King of kings, the Rock of ages; I give You thanks, O my God, the Power of those who take refuge in You, the Crown of the virgins and the Savior of the world.” Then, she captured Satan by her hand, and he said to her: “Marina! Obey the governor to save yourself.” Mariana found a hammer next to her, so she grabbed it and kept hammering Satan on his head, then put her foot on his neck and said: “Stop disturbing me O evil one; for my, God will save me from every sin; for I truly worship Him.” On saying that, a bright light shone in the prison and she saw before her the Cross of Jesus Christ, with a dove above it. The dove said to the saint: “O saintly virgin Marina, a crown of light and joy is prepared for you, and the gate of Paradise is open, waiting for you.”

Again, the saint made the sign of the Cross on Satan, then on the ground, which split open and became a pit in which Satan was swallowed.

Her Baptism:

On the next day, the governor ordered that the saint be brought before him. Then, he repeated his orders to her to worship the idols. When she refused, he ordered his men to drag her away from his sight, hang her somewhere, then burn her alive. Before the persistence of the saint on disobeying the orders of the governor, he ordered first to tie her hands and feet and to be immersed in boiling water. When they did so, she looked up toward heaven and prayed: “O, You who dwells in heaven, I beseech You to loosen my bonds and to turn this water into Water of Baptism. Clothe me with the attire of salvation; take

the old person away from me, and clothe me with the new one. Make me, by this baptism, worthy to inherit the eternal Life; and strengthen my faith.”

At that moment, there happened a great earthquake, the bonds of the saint were loosened; she plunged three times in the water, in the Name of the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit. Then, she came out of the water praising God; and a voice from heaven came, heard by all those present, saying: “O blessed Marina, now you are sealed with the Holy Baptism. Blessed you are, for you came to be worthy of the crown of virginity.” In that hour, many who proclaimed their faith in the Lord Jesus Christ were baptized in the water and received the crown of martyrdom after the governor ordered cutting their heads off by the sword.

Her Martyrdom:

When the governor finally realized that the presence of Marina posed a significant danger on his idols and their worship, he ordered cutting her head off by the sword. The soldier assigned for that task brought her out of town and told her that he believed in Christ and that he has seen the Lord Jesus Christ surrounded by angels. The saint asked him to give her a little time to pray.

At the end of her prayer, a great earthquake happened, and the Savior with His saintly angels came to the chosen saint. She was immensely terrified and cast herself at the Savior's feet, who said to her: “Do not be afraid, Marina. I came to consummate for you all your requests.” The Lord stretched His hand, stand her up, and said to her: “Get up, Marina. Blessed you are, for in your prayers, you mentioned all the sinners. I shall fulfill for you everything you asked for and more.”

Here, the saint said to the swordsman: “Brother! Do now what you were ordered to do.” When he answered her: “I cannot kill the blessed maidservant of Christ.” The chosen martyr said to him: “If you do not do what you were ordered to do, you will not have a portion with me in the Kingdom of Heaven.” Here, the swordsman approached her trembling and cut her head off, while saying: “O Lord, do not count this sin on me.” Then, he cut his head in the name of the God of St. Marina the Martyr, and he fell on her right-hand side. Then, there was a great earthquake; many of the sick and impaired hastened to get the blessing of the body of the saint and to seek her intercession, and they were all healed. Many saw the angels carrying the soul of the saint while singing: “No one is like You O Lord.”

When a multitude proclaimed their faith in the Lord Jesus Christ, most of them were martyred and received the crowns of glory, together with her.

[Dr. Emile Bishay: The Chosen Martyr St. Marina, 1997]

MARINUS AND ASTYRIUS (The martyrs)

In the history of the church written by Eusebius (260-339 AD), he tells about the martyrdom of St. Marinus in the year 262 AD, who was of a noble origin in Caesarea of Palestine. For his distinguished military service, he was highly decorated with one of the top medals. Competing with him for the same honor was one of his fellow officers, who claimed that Marinus was not worthy of it. He indicated that Marinus was a Christian and that he refrained from burning incense before the idols. Therefore, he sought to deprive him of that honor. The governor Achaëus called Marinus to investigate the matter. And when Marinus confessed his faith, the governor gave him three hours to reconsider his situation.

Once Marinus came out of the court of justice, he was encountered by Theotecnus, the bishop of the city, who took him to the church. Then he made him stand before the altar. The bishop pointed first to the sword hanging on Marinus side, then second to the Holy Bible, and asked him to choose one of the two. With no hesitation, Marinus stretched his hand and took the Holy Bible. The bishop then said to him: "Stand fast in God, who will give you the strength, by which you will get what you have chosen. Now, go in peace!" Going back to the judge, when Marinus bravely and persistently, confessed his faith, he was instantly taken away to be executed. A noble elite of Rome, by the name of Astyrius, close to the emperor, happened to be present when Marinus was martyred. He wrapped the body of the martyr in his cloak, carried and buried him with honor. Even though Eusebius did not mention that Astyrius himself was martyred, Rufinus (344-411 AD), beside the Roman and Greek Synaxarions, honor him as a martyr.

[Butler: March 3]

MARINUS, ST.

St. Marinus was a Christian stone-cutter, and when he heard that the walls of the city of Rimini on the Adriatic Sea in Italy were to be rebuilt, he went there to look for a job, along with his friend St. Leo. While they were working there, they got acquainted with a group of Christian workers of noble origin, who were condemned by the rulers to work in forced labor there only for holding fast to their Christian faith. During their work, Marinus and Leo kept on helping, comforting, and encouraging those condemned Christians, and managed as well to convert so many other workers to Christianity. Three years later, Leo was ordained as a priest in Rimini by its bishop. While Marinus, who was ordained as a deacon, went back to resume his work as a stone-cutter. He worked hard to hold fast the confessions and to

convert more non-believers. He remained working there for 12 years, as a good role model for a pious Christian worker.

Then, it happened that a woman falsely claimed that St. Marinus was her husband and that he has deserted her for such a long time. Marinus almost lost his mind because of that accusation, and he went and hid in a cave. He stayed away until the woman lost hope of finding him. However, he decided to spend the rest of his life worshipping God as a hermit in that cave. Later, they built a monastery in that location. And, the city of San Marino was eventually built on that spot. This saint reposed in the 4th century AD.

[Butler: September 4]

MARIUS THE PERSIAN AND HIS FAMILY (The martyrs)

The light of faith shone on Martha, a noblewoman from Persia (Iran). So she received the new life in Jesus Christ along with her husband Marius (Maris) and their two sons Abachum and Audifax. Their souls were exultant in God, their Savior, that they used to spend extended time praying. They loved the poor, sold all their possessions and distributed the proceeds on the needy, in accordance to the commandment of the Lord Christ, who said: *“If you want to be perfect, go sell what you have, and give to the poor, and you will have treasure in heaven and come, follow Me”* (Matt. 19:21).

In Rome:

Then, this pious family set forth from Persia to Rome to have the blessing of the relics of the apostles and martyrs. There in Rome, Emperor Aurelian (270-275 AD) persecuted the Christians at that time. By his orders, many of them were led to the vast arena to be martyred by the spears and the arrows the Roman soldiers were constantly darting at them. These merciless soldiers found great pleasure in killing those saints and burning their bodies before the pagan multitudes.

Gathering the Precious Jewels:

Following the example of St. Julius El-Aqfhsy (2nd half of 3rd century AD), who used to collect the bodies of the martyrs and send them with honor to their hometowns. He wrote down their biographies, in the middle of the fire of persecution. Martha, Marius, and their sons dared to approach the soldiers, generously paid them bribes, to allow them to gather the bodies of the martyrs, whom they considered being precious as jewels.

Before the Emperor:

Hearing about the courage of that noble Persian family, the emperor called

them for questioning. They stood with no fear before the emperor; for their hearts were raised to the Higher Jerusalem, enjoying fellowship with the Crucified Jesus Christ. Upon failing to seduce them in every possible way, the emperor started to get violent, and he accused them of three serious charges that could bring them to death. The first believed in the Lord Christ. The second was collecting the bodies, and the relics of the martyrs; while the third was provoking the Christians to disobey the orders of the emperor and refuse to deny their crucified Christ.

Eventually, the emperor gave his men the orders to have Martha drowned in the sea, 13 miles away from Rome, in a place called nowadays Santa Ninfa. He also ordered to have her husband and her two sons beheaded by the sword. They all received the crowns of martyrdom around the year 270.

[Butler: January 19]

MARK AND MARCELLIAN (The martyrs)

These two saints were twin brothers of noble Roman pagan origin. They converted to Christianity in their youth, and later on, they got married. In the persecution stirred up against Christians right after the start of the reign of Emperor Diocletian (284-305 AD), they were arrested, cast in prison, and condemned by the deputy governor of Rome Chromatius to have their heads cut off by the sword. However, their friends managed to get a temporary hold of one month on their verdict, hoping that they would be able during that time to come to be their consent to sacrifice to the idols according to the imperial orders. So, the two saints were moved from the prison to the house of Nicostratus, the scribe.

Releasing Them:

Then, their wives came with the little kids, as well as their pagan parents: Tranquillinus and Martia. They begged them with tears to change their minds. But, St. Sebastian, who was at the time a prominent officer in the imperial court, visited them every day to encourage them to hold fast to their faith. As a result of these multiple encounters and discussions among those two saints and their households, relatives, Nicostratus, and even Chromatius himself, all of them ended up believing in Christianity. The deputy governor Chromatius set them free and resigned from his job, preferring a life of retreat.

Their Martyrdom:

After the deputy governor Chromatius resignation, he was replaced by

Fabian, who re-arrested the two saints. Then, he ordered them to be tied to wooden posts and nailed their feet to the posts and to be left that way for 24 hours. Afterward, he ordered his men to shoot them with spears. That way, they received the crowns of martyrdom in the year 287 AD. Their bodies were moved to the church of St. Cosman and St. Damien. Their bodies are now in the Cathedral of St. Praxedes in Rome.

[Butler: June 18]

[David Farmer: Oxford Dictionary of Saints]

MARK, POPE OF ROME, ST.

St. Mark was Roman by birth and served God among the clergy of that church. He was the first pope of Rome. He was chosen after the liberation of Christianity at the hand of Emperor Constantine the Great (306-337). His new position did not distract him from being so alert on shepherding his people. He did expand his strife during the peaceful period the church was passing through, knowing for sure that Satan would never leave the believers for long in peace. When he consummated his short papacy, he reposed in peace on the 7th of October, 336. He remained as a pope for only 263 days.

[Butler: October 7]

MARK, THE CONFESSOR BISHOP, ST.

Destroying a Pagan Temple:

St. Mark (Marcus) was the bishop of Arethusa on Mount Lebanon, and he was a confessor. He managed to destroy a vast temple of idols during the reign of Emperor Constantius II (337-361 AD), and he built a church on its location. He also converted so many to the Christian faith. By his actions, he provoked the pagans to anger; yet, they could not do anything against him because the emperor was a Christian. However, they got their chance when Emperor Julian the Apostate reigned (360-363 AD) and then issued a decree that whoever destroyed a pagan temple had to rebuild it or pay a massive penalty. As Mark did not have the ability or the intention to obey that decree, he escaped before the wrath of his enemies. However, hearing that some of his flock was disturbed by his escape, he came back and submitted himself.

His Persecution:

The pagans caught the older man, dragged him by his hair along the streets of the city, scourged, beat, cast him in a sewage pit, and pierced his flesh with sharp poles. They tied his legs tightly with ropes, covered his body

with honey, and hanged him upside-down in a cage in the heat of summer to be stung by the bees and insects.

Amid all his sufferings, he was very calm. He gave thanks to God, who made him worthy to be raised close to Heaven. After a while, the mob's mood turned from violence to commendation and appreciation. They requested his release, and the emperor issued a decree to forgive the saint, saying that he did not want to give the Christians any more martyrs.

According to the historian Socrates (380-439 AD), the pagans of Arethusa were so impressed by the courage of the bishop that they asked him to teach them that religion which granted such courage. A large number of them converted to Christianity. It was said that the reason Julian the Apostate, spared the bishop from more torture, was that the bishop had previously rescued Julian when he was six years old from the slaughter that killed all the rest of his family. He reposed in the year 365 AD.

[Butler: March 29]

[A Dictionary of Christian Biography, Vol. III, p. 825]

MARO, ST.

St. Maro lived as a hermit near the city of Cyrus in Syria. He dwelled in a little hut covered with leather hides, which he rarely used. He preferred to be in the open air. And once he found the ruins of an ancient pagan temple, he turned it into a place for him to worship the True God. St. John Chrysostom (349-407 AD) used to admire him and respect him. He wrote to him from his exile in Cucusus, asking him to pray on his behalf; and to let him hear from him as much as possible. St. Maro learned from his teacher St. Zebinus how to pray. St. Zebinus used to dedicate days and nights to praying without boredom, standing with reverence leaning on the canescence he was advanced in age. He gave his counsel to those who asked for it in the least number of words because of his great desire to spend all his time in a fellowship with God in prayers and contemplation.

St. Maro was like his mentor in his faith and the way he prayed. However, he used to treat his visitors very differently. He not only received them with great generosity and compassion but encouraged them to stay longer with him, even overnight, standing with him and sharing in his prayers. God gave him many gifts, like healing the mind and the body. When his fame spread as a spiritual father, many came to seek his counsel. Many hermits became his disciples; he founded many monasteries and three convents for nuns, which carried his name. According to Theodoret bishop of Cyrus, many monks who populated his diocese were the fruit of the counsel of that saint. Finally, St.

Maro reposed in the year 433 AD, after a short illness because of his extreme weakness. A magnificent cathedral was built over his grave, with a great monastery around it.

The naming of the religious group 'The Maronites, which was originated in Lebanon, has been driven from the name of this St. Maro. They consider him to be their great father and do mention him in their liturgies.

[Butler: February 14]

MARTHA, THE EGYPTIAN SAINT

St. Martha was born to wealthy Christian parents. However, when she reached the age of youth, she loved fornication, ran behind her evil desires, and fell into a muddy path. Then, the mercy of God encompassed her and moved her to go to the church on the eve of the feast of Nativity. However, she was denied admission to the church by the archdeacon, and the bishop heard their loud commotion at the door. The bishop went to the church's entrance to find out what was going on. Then, when he saw her, he told her: "Don't you know that the House of the Lord is Holy and the unclean cannot get into it?" Martha was very deeply hurt to hear such words. She bitterly wept and said to the bishop: "Please, accept me O Father, for I am repenting from this moment on, and I am persistent on not going back to sin. The bishop answered her: "If your repentance is honest, then go and bring here all your silk clothing and golden adornments." So, Martha rushed to her place and brought back with her all those things. The bishop sold all that she brought and distributed all the proceeds on the poor; then, he sent her to a convent. In the convent, St. Martha firmly struggled in so many worships. She used to say in all her prayers: "My Lord! If I could not stand being disgraced by the minister of Your House, please, do not disgrace me before Your Angels and Saints." She kept striving for 25 years, and then she reposed in peace. The Church celebrates her on the 3rd of Paona.

[Repentant Female Saints, p. 63]

[The Synaxarium: 3 Paona]

MARTHA, MARIUS, and THEIR CHILDREN; THE PERSIAN (The martyrs)

Cf. St. Marius the Persian, and his family the martyrs.

[The Metropolitan of Girga: The Paradise of the Female Saints, Part 4]

MARTHA, ST.

St. Martha was the sister of Lazarus and Mary of Bethany. She was preoccupied with serving the Lord Christ (Luke 10:38-42; 12:1-2). The Lord said to her: “***I am the resurrection and the Life***” (John 10:25). She responded by confessing faith, saying, “***Yes, Lord, I believe that you are, the Son of God who is to come into the world***” (John 10:27). St. Martha is considered to be the intercessor of those who care for the needy, and is celebrated by the Western Church on the 29th of July.

[The Penguin Dictionary of Saints, p. 226]

MARTHA (The martyr)

On the 9th of Baramhat, the Church celebrates the martyrdom of St. Martha and her husband, St. Anderianus. St. Eusebius, St. Erma, and 40 other martyrs were exposed first to severe torture in the name of our Lord Jesus Christ before their martyrdom.

[The Synaxarion: 9 Baramhat]

MARTIAL, BISHOP OF LIMOGES, ST.

St. Martial founded the diocese of Limoges in central France, and he became its first bishop. According to the tradition recorded by St. Gregory of Tours, Martial was one of the seven preachers sent from Rome by its pope St. Fabian (236-250 AD) to preach the land of Gaul before the year 250. In that, St. Gatian taught in Tours, St. Trophimus in Arles, St. Paul in Narbonne, St. Dionysius (Denis) in Paris, St. Saturnin in Toulouse, St. Austromoine in Clermont (Auvergne) and St. Martial in Limoges. Each of them preached in their chosen region and eventually became its first bishop.

One of the 70 Apostles:

According to another narrative, though from a doubtful source, St. Martial was one of the 70 apostles sent by the Lord Christ. Also, another one says that he was the little boy who gave the five loaves of bread and the two fish to the Lord and that he accompanied St. Peter, the Apostle to Antioch, then to Rome; and from there the apostle sent him to preach in the land of Gaul. There, it was claimed that he drove an unclean spirit from the daughter of his host; and because he raised the son of the Roman governor from the dead, 3,600 persons believed in the Lord Christ and were baptized.

When the pagan priests attempted to kill him, they were inflicted with

blindness. Then, they regained their eyesight through the prayers of the saint. When some others beat the saint and put him in prison in Limoges, lightning struck them and killed them, but the saint prayed on their behalf and restored them to life. One of those was the pagan priest Aurelian, who eventually wrote the biography of St. Martial. As a result of all those miracles, a significant number of pagans got converted to Christianity.

Valeria the Virgin:

Among those who believed at the hands of St. Martial was a virgin by the name of Valeria, who, dedicating her virginity to the Lord Christ. However, she was beheaded by an order from the governor Duke Steven, to whom she was previously engaged. It was claimed that after her execution, she was seen entering into the church, carrying her head on her hands. The governor, who happened to be there, proclaimed his faith in Christ, set forth to Rome, encountered St. Peter the Apostle¹, and told him about the activities of St. Martial and how successful the preaching in the land of Gaul was. St. Martial was informed in a night vision that his repose would be 15 days later. When his time came, he reposed in peace².

[Baring-Gould: The Lives of the Saints, Vol. 6: June 30]

MARTIAL, FAUSTUS and JANUARIUS, SS.

Those three saints were martyred around the year 304 AD in the city of Cordova in Spain. Their biography could be found under the letter “F:” (Faustus, Januarius & Martial; SS.)

MARTIN, BISHOP OF TOURS, ST.

St. Martin (Martinus) is considered to be the glory of the land of Gaul and the light of the Western Church during the 4th century AD. He was of pagan parents from Savaria³, one of the cities in the region of Pannonia in central Europe. As his father was an officer in the army, the family had to move to Pavia in northern Italy. On reaching 15 years of age, Martin had to join the army. Although he was not yet baptized, his lifestyle was more like a monk rather than a soldier.

¹ This narrative sound doubtful when compared to the account given by St. ‘Gregory of Tours.’

² Some doubtful sources say that this happened in the 40th year after the Resurrection.

³ In the diocese of ‘Pannonia’ (in nowadays: Hungary)...

The Lord Christ Wears Half his Overcoat:

While being at Amiens in northern France, a remarkable incident happened to him. At a very cold night during a snowstorm, at the gate of that city, the saint encountered an almost naked poor man who was trembling from the cold and begging from the passersby. Seeing how no one cared for that poor man, St. Martin intended to help him. So, as he had nothing on him other than his clothes and weapon, he used his sword to cut his overcoat into two halves and gave one half to the poor man to cover himself. In a night vision, Martin saw the Lord Christ wearing half of his overcoat, and heard Him telling others: Martin, even though he still a Catechumen, he clothed me with half of his coat. In the morning, he hastened to be baptized.

Going to Poitier:

Martin did not leave the military service right away, but, in his 20th year of age, when the Barbarians happened to attack the land, Martin and his troops stood before 'Julian Caesar' (360-363 AD) before starting their battle to defend their country. Martin told Caesar: "I have served you long enough as a soldier. Now, let me serve Christ, for I am now His soldier, and it is not befitting for me to go to war." When Caesar got angry for hearing that, he accused Martin of cowardice. Martin answered him that he was prepared to stand weaponless at the front of the battle before the enemies in the name of Christ. However, Martin was cast into prison until the war came to an end. Then, he was released. When he got his freedom, he set forth to Poitier, where St. Hilary the bishop accepted him as one of his disciples.

His Preaching Ministry:

In a night vision, he saw someone calling him to visit his home-town. So, he crossed over the Alp mountains to reach Pannonia, where he managed to convert his mother and a group of her friends to Christianity, whereas his father kept his paganism. At Illyricum region by the Adriatic Sea, he opposed the Arians with enthusiasm and zeal that they publicly scourged him and drove him out of the area.

A Life of Seclusion:

Then, St. Martin longed for a life of seclusion, and the bishop of Poitier gave him a plot of land to dwell on it. There, he was joined by a group of hermits to form what was counted as the first monastic congregation in the Gaul, who grew up and developed to establish a large monastery. St. Martin lived for ten years, guiding his disciples, preaching the villages around, and performing miracles.

His Bishopric:

When his fame spread in the surrounding areas, he was sought by the people of Tours (Thrace)¹ in the year 371 AD, to become their bishop. Because he did not want to be, they thought of tricking him into accepting it. They called him to visit someone sick in town, and when he did, they caught him and carried him to the church and had him ordained despite the objection of some bishops who claimed his unworthiness for that honor, because of his humble appearance. In the beginning, he kept doing his usual monastic routine, living in a cell close to the church, but, with the significant increase of his visitors, a disturbance he could not endure, he retired in a wilderness nearby where 80 monks joined him.

Raising a Dead Man:

God performed at his hands many signs. One of those signs was while he was passing by, and saw a man stopping people carrying a casket in a funeral. That man kept the dead man's family from burying him, claiming that he owed him 400 dinars. When the saint implored him to leave them alone, the man rudely refused. Then, the saint prayed to God to reveal the truth. At that point, the dead man instantly got up, rebuked the rude man, and exposed him as a liar. The liar died on the spot, whereas the dead man was raised by the prayer of the saint and went home where he lived many more years.

His Ministry among the Pagans:

As a fruit of his asceticism, miracles, and his spiritual zeal, the number of pagans in the area decreased, not only in the city of Tours but also in the entire land of Gaul. The saint got rid of so many of the idols' temples.

Then, it happened once that, when he planned to cut down one of the idol's sacred trees, their high priest approved on the condition that they would do the cutting themselves, under his supervision while he would stand where they chose for him. St. Martin did not hesitate to go along with their request. However, they tied him at the spot where the tree was supposed to fall, that he would be killed. They started cutting it, and when it was about to fall on him, the bishop made the sign of the cross on the tree, and it dropped the other way. Another time, while the saint was supervising the destruction of an idol's temple, one of the pagans came charging with his sword attempting to kill him. St. Martin bravely uncovered his chest before the attacker, who was shocked and retreated, fell on his back, crying out, trembling, supplicating to the bishop to forgive him.

St. Martin cared every year to visit all the cities of his diocese, either on

¹ 'Tours' is in the west of France...

foot, riding on a donkey, or sailing on a boat.

He was known to strongly object to the killing of the heretics, seeking instead to expose their heresy and to excommunicate them with their bishops.

Coming to know that he was about to repose, he told his disciples who wept supplicating to him not to leave them. He prayed to God, saying, “If your people still want me, I shall not cease working. Yet, let it be according to your will.” Finally, he reposed in peace on the 8th of November 397 AD, and they built a church over his grave.

[Butler: November 11]
[The Synaxarion: 14 Hator]

MARTINIAN, HIS COMPANIONS & MAXIMA THE VIRGIN ***(The martyrs)***

Slave Martyrs:

St. Martinian, St. Saturian, and their sisters were martyred during the persecution which took place in North Africa in the year 458 AD, during the days of the Arian Vandal king Genseric (Gaiseric: 428-477 AD). These saints were slaves who were converted to Christianity by the help of a fellow female slave virgin called Maxima. However, their heretical master used to scourge them because they were holding fast to the upright faith. He kept beating them until their bones were exposed. He put them through torture for a long time. However, miraculously, they showed up the next day every time with no trace of any torture or injuries.

Preaching in Exile:

Their master decided to exile them. Yet, in their exile, they managed to convert so many Barbarians to the Faith in the Lord Christ, and they sent a request for priests to come to baptize them.

Finally, the heretics tied them by their feet to a carriage which dragged them in the woods, on stones and thorns, until they were martyred. Through a Divine miracle, St. Maxima, the virgin, was released after being put through a long series of sufferings. She lived the rest of her life in peace in a convent, and she became a mother-superior of a significant number of nuns.

[Butler: December 16]

MARTINIAN, THE ANCHORITE, ST.

St. Martinian (Martinianus) was born in Caesarea of Palestine in the middle of the 4th century during the days of Emperor Constantius II (337-361

AD). He was wealthy, splendid looking and of a prominent status. He loved the Lord dearly, and his heart was so flared up for worship that when he became 18 years old, he retired to a mountain near the city which was called “The Place of the Ark,” where he practiced a life of virtue for 25 years, living among so many holy solitaries. His reputation spread all over the area, to the amazement of the elder hermits.

His War against Satan:

When the saint grew in the life of seclusion, Satan started to fight him by several temptations day and night. However, he was strengthened by the Lord Christ, his Savior. Once Satan appeared to him while he was praying, in the form of a horrible dragon, who kept digging into the foundation of his cell until the cell was about to collapse on the saint. He perceived that it was a demonic trick, and he ignored what went on around him. When he finished his prayer, he very calmly looked at Satan and said to him: “How great is what you do now on earth, you who intended once to rise above the stars and to sit on the right hand of the Almighty. Remember that Jesus, who was born by the Virgin, has crushed your head. Therefore, you are not able to harm me or to bring fear within me, as long as Jesus strengthens and supports me.”

Satan then got transformed into a young man and threatened him in a horrible voice, saying, “Wait, Martinian the recluse; in a little while, I shall overcome you, and drive you out of your cell, which you consider to be your stronghold against the forces of hell. I, myself, shall come and shake you like a leaf plucked from a tree by the force of the wind.” The saint did not care for any of those empty threats.

The Repentance of Zoe of Caesarea:

Having spent 25 years in the wilderness, practicing a life of asceticism and virtue, Satan set for him a horrible snare. An evil woman harlot called Zoe was listening to a group of men, assembled in the city of Caesarea and hearing them commending the recluse Fathers, in particular Fr. Martinian. The woman said to them: “What you say about the recluse hermits is far from the truth. They are like straw, which is safe as long as it is away from the fire. They are like a bear who thinks of himself to be strong while hiding in its cave. I am ready to prove that to you. If you promise to give me a reward, I will seduce that Martinian, make him fall into sin, and expose his real nature.” All the men in the group approved and gave her their promise.

She walked in the desert toward him, dressed as a poor woman in very modest attire. She reached his cell late at night and knocked at his door weeping and trembling because of the intense cold and pretending to be about to die from exhaustion and from the fear of being devoured by a wild

beast. Hearing her, Fr. Martinian entered into a struggle between being merciful and compassionate on a helpless woman in the wilderness on the brink of death, and his commitment to keeping his purity and chastity. The compassion ultimately won, and the saint decided to let her in for that night inside his cell. So, he opened his door for her, made a fire, offered her food, and made her promise to leave early in the morning; then, he went to spend the night in another cell, where he kept praying all night long as he used to do. Very early in the morning, the evil woman threw away her inadequate outer clothing to expose her luxurious attire underneath. Then, she adorned herself and waited for the saint to return.

Upon opening his cell, expecting to find her gone, the saint was shocked to see such a scene. He asked her: "Who are you?" She answered that she was the same woman he let in his cell and that she came from Caesarea; and that she had great wealth. And, she was willing to put herself as well as her wealth at his disposal; and that she came to serve him, obey him and live with him. On telling her that he was a recluse hermit, she started to talk to him about rich married saints in the old, like Abraham, Isaac, Jacob, and others of the Fathers and the Prophets. Here, the saint did not fly away but fell into the snare, through the fire of lust that flared up inside him.

Martinian consented to her proposal in his heart. As he was expecting some visitors coming to get his blessing, he told her, he will go to meet them on the road and send them away. Going out with this intention, on his way, he felt the criticism of his conscience, and he rushed back to his cell, ignited a great fire, in which he put his feet, saying, "Try, O miserable Martinianus, if you could endure the eternal fire." Then, he came out of the fire unable to walk, knelt before God, proclaiming repentance on the fire of lust that flared within his mind.

His pain was so intense that he could not keep himself from screaming; that the woman hastened to find him turning on the floor in such a bad condition. Seeing her, he cried out, saying, "If I could not endure such a simple fire, how shall I endure the fire of hell?" Instantly, Zoe, proclaiming repentance and supplicating to him to help her on the way of salvation, the saint sent her to the convent of Abba Paula in Bethlehem, where she remained for the rest of her life in repentance.

His Reclusion on a Rock:

St. Martinian remained for as long as seven months unable to move up from the floor, and once he could, he decided to escape to another wilderness, where no woman can reach him. He went to the seashore and asked the sailors about a deserted place. They told him about an island with a very high rock but added that the area is so horrible that no man can dwell in it. He

begged them to take him there, and made one of them promise to come to him three times every year with bread, water, and palm leaves to work; and promised him on his part to pray on his behalf, and to give him his handwork. He was so exalted by the spirit, worshipping God in the heat of summer and the cold of the winter.

Traveling to Athens:

One day he saw a boat broken up on the rocks near his island, with everyone on it drowned, except for one girl, who cleaved to a wooden board, which the waves carried to the shore. Hearing her crying out for help, Martinian went down and rescued her. Then, under his feeling of responsibility, he brought to her bread and water and asked her to remain in her place on the island until the sailor who promised him to come after two months, would show up with his provisions. However, for fear of his experience, he told the girl, that being a recluse hermit, it was not befitting of them to be together. Then, he made the sign of the Cross on himself, and cast himself into the big sea, saying, "Lord! I would rather risk my life and not my chastity." When the sailor came to the island, he found the girl but not the hermit. He intended to fly away out of confusion. But, the girl cried out, confirmed to him that she was a believer, narrated to him what happened, and asked him to treat her the way he handled the recluse. She asked him to bring her a provision every four months, for she did not wish to go back to the world. She made him promise to come back to her the next time together with his wife and maidservant and to bring her wool to weave for him, as a payback for his goodness toward her. She decided to spend the rest of her life on the rock, and so she lived six years there before she delivered her soul. The sailor and his wife carried her body to Caesarea, where she was buried with great honor.

As for the saint, trusting in God, he cast himself into the sea, until he reached land. Then, he moved from one city to another until he arrived at Athens, where he fell seriously ill, entered into a church, and sought from the priest to call the bishop for him. Thinking that he was out of consciousness, the priest still told the bishop about him. Having seen, in a night vision that he would see this saint, he hastened to him and asked him to remember him in Paradise. St. Martinian asked the bishop to give him the Holy Communion and delivered his soul in the hands of his Savior. He reposed when he was about 50 years old. He was greatly honored in the East, particularly in Constantinople.

[Butler: February 13]

[Fr. Butros the Jesuit: Pastures of the Pious in the Biographies of the Righteous;
Beirut 1880; Shabat, 13]

MARTURINUS, ST.

St. Marturinus (Mathurin/Marcellus¹?) lived in the 4th century. He was born to pagan parents in a province of Sens in the Gaul. At the age of 12, he got the grace of baptism; and his parents were the first to believe because of him. In his 20 years of age, he was ordained as a priest, and God granted him the gift of driving the demons out. The bishop of his city entrusted him with caring for the church, whenever he had to travel to Rome. He managed to draw many to faith, that his fame spread and reached Rome.

He was called to travel to Rome on a mission where he reposed in peace, and his relics were eventually returned to his home town in Sens.

[Butler: November 1]

MARTYRS OF AKHMIM

After the decree of the persecution of the Christians was issued by Emperor Diocletian (284-305 AD), Ariana, the governor of Ansenah made a tour through Upper Egypt to supervise by himself the execution of the imperial orders. Upon arriving at Akhmim on the day of the Holy feast of Nativity, Ariana found out that the Copts were assembled in the Church, with Abba Abadion the bishop of Ansenah, who was delivering to them a sermon of words of grace; because their own bishop Audacius reposed a short time before. Because the Copts were assembled in the Church and did not come to welcome him, Ariana was provoked to evil anger, and he gave the order to kill all those who were in the Church. The blood which was shed on that day ran from the Church to the streets of the city. Hearing about that massacre, those in the other towns and villages, hastened to come to Akhmim, proclaiming their faith. Before the governor Ariana, the fathers and mothers cried out with joy: "We are going to the Kingdom of Heaven," and presented their children by their own hands to the sword and encouraged them by saying, "Have no fear; it is only moments, and you will be with Your Heavenly Groom." It was hard to estimate the exact number of those martyrs who were killed in and outside the church on that day.

[Martyrdom in Christianity, p. 190]

MARTYRS OF ALEXANDRIA

During the persecution stirred up by Emperor Diocletian (284-305 AD)

¹ 'Marcellus of Paris (d. 436 AD) was mentioned in Baring-Gould's book: "The Lives of the Saints, vol. 13" on November 1.

against the Christians, there were an 80 years old priest called Festor,' who exerted so much effort to hold his flock fast to their Faith and kept visiting the imprisoned confessors to strengthen them. Hearing about him, the governor of the city of 'Al-Kais¹,' which was the site of the bishopric at that time, arrested him, scourged him, pressed him in the Hinbazeen, then put him in a fiery furnace. Throughout all these tortures, God gave him endurance. Then, the governor sent him chained, along with some confessors to the governor of Alexandria. There, they used on him other tools of torture, then brought a sorcerer called 'Sidrachis,' who mixed a deadly poison and made him drink it. The saint made the sign of the Cross on it and drank it. Seeing that it did him no harm, the sorcerer proclaimed his faith in the Lord Christ. The angry governor ordered to cast him in the fiery furnace along with 920 of the pagan audience, who proclaimed their faith in the Lord Jesus because of that miracle. As for Fr. Festor, they put him first in a large pot of boiling oil, and then they cut his head with the sword.

During the Persecution of Chalcedonian Emperor Marcian:

On the 23rd of Mesra, the Coptic Church celebrates the memory of the martyrdom of 30,000 Christians in the city of Alexandria. After Emperor Mercian (450-457 AD) exiled the 25th Pope Dioscorus to the island of Gangra' (Gagra), he appointed Protarius to replace him. However, the bishops of Egypt refused to have any relationship with him. They held a Council of their own to oppose him, as well as, the Chalcedonian Council and Leo's Tomes. The foreign archbishop Protarius was provoked to anger and utilized the Roman forces to attack the monasteries and the churches, rob them and take away all their endowment possessions for himself. That Protarius became so wealthy that the thieves came by night, killed him, and robbed what they found on him. However, his followers sent to the emperor, claiming that it was the followers of Pope Dioscorus, who killed Protarius, the emperor's appointed archbishop. Emperor Mercian was provoked to anger and sent a large number of his soldiers and killed about 30,000 of Alexandria's believers.

Emperor Mercian died, and Emperor Leo I (457-474 AD) reigned in his place. The bishops of Egypt utilized the chance, consecrated Fr. Timotheos II (457-477 AD), as a patriarch of Alexandria, who instantly held a Council, which excommunicated the Chalcedonian Council. The heretics reported to the emperor that those who killed Protarius have ordained a patriarch for themselves without the consent of the new emperor. Again, the emperor was provoked to anger and exiled the new pope along with his brother Anatolius

¹ 'Al-Kais' is now a little village near the city of 'Beni-Mazar'...

to the island of Gangra for so many years, until they were released by Emperor Leo II (474 AD). The pope was joined with Peter the patriarch of Antioch and held a Council in the capital attended by 500 bishops. That Council issued a verdict to reject the decrees of the Chalcedonian Council and to assert the Unity of the Nature of the Lord Christ. They raised their verdict to the emperor, who accepted it and issued an order to hold fast to it and to reject any other teaching. By that Council, the Sees of Alexandria, Antioch, Constantinople, and Jerusalem were united for a long time.

[Encyclopedia of the History of the Copts; Part 11, Bk 4, p. 121]
[The Synaxarion: 23 Mesra]

MARTYRS OF ANCYRA, THE SEVEN VIRGINS

Those female martyrs of Ancyra (Ankara) were martyred in the year 304, during the persecution by Emperor Diocletian (284-305). They were dedicated virgins of an age of about 70 years, known for their holiness and good deeds. When the persecution started, the governor of Galatia Theotecnus, who was a sorcerer, a philosopher, and a denier of faith vowed to wipe Christianity out of his jurisdiction. The first of his victims were those seven virgins: Tecusa, Alexandra, Faina, Claudia, Euphrasia, Matrona, and Julitta. When these virgins stood before Theotecnus, he asked them to burn incense to the idols. When they refused, he ordered them to be cast into the public brothel. However, they managed to escape from it, because of their age and the prudence of their leader Tecusa.

Their Martyrdom:

Governor Theotecnus then ordered them to officiate as priestesses of the goddesses Diana and Minerva in washing their statues according to the annual custom of the city of Ancyra. They were accordingly carried naked in a procession along the streets of the city until they reach a nearby lake, where garlands and white garments were offered to them to wear during performing those rites. Upon their refusal to proceed, Theotecnus ordered his men to drown the virgins in the lake, with heavy stones tied around their necks lest their bodies should be recovered and buried by their fellow Christians. This way, they received the crowns of martyrdom.

Burying Their Bodies:

According to some unconfirmed reports, there was in Ancyra; a zealous Christian called Theodotus, who was known for encouraging the Christians who were about to be martyred, to hold fast to their faith and endure until the end. In a night vision, St. Tecusa, one of the seven virgins, appeared to him

on the same night they were martyred and asked him to take their bodies out of the lake. The next evening, he went to the lake along with Polychronus, St. Tecusa's cousin, to find the lake guarded by soldiers to prevent any attempt to take the bodies of the martyrs out of it. Besides, the darkness made it impossible to even try. However, through a Divine help, two saints appeared carrying lamps to guide them besides Sosandus, a well-known martyr in that region. These saintly appearances terrified the guards and made them flee out of the area. At the same time, God sent a strong wind which pushed the lake water to one side to reveal the location of the virgin's bodies. Theodotus and his friends carried the bodies to Ancyra, and they were buried close to the Church of the Patriarchs there. Hearing that the bodies were taken away, the governor arrested Polychronus, who, under torture, had to reveal the names of those who carried the bodies away. The governor brought the bodies back and burned them. Theodotus, after being tortured, had his neck cut off. The Greek Church celebrates his martyrdom on the 7th of June.

The biography of the seven virgin martyrs and the martyr Theodotus was written in Greek by an eyewitness called Nilus; then translated to Latin, by a Jesuit priest called Daniel Papebrochius. As to the Church of the Patriarchs mentioned in the biography, most probably, it was dedicated to the names of the great Patriarchs: Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob, whom the Greek Church celebrates on the 13th of December.

[A Dictionary of Early Christian Biography, Vol. IV, p. 624]

MARTYRS OF ANSENAH

When Arianus (Ariana) the governor of Ansenah (Antione) received the decree issued by Emperor Diocletian (284-305 AD) to persecute the Christians, he called bishop Abadion. He gave him these instructions: "Bring me those Christians of yours, to listen to the decree of the emperor and to worship his idols." The bishop answered him: "Tell me what benefit you got from the emperor? You left us earlier as a friend, and now you act as an enemy. You went to him as a human, and now you return as a wild beast." Arianus commented, saying, "On account of that, the people of Upper Egypt are hard-hearted and thick-necked, the emperor assigned me to chastise them." The bishop answered: "Beware, lest those people would probably steal your idols and sell them." After bishop Abadion left the governor's place, he went to the Church and gathered the congregation to tell them about the governor's request. Then, he gave them a sermon to hold them fast on faith. Feeling their courage and their readiness to shed their blood in the Name of the Lord Christ, the bishop brought them forth to the governor. They

publicly confessed the Lord Christ before him. Provoked to anger, Arianus ordered his men to cut off the heads of all the congregation members; and all the streets of Ansenah were covered with blood. As for bishop Abadion, Arianus took him and sailed to Assiut, where he killed him by the sword, along with a significant number of that city's inhabitants.

Torturing St. Paul the Syrian:

It happened that 150 men and 24 women of pagans were present in the court of the governor of the city of Ansenah and saw how some soldiers were torturing St. Paul (Boulus) the Syrian. By orders of the governor, they heated iron pins in the fire and pierced the eyes of the saint, then cast him in prison. The next morning, when the same group of pagan men and women saw his eyes sound and in perfect form as they were before, they were astounded and said: "No one could perform such a miracle except God, who created everything from nothing." all the pagans shouted with one loud voice, saying, "We all believe in the God of Paul." Then, they all came and knelt at the feet of the saint, asking him to pray on their behalf. They approached the governor, confessed the Lord Christ; and he ordered beheading them by the sword. That way, they all received the crowns of martyrdom.

Among the Monks:

Five thousand monks, along with their bishop Abba Julian were martyred in the desert of Ansenah at the hand of Mercian, the governor, during the persecution stirred up by Emperor Diocletian (284-305) and his agents.

[The Martyrdom in Christianity, p. 147 & 157]
[The Synaxarion: 28 Kiahk]

MARTYRS OF ATRIB

At the end of the reign of Emperor Diocletian (284-305 AD), Alexandros, the governor of Towa in the province of Atrib in the Nile Delta, attempted to convince the Copts to worship the idols. When all his trials ended up with failure, he killed 1,500 believers, and they all received the crowns of martyrdom.

[Encyclopedia of the History of the Copts, Part 11, Bk 4, p. 121]

MARTYRS OF CAIRO

At the beginning of the reign of the Circassian Mamluks (Burji dynasty: 1382-1517 AD) over Egypt, in the year 1389 AD (791 AH), a large number

of men and women who were forced earlier to convert to Islam, came into the city of Cairo (El-Fustat) in a vast procession and publicly proclaimed that they have forsaken 'Islam' and returned to the fold of the Lord Jesus Christ. They declared that they would never change their position again, even if their necks would be cut off. They kept saying, "We came here to atone for our weak faith and our earlier denial of Christ, and we are ready now to offer our lives on the altar of sacrifice to receive the blessing of martyrdom and the mercy of the Lord Jesus Christ."

The Muslim mob gathered around them and advised them to return to Islam, but the converted believers daringly refused. The Muslim mob tried to frighten them through the threat of death, but it was in vain. Then, the Muslim mob led many of them, men and women, to a public square before the "School of the 'King el-Saleh,'" and there in front of everybody, they cut their necks one after the other. However, the faith of none of them was shaken. The mob took some women and tortured them, but they also held fast to their faith. So, the mob bared them of their clothes, dragged them to the valley beneath the Citadel, then cut their necks with such viciousness, that many moderate Muslims protested against those atrocities, and turned against the judge who issue such a verdict.

[The Patriotism of the Coptic Church and its History, p. 234]

MARTYRS OF CRETE, THE TEN

As soon as the decree issued by Emperor Decius (249-251 AD) for persecuting the Christians was made public, the governor of Crete began practicing a barbaric means against the Christians on the island, which resulted in so many martyrs. Among the most prominent of those martyrs were the saints: Theodulus, Saturninus, Euporus, Gelasius, Eunicianus, Zoticus, Cleomenes, Agathopus, Basilides and Evarestus, who were later on called "The Ten Martyrs of Crete." They were all martyred in the year 250.

They were all citizens of Gortyna, near the islands capital. They confessed their faith in Christ and were arrested, cast in prison, beaten, and stoned by the pagans. Then, they were tried before the governor of the island who ordered them as soon as they arrived at the court, to sacrifice to Jupiter, whose feast was being celebrated that same day by the people of Crete.

The saints proclaimed that they would never sacrifice to the idols. So, the governor told them: "You will soon get to know the power of the gods and of Jupiter, who is capable of everything." They told him that they were completely aware of the history, life, and works of Jupiter. At this point, the mob was about to charge against them, but the governor prevented them and gave the orders to his men to start torturing the saints. They endured their

torment with great courage. The pagans kept screaming at them, seeking from them to save themselves by sacrificing to the gods, but the saints answered them, saying, “We are Christians, and we prefer to die thousand times than to do what you ask us to do.”

After a while, the governor realized that he was defeated before them. So he gave his orders to his men to cut the Saints heads off. The saints, with courage and joy, approached the swordsmen while praying to God to have mercy on their souls, on those of all other men, and to save their fellow citizens from the darkness of idol worship. After cutting their heads, the other believers came and buried their bodies, which were moved to Rome.

Later, the Fathers who assembled in the Council of Crete in the year 458 AD, wrote to Emperor Leo I (457-474 AD), saying. “The blessing and intercession of those Ten Martyrs have protected their country so far against the heresies.” The village where the saints were tortured was named “The Ten Martyrs.” Also, a large broken stone was discovered in the location where those ten saints knelt down to receive the crowns of martyrdom. They found that this stone had ten depressions resulting from the strikes of the sharp blade during the saint’s execution.

[Butler: December 23]

MARTYRS OF DANDARA

On the 16th of Bashons, the Coptic Church celebrates the memory of the martyrdom of 400 martyrs in the town of Dandara (on the west bank of the Nile, about 5 kilometers south of the city of Qena). They were executed after suffering many tortures because they were Christians. This happened near the end of the reign of Emperor Diocletian (284-305 AD).

[The Synaxarion: 16 Bashons]

MARTYRS OF EDESSA

In the days of Caesar Trajan (98-117 AD), there was a violent persecution against Christians in Edessa (El-Roḥa) in the Syrian section of Upper Mesopotamia. The bishop Barsimaeus (Barsamya) was arrested, violently tortured, and martyred in the year 114 AD. However, according to another version, he was only arrested but not killed; then, he was released after the persecution and later on reposed in peace.

Among those who were martyred was Sarbelius and his sister Barbea, who were baptized by the bishop Barsimaeus; and they were martyred during the persecution. Sarbelius in particular was viciously tortured because he was

initially a pagan priest before he converted to Christianity.

The Church in the West celebrates those martyrs on the 30th of January.

[A Dictionary of Christian Biography, Vol. II, p. 41]

MARTYRS OF EPHEBUS

Cf. biographies under the letter “E”: (Ephesus, the Saints Who Died in the Cave of Ephesus.)

MARTYRS OF ESNAH

We have already spoken about the martyrs of Esnah (Latopolis in Greek), when we covered the biographies of St. Ammonius the bishop of Esnah, mother Dolagi, the archons: Saman, Herwag, Bachos and Eusebius, and the farmers: Soris, Antiochion, and Mashhoury.

The New Jerusalem:

Abba Boules, the bishop of Licopolis (Assiut), who was probably a contemporary of the period directly following the persecution, wrote a description of the role of Esnah during that difficult period. Abba Boules was a contemporary of bishop Abba Tawadros, the successor of bishop Abba Ammonius, the father of the martyrs. Among what he wrote: “This blessed city Esnah by its sacrifices, has been like a lighthouse that gave light to all Upper Egypt; as its righteous martyred inhabitants presented themselves as a pure Corban and holy sacrifice; shed their blood for the sake of the Upright Faith. They all with one accord, set forth to dwell in the Heavenly Jerusalem, singing praise along with the angels, filled with spiritual talents in harmony with each other. My beloved brethren, that city Esnah is like the city of peace Jerusalem, described by David the prophet in the Psalm: ‘*O God! The nations have come into your inheritance, your holy temple they have defiled. They have laid Jerusalem in heaps. The dead bodies of your servants, they have given as food for the birds of the heavens. The flesh of your saints to the beasts of the earth. Their blood they have shed like water all around Jerusalem, and there was no one to bury them.*’ (Psalm 79:1-3).”

After the decrees of persecution were issued by Emperor Diocletian (284-305 AD), Arianus (Ariana), the governor of Ansenah¹ made a tour through Upper Egypt, to oversee the execution of the orders to persecute the Christians. He came more than once to Esnah, and every time, he came out with a harvest of martyrs: On the first tour, the mother Dolagi and her four

¹ ‘Ansenah’ (Ansina): on its ruins the town ‘Sheikh Ābadah’ was built, near the city of ‘Malawy.’

children were among the martyred. On the second tour, some of the city's archons were among the martyred. On the third tour, it was the greatest slaughter of all. During that tour, the people were prepared and their emotions were aligned behind their bishop Abba Ammonius, and they spent the night before going to their martyrdom in prayers and partook in the Holy Communion. The prominent martyrdom of mother Dolagi with her four children and that of the four archons, inflamed the hearts of the whole congregation. Everybody longed to receive the crown of martyrdom; however, they were disappointed when they found out the next morning that the governor has left their city with his soldiers. The governor imagined that the people of Esnah would learn their lesson from what happened to their fellow citizens who did not obey the emperor.

Details of that Dreadful Third Tour:

The people went to their bishop in the Monastery of Abba Isaac, asking him to pray for them to bring the governor back to the city for them to enjoy the crowns of martyrdom. Indeed, the governor came back for the third time, putting in his heart to kill anyone who would not deny his Christian Faith.

The Guide:

Along with his soldiers, the governor crossed through the city, from the Northern Gate, until he came to the Southern gate (called the Gate of Thanksgiving), through which the multitudes left the town to Mount Agathon, accompanying their bishop to worship God. At that gate, the governor found an old woman lying on the ground; for her age and health did not allow her to go along with the rest of the people. He asked her: "Where did the people go?" She answered him: "On hearing that the infidel governor Arianus would arrive here to persecute and kill the Christians to force them to worship the idols, they all left to pray in Mount Agathon." He asked her: "And you, whom do you worship?" She answered: "I am Christian; I worship the Lord Jesus Christ, the Creator of heaven and earth." He ordered, cutting her head off, and she received the crown of martyrdom. That old woman was given the title 'The Guide' because she led Arianus to the gathering location of the people of the city.

To the Monastery of Abba Isaac in Mount Agathon:

Arianus ordered his soldiers to kill all the Christians they would encounter on their way to the Monastery of Abba Isaac on the mountain. So, they killed a group of believers they found at the Karim's waterwheel. Then, when they arrived at the monastery, they found the whole congregation assembled with their bishop Abba Ammonius, who was encouraging them,

holding them fast and reminding them of the saying of the Lord Christ: “*Do not fear, little flock, for it is your Father’s good pleasure to give you the kingdom*” (Luke 12:32). He kept strengthening them, saying, “My children! Blessed is he who listens to and follows the words of God. Go ahead of me to the Kingdom of Heaven, to receive me when I depart from this world; the way you used to come out of the earthly church to receive me, you would welcome me into the Church of the firstborn together with the angels of God. I shall rejoice in you. There is the Kingdom of Heavens, and, along with Isaiah the prophet, I shall say: ‘*Here I am and the children whom God has given me*’ (Isaiah 9:18).”

Finally, seeing that the governor and his soldiers have reached the location, the multitudes raise their voices and shouted in one accord: “We are all Christians, believers in the Lord Jesus Christ, the Creator of heaven and earth.” By orders from the governor, the soldiers kept killing the multitudes with the swords and the spears until they slaughtered all of them on the 19th of Abib. They were thousands. As to the bishop Abba Ammonius, he was martyred in Ansenah after the governor took him chained to the city of Aswan in the South, then back to Ansenah, to give him a longer chance to reconsider and possibly deny his faith.

Back to Esnah for the Fourth Time:

On his way back from Aswan to Ansenah, the governor went back to Esnah to enjoy seeing how the Christ-loving city became abandoned entirely. In his way, the governor happened to encounter the three farmers: Sores, Antiochiun, and Mashhour.

The holy bodies of countless martyrs are still buried in the Monastery of the Martyrs, about 5 kilometers south of the western border of Esnah. Queen Helena (325-330 AD), the mother of Emperor Constantine the Great (306-337 AD) built for them a grand mausoleum in Mount Agathon on an area of about 80 acres; and she dug a spring of water in its midst, which heals whoever would wash in it.

[Helmy Armanius: *The Coptic Martyrs in the Roman Era*, 1968, p. 111]

MARTYRS OF HADIAB IN PERSIA

Hundred-Twenty Martyrs:¹

In the year 345 AD, during the time of the Persian king Shapur II (309-379 AD), more than 100 Christians were martyred in one day. Among them were

¹ See “*Martyrs of Persia*” (3rd group)...

nine dedicated virgin girls, and the rest were priests, deacons, and monks. Refusing with one accord to worship the sun, they were left for nine months in filthy dungeons, where a pious rich woman, called Jazdundocta, visited them, encouraged them, and provided them with food.

Getting to know the day of their execution, she prepared a great banquet for the saints and brought for each of them a beautiful white robe to wear. On the next day, she came again to tell them that it was the day they are to be tortured, encouraged them, and advised them to hold fast to the grace of God, who was going to give them the strength to shed their blood for His sake. Then, she added: "As for me, I seriously pray to God, that by your prayers on my behalf, He would grant me the joy of seeing you again before His heavenly throne." At the location of the execution, the king attempted again to seduce them, and promised to forgive them if they worshipped the sun; but they, with courage, told him that they wore those white robes as an expression of what their hearts feel of readiness to deliver their lives to the Lord Christ. They were finally executed by the sword, and Jazdundocta came, carried their bodies, and buried them with great honor.

[Butler: April 6]

MARTYRS OF LYONS

In the year 177 AD, during the reign of Caesar Marcus Aurelius (161-180 AD), many Christians were martyred in the two cities of Lyon and Vienna. The story of their martyrdom became known through a message which was sent by those two churches to the churches in Asia and Phrygia. This message was recorded in the writings of the historian Eusebius and is considered to be one of the most precious old Christian documents.

That message mentioned the names of 48 of those martyrs, many of whom were Greek. Among those martyrs was the maidservant Blandina, bishop Pothinus, deacon Sanctus, Attalus, Maturus, who was newly baptized, and a young 15 years old boy called Ponticus. Many of those martyrs, who were tortured, were falsely accused by their pagan servants and slaves. Some of them died in prison through the mal-treatment and the adverse conditions. Those with Roman citizenship were executed by the sword, and the rest were devoured by the wild hungry beasts.

[The Penguin Dictionary of Saints, p. 217]

MARTYRS OF MOUNT SINAI

During the 4th/5th century AD, 38 hermits on Mount Saini were martyred

in a barbarian Arab (Saracens) raid on their area. Also, a significant number of more hermits in the desert of Raithu (by the Red Sea, about two days travel from the center of Sinai) were slaughtered in the same manner at the hands of those Arab raiders. Among the martyrs was a young 14 years old boy, who was starting a life of great strife in seclusion. When the Arab invaders found him, they threatened to kill him if he would not reveal the location of the older hermits. He told them that he did not fear death, and he was not ready to spoil his life by the sin of betraying his Fathers. Provoked to anger by his answer, they killed the young saint, and he received the crown of martyrdom. The above incidents were documented by St. Nilus of Sinai (died in 430 AD) who wrote the “Works about the Monastic Life” concerning the above slaughters in seven parts, and told about his own life in Sinai, the invasion of the Saracens’ the captivity of his son, etc.

[Baring-Gould, *The Lives of the Saints*, Vol. 1, 1897, pp. 202-9: January 14]

MARTYRS OF NICOMEDIA

Twenty Thousand were martyred in the Feast of Nativity:

According to the Greek tradition, 20,000 Christians were martyred in Nicomedia, in the day of Nativity, in the year 303 AD. The Roman tradition, adds that, while being assembled to celebrate the Liturgy of the glorious Nativity, Emperor Diocletian (284-305 AD) ordered to close the gates of the church before the believers, and his men prepared fire to be ignited all around the church. Then, they declared that whoever wished to be saved from the fire had to get out of the church and sacrifice before the god Jupiter. Once all those inside, with one accord, proclaimed their readiness to die for the sake of Christ, the fire was ignited, and all who were inside the church were burnt alive and got the honor of being reborn in heaven, on that same day chosen by the Lord Christ to be Himself born on earth, for the sake of the salvation of the whole world.

[Butler: December 25]

MARTYRS OF PEPNOSAH

When St. Serapion, an elite of the town of Pepnosah in Upper Egypt, confessed before the Roman governor Arminius that he was a Christian, the governor cast him in prison. Getting to know about it, his fellow citizens gathered together and went with their weapons to kill the governor and set the saint free. However, the saint convinced them not to use any force and

told them that it was his intention to be martyred.

His Martyrdom with his Fellow Citizens:

The governor ordered his men to press the saint in the Hinbazeen. Then they immersed him into a pot of molten tar. Then they nailed him on a cross until his body was torn apart. And finally, they killed him, along with 540 of his fellow citizens who came to rescue him.

[Encyclopedia of the History of the Copts, Part 11, Bk 4, p. 125]

MARTYRS OF PERSIA

Among the many thousands who suffered death in Persia in the Name of the Lord Jesus Christ, we can list five unidentified groups of martyrs:

First group composed of 42 martyrs who were put to death in an unknown year. The Western Church celebrates them on the 10th of March.

Second group composed of 310 martyrs executed in an unknown year. The Western Church celebrates them on the 9th of May.

Third group¹ composed of 120-150 martyrs believed to have suffered under the king of Persia Shapur II (309-379 AD), around the year 345 AD. The Coptic Church celebrates them on the 8th of Baramouda, while the Western Church on the 6th of April.

Fourth group composed of a large number of martyrs put to death by the Persian ruler Shapur II on a Good Friday around the year 376 AD. These martyrs included 25 bishops, 250 priests and deacons, and scores of other clergy and nuns. The Western Church celebrates them on the 22nd of April.

Fifth group composed of martyrs slain under the Persian rulers of the region in the 6th Century AD. The Western Church celebrates them on the 8th of February.

[The Synaxarion: 8 Baramouda]

[The Western Church Martyrology Calendar]

MARTYRS OF ROME UNDER NERO

Rome on Fire:

‘Nero’ (54-68 AD) was the first emperor to persecute Christians. In July of the year 64 AD, (the 10th year of his reign), a fire was ignited in Rome, which started near the magnificent Amphitheater, in a region of markets packed with flammable merchandise. The fire quickly spread in all directions and

¹ See “Martyrs of Hadiab in Persia”...

was sustained for a whole week. Before that fire was nearly out, another one ignited in the garden of the commander of the imperial guards Tigellinus and lasted for three days. When the fire was finally extinguished, two-third of the city of Rome had turned into ruins. On the third day of the fire, Nero came from Antium to inspect the scene. His extensively wild happiness, to see the tongues of fire ascending from his city, was the reason for many to believe that he was the one who ordered it, or at least who worked against any attempt to put it off. This belief quickly spread because it was claimed that fire torches were thrown on the houses by mysterious men, who admitted that they were ordered to do so. So far, the validity of accusing Nero of being behind the fire could not be verified. Since Rome had experienced so many destructive fires along with its history, it is possible that this fire too might have happened by accident though it was the worst of them all. Accusing the Christians of Igniting that Fire:

When Nero got seriously disturbed by the accusation pointed at him, he deflected the blame by accusing the Christians of doing it. According to the Roman historian Tacitus (56-120 AD), even though no one came to believe such an accusation against the Christians, the believers were arrested and led to death in the fiercest ways. Some were clothed in the hides of beasts and cast before the wild dogs to tear them apart. Others were crucified. With some others, they soaked in tar, stabbed them with spears, then put them on fire and turned them into live torches. All those barbaric activities were carried out in the private garden of the imperial palace, while emperor Nero and his guests were enjoying watching a race of chariots.

[Butler: June 24]

MARTYRS OF SAMOSATA, THE SEVEN

A Celebration in Samosata:

Near the end of the 3rd and the beginning of the 4th century AD, when Emperor Maximian (286-305 AD) came back victorious from his campaign against the Persians, he celebrated Samosata on the bank of the Euphrates in Asia Minor. He ordered everybody to come to sacrifice to the gods. However, Hipparchus and Philotheus, the elites of the city, who have already received the Christian faith a little while ago, set a holy cross in the house of Hipparchus, where they worshipped the Lord Christ.

Preaching Five Young Friends:

One day, five young friends came to visit them: James, Paragrus, Habibus, Romanus, and Lollianus. They found them praying before the Cross. Asking

them why they prayed at home when the emperor gave his command to assemble in the temple of gods. They answered that they only worshipped the Creator of the world. The visitors asked: “Do you take the Cross as a symbol of the Creator of the world?” ‘Hipparchus’ answered them: “We worship Him who was crucified, and confess that He is God and the Son of God. And this is the third year since we have got the grace of baptism at the hand of the priest Fr. James, who also gives us the body and blood of Jesus. It is therefore not good to get out of the house these days, as we are disturbed by the smell of the idols sacrifices which fills the air.”

The Baptism of the Five Young Men:

After lengthy discussions, the five young men believed in the Lord Christ and expressed their longing to be baptized. Hipparchus called Fr. James, who came to their house carrying the holy vessels under his long robe. He found the five young men waiting for him. He greeted them, saying, “Peace be with you, O servants of Jesus Christ, who was crucified for the sake of His creation.” The five of them threw themselves on the ground at his feet, saying, “Have compassion on us and give us the badge of the Lord Christ, whom we shall worship.” They stood to pray together after they gave confession of the Lord Christ and denied their paganism. The priest baptized them and gave them the Body and the Blood of the Lord Christ.

The priest then carried the holy vessels underneath his long robe, and in a hurry went home, for fear that his presence with those men would raise doubt among the pagans. The reason was that this priest was a simple man, while Hipparchus and Philotheos were among the most prominent people in the city, and the other five new believers were among the nobles as well.

Putting Hipparchus and Philotheos under Arrest:

On the third day of the celebration, the emperor was checking whether all the leaders and rulers of the city had carried out the sacrificing duty to the gods in that general celebration. He was told that Hipparchus and Philotheos were absent from the celebrations all through the three days. At this point, the emperor ordered his men to bring them over to the temple to offer sacrifices to the gods. Upon arriving at the house of Hipparchus, the deputies found the seven young men altogether. However, they took only Hipparchus and Philotheos to the emperor. He asked them why they despised his command and ignored the gods. When Hipparchus answered that he would refuse to call the wood and the stones as gods, the emperor ordered giving him five lashes. He then turned to Philotheos and promised to promote him if he obeyed his command. However, he was told by the saint that for him, accepting his promise was a disgrace; then he started to explain to him with

eloquence, the secrets of the Creation. He was sharply interrupted by the emperor, and he was told that being a man of such wisdom, he would not be tortured. This was done in the hope that it might make the saint eventually change his position. Then, the emperor ordered to put the two men chained, but separately, in jail. Going after the five young men, the soldiers went back to Hipparchus house and brought them before the emperor. He threatened to crucify them like their Lord if they refuse to obey him. Finding that they did not care for his threats, they were chained and cast separately in prison without food until the end of the celebration.

Trial of the Seven Confessors before the Emperor:

The court of justice was held on the bank of River Euphrates. The two older men were brought in chained around their necks, while the five young men were brought in chained around their hands.

Because of their refusal to sacrifice to the idols, all seven saints were bound and scourged with 20 lashes each. Then, they were sent back to jail, and no one was allowed to visit them or help them. They were given the least amount of food, just enough to keep them alive. So they were kept on that condition for two months before they were brought again before the emperor while they were more like bone skeletons.

After a last attempt to seduce them to forsake their faith, they responded by asking him to stop trying to lead them astray from the way shown to them by the Lord Christ. Then, the emperor ordered to set seven crosses near the gate of the city, and they crucified them there. In the evening, some women came, paid money to the guards to allow them to wipe the blood off the martyrs' faces and wash them with some water.

Hipparchus delivered his soul after a little while, followed by James. While Romanus and Lollianus delivered their souls on the next day after being stabbed with spears. The rest of them were brought down from the crosses and had their heads cut off by the sword. A Christian man called Bassus came, bribed the soldiers to let him take the bodies of the martyrs to bury them in his field instead of throwing them into the river.

[Butler: December 9]

MARTYRS OF SCETIS, THE ELDERS

The Messenger of Emperor Theodosius II:

In the wilderness of Scetis, 49 elder priests, and Martinus, the messenger of Emperor Theodosius II (402-450 AD) and his little son were all martyred. It happened that the emperor, who had no son of his own, sent to the elders of

Scetis to seek from them to pray to God on his behalf to grant him a son. St. Isidore of Scetis answered him that God did not intend for him to have seeds who might come to partake of the heresies after him. Reading the letter, the emperor gave thanks to God.

When some counseled him to marry another woman, with the hope to have a son from her to inherit the throne after him, the emperor answered them: "I shall do nothing, except what the elders of Scetis instruct me to do." He then sent a messenger called Martinus to seek their counsel. Martinus had a little son, called Zeus, whom he took along with him to get the blessing of the elders. Upon reading the message of the emperor, which arrived after St. Isidore was already reposed, they took the messenger to where the saint was buried, and they cried out: "Father, how shall we answer the message of the emperor?" A voice came from the saint's body, saying, "What I said before, I repeat now: The Lord will not grant him a son who might partake of the heresies, even if he gets married to ten women" They so wrote to the emperor.

The Barbarians Attack the Monastery:

Before the messenger had a chance to leave with his son, the Barbarians came to attack the monastery. A great elder called Abba Joannes stood and addressed the brethren, saying, "Behold, the Barbarians are coming to kill us. Whoever wants to be martyred let him stand here, and whoever has some fears, let him take refuge in the stronghold Fort. Some of the monks rushed to the Fort, while 48 monks faced the Barbarians. The ones who did not take cover were all slain by those Barbarians.

The Martyrdom of Martinus and His Son:

Martinus and his son were hiding somewhere. The little son was able to see the Lord's angels placing Crowns on the heads of those Fathers who were slain. He said to his father: "Behold, I see spiritual people placing crowns on the heads of the killed monks; I shall go and earn one of my own." His father answered him: "And I shall go with you, my son." Both of them came out of their hiding and showed themselves to the Barbarians who killed them, and they too received the crowns of martyrdom.

The Bodies of the Martyrs:

After the Barbarians left, the monks came down from the Fort, took the martyrs' bodies, put them in a cave, and kept singing hymns and praise before them every night. Some people from El-Batanon came and took the corpse of Abba Joannes to their city, but the elders brought it back to its original place.

So did some people from El-Fayyum, who came and took the corpse of Zeus the son of Martinus, and when they came to their city, the angel of the Lord brought it back to where his father's corpse was. Several times the elders attempted to move the corpse of the little boy from his father's side, and they could not. Whenever they moved it, it came back to its place. In a night vision, an elder heard the little boy's voice, saying, "We did not separate from one another, while in the flesh; why do you separate us now?"

When the persecution intensified, and there were several attacks on the wilderness, the elders moved the bodies to a cave they dug beside the Church of Abba Macarius. During the days of the 33rd Pope of Alexandria Abba Theodosius I (536-567 AD), they built a Church in their name. When the 38th Pope of Alexandria Abba Benjamin I (623-662 AD) came to visit the wilderness, he set for them a feast on the 5th of Amshir, the day their bodies were moved to that Church. Over time, when the Church of the Elders of Scetis was destroyed, they moved them to another place, until muâallem Ibrahim el-Gohary, built for them another church in the 18th century and moved their bodies to it; and it still stands up to this day in the monastery of Abba Macarius. The cell where they used to be is known today by the name Ehme Epsit, meaning The Forty-Nine.

[Synaxarion: 26 Toba]

MARTYRS OF SCILLIUM

A group of seven men and five women of the town of Scillium in North Africa were martyred in the year 180 AD. They were arrested and taken to Carthage to be questioned by the governor Saturninus. St. Speratus was their chief spokesman who answered on behalf of the whole group. He carried a bag, in which he said, he kept the Holy Bible and the epistles of Paul the Apostle. When they all refused neither to forsake their faith nor to be given a month to reconsider their decision, they were condemned to be immediately killed by the sword. St. Speratus cried out, saying, "Thanks be to God."

[The Penguin Dictionary of Saints, p. 293]

MARTYRS OF SEBASTE

On the 13th day of the Coptic month of Baramhat, the Coptic Church celebrates the martyrdom of the 40 martyrs of the city of Sebaste (now Sivas in Turkey), in the year 320 AD.

Forty Young Soldiers from Various Nationalities:

Emperor Constantine the Great (306-337 AD) appointed Licinius (308-

324) his relative to rule over the East and asked him to have compassion on the Christians. However, as soon as he arrived at Cappadocia, he ordered his subordinates to worship the idols, though they all refused to obey him. One evening, 40 young soldiers of various nationalities residing in Sebaste, decided with one accord to approach the governor and confess the Christian Faith before him. In a night vision, the angel of the Lord appeared to them and encouraged them to hold their hearts fast. In the morning, they stood before the governor Agricolaos, and confessed the Lord Christ. He first attempted to convince them to worship his idols. Then, he instructed them that being in the military, shame would dwell upon them for disobeying his orders and promised to promote them if they obey. He threatened them if they do not obey, they were to be killed, but to no avail. He then ordered them to be tortured and to be cast in prison while they were singing the Psalm, saying, *"He who dwells in the secret place of the Most High, shall abide under the shadow of the Almighty"* (Psalm 91:1). They were comforted in prison by the appearance of the Lord Christ, who came to encourage them and strengthen them to hold fast to their Faith. Next to the prison, there was a frozen lake. Governor Agricolaos ordered his men to get ready to cast the 40 saints naked in the lake. Also, he ordered his men to place a tub of hot water outside the lake to seduce the saints to use it by getting out of the frozen lake after denying their Faith. The saints did not wait for the soldiers to cast them in the lake, but took their clothes off, encouraged one another, saying, "A one difficult night will qualify us for a glorious eternal life." Then, the saints cast themselves in the frozen lake, praying: "O our God, we are forty people asking you to crown us. We implore you not to make us any less than this holy number." According to St. Gregory of Nyssa, they remained three days and three nights in the lake, and no one weakened except for one individual, who ran and plunged himself into the hot water outside the lake. When this poor man did that, the melting of the ice on him, caused his nerves to explode, and he instantly died and lost his crown of conquest.

A Guard enjoys a Heavenly Vision:

One of the guards standing by the lake saw angels coming down from heaven with crowns in their hands, which they were about to place them on the heads of the 39 martyrs. Seeing that an extra crown remained in the hand of one of the angels, the guard hastened to plunge in the lake, crying out: "I am Christian. I am Christian." Eventually, the remaining crown was placed on his head. He joined the other 39 saints in the ranks of martyrs.

Melito and his mother:

After most of those saints were martyred by freezing to death, few of them

stayed alive in the frozen lake, including a young man called Melito. The governor ordered to break the hands and legs of those who were still alive, and to cast them into fire. So, the guards did what they were ordered and carried the saints' broken bodies in a wagon to be burned. However, they kept Melito until the end, with the hope that he might change his mind when he would find out that he became alone. But his mother, a poor widow, admonished the guards on their wrong consideration and approached her son, who smiled at her with thanksgiving. With the power of the Holy Spirit, she exhorted her son to abide until the end, then carried him and cast him by herself into the wagon among his fellow martyrs. The guards burned the bodies of the martyrs and threw the ashes in the river, but the believers managed to haul some of the precious relics, and kept them in Caesarea.

[The Synaxarion: 13 Baramhat]
[Butler: March 10]

MARTYRS OF ST. ANTHONY MOUNTAIN

On the 26th of Baba, the Coptic Church celebrates the memory of seven martyrs who were martyred at the hands of the Barbarians, on the Mountain of St. Anthony, the Father of all monks.

[The Synaxarion: 26 Baba]

MARTYRS OF THE ARIAN HERESY

When the Arian Emperor Constantius II (337-361 AD), the son of Constantine the Great (306-337 AD), approved the heresy of Arius (250-336 AD), he sent someone called Gregory of Cappadocia to Alexandria guarded by 500 horsemen, to be appointed as the patriarch of Alexandria, instead of the 20th Pope Athanasius the Apostolic (328-373 AD), who rejected and opposed that heresy. The emperor ordered his envoy to kill whoever would disobey him. When the people of Alexandria refused to accept him, he killed several thousands of them. In the meantime, Pope Athanasius fled away and hid for six years. Then, the pope went to Constantinople to face the emperor. However, the emperor ordered his men to place him on a boat without food or drink, with the hope he would perish of hunger and thirst or drown along the way, through a miracle, the boat came to land in Alexandria peacefully, where his people greatly rejoiced, brought him to the Church; and drove away Gregory the intruder and all his followers.

During the whole period (337-361 AD) of the reign of Emperor Constantius II, the Arian persecution against the Orthodox prevailed over the

entire land of Egypt. According to St. Athanasius the Apostolic, it was impossible to describe the suffering endured by the bishops and the priests for the sake of their Orthodox faith. Even their features were changed because of the torture imposed upon them by the Arians. The Arians ordered them to retreat from their bishopric and forsake their thrones for them to occupy, and when they refused, they put them in chains and exiled them to far away countries.

Among those Exiled were:

- Bishops Amon and Adelphius, who were exiled to the Outer Oasis.
- Bishops Muis, senosiris, Pilammon, Plenes, Marcos, and Athenodorus, who were exiled to Amon Oasis (Siwa Oasis), instead of being condemned to be burnt alive.
- Bishop Dracuntius, who was exiled to the desert of Qalzam, near city of Suez.
- Bishop Philon, who was exiled to Babylon.
- Bishops Ammonius, Agathos, Agathodemon, Aplonius, Eulogius, Pavnotius, Apollon, Gaios, Flavius, Dioscorus, Heraclides, and Psain, along with the two priests Hierax and Dioscorus, who were exiled to Aswan. Then, they kept chasing them from one location to another. They forced many of them to toil in the mines and quarries. Also, they slaughtered some of them without any mercy.

The bishops of Pentapolis were exiled to the Outer Oasis, while the bishops of Upper Egypt were exiled to Siwa Oasis.

This is not a complete list of the bishops and priests who were tortured or martyred, for the list wrote by Pope Athanasius was unfortunately lost. However, in another document, the names of 90 great priests were included, who were expelled from their churches. Pope Athanasius has advised that all of those who suffered should be honored by the Church on the same level as the blessed saints and martyrs.

[Encyclopedia of the History of the Copts; Part 11, Bk 4, p. 127]
[The Martyrdom in Christianity, p. 245]

MARTYRS OF THE HIMYARITES IN YEMEN

Refer to those martyrs under the letter “Y”: (Yemen, the Himyarites.)

MARTYRS OF THE PLAGUE IN ALEXANDRIA

A severe plague dwelt upon most of the Roman Empire during the years

249-263 AD that it was said, in a single day, more than 5,000 people died in Rome. In Alexandria, the inhabitants so severely suffered, that the 14th Pope of Alexandria St. Dionysius (246-264 AD) said that his city went through several calamities: plague, famine, followed by cruel subversion and civil war that filled that city with murders and commotions; so that it was safer to travel from the eastern to the western parts of the world than to go from one street of Alexandria to another. The plague so spread that no house in this great city was spared of having at least one member of the family inflicted by it, and mourning prevailed all around. The corpses were forsaken without burying, and the air was filled with the smell of death. Because the city was so overcome with terror and fear of death, the pagans became so wild, even towards their close relatives. At the moment those pagans came to know that one of their own was inflicted with the plague, they would instantly forsake him/her and flee away. The Christians in Alexandria, on the other hand, had displayed the highest example of merciful behavior.

During the time of persecution under the Emperors Decius (249-251 AD), Gallus (251-253 AD), and Valerian (253-260 AD), the Christians had to hide and hold their religious assemblies in secret, in boats in the sea, in prisons or underground. Once the plague started, they forgot all about the danger of persecution, plague, or death. They hastened to give care to the sick in the streets, those who were forsaken by their own; to comfort those on the brink of death, to close the eyes of the dead, to carry their corpses on their shoulders, wash them and bury them with honor. They did that knowing for sure that they could share their same end. Pope Dionysius said, "Many of those who treated the victims have become victims themselves. We lost in this way so many of our best brethren in faith; some priests, deacons, and laymen. That way of death, besides being full of faith, was no less than a martyrdom." The Roman Martyrology perceiving the strength of the words uttered by Pope Dionysius honored those loving Christians as martyrs who cared for their tormentors when they became sick.

[Butler: February 28]

MARTYRS OF THE SERAPEUM

When the 23rd Pope of Alexandria St. Theophilus (385-412 AD), got a decree from Emperor Theodosius I (379-395 AD) to turn the deserted pagan temple of Bacchus into a Christian church, this led the pagans to a great riot. During that time, they killed so many Christians on the streets. The pagan rebels made their headquarters in the temple of Serapis in Alexandria, from which they attacked the Christians. They caught many of them and gave them

the choice, either to sacrifice to Serapis or to be killed without mercy. In that manner, they killed so many martyrs. Emperor Theodosius I proclaimed his admiration for the courage and brevity of those saintly Christian martyrs, and to honor them, he forgave those pagans who killed them. However, he issued a decree to destroy all the pagan temples on the land of Egypt. When the emperor's decree was publicly broadcast, the pagans forsook the temple of Serapis. Then, after the idol was broken down, it was cast into the fire. The pagans imagined that as a result of the destruction of their temple and its idols, the heaven would fall, and a chaos would prevail on the whole land. However, on seeing that nothing changed, many of them proclaimed their faith in the Lord Christ.

Those Christian saints were martyred in the year 390 AD, and are celebrated by the Church of the West on the 17th of March. Two churches were built on the same place of the temple of Serapis in Alexandria, which was one of the most important landmarks in the old world.

[Butler: March 17]

MARTYRS OF THE THEBAN LEGION ***(The Martyrs of Agaunum)***

This Roman legion (6,666 men) was named that way because they all came from the garrison of the region of Thebes¹ in Egypt. They were known for their courage in battle, diligence, and faithfulness. Then, when some tribes of farmers (the Burgundy) in Gaul (France) rebelled against Maximian (286-305 AD), the Roman emperor of the West in the year 286 AD, Emperor Diocletian (284-305 AD) of the East, sent this regiment to help him break that rebellion down. The Theban Legion was commanded by St. Maurice (Moritz/ Mauritius). When the Legion reached Italy, the emperor distributed some of its divisions on the borders of the French territories and the rest on regions within Switzerland. Before the start of the battle, certain pagan religious ceremony was to be held to seek victory from the idol gods. The men of the Theban Legion refused to take part in that ceremony, on account of being Christians. The emperor ordered cutting the heads of one-tenth of the Legion soldiers after scourging them to terrify the rest. However, the Legion sent him a message which they all signed, saying,

“O great Caesar! We are your soldiers, but at the same time, we are the subjects of God. We owe you our military service, but to God, we owe the faithfulness of our hearts. We earn our wages through you, but from God, we

¹ The ‘Thebes’ (Thebaid/Thebais) was a region of ancient Egypt, which comprised the 13 southernmost provinces of Upper Egypt, from Abydos (near el-Āraba el-Madfuna and al-Balyana) to Aswan...

shall have the eternal reward. We cannot, under any circumstances, obey orders which contradict with those of God. We shall obey your commands as long as they conform to God's commandments, but we shall not if they conflict with them. For God should be obeyed more than men. We are not rebels; for we have weapons, by which we could defend ourselves and disobey you, but we prefer to die blameless than to live defile. We are ready to endure all what you will bring on us of torture because we are Christians, and publicly we proclaim our Christianity."

Reading this message, Emperor Maximian was provoked to more anger and ordered his officers to kill the whole regiment. This was accomplished by multitudes of Roman soldiers, who did not spare even a single member of the Theban Legion. Some were martyred in North Italy, some in Switzerland, and some in France. The whole Legion, were martyred even before the general persecution stirred up by Emperors Diocletian, and Maximian had begun.

[The Martyrdom in Christianity, p. 188]

[The Coptic Encyclopedia: Theban Legion, by Samir F. Girgis; pp. 2231-4]

MARTYRS OF TUNA EL-GABAL, THE HERMITS

On the 29th of Paona, the Church celebrates the memory of seven hermits of Tuna el-Gabal in the region of El-Ashmonein in Middle Egypt. Those martyr hermits confessed their faith before the governor, who, after torturing them, ordered his men to cut their heads off.

[Martyrdom in Christianity, p. 158]

MARTYRS OF TYRE, THE EGYPTIANS

Tyre was one of the most flourishing Phoenician cities, having an excellent harbor with two fronts, one facing south-west toward Egypt and the other facing north toward the city of Sidon. Therefore, it was an important center for various nations. Yet, the worldly businesses did not hinder the efforts made by the preachers of the Good News of Salvation, and Christianity spread over there. It seems that the first waves of persecution did not reach Tyre. However, the tyranny of Emperor Diocletian (284-305 AD) eventually extended to it. And, its first martyr was its bishop Teranius.

The Wild Beasts Turned Tame Before the Saints:

This saintly bishop was taken to the arena of execution, along with a number of the confessors, among them were five Egyptians. The experienced eyes of bishop Eusebius, the father of the ecclesiastical history, managed to

distinguish those Egyptians who daringly presented their bodies to the executioners. After brutally scourging them, they delivered them to the trainers of the wild beasts, which, by orders of the emperor, were left hungry for an extended period. Once the gates of their cages were opened while being provoked by sharp spears, the beasts ran off toward the saints like arrows. Amazingly, those vicious beasts, once approached the bare torn-off bodies of the saints, stopped all at a sudden, went around them, and then went back to their cages. At that time, all the confessors were praying. Among the five Egyptian confessors was a young man not more than 20 years of age, who was kneeling on the ground, raising his eyes toward heaven in a complete tranquility, paying no attention to the wild beasts or their roars.

The Wild Ox Retreated Before the Saints:

The beast-trainers tried again to provoke the beasts to no avail. Then, they brought to the arena a huge ox with long horns that had a long history of killing victims. This ox retreated, as well, before the saints, despite provoking it by iron heated spears, which made him jump in anger but did not approach the praying saints. Then, the governor ordered his men to send all the beasts to their cages, and to cut the heads of all the saints whom the wild beasts did not dare to touch. Although Bishop Eusebius recorded that scene after witnessing it with his eyes along with a number of his friends, he failed to give us the names of those heroes who held fast to their Christian Faith.

[The Faithful Synaxarium: 1 Abib]

MARUTA, THE SYRIAN MONK, ST.

St. Macarius and St. Yehnes Kama Appeared to Him in a Dream:

St. Maruta was a Syrian monk and among those who lived in the 9th century AD, and were impressed by the holiness of Abba Yehnes Kama. In a night vision, he saw a fantastic dream. He saw himself standing among saints and angels surrounding the throne of Grace. While he was watching those multitudes, his attention was drawn towards two men among them, radiating with light. He whispered in the ear of an angel near him inquiring about their identity, and he was told that the tall one was St. Macarius, the Father of the Monks in the wilderness of Scetis, and the one beside him was St. Yehnes Kama, who followed his example.

Leaving to Egypt:

St. Maruta was so much rejoiced by that vision that he started to paint a portrait of those two saints as he saw them in his dream. He kept working on

his painting day and night, until he finished it in a few days, precisely in the same way he saw it in his heavenly vision. Upon completing that portrait, Maruta took it along and departed from his country, setting forth to Egypt. There, he headed to the wilderness of Scetis. The first monastery he visited was that of Abba Macarius the Great, then that of Abba Yehnes the Short. And, from there, he went to the monastery of Abba Yehnes Kama. He arrived there when Fr. Shenouti was the Abbot of that monastery. He narrated to the monks the vision he saw; then, he showed them the portrait he painted. This filled their hearts with joy and thanksgiving to the Lord. After spending a few days with the monks in the monastery of Abba Yehnes Kama, St. Maruta was so impressed by their life of love, humility, and active service, that he proclaimed his desire to spend the rest of his life among them. They readily welcomed him. When it was time for him to repose, he gave the portrait he painted as a gift to the monastery, and then he reposed in peace.

Many Syrian monks followed the example of St. Maruta, and a large number of them came to Egypt and dwelt in the monastery of Abba Yehnes Kama. For that reason, many Egyptians used to call that monastery: The Syrian Monastery, which is still being called to this very day.

[The Story of the Coptic Church, Bk # 2, p. 469]

MARUTHAS, THE BISHOP, ST.

The Bishop of Marjferqat

On the 22nd of Amshir, the Coptic Church commemorates the repose of St Maruthas (Maruta), bishop of Marjferqat (Mia Farcane)¹, and moving the relics of the saints which have been martyred there in the days of Emperor Diocletian (284-305). He was one of the great Fathers of the Syrian Church at the end of the 4th century. He was a bishop on Maiferkat (Marjferqat) between the river Tigris and Lake Van, close to the border of Persia. He used to collect the biographies of the saints who were tortured in the days of King Shapur II (309-379), brought many of their relics to his church, and wrote many poems of praise in their honor in the Syrian language.

Traveling to Constantinople:

When king Yazdgard I (Yezdigerd: 399-420) sat on the Persian throne in the year 399, St. Maruthas moved to Constantinople to convince the Eastern Roman Emperor Arcadius (395-408) to use his influence on the new king of Persia, to appease the persecution of the Christians there. However, in Constantinople, he saw the imperial court so occupied with the case of St.

¹ This name is of Persian origin.

John Chrysostom to care for any other issue. St. John Chrysostom wrote from his exile a letter to St. Olympias, asking her to look for bishop Maruthas and to inquire from him about the conditions of the Christians in Persia.

His Friendship with the King of Persia:

Because St. Maruthas was an exceptional virtuous scholar, he was personally selected by emperor Theodosius II (402-450 AD) to go and meet with the king of Persia to negotiate with him the issue of declaring a truce between their empires and to ask their king to treat the Christians better in his kingdom. According to the historian Socrates (380-450 AD), his knowledge of medicine enabled Maruthas to treat Yazdgard I from a severe migraine that tortured him; and since then, the king called him The Friend of God.

For fear that their king would convert to Christianity, the Magi resorted to trickery. They hid a man underneath the flooring of their temple. When the king came to worship there, the man cried out aloud: "Drive out of this holy place, the king who befriends a Christian priest." The king was about to drive the bishop away, but Maruthas managed to convince him to go back to the temple, where he would find out about the man who was hidden under the temple's flooring. Afterward, the king allowed the bishop to build churches wherever he wanted. The bishop made use of his friendship with the king to restore discipline to the church in Persia. This peaceful time held fast until the Islamic invaders entered Persia in the middle of the 7th century.

The King Persecutes the Christians:

The Christians in Persia were hoping that king Yazdgard I would become the Constantine of Persia. However, this had not been realized. Since the efforts of bishop Maruthas in sowing peace were destroyed by the viciousness of Abdas, the bishop of Susa, who caused Yazdgard I to resume persecution of the Christians at the end of his reign. Yet, most probably, Maruthas did not live long enough to see that persecution, for he reposed in the year 415 AD, while king Yazdgard I died in the year 420 AD.

It was also said that St. Maruthas was known for performing miracles and that he was honored even by his opponents. And because of his writings, he was counted as one of the pillars of the Syrian church after Mar. Ephraim.

[The Synaxarion: 22 Amshir]
[Butler: December 4]

MARY AND EPHCHARISTOS, THE RIGHTEOUS

Although so many monks among the great Fathers were characterized by the spirit of humility and enjoyed so many Divine gifts, they always

wondered within themselves whether there were any others out there, who surpassed them spiritually to learn from them and follow their path. Among those Fathers were St. Anthony the Great, to whom the Lord revealed the existence of St. Paul the First Hermit, St. Zosima the Priest, whom the Lord guided to St. Mary the Egyptian, and St. Macarius the Great, to whom the Lord revealed the two married women in Alexandria, who lived by the spirit of love, sanctity, and asceticism.

A Married Couple Living better than a Monk:

Such a thought came upon one of the saintly elder monks, and a Divine voice informed him that there was a virtuous wife called Mary living with her husband Ephcharistos in a village in Egypt at a spiritual level higher than him. By the guidance of an angel, the elderly monk set forth to that village, to meet with that couple who did surpass him spiritually. Knocking at their door, the woman opened for him, while her husband was still away shepherding a flock of sheep. In the evening, Ephcharistos came home and joined in welcoming their guest. After they prepared dinner for him, the monk refused ultimately to eat until they would tell him about what was going on in their lives. Ephcharistos did not want to talk about their private life together. He just said: "I am a shepherd, and this is Mary, my wife." The elder monk persisted on knowing more about them and revealed to the man that it was God who sent him to them. Here, the man started talking with the fear of the Lord. He said: "I shepherd the sheep we inherited from our parents, and whenever we make a little profit by the help of God, we divide it into three portions: one for the poor, one to accommodate the strangers and the third for our personal needs. Since we got married, my wife lives with me like a sister. Each of us sleeps separately. At night we wear sackcloth, and during daytime, we put on our regular attires. No one knows anything about our lives." Here, Mary looked down and supplicated to the elder monk to keep their life secret until they repose.

MARY MAGDALENE, ST.

The Lord Christ healed St. Mary Magdalene (from 'Magdala') by driving seven unclean spirits out of her. She was one of the women who served the Lord in Galilee (Luke 8:1-2). She also was present when He was crucified and went to His tomb along with two others, to find the grave empty. According to the Gospel of St. Mark, she was the first to see the Lord Christ after His resurrection (Mark 16:9), and St. John added that the Lord entrusted her to carry a message to His brethren (John 20:11-18).

Among the women who were mentioned in the Gospel, there was "The

Sinful Woman” (Luke 7:37-50), whose name was not mentioned, Mary of Bethany, the sister of Martha (Luke 10:38-42) and Mary Magdalene. According to the Eastern Tradition, they were considered to be three different persons, whereas according to the Western Tradition¹, the three of them are considered to be one person (the sinful woman, Mary, the sister of Martha, and Mary Magdalene). However, St. Ambrose (374-397 AD) was on the opinion that this issue should be left unanswered. In any case, the Western Tradition views St. Mary Magdalene as a fantastic role model for the repentant person. Since 1969, the Eastern tradition has been taken into consideration in the New Western Roman calendar. St. Mary Magdalene is celebrated by the Western Church on the 22nd of July.

[The Penguin Dictionary of Saints, p. 230]

MARY, THE ARMENIAN (The martyr)

A Brave Captive gets martyred:

This St. Mary was a captive of a Muslim man, one of the soldiers of the Mamluk Sultan of Egypt Al-Zahir Rukn al-Din Baibars (1260-1277 AD). Her master tried to persuade her to deny her faith in the Lord Christ. But, she refused to go along and proclaimed that she was a true Christian. The man viciously tortured her in his house while she held fast to her faith. When the man got tired of tormenting her without any results, he finally reported her to the Sultan using falsehood, saying, “I have a Muslim maidservant who claims to be a Christian.” The Sultan brought her before him and asked her to declare her Islam, which she refrained to do and persisted on confessing her Christian faith. The Sultan ordered his men to burn her alive. They dug a large pit at the gate of Zoweila in Cairo, where a great multitude came to watch. Then, they brought Mary to the edge of the fiery pit to scare her up and force her to change her mind. However, the saint bravely shouted: “It is great for me, O Sultan, to deliver my soul into the hands of my Lord God and Savior Jesus Christ.” Then, she quickly jumped into fire, where she received the crown of martyrdom.

[The Synaxarion: 27 Mesra]

MARY, THE EGYPTIAN, ST.

St. Mary, the Egyptian lived in the 4th and 5th centuries AD, and her biography was told by a priest called Zosimus, who lived in one of the

¹ Proposed by the Roman Pope ‘Gregory the Great’ (590-604 AD).

monasteries in Palestine for 53 years. When the evil thoughts of loftiness started to creep into his mind, God sent him one of the monks who led him to a monastery close to the Jordan River, where he was told that he should spend the rest of his life. The monks of that monastery were elderly hermits who practiced harsh asceticism in all their lives. The monastery was close to the wilderness where the Lord Christ spent His 40-days fasting. It was the habit of those monks there to spend these 40 days in the desert outside the monastery to return only on the day of Palm Sunday. These monks used to have the Holy Communion before they would go on the first Sunday of the Great Lent. Then they would proceed to the wilderness. Fr. Zosimus followed the rest of the monastery's hermits in their wilderness outing.

His Encounter with Mary the Egyptian:

It happened one year, on his way back to the monastery just before the end of Lent, Fr. Zosimus saw from afar a ghost, whom he first thought to be a demon and made the sign of the Cross on him. Then, he realized that it was a human being. The elderly Zosimus hastened behind him, and when the ghost kept running away, he cried out to him to stop running. The spirit stopped and dived into a pit in the sand, calling Zosimus by his name and saying to him, "I am a woman. If you want to help a sinner, please leave for me your robe to cover my nakedness." Amazed at how she called him by his name, he left his robe for her. She covered herself with it and asked him, being a priest, to bless her. Equally amazed at her knowledge that he was a priest, he asked her to bless him too and to pray for him. Then, he asked her in the Name of the Lord Christ, to tell him about her identity, why she came to this place, how she survived living in such a desolate and horrible wilderness, how long did she dwell there, and how did she manage to endure all that?

The Saint Tells Her Story:

She started her confession and asked him not to be shocked by her horrible sins, and requested from him to keep praying for her while listening to her. Then she began to tell him her story: "I am an Egyptian woman from Alexandria. Since I was 12 years of age, my mind started to get defiled with lust and evil thoughts, through the impact of the evil which prevailed at that time. What kept me from committing the actual sin, then, was my fear and respect for my father. Yet, once both my father and my mother died, I found myself free to do whatever I wanted. So, I got down to the abyss of the defiled physical sins and delivered myself to the carnal pleasures all through the following 17 years. That was not out of any financial needs, but it was to fulfill my evil desires.

Then, one day in the summer, I saw a gathering of Egyptians and Libyans

in the sea-port, on their way to sail to Jerusalem to attend the feast of the Holy Cross. So, I planned to join them, although I did not have the money for the fare. However, I paid for my trip by fulfilling my pleasures with the other travelers.” In deep shame, she looked up at Fr. ‘Zosimus’ and said: “Do you see Father, how shrewd and guilty I was. Woe to my disgrace. The goal of my travel to that Holy City, above all, was to lead the souls to perdition.

Once we reached Jerusalem, I committed many other evil things in the Holy City. When the feast of the Holy Cross came, the multitudes set forth to the Church of the Resurrection. And when it was my turn to enter into the Church amid the dense crowd, it happened that my feet were, as though, nailed to the ground. I could not move an inch. A hidden power kept me from entering into the church despite my repeated trials to do so.

Then, I realized that I was the only person who was denied the entry into the church among that entire great crowd who were able to get in and out without any hindrance. Right away, I retreated to a quiet corner near the gate, and I perceived that what was keeping me from entering into the church was my unworthiness due to my unspeakable corruptions. So, I exploded in a bitter fit of crying. After a little while, I looked up, and I saw the portrait of the Virgin St. Mary right above my head. And in big shame, I cried out: ‘O Holy Virgin! I perceive the extent of my filth and unworthiness to enter into the house of God. With my dirty soul, I do not even dare to look up at your real portrait. Oh, my shame, and my lowliness before you.’

I asked out of my whole heart the intercession of the Virgin Mary on my behalf; I asked her to allow me to enter the church to honor the Holy Cross. I pledged not to resume my evil life any longer and sought her guidance in helping me to bid farewell to the world and its whole pleasures. Feeling then, that my request was well-received, I set forth to take my place among the incoming multitudes and found out that I could enter into the church without hindrance. Extremely terrified, I worshipped down to the ground, shed dense tears at the Holy Cross, and kept praying, not aware of the passing of time, until mid-noon, seeking God’s help, with the intercession of the Virgin St. Mary, to guide me in what I was supposed to do. Here, I heard a voice saying to me: ‘Cross over the Jordan; for there you will find a place for your Salvation.’ I spent that night near the church, and in the morning, I went in my way. Then, I met a man who gave me three silver coins, saying, ‘Take what God has given you.’ I purchased three loaves of bread and asked the baker about the way to the Jordan River. Crossing through the city gate, I felt completely transformed. Then, I reached a church by the name of St. John the Baptist near the River. There, I kept crying, washed my face with the water of the holy River, entered the church, confessed my sins, and got the Holy Sacraments. Then, I crossed the River, and, seeking the intercession of the

Virgin St. Mary, I continued walking in the barren desert until I came to this location we are on, where I spent the last 45 years sustained by God.”

The Devil Battles with Her:

Then, Fr. Zosimus, the priest, asked her about her life in the wilderness. The saint told him about the battles she fought along those years, saying, “I spent the first 17 years suffering from severe hunger and thirst. However, that was nothing compared to what I went through in fighting the vicious battles against the evil carnal desires as if I was fighting actual beasts. All the horrible sins and the iniquities I have committed have played back into my mind. Several times, the thousands of carnal memories and impure thoughts which came to attack me brought so much pain to my heart and went through my veins like live coal, which caused me to cast myself on the ground supplicating out of my whole heart for them to be lifted away from me. I often remained in such a position for several days and nights. Then, a Divine light, like a circle of fire, surrounded me, through which the tempter could not pass through anymore. The Holy Virgin was a great help to me in my life of repentance. All along the way, she kept holding my hand, guiding me through and praying on my behalf. When I ran out of bread, I started to feed upon some herbs and plant roots, which I found in the ground. As for my clothes, they were utterly worn out with time, that I suffered the burning sun and trembled from the desert cold that I was often on the brink of losing my consciousness. Since I crossed the Jordan, you are the first human face I saw. However, the Merciful God has instructed me in the knowledge of the Holy Bible and the psalms.”

Fr. Zosimus Blesses Her:

At the end of her talk, she bowed before Fr. Zosimus, the priest to bless her, and he did. Then, she implored him not to tell anyone about her life, asked him to come to visit her in the following year on the Covenant Thursday, bringing with him the Holy Communion. She promised to be waiting for him at the Riverbank.

Getting the Holy Communion:

In the following year, when the monks went out during the Great Lent, as they used to do every year, Fr. Zosimus was ill with high fever. However, after the Holy Liturgy on the Covenant Thursday, he carried the glorified Body and Blood of the Lord Christ and took with him as well some beans and dates, then went to see the saint and waited for her to come at the bank of the river as she promised. After a long wait, he saw her on the other side of the river coming toward him. She made the sign of the Cross on the water,

and then she crossed the river walking on the water. Seeing that miracle, the priest Zosimus attempted to bow before her. She cried out loudly, "O Father priest, what are you doing? Did you forget that you are carrying the Holy Sacraments?" She then approached, worshipped with reverence, took the Holy Sacraments, then raised her hands toward heaven, crying out: "*Lord, let your servant depart in peace, for my eyes have seen Your Salvation.*" (Luke 2:29-30) She asked him to come to her in the following year, in the same place, to pray for her. She made the sign of the Cross on the river, crossed it back walking on the water, and disappeared from his sight.

Her Departure:

In the following year, and in the appointed time, the priest set forth to the designated place, where he found the saint worshipping to the ground, with her face directed toward the East, and her hands motionless. Perceiving that she was already dead, he worshipped beside her, cried, and prayed on her the funeral prayers. Up to this moment, he realized that he did not even come to know her name; but when he got close to her, he found a written message saying, "Father Zosimus! Bury here the body of the miserable Mary and leave to the dust this sinful body. Pray on my behalf."

Fr. Zosimus realized that she died the year before after she had the Holy Sacraments he brought for her. It is believed that she reposed in the year 421 AD. Returning to his monastery, Fr. Zosimus kept saying to himself: "Indeed, the tax-collectors, the sinners and the adulterers will precede us to the Kingdom of Heaven." St. 'Mary's life was a big motivator for so many to expand their spiritual strive. The Coptic Church celebrates her feast on the 16th of Baramouda every year.

[Fragrant Bouquets from the Biographies of the Righteous and Saints, pp. 249-253]
[The Vita of St. Mary of Egypt written by St. Sophronius, the patriarch of Jerusalem (634–638 AD)]

MARY, THE ISRAELITE (The martyr)

During the early life of St. Mary, the Israelite, she did not know the Lord Christ, and she led a sinful life. When she wanted to repent and to return to the righteous life, the Lord sent to her a saintly man who preached her and revealed to her the way of salvation through believing in the Lord Christ. He told her that the soul would have to give an answer for all her deeds on the Day of Resurrection. After death and departure from this world, everyone will be rewarded according to his deeds. The man explained to her the fearful punishments for the evildoers. She asked him: "What are the proofs to what you have said to me since the 'Torah' that God gave to 'Moses the Prophet'?"

and also my Fathers did not mention that? So, confirm to me the truth of what you just have said with Biblical and logical proofs."

After he explained and confirmed to her all these concepts, she became convinced in her heart and mind. Then, she asked him: "If I repent for my evil deeds, would God accept me?" He replied: "If you believed that Christ had come to the world for the Salvation of the human race, and if you walked in the way of repentance, God would accept you." So, Mary believed and repented. When the governor of the region knew about her, he brought her before him. Then, when she insisted on her Christianity, he ordered her beheaded by the sword, and she received the crown of martyrdom.

[The Synaxarion: 7 Baramhat]

MARY, THE REPENTANT, ST.

Her Monasticism:

St. Mary the Repentant was born in the city of Edessa (Al-Roḥa) in Mesopotamia. When she was orphaned in her childhood, some neighbors brought her to St. Ibrahim, the hermit, who was her uncle in the flesh. Thinking of how to raise that little infant, he decided to let her dwell in the inner room of his cell, and kept on raising her with fatherly love and compassion, teaching her the ways of virtue; and she grew up on the love of worship and asceticism. When the girl reached the age of youth, and according to her wish, her uncle Fr. Ibrahim set for her a cell near his and kept on guiding her on how to win in her fights against the devil.

This nun grew in the spiritual stature, concentrated her sight on the life of piety and virtue, and her Christ who loved her and delivered Himself for her sake until she reached 20 years of age.

Adultery, then Despair:

The devil plotted a crafty way to bring that recluse nun down. At that time, a young man used to frequently visit the elder Fr. Ibrahim to seek his guidance through his spiritual life. It happened that the young man started to notice the recluse nun while she was passing at the same time through a lukewarmth spiritual period. The man kept coming back often to his mentor, to enjoy watching that nun. Then, he got his chance when the elder father got out and left them to walk in the wilderness to contemplate; the young man hastened to her and managed to seduce her to fall with him into the sin of adultery. The devil wanted to uproot that poor nun out of the monastic soil after that horrific mistake, so he planted into her mind the spirit of depression. Feeling the horror of what she had committed, she kept on

slapping her cheeks, hopelessly crying and heartily wishing to die. The devil of shame kept her from offering any repentance or confession, and the devil of despair possessed her. She kept telling herself: “What will my uncle do? He will surely die grieving on me. All the doors of the Divine Mercies are now closed shut in my face because I am so defiled. And, I am no longer worthy of uttering the Name of my God.”

In a House of Harlotry:

The fallen saint came out of the wilderness down to the city, without the knowledge of her uncle and spiritual guide. In the city, the devil guided her into a house of harlotry, to make sure of securing her under his dominion. There, she kept practicing sin for two years. In the meantime, her uncle Fr. Ibrahim was much confused for knowing nothing about her. And he thought that she probably has gone deep into the wilderness for contemplation and asceticism.

Her Uncle Found Her and Her Repentance:

The elder saint Ibrahim supplicated to the Lord to reveal to him what happened to his niece, and he imposed on himself a law of increased prayers and fasting with tears until he would know. After a little while, the Lord revealed to him in a dream as though a large dragon entered into the cell of the saintly nun and devoured a dove there. This vision made the saint cry fervently. Then, in a second vision, the Lord showed him, as though that dragon was split open and the dove came out of it, sound and safe.

Waking up from his sleep, St. Ibrahim kept crying loudly and calling the name of his niece, without avail. He then asked a close friend, Mar Ephraim, who happened to have a spiritual retreat near-by, to help him in his search for the absent nun, to have peace of mind. After a few days of searching, his friend Mar Ephraim came back to tell him that his niece was in a house of sin. With his heart flared with love to bring back the fallen nun, the elder monk disguised himself in the attire of a stranger, and went down to the city, and aimed for that house where the fallen girl lived. When he first did not see his niece among the harlots, he pretended to seek a superb meal to eat. But Lo! It was brought over to him by his niece. She came to offer him the food, besides the other pleasures, as it was the custom. At this point, the girl noticed that her customer was dressed with the attire of purity and asceticism underneath his disguise, and she smelled the fragrance of incense. At once, she remembered her early life, her past strife for purity and her uncle who cared to raise her on a life of virtue and purity.

Immediately, the fallen nun started to cry, fervently remembering how low she had fallen. The owner of the house asked her: “Mary, Why are you

crying, and what is bothering you?” She answered him: “I wish I would have died two years ago.” Remembering that she disappeared two years before, her uncle tried to control the situation, and he asked the owner to bring her a drink. Father Ibrahim started to talk to her about God’s love for the sinners, the adulterers, and the repentant; and that God is always ready to forgive them if they forsake their evil ways. Here, Mary was trembling and kept crying, so he told her: “Look at me; I am your uncle Ibrahim the monk, who raised you. I kept searching for you everywhere, and when I saw you, I tried to hide my tears, lest anyone would recognize me. The Lord Christ said: *‘Those who are well are in no need for a physician, but those who are sick; I did not come to call the righteous, but sinners to repentance’* (Mark 2:17).”

Instantly and without letting anyone notice, the two of them crept out of the house of sin, forsaking the place of iniquity.

Back to her Old Cell:

After those events, the nun entered into her old cell once more, crying out and sorrowful for what she did. From that time on, everybody passing by her cell used to hear the sound of her unceasing cries of repentance. In the meantime, her uncle St. Ibrahim, departed to the heavenly Jerusalem at 85 years of age. The Church celebrates his departure on the 30th of Toba.

The striving saintly nun lived for about five more years after the departure of her uncle, continuously weeping and sorrowfully singing songs of praise. Yet, God gave her a proof of His forgiveness of her sins, by granting her the gift of healing the sick near the end of her life.

Then, she fell ill for a short time and reposed in peace, with her countenance shining with the light of the grace of repentance.

[The Paradise of the Female Saints, Part 1, p. 116]

MARY, THE VIRGIN CONFESSOR, ST.

A Maidservant Testifies to the Lord Christ:

St. Mary lived in the 4th century, as a maidservant to a noble Roman man called Tertullus. Since her childhood, she was a Christian, and she was the only Christian in her master’s household. She kept practicing all her prayers and fasting, particularly during the pagan festivals. This provoked the anger of her mistress, though she endured her maidservant because of her honesty.

Delivered to the Governor:

When the persecution of the Christians started, Tertullus vainly tried to force his maidservant to deny her faith. However, when he failed, he

violently scourged her and hid her in a dark room in his house, for fear that she would fall into the hands of the governor. Eventually, her presence became known, and the governor accused Tertullus of hiding a Christian in his house. So, Tertullus had to deliver her to him. She stood before the governor and confessed the Lord Christ. When the crowd there heard her confession, they sought to burn her alive. She raised her heart in prayer to God for Him to give her steadfastness. Then, she said to the judge: "Because the God I worship is with me, I do not fear your torture, which can only take my life. This life which I am willing to give away for the Lord Christ." The governor ordered to torture her so cruelly that the same crowd present cried out for the horror of the scene and asked the governor to release her.

Eventually, she passed away from natural causes. However, the Roman tradition counted her among the martyrs because of the sufferings she endured for the sake of the Lord Christ.

[Butler: November 1]

MARY, THE SHUT-IN ASCETIC, ST.

A Noble Woman becomes a Nun:

This St. Mary was born to noble parents, among the elites of Alexandria. While she was growing up, so many young men of prominent families came to her parents proposing to have their daughter in marriage. However, she always declined that request. Once her parents died, she distributed her inheritance on the poor and the needy, kept only a small portion; then she set forth to a convent near Alexandria. There, she put on the monastic attire, strove in so much worship for 15 years, and then she was clothed in the Holy "Eskeem," and put on sackcloth on her body.

The Shut-in Ascetic:

After having the permission of her mother-superior, she shut-in herself in her cell, left a small opening in the wall to get through it her bodily and spiritual needs. There, she spent 22 years, during which she used to fast for two days in a row, and then in the Great Lent, she used to fast three consecutive days and break her fasting on few wet beans.

Her Departure:

On the 11th of Toba, she asked for a little holy water, by which she washed her face and hands, had the Holy Communion, and drank from the sacred water. Then, she fell ill and was bed-ridden until the 21st of Toba, when she had Holy Communion again, bid farewell to the mother-superior and the rest

of the nuns, and asked them to check on her after three days. On the 24th of Toba, when they did, they found out that she reposed in peace. They carried her body to the church, and after praying over her, she was buried beside the bodies of the saintly virgins.

[The Synaxarion: 24 Toba]

MARY, THE VIRGIN THEOTOKOS.

This saintly virgin was born in the city of Nazareth, where her parents lived. Her father Joachim was carrying sorrowful heart because he was barren. Her mother Henna was very grieved too, and she vowed to God with a contrite heart, saying, "If you give me a fruit, I shall give her back to Your Holy Temple." When the fullness of time arrived according to the Divine Plan, the angel of the Lord came down and announced the good news to the elder Joachim, who, in turn, told his wife Henna about what he saw and heard. They both rejoiced and gave thanks to God. Then, Henna conceived from Joachim and gave birth to a saintly girl, and they called her Mary.

When Mary reached three years of age, her mother brought her forth to the Temple. There, she spent 12 years, during which she was fed by the hands of angels. When her parents passed away, the temple priests decided to betroth her to a good man to keep her and take care of her because it was not proper to keep her in the Temple after reaching that age. Therefore, the priests gathered 12 pious men of the tribe of Judah to choose from among them one that they would give Mary to. The priests brought these men's canes inside the Temple, and it so happened that a dove came and stood on the cane which belonged to Joseph the Carpenter. By that sign, they knew that the Lord selected Joseph, who was a righteous man, to take care of the young Mary. She remained with him until the Archangel Gabriel came down to bring her the good news that the Son of God would be incarnated within her.

After the ascension of the Lord Christ to heaven, the Virgin St. Mary was always praying in the holy sepulture, anticipating the happy day in which she would be loosened from the bonds of the flesh. Then, she was told by the Holy Spirit that she would soon depart from this mortal world. When it was the designated time, the disciples and the virgins of Mount Olive came to her. While the Virgin St. Mary was lying on her bed, the Lord Christ Himself came to her with thousands of angels around Him, comforted her, and told her about the perpetual happiness she was going to enjoy. Rejoiced, she stretched her hand and blessed the disciples and the virgins, and delivered her pure soul in the hands of her Son and God, who took her up to the high dwelling places. As to her pure body, they shrouded it and carried it to the

Gethsemane. While they were going in their way, some Jews came and tried to prevent them from burying her. When one of them stretched his hands to hold the coffin, his arms separated from his body and remained hanging until he believed and showed remorse on his evil deed. By the supplications of the saintly disciples, his arms were attached back to his body.

It happened that Thomas the Apostle was not present at the time the Virgin St. Mary reposed. However, in his way back to Jerusalem, he saw her shrouded body being carried by the angels to be taken up to heaven; and he was advised by one of the angels to hasten and kiss her pure body, which he did. When he arrived to join the disciples, and they told him about her departure, he said to them, "I shall not believe unless I see her body, for you already know how I doubted the resurrection of the Lord Christ." They took him to her tomb and were shocked and surprised to see it empty. However, Thomas, the Apostle, told them how he saw her pure body with the angels carrying it up to heaven. The Holy Spirit told them that God did not intend for her pure body to remain on earth, and the Lord Christ promised his pure disciples to let them see her in the flesh again, and they waited for this true promise until the 16th of the month of Mesra when it was fulfilled. She lived on earth 60 years: she spent 12 years in the Temple, 30 years in the house of the righteous Joseph the Carpenter, and 14 years in the house of St. John the Evangelist, according to the commandment of the Lord, who said to her: *"Woman! Behold your son,"* and to John: *"Behold! Your mother"* (John 19:26-27). The first church, which was built in the name of the Virgin St. Mary, was in the city of Philippi, in Greece. That happened after the preaching of St. Paul and St. Barnabas to the Gentiles in that city, and when many of them believed, they built that church.

The Virgin St. Mary provided twice special blessings to the Land of Egypt. The first time when she fled to Egypt with the infant Jesus and St. Joseph the Carpenter, running away from king Herod who intended to kill the infant. the second time when she appeared in spiritual ways, inside and outside the domes of the church consecrated in her name in the area of El-Zeitoun, in the suburbs of Cairo on the 2nd of April 1968 (24 Baramhat 1684 AM). Her appearances continued for many consecutive nights.

The Church celebrates the Birthday of St. Mary on the 1st of Bashons, her Entrance into the Temple on the 3rd of Kiahk, her Departure on the 21st of Toba, the Ascension of her body to Heaven on the 16th of Mesra, Building the first Church in her name on the 21st of Paona, Consecrating the church in her name in the 'Muḥarraḡ' monastery, which the Lord Christ blessed by his presence along with His Apostles, on the 6th of Hator and her Apparition in the church of El-Zeitoun on the 24th of Baramhat.

MARY (*The martyr*)

This saint was born in Atrib. Later on, she got married to a good man called Theodore and gave birth to a son, whom they called Sergius. When her son went to the governor Kyriacos and confessed his Christianity, the governor tortured him, brought the statue of an idol, and ordered him to worship it. The young man, instead, kicked the statue and it fell down shattering into pieces. Before such a scene, the governor Kyriacos instantly believed in Christianity, saying, "A god, who cannot save himself, how could he save others?" The minister Ohius then came forward and took over torturing Serguis with fire and other means. When Serguis' mother and sister arrived at the torturing spot, they kept weeping for seeing him in that manner. However, that minister ended up having Serguis' head cut off by the sword.

His mother, Mary, his father, and his sister then came forward and confessed the name of the Lord Christ, and had their heads cut off by the sword too. They all received the crowns of martyrdom on the 13th of Amshir.

[Female Martyrs of Christianity, p. 91]

MATHOY, FATHER

Ordained as a Priest:

It happened that the elder Mathoy (Mathos) once came out of Raythu to go to Magdelon with his brother. The bishop of the area took hold of him and ordained him as a priest. Afterward, while they were having dinner together, the bishop said to him, "Forgive me, father, I know that you did not want that, but I dared to do it to be blessed through you." The elder Mathoy humbly answered, "To some extent, my mind did wish it, however, something was disturbing me, that I do not want to get separated from my brother because I am not used to do my prayers alone." The bishop told him, "If you think he is worthy, I may ordain him as a priest too." Fr. Mathoy answered, "I do not know if he is worthy or not; all I know is that he is much better than me."

The Concept of Perfection:

Fr. Jacob told the following story about Fr. Mathoy, "I was once visiting Fr. Mathoy, and when I intended to leave, I told him, 'I wish I could visit the "Cells." He answered, 'Please, Greet Fr. John, for me.' When I conveyed the message to Fr. John, he said, 'Fr. Mathoy is *an Israelite indeed, in whom there is no deceit*' (John 1:47).' A year later, when I conveyed the good

words of Fr. John to Fr. Mathoy, the latter said, ‘I am not worthy of the words of Fr. John, but anyway, when you hear an elder commends his neighbor more than himself, you should know that he has reached a high level of perfection. Because *the perfection is achieved when you glorify your neighbor more than yourself.*’”

A Word of Wisdom:

Fr. Mathoy told the following story: “Once Fr. Paphnutius (Paklavas) received three brethren who came to request his counsel. When the elder asked them, ‘Are you asking me for a spiritual advice or a material matter?’ They answered him, ‘A spiritual advice.’ So, he told them: ‘Go and love suffering more than comfort; love despise more than glory and love giving more than getting.’”

About the Slander:

Fr. Mathoy once said, “A brother once came to me and stated, ‘Slander is worse than adultery.’ So, I told him, ‘This might be a little difficult.’ He said, ‘Then, how do you see it?’ I said, ‘Slander is evil, but it could be easily cured, for he who slanders could repent several times by saying “I have uttered evil,” whereas adultery is a natural death.’”

The Monk and Humility:

When a brother once asked Fr. Mathoy a word of wisdom, the elder said to him, “Go and supplicate to God to put sorrow and humility in your heart; always beware of your sins; never condemn anyone, be the least of all; never have the company of a boy, the familiarity with a woman or the friendship of a heretic. Cut out the speaking in public, control your tongue and your belly, and avoid drinking wine. In case you hear someone talking, do not argue with him. If what he says is right, say, ‘Yes,’ and if what he says is terrible, say to him, ‘You know more about what you are saying,’ but do not rebuke him. This is humility.”

Seclusion and the Feeling of Weakness:

A brother once asked Fr. Mathoy, “My tongue disturbs me! What should I do to control it? Whenever I am with people, I keep condemning and rebuking everyone.” The elder answered, “In case you cannot control your tongue among men, go into seclusion to drag this weakness. I am a hermit, not because of my virtue, but because of that weakness.”

Of his Sayings:

- I prefer to have a smooth and lasting work, rather than a heavy one from

the start that does not endure.

- The closer one gets to God, the more he knows how much of a sinner he is. When the prophet Isaiah saw God, he said, “*Woe is me, for I am undone, because I am a man of unclean lips*” (Isaiah 6:5).
- When I was young, I used to say to myself, “I wish I could do some good deed one day. But, when I became old, I realized that there is nothing good at all in me.”
- Satan has no idea which way to use to seduce the soul. He throws the seeds of all kinds of evil thoughts, not knowing what kind he will reap. Yet, once he gets to see, he would choose the ones which do his work.

[Publications of the Light: The Sayings of the Elder Fathers; Lebanon 1983]

MATRA (The martyr)

St. Matra was martyred during the days of the 12th Pope of Alexandria St. Demetrius the Vinedresser (188-230 AD), during the reign of Emperor Septimius Severus (193-211 AD). Hearing the decree issued by the emperor being read, ordering everyone to worship the idols, the saint went to the temple and removed the golden hand of the god, cut it into pieces, and distributed it among the poor. Upon finding out that the idol’s hand was missing, they arrested so many people because of that. However, the saint came forward and confessed that he was the one who cut it and took it. The pagans tortured him, and then cast him in fire. The angel of the Lord came down and rescued him. They cut his hands and feet off and nailed him to a wooden pole. A blind man took the blood bleeding from him, put it on his blind eyes, and he instantly regained his eyesight. Finally, they cut his head off and he received the crown of martyrdom.

[The Synaxarion: 10 Mesra]

MATRA (The martyr)

This St. Matra was an elderly Christian believer from Alexandria. When Emperor Decius (249-251 AD) pushed forward the worship of idols and persecuted Christians everywhere, some people reported this saint to the governor of Alexandria. The governor called him over and inquired about his faith. The saint confessed the Lord Christ, to be the True God from the True God. When the governor ordered him to worship the idols and promised him to be given great rewards if he would, the saint despised his promises. When the governor threatened to punish him, he did not care, but proclaimed, “I shall never worship except Christ the Creator of heaven and earth.” The

angry governor ordered him to be beaten viciously, and then he was hanged by one arm. He was cast into prison afterward. Again, they tortured him by burning his face and sides with hot iron rod. Then, when he persisted on his faith, they cut his head off outside the city, and he received the crown of martyrdom.

[The Synaxarion: 8 Baba]

MATRONA, THE VIRGIN (The martyr)

There are three saints carrying the name Matrona In the Roman Martyrology. The Western Church celebrates them on the 15th of March.

The first St. Matrona was of Thessalonica, born to Christian parents, and she worked as a maidservant in the house of a Jewish woman, who kept on asking her to forsake her faith and to become a Jew. However, when Matrona kept on refusing, her mistress increased the burdens of her work and treated her badly. It happened one day that, after taking her mistress to the synagogue of the Jews, she went to the church to pray. Getting to know about it, provoked to anger, her mistress beat her viciously, locked her for four days in a dark place without food or drink; took her out and scourged her with a whip, then took her back to her jail, where the girl delivered her soul to her Savior. For fear that she could be condemned for killing her, she intended to cast the corpse from the roof of the house and to claim that her maidservant fell by accident and died; but while she was doing it, the mistress trampled and fell off from the roof to her death. She was martyred on the 10th of Tout.

The Second St. Matrona was an orphan from the city of Barcelona, and then moved with her aunt to Italy. The girl was given a crucifix, which she carried about with her. Having been condemned as a Christian, she was arrested, thrown into jail, and left to go hungry to death. Her body was carried back later on to her hometown in Spain.

The Third St. Matrona was of a noble origin, from Portugal. She lived a life of sanctity, and because she suffered from acute dysentery, she traveled to Italy searching for a cure.

[The Female Martyrs of Christianity, p. 88]

[Baring-Gould: March 15]

MATTHAOS I, the 87th POPE OF ALEXANDRIA

During the 14th century, the Coptic Church went through so many tribulations. It seemed as if the gates of hell were left opened by Satan, who seemed to have forgotten the Divine promise: “*On this rock, I will build My*

Church, and the gates of Hades shall not prevail against it” (Matt. 16:18).

His Upbringing:

At the end of the 14th century, the Church was headed by Pope Matthaos I (1378-1409 AD), a star who reached the climax of perfection and holiness. He, like St. Athanasius, was fond of practicing the religious rites in his youth, and, like St. Shenouda the Archimandrite in that he used to attend to the sheep and distribute his food to the shepherds to dedicate his time for prayers. The wild beasts were awed by seeing him or hearing his voice. He was like St. Anthony the Great, in that he never got terrified by the demons that appeared to him, and, like St. Paul the First Hermit in his ascetic life. He was like an angel in human form. He continued to shepherd the sheep most of his time, feeding on the minimum of food in summer and winter. Unknowingly, the bishop of the region observed him. Then, when he reached 18 years of age, the bishop ordained him as a priest.

His Escape to the Monastery of Abba Anthony:

The saint escaped from the vainglory and set forth to the monastery of Abba Anthony. There, he did not let anybody know that he was a priest, and served as a deacon, until one day, God revealed his priesthood, as well as his future, before his brethren. For, while he was reading the Holy Bible, a hand came out of the altar to offer incense to him three times, then it disappeared.

His Escape to Jerusalem, then his Return to his Monastery:

For the second time, he escaped to Jerusalem, where he occupied himself with construction during daytime and with worship at night. When his virtues became well known, he returned to his monastery of St. Anthony, the Father of all Monks. Eventually, he became the Abbot of that monastery.

Then, when religious persecution started against Christians, Fr. Matthaos was arrested along with the elder monk Marcus St. Anthony, and they were moved to Cairo in the middle of insults and beating with sticks. They were denied water during the intense heat of the day, but God allowed for heavy rain to pour in the middle of the summer. Once they were brought to the prison, an order was issued to release them and they returned to their monastery. Then, Fr. Matthaos moved to the monastery of Al-Muḥarraḡ in Assiut Governorate to resume his saintly strife, which included cleaning, cooking, sweeping, and serving the sick, the elderlies and the visitors.

Rescuing a Little Hyena:

It happened one day while Fr. Matthaos was in seclusion in the wilderness, that a female hyena approached him and started to pull the hem of his robe.

The saint followed the hyena, which led him to a cave. He entered the cave with the hyena, to find a little hyena had fallen into a dry well within the cave. The saintly father instantly went down and rescued it, amid the joy and gratitude of the mother hyena.

Ordained as a Patriarch (1378-1408 AD):

After the departure of the 86th Pope St. Gabriel IV (1370-1378 AD), the bishops and archons of the Church were discussing whom they would choose to replace him on St. Mark's See. Once, Fr. Matthaos heard that his name was mentioned, he fled away and hid himself in the bottom of a boat. However, God allowed a little child to lead those who were searching for him to his hiding place. When they caught him, he cut his own tongue to appear imperfect for the post and be spared. Yet, the Divine grace instantly repaired his weakness, and his tongue was instantly healed. And he had no other choice but to accept, after getting the counsel of the elder monks in his monastery. So, he moved from shepherding the sheep to shepherding men on the pasture of the Kingdom of Heaven, amid very strong tribulations. He was ordained in the St. Mark Cathedral in Alexandria on the 25th of July 1378.

His Humility:

The rank of a patriarch did not change Pope Matthaos I at all away from his humility, asceticism, watching the nights, praying, and serving everybody, particularly the monks and the nuns, whom he felt as a father for all of them. He was the first to place a bell on the minaret of the patriarchate in Haret Zoweila to alert the believers to get up and pray. This tradition is still followed in the monasteries, particularly in the midnight praise.

With his love and humility, he used to go down to help the workers in the lowest of tasks, yet he was highly respected. Whenever he stood before the altar, his countenance would shine with marvelous light; and when he looked up toward the Lord, who often appeared to him, his eyes would glitter. It was not surprising to see the warehouses of the patriarchate full up in the midst of the tribulation and famine. It turned to be a source of food for everybody with no discrimination. Yet, it was amazing to see those who were satisfied with the bread of the Copts, return to destroy their churches, to fulfill the words, saying, "*Who ate my bread, has lifted his heel against me*" (Psalm 41:9).

This pope was known for his amazing transparency and his ability to see events before they would happen. He warned the monks ahead of time against a famine and kept on reminding many people about their wrongdoings. Once a deacon fell dead when he lied to him and hid a document concerning a deed of the possession of some property belonging to orphaned children.

He was of a competent counsel to the rulers and to everyone who would seek his help. It happened once that a builder who was working on the church of Haret Zoweila fell down from the top of the church and died under the weight of a large stone he was carrying. The pope hastened to bring him to the icon of the Virgin St. Mary, his intercessor, prayed and sprayed holy water on him. Whenever the water touched a part of his body, it started to move. Moreover, the builder life was restored.

As usual, the mob tried to burn the church known as 'The Hanging Church,' despite the apparent intervention of the governor. At the time, the pope was in the monastery. The mob threw live flames inside; however, once the believers attempted to put the fire out, heaven contributed to their effort by a heavy pouring of rain. The same thing was attempted against the monastery of Shahrān, when the pope hastened to the monastery, confronted the mob alone, crying out: "Whoever has the authority, let him kill me first." And, by this way, they all fled.

His Care for his Children:

Pope Matthaos I kept watching over his flock, visited them, fulfilled the needs of the needy, and urged the rulers to treat his children well. Because of him, his flock was honored. In addition, whoever among them had a hard time in his job; it turned by his prayers to a favor. Then, it happened that a monk denied his faith, became violent, and slandered his brethren before the rulers. When some people came to ask the pope to curse him, he refused and, instead, prayed to God to restore him to faith and to grant him the grace of martyrdom. That what did happen to that monk. God also granted him the grace of driving the demons out. *For whomever the prayers and fasting are his food, his power certainly would terrify the demons.*

His Relationship with Sultan 'Barquq' (1382-1399 AD):

People used to come to seek the counsel of Pope Matthaos I for their personal affairs, because of his proven Heavenly wisdom. Even the Mamluk Sultan of Egypt 'Barquq' did not accept his high-level assignment until after seeking his counsel, and he, in turn, asked the prayers of Fr. Marcus St. Anthony. When the two Mamluk princes 'Mandash' and 'Yalbogha' removed Sultan 'Barquq' from his post in Egypt and exiled him to Syria, they started to plant exploitation and chaos in Egypt, especially among the Copts. The pope, himself, was not spared. Mamluk Prince Mandash tortured the pope, who endured the punishment with so much courage that brought shame on his persecutor. Mamluk Prince Yalbogha likewise, was very violent in his persecution, that the pope rebuked him with courage. The prince ordered to put him in jail then issued an order to cut his head off by the sword.

However, when the pope stretched his neck to the sword-man and said, "Strike quickly." The prince was amazed and set him free. Anyway, shortly after that prince Yalbogha was jailed and died as a prisoner in Alexandria.

After a short while, the rebels turned against one another, and Sultan Barquq returned from his exile to rule Egypt amid exultation from all, especially the Coptic Pope and his clergy.

When Sultan Barquq planned to improve his peaceful relationship with Ethiopia, he found no one better than the Coptic Pope to help him achieve that goal. The pope did not write to the evil Ethiopian king who was on the throne at the time, but he wrote to his brother Dawud. When his delegates arrived at Ethiopia with the papal letter, they found out that the evil king was deposed and was replaced by the one to whom the papal letter was addressed. The new king rejoiced to receive it and inquired from them: "Where are the pope's two gifts: the Cross and the Handkerchief?" On noticing how they were amazed, the king told them that he saw the pope, in a night-vision, entering his room to give him those two gifts. The papal letter was fulfilling to what he saw in that vision.

Sultan Barquq died and was followed by his son 'An-Nasir Faraj' (1399-1411 AD), who followed suit of his father's policy. However, the tyrant Mamluk Prince Sudun seized his throne and conspired with evil forces to destroy the Coptic population. The pope retired to the church of Abu-Seifein for seven days, with prayers and fasting, until the Virgin St. Mary appeared to him. She put his heart at ease, and he came out of his seclusion with his face shining like an angel. When prince Sudun called him in, he revealed to the pope what he originally planned to do with the Copts. Then he released him.

When that prince kept resuming his pressure on the Copts, God sent the Archangel Michael who killed him. When the Mamluk Prince 'Jamal al-Din' intended to kill the pope personally, he sent some people to call him. However, the pope dismissed the delegates away with respect after he asked them to give him another day. When they returned on the next day, they found that the pope had already responded to the call of heaven and delivered his pure soul. However, God allowed for Sultan 'Abdel-Aziz ibn Barquq' to bring his wrath on that evil prince, confiscated his wealth, and ordered his men to beat him to death.

The pope let his disciples know about the time of his departure. And, according to the pope's request, he was buried in 'Deir El-Khandaq' (nowadays Abba Roweis), on the 31st of December 1409 AD.

It is amazing that in the evening the pope reposed, a voice came from the relics of the saints buried in the monastery of 'Abba Maqar,' saying, "Wake up and open the gate, for Matthaos has arrived." The monks then knew that the pope has departed to the Heavenly glories. The pope, with his ministering

spirit was seen raising incense among the dead after his departure.

[Fr. Raphael Farid: *Revealing the Secrets of the History of the Righteous Patriarchs, Part 2*]

[Kamel Saleh Nakhla: *The History of the Patriarch of the See of Alexandria*]
[The Coptic Encyclopedia: Matthew I, by Subhi Y. Labib; p. 1569-70]

MATTHAOS II, the 90th POPE OF ALEXANDRIA

After the repose of the 89th Pope 'Yoannes XI' (1427-1452), the whole congregation unanimously chose a simple monk in the Muḥarraḡ monastery who called himself Matthaos the Saāidi (meaning: from Upper Egypt) to distinguish himself from his great synonym Pope Matthaos (1378-1408 AD). He was ordained in Alexandria in the year 1452 AD, and had his residence in the church of the Virgin 'Ĥaret Zoweila,' like his predecessor.

During his papacy (1452-1465), four Sultans reigned over Egypt and their rules were characterized by moderation and reform. During the time of this blessed pope, Egypt again ordained bishops and priests for Ethiopia. And, the pope ordained for them a new metropolitan in place of the one who reposed. There was a good chance for the pope to visit his people in all Egypt's dioceses and the monasteries and to make the Holy Myron. He reposed in the year 1465, and was buried next to Pope Matthaos I in Deir al-Khandaq.

[Fr. Raphael Farid: *Revealing the Secrets of the History of the Righteous Patriarchs, Part 2*]

[The Coptic Encyclopedia: Matthew II, by Subhi Y. Labib; p. 1571]

MATTHAOS III, the 100th POPE OF ALEXANDRIA

Becoming a Monk in the Monastery of St. Macarius:

His parents were Christians of the village of Tukh el-Nasara in El-Menoufyia governorate in Lower Egypt. They were God-fearing people, who loved strangers and had compassion on the poor and the needy. God blessed them with their son Tadros, whom they raised in spiritual way and taught the books of the holy church in the preschool of their village. The grace of God dwelt on him, and he focused his efforts on studying and learning the Christian principles until he was moved by the Divine grace to pursue the angelic path and the ascetic life. Therefore, he set forth to the wilderness of Scetis and became a monk in the monastery of St. Macarius the Great. He strove in asceticism and worship, to be ordained as a priest. He was ordained as a hegemon and was assigned as the Abbot of that monastery.

When the 99th Pope of Alexandria, St. Yoannes XV (1619-1629) reposed,

the bishops, the priests and the archons were guided by the Lord to choose hegemon Tadros of St. Maqar. He was ordained on Sunday the 8th of September 1631 by the name Pope Matthaos III (1631-1646 AD) in the days of Prince Hâsan, the deputy of the deposed governor Mousa Pasha. During his papacy, the church flourished through prayers and fasting. The Coptic congregation set forth to praise God following the man of God who covered the entire land with his continuous visits. Some evil people provoked the governor to force the pope to pay a significant annual sum of money. The governor was so persistent on collecting much money, which created very tense situation within the Church. However, God never leaves Himself without a witness; as the Holy Bible says, *“When a man’s ways please the Lord God, He makes even his enemies have peace with him”* (Proverb 16:7). Therefore, a Jew volunteered to pay the requested money right away and collect it later from the pope. This way, that tribulation came to an end for that year.

The Blessing of Praise and Prayers:

The tremendous financial anguish, suffered by the patriarchate during the papacy of Pope Matthaos III, was the reason behind his repetitive travels and encounters with his flock, and on his return from Upper Egypt full of happiness and content. The tongues and minds were set forth praising God of the Church. As a result, the holy prayers of Praise were written in color in Coptic and Arabic. Then, for the first time, a manuscript was published documenting the history and sanctification of the Holy Myron. Heaven, in responding to the prayers and supplications, caused the Nile to flood and reach its highest level, and prosperity covered the whole land with the prices of goods going down. When the Nile receded again, the Church raised prayers every day until it increased. The land rejoiced, the crops grew, and the conditions got back to normal. It was not unusual for the Turkish governor to issue an order to demolish a great church in El-Maḥalla el-Kobra, which he considered to be more than what the Copts deserve to have. To cover up his evil deed, he built a school in its place.

A Metropolitan for the Ethiopians:

When the Roman Catholic Church attempted to get the Ethiopian Church again under her domain, the Ethiopian king Vasilas refused and expelled the Roman monks. Then, he sent to the pope of Alexandria, who ordained Abba Marcos as a metropolitan for the Ethiopians. However, the metropolitan suffered many persecutions, despite the support of the king for him.

During a shepherding visit to Lower Egypt, the pope visited Berma, Tanta, and his hometown Tikh el-Nasara, where its people received him with a

great welcome and requested from him to stay longer among them. The pope spent with them a whole year. On the Saturday of Lazarus 1646, after the Holy Liturgy, he blessed his congregation, sent them away. Then he entered into his room, where he reposed with a shining countenance, delivering his peaceful soul in the hands of his Creator. He was buried in St. George Church in Tukh Delka (Tukh el-Nasara), in the days of the Ottoman Sultan Ibrahim I (1640-1648) and the governor of Egypt Moḥammed Pasha ibn Ḥydar Pasha.

[Fr. Raphael Farid: *Revealing the Secrets of the History of the Righteous Patriarchs, Part 3*]

[The Coptic Encyclopedia: *Matthew III*, by Subhi Y. Labib; p. 1571]

MATTHAOS IV, the 102nd POPE OF ALEXANDRIA

As a monk, this pope was called by the name of Guirgis el-Miry. He was the Abbot of the Paramus Monastery, and was ordained as a pope (1660-1675) during the days of the Ottoman Sultan Moḥammed IV (1648-1687). In the same year, the papal throne was moved from Ḥaret Zoweila to Ḥaret el-Rum in the year 1660. In the year 1669, a great fire erupted in the region of Ḥaret Zoweila, and many people died as a result of that. In the year 1670, a great plague spread in Egypt and the surrounding areas.

Persecution of the Copts:

This pope suffered so much abuse from the ruling Turks. He had been the only pope among the other sects, whom they put under continuous supervision, forbade him from leaving his residence, prevented him from having any communication with any foreign embassy or to travel anywhere; and his life was threatened at every moment. Copts were harshly abused by Muslims, who insulted them, even more than what they did to the Jews. They would close their churches and their houses for any trivial reason, and they kept treating them so badly to force them to pay huge fines. In the year 1672, the Turkish soldiers slew a harlot and cast her body near the Azbakieh Lake. Then, those evil soldiers closed the houses of the Copts in that neighborhood and forced them to pay 1,000 Dinars as an exchange for that harlot shed blood; otherwise, the Copts were not allowed to go back to their houses and be able to go back to their work.

The Intercession of St. Marcorius:

It happened once that the mob intended to demolish the church of St. Marcorius in Old Cairo. So, to give their crime the official appearance, they asked the State to appoint a representative to supervise the process. Hearing about their intention, the pope was so intensely grieved, that he stayed awake

the whole night seeking the intercession and the help of the great St. Marcorius. Once the soldiers approached the church, a near-by wall fell upon them, and they all died. When the news spread all over the city, the evil people were terrified and forsook their evil plan.

Finally, Pope Matthaos IV reposed in the year 1675, and was buried in the tombs of the Patriarchs in Old Cairo.

[The Patriotism of the Coptic Church and its History; p. 275]
[The Coptic Encyclopedia: Matthew IV, by Subhi Y. Labib; p. 1571]

MATTHEW BASILY, HEGOMEN

The Ministry of the Villages:

Fr. Matthew Basily belonged to a family which dwelt in the village of El-Buâayrat on the western bank of the Nile River, opposite to Luxor. That family was known for their deep spirituality. Before being ordained, he worked in farming, being the older son to his father, who reposed in peace. He got the honor of priesthood at the hands of Abba Marcos, the metropolitan of Luxor, Esna, and Aswan on the 7th of March 1930. He was ordained to serve in the monastery of El-Muhareb, the church of his village, and those of El-Dabâyiah, Meris, and the other villages around the area. At the same hour, his cousin Matthias Tawadros got the same honor, and the two served together.

Love for All:

The most prominent feature of Fr. Matthew was the true love for all his flock without discrimination, stemming from the bottom of his heart. So, whenever he was called by anyone in distress or illness, Christian or Muslim, he would go to his house to pray on his behalf without any hesitation. This love, which filled his heart, kept working even after his departure. One example was that of a poor vegetable seller, called Nefissa, who used to seek his blessing while he was alive. It happened that after Fr. Matthew reposed; she was afflicted by cancer in her goiter gland underneath the neck and was told by the surgeon that she had to have surgery. Immensely disturbed, she left his office directly to the tomb of Fr. Matthew Basily, and asked for his intercession, then took some of the dirt above his grave, wet it, and anointed her neck. Miraculously, she was instantly healed, to the great amazement of her surgeon who diagnosed her ailment.

Fr. Matthew's trust in the Divine Mercies was deeply rooted. It happened that one of his farmers came to seek money to purchase seeds for the new plantation season at a time when he only had what would cover his daily

expenses. He told him: “Come in tomorrow, Our Lord will provide.” The next morning, before the farmer showed up, someone came to Fr. Matthew to fulfill a vow he had, and brought with him double as much as the required money. When the farmer came, Fr. Matthew gave him what he asked for, saying, “God’s storehouses are always full.”

The hegemon’s family that lived the Christian love presented seven of her sons to serve at the Holy Altar. Fr. Matthew was their eldest. He used to say to them: “Let each of you choose the church where he wants to pray this week, and whatever church left, I shall pray there. Counting him like their father, they used to provide him with whatever each received of material gifts, which he would distribute according to the need of each of them; and, they would take it from him with pleasure. He also took care of the churches in which he served, renewed and widened some of them.

He lived for more than a century. In the great lent of 1986, his old age forced him to stay in bed. At the end of the 40 days of fasting, he said to his sons: “I shall go home on Wednesday of the Holy Pascha. They sent to call all the family and friends to come to have his blessing. At 9 o’clock of Wednesday of the Holy Pascha, the 4th of April of the year 1986, he sat in his bed, gave blessing to all around him, and then departed in peace.

[The Faithful Synaxarion: 26 Baramhat]

MATTHEW, THE APOSTLE, ST.

St. Matthew was from the Galilee. He was called Levi and worked as a tax-collector, collecting money from the Jewish people on behalf of the Roman occupiers. Therefore, he was disliked by the population and considered to be a sinner in their point of view. The Lord called him to follow Him while he was sitting at his collection location of his job. St. Matthew stood up and followed Him; for the grace of the Lord worked in his heart right away (Matthew 9:9-24). He got attached to the Lord Jesus, heard His teachings, saw His miracles, and observed His amazing resurrection and ascension. And, his heart got filled with the Holy Spirit on the day of the Pentecost. It was said that he preached the Gospel in Judea, Ethiopia, Persia, and the land of the Parthians. He wrote the Gospel, which carries his name.

[The Church in the Apostolic Era, p. 324]

MATTHEW, THE POOR, ST.

St. Matthew the Poor lived in the 8th century, during the days of the 43rd Pope of Alexandria Abba Alexandros II (704-729). This great saint was born

in the city of Luxor to Christian parents. His father was a potter, and he called him Matthaos. Since his childhood, the boy was committed to worship and holiness. He kept going to the monastery of Abba Isaac the Hermit on mount Agathon, south-west of the city of Esna, about 55 kilometers south of Luxor.

His Monasticism:

When Matthew grew up, he joined the monastery of St. Pachom on mount Asphon. That monastery was 12 kilometers north-west of the city of Esna, on the western bank of the Nile River and 7 kilometers west of Asphon. Asphon was mentioned by the Egyptian Arab historian Al-Maqrizi (1364-1442) in his book: 'The Maqrizian Plans;' this city is still affiliated to Esna until now. Also, Gotier mentioned it in his dictionary, saying that its holy sounding name referred to the home town of the god Hôris, and its civil name meant "The Palace of king Snophro."

His Love for Seclusion and Becoming the Monastery's Abbot:

This saint loved seclusion and silence, so he made for himself a little cave in the western side of that mountain, close to the monastery where he dwelt praying in utter silence and unity with God. After the repose of the Abbot of the monastery Abba Marcos, Fr. Matthaos was chosen to be the Abbot, and he carried out great construction projects.

God granted him the grace of healing the sick and driving the unclean spirits out. When they once brought him a woman with a hidden illness which challenged the knowledge of the physicians, he knew by the Spirit what was wrong with her; and asked her to confess her sin before those present. She confessed that she got married to two brothers at the same time and that this sin was the cause of her getting inflicted with that sickness. The saint then prayed for her, and she was instantly healed.

This saint was so virtuous that the wild beasts used to come to feed off his hands. When he consummated his path, he reposed in peace on the 7th of Kiahk at the age of 105 years. He lived 45 years as a monk and 50 years as the Abbot of the monastery. His blessed body is still buried in a marble tomb in a little chamber at the entrance of the stronghold of that monastery.

[Hegemon Simon, the Syrian: 'Esna,' the City of Martyrs; 1985]

MATTHIAS TAWADROS, THE HEGOMEN

Fr. Matthias Tawadros belonged to a family of hegemon. This family has presented its members as priests to the Almighty God for some time and continues to do so. Fr. Matthias started his education in the church's pre-

school, as it was the custom. He learned the church teachings and loved the praises and hymns. God granted him with such a sweet and comforting voice, which made the listener exultant. He started his service as a deacon, and the congregation was attached to him. He made for himself a private library, collected all he could get of the church books to deepen his knowledge of the church subjects. By his exalted characters, he drew the hearts of the people that they strongly recommended him for the honor of priesthood. However, he kept on resisting that honor, because of his humility and his perception of the great responsibilities, which get entrusted to the priest. Finally, he delivered his whole life to the Divine will.

The Spirit of Prophecy:

Abba Marcos, the metropolitan of Luxor, Esna, and Aswan, never accepted a recommendation from anyone, whatever high his position was. He believed that priesthood was a great responsibility and not for everyone to bear. However, God proclaimed to him in a dream, the worthiness of a deacon. So, he ordained him on the 7th of March 1930 with the name of Matthias. He ministered in the church of the monastery of Al-Mohareb, in the two churches of the Virgin Mary in Palmris and Armant, in the church of John the Beloved in El-Dabāyah and in the church of the Archangel Michael in El-Aqualta. He kept ministering by turn with his relatives the priests in these churches which were all on the west bank of the Nile. The heart of Fr. Matthias was so full of love for his flock and his brethren the priests. God granted him the grace to sense the feelings of others without being told, even if they were far away from him. God also granted him to know some events before they would happen. As an example: In 1974, Abba Abraam (1949-1974) the bishop of Luxor, Esna and Aswan reposed, and the 117th Pope Abba Shenouda III (1971-2012) sent Abba Aghathon (1977-1999), bishop of Ismaāilyia to care for the diocese until a new bishop would be ordained for them. Then, it happened that one morning, while the priests assembled, Abba Aghathon told them: "Pray to God to give you a good watching Shepherd. Spontaneously, Fr. Matthias, pointing to the monk Angelos, who was accompanying the bishop, said: "Here is our blessed bishop in our midst, who will carry the burden of the Diocese." A prophecy which was realized.

His Departure:

Hegemon Matthias knew by the spirit, the time of his departure to Paradise. He felt ill for a few days. When Fr. Besada intended to call a physician for him, he refused saying, "Do not bother yourself, my son, because I am traveling to Heaven. The more his illness progressed, the more was his joy, and he kept on singing the hymns of the third Sunday of the

Great Lent. One week before his departure, the Virgin St. Mary appeared to him, accompanied by St. George, and said to him: "Matthias, I shall relieve you of this world. St. George added: "We shall come on Thursday to take you with us." On that day, the 27th of July 1980, he departed to Paradise in peace.

[The Faithful Synaxarion: 18 Abib]

MATTHIAS, THE APOSTLE, ST.

St. Matthias was one of the 70 disciples assigned by the Lord. St. Matthias was attached to the Lord Jesus from the very beginning. He heard His teachings and saw His signs. When Judas Iscariot fell from his rank by betraying his Lord and committed suicide, they had to choose another one to replace him, according to the words of the Psalm on Judas: "*Let his days be few, and let another take his office*" (Psalm 109:8). The Book of Acts (1:15-26) gave us the details of St. Matthias selection: "And in those days apostle Peter stood up in the midst of the disciples and said, 'Men and brethren, this Scripture had to be fulfilled, which the Holy Spirit spoke before by the mouth of David concerning Judas, who became a guide to those who arrested Jesus; for he was numbered with us and obtained a part in this ministry. Therefore, of these men who have accompanied us all the time that the Lord Jesus went in and out among us, beginning from the baptism of John to that day when He was taken up from us, one of these must become a witness with us of His resurrection.'" And they proposed two: Joseph called Barsabas, who was surnamed, Justus and Matthias. And they prayed and said, "You, O Lord, who know the hearts of all, show which of these two You have chosen to take part in this ministry and apostleship from which Judas by transgression fell, that he might go to his place." And they cast their lots, and the lot fell on Matthias. And he was numbered with the eleven apostles."

St. Matthias was filled with the Holy Spirit in the day of the Pentecost, like all the other apostles, but we do not know where he preached; whether it was in Judea and Samaria, or one of the provinces of Asia Minor. His life ended by martyrdom.

[The Church in the Apostolic Era, p. 325]

MATTHIAS (The martyr)

On the 24th of Amshir, the Church celebrates the martyrdom of St. Matthias of the city of Kus (Quoce). Kus is on the eastern bank of the Nile River in the governorate of Qena in Upper Egypt.

[The Synaxarion: 24 Amshir]

MAURA AND BRIDGET (The martyrs)

St. Maura (Mawr) and St. Bridget were both British twin-sisters princesses of Scotland and Northumberland during the 5th century AD. These two virgins lived an ascetic life with their brother in the land of Gaul after fleeing away from their royal status. Later, they set forth to Rome to get the blessings of the saints there. Then, on their way back to the land of Gaul, they were caught by outlaws who brought them to death. The tombstone on their grave described them as the Martyrs. In the 7th century, queen 'Bathild' attempted to move their relics but was stopped by a heavenly proclamation. Eventually, a shining light was seen over their tomb in Tours, and they appeared to bishop Euphronius, to proclaim that they were the two recluse virgins, Maura and Bridget. They asked him to build an altar over their relics.

[Baring-Gould: The Lives of The Saints: Vol. 07, July 13]

MAURA AND TIMOTHY (The martyrs)

Their biography could be found under the letter "T": Timothy and Mora.

MAURICE AND HIS INNUMERABLE COMPANIONS. (The Martyrs of the Theban Regiment)

When one of the regions in the land of Gaul revolted, Emperor Maximian Herculus (W: 286-305 AD) prepared an army to send there to put it off. One of the regiments of that army was the Theban Regiment, which consisted of drafted soldiers from Upper Egypt all of whom were Christians.

The Theban Regiment refuses to Worship the Idols:

When the army arrived at Octodorum on the river Rhone near lake Genève in Switzerland, Maximian issued an order to the whole army to partake in offering sacrifices to the idol gods to ensure the success of their mission. There, and then, the Theban Regiment retreated and camped in the neighboring region called nowadays St. Maurice-en-Valais, refusing to participate in that kind of celebration. Upon refusing to obey Maximian's orders so many times and before their unity in persistence, Maximian ordered to kill every tenth person in the regiment, in an attempt to terrify them into obeying his orders. Then, upon failing to cause any descent, he ordered to kill the tenth person among the ones remaining, and so on. The Theban Regiment was led and encouraged by three of their commanders: Maurice, Exuperius, and Candidus. They proclaimed that they were ready to endure any punishment rather than to do what contradicted with their religion. When

Maximian threatened to kill every one of them until they would be all gone if they persist on their disobedience, their response was:

“We are your soldiers, but we are the servants of the True God. We owe you obedience and military loyalty, but we shall never disobey our Creator and yours as well, whom you reject. We are ready to obey you in anything which do not contradict with His Commands. We always oppose your enemies, whoever they are, but we are not going to dip our hands in innocent blood. We have already vowed to obey God before we did vow to you, and if we would betray our first vow, you should not entrust us with our second vow to you. You command us to punish the Christians while we are the same. We confess God the Father, the Creator of everything, and His Son Jesus Christ. We watched our brethren being killed, and we rejoice on their behalf, but do not assume that this or any other persecution could make us change our stand. We carry our weapons in our hands, yet we do not intend any resistance because we would rather die innocent than live in sin...”

The Theban Regiment consisted of 6,600 soldiers. When emperor Maximian realized his failure in making them obey his commands, he gave his order to the rest of the army to surround them and to tear them apart into pieces. This Christian regiment did not resist but were led like sheep to the slaughter until their corpses covered the whole vast land, and their blood flowed like a river. Then, Maximian allowed his soldiers to loot and seize the possessions of the martyrs. It happened while the plundering of the martyrs was going on, one of the soldiers called Victor refused to take part in it. When he was asked if he was a Christian, he answered in the positive. They killed him too.

The slaughter of the Theban Regiment took place in the year 287 AD. A great Cathedral was eventually built over the location where they were buried, and so many miracles were performed by their intercessions. Later, so many people sought, from inside and outside Switzerland, to acquire some of the relics of these great martyrs to place them in their churches. And, St. Maurice became the patron saint of the soldiers and the weapon makers.

[Butler: September 22]

MAWHOUB IBN MANSUR, THE DEACON

Collecting the Biographies of the Fathers Patriarchs:

The deacon Mawhoub ibn Mansur raised in Alexandria during the 11th century. He loved the Coptic Church and its rites that he became a ministering deacon. He presented the Church with an excellent service since he collected the biographies of our Fathers the Patriarchs. At the introduction

of those biographies, he wrote:

“I am the miserable sinner, desiring since a long time to do this work seeking my benefit and that of the readers after me. With God’s support, I set forth to the monastery of Abba Macarius in the Holy Valley, and there I found the deacon Abu H̱abib Mikhail el-Damanhury.”

Joining forces together, the two deacons kept traveling from one monastery to another in search for their references. In the monastery of the Virgin St. Mary in Nohia, they found the biographies of 42 popes, starting with St. Mark. In the monastery of the great martyr Tadros in Iblag, they found the biographies of 4 popes, from the 43rd to the 46th. Going back to the monastery of the Virgin St. Mary, they found the biographies of the 47th to the 55th popes. When they returned to the monastery of Abba Macarius the Great, they completed their series from the 56th pope to the 65th pope. They gathered all these 65 biographies and copied them in one volume.

Abba Mikhail, the Bishop of Tanis¹ (initially: deacon Abu H̱abib), entrusted one of his monks to inscribe a personal copy for him. Deacon Mawhoub, on the other hand, occupied himself with recording the biography of his contemporary patriarch, the 66th Pope Abba Christodolus (1046-1077 AD), and who reposed in the year 1077 AD.

[The Faithful Synaxarion: 12 Bashons]

MAXENTINA, THE VIRGIN (The martyr)

St. Maxentia was the daughter of a prince in Ireland², who dedicated her life to God since her childhood. When her father intended to give her in marriage to a pagan man, she fled from her house before the wedding, along with a servant and a maidservant. They sailed to the land of Gaul, where she settled down in the region now known as Pont-Sainte-Maxence.

One day, St. Maxentia found herself before a group of horsemen outside her cottage, among them was her would-be husband. He got very angry when she escaped and kept searching for her since then. He asked her to go back with him, but when she firmly dared to refuse, he pulled her by the hair and cut her head off. She received the crown of martyrdom, and along with her were her faithful servants, who had the same destiny.

[Butler: November 20]

¹ ‘Tanis’ is a city in the north-eastern the Nile delta. Location: ‘San el-Hagar’, ‘El-Sharqya’ Governorate.

² It could have been ‘Scotland.’

MAXIMA, DONATILLA & SECUNDA (The martyrs)

Three girls of the city of Tuburga in North Africa, who were martyred during the persecution stirred up by Emperors Diocletian and Maximianus (284-306 AD). Their biography could be found under the letter “D”: (Donatilla, Maxima & Secunda; SS.)

MAXIMILIAN AND BONOSUS (The martyrs)

They were among the prominent government officers in Antioch, who were martyred in the days of Julian the Apostate (360-363 AD). Their biography could be found under the letter “B”: (Bonosus, ST.)

[Butler: August 21]

MAXIMILIAN (The martyr)

This saint preached Christianity in a part of the Roman empire known as Noricum, which is located between Styria and Bavaria, where it was said that he established the church of Lorch, near the city of Passau, where he was martyred. According to his biography, which was written in the 13th century AD, he was born in ‘Cilli’ in Styria. When he was seven years old, his father handed him to a priest to educate him. St. Maximilian distributed the vast wealth he inherited from his wealthy parents among the poor and the needy and went to visit Rome to get the blessing of its saints. There, the Roman Pope Sixtus II (257-258 AD), sent him to Noricum to preach Christianity, where he founded the diocese of Lorch. Even though he was a contemporary of the persecution, stirred up by Emperors Valerian (253-260) and Aurelian (270-275), he kept preaching there for about 20 years and managed to convert so many pagans to Christianity. However, during the time of Emperor Numerian (283-284 AD), the governor of Noricum issued a decree to persecute Christians. St. Maximilian was arrested and ordered to sacrifice to the idols, and when he refused to do so, his head was cut off outside the walls of Cilli around the year 284 AD.

[Butler: October 12]

MAXIMILIAN (The martyr)

The Roman soldier Fabius Victor was brought to trial along with his son Maximilian in the city of Theveste in Numidia (now Tebessa in north-eastern Algeria). There, the general prosecutor opened the case in the presence of

Valerian Quintian, the deputy Caesar, who asked Maximilian about his name, then ordered his men to enlist him in the military service and let him wear the military seal since he was the son of a soldier. However, Maximilian responded that he would not join the military service because he was a Christian. Then, the interrogation of the judge for him went in the following manner:

- You have to serve in the military, or else you will die.
- + I cannot serve the military (**because the soldiers were obliged to worship the idols**). You may cut my head, but I shall not serve the world, for I am a soldier of Christ.
- Who put those strange ideas in your head?
- + My conscience and God who called me to serve.

Here, the judge asked his father Fabius Victor to try to bring his son back to reason, but Maximilian proclaimed that he would never change his mind. The judge attempted so many times to make Maximilian accept the military seal, but the saint said:

- + If you force me to wear it, I shall disfigure it. Being a Christian, I am not allowed to carry such a heavy seal on my neck because I am already carrying the holy sign of Christ – the Living Son of God, whom you do not know. Christ, who endured the suffering and death for the sake of our Salvation. We Christians follow Him with our whole hearts and serve him through all the days of our lives.
- But there are Christian soldiers who already served and are serving our rulers: Diocletian (284-305), Maximian (286-305), Constantius (305-306) and Galerius (305-311). So, how come you do not follow their example?
- + That was their business. I am a Christian too, and I shall not serve.
- If you persist on your position, I shall condemn you to die because you are violating the rules of the military.
- + I shall not perish, but if I depart from this world, my soul shall live with Christ.

The judge condemned St. Maximilian to death by the sword to make him an example for the others. This martyrdom took place in the year 296 AD when St. Maximilian was of the age of 21 years and three months. Before his death, he addressed the Christians assembled to observe the execution. He said: “Beloved brethren, try to hasten with deep longing to enjoy seeing God by receiving the crown of martyrdom like me.” Then, he addressed his father: “I hope to receive you in Paradise and to glorify God together there.”

St. ‘Maximilian’s head was cut off, and his father Victor returned home exultant and thanking God, who allowed him to send such a precious gift to

Heaven. He was longing and hoping to follow him after a little while.

After his martyrdom, a pious woman called Pompeiana cared for the body of St. Maximilian. She took it to Carthage, where she buried him.

[Butler: March 12]

MAXIMINUS OF AIX, ST.

This St. Maximinus was said to be one of the 70 apostles of Christ. After the ascension of the Lord Christ to Heaven, this saint seemed to have left Palestine, along with SS. Mary Magdalene, Mary Cleopus, Mary Salome, Martha, her sister. Mary, their brother Lazarus and other saints, to go and preach in the region of Provence on the Mediterranean in southern France. There, St. Maximinus made his center in Aix, and he became its first bishop. When it was time for St. Mary Magdalene to depart, she was carried from the cave where she dwelt at Sainte Baume, to a place known nowadays as Le Saint Pilon, beside which there is the church of St. Maximin. This church was built on the same location as an old church in the name of this saint, which included the relics of St. Maximinus and St. Mary Magdalene. The relics of St. Maximinus was later moved in the year 1820 to Aix, where he has been considered to be its main patron saint. It is believed that the head of St. Mary Magdalene is still there in an old grave in the church of St. Maximinus.

[Butler: June 8]

MAXIMINUS, THE BISHOP, ST.

This St. Maximinus was most probably a native of Poitiers in west-central France. He forsook it early in his youth to go to Treves (Trier) on the southwestern border of Germany with France. He was drawn to Treves because of the great things he has heard about its bishop St. Agritius. Over there, he completed his education; then, later on, he became the bishop of the city, after the departure of St. Agritius.

When St. Athanasius the Apostolic (328-373 AD) was exiled to Treves in the year 336 AD, he was received with great honor by its bishop St. Maximinus. He regarded himself so lucky to give hospitality to such a great minister of God. There, St. Athanasius stayed for 2 years, during which his writings referred to the courage, and virtues of his host, as well as the miracles performed at his hands.

When Emperor Constantius (305-306 AD) exiled St. Paul, bishop of Constantinople, to Treves, he also found in its bishop Maximinus, a great advocate for him. St. Maximinus got in touch with Emperor Constans I (337-

350), who used to visit Treves so often, to draw his attention towards the Arians and warn him against them. The saint himself kept on attacking the Arians in every occasion; that his name often was bound to that of St. Athanasius as could be seen in the letters written by the Arians against their opponents. Although St. Maximinus had plenty of written works, none of them was preserved. We do not know the exact date of his departure, but most probably it was in or before the year 347 AD since his successor Paulinus sat on the throne of Treves in that year

[Butler: May 29]

MAXIMUS AND HIS COMPANIONS (The martyrs)

On the 1st of Hator, the church celebrates the martyrdom of SS. Maximus, Numitius, Boctor (Victor), and Philip (Philopus) who were martyred during the days of Emperor Decius (249-251 AD).

Their biography could be found under the letter “B”: (Boctor, the Roman)

MAXIMUS, THE CONFESSOR BISHOP

Bishop Maximus III (334-350) was the 40th in the series of the bishops of Jerusalem after the Apostles. He sat on the throne after the repose of his predecessor bishop Macarius I (314-334) in the year 334. He was among the confessors because he endured severe torture for the sake of faith while he was serving as a priest in Jerusalem during the persecution stirred up by Caesar Galerius Maximianus (293-305 AD). This torture caused deformation to his body; he lost an eye, muscles of an arm and a damaged off foot.

According to the historian Sozomen (400-450), his predecessor bishop Macarius I recommended him to be ordained as a bishop on the diocese of Diospolis (Lydda). However, as Maximus was so loved by the people of Jerusalem, that recommendation was not received by them with pleasure and was about to cause a public revolt in the city. Therefore, Macarius I changed his mind and recommended another person for that diocese while keeping Maximus in Jerusalem as his assistant to, consequently, succeed him after his death. He had full trust in the orthodoxy of the beliefs of Maximus, while he had fears that the two Arian bishops Acacius of Caesarea and Patrophilus of Scythopolis might manage to bring an Arian bishop to succeed him instead.

Maximus and his Weak Personality:

However, it seemed that Maximus had a weak personality. Although he was faithful, his shyness and simplicity made him an easy prey in the hands

of others. It is known that he attended the Council of Tyre in the year 335, and according to the historians Socrates (380-450) and Sozomen, his simplicity and weak nature made him unable to recognize the tricks of the enemies of Orthodoxy. So, he ended up taking side against the 20th Pope of Alexandria, St. Athanasius the Apostolic. The historian Rufinus (344-411) narrated about that Council, concerning an elder confessor bishop of Thebes by the name Paphnutius, whose deformed tortured body drew the attention of the members of the Council. He said that when Paphnutius saw the way bishop Maximus stood, he rushed to hold his hand and took him to where a small group of those pro-Athanasius were standing, telling him: "It is not befitting for those who carry in their bodies the signs of endurance for the sake of Faith, to join the enemies of that Faith." Sozomen had reiterated the same story in his account.

Little is known about the position of Maximus from the troubles which the Arians had stirred up in the period between the Council of Tyre (335 AD) and the Council of Sardica (343 AD). Yet, it is known that in the Council of Sardica, Maximus stood on the side of Orthodoxy. His name came at the top of the bishops of Palestine, who signed its pro-Orthodox decisions. Afterward, he showed his deep remorse on his previous hesitant position, by the great welcome he gave to St. Athanasius the Apostolic, when he was passing through Jerusalem, on his way back from his exile to his seat on Alexandria. Maximus assembled a large number of his bishops to welcome the great guest; and wrote letters to the bishops of Egypt to congratulate them on the return of their pope, and Maximus was the first to sign it.

St. Maximus III reposed in the year 350 AD and was succeeded by Bishop Cyril (350-386 AD), who was ordained as a deacon by bishop Macarius I, then as a priest by bishop Maximus III.

[A Dictionary of Christian Biography, Vol. III, p. 877]

MAXIMUS, THE CONFESSOR

He was a Roman priest and a confessor during the year 250. He became the head of a group of confessors after the death of Moses (Moyses)¹. It was said that he had followed first the heresy of Novatian², yet when he proclaimed his repentance and rejected it, he was promptly restored to his

¹ Cf. 'Moses' the confessor... [File # 1689]

² 'Novatianism', an Early Christian sect devoted to 'Novatian' (c. 200-258), held a strict view that refused readmission to communion those baptized Christians who had denied their faith or performed the formalities of a ritual sacrifice to the pagan gods under the pressures of the persecution sanctioned by Emperor Decius in AD 250...

priesthood rank.

[A Dictionary of Christian Biography, Vol. III, p. 883]

MAXIMUS (The martyr)

According to the *Roman Martyrology*, this saint's martyrdom is celebrated on the 30th of April. While the Greek Church honors him on the 14th of May, the day of his martyrdom in the year 250 in either Ephesus or Lampsacus.

When Emperor Decius (249-251 AD) issued his decree to persecute the Christians, Maximus, who was a simple merchant and a faithful servant of the Lord, delivered himself to the governor in Asia Minor. He was brought before Optimus, the governor who had the following interaction with him:

- What is your name and status?
 - I am Maximus. I was born free, but I am a slave of the Lord Christ.
- What is your profession?
 - I am a merchant.
- Are you a Christian?
 - Yes, even though I am not worthy.
- Have you not heard about the decrees issued by our great emperor that order the Christians to forsake their fantasies, and worship the idols?
 - Yes, I know about the decrees issued by the emperor of this world; hence I delivered myself to you.
- Therefore, come and offer sacrifice to the gods.
 - I offer sacrifice only to one True God, to whom I was lucky to do so since my childhood.
- In case you sacrifice to the gods, you will go free; otherwise, you will be tortured to death.
 - That is what I desire. How I wish to exchange this short and miserable life with the eternal one.

After trying with him for a long time, Optimus ordered hanging him on the tools of torture. Then, on seeing how he held fast through all the tortures, he ordered stoning him to death to be an example in front of the other Christians. St. Maximus was immediately seized by the executioners and carried to the outside of the city walls, where they stoned him to death on the 14th of May 250 AD. While St. Maximus was led outside the city, he kept giving thanks to Jesus who granted him the grace of martyrdom.

[Butler: April 30]

MAXIMUS, ST.

This St. Maximus was the son of Emperor Valentinian I (364-375 AD), the Roman Caesar of the West; and the brother of St. Dometius, whose biography could be found under the letter “D”: (Dometius and Maximus SS.)

MAXIMUS, the 15th POPE OF ALEXANDRIA

Pope Maximus (264-282) was born to Christian parents in Alexandria, who raised him well and made him join the School of Alexandria, at the time when Origen was its dean. He mastered the Greek language and studied religion and philosophy. Being a man who feared God, the 13th Pope St. Heraclas (230-246) ordained him as a deacon on the church of Alexandria. Then, the 14th Pope St. Dionysius the Great (246-264) ordained him as a priest and entrusted him to give sermons in St. Mark Cathedral. Owing to the prominence of Fr. Maximus in virtue and knowledge, the Church bishops chose him for the patriarchate after the repose of Pope Dionysius. Especially that it was known that Fr. Maximus endured with an incredible perseverance, tranquility, and joy so much persecution ordered by Emperor Decius (249-251). The people chose him to become the 15th successor of St. Mark the Apostle. He was ordained on the 13th of Hator 264 AD. During his days peace prevailed after so many years of flaring persecution that ended during the later years of the papacy of Pope Dionysius the Great.

After a little while from becoming a pope, he received a message from the local Council of Antioch, explaining the reasons for excommunicating the heretic Paul of Samosata¹ and his followers. The pope took the chance and read it on the clergy of Alexandria, and then he wrote a message to his congregation to tell them about the venoms of that heresy. He warned them, as well, against the heresy of Mani² and what it contained of vanity. Those pastoral messages were for the congregation like a healing balsam for the wounded hearts.

This pope continued to shepherd his people and strived to guard them and to hold them fast in Faith. He used sermons, warning, and pastoral letters. What was known about his sanctity and perpetual teachings, made his people revere him during his life and after he reposed. He sat on the papal seat for 17

¹ *‘Paul of Samosata’s teaching is a form of ‘Monarchianism’, which emphasized the oneness of God... He taught that Jesus was born a mere man, but that he was infused with the divine Logos or word of God... Hence, Jesus was seen not as God-become-man but as man-become-God...*

² *‘Manichaeism’ was a major religion founded by the Iranian prophet ‘Mani’ in the Sasanian Empire. Manichaeism taught an elaborate dualistic cosmology describing the struggle between a good, spiritual world of light, and an evil, material world of darkness...*

years and 5 months, and he departed on the 14th of Baramouda 282 AD.

[Great Patriarchs of our Coptic Orthodox Church; Part 1; p. 66]
[The Coptic Encyclopedia: Maximus, by Aziz S. Atiya; p. 1574-5]

MAXININUS AND JUVENTINUS (The martyrs)

Those two saints were officers in the army of Emperor Julian the Apostate (360-363 AD) and were martyred by the sword in prison in Antioch in the year 363 AD. Their biography could be found under the letter “J”: (Juventinus and Maxininus, SS.)

MEATHIUS, FATHER

About Father Meathius, it was said that he used to go out of his cell, not caring even to come back, because he had no possessions of this world to worry about. The only thing he had was a sharp knife by which he used to cut the palm leaves of which he used to make three baskets every day, just enough to earn his daily needs.

Fasting:

About another Father by the name Meathius, it was said that he was so humble and was disciplined at the hands of elderly Egyptian Fathers, such as Fr. Sishoy and Fr. Bemen. He lived near a little river in Sinai. Once, he spoke about one of the saints who came to visit him saying that saint asked him: “How do you spend your time here in such a wilderness, my brother?” He answered him: “I fast for two consecutive days, and then eat only one piece of bread.” The visitor saint told him: “If you want to listen to me, eat every day half a piece of bread.” And, when Meathius did what the visitor suggested, he felt more comfortable.

Fr. Meathius was once asked by his disciples: “In case some food remained for the next day, shall we give it to the brethren to eat?” He answered them: “If it was spoiled, we should not offer it to the brethren, lest they would get sick. Therefore, we should throw it out. But, if it was tasty and good to eat, it should not be disposed of out of luxury and replaced with fresh food; because that would be a bad thing to do.”

The Constructive Communal Living:

He also said: “At the beginning, we used to gather together to discuss beneficial matters, building one another, and we used to form a holy choir and rise to Heavens. But now, once we gather together, we condemn one another, and we keep going down into the pit.”

MEDIUS (The martyr)

His martyrdom is celebrated with the deaconess Dionisa(Denisa) by the Church on the 13th of Baramouda.

MEHRAEL (The martyr)

Her Upbringing:

St. Mehrael lived in the 4th century AD and her name was mentioned in some manuscripts as Mehraty, which means (God's Safety). She was raised by good Christian parents in the town of Temwa in the province of Giza. Her father was a pious priest called Yuannis (John), and her mother was a virtuous woman called Hilaria. Initially, they did not have any children, and they kept praying fervently to God to give them offspring. Abba Bissari, the bishop of Manf, prophesied that God would provide them with descendant. Heaven responded to their request, and they got this holy baby girl.

Her Father's Night-Vision:

This little girl was raised on a life of piety with many heartfelt prayers. Then, when she reached 12 years of age, the Virgin St. Mary appeared to her father the priest, and told him: "I come to you concerning your daughter Mehrael, whom I call to the wedding of my Son in the heavenly Jerusalem, where there would be no hunger, thirst or labor, but only unceasing joy and gladness." Fr. Yuannis answered the Virgin, saying, "How could I deliver my daughter to such a faraway and foreign land?" The Virgin responded: "Live is the Lord God the Almighty. After the repose of your daughter, I shall send her body to you to bury wherever you wish." The Virgin then anointed St. Mehrael with fragrant oil that granted her the grace of performing miracles and wonders of healing the sick.

Her Persecution:

The promise of the Virgin St. Mary that Mehrael would receive the crown of martyrdom was realized when Emperor Diocletian (284-305 AD) stirred up his persecution against the Christian believers, and a multitudes were martyred. Then, it happened that Mehrael went out to the river bank; and when she found a boat carrying a great number of those led to martyrdom, she went along with them without telling her parents. When the boat reached Ansenah, the governor thought of releasing that 12 years old girl for the sake

of her young age. However, when she bravely proclaimed her faith and cursed the idols in front of her, the angry governor ordered his men to torture her. The Lord, however, kept her safe of any harm.

Finally, the governor ordered her to be put in a box filled with serpents and scorpions, and to be taken on board of a boat to get rid of her box. The boat sailed for three days, during which the saint was singing praise to God. On the 4th day, the Lord Jesus Christ appeared to her and said: "Peace be with you, O martyr saint, peace be with you, O pure Mehrael. I shall deliver you to your father's house, according to what my mother promised him. The perfume my mother poured over your head, I shall keep its fragrance in your body to the age of ages. Whoever builds a church in your name, I shall write his name in the Kingdom of Heaven; and whoever calls his daughter by your name, I shall keep her safe of any harm." Then, all those on the boat, started to smell the sweet fragrance of perfume, but they could not see anybody, they just heard some voices and were terrified.

Her Repose:

After a while, her spirit reposed in the Lord. A strong wind made the boat land motionless at Temwa. There, the soldiers got out of the boat to purchase some food, and on their return, they saw a great shining light. They went back and told the people of the town about what happened to the saint. Her father priest Yuannis came with a multitude of the inhabitants of the town, took her holy body, shrouded it, and buried it with honor. From the saint's body, so many signs and wonders appeared.

During the era of Emperor Constantine the Great (306-337), he ordered to build a church in her name in Temwa, which was consecrated on the 22nd of Mesra, where the body of the saint was laid. After 600 years from the disappearance of her churches, the memorial of her martyrdom was again celebrated on the 14th of Toba (22 January).

[Watany Newspaper, # 1839; 22 March 1997, p. 3]

[The Martyr Mehrael, Christ's Bride, by: Yusuf Tadros Al-Gomi, March 2000]

MELANIA, THE ELDER, ST.

This virtuous woman St. Melania was born in Spain in the year 341 AD. Her father was a general consul, called Marcellinus. She moved to Rome following her marriage at age 14, to a proconsul and prefect of Rome. She became a widow when she was 22, in the days of Emperor Valens (364-378).

In Alexandria:

After the death of her husband, the emperor's court took over the

responsibility as a guardian for her son. being among the richest women of her day, she took all what she could carry off her wealth and slaves, and she sailed to Alexandria, where she sold all, and carried the proceeds to the wilderness (the Natron Valley) where she had a chance to meet with the saintly Fathers; such as SS. Pambo (Bemwa), Isidore, Evagrius, Paphnutius, and others. She remained in the wilderness near them for one-half year.

Serving the Confessors:

When the Arian persecution broke out after the death of the 20th pope of Alexandria, St. Athanasius the Apostolic in 373 AD, many of the monks were exiled to Caesarea of Palestine, and some of them were imprisoned. St. Melania followed them to Palestine and supported them financially. It was said that she clothed herself in one of her maidservants clothing, and brought the monks the food and their other needs late at night. When the governor of the region discovered that she was a wealthy woman, he arrested her in hope that he would get some of her money. So, he cast her in prison, charged her with helping the outlaws. However, when she informed him about her imperial connection, he apologized to her and allowed her to visit those in prison at any time she chose. The saint built a convent in Jerusalem and a monastery on the Mount of Olives led by the pious monk and theologian Rufinus of Aquileia. In that convent, she dwelt for 27 years welcoming the pilgrims visiting the holy city. She also gave a large sum of donations to the poor, besides what she distributed in secret on the churches.

Returning to Rome:

Around the year 400 AD, while she was about 60 years old, she left Palestine for Rome to see her son Valerius, who had married Caeionia Albina. She also visited Paulinus of Nola and brought him a relic of the True Cross. St. Augustine of Hippo wrote Paulinus that St. Melania the Elder was in north Africa when her son Valerius died in 406 AD¹.

St. Melania also helped so many poor people and moved them from Rome to other quiet locations to worship God. Then, she challenged the Roman Senators and their wives, for whom notions of asceticism within marriage, purity, and virginity were gravely scandalous. She used to say to them: “Little children, it was written over four hundred years ago, it is the last hour. Why are you fond of the vain things of life? Beware lest the days of the Antichrist overtake you, and you not enjoy your wealth and your ancestral property.” By such teaching, she not only gained them to Christ but a life of asceticism as

¹ Due to the influence of St. ‘Melania the Elder’, her granddaughter, known as ‘Melania the Younger’ would later on take up a holy religious life...

well. Forty days after her return to Rome, she reposed around the year 410 AD, in right old age.

[The Paradise of Saints, p. 40]

MELANIA, THE YOUNGER & HER HUSBAND PINIANUS

Married to a Nobleman:

St. Melania the Younger was born to Valerius Publicola and his wife Albina. Her father was the son of Valerius Maximus Basilus and St. Melania the Elder. St. Melania, the Younger was a girl full of wisdom and heavenly knowledge who longed for a life of virginity. When her father forced her to marry, she still kept in her heart the pious words of her grandmother, the princess Melania the Elder. At the age of 14, Melania married one of her noble relatives, Valerius Pinianus. During her married life of 7 years, she had two children who died very young. After their death, Melania's inclination toward a celibate life reasserted itself, and she secured her husband's consent and entered upon the path of evangelic perfection, parting little by little with all her wealth. Her husband Pinianus, who acted like a dear brother to her, was her companion in all her efforts toward sanctity. St. Melania the Younger and her husband embraced Christian asceticism and maintained a celibate life after that. Upon inheriting her parents' wealth, she donated it to ecclesiastical institutions and the poor through anonymous intermediaries.

Her Ministry:

She sent money to the churches of Egypt, Antioch, and Palestine, treated her slaves and maidservants like brothers and sisters, and set free those who chose to be free. She sold all her possessions in Spain, France, Britain, and Sicily and gave the proceeds to the monasteries and the poor, often saying that she wanted to be relieved from their heavy burden.

St. Melania the Younger joined a convent, where she lived like the least nun, in an ascetic life with a warm spirit. She spent her nights in prayers and planned to eat once every five days, but for the sake of those she gained to Christ, she consented to eat once a day, along with them.

The Monk Pinianus:

Her husband, Pinianus, grew as well in the ascetic life, lived with about 300 monks in a monastery he built. He focused on reading the Holy Bible and on working by his hands in the garden. He managed to bring to Christ someone called Pachomius of a noble family, who distributed his wealth on the poor and the needy.

In 410 AD, Melania and her husband traveled to Africa, where they befriended St. Augustine of Hippo and continued to devote themselves to a life of piety and charitable works. There, they founded a convent on which St. Melania became mother-superior and a big monastery of which St. Pinianus took charge.

In Jerusalem:

In 417 AD, they went to Palestine by way of Alexandria, where they visited in their way the main places of monastic life and hermitages. Then, in Jerusalem, they lived in a hospice for pilgrims and met St. Jerome, whose disciple Paula was one of Melania's cousins. Melania became a member of St. Jerome's circle of helpers.

After the death of Pinianus about 420 AD, Melania built a church and another monastery for men. Her mother Albina died in 431 AD, and after this, Melania opened a convent for women on the Mount of Olives, which she inspired and maintained, but refused to become its mother-superior. She attracted many men and women to the solitary way of life, one of whom was her chaplain and biographer, Gerontius. She lived in Jerusalem for 22 years in a hermitage near the Mount of Olives.

Her Departure:

St. Melania the Younger spent the Christmas of 439 AD in Bethlehem and then died a week later.

[The Paradise of the Saints; p. 41]

MELETIUS, THE ARCHBISHOP OF ANTIOCH, ST.

His Upbringing:

St. Meletius was born in Melitene in Armenia at the beginning of the 4th century. He was among the elite and lived by the spirit of piety and goodness. He was a role model in his talk, movements, and behavior, besides having a beautiful countenance and sharp mind that made him beloved by everybody. He was commended by many like St. John Chrysostom, St. Gregory of Nyssa, and Amphilocius bishop of Iconium.

Bishop of Sabaste:

When the bishop of Sabaste (in Armenia) reposed, Meletius was unanimously chosen to become a bishop in his place. Strangely enough, the Arians themselves approved his choice, which made the Orthodox doubt his faith. but they soon recognized his genuine effort to bring the lost souls to the

Upright faith. Sensing that his efforts in that regard were not making any fruits, he fled from the bishopric and dwelt in the wilderness of Beroea¹ in Armenia. There, he attracted so many people to follow him.

Not enduring the honor and fame, he escaped from the wilderness of Beroea disguised to the city of Aleppo in Syria to live unrecognizable among its people. However, he was not able to hide for long the marvelous spiritual light shining from his countenance.

The Patriarch of Antioch:

When Eudoxius (358-359 AD), the Arian patriarch of Antioch was expelled, the Arians and the Orthodox focused on searching for a successor. Here, God had compassion on His Church, which had endured under the yoke of the Arians for about 30 years, so He inspired both sides to move towards choosing Meletius as its patriarch. The Arians did not hesitate to do so because they have previously approved of him in Sebaste, and the Orthodox were sure of his Upright Faith. His upright behavior, his eloquence, and the sweetness of his interactions had significant effect on getting the approval of everybody on his selection. All hoped that tranquility and peace would dwell on the church of Antioch under his pastoral guidance.

When the Arian Emperor Constans (337-350 AD) was in Antioch, the Arians asked him to let Meletius become the patriarch of Antioch. The Orthodox congregation approved that request with their whole hearts. Hearing about that, Meletius intended to escape. However, he was chased by the emperor's delegates, and they brought him back to Antioch. There, the bishops, the priests, the people, even the Jews, and the pagans welcomed him with great joy.

His First Exile:

St. Meletius started his ministry by concentrating his effort on guiding his people to live a holy life and grow into all virtues. This approach had significant impact on so many. But the Arians wanted to test his faith, and they sought from the emperor to question him, along with two other bishops to find out from the three of them how to interpret the bible's verse, saying, *"I have been established from everlasting; from the beginning, before there was ever an earth"* (Proverb 8:23). Gregorius, the Bishop of Latakia started by interpreting the verse in the Arian way, followed by Acacius, the Bishop of Caesarea, in the same manner. Yet, when Meletius started to interpret it elaborately and with theological eloquence, confirming the unity and equality

¹ 'Beroea' (Berea) was a city of the Hellenic and Roman era now known as 'Veria' in Macedonia, northern Greece...

of the Father and the Son in the same essence, they all got very annoyed, that one of the deacons dared to stretch his hand and tried to shut the mouth of the patriarch. However, St. Meletius completed his talk with audacity that drew so many of those present to his side.

St. Meletius was so admired by the Orthodox that they were called 'The Meletians.' In the meantime, the embittered Arians resented him at the emperor, that he exiled him back to Armenia.

On observing what was happening, St. Eusebius, the bishop of Samosata, got hold of the Council's document, which declared the choice of Meletius as a patriarch on Antioch and carrying all the seals of the attending bishops. The Arians sent to him a messenger from the emperor asking him to hand in that document, and the emperor has issued an order to cut off the right hand of bishop Eusebius if he refused to deliver it. Reading the emperor's order, St. Eusebius presented his two hands to the soldier to cut them both. Hearing about it, the emperor was amazed of his courage and commended him before everybody.

His Second Exile:

When Emperor Julian the Apostate (360-363 AD) sat on the throne and brought back the exiled bishops, patriarch Meletius returned to his seat in the year 362 AD, though with a bitter soul for the following reasons:

- 5- He got to know that Julian has made his residence in Antioch.
- 6- The Arians and the pagans opposed him.
- 7- He noticed disagreements within the Church itself.

However, the patriarch did not get discourage but did his best to gain back the souls. Hearing about that, Emperor Julian exiled him again. In the year 363 AD, when Julian died, and the pious Emperor Jovian (363-364 AD) reigned, Meletius returned to his seat.

His Third Exile:

Jovian reigned for only eight months, and then he died. He was followed by the Arian Emperor Valens (364-378 AD). St. Meletius continued to work with fiercely under the guidance of St. John Chrysostom. Then, Valens came to Antioch and tried to draw the patriarch to the Arian side. But, finding out how he was steadfast in faith, he ordered that Meletius be exiled for the third time. Then, Meletius was taken out of his residence to be exiled accompanied by an officer, whom the multitudes intended to stone to death but was rescued by the patriarch.

When Valens died a horrible death and was followed by Emperor Gratian (367-383 AD), the patriarch returned to his seat. By that time, he was an older man, yet he visited his entire congregation and brought many of them

back to the Upright faith. He then held a Council in Antioch, in which he re-confirmed the Nicene Faith. It also happened that emperor Gratian asked the leader of the army Theodosius to be his partner on the throne, and delivered to him the East to rule.

The Council of Constantinople:

On becoming an emperor, Theodosius I (379-395 AD) intended to bring peace back to the Church, so he held a Council in Constantinople in 381 AD, which was attended by 150 bishops, of which St. Meletius was the most prominent. Seeing him, the emperor cried out, saying, "This is the one who put the royal robe on my shoulders in the night vision." He approached him, hugged him, and honored him. During the Council meetings, the patriarch demonstrated his full knowledge, eloquence, and piety. When he reposed during the meetings of the Council in the year 381 AD, the Fathers buried him with great honor in a ceremony led by the emperor himself.

[Fr. Butros the Jesuit: *Pastures of the Pious in the Biographies of the Righteous*;
Beirut 1880; Shabat 12]
[Butler: February 12]

MELICIUS, THE HERMIT FATHER (The martyr)

St. Melicius (Melius) was an ascetic and a striver his whole life, dwelling with his two disciples in a cave on mount Khorasan in northern east of Persia.

Raising a Dead Man:

While Fr. Melicius was passing by one of the areas, he saw someone getting hold of a monk and charging him with a murder. The old saint approached them and asked the brother monk about the cause of being so accused. When he was told that the accusation was wrongly made, he asked the accuser: "Where is the murdered man?" Then, the saint approached the corpse and asked everybody watching to pray. When he raised his hands upward, the dead man sat down. Fr. Melicius asked him: "Tell us, who killed you." The man answered: "When I entered the church to give money to the priest, he got up and killed me, and then he threw my body in the monastery of this Father. Yet, I implore you to get my money back and give it to my children." The elder saint told him: "Go back to sleep until the Lord comes and resurrect you."

With Two Sons of a Pagan King:

While Fr. Melicius was dwelling with two of his disciples at the border of Percines (Persizes), it happened that two sons of the king of Khorasan went

out in that area to hunt as they used to. They set their snares in a vast region of about 40 square miles, to catch and kill by their bows and arrows any prey which would fall into their snares. When it happened that the elder father fell into one of their snares, the two princes came and asked him: "Are you a human or a demon? He answered them, saying, "I am a sinner, who came to this place to cry on my sins and to worship and honor Jesus Christ the Son of the Living God." They mockingly told him: "There is no other God besides the Sun, Fire, and Water (which they worshipped). Now, come with us and sacrifice to them." He answered them: "These are only created by the Living God; you have lost your way, and I advise you to reconsider and recognize the True God who created everything." They sarcastically said to him: "Do you call the One condemned by the Jews and Crucified by them, the True God?" The elder saint replied: "He is the One who crucified sin and banished death by His death; He is the True God." The two angry princes got hold of his two disciples and tortured them to force them to sacrifice to the idols, and then they killed them. Afterward, those two evil princes did not kill Fr. Melicius right away, but they kept on torturing him for two weeks. Then, they set him in the middle and kept aiming their arrows at him from both the front and the back. The saint told them before he was martyred: "As long as you are committed to shedding innocent blood; I assure you that, tomorrow around that time, your mother will lose both of you and will be deprived of your love. For you will be shedding each other's blood with your arrows." They ridiculed the saint's statement and kept shooting him with their arrows until he died. On the next day, they set forth to hunt, chased a running deer with their horses, and aimed their arrows at it from opposite sides. The arrows shot by each prince ended up missing the deer and piercing the other prince, so both brothers fell dead off their horses, exactly as what the saint martyr Melicius has told them.

[The Publications of the Light: The Sayings of the Saintly Fathers; Lebanon, 1983]
[The Synaxarion: 28 Baramouda]

MELITIUS, THE DISSENTED BISHOP

Melitus (Meletius) was the bishop of Lycopolis (Assiut) during the days of the 17th Pope St. Peter the Seal of Martyrs (302-311 AD).

The Melitian Dissension:

The cause of that disagreement is still vague. The Coptic documents, the Coptic historians, and some of the western ones depended on the 20th Pope of Alexandria St. Athanasius (328-373 AD), who wrote about this issue 50 years later. St. Athanasius proclaimed that Melitus burned incense before the idols

to save his life during the persecution, and because of that pope Peter applied chastisement on him. Yet, Melitius opposed the pope's action. So, the pope held a Council of bishops in Alexandria, in which he was condemned and excommunicated. However, Melitius created a dispute; and not only continued to ordain priests, but he ordained bishops as well.

On the other hand, the followers of Melitius claimed that what he did was necessary and unavoidable because the pope was in hiding and many of the bishops of Lower Egypt were imprisoned.

Yet, the majority of historians depended upon the accounts given by St. Epiphanius of Salamis (315-403 AD). Those historians agreed to the version, which stated that during the year 304 AD, a significant number of the Egyptian bishops were cast in prison, among them were Pope Peter, the Seal of Martyrs, and Melitius who stayed imprisoned for some time. There was a significant disagreement among the two of them, concerning the situation of those who apostatized and wanted to come back and repent. Melitius adopted a very harsh stance against them, while the pope took a much milder one. Melitius insisted on expelling them indefinitely, considered them to be traitors and cowards in the face of an enemy, and that the priests among them should be replaced. The controversy between Pope Peter and Melitius was so bitter; and the pope felt that by such a stand, Melitius would block completely the way of salvation for so many. The pope, being in prison, not being able to even look at him, hanged a curtain between them in the middle of the room, declaring that he would rather lose his relationship with that bishop than to lose the salvation of thousands forever. Yet for some time, many bishops and monks in prison took the side of Melitius, and the two opponent groups refrained from talking to each other.

Then, when Melitius was released from prison, he kept ordaining priests outside his diocese. Four bishops in prison, before their martyrdom, sent to him a message, in which they wrote: "From Hytichus, Pachomius, Theodosius, and Philas, to our beloved Melitius, the fellow minister in the Lord, Greetings. In the simplicity of mind, we should like to tell you that we heard unbelievable rumors about you. Some of our visitors had informed us about some attempts, and even actions you have taken, which are contradictory to the Divine and the ecclesiastical order; which we could not first believe because of its absurdity and its recklessness. However, many of our visitors confirmed and assured us about the truth of what we have heard. That we were greatly amazed, and we felt obliged to write to you.

We cannot express our anguish and sadness, which fell upon us as a congregation and as individuals, to hear about the ordinations you have carried out in dioceses out of your jurisdiction. Anyway, we feel committed to briefly put the blame on you; taking into consideration the existence of the

laws established by the Fathers, which you know well. These laws which are based on a Divine and an ecclesiastical foundations. Those who intended to please God by their zeal and good deeds; confirmed and settled on that it is not allowed for the bishop to carry out ordinations outside his diocese. Such a law which was handed to us had its wisdom and importance:

- 1- To be sure that the behavior and personal life of those recommended for ordination are truly and carefully investigated.
- 2- To avoid any more disturbance or confusion. Since each one of us has for himself more than enough labor in his diocese. He has to seek with diligence and exalted care, to find well qualified and worthy ministers, among those he lived all his life with, and were all trained on his hands.

However, you have not taken those things into consideration; nor looked at the future, or to the doctrine of our blessed Fathers, which they received from the Lord Christ, nor to the honor of our great bishop and Father Peter in whom we all put the hope we have in the Lord Jesus Christ, nor had compassion on us who are imprisoned with all what is falling on us of pressure and tribulations.

You may probably say that what you have done was for the sake of preserving the multitudes after so many of them have already apostatized from Faith, and the flocks of believers were left with no shepherds, and they were in need of them. But, as the situation is far from that, and as the flock is not in such an urgent need, since:

- 1- Many shepherds come to visit them as guest ministers on the diocese.
- 2- Even if there is certain slothfulness toward them, it would be more befitting of us to follow the sound way in performing our duty toward them. They did not seek more ministers, and they know for sure that we are doing our mission to provide them with guidance, which makes such a claim unacceptable, for everything is already in its proper order and correctness.”

Upon receiving this message, Melitius did not write back to them, or come to meet them in their prison or go to comply with the blessed Pope Peter, but he went to Alexandria. There, the heretic Arius (256-336 AD) and Isidore discovered his ambition for the leadership of the Church of Alexandria, and they hastened to meet with him. Melitius instantly ordained two priests: one to serve in the prison and the other in the mines. He claimed for himself the right for the archbishopric task in the Church during the absence of its legal archbishop (Pope Peter).

St. Peter hastened to return to Alexandria to confront Melitius. A big controversy and dispute erupted in the Church that lasted for a long time, until the days of St. Athanasius the Apostolic, and flared more intensively during the peaceful period that followed Emperor Diocletian deserting his

throne in 305 AD. In 306 AD, the pope used his Easter (Pascal) pastoral message, to issue 14 laws to deal with the situation of the returning apostates in which he was quite compassionate with those who had fallen.

As for Melitius, despite being excommunicated by an Alexandrian Council, he kept ordaining priests and bishops. Somehow, he was supported by the confessors in the mines. When he eventually was condemned to hard labor in the mines, he was called ‘a Confessor’ too.

In the year 325 AD, according to Pope Athanasius, the number of his followers among the bishops reached 28. Yet, their influence would be of no real importance except for being a significant support for Arianism in its early stages and a source of trouble for Pope Athanasius. They also have represented a danger in that support by falsely charging the pope with several accusations in the year 331 AD to distort his image.

Melitius kept on his stubbornness even after the martyrdom of Pope Peter the last of the martyrs. Melitius also rebelled against his successor, the 18th Pope St. Achilias (311-312 AD), and went even further to complain about the 19th Pope St. Alexandros I (312-328 AD) to Emperor Constantine the Great (306-337 AD). Melitius claimed that his excuse in his complaints against Pope Alexandros and his predecessors was that they went too far in their compassion on the repentant, disregarding his crime he has previously committed when he burnt incense before the idols. He continued his rebellion until the First Ecumenical Nicene Council was held in 325 AD.

Upon looking into the charge against bishop Melitius, that Council preferred to deal with him with compassion by only denying him the right of discretion in his diocese or any other one; and they let him keep the title of bishop, as a mere honorary title.

In the 6th law of the Nicene Council’s 20 rules, they said: “**Canon 6:** Let the ancient customs in Egypt, Libya and Pentapolis prevail, that the Bishop of Alexandria have jurisdiction in all these since the like is customary for the Bishop of Rome also. Likewise, in Antioch and the other provinces, let the Churches retain their privileges. And this is to be universally understood, that if anyone be made bishop without the consent of the Metropolitan (the bishop of the Capital), the great Synod has declared that such a man ought not to be a bishop.” The Council, as well, decided that the bishops ordained by Melitius were not to be counted among the clergy unless the Pope of Alexandria would honor their bishopric. The date of Melitius death is unknown, but probably it was before 332 AD.

[Fr. Tadros Y. Malaty: *The Coptic Orthodox Church: A Church of Knowledge and Theology*]

[*The Coptic Encyclopedia: Melitius*, by Janet Timbie; p. 1585]

MELITO, BISHOP OF SARDIS, ST.

St. Melito was the bishop of Sardis near Smyrna in western Anatolia in Asia Minor. He lived during the 2nd century AD and wrote his most famous work, an “*Apology for Christianity*” addressed to Emperor Marcus Aurelius (161-180 AD). St. Melito also had other theological and ethical writings, which the historian Eusebius (265-340 AD) and St. Jerome (347-420 AD) quoted some of their titles and the material included in them though only very little of his work survived. According to Tertullian (155-240 AD), many of the faithful used to consider St. Melito to be one of the prophets. He was held at a high regard at his time and was remembered for his work on developing the first Old Testament Canon. Although his name was mentioned in many old Synaxarions, his biography was not well-known. Most probably, however, he reposed around the year 180 AD.

[Butler: April 1]

MENAS, HERMOGENES & EUGRAPHIUS (The martyrs)

St. Menas was a philosopher and a senator of Alexandria. He was called ‘The One with the Sweet Voice.’ He was sent by the pagan Emperor Galerius (305-311 AD) to Alexandria to use his knowledge and eloquence to calm down the disturbance, which happened there at the time. Having accomplished his mission, he proclaimed his Christian faith. Along with his assistant Eugraphius, they converted so many to Christianity.

The emperor sent the judge Hermogenes to Alexandria to deal with Menas. On his way, he saw in a dream three luminous persons who assured him that he would gain a significant advantage by his trip. Upon reaching Alexandria, Hermogenes summoned the accused to the court of justice and asked him about what he believed in. Menas replied with his sweet voice and gave a speech before the court, which lasted for 4 hours and enjoyed by all the audience. However, the judge condemned him to have his eyes plucked out, his tongue cut off, and the soles of his feet to be scrapped away. In that condition, he was taken back to prison. Yet, on the next day, he stood before the court sound and free of any wound, which made judge Hermogenes himself and many others with him believe in Christ.

Then, when Emperor Galerius gave his orders to increase the intensity of torture on all of them, including Menas assistant Eugraphius, the Lord kept healing them of their wounds. Finally, the heads of the three of them were cut off by the sword, and they received the crowns of martyrdom.

[Baring-Gould: December 10]

MENASSA YUHANNA, THE PRIEST

His Prominence and Piety:

Fr. Menassa Yuhanna was born in the year 1899 to pious Christian parents in the village of Hur in the district of Mallawi in the governorate of El-Minya in Upper Egypt. His father died while the boy was still in his childhood. His mother raised him in a Godly manner, and he absorbed from her the piety, wisdom, and compassion on the poor and the needy. His jealousy on the advancement of the church motivated him to dedicate his life to serve from within. So, he joined the church's Clerical School while he was still sixteen years of age, and he excelled in his study that once he graduated, he was assigned to give the sermons in the Coptic Church of Mallawi. There, he was initially received with apprehension as being a twenty years old young man. Still, soon, the congregation found in him a pious and capable sermon-giver, whom everybody much loved. Eventually, he was ordained as a priest in Mallawi in January 1925 based on the unanimous recommendation of its people. It was a great day, and the whole inhabitants of the city celebrated it.

Being a diligent reader, Fr. Menassa Yuhanna was able to absorb hundreds of books during his young age. Although his life on earth was short, yet he was so productive and provided so many services, even the elders could not match. He was a great ecclesiastical preacher and the greatest sermon-giver in the district of Mallawi in Upper Egypt during his days.

He authored fifteen books on Spiritual, Theological and Dogmatic subjects. He also wrote about the Holy Bible and the history of the church, in addition to writing so many essays in the newspapers and magazines. He was also a prominent figure during the Egyptian National Revolution in 1919, to be called the great orator of Mallawi.

In his short life, he went through various trials, all of which he endured with perseverance and thanksgiving. Whenever he was given a child, death took him away from him. He was also tried in his health, and his mother passed away in the year 1928, on whom his grief was enormous.

Finally, Fr. Menassa Yuhanna got to know the day of his early departure, and he told those around him on the 16th of May 1930: "I shall die tonight. Pray over me in Mallawi, but bury me in Hur." Then, he died that same night. He was so beloved, even by the non-Orthodox, that everybody mourned him deeply. Fr. Menassa Yuhanna was loved by the Muslims as well, that they competed on carrying his casket during his funeral.

[Patriotism of the Coptic Church and its History, p. 402]

MENODORA, METRODORA & NYMPHODORA ***(The martyrs)***

They were three orphan sisters who lived a life of seclusion, with works of mercy and love, in Bithynia. In the days of the persecution against the Christians stirred up by Emperors Diocletian and Maximian (284-305 AD), they were arrested and brought before Fronto, the governor of the province. Fronto was attracted to their beauty and simplicity and suggested to defend them and release them if they agree to worship his gods. The virgin saints rejected his request, preferring death instead. Failing to make them change their minds, the governor ordered to beat their eldest sister Menodora so violently to death to bring fear to her other two sisters. Yet, even the scene of her torn off corpse, which they left to rot in the intense heat of the sun, did not terrify them. Then Metrodora said to the governor: "Being three branches of the same blessed tree, we shall never bring shame to our good roots by fulfilling your request." So, she was tortured by fire after being violently beaten; then, she was beheaded. Nymphodora, the youngest, was also martyred as a result of her severe beating by her tormentors. They all were martyred in the year 304 AD.

[Butler: September 10]

MERCURY (The martyr)

This saint was a soldier of Scythian origin (in Persia), who so bravely fought against the Barbarians, to earn the admiration of Roman Emperor Decius (249-251 AD). Yet, because he was a Christian and refused to offer sacrifices before the goddess Artemis, he was severely tortured among the appearances of angels to encourage him. Then, he was moved to his home town in Cappadocia and was executed in Caesarea.

The Western church celebrates him on the 25th of November.

[The Penguin Dictionary of Saints, p. 236]

MEROB (The martyr)

The lady St. Merob was the wife of a pious man in Alexandria during the days of Emperor Decius (249-251 AD), who intended to bring an utter end to Christianity and the memory of martyred Christians by destroying their bodies. She bravely used to go to prison in the darkness of the night, pay generous bribes to the guards, to let her take the relics and bodies of the martyrs. Then, she used to keep them as precious jewels.

On hearing about what she was doing, the tyrant emperor ordered to put her under arrest and to bring her to trial. The judge charged her with three crimes, all of which were punishable by death:

- 3- Believing in Christianity as a forbidden religion.
- 4- Giving bribes to the guards over the bodies of the martyrs.
- 5- Opposing the civil authorities.

The saint did not show any fear and did not deny her actions, but bravely proclaimed her faith in the Lord Jesus Christ and her care for the bodies of the holy martyrs. The judge condemned St. Merob to be scourged until death. Her hands and feet were tied with ropes to a post erected for this purpose. Then, she was scourged so violently that her flesh and blood scattered all over the place. All that was happening while she was praying to God, her Savior, in whose Hands she soon delivered her soul.

MESROP, THE BISHOP, ST.

The biography of the patriarch/catholicos Isaac the Great (Sahak of Armenia: 354-439 AD) mentions his effort to unite the Armenian people and to set the foundations for the Armenian language. It also states that he was helped in such an endeavor by St. Mesrop Mashtots, who was a government officer at the time.

Constructing a New Armenian Alphabet:

When Armenia lost its independence in 387 AD, it was partitioned into two sections, one small part was ruled by the Roman Empire and the larger one by Persia. During that time, Mesrop retreated into a life of seclusion. Later on, he became a priest and continued his studies of the Greek, Persian, and Syriac languages; then he became a preacher among his people. However, he experienced great difficulty in instructing the people, for the Armenians had no alphabet of their own; instead, they were using a combination between Greek, Persian, and Syriac scripts to express the phonetics of their speech. However, none of these three languages was well suited for representing the many complex sounds of their native Armenian tongue. Again, the Holy Scriptures and the Liturgy, being written in Syriac, were, to no small extent, incomprehensible to the believers. Hence there was a constant need for translators and interpreters to explain the Word of God to the people. So, with the counsel of St. Isaac the Great, St. Mesrop Mashtots took upon himself to construct for the first time a new Armenian alphabet. He managed to do that in 405 AD in a reasonably short time with the help of some other scholars, using the small letters in the Greek Alphabet and adding few new ones.

After several years, the first Armenian version of the Holy Bible was translated from the Syriac language. It was said that St. Mesrop was the one who brought the New Testament and the Book of Proverbs to the Armenian. These translations were revised in Edessa (El-Roḥa) by two of his disciples. Then, a final revision was made by comparing them to the Septuagint version of the Old Testament. Also, they managed to translate the Holy Liturgies into the Armenian language.

St. Mesrop preached and taught in Armenia and Georgia, established schools, and set another alphabet for Georgia, then he returned to his hometown. There, he created a particular school by the encouragement of St. Isaac, and he supervised its operation. In this school, he translated so many books from the Greek and the Syriac languages to the Armenian language with the help and guidance of so many other saints. St. Mesrop reposed when he was eighty years old, on the 17th (19th) of February 441 AD.

[Butler: February 17 (19)]

METHODIUS, BISHOP OF OLYMPUS (The martyr)

The Western Church celebrates st. Methodius (Eubilis) on the 20th of June and on the 18th of September. St. Methodius became the bishop of Olympus in Lycia in the southern part of Asia Minor, then became the bishop of Patara. He has martyred in the year 311 AD in Chalcis in Greece. He was forgotten or disregarded by the historian Eusebius of Caesarea, probably because he opposed Origen. This saint was not the same as Methodius, the bishop of Petaris in Syria or the bishop of Phoenicia, who was martyred in Syria.

His Culture and Views:

St. Methodius seemed to have read Plato's works and admired his dialogue style since he authored his essays using the same method. He opposed Origen's views about the prior existence of the souls, the resurrection of the bodies with the spirit, and that the body is a prison for the soul.

His Martyrdom:

According to St. Jerome, St. Methodius received the crown of martyrdom during the last days of the persecution stirred up by Emperor Diocletian (284-305 AD). However, others insisted that he was martyred at the time of Emperors Decius (249-251 AD) and Valerian (253-260 AD) in Chalcis in Greece. Yet, other scholars dismiss the idea of St. Methodius early martyrdom, on account of that he was briefly mentioned by Eusebius of Caesarea (265-339 AD), as being one of his contemporaries.

His Writings:

St. Methodius drew his fame from the many articles he wrote, among which were:

1. ‘On Virginity’ (*Symposion e peri hagneias*): It is a dialogue about commending the virginity. This dialogue ended with a long hymn sung by Thekla, and its verses were arranged in alphabetical order. It is considered as one of the earliest Christian hymns. He quoted from Psalm forty-five, saying: “The bride will sit at the right hand of Christ, adorned with gold.” This work is his only writing, which has been left complete. It revealed his admiration of Plato in following his dialogue style, from which he quoted not only some of its verses but also the idea of the work as a whole. Plato, in his work, commended love, while Methodius commended glories of virginity.

2. ‘On the Resurrection’ (*Aglaophon e pen tes anastaseos*): This article was lost, but many quotes from it remained in the work of Epiphanius of Salamis (315-403 AD) [Against the Heresies: 64], Photius of Constantinople (858-886 AD) [Codice 234] and John of Damascus (675-749 AD) [On Holy Images: Sermon 2]. In this work too, Methodius followed the Platonic dialogue style to refute Origen and his followers, who denied the resurrection of the material body, and believe that it was enough to say that what would resurrect is an adorned and glorified form of that body. In heaven, our bodies will be spiritual, and according to St. Paul the Apostle: “*It is sown a natural body, it is raised a spiritual body*” (1 Corin. 15:44), and, “*Flesh and blood cannot inherit the kingdom of God; nor does corruption inherit incorruption*” (1 Corin. 15:50). According to them, the man initially was in Paradise, namely in the 3rd heaven (2 Corin. 12), in a spiritual body, then having fallen, he was brought down to earth, where God provided him with a leather cover, namely, he got the material body as a punishment. Such a substantial body is the source of temptations and trials of the soul, and without it, the soul could not sin. Then, when we resurrect, we would be where there is no place for crime, we would be like angels, free from the body, which represents a burden on the soul. St. Methodius responded to that in his dialogue by saying that the body is a tool in the hand of the soul to use for doing good or doing evil. When the Holy Bible says that we shall be like the angels of God, this did not mean that we shall be without bodies, but we shall be like the angels in their incorruptible and unchangeable nature.

He also said that by death, God did not plan to change us from what He intended for us when He created us. He is like a sculptor who would re-knead his hand-work when he finds it getting out of shape. He would re-knead it in such a way to conform to what he had for it in his mind originally. In the same manner by death, God would transform us to be free from the

corruption of sin.

It was a bold dialogue in the house of a physician by the name Aglaophon in Patara. In that dialogue, Methodius confirmed the resurrection of the body, being a partner of the soul in her strife, to share in her glory, and he indicated that it was not another spiritual body, but he mentioned that this resurrected body would enjoy a heavenly renewal. He said about Christ: “He became a True Body and died a True Death, and not just in appearance, to show that He was the First of those who resurrected from death, to turn what is earthly to heavenly, and what is mortal to immortal.”

Methodius said that at the beginning, the man was immortal, body and soul, that death and the separation of the soul from the collection were the results of the envy of Satan, and that the goal of Christ's Redemption was to rejoin what was separated by Satan.

3. St. Jerome (347-420 AD) mentioned in his book: ‘Of Illustrious Men’ (sec 83), and in his two Letters 48 and 70: that Methodius argued very well in refuting Porphyry's fifteen letters which were written against the Christians.

4. St. Jerome also mentioned another work for Methodius. It is called ‘The Diviner,’ which was addressed against Origen, although it is now lost. It has the same title used by Ostadtheos in his book; he wrote to refute Origen, who believed that the soul of Samuel the Prophet was under the control of the devil and that it was recalled by the diviner using sorcery. The response of Methodius was very different from that of Ostadtheos, in which Ostadtheos believed that the soul of Samuel was indeed called.

5. Socrates [The Ecclesiastical History 6:13] mentioned another work by Methodius, called ‘Xeno,’ which, according to some, was the same work referred to by Photius.

6. ‘On the Created Objects’: Some quotations from this work were kept by Photius, in which he refuted the Origen teachings, which called the eternity of the world. This teaching assumed that if God is eternal, then He was always the Almighty Creator, and at no time, He was not the Creator, and, since there is no Creator without creation, therefore, they concluded that there was creation since eternity. This Methodius work, too, came in the form of dialogue that responded to all those wrong assumptions.

7. ‘On the Freedom of Will’: A discussion to confirm that the will of man is free and responsible for his actions. It was most probably addressed against the followers of Valentinus and the Gnostics.

8. Lost works: Such as ‘On the Martyrs,’ ‘Interpretation of the Book of Genesis,’ and ‘Interpretation of the Song of Songs.’

Of His Words:

- The church grows daily in stature and beauty through her cooperation and unity with the Logos, who descends to us to this very day and keep on descending in the commemoration of His passion.
- No one should be lazy in welcoming the King; otherwise, he would be deprived of the beauty of the participation in the wedding. I wish no one among us would welcome Him with an ugly face, lest he would be condemned as an evildoer who refrained from receiving the King. Let us come to Him with gladness, receive Him with joy, and hold fast to our banquet with faithfulness.
- I keep my soul pure for You, O Bridegroom. I would carry for You a lighted lamp and march to receive You.

[Dr. A. Rustom: *The Church Fathers in the First Three Centuries*
[H. Wace & W. Piercy: *A Dictionary of Early Christian Biography*, 1999]

METROPHANES, THE BISHOP, ST.

St. Metrophanes was most probably the first bishop of Byzantium (became Constantinople later on), in the days of Emperor Constantine the Great (306-337 AD). This diocese was previously affiliated with the bishopric of Heraclea in Asia Minor. He was so well known within the church of the East for his holiness that in a little while after the death of Emperor Constantine, a church was built in his name, and when it turned into ruins in the 6th century AD, it was reconstructed by Emperor Justinian I (527-565 AD).

According to the Greek tradition, Metrophanes was the son of Dometius, the brother of Emperor Probus. Dometius converted to Christianity, moved to Byzantium, where he had a close friendship with its bishop Titus. After the repose of Titus, Dometius was ordained as a bishop in his place. Then, after the death of Dometius, he was succeeded by his two sons: Probus, who sat on the throne for twelve years, then followed by Metophanes. It seems that Emperor Constantine has chosen Byzantium to become his new capital for two reasons: First, its designate location and second, because of the impressive holy life of its bishop Dometius.

When the First Ecumenical Nicene Council was held in the year 325 AD, St. Metophanes was not able to attend because of the frailty of his advanced age, so he sent his secretary Alexander to represent him in the Council. However, Emperor Constantine requested from the attendee bishops to return after the Council with him to Byzantium to see Metrophanes, the aged

bishop, whom he called his father, and to bless by their presence his new city which he had recently founded.

The bishops came to Byzantium, and they met both the emperor and bishop Metrophanes. The emperor then adjured the aged bishop to name his successor. Metrophanes replied with a smiling countenance that he was told three days ago in a dream, that his end would come after ten days, and he accordingly named Alexander of Byzantium his successor, and the boy Paul to be the successor of Alexander. Then, Metrophanes turned to the bishop of Alexandria (the 19th Pope Alexandros I: 312-328 AD): “You too, my brother,” he said, “shall have a good successor.” Taking the young deacon Athanasius by the hand, “Behold,” said he: “the great champion of Christ! Many conflicts will he sustain in the company not only with my successor Alexander but even with my next successor Paul.”

With these words, he laid his pall on the Altar for his secretary Alexander to take, and in seven days, on June 4th he expired at his 117 years of age. Such, according to the Byzantine tradition, was the inauguration of the next two significant events of Eastern ecclesiastical history:

- 1- The foundation of the city and patriarchate of Constantinople.
- 2- The consecration of Athanasius to be the champion of the faith against the world.

[Baring-Gould, *The Lives of the Saints*, Vol. 6 (June), London 1897, pp. 33-4]

MEZRICUS, THE PRIEST

St. Mezricus was such a giving person that he used to go by night to the poor and the needy to share with them whatever the Lord has given him. He also used to visit the prisons to exhort the prisoners to repent, to the hospitals to strengthen the sick in their sufferings, to the rich to urge them to give and do good and to those in controversy to reconcile them. For these reasons, Fr. Mezricus's church was always full of the poor and the needy.

One night, it happened next to the church, that a woman was lying on the curb screaming, passing through the intense pain of labor in the cold winter night with no one to help her. The saint did not hesitate to cut his prayers to see what she needed. He stayed beside her, and when he found nobody else to help her give birth to her baby, he did not shy out from carrying out the task of a midwife himself.

St. Mezricus was always clothed with cheap valueless clothing and never had any worries about his material matters. Once, when he found nothing on him to give, he sold his Holy Bible and gave the proceeds away. He kept on practicing the deeds of virtue until he reposed in the year 420 AD, fulfilling

the blessed verse: *"I was hungry, and you gave Me food; I was thirsty, and you gave Me drink;... I was naked, and you clothed Me"* (Matt. 25:35-36).

[Paradise of the Saints, p. 54]

MICHAEL I, The 46th POPE OF ALEXANDRIA

Refer to 'Khael I, The 46th Pope of Alexandria' under the letter 'K.'

MICHAEL II, The 53rd POPE OF ALEXANDRIA

Refer to 'Khael II, The 53rd Pope of Alexandria' under the letter 'K.'

MICHAEL III, The 56th POPE OF ALEXANDRIA

Refer to 'Khael III, The 56th Pope of Alexandria' under the letter 'K.'

MICHAEL IV, The 68th POPE OF ALEXANDRIA

Pope Khael IV (1092-1102), lived as a locked-in monk, in a cell in a town called Singar¹. Due to his piety, the sweet fragrance of this monk reached the assembled bishops in Cairo, who were praying for God's guidance to select for them a worthy father who could carry the responsibility of the See of St. Mark after the departure of Pope Cyril II (1078-1092 AD). So, it happened that someone familiar with the monk Michael came to the assembly and suggested him to the bishops. The bishops welcomed the idea, and they were so happy to find the man they were looking for.

When they sent a delegation to inform him about their choice and requesting his presence, Michael excused himself to those who came confirming that he was not worthy of such a great honor, but when he was told that they would carry him by force, he consented to go along with them to Alexandria. There, he was ordained in the year 1092 AD. Then, the new pope headed to the monastery of Abba Macarius to seek the Divine help for his new assignment, then he returned to Cairo and used the church of the Archangel Michael on a Nile island, as his papal residence.

His Good Relationship with the Statesmen:

The peace dwelt on the land during the rule of the Fatimid vizier of Egypt Al-Afdal Shahenshah ibn Badr al-Din al-Jamali (1066-1121 AD), under the 8th Fatimid caliph Al-Mustansir bi-Allah (1036-1094 AD). The conditions seemed peaceful for the new pope to carry out his pastoral ministry. In the meantime, Jerusalem was under the rule of a Coptic individual by the name of Mansur Al-Tilbani, who has gotten favor in the sight of the State.

¹ The town of 'Singar' was later on submerged and swallowed by the lake 'El-Burullus.'

When the Nile flood happened to be so low that disturbed the government in Egypt, the authorities sought from the pope to go to Ethiopia to find some ways to facilitate the passage of the Nile water to Egypt. His mission came with good news, and the relationship between Egypt and Ethiopia was improved through the effort of this pope. This pope also was the first Alexandrian pope to visit Ethiopia. However, the relationship between the two churches was already established since the days of the 20th pope St. Athanasius the Apostolic (328-373 AD). Pope Michael IV ordained for the Ethiopian church a new metropolitan, then another one after him, when the first one proved unworthy.

Then, when the plague spread over Egypt, the pope traveled wandering among his people to console them, encourage them, and to pray on their behalf, until he got inflicted by the plague and reposed in the year 1102 AD. This happened during the days of the 10th Fatimid caliph Al-Aamer bi-Ahkam Allah ibn al-Mustaali (1101-1130 AD).

[Revealing the Secrets of the History of the Righteous Patriarchs, Part 3, p. 21]

MICHAEL V, The 71st POPE OF ALEXANDRIA

Pope Michael V (1145-1146 AD) was one of the monks of St. Macarius monastery in the wilderness of the Scetis. He was a simple man, yet was characterized by reverence, sanctity, and chastity. Even though he was neither a scholar nor even a devoted reader, yet he was committed to the monastic law without being verse in either the Coptic or Arabic languages.

An Altar lot was made before the ordination. The candidates included him and two others. For the lot, they added a 4th paper written on it: 'The Lord Jesus Christ, the Good Shepherd.' All the four documents were placed on the Altar, then the Holy Liturgy was held for three consecutive days. Afterward, a child picked one of those papers, which happened to carry the name of Michael. All accepted him for having ethical conduct.

After the lot, in the Hanging Church in Cairo, the bishops ordained him as a deacon, then as a priest, and on the third day, they ordained him as a Hegomen. Then, he was ordained as a patriarch in Alexandria in the year 1145 AD. According to 'The History of the Patriarchs,' they taught him after a great effort, how to pray the Liturgy of St. Basil.

His papacy, even though very short, yet it was a good one. During his short papacy, no one apostatized from Christianity. However, he managed to ordain eight bishops: including one on Shubra el-Kheima, Shubra Damanhur, Meniat-Bani-Khasib, Akhmim, and El-Baliana.

He sat on the Seat for only eight months and four days: of which three

months he was in good health, and the rest of the time he was ill. He spent his illness time in the monastery of Abu Maqar, and he reposed in the year 1146.

[The Patriotism of the Coptic Church, and its History, p. 147]

MICHAEL VI, The 92nd POPE OF ALEXANDRIA

This pope followed the 91st Pope Gabriel VI (1466-1474 AD) on the St. Mark Seat. He was from Samallot (or of Sunbat). He was ordained as a patriarch on the 3rd of Amshir 1193 AM (1477-1478 AD), in the days of the Circassian Mamluk Sultan Al-Ashraf Abu el-Nasr Qaitbay al-Zaheri (1468-1496 AD). He sat on the papal seat for only one year and three days, after which the position remained vacant for two years, two months, and seven days. In his days, the relationship between the Egyptian and the Ethiopian churches started to deteriorate as a result of the stressed relationship between the sultan of Egypt and the kings of Ethiopia.

[The Story of the Coptic Church, VI p. 519]

MICHAEL, BISHOP OF TANIS

He was a deacon named Abu Ĥabib Michael el-Damanhury. He was a friend of deacon Mawhoub ibn Mansur. Before Abu Ĥabib Michael was ordained as a bishop of Tanis,¹ the two deacons cooperated and collected the biographies of our fathers, the patriarchs, the popes of Alexandria.

Abu Ĥabib Michael lived in the Fatimid era, and he became a monk in St. Macarius Monastery in the Scetis. Through his uncle Mina, who was an employee in the government, he got acquainted with deacon Boquerra el-Rashidi, the Cross-Bearer, and they became close friends. In the monastery, he was ordained as a deacon, and he occupied himself with documenting the biographies of the popes of the Coptic Church. So, he isolated himself by living in seclusion in the monastery of Abba Yēh̄nis Kama, as a guest of the monk Pisos. He worked day and night and was able after difficult effort to gather and write down the biographies of ten popes (from the 56th to the 66th popes). He also was helped by Abba Severus, bishop of El-Ashmonein, when he was working on writing the history of the popes. Bishop Severus translated the biographies from Coptic to the Arabic language.

The Scribe of the Pope Ibram ibn Zarāa:

Abu Ĥabib Michael was chosen by the 62nd Pope of Alexandria, Abba

¹ 'Tanis' is an ancient Egyptian city, long destroyed, located on an island in the lake 'Manzala.'

Abraham ibn Zarâa (975-978 AD), to be his scribe. He helped in writing the Synodica (The message of fellowship in faith), which the pope of Alexandria sent to the patriarch of Antioch, as it was the custom at that time. Abu Hâbib participated in writing that Synodica under five consecutive popes.

Ordained as a Bishop:

In appreciation for his great efforts, the 66th Pope Abba Christodolus (1046-1077 AD), ordained the deacon monk Abu Hâbib Michael as a bishop on Tanis by the name of Abba Michael.

Besides his responsibilities as a bishop, he continued to be tasked as the writer of the Synodica. Pope Christodolus asked him to deliver it to the patriarch of Antioch, in the company of Abba Gabriel, the bishop of Sa el-Hagar.

His Departure:

It seems that the departure of this active bishop took place near the end of the papacy of Pope Christodolus. In this way, Abba Michael was contemporary to six popes, and he became bishop only with the last of them.

[The Patriotism of the Coptic Church and its History, p. 126]

MICHAEL EL-BEËHERI, THE HEGOMEN

During the year 1963, in the first Holy Synod meeting attended by Abba Shenouda, the bishop of education (became Pope Shenouda III in 1971), it was suggested that the names of Abba Abram Bishop of El-Fayyum and Abba Serabamon (Abu-Tarâa) Bishop of El-Menoufyia be added to the list of saints of the Coptic Church. Then, one of the members of the Synod suggested adding, as well, the name of Hegomen Michael el-Beheri (a contemporary of Abba Abram). The Holy Synod unanimously approved the addition of the names of all three of them, because they were all beyond any questions, and so it became official.

Hegomen Michael el-Beheri was the disciple of Abba Abram. He was born in the year 1848 in the village Ashnin el-Nasarah, in the district of Maghagha in El-Menya governorate. His parents were pious, virtuous Christians, filled with the grace of God, lovers of the poor, and respected by all the people around them. On reaching twelve years of age, his father passed away, then his mother four years later.

Later on, the saint narrated about his early days saying: "After the repose of my father, some relatives took me away to a neighbor's house, for fear of the effect of mourning on my health. While I sat in my seclusion on the roof

of that house, I saw my father ascending to heaven, surrounded by angels of light. When I recognized him and called him: 'Father, father,' an angel responded to me: 'Seek to have a similar departure,' and he disappeared."

His Monastic Life:

One of the monks, called Hegomen Tawadros el-Muḥarraqi used to visit the village of Ashnin. The young man Michael loved to spend time listening to Fr. Tawadros and learning from him much about the saints and the monastic life as an elevated form of experience in the Lord. So, the young Michael started to apply what he learned and kept training under the guidance of his father of confession, that he tasted the monastic life in his private room.

On reaching twenty years of age, he became a monk in the monastery of the Virgin St. Mary (El-Muḥarraq), when Hegomen Boules el-Delgawi (St. Abba Abram) was its Abbot. The young monk followed the Abbot's steps and was adorned with so many virtues, particularly humility and love. Self-trained on the art of binding books, he bound all the old books in the monastery's library, as well as those of the visitors to the monastery, and whatever money he was given, he distributed on the poor and the needy. Binding the books motivated him to read them, and to encourage the other monks to do so too.

The saint became a disciple of the expert old monk Hegomen Salib el-Āalwani, so he gained a broad knowledge and enjoyed the training for his spiritual growth. Then, in Toba 1591 AM (1874 AD), his mentor sought from the monastery's Abbot to ordain him as a priest. So, it was done through Abba Athanasius, the bishop of Sanbo, Dayrut, and Qanam.

His Virtues:

Besides being a virtuous teacher, he was a man of miracles, on whose hands many got the grace of being healed from sicknesses, which the temporal medicine could not. He was characterized by his love of silence and retreated away from the noise, sleeping at night only for a little while, and spending the rest watching and singing praises.

God granted him authority over the wild beasts, evil spirits, and diviners. He passed through many temptations by the demons that he could overcome them by making the sign of the Cross in his complete humility. He kept wrestling against them by fasting and praying until he lost his eyesight. Yet, even after being ordained as a Hegomen, he kept on humbly cleaning the churches of the monastery and caring for the garden inside, of which two palm trees are still there on the western side, on the way leading to the ancient church in El-Muḥarraq Monastery, known as 'The Palm trees of our

father St. Michael el-Beheri.’

Abbot Boules El-Delgawi was Exiled:

In the year 1870, a violent, angry wave blew against the monastery's Abbot Hegomen Boules el-Delgawi (Abba Abram), and he was expelled, not only from being the Abbot of the monastery but from the monastery itself. He left the monastery, along with his disciples, who requested from their mentor to get Hegomen Michael el-Beheri to go with them. Hegomen Boules el-Delgawi declined their request and told them: “Let him stay in this monastery and do not deprive its community of the presence of such a man of God, lest the wrath of God might dwell on them. Let him stay, for this will give us comfort, as would be a blessing to that place.”

St. Michael was unfortunate to be separated from his beloved father and Abbot. He also had to bear so many anguishes, and the other monks attempted to force him out of the monastery. He endured everything with silence and perseverance, in observance of the Divine commandments. As an example, having been occupied with making the bread in the monastery's bakery, an unknown person went into his cell and took all his clothes and possessions away. On coming back to his cell with his wet gown covered with dough, he found nothing else to wear. He reported it to the new Abbot, expecting to be given another dress to wear. However, the Abbot rebuked him for insulting the monks by accusing them of theft, although he accused no one. His spiritual father Hegomen Salib el-Āalwani had to give him an old gown, which he put on all through the winter, not having another one to replace it while being washed. The saint never lost his peace or his inner joy, amid all those tribulations. Instead, they motivated him to more spiritual strife to support many others.

Losing his Eyesight:

Even though he lost his eyesight, along with most of his hearing ability and his physical strength was fading, yet he kept on going to the church to attend the daily holy liturgy. When one of his disciples, who used to help him go to the church, said to him: “Father, you should sit in your cell and pray. Not able to see or to hear, what is the use of going to the church?” He answered him, saying: “My son! When I go to the church, I smell the fragrance of the incense, which gives me so much comfort, that I could see what the eyes have not seen, and hear what the ears have not heard.”

His Love for the Poor and His Ascetics:

St. Michael had almost nothing in his cell, for he was trained on the hand of his mentor Abba Abram to give everything in his hands to the little

brothers of Jesus. In the monastery, they called him: 'The man of mercy and the father of the needy.' Since he entered the monastery, he never ate meat. He used to fast until sunset and did not give his body any rest in sleeping, eating, or drinking. He loved to work, bound his work, and asceticism to the life of prayer, to pray every day the whole book of psalms.

His Friendship with the Wild Beasts:

When he was fifteen years old, he once went together with some of his friends to work on the construction of roads and bridges. Going back home at night, they passed through a way known to have many hyenas. Once, it happened that all of a sudden, two hyenas appeared. On seeing how his friends were terrified, St. Michael said to them: "Do not be afraid, for they are nothing but two domesticated dogs." They saw the two hyenas approaching the saint, who played with them as though with real domesticated dogs. Close to the village, the actual dogs, smelling the scent of the hyenas, started to bark so loudly that disturbed the inhabitants of the village and thinking that thieves have come to rob their village, they went out of their homes carrying their weapons, to be surprised to see that scene, and to glorify God who worked through His saints.

The saint was used, whenever someone entered into his cell, to say: "Go your way, O blessed one!" When one of his disciples insisted on knowing the secret behind that phrase and forcefully said to the saint: "In the name of your fatherhood, tell me who is that blessed one? Is it one of the unseen hermits who come to sit with you or to serve you?" The saint cried and said: "O how miserable I am, but I shall show it to you." He called up, saying, "Come, O blessed one," and he addressed his disciple, saying: "Do not be afraid, my son!" Then, a massive serpent about seven feet in length came out from behind the cupboard, to which the saint pointed, saying: "Here is my friend, which shares my food, and on the whose twisted body, I find rest to sleep." Then he said to the serpent: "Now, go your way, O blessed one," and the snake crawled back to its place. After the repose of the saint, the serpent abandoned the cell, went sad for its friend, and died from grief. Finally, after a life full of strife, he reposed on the 23rd of February 1922, during the second week of the Great Lent.

Of his Sayings:

- * Do you want the comfort of mind, then observe the conditions of love: love of God and love of your neighbor.
- * Abide in God, and He will grant you all.
- * Getting used to doing good, will let you inherit the characteristics of righteousness and piety.

MICHAEL EL-TUCHI, THE HEGOMEN (The martyr)

Ordained as a Priest:

This saint was born to pious parents in the village of Tuch el-Nassarrah in El-Menufyya governorate during the 2nd half of the 15th century AD. He was given the name of Michael. When he grew up, he started to study the hymns, the praise, the Coptic language, the Holy Bible, and the other ecclesiastical knowledge. The bishop ordained him as a deacon while he was eight years old. On reaching the age of maturity, he got married. Eventually, he was ordained as a priest, then as a Hegomen on St. George Church in his home town.

His Martyrdom:

Then, it happened when he was about fifty years of age, that he was traveling to Cairo, and some evil people who hated the Christians accused him falsely of insulting them with terribly wrong words. They dragged the saint to the authorities, and the judge ordered his arrest. When they brought him chained later on before the judge, he told him that whatever those evil men had claimed was all made up and false. However, those wicked men brought forth false witnesses to confirm their claims, and the judge delivered him back to jail. There, the jail-keeper dug up for him a bit in the ground where he crucified him upside down all day long. On the next day, his accusers came back and with them some others who were eviler than them. They all stood before the judge to accuse him with terrible things he never said, which the saint kept denying with a healthy heart and courage, confirming his argument with verses from the Holy Bible. Failing to nail him to any accusation, they took the saint to a higher judge, who had no fear of God. The more senior judge advised him to deny the religion of his fathers to set him free. With his sound faith, the saint firmly refused to listen, despite their threats and promises.

Then, they dragged him along the streets of the city, until they reached a place called Ḥaret el-Magharbah while continuing their attempts to make him deny his faith. The saint kept on crying out: "This is my wedding day, my day of Joy." The mob ignited a great fire, and they cast him into it. He made the sign of the Cross on himself, and the fire did not harm him. The fire only burned the ropes by which he was tied. In the meantime, the saint saw the Virgin St. Mary coming to him accompanied by four angels, and she brought him out unharmed. Someone among the mob was provoked to anger and

struck the saint on his head with a big ax, then push him back into the fire. There, he delivered his pure soul. His martyrdom was on Sunday the 30th of Kiahk 1240 AM (27th of December 1524 AD). The head of this martyr is now kept in the church of the Virgin St. Mary at Haret el-Rum in Cairo. It is still in a good uncorrupted condition, as testified by the priest of the church who last examined it on the 14th of December 1981.

[St. Michael EL-Tuchi: The Priest and Martyr, published by Fr. Antonius Guirgis]

MICHAEL GUIRGIS, MUĀALLEM

Even though his father occupied a modest position in the government, which reflected the mild conditions of the family in which Michael was raised, yet the 112th Pope Cyril V (1874-1927), so cared for that family that he sometimes came to spend the night in their house. Michael was born on the 14th of September 1873, and once he reached the third year of his age, he was inflicted with bad trachoma, which led to the loss of his eyesight. Yet this painful calamity did not break the father down. The father sent his blind son to join the preschool of the Cantor muāallem Abu el-Saād in El-Azbakieh. The young Michael spent two years there (1879-1881), in which he studied the psalms, the praise, and the Coptic language. Then, his father brought him to join the high Coptic School for the next four years.

Cantor and Teacher of Hymns in the Clerical College:

Afterward, the blind boy managed somehow to join Al-Azhar for six years (1885-1891), where he mastered the Arabic literature. During the 2nd year of his study in Al-Azhar, Pope Cyril V noticed how that boy was gifted with a sweet voice and has mastered all that he was taught of the rituals and hymns. So, the pope ordained him as a deacon by himself. Then, once he finished his studies in Al-Azhar, the pope appointed him as the Cantor of St. Mark Cathedral. Later on, in appreciation of his work and his love for the church, he also appointed him in November 1893 to be a teacher of hymns in the Clerical College, which the pope opened a year earlier. After the young man joined the Clerical College, he studied theology and dogma on the hand of Hegomen Philothaos Āawad, whereas, he was taught the hymns by both muāallem Armanius and muāallem Salib. Besides, he memorized the Coptic language by heart, because of the lack of books, particularly those written in Braille format. By such zeal to learn, the authorities appointed him as a teacher of the Church Rituals, Religion, and the two languages: Arabic and Coptic in the School for the Blinds in El-Zeitun.

Earning the Rank of 'Bek':

For the devotion of muâallem Michael to provide his students with all the knowledge that he has gotten, he used the Braille format in teaching the Arabic language in the School for the Blinds, and he applied the same technique to invent a special Braille format to teach the Coptic language.

Then, it happened that the ruler of Egypt, the khedive Abbas Helmy II (1892-1914), visited the School for the Blinds in El-Zeitun in 1903. Muâallem Michael recited before him a poem he wrote in the Coptic language, then he translated it for him into the Arabic language. Then, he let his students chant another poem he wrote and composed for the occasion. The khedive was so impressed that he greeted muâallem Michael by saying: "Bravo, O Michael Bek." This statement implied that the khedive has bestowed on muâallem Michael the high rank of Bek on the spot.

His Zeal on the Fathers' Heritage:

Besides his excellent knowledge and mastering of the church hymns, muâallem Michael was characterized by the humility and the simplicity of that of the children. He had a great zeal on the Fathers' heritage of authentic hymns, and he was very keen to hand them intact to the new generations. He did not feel that it was enough for him to be the Cantor of the Great Cathedral and a teacher in the Clerical College, but he kept moving between the different churches, to be in touch with those who sought to learn and absorb his authentic hymns. Those hymns flowed from the bottom of his heart with piety and sweetness that shivered the listeners. He used to focus his ears on the voice of his students, that whenever he would hear any wicked whisper amid their hymn recital, he would make them stop and repeat it again and again until he was delighted.

One of his admirers described him, saying: "In his simple attire and humble overcoat, he was seen at the Great Cathedral or at the Clerical College in Mahmasha or El-Anba Roweis delivering the precious treasures he diligently gathered by his blood and nerves, to whoever sought them. Whenever he was asked to correct a melody, he instantly responded and was willing to spend long hours to get the task done. His sweet voice was heard at midnight, at dawn, in summer and winter, to teach a young man or an older adult, with no discrimination whatsoever, for he considered himself a steward entrusted with a treasure which he had to hand in and deliver completely and precisely, until his last breath."

After ministering the rites of the Holy Pascha from Sunday to Wednesday evening, muâallem Michael reposed in peace at the dawn of the great Thursday in April 1957.

MICHAEL IBRAHIM, HEGOMEN

Fr. Michael Ibrahim was a contemporary priest who presented to us a living icon for the happy heavenly life without any earthly worries. He passed away like a gentle breeze, leaving behind a sweet impact on the lives of so many. He supported so many priests amid their sufferings and guided them on the true path of the Gospel, by the spirit of humility and love.

Whoever got to know him or even see him or became one of his disciples witnessed unceasing series of God's exalted dealings with him, and the generous grace of God had poured onto his life.

His Upbringing:

Michael was born in April 1899, and he was raised in the bosom of the church in Kafr Ābdu in the district of Qwesna in the Manufyya governorate. He joined the preschool of the church, where his heart flared with the love of God and the ministry. After graduating from the Great Coptic School, he was appointed as an employee for ten years (1938–1948) in the ministry of the interior, in the police center in Fowwa, Sherbin, Kafr el-Sheikh, Belbeis, and Hehia. Then, he worked in the governorate of Giza for three years, after which he was blessed by the priesthood in his home town in Kafr Ābdu on the 16th of September 1951.

His Priesthood:

He started his ministry by canceling the passing of collection plates on his church attendee to beseech their donations, preferring to let everyone give to God in secret. Also, he withdrew the charging of any fees for the church services. The congregation loved him and gathered around him. Moreover, one year after his ordination, the bishop elevated him to the rank of a Hegomen in May 1952.

Moving to Cairo:

A few years later, the devil stirred up his partner in the ministry against him, and he considered what Fr. Michael was doing as meaningless and too excessive. He got very uncomfortable with him that abuna Michael quietly retreated to his family home in Cairo in the year 1955 AD. He took refuge in the church of the monastery of St. Mina in Old Cairo, where he fervently kept on praying with tears for God to take care of His people in Kafr Ābdu. Then, it happened that Fr. Marcos Dawod invited him to serve with him in the Sunday Holy Liturgy because of the absence of one of the monks. Fr.

Marcus's soul found so much comfort in him that he asked him to continue to serve with him. Therefore, Fr. Michael continued his ministry and became holy yeast that worked in the lives of so many, until the day of his departure in the year 1975.

Bless me, O my son!

Once Fr. Michael Ibrahim was visiting one of the families, then all of a sudden, he stood up for prayer to get ready to leave. Amazed at such an unexpected move, those in the house asked him: "How come you are in such rush, father?" He told them: "Because my son Ibrahim went home." They answered: "So what? He went to his house." Fr. Michael said: "No, he went to Paradise." Later on, They knew that in those moments, Fr. Michael's son, Dr. Ibrahim, delivered his soul and departed from this world.

While Fr. Michael, Fr. Bishoy Kamel, and my weakness were visiting the house of Fr. Marcus Basilius because his wife departed, Fr. Michael said: "While I was sitting in the reception room of my house, full awake thinking about a particular problem, known only to me and to my son Ibrahim. I raised my eyes to the Lord, saying: 'Is it possible, my Lord, to send me my son Ibrahim to help me with this issue?' All of a sudden, I saw my son Ibrahim standing next to me in beautiful white attire, saying: 'What do you need, father?' I was much rejoiced and said to him: 'As long as you are dressed in such white attire, my son, I shall not spoil it by temporal worries. I wish you pray for me and bless me'." Fr. Michael said: "My son Ibrahim blessed me and went his way." However, he probably hid their talks of spiritual love, and the details of the blessing exchanged between the two of them.

Is This Her Voice?

Fr. Michael, told Fr. Bishoy and me the following story which happened with him: "A young husband once came to me to complain about his wife, saying: 'She insults me with very harsh and cruel words, for no reason.' Then, he started to repeat those filthy words." Abuna listened without commenting until the husband finished his talk. Then he asked the husband: "Are you sure that those harsh words came from your wife?" The husband answered: "Yes, I would never lie to you, father." Abuna said: "Was it her voice, that what you have heard?" He replied: "Yes. it was." Again he said: "Are you sure?" He answered: "She is my wife, with whom I lived for so many years. She was the one who insulted me." Here, Abuna Michael smiled and said to the husband: "It was not your wife. It was rather the devil who spoke through her mouth to destroy both of you. She is good, but the devil

intends to lead you both to destruction. Now, go back to your wife and be gentle and talk nicely to her.”

The husband returned home, prayed for his wife and himself, started treating her with compassion and true love, and the house turned into a holy church full of peace.

A Lesson from a Fallen Elder:

“At the beginning of my ministry as a priest, an elderly man whom I did not know, asked me to hear his confession. With great shame, he whispered: ‘For the first time, I fell into the sin of adultery.’ I simply assumed that he meant a quick sinful glimpse or a touch, which we also consider as adultery, and so I told him., but he confirmed to me that it was not a glimpse nor a bit, but it was the actual act of adultery. At that time, I simply could not imagine that any man could commit such a sin. In bitterness and a contrite soul, I went to see Fr. Michael Ibrahim and told him about that story without mentioning any name. On seeing how I was much confused, he calmed me down, saying: ‘Do you know why God sent you that fallen older man? ’ I replied: ‘No, I do not.’ Then he said: ‘God intended to give you at the beginning of your priesthood ministry, several lessons, among which:

- Never trust your body, even if you have reached an advanced age, yet you are a priest, but be always alert and cautious.
- Never be harsh in condemning a fallen man, even a young man, for sin is exceedingly sinful, and its victims are mighty men. Have compassion for them to support them against sin.
- I do not mean for you to become sluggish on their sins, but beware not to be so harsh on the fallen. Raise them by the living hope.’”

The Angel Deserted Me:

Once Fr. Yuhanna of St. Mark Church in Shubra was astonished to see Fr. Michael Ibrahim, after he has dismissed the Sacrifice's angel and sprinkled the water, has stepped back calmly towards the Altar, then knelt to the ground in front of a very young deacon and repeated that for a second and a third time. Fr. Yuhanna was greatly amazed to hear the elder Fr. Michael Ibrahim saying to the little deacon in a very humble way: “Forgive me, son, that I raised my voice on you. Forgive me.”

Later on, Fr. Yuhanna asked Fr. Michael: “How come that you, an old priest, kneel before a little boy, who is considered as one of your grandchildren?” Fr. Michael answered: “I shall tell you father if you promise me not to tell it anyone before I depart from this world. While I was

mentioning the names of those who asked me to be mentioned at the Altar, I used to see an angel standing by the Altar whenever I mention one of the names; then he disappears, to show again when I mention the next name, then he disappears. However, when I noticed that this little deacon was constantly moving and distracting my attention, I screamed at him to calm down. After I have done that, I found out that the angel disappeared completely and did not come back.”

May the Blessing be On You, Put It On:

As the church was overcrowded on the eve of one of the feasts, Abuna Michael noticed a young man coming out of the deacon's chamber with tears flowing from his eyes. Calmly and with a smile, he patted him on the shoulder and asked him what was bothering him. The young man reluctantly said that he came a little late to serve as a deacon in the eve of the feast, but he did not find his tunic, and apparently, some stranger has taken it to serve in the Holy Liturgy. Abuna held the young man by the hand, entered into the priests' chamber, and gave him one of his priestly tunics. The deacon refused utterly to take it. So, Abuna insisted and said to him: “May the blessing be on you. Put it on, do not be sad but go and serve. No one should be sad in a night like this.”

MICHAEL MINA, HEGOMEN

Fr. Michael Mina was born in the year 1883 in the town of El-Qasr near the monastery of Abba Balamon. He was the 2nd child among five brothers, and he was given the name Michael. His father, Mina, was the priest of the church of the Virgin St. Mary in the town of El-Sallamyia. His father took him to the preschool of muāallem Philistine, where he studied and mastered Arabic and Coptic languages, in addition to the ecclesiastical teachings.

An instant translation from Coptic to Arabic:

It happened in the year 1897 that Abba Marcus, the metropolitan of Esnah, Armant, and Luxor visited the town of El-Sallamyia, and during the Holy Liturgy, the Gospel was read in Coptic. They searched for a Qatamarus in Arabic to read, but they could not find one, so the young Michael came forward and read it from the Coptic version and instantly translated it into Arabic. The metropolitan was so impressed by that fourteen years old young man. Then, when he knew that he was the son of Fr. Mina, the priest, the metropolitan wrote down a letter of recommendation for Michael to join the Clerical College.

Joining the Clerical College:

The young man Michael traveled to Cairo, and from there to H elwan. There, he met the 112th Pope Cyril V (1874-1927), who was residing there at that time. He delivered to him the letter of recommendation, which the pope instantly approved and signed. The pope sent him to the scholar and historian Yousef Bek Armanius, the dean of the Clerical College. The dean noticed in admiration how the young man was fond of the theological knowledge in particular and the religious matters in general. So, he made him give answers to all the questions posed by any of his fellow students. In the Clerical College, Michael spent five years, during which he was known for his piety and superiority.

Becoming the Principal of Monk's School in Bush:

After his graduation, he went to the town of Bush in Beni-Sweif governorate, where the ranch affiliated with the monastery of Abba Anthony was located. There, Abba Marcus, the bishop of St. Anthony's monastery, opened a school for the monks. Michael was appointed as a teacher and instructor for the monks in that school. Among his students at that time were monk Aqladius, who became later on the 115th Pope Abba Yusab II (1946-1956), Abba Basilius the metropolitan of Jerusalem, Abba Kyrillos metropolitan of Qena, Abba Timotheos metropolitan of Daqahlia, Abba Kyrillos metropolitan of Ethiopia, Abba Theophilus Metropolitan of Jerusalem and Abba Abram bishop of Giza and Qwesna.

Michael planned to extend his teaching task to include the inhabitants of the town of Bush. So, he opened an elementary school for the children of the region, which soon became crowded with them. He was pleased with how the young men and their families were eager to learn, so he also established a middle school, at the end of which the student would get a qualifying certificate. Michael remained as a principal for the school of monks and the other civilian schools for twenty-six years.

Becoming the Principal of Monk's School in H elwan:

In the year 1928, the 113th Pope Yoannes XIX (1928-1942) sat on St. Mark's Seat. The pope cared very much for providing his brethren monks with broader knowledge, so he held a meeting for the Holy Synod, and suggested the establishment of a college in H elwan to educate a select group of monks chosen from all the different monasteries. The Holy Synod unanimously approved the idea. The college was built inside the lawn of the church of the Virgin St. Mary in H elwan and mu allem Michael was chosen to be its principal. When Michael came from Bush and proclaimed his

consent to be so appointed, the pope and the bishops rejoiced, and the college was opened directly on the next day. In the celebration, Michael stood and gave a great speech that was admired by all. He remained as a principal, teacher, and sermon-giver in that college for twenty-seven years.

Among the graduates of the Monk's School in H elwan was the 116th Pope St. Cyril VI (1959-1971), Abba Marcus metropolitan of Abu-Tig, Abba Thomas metropolitan of Gharbyia, Abba Abram metropolitan of Giza and his direct successor Abba Joannes, Abba Demetrius metropolitan of El-Manufya, Abba Maximus metropolitan of Qalubya, Abba Anthonius metropolitan of Sohag, Abba Lucas metropolitan of Manfalot, Abba Boulus metropolitan of H elwan, Abba Macarius metropolitan of Qena, Abba Abram metropolitan of Luxor and Abba Mina metropolitan of Girga.

Becoming a Monk:

Deacon Michael always had a powerful desire for virginity and seclusion, although his father forced him to marry a bride from among his relatives, with whom he lived for eight years and had two daughters. When his wife passed away, he resumed his seclusion. When it so happened that Pope Yoannes XIX went to visit the monastery of Paramus in Wadi el-Natrun, accompanied by Ismael Pasha Sidqy, the prime minister and Tawfiq Pasha Doos, the minister of Transportation, they had in their company Michael Mina. To welcome the official guests, Michael gave a speech, which they all so much admired that at the end of the visit, the pope made Michael a monk and ordained him as a Hegomen under his original name.

His Sermons and Writings:

Since the beginning of his life of service, Hegomen Michael Mina used to give so many sermons whenever he was invited in churches to do so. During these sermons, he used to weep and induce the audience to cry too. He also made it a strict rule, not to exceed half an hour in his sermons.

Of his most essential writings was the book of Theology, which he wrote in three volumes, to be more of an encyclopedia rather than a book. In this work, he dealt with the doctrinal issues, the spiritual facts, the holy Sacraments, and the Church Rituals, which he supported by strong proofs. He also wrote a book on The interpretation of the Torah and the Gospel. Another on sermons for the different occasions throughout the year. Besides, he wrote so many essays which were published in the different newspapers and magazines, existing at the time.

His Departure:

He finally reposed on Friday the 17th of August 1956, while being in the

college of H elwan, when he was seventy-three years old, of which he spent fifty-three years in the service of the church.

[The Story of the Coptic Church, Bk 9, p. 33]

MICHAEL, BISHOP OF MALIJ AND ATRIB

This bishop Michael was known as Michael el-Gamil (which means the beautiful). He was a bishop of the cities of Atrib and Malij in El-Manoufyia governorate. He lived¹ in the 13th century AD, and most probably was contemporary of the 75th pope Cyril III (1235-1243 AD) and the few popes who followed him.

We still have a portion of his written work that indicated his great care for spreading the ecclesiastical knowledge among his people. Among his works is a Synaxarion, which he organized by himself. Also, he authored a book of more than 560 pages (although only 560 pages were found, and an unknown number of pages was lost from its last section). This book has the title 'The Spiritual Medicine,' which is a manual of moral and pastoral theology, a collection of the laws of the saintly fathers, and it includes questions and answers by the church scholars. This book was translated to the German language by the German scholar Franz C  ln, who published it in the magazine of Oriens Christianus in the years 1906-1908.²

[The Story of the Coptic Church, Bk 4, p. 96]

[The Coptic Encyclopedia: Mikhail, by Ren  -George Coquin, pp. 1625-7]

MICHAEL, BISHOP OF NAQADAH

On the 22nd of Baramhat, the church celebrates the memorial of the departure of the bishop Abba Michael of right old age and fragrant memory. Abba Michael was the bishop of Naqadah.

[The Synaxarion: 22 Baramhat]

MICHAEL, BISOP OF EL-BAHNASSA & EL-ASHMONEIN

This scholar Abba Michael lived in the 1st half of the 18th century, and he was one of the most prominent metropolitans during the days of the 104th Pope Butros VI (1718-1726), under the Ottoman rulers.

¹ In some sources, they say that this bishop lived in the 17th century AD, and was contemporary of pope 'Joannes XVI' (1676-1718 AD)..

² C  ln, Fr. J, "Der Nomokanon Mihails von Malig.", Oriens Christianus 6 (1906):70-237, 7 (1907):1-135, 8 (1908):110-229...

Abba Michael was known as ‘The Scholar’ because he authored a volume including an elaborate explanation for the Orthodox Doctrines. He refuted the claims of the Roman Pope Leo I (440-461), who was a contemporary of the 25th Pope St. Dioscorus, the Champion of Orthodoxy (444-454 AD), and who played an unfortunate role in the Chalcedonian Council in the year 451 AD.

[The Story of the Coptic Church, Bk 4, p. 114]
[The Patriotism of the Coptic Church and its History, p. 381]

MICHAEL, METROPOLITAN OF DAMIETTA

This bishop Michael lived during the 12th century AD. Not much is known about him, except that he was appointed as an assistant to the 71st Pope Michael V (1145-1146 AD), and lived until the time of the 73rd Pope of Alexandria, Abba Mark III (1166-1189 AD) and the 74th Pope John VI (1189-1216 AD). He was the first Coptic bishop to receive the honorary title of Metropolitan. Bishop Michael of Damietta's principal work was his Nomocanon,¹ of which a first version was completed in 1188 AD in Luxor, as was indicated in his manuscript. Four hand-written copies of these instructions are in existence up till now: two manuscripts are kept in the Coptic Papal Library in Cairo, one manuscript is in the National Library of Paris, and the fourth manuscript is in the Library of the Vatican. His Nomocanon instructions were about the practice of some Ecclesiastical Rites. These rites included: The secret confession, shaving the head, the circumcision, the incense, not keeping any of the holy sacraments from one day to another, making the sign of the cross, and the intermarriage among the relatives.

The Artistic Metropolitan:

Although not much else is known about this bishop, however, he left behind amazing artworks. Being an Egyptian in him was no deceit, he tried to bring to his congregation the good news of Salvation in a way they could easily understand, especially many of them were illiterate. So, Abba Michael used his artistic talent in that regard. He managed to draw ninety portraits to complement some of the stories in the four Gospels to demonstrate some of the events in their right sequence. For example, when he wanted to illustrate how Herod ended up killing all the infants of Bethlehem, he started drawing on the upper corner of the page, the portrait of the Magi following the star. The Magi standing in the royal hall before Herod on his throne while the scholars and the priests were occupied with searching the prophecies

¹ A collection of “Instructions” ...

referring to the coming of the heavenly King. Then, the 3rd scene showing Herod giving instructions to the Magi, followed by the portrait of the Magi on the road following the star again, then the Magi arriving at Bethlehem and delivering their gifts to the Divine newborn. Then, the scene of the Magi going home by another route. At the end of the portrait series, he drew a view for the soldiers of Herod snatching the infants from the bosoms of their mothers and killing them. Then, the last in the series showing a group of those miserably crying mothers leaning on a tree, while the soldiers were carrying baskets full of the corpses of their children to explain to Herod.

These portraits were drawn according to the ancient Egyptian Pharaonic style. In that style, the portraits of the story are drawn in one row without separation in between them and shown on the same horizontal level, where all the drawn individuals are standing next to each other. This authentic Egyptian style also extended to the coloring of the portraits. It was an amazing work that it draws the heart before the eyes, for its simplicity and elaboration. Abba Michael drew them along two years, as indicated by the date written at the end of his manuscript (1179-1181 AD). This manuscript is now kept in the National Library of Paris, which seemed to have been taken away secretly by the French king Louis IX (1226-1270 AD) as he returned home. This king, after capturing the port of Damietta, failed in his Crusade campaign, and he fell captive into the hands of the Egyptians in the year 1250 AD, then he was released later on after a ransom was paid.

Abba Michael, the artist, left to us, as well many sermons and interpretations of the Holy Bible. Besides, some letters he exchanged with Abba Saleh the Armenian, which are existing up till now, which concerned someone of prominence, who was wavering between the Orthodox and the Chalcedonian doctrines.

[Iris Habib el-Masri: *The Story of the Coptic Church*, Bk 3, pp. 139, 172-4]
[The Coptic Encyclopedia: Mikhail, by René-George Coquin, pp. 1624-5]

MILAS, THE BISHOP, ST.

St. Milas was a bishop contemporary of the 21st Pope Butros II (373-379 AD), who sat on the throne of Alexandria after Pope Athanasius the Apostolic (328-373 AD). The departure of Pope Athanasius was the event that the Arians were waiting to have one of their people sit on the Seat of St. Mark. However, their dreams were shattered by the ordination of Pope Butros II in the year 373 AD. Emperor Valens (E: 364-378 AD), who was pro-Arians, planned to take revenge against the new pope and those who ordained him. So, he ordered his governor in Alexandria to remove and exile Pope Butros II

and to place Lucius the Arian in his place, even if he had to use military force. Then, the Emperor sent Lucius the Arian with a squadron of soldiers from Constantinople to Egypt. When Lucius and the soldiers accompanying him arrived at night to the town of Rhinocorura,¹ they found its bishop Milas occupied with fixing the lamps in the church. They assumed that such a simple task would be performed only by one of the servants, so they asked him where they can find the bishop. He took them to the bishopric residence, offered them dinner, and served them by himself, and when they finished, he told them that he was the bishop Milas whom they came to seek. Amazed and ashamed for the generosity and humility by which he treated them, they suggested to him to escape to avoid being exiled. The saint responded to their suggestion with a calm smile, saying: "I would rather be exiled for the sake of faith than to be free under the Arian umbrella."

[The Story of the Coptic Church, Bk 1, p. 345]

MILIUS, The 3rd POPE OF ALEXANDRIA

Pope Milius (Melyos/Avilius/Abilius/Sabellius/Abilius/Abitius) was unanimously chosen to be the patriarch after the repose of the 2nd Pope St. Anianus (62-83 AD). He has been ordained in the month of Kiahk in the year 83 AD, during the days of Caesar Domitian (81-96 AD). He was known for his piety, chastity, and zeal on the flock of the Lord Jesus Christ. He held them fast into faith, that their number multiplied in Egypt, in the Five Western Cities, and Africa. The Egyptians started to despise the worship of idols and to come in high numbers to cast themselves into the bosom of Christianity. During his days, peace dwelt over the church. According to some historians, Caesar Domitian has expelled Pope Milius from the Seat of Alexandria and put another in his place. However, such a claim was not confirmed.

That pope reposed in the 1st of Tout in the year 95 AD.

[The History of the Coptic Church, p. 30]

MILTIADES, POPE OF ROME, ST.

The Roman Pope Miltiades was initially from Africa. He was chosen as a patriarch on the See of Rome, most probably on the 2nd of July 311 AD. Hence, his memorial is bound to the end of the period of persecution in the church. It happened that after Emperor Constantine the Great (306-337 AD)

¹. 'Rhinocorura' was a town on the Eastern border of Egypt with Phoenicia (nowadays Levant)

defeated Maxentius in the battle of Milvian Bridge on the 28th of October 312 AD, he marched to Rome at the beginning of the year 313 AD, gave freedom to all the religions in the entire Roman Empire. Christianity became acceptable, and the Christian captives were released from prisons and labor mines. All celebrated the victory of Christ, singing the praise of glory to God, day and night, praying for permanent peace in the church after such long persecution.

Amid the happiness of the church, a significant disturbance took place, as a result of dissension within the church of North Africa as when Caecilian was chosen as a bishop on Cordoba, an opposition group was formed led by Donatus and objected to that choice. They accused Caecilian of unworthiness because he had delivered the Holy Bibles he was entrusted with to his persecutors when he was tortured.

Then, Emperor Constantine sought from Pope Miltiades to hold a Council in Rome and to invite the Italian and the French bishops to resolve that matter. In that Council, the bishops decided that the ordination of Caecilian was proper. Later on, St. Augustine (354-430 AD) commended the wisdom of Pope Miltiades, describing him as the true son of peace and the great father of Christians. He is counted by the Western Church among the martyrs, because of the sufferings he endured on the hands of Emperor Maximian (286-305 AD) before he was ordained as a pope. He reposed in the year 314.

[Butler: December 10]

MINA I, The 47th POPE OF ALEXANDRIA

Pope Mina I (767-776 AD) was from the monks of the monastery of St. Macarius in the wilderness of the Scetis. He sat on the Seat of Alexandria after the departure of the 46th Pope Khaal I (Michael I: 743-767 AD), unanimously chosen by the clergy and the congregation. Intending to keep his name, he became Abba Mina I in the year 767 AD (474 AM). His ordination took place during the reign of the Abbasid Caliph Abu Ja'far al-Mansur (754-775 AD) and his vizier, the governor of Egypt Abdel Rahman ibn-Hudayj (769-772 AD). On receiving the exalted spiritual leadership, he kept on teaching the people and explaining to them the meaning of the Orthodox Faith and rebuilding the ruined churches, with spiritual joy that so reflected on his countenance, that the people were amazed to see such grace on him. Pope Mina I could manage to do all his constructive work quickly and peacefully, because of the spirit of understanding which prevailed through the proper relationships between the Copts and the governor of Egypt at that time.

A Monk Tried to Take Over the Papacy:

The devil did not let Pope Mina I do his spiritual work in peace for long as that peaceful atmosphere was disturbed by a strange internal incident. An evil monk named Butros asked the pope to elevate him to the rank of a bishop, but his request was declined. So, that monk boldly reported falsely to the Abbasid caliph in Baghdad that the Alexandrian pope was a magician and was able to transform with a chemical process much metal into gold, to be used in filling his churches with gold sacramental cups. The Abbasid caliph was hard-pressed for funds and listened to that impostor, who managed to get the caliph to issue a decree making him a patriarch on the See of Alexandria instead of Mina I, to deliver the accumulated gold of the church to the caliph.

The caliph wrote to his governor in Egypt that the patriarch would be replaced. Although that governor respected Pope Mina I, yet he had to obey the order of the caliph. He placed the pope under arrest in the governor's residence, then arrested the bishops who refused to accept that monk as their pope, and for a whole year, Pope Mina I and his bishops were tasked with painting boats, without any sign of protest. However, that monk Butros went too far in his arrogance with the governor, that the governor ordered his men to put him under arrest, and allowed Pope Mina I and his bishops to return to their thrones with the due honor. Pope Mina I, spent his last years interacting with his congregation and urging them to strive, as well as to renew the churches. It was a peaceful period mainly that the new governor Musa ibn Ali (772-778 AD) followed the same pleasant path of his predecessor Abdel Rahman in dealing with the Christians and the Egyptian people in general. This pope departed to the church of the firstborn, after a papacy which lasted for eight years and ten months.

[The Story of the Coptic Church, Bk. 3, p. 385]

[The Coptic Encyclopedia: Mina I, by Subhi Y. Labib, p. 1631-2]

MINA II, The 61st POPE OF ALEXANDRIA

His Marriage and Virginity:

After the repose of the 60th Pope of Alexandria Abba Theophilus (Theophanes: 952-956 AD), St. Mark's Seat became vacant. The entire Coptic congregation prayed to God to send them his replacement. The bishops and the priests set forth to the monasteries, where the Holy Spirit guided them in the monastery of Abba Macarius to a simple ascetic monk, called Mina. He was originally from the village of Sandala in Kafr el-Sheikh district, and he used to carry the same name before he became a monk. When his parents intended for him to get married, he kept silent until after the

wedding ceremony. Then, when he joined his wife in seclusion, he preached to her the virtues of chastity and living a godly life, which she accepted. After they had lived together for three days, without any physical contact, she allowed him to withdraw to the wilderness silently. There, he became a disciple of one of the saintly old monks, to whom he revealed his situation and his chastity in the seclusion of his cell. His family, thinking that he has died, set over him great mourning. In the monastery, his virtues of asceticism, humility, gifts, broad knowledge, and simplicity became well known.

Then, when his spiritual father recommended him for the patriarchate, they took him by force to Alexandria, where he was ordained in December 956 AD. His papacy lasted for seventeen years and eleven months (956-974 AD).

His Pastoral Activities:

The new pope started his mission by making a pastoral tour with his bishops to meet his congregation in the different dioceses in the country, and when he got to his village of Sandala, one of the natives divulged to the bishops that pope Mina II was a married man. St. Mina acknowledged the marriage and told them to call on his wife to hear from her. Her public revelation of their nominal marital relationship and their purity appeased the bishops. Pope Mina II began one of the essential patriarchal reigns, during which momentous events in the history of Egypt took place.

Also, it happened that the level of the Nile flood continued to below for three consecutive years, during which famines and plagues spread around Egypt until God lifted them because of the prayers raised by the church.

During the reign of the Abbasid caliph Al-Muti Lillah (946-974 AD) in Baghdad, this revered pope was contemporary of Egypt's acting governor (Amir) Abu al-Misk Kafur (966-968 AD) who was an Abyssinian eunuch and became the guardian over the underage children of the deceased governor Al-Ikhshid ibn Tughj. Kafur was known for his justice and leniency. Under these circumstances, the Copts and the patriarchate had a breathing space and a period of relative peace and security, providing that they rendered the *Kharaj* (Tax) to the ruler. During his rule, the Coptic feasts were publicly celebrated.

The pope focused his efforts on building and mending the churches, and establishing preschools and regular schools for the children. He consecrated the Holy Myron in the church he built in the name of St. Mark at Maâlet Daniel, instead of the well-established custom of consecrating it in the monasteries. While he was in that town, he departed to the heavenly glories on the 13th of November 974 AD. His body was then moved to be buried in the tombs of the Patriarchs in Alexandria.

MINA, THE RELEASE DEACON, ST.

This St. Mina is celebrated by the church on the 15th of Bashons.

MINA, THE ASCETIC, ST.

This St. Mina lived for fifty-nine years in a monastery near Alexandria. He reached a high level of asceticism that he forgot all about himself. Also, in his honor to his monastery's Abbot, he used to bow low in front of him whenever he would enter his cell until the Abbot would give him his blessing. Such a practice of piety was used by the Abbot of the monastery to teach a lesson to the new monks entering the monastery. Some of those monks used to ridicule such practices of giving honor to the elderly monks. So, it happened once that Mina entered the cell of the Abbot and prostrated himself before him to the ground as he used to do while saying: "Bless me, father." The Abbot chose to disregard his presence and left him bowing for hours until it was time for prayer. Then, he gave him the blessing, and only then, Mina stood upright. A young monk said to him: "By so doing, you have wasted your precious time while doing nothing." The saint answered him: "No, I did not waste my time, because I did use that chance to recite the whole book of Psalms."

God chose to honor this ascetic worshipper after his departure. So, while they were praying on him during his funeral, the church was filled with sweet fragrance as a testimony of the virtues by which he was adorned.

[The Faithful Synaxarion: 26 Baba]

MINA, THE BISHOP (The martyr)

This St. Mina lived in the 8th century AD and became the bishop of Tamai el-Amdid in Sinbellawein. His father was from Samannud. He was the only son of God-fearing parents, who were known to practice a monastic style of prayers and fasting, which made them famous all around the area. His parents forced him to get married, but he got his bride's consent to keep their virginity. They practiced so many worships like those performed by the monks, they put on sackcloth and spent most of their nights in prayers and in reading the Bible.

His Monastic Life:

St. Mina longed for monastic life, so he said to his wife: "It is not befitting

of us to practice a monastic life while being in the world.” On having her approval, he set forth to the monastery of Abba Anthony in the eastern desert, to be as far as he could from his parents. They diligently searched for him for a while, and then they stopped. From there, he went to the monastery of St. Macarius, in the wilderness of the Scetis accompanied by Abba Khael (who eventually became the 46th Pope on the See of Alexandria: (743-767 AD). There, they both started their monastic life, in the days of the two shining stars St. Abram and St. Gawargi. St. Mina became a disciple of these two saints and had the benefit of their vast knowledge, imitated their worship, and grew in the angelical work, more than many other fathers. Satan envied him for his strife, and he severely struck him in his legs, that he was left bed-ridden on the ground for two months. Then, he was healed by the power of the Lord Jesus Christ.

Ordained as a Bishop:

Then, St. Mina was called for the rank of a bishop by messengers sent by the pope. He cried for forsaking the wilderness, but after being told by the fathers that it was a call from God, he obeyed and went along with the pope's messengers, and the pope ordained him as a bishop on Tamai el-Amdid.

God granted him the grace of healing the sick and that of knowing the hidden matters in the minds of people. The other bishops all around used to visit him and seek his counsel. The multitudes from everywhere would come to him to hear his teachings. He was a contemporary to four of the popes of Alexandria, and he laid his hand upon some of them during their ordinations: Abba Alexandros II (704-729 AD), Abba Cosmas I (729-730 AD), Abba Theodore I (730-742 AD), and Abba Khael I (743-767 AD).

When the Lord Jesus Christ wished him to depart from this world, He informed him about it. So he called up the people of his diocese, urged them to abide in the upright faith, and to keep the Divine commandments. Then, he committed them to their True Shepherd Jesus Christ and departed to His Savior, who loved him. He was so mourned by his people, who buried him in a place he assigned to them ahead of time.

[The Synaxarion: 7 Hator]

MINA, THE MONK (The martyr)

This saint was born in a village around Akhmim to Christian parents who lived on farming. Since his youth, his heart longed toward asceticism. He became a monk in one of the monasteries of Akhmim, where he dwelt, fasting every two days and practicing asceticism in his food and drink. Then,

he moved to El-Ashmonein, where he stayed in a monastery for sixteen years, during which he never left the monastery. When the Arabs ruled the country (after 640 AD), he heard that they denied that God has a Son from His nature and essence, and equal with Him in Eternity. This denial of faith was painful to the saint, so he took permission from the Abbot of the monastery and went to El-Ashmonein.

He came before the commander of the Arab camp and asked him: "Is it true that you say that God has no Son from His Nature and Essence?" The commander replied, saying: "We deny that saying about God and reject it. " The saint told the Arab commander that it should only be rejected if His Son was born through parental procreation, but we believe that the Lord Jesus Christ is God from God and Light from Light. The commander replied: "In our faith, this is blasphemy. " The saint told him that the Bible says: *"He who believes in the Son has everlasting life, and he who does not believe in the Son shall not see life, but the wrath of God abides on him. "* (John 3:36)

The commander became enraged at this and ordered his soldiers to cut the saint into pieces and to throw him into the river. The believers gathered the parts of his body, shrouded it, and buried it. They arranged a commemoration to celebrate the martyrdom of St. Mina the Monk on the 17th of Amshir.

[The Synaxarion: 17 Amshir]

MINA, THE WONDER-MAKER (The martyr)

This St. Mina is the most famous of the Egyptian martyrs. He became so well-known in and outside of Egypt, because of the so many wonders, performed by God through his prayers, up to this very day.

St. Mina was born around the year 285 AD in the town of Nikiu (Nakiyos) in the district of Menuf in El-Monufyia governorate on the Nile delta. His father, Eudoxius was the governor of the city, and his grandfather Plondionus was also governor before him. Because Eudoxius had an excellent reputation and was loved by everybody around him due to his piety and virtues, his brother Anatolius was envious of him. He brought charges against him before Caesar Carinus (283-285 AD). However, the Caesar wanted to gain the favor of both men, so he sent Hypatus the leader of his army, with an order to appoint Eudoxius as a governor on ancient Africa (Algeria), in place of its governor who passed away, and he asked Hypatus to accompany Eudoxius and his family on the trip and make sure that everything was for them in their new residence. The people of Nikiu were unfortunate to lose Eudoxius, while his brother Anatolius showed remorse on what he has done.

The Son of the Promise:

St. Mina's mother, Euphemia, had no children, and one day, she went to the church on one of the feasts of the Virgin St. Mary, the Mother of God, at Atrib on the 21st of Toba. She saw the children in the church wearing their beautiful clothes with their parents. She heaved a sigh and wept before the icon of our Lady St. Mary, imploring her to intercede for her before her beloved Son, so that He would give her a son. A voice came from the icon saying, Amen. She rejoiced in what she had heard and realized that the Lord had heard her prayers. When she returned to her home and told her husband about it, he replied: "May God's Will be done."

Euphemia conceived and gave birth to the son of her prayers, promised to her by the Lord Jesus, whom she called Mina, meaning 'Amen.' The whole city rejoiced for his birth, and his father Eudoxius, the governor, released many prisoners and gave away many donations in celebration.

His Upbringing:

His father cared to educate him with an Evangelic spirit about all the church teachings. He planted in him the love of the Holy Bible and the right knowledge, with the mood of worship and the pious behavior. Then, his father passed away when Mina was only eleven years old, followed by his mother when he was fourteen years old. The saint inherited from them a significant wealth and much spiritual blessings and honor.

A year after the repose of his mother, when he was fifteen years old, he was appointed an officer in the army in the regiment of ancient Africa (Algeria), for the high regard they had for his departed father.

Becoming a Monk:

In the year 303 AD, when a decree was issued by the two evil Emperors Diocletian and Maximian (284-305 AD) ordering everyone to worship and offer sacrifices to the idols, the officer Mina distributed his wealth on Jesus' little brethren and decided to dedicate all his time and energy to the kingdom of God. He abandoned the military service after three years and set forth to the wilderness to worship God, which he was longing to do for some time.

Then, it happened that after five years in his monastic life, Mina saw while praying the martyrs were being crowned by the angels and carried by them to Paradise, with their shiny countenance more splendid than the sun. Desiring to become a martyr, he heard a voice from heaven, saying: "Blessed you are Abba Mina, for you are called for piety since your childhood. You will get three immortal crowns: one for your virginity, one for your monastic life, and the third for your martyrdom. Your name will be famous among the martyrs,

for I shall make men of every tribe and tongue come to worship Me in your church, which will be built in your name, and above everything else, you will get an indescribable glory in My everlasting kingdom.”

In the Celebration Arena:

Forsaking the wilderness, Mina set forth to the city in his monastic attire. On that day, there was a big pagan celebration for the gods. The saint's soul felt bitterness on seeing such a high number of lost souls getting into the celebration arena. He cried out in a loud voice, proclaiming the longing of the True God to see all of them getting to know His love and Salvation. He quoted the prophetic words: “*I was found by those who did not seek Me. I was made manifest to those who did not ask for Me.*” (Isaiah 65:1; Romans 10:20).

The multitudes and the spectators were amazed to see such a daring scene, and an impressive silence dwelt on the place. The governor wondered how someone dared to interrupt the celebration of the gods. In the meantime, some of the military people recognized Mina and informed the governor about his past position. So, he asked the saint: “Why did you desert your military service, and how come you proclaim that you are a Christian?” The saint answered him: “Yes, I am a soldier, but I decided to serve my Lord Jesus Christ to please His Holy Name.”

At that point, the angry governor decided to punish the saint. So, he ordered the leader of his officers to put the saint in the hinbazeen, which tore off his flesh and exposed his bones. In the meantime, that leader kept asking the saint sarcastically if he was in pain. The saint responded by saying: “Your tortures are my investment which prepares for me the crowns before Christ, my King, and God.” Then, they dragged him over a platform made of sharp iron nails until the rest of his flesh was torn apart. Afterward, they rubbed his wounds with rough fabrics and burned his sides by flames for two hours. However, the Lord relieved all his pains that nobody heard him moaning.

They also hit the saint's mouth with rods until his teeth were broken, all that while he kept giving thanks to God, and considering himself unworthy to be reproached for the sake of His Holy Name.

When the leader failed to make the saint change his stand, he sent him sailing back to the governor with a report about all that happened. While sailing with the soldiers on board of a boat, the saint heard a voice from heaven saying: “Do not have fear, O My beloved Mina, for I shall always be with you wherever they take you.”

The governor put him in jail together with so many other believers. The saint kept consoling them and encouraging them. There, the Lord Jesus Christ Himself appeared to him and comforted him, then ascended to heaven.

The Saint's Martyrdom:

On the next day, the governor brought him up before the court of justice; started to treat him tenderly to bring him to his side, then when he failed, he threatened him with death. The governor ordered his men to scourge the saint with oxtails. Then, they tried to saw him with a sharp iron saw, but the saw melted like wax. Finally, the governor ordered to cut his head off by the sword. In the arena of martyrdom, the saint knelt, and after raising his hands in prayer toward heaven, the swordsman struck him with the sword. St. Mina was martyred on the 15th of Hator, around the year 309 AD, when he was twenty-four years old. The soldiers ignited a fire to burn his body. However, it remained three days and three nights in flames without being burned. Some believers came, took his body, shrouded it with precious fabrics, and buried him with honor.

The Body of St. Mina:

After a few years from St. Mina's martyrdom, some of the Barbarians came from Eastern Libya and attacked the city of Marriott. Athanasius, the army commander, was asked to take his troops and defend that area. He used to be a very close friend of St. Mina when they were together in the army. So, he decided to take the body of the saint along with him. The soldiers uncovered St. Mina's tomb, a great light came out, before which they fell on the ground worshipping the God of St. Mina. While sailing with the body on a boat toward Alexandria in their way to Marriott, fierce marine beasts attacked them, but fire came out of the body and scared them away.

After arriving at Alexandria with the body loaded on a camel, they marched to Marriott, and they defeated the Barbarians, and on their way back, the camel refused to get up to go with them, despite striking it very hard. They loaded the saint's body on another more robust camel, but it refrained from moving, as well. When this was repeated, the prefect Athanasius perceived that it was the will of the Lord for the body to stay in Marriott.

The Lord Jesus Christ Reveals the Location of the Body:

Around the period (320-325 AD), according to the 48th Pope of Alexandria St. John IV¹ (777-799 AD), a lame boy who was living in a village near the place where the body of the saint was buried, happened to crawl out of his village, and when he saw a brightly lit lamp at a distance, he kept crawling toward it, when he got there, he fell asleep, from exhaustion. The next

¹ From a biography of St. Mina found in a Coptic manuscript (893 AD) called "Encomium" kept in P. Morgan library in NY.

morning, when the worried parents of the lame boy found him, they kept screaming at his face. However, they were amazed to see him jump and run away from them. The healed boy told the people in the village about what he saw. People came to the tomb, and they saw the splendid light coming out of it. Multitudes of people came to the saint's tomb to enjoy many wonders that God performed through the prayers of St. Mina.

Healing of the Emperor's Daughter:

Sometime later, a shepherd who was attending to his flock outside of the city had a sheep inflicted with skin disease. Then, it happened that the inflicted sheep went down into a nearby swamp, then came out and rolled over into the dirt, and it was instantly healed. Incredibly amazed, the shepherd brought over all the inflicted sheep into the swamp, then let them roll over in the dirt to be repaired in the same fashion. Soon enough, the news spread around and reached the emperor¹ of Constantinople, whose only daughter was inflicted with leprosy. He sent her with a large entourage to Egypt to be healed in that fantastic location. In that spot, the saint appeared to her in a dream, instructed her to have that location dug few meters deep to find his relics. So, she did, and she was instantly healed. Her father built a small church on that spot in the name of St. Mina, which was consecrated on the 15th of Paona.

In (363-373 AD), the 20th pope of Alexandria St. Athanasius, the Apostolic (328-373 AD), built a church in that location, and he placed the holy relics of St. Mina in a special chamber beneath the Altar. Then, the 23rd Pope St. Theophilus (385-412 AD) wrote to Emperor Arcadius (E: 383-408 AD), the son of Emperor Theodosius the Great (379-395 AD), to ask for his help because St. Mina's church became too small to accommodate the multitudes of visitors. The emperor responded and helped him in building a sizeable beautiful church, in the form of an eastern extension to the church previously built by St. Athanasius the Apostolic.

Then, in the days of the 82nd Pope Benjamin II (1327-1339 AD), the holy body of St. Mina was moved to the church of St. Mina in Fum el-Khalij on the outskirts of Cairo. In the days of the 116th Pope St. Kyrillos VI (1959-1971), a part of his relics was moved back to its original location and was placed in the new monastery of St. Mina in Marriott.

His Spiritual Effect:

St. Mina has been martyred over 1,700 years ago when he was twenty-four years old, but his fragrant life and prayers still have their miraculous

¹ Most probably, it was emperor 'Constantine the Great' who was reigning at the time (306-337 AD).

effect on so many. At the beginning of the 5th century, the hearts of many young men flared with God's love, sold all their possessions, and set forth to St. Mina's holy tomb to practice the monastic life and establish his monastery in Marriott.

The history testifies that seven monks of the St. Mina Monastery preached the Gospel to Ireland and built the first church there in the name of St. Mina. The Irish Church still keeps in its prayers up to this very day, a litany for the Coptic fathers who carried to them the torch of faith. According to the historical accounts¹ of that area, the great city of St. Mina went through several stages of ups and downs, flourishing and looting. During the papacy of the 52nd Pope Yusab I (831-849 AD), St. Mina's cathedral was ransacked, and most of its marble columns were stolen. However, its monastery came to flourish again in the era of the 55th Pope St. Shenouda I (859-880 AD).

It is believed that the eventual demise of the first great city of St. Mina took place around the end of the 13th century AD. Then, in the era of Pope St. Kyrillos VI (1959-1971), the new monastery of Mar Mina was built, and another wave of monastic renaissance started anew in Marriott.

Monuments of the era of St. Mina:

In the German city of Frankfurt, there is a museum that is wholly dedicated to St. Mina. The reason behind that was the German scholar bishop Carl Maria Kaufmann (1872-1951), who discovered the location of St. Mina's ancient city in Marriott in the year 1906/1907, managed to take back with him to Germany about 100 large size boxes full of beautiful artifacts, crowns of marble columns, etc. After that discovery, the museums of the whole world moved to take some of St. Mina's monuments, but Kaufman got the best of it. Some German researchers kept working on the location until 2013 through an assignment by the German Museum of antiquities in collaboration with the Coptic Museum of Cairo, to carry out new and elaborate excavations.

The departed Coptic scholar Banoub Hâbashy moved a lot of St. Mina's antiquities to a section of the Graeco-Roman Museum in Alexandria, and he called that section: [The Coptic Museum in the era of St. Mina.]

An Ecumenical Love:

The heart of St. Mina was full of love for God, and he kept working, even after his martyrdom. Many sick people from all over the world came to get the blessing of his prayers and to get healed from their sicknesses. They went

¹ Some of these accounts came from: 'History of the Patriarchs, by Sawiris ibn el-Moqafaâ', 'Ibn Khardazaba', 'Abu Obeid el-Bakry', 'Abu Saleh el-Armany', and others...

back home with holy water in small clay flasks (ampoules) on which his name and picture were engraved. These ampoules are still found in many countries far apart, like Colon and Heidelberg in Germany, Marseille in France, Dalmata in Yugoslavia, Milan in Italy, Dengela in Sudan, Jerusalem and parts of England.

The Icon of St. Mina:

In the Louvre Museum in Paris, there is a Coptic icon from the 5th century, in which we see the Lord Jesus Christ puts His blessed hand on St. Mina's shoulder in exalted amiability. Such an icon reveals how the church views the saints, through whom we get to recognize the elevated compassion of God and His longing toward the believer to set with Him a covenant of love and friendship on an everlasting level.

An Unceasing Action:

My dear friend (H. Y.), who was also a friend of Pope St. Kyrillos VI, since he was a monk in Old Cairo, told me the following story:

“One evening in the monastery of St. Mina in Marriott, when the only persons attending the church with the pope were just two or three people, during the vesper I noticed that the pope was laughing while he was alone in the sanctuary. At the end of the prayer, I hastened toward the pope and told him: ‘I never saw you laughing in the sanctuary. Would you please tell me what you have seen.’ After much reluctance, he told me: ‘You know the intense tribulation we are living through these days.¹ I was complaining to God that, because of such bitter anguish, I am not able to resolve any problems for His children, but right away, St. Mina appeared to me and poked my belly with his finger, saying: ‘You think that you are alone!? We are all working together with you. Do not despair.’ For that reason, I laughed!” After more than seventeen centuries since his martyrdom and departure from this world, St. Mina's heart, full of love, still works for the kingdom of heaven, to support so many: patriarchs, bishops, priests and the members of the congregation. Indeed: *"Love never fails"* (1 Cor 13: 8).

[The Church of St. ‘Mina’ in Fleming: *Mar Mina, the Wonder-Maker*, 1963]

[The Church of St. George in Sporting: *The Egyptian Martyr Mina*, 1974]

MINA (The martyr)

This St. Mina was the familial brother of the 38th Pope of Alexandria St.

¹ It was at the beginning of the rule of ‘Gamal Abdel Nasser’ (1956-1970).

Benjamin I (623-662 AD). He endured so many tortures by those believing in the two natures for the Lord (the Chalcedonians). He was tortured by burning his sides with flames and breaking his teeth through continuous beating. During all his sufferings, he refused to submit to their request to accept the decree of the Chalcedonian Council. They finally cast him into the water to drown, where he received the crown of martyrdom.

[The Martyrdom in Christianity, p. 80]

MIOS, FATHER

Fr. Mios, who was from Philips, once said: “The obedience should be for its own sake, for if man obeys God, God in turn, would obey him.”

A Slave in Scetis:

Fr. Mios narrated about an elder monk living in the Scetis, who was formerly a slave to some masters in Alexandria. He used every year to leave the Scetis to go down to Alexandria, to deliver his wages to his masters. His masters, in turn, used to welcome him by prostrating themselves to the ground before him, but the elderly monk on seeing them would pour water into a basin and would wash the feet of his masters. Those masters used to tell him: “No father, do not do that and bring us to shame,” but, he would answer: “By doing so, I confess that I am your slave, and I wash your feet to give you thanks for making me free to serve the Lord as God's slave. Therefore, I now receive these wages of mine.” On seeing that they persisted on rejecting his request, he would say: “If you do not receive my wages, I shall stay here to serve you and will not go back to worship God.” Fearing that he might do so, his masters would let him do whatever he wanted. However, they would send him away with great honor and full respect, seeking from him to do mercy for their sake, for which he became famous and beloved in the whole Scetis.

A soldier once asked Fr. Mios: “Does God accept repentance, father?” He answered: “Tell me, my beloved son, in case your coat gets torn off, would you throw it away or you would mend it?” When the soldier replied: “I shall certainly mend it.” The saint said to him: “If you man, would keep your coat, will God not keep his creation?”

[The Publications of the Light: The Sayings of the Elder Fathers, Lebanon, 1983]

MISAEI, THE HERMIT

A young man came to the monastery of El-Qalamon and approached its

Abbot Abba Isaac while sitting there. The Abbot made the sign of the Cross on his face, as it was the custom of the monks, and allowed him to come closer. The young man made a metanoia before him, saying: "Father Abba Isaac, accept my lowly person for Christ's sake, and help me save myself by taking me as one of your children." The Abbot was wondering how he knew his name, and the young man said: "The grace residing within you has informed me about it." The Abbot told him: "Sit down. May the Holy God make you a holy temple. Now, tell me about yourself." The young man said: "My name is Misael, my father was a worldly man, quite occupied by it away from the worship of God. However, he was unhappy because he had no child of his own. Then, it happened one day that he was visited by a saintly monk to whom he complained that he was unhappy for not having anyone to inherit his wealth. Therefore, the old monk told him: 'If you mend your ways with God, the Lover of humankind, will give you a blessed seed of your own.' Asking him how he would do that, the monk said: 'Live a life of perfection according to the Divine commandments, pray day and night, regularly go to the church and have a priest as a spiritual father to seek his counsel in all your affairs. If you do so, you and your wife will get your request.' So, my parents followed the old monk's advice, and my mother conceived with me. When I reached six years of age, my parents both passed away, and the bishop cared to raise me, educate me, and to manage my inheritance. On reading the Holy Bible, I longed for the monastic life, and here I am in your hands."

His Monastic Life:

The Abbot was pleased to hear the story of Misael, and he handed him to an old monk to teach him the monastic way of strife and asceticism. Then they eventually clothed him with the monastic attire and its holy Eskeem. Since then, Misael lived in seclusion and strict asceticism. One day, it happened that a brother came to visit him, and he found him standing in prayers. Knocking on the door of his cell, he opened it, and they prayed together, then they exchanged the blessings, and sat talking about the ways to overcome the evil enemy. St. Misael said to his guest: "The devil flees away from prayer coming out of a fervent heart." Ending their spiritual talk, they praised God, and the guest went on his way, to return after a while to find Misael still standing in prayer, and heard him saying: "O my God, save me. Look down on my humiliation, wash me out of my iniquity, for *"When my father and my mother forsake me, then the Lord will take care of me."* (Psalm 27:10)." The guest cried and said to him: "Your body became like a burnt stick." Misael responded by saying: "I give thanks to God who granted me

the eyesight to read the Scriptures, the ears to hear the Divine sermons and the strength to stand to pray.”

Becoming a Hermit:

When the Abbot of the monastery heard about the asceticism of St. Misael and came to visit him, Misael told him: “After three days, some men in soldiers attire will come to seek me from you. Have neither fear nor sadness, because it is the will of God, and allow me to go with them, and you shall know that there will be a famine on the land in this coming year, but I shall come back to you then.” On hearing this, the Abbot purchased an excellent quantity of grains, and eventually, the men in the soldiers' attire came, took Misael, and went their way. When the famine came, the governor came with his men to confiscate whatever he would find in the monastery of grains, but a group of those soldiers stood in his way, and the governor had to back off in failure. Then, the Abbot wanted to welcome those soldiers and to offer them food to eat, but they said to him: “We do not need anything of the sort.” Then, one of them came forward, held the old monk's hand, and said to him: “I am your son Misael, and those men in the soldiers' attire are hermits, who came here last year to take me away with them. Now, I implore you to go to Abba Athanasius, the bishop of my hometown, tell him about me and seek from him my inheritance, then use it to build a church in my name and invite the father bishop to consecrate it.”

So, Abbot Abba Isaac went to the bishop, and he was given 700 measures of gold and 900 measures of silver, many books, and 500 heads of sheep, besides many fabrics and vessels. The Abbot demolished the old house, purchased the neighboring land, and built a church there. While the father bishop was consecrating it, St. Misael, together with the father's hermits, came to attend the consecration ceremony. Then, St. Misael approached Abba Isaac and told him: “Next year, you will depart from this world.” Then, he went his way with the rest of the hermits.

MOUGI (The martyr)

Refer to the two martyrs Thecla and Mougi. Their biography could be found under the letter ‘T.’

MOISES AND HIS SISTER SARAH, (The martyrs)

These two saints were born to wealthy Christian parents. When their parents passed away, St. Moises (Moses) intended to become a monk after

giving his sister Sarah in marriage and handing their whole wealth to her. However, when he discussed the idea with his sister, she responded to him by saying: “If you get married first, then I would follow suit.” He told her: “I have committed so many sins, which I intend to atone for by leading a monastic life, for I cannot get married and care for my salvation at the same time.” She answered him: “How would you cast me in the snares of this world, and care only for your salvation?” Then, he answered her: “Whatever you choose will be yours.” She responded: “All that you would do, I shall also do, for we are of one father and one mother.” Then, they distributed all their wealth to the poor and the needy. St. Moises brought his sister Sarah into a house of virgins, and he joined a monastery near Alexandria, and for the following ten years, they did not see one another.

Their Martyrdom:

Then, when Emperor Decius (249-251 AD) incited persecution against the Christians, in the days of the 14th Pope St. Dionysius the Great (246-264 AD), so many believers were martyred. At that time, St. Moises sent to his sister to bid her farewell, and let her know of his decision to be martyred in the Name of the Lord Jesus Christ. She hastened to her mother-superior, sought to be released, got the blessings of her sisters, and joined her brother on his way to Alexandria. There, they both confessed together the Lord Jesus Christ, and after being tortured by many tools, they had their heads cut off by the sword, and they received the crowns of martyrdom.

[The Synaxarion: 26 Mesra]

MOISES, BISHOP OF OSIM, ST.

St. Moises (Moses) was one of the prominent fathers and saints of the church in the 8th century AD. He was raised on the love of virginity and purity since his childhood, and he studied the church's various subjects.

St. Moises became a monk, since his youth in the wilderness of the Scetis, where he lived in the obedience of a great hermit for eighteen years, during which he walked along the road of virtue and harsh asceticism. He became known for his virtues that he was chosen to be the bishop of Osim (Ouseem), in the district of Embaba in the Beheira governorate. His life as a bishop was an extension of his monastic one in the wilderness. He was living in a life of deprivation and was known for his piety, courage, and zeal on the Orthodox faith. He used to spend most of his time in worship, that it was said that he did not see anyone, except on Saturdays and Sundays.

The Bitterness of Anguish:

During his bishopric, the Umayyad rulers of Egypt subjected the Copts to extremely severe persecutions, and great anguish dwelt upon the church. The bishops returned to their monasteries to concentrate on prayers and fasts, imploring God to lift that anguish. However, St. Moises remained among his people to encourage them and to keep them holding fast to their faith against the snatching wolves. St. Moises also got the grace to perform miracles and signs, healing sicknesses, as well as the grace of prophecy.

Due to these intolerable persecutions at the time, the number of Copts who converted to Islam reached 24,000 persons. When some archons came to seek from St. Moises to pray to the Lord to lift the anguish from His people, he told them: “My children, be assured that the governor who is persecuting you will perish within this month,” and this was what did happen.

Imprisoned along with the Pope:

The last of the Umayyad caliphs Marwan ibn Muhammad (Marwan II: 744-750 AD), arrested the 46th Pope of Alexandria, St. Khael I (743-767 AD). Bishop Moises stayed in the company of the pope, and he longed to be martyred in the Name of the Lord Jesus Christ. When the soldiers brought them to the tent of Marwan, they forced St. Moises on his knees, raised his feet, and beat him with bronze clubs on his sides and neck. His tormentors were seeking from him a bribe to set him free. The saint did not utter a single word, for he did not understand their Arabic language. When Marwan gave the order to cut the head of Pope Khael I, and the swordsman led him to the place of execution, St. Moises ran after him, despite the attempts of the swordsman to keep him away. An angry soldier intended to kill him if it was not for some officials who did not let him do it. Then, he was cast in prison along with Pope Khael I, and their feet were placed in chains, among many others. However, St. Moises prophesied that they would eventually come out safe from that prison, which was realized when Marwan was defeated by the Abbasids dynasty.

His Prophecy concerning the Umayyad Caliphate:

During the revolt of the Coptic Bashmurians (Coptic rebels) due to the intolerable Umayyad persecution, St. Moises disciple asked him a question concerning when that calamity would come to an end, the saint prophesied: “God will not forsake His church to the end, but He will save her, and this caliphate (of Umayyad) will vanish and be replaced by some other.” This prophecy was realized in 750 AD when the Umayyad dynasty was replaced by the Abbasids.

His Departure:

Abba Moises continued to accompany Pope Khael I, faithful to him and to the church all along during the bitter tribulations. Then, when he completed his strife and was in a right old age, he had a short illness and knew the time of his departure. So, he called his congregation, blessed them, commanded them, and asked them to pray for him. They all wept and asked him to remember them before Christ. He stretched out his hand, prayed, bid them farewell, and departed in peace.

The Church of Saint Mina in Marriott:

Bishop Moises was with pope Khael I when the Chalcedonians (Melkites Byzantine Christians) tried to take possession of the great church of St. Mina in Marriott to take away its marble pillars and adornments. They bribed the caliph Marwan II and asked him to issue an order to Ābdel Malek ibn Mousa, the governor of Egypt, to give them the possession of St. Mina's church in Marriott. When the decree was delivered to Ābdel Malek, he held a council under a judge by the name of Āyssa to decide who had the possession of that church, and he asked the two parties to defend their rights before him. Here, Pope Khael I asked the most prominent of his bishops and archons, including St. Moises, to attend the governor's council. Still, as the Chalcedonians bribed the judge, he took the stand against the Orthodox Copts and refrained from listening to their defense. Some archons suggested paying a bribe to the judge to take their side, but St. Moises rejected such a counsel, saying that it would not befit for the pope or the bishops to pay bribes to anyone, and he prophesied that God would never forsake them. Then, when judge Āyssa was about to write his verdict in favor of the Chalcedonians, he was fired from his position and was replaced by another judge called Abu el-Ĥuseiny, who happened to be just and honest. The new judge issued his verdict in favor of the Copts, and the Copts kept St. Mina church in their possession.

The church celebrates him on the 11th of Mesra.

[The Patriotism of the Coptic Church and its History, p. 57]

[The Synaxarium: 11 Mesra]

[The Coptic Encyclopedia: Kha'il I, by Subhi Y. Labib, pp. 1410-2]

MONICA, ST.

Her Childhood:

“O God, You did create her. Although at the time, her parents were not

aware of the value of the precious pearl which they gave birth to.”¹ St. Monica was born in the year 332 in the village Thagaste (nowadays: Souq el-Akhras) in North Africa. She was raised in a genuinely Christian manner. While she was still very young, she used to leave her friends and toys, hide behind a tree, kneel and pray. The more she grew up, the buds of Christianity blossomed in her heart. At the same time, she had splendid beauty, tall stature, sound mind, great wisdom, high esteem, and kindly emotions.

Her Married Life:

“O my God, she was the maidservant of your servants, and all who got to know her, glorified, praised, and loved Your Holy Name residing within her.”² Monica got married against her will to an evil pagan man called Patricius, who had a prominent official position in Thagaste that caused her family to welcome him. Patricius' mother was an evil and envious woman, so were her house servants too. After her marriage, Monica perceived that God wanted for her to carry His Cross, so she did not grumble or complain about her husband's harsh treatment or her mother-in-law's harassments, but showed them the love and humility of Christianity.

Finally, before her meekness and long-suffering, she managed to defeat the evil within her mother-in-law. So, she did not allow any more, her evil servants to bad-mouth Monica to her or Patricius. On the contrary, she even sought from her son to scourge them when they did.

Monica used to receive the wrath of her husband by perseverance, silence, and forgiveness, and once he would calm down, she used to explain to him gently and with compassion, how she suffered from his anger. Eventually, before her perseverance, he showed remorse and promised to mend his ways although he kept resuming with her those anger bursts again and again.

During the first few years of her marriage, St. Monica gave birth to three sons, and the oldest was Augustine. She cared so much for him, and she was comforted by him from her husband's violence and foolishness.

A Life of Prayer and Work:

The righteous saint Monica was characterized by her faith in the power of prayers. She fulfilled the sayings of the fathers: “Blessed is he who stands at the door of prayer.” By her fervent prayers, which were coming out of a heart full of faith, she gained both her evil husband and her son Augustine, who strayed like those of his age at the time. In her heart, she put such strong faith to gain her husband's soul that she used to guide those women who suffered

¹ From St. Augustine's memoirs about his mother St. Monica.

² Ibid.

in the same way, telling them that prayer was the key to comfort. The first fruit of her prayer was that her pagan husband converted and proclaimed the Christian Faith. God responded to her supplications concerning her husband when her son Augustine was seventeen years old. She greatly rejoiced for that change and forgot her sufferings. However, her husband soon fell ill and died, leaving her as a widow while she was still reasonably young. After the death of her husband, she was occupied with raising her children, serving strangers, and worshipping God by going daily to the church. She was granted by God the grace of tears, that she was known by this gift among the believers. She dedicated long hours to visit the sick, serve the poor, comfort the widows, and strengthen the hearts of the women who were married to evil husbands and the mothers of children who have gone astray.

Her Son Augustine Going Astray:

Augustine completed his education in the school of Madaura in Thagaste. He was so smart and talented that he excelled even over his instructors.

His father, before his death, planned to send him to Carthage to spend two more years in higher studies, and Augustine had to stay at home for one year until his father would raise the money needed for the expenses of his research. However, that year in idleness proved to be such a curse on the young man's life. He had nothing to do except being among evil friends. He led them to rob the pear fruits from the gardens of their neighbors, although his backyard was full of it. It was his love of leadership that led him to steal the pears; he then threw them to the pigs.

In Carthage, Augustine was so brilliant in his studies that his heart flared with the love of wisdom. His mother longed for him to have more education, with the hope that more information would probably lead him to the knowledge of God. Instead, when Augustine got older, he strayed pretty severely, and he allowed an older woman to seduce him, and he ended up having several female partners and an illegitimate son.

Augustine did not care at all for his mother's desperate advice. However, once he repented, he used to pray to God, saying: "My pious mother tried to reach me. Her voice, I believe, was the echo of Yours, because she kept firmly exhorting me to forsake the harlots and every kind of fornications, I did not care for her counsel or her words, on account that they came out of a woman, while they were originating from You. My despise of her was a despise of You, and my disrespect for her was as such disrespect for You."

St. Monica put all her focus on prayers, fasting, and tears, hoping that God might bring her son back to his senses. About that, St. Augustine later wrote:

"Weeping for me, my mother shed more tears than any mother who has lost her children through physical death. You, O Lord, listened to her.

You did not forget those tears she shed in her prayers before You, those tears which soaked the face of the earth.”

For twenty years, St. Monica kept chasing after her prodigal son from one town to another, trying to straighten him out, without despair or complaints.

A Comforting Night-Vision:

After having shed so many tears for so many years for the sake of her son, and asking the clergy to pray on his behalf, God finally comforted her in a night-vision: She saw herself standing on a wooden platform while the grief had filled her soul, when a little boy with a shining smile, came to ask her the reason for her grief and unceasing tears. She answered him: “I am crying for the loss of the soul of my son.” The boy said to her: “Look and contemplate, O pious mother! For in the same place you stand now, so your son shall stand.” St. Monica looked, and there she was standing on that high platform along with her son Augustine. On telling that vision to her son, he said to her: “Do not despair, O mother, for you may end up as free as I am.” However, she said to him: “No, the boy in the vision did not say: ‘Wherever your son is so that you will be, but he said: ‘In the same place you stand now, so your son shall stand.’”

Her Strife for the Salvation of her Son:

In the year 382 AD, Augustine traveled to Rome, provoked by his evil friends, seeking the temporal glory and riches. His mother tried in vain to keep him from moving, and then she decided to travel along with him. However, he deceived her by saying that he was going there just to bid a friend a farewell on the boat, and left her drowned in her tears. It happened that the governor of Milan sought from the governor of Rome, to recommend to him a teacher of Eloquence, so he sent Augustine to him. There, Augustine met with St. Ambrose (374-397), the bishop of Milan, whom he loved and admired his sermons because of their superb eloquence, without caring for his salvation.

St. Monica, not surrendering to despair, sailed to Milan to be near her son. There, she begged St. Ambrose to discuss the matter with her son to bring him back to reason. The saint declined to do so, perceiving that there was no use to talk to someone like her son who tended to brag about his logic and reason, and had his way of evasion during any discussion. Still, the saint sought from her to keep on praying, and when she kept on pressing on him, St. Ambrose answered her by his famous phrase: “Go your way, and may the Lord bless you, O woman, be assured that the son of those tears would never perish.” Augustine set forth to Rome for the sake of fame, leaving his mother crying and supplicating to him to stay with her. She did not request that for

her comfort or her longing for him, but rather for worrying about him being away from God. Because he was not yet had acquired the grace of Baptism, and there were no signs of his possible repentance.

Her Son's Repentance:

Finally, after so many years, the prediction of the bishop was realized, and the tears of the mother produced a blessed fruit. Augustine repented and earned the title of 'The Son of Tears,' and for him, St. Monica came to be his mother in flesh and spirit, she delivered him as a man in the world and mourned on him until she offered him as a son of Christ and the church.

After his repentance and getting to know God, he remembered his mother and her flood of tears; St. Augustine said to God: "Your maidservant, who conceived with me, to be born to the temporal light, carried me in her heart to be born for the eternal light. My mother, to whom I believe, all that flow in me of life goes back to her, to her faithful tears to the unceasing tears, for the sake of my mother's tears, I did not perish."

St. Monica traveled to Milan, attended the baptism of her son Augustine on the hand of its great bishop St. Ambrose, his spiritual guide. She had an inexpressible joy, and her heart was raised, along with those who praised, saying: "We praise and bless You, O God. We indeed confess that You are our Lord, whom the earth and its fullness worship, O the Eternal Father, before whom the Cherubim and the Seraphim perpetually glorify, crying out, unceasingly, saying: 'Holy, Holy, Holy.'" After the Baptism, St. Augustine decided to go back to Africa and was accompanied in the ship by his mother, St. Monica. She told him: "O my son, my remaining on earth became now unnecessary. I do not know why I am still living since I have no more wish after all my wishes have been now realized."

Her Departure:

Five days later, she fell terminally ill, and she crossed over to eternity. Before her departure, she told her son: "Bury me wherever you choose, but I seek from you to remember me always before the Altar of God, wherever you go." She delivered her soul and set forth to the Lord Jesus Christ, whom she loved. She departed while she was praying and seeking the intercession of the pure Virgin St. Mary and the saints. Her departure was in the year 387 AD when she was just fifty-six years of age. On her departure, St. Augustine commented: "I felt waves of sorrow stirred up in my heart. I tried to hold myself together, so as not to cry in front of my mother in her last moments, I knelt on my knees before her, the way I would do before the icons in the church."

[Marcus' Magazine House: St. Monica, the Mother of St. Augustine]

MONTANUS, THE DISSENT

His Upbringing:

He was initially from Aradabau, a village in Phrygia in Asia Minor. He appeared in the 2nd half of the 2nd century (around the year 170 AD). He caused a conflict within the Apostolic Church that widely spread, and its effects lasted until the 4th century. Montanus was from a pagan family, and St. Didymus the Blind (313-398 AD, mentioned him as one who used to be an idol priest.¹

His Principles:

3- He taught that the exalted Divine Proclamations did not come to an end by the departure of the apostles. Still, more amazing Proclamations would be expected to happen by the power of the Paraclete. Due to this assumption, a movement full of exciting, emotional reactions appeared among the Christians in Asia Minor. That movement was known after the name of its founder as 'Montanism,' and it was also known as 'The Phrygian Heresy' by the Apostolic church. According to some, Montanus himself claimed to be the Paraclete, but most probably, he claimed to be only the tool through whose tongue the inspiration of the Holy Spirit was given. With this claim, Montanus' followers considered his words as those of God Himself.

It was also said that he was a prophet, and he used to talk as if he was enjoying a condition of overwhelmed Divine vision. He tried to explain to his followers the relationship between him as a prophet and God. He claimed that the prophet is like a musical instrument on which God plays. So, whatever the prophet would utter could not be counted as a human talk, but he would be speaking in the name of God and on His behalf. In one of his quotes, which was documented in the writings of St. Epiphanius of Salamis² (315-403 AD), Montanus said: "I have come, not as an angel or an ambassador, but as God the Father." Among his very enthusiastic followers were two women Priscilla or (Prisca), and Maximilla, who were counted by Montanus and his followers as two hugely revered prophetesses.

St. Clement of Alexandria (150-215 AD), promised to write about 'The Prophecy' as a refutation to the Montanism claims,³ referring to them as

¹ St. 'Didymus the Blind': *The Trinity*, 3-41.

² In his best-known book: the *Panarion* which means "Medicine-Chest" (also known as *Adversus Haereses*, "Against Heresies"), presented as a book of antidotes for those bitten by the serpent of heresy. Written between 374 and 377 AD, it forms a handbook for dealing with the arguments of heretics.

³ St. 'Clement of Alexandria': *The Stromata* (Miscellanies) – written c. 198 – c. 203...

false prophets. Whereas, Tertullian (155-240 AD) defended them in his lost work about 'Being Overwhelmed,' which was in six books. Also, so many came from afar excited about the movement and to meet with the Montanians and to listen to them.

- The Montanians were known for their robust ascetic practices and the length of their fasting. During their fast, they used to refrain from eating meat, drinking wine or fruit juices, and even from taking a bath. They did not allow fasting on Saturdays or Sundays.
- While the Apostolic church views the person's 2nd marriage (after the death of his/her first spouse) as an unfavorable matter, but it is ecclesiastically approved. However, the Montanians, on the other hand, they banned it and even counted it as adultery.
- The Montanians were inflexible in refusing to accept back in their fellowship, those who fall into any serious sins.

Eusebius and the Phrygian Heresy:

The historian, Eusebius of Caesarea (260-339 AD), wrote four chapters in his 5th book of his historical work¹ to talk about this heresy. He quoted from St. Apollinaris (Apollonius/Apolinarius) the bishop of Hierapolis in Phrygia (during the 2nd century) and others. We quote here some of what Eusebius wrote about Montanus and his disciples:

- Montanus, as a recent convert, through his unquenchable desire for leadership, gave the adversary opportunity against him. He became out of his mind, and being suddenly in a sort of frenzy and ecstasy, he raved and began to babble and utter strange things, prophesying in a manner contrary to the constant custom of the church handed down by tradition from the beginning (Chap. 16:7).²
- Some of those who heard his spurious utterances at that time were indignant. They rebuked him as one that was possessed, and that was under the control of a demon, and was led by a deceitful spirit, and was distracting the multitude. They forbade him to talk, remembering the distinction drawn by the Lord and his warning to guard watchfully against the coming of false prophets (Matt. 7:15). Others imagining themselves possessed by the Holy Spirit and by a prophetic gift was elated and not a little puffed up, and forgetting the distinction made by the Lord, they did not challenge the mad and insidious and seducing spirit and were cheated and deceived by him. As a consequence of this, he could no longer be held in check to keep silent. (Chap. 16:8)

¹ 'Eusebius of Caesarea': *Ecclesiastical History*, Bk V, Chap. 16-19...

² *New Advent Internet Site: Fathers of the Church/Church History (Eusebius)/Book V...*

- It was claimed that both Montanus and Maximilla committed suicide, both hung themselves, not at the same time when they were inflicted by a demonic spirit. (Chap. 16:13)
- It is also claimed, as the general report says, that this remarkable person, the first steward of their so-called prophecy, named Theodotus, who as if at some time taken up and received into heaven, fell into trances and entrusted himself to the deceitful spirit, was pitched like a playing dart and died miserably. (Chap. 16:14)
- Montanus' actions and teachings show who this new teacher is. He who gave the two small towns Pepuza and Tymion in Phrygia, the name of Jerusalem, wishing to gather people to them from all directions. He who appointed collectors of money, who forced the receiving of gifts under the name of offerings. He who provided salaries for those who preached his doctrine that his teaching might prevail through gluttony (Chap. 18:2)
- We are told about those two prophetesses that once they claimed to be filled with the Holy Spirit, they deserted their husbands, in contradiction to those who were saying that Prisca was a virgin (Chap. 18:3)¹

These are quotes from Eusebius, who also documented the faults of Montanus followers, such as Alexander. Montanus was tried by the governor of Ephesus, not for defending the Name of Christ, but for the robberies that he committed because he deviated from the right path.

[Wace & Piercy: A Dictionary of the Early Christian Biography]

MONTANUS, LUCIUS & THEIR COMPANIONS ***(The martyrs)***

They were among eight disciples of Cyprian, the martyr. They have been martyred in the year 259 AD in Carthage. Their biography could be found under the letter 'L': SS. Lucius, Montanus & their Companions.

MOSES, THE BLACK (The martyr)

His Upbringing:

Not much is known about the past of St. Moses the Black before his repentance. He was most probably one of the Barbarian tribes. His life was so evil that it was said that there was no sin he did not commit. He was born between the years of 330 and 340 AD. It seems that he was a slave of a head of a tribe that worshipped the sun, but because of his extreme evil nature, his

¹ New Advent Internet Site: Fathers of the Church/Church History (Eusebius)/Book V.

master got rid of him. He turned into a gangster who lived on robbing and killing people. He had a large, muscular stature, which helped him to become the head of an evil gang.

Having Faith in the Lord Jesus Christ:

Even though an extreme evil-doer, yet he kept raising up his eyes towards the sun, believing that it was the true God, seeking from it to proclaim itself to him. Then, he heard a voice telling him to go to the wilderness to encounter the monks of the Scetis, whose fame was widely spread all over the area at that time. He went there, carrying his sword, where he happened to meet with St. Isidore (The Priest of the Cells) coming out of his cell and heading to the church. Terrified by his appearance, the saint asked him: "What do you want from here, O brother?" Moses answered: "I heard that you are a good servant of God. Therefore, I escaped and came to you to let God save me the way he saved you." He continued in persistence and with submission, saying: "I want to remain with you, despite my countless sins and my great evils."

St. Isidore kept asking him about his past life and where he has been. Moses confessed to him all the sins he committed. On seeing how he opened his heart to him, St. Isidore started to teach him and preached him at length the word of God, he told him about the judgment to come and then left him to contemplate.

For hating evil and deciding to rid himself of it, Moses shed so many tears, and deep remorse swept his soul and disturbed his sleep, like a dreadful ghost. Then, he went to St. Isidore, prostrated himself before him, and in a loud voice, he confessed all his evil crimes again, with such contrition of heart that drew his compassion. He took him to Abba Macarius the Great, who put him under his care, taught him and guided him, gave him the grace of baptism, then put him back under the supervision of St. Isidore.

His Monastic Life:

After a while, Moses sought from Abba Isidore to make him a monk. However, Abba Isidore started to explain to him how tough the monastic life is with the constant fight against the demons and the other physical needs. He told him as a way of testing him: "It is better for you son, to go and live in the populated areas," but after seeing his real intention and solid stand, St. Isidore sent him back to Abba Macarius the Great, the father of the wilderness.

Moses stood in the church and confessed publicly about all his sins and evil deeds. Abba Macarius said afterward that he saw during Moses confession a whiteboard with black writings, and with every sin Moses

proclaimed, an angel wiped it out off that board until the board became all-white. After Abba Macarius instructed him, he sent him back to the priest Isidore who clothed him in the monastic attire. He advised him: "Remain, my son in this wilderness and never depart from it, because the day you would leave it, all evil will come back to you. Stay here all your life, and I am sure God will do mercy and grace on you and will crush the devil under your feet."

His Strife:

St. Moses started by dwelling among the monks. Yet, because of the multitudes of visitors, he sought from Abba Macarius to find for him a secluded place, and he guided him to a separate cell, where he dwelt tirelessly with such tremendous spiritual strife, in an attempt to make up for his previous sins and evil deeds. Even though the devil kept reminding him of his dark past, but his spiritual guide Abba Isidore counseled him to stand firm in opposing the old habits which were planted deep in his soul. He mainly complained against the evil carnal desires of Abba Isidore, who kept counseling him to stand fast until the devil would get tired of him. He gave him an example of a stray dog that kept standing before the shop of a butcher, seeking to get something from him, but when the butcher did not respond to it, the dog had to go somewhere else. St. Moses was painfully attacked by the thoughts of adultery, so viciously that he could not stay in his cell. So, he went to ask help from St. Isidore, who told him to go back to his cell, but he refused, saying to the saint: "I cannot endure any more of it." Father. Abba Isidore took him up to the roof and asked him: "Look towards the west." There, he saw an uncountable crowd of demons, in great chaos, as though preparing for war. He then asked him: "Look towards the east." There, he saw a great number of hosts of glorious saintly angels, about whom the saint said to Moses: "Look, these have been sent by God to help the saints, against those in the west. Those who are on our side are far more than those who are against us." Afterward, Moses was encouraged, gave thanks to God, and returned to his cell.

Obeying the counsel of his father of confession, Moses fatigued his body by standing a long time in prayers, fasting, and doing metanoias. To discipline his body further, he used to go around the cells of the older monks at night, take their water pots and fill them with water from a well at a far distance from the monastery. Getting fed up with his harsh strife, the devils caught him once at the well, beat him so violently, and left him unable to move, until some brethren happened to come to the well, and they carried him to the church to Abba Isidore. He cared for him for three days until he

regained his ability to move.

Once four thieves tried to rob his cell, but he tied them together and carried them to the church. When the thieves realized that he was Moses, who used to be the head of a gang of thieves, they repented and wanted to become monks. St. Moses preached them with words that moved their hearts.

Because of his great strife, the devils were stirred more against him, that his mentor Abba Isidore counseled him to moderate in his ascetic practices to keep them from causing him more troubles. He sought from him to deliver himself to God, and He alone would be able to alleviate that fight on him. Abba Isidore told him that, to keep him from thinking that by his ascetic efforts, he could overcome the demons, but by humility and spiritual repentance, God would fight on our behalf.

Ordained as a Priest:

Because of his strife and virtues, they decided to ordain him as a priest. They arranged that the ordination would be performed at the patriarchate in Alexandria. However, the patriarch wanted to test Moses before ordaining him, so he ordered his priests that once they see him about to enter into the sanctuary, to drive him out saying: "Get out of here, O you with the blackface." When they did that to him, the patriarch sent a deacon after him, and he heard him saying: "They did what you deserved Moses, for you are not a human, but dared to mix with men. Why then would you venture to sit among them?" St. Moses was ordained as a priest by the hand of the 23rd Pope St. Theophilus (385-412 AD), who heard at the time a voice saying: "Worthy, Worthy, Worthy," and after putting the white robe on him, they said to him: "There you became all-white Moses." He responded by saying with humility: "I wish this to be true on the inside as it is on the outside."

His Virtues:

He lived denying himself that a governor, hearing about his virtues, longed to see him. When Moses knew about that, he ran away, but it happened that the saint passed by the governor in his way to the monastery, and he inquired from him about the location of father Moses' cell. St. Moses told him: "What do you want from such an old man, who is far from being upright." The governor was disturbed and went to the monastery and told the monks about what happened. On understanding the monks how that monk looked like, they knew that it was no one but Fr. Moses, who denied himself.

Because of his love, humility, strife, and intense asceticism, he was granted by God to perform miracles and signs.

A monk fell into a specific iniquity, and a meeting was held to discuss an appropriate penance. Moses was invited to attend, but he refrained from

going. When they insisted on having him, he came carrying a bag of sand with a hole in the back, which he explained by saying: “My sins run out behind me and I do not see them, but today I am coming to judge the errors of another.” On hearing this, the assembled monks forgave their sinful brother.

For some reason, it was proclaimed an obligation in the Scetis to fast for a week. During that week, some guests came to visit Fr. Moses. He prepared food for them to eat. On seeing smoke rising from his cell, the brethren said to one another: “Look, Moses has broken his fast and is preparing food for himself. We shall talk to him about it.” When they got to know the facts, they said to him: “Father Moses! You have disregarded the commandment of men, but kept that of God (i.e., giving hospitality to strangers).”

His Martyrdom:

Then, it happened that the Barbarians came to attack the monastery, an incident St. Moses knew by Spirit beforehand, and he sought from the brethren to escape. However, seven brethren stayed behind, and they asked him: “Are you not going to escape, father?” He answered: “For a long time, I waited for this day, for the words of the Lord Jesus Christ to be fulfilled: *“All who take the sword will perish by the sword”* (Matt. 26:52). They said to him: “We shall stay with you and will not escape.” He told them: “There, they are already at the gate.” The Barbarians entered the monastery and killed them all. However, when one of the seven escaped to the stronghold out of fear, he saw seven crowns coming down from heaven on the seven martyred monks. Then, he hastened to come down and ran forward to receive his crown of martyrdom.

So, Abba Moses completed his strife on the 24th of Paona in the year 408 AD, when he was seventy-five years old (or eighty-five). He earned three crowns: the 1st for love and intense asceticism, the 2nd for monasticism and priesthood, and the 3rd for martyrdom. He was counted the first martyr in the Scetis, and he had so many great teachings. His body was kept along with that of his spiritual guide Abba Isidore in one tube at the Paramus monastery in Natrun Valley.

Of his Sayings:

- To a brother in the Scetis who sought from him a word of encouragement, he said: “Go and sit in your cell, it will teach you everything.”
- The man who flees from the world is like ripe grapes, but he who dwells among the distractions of men is like sour grapes.
- If we keep the commandments of our fathers, I promise you that the

Barbarians would never come here, but if we do not, this place will soon become desolate.

- According to Fr. Poemen, Fr. Moses was once asked: “How can a man become like dead to his neighbor?” The older saint said to him: “Unless a man keeps in his heart that he has been three days in the grave, he will not be strong enough to do that.”
- It is better for a man to put himself to death rather than his neighbor, and he should not condemn him in anything.
- It is good for a man to die to every work which is evil before he departs from the body, so as not to offend anyone.
- Unless a man feels in his heart that he is a sinner, God will not listen to him. A brother asked him about the meaning of that, and the saint said: “Whoever focuses on his sins, would never see those of his neighbor.”
- Unless your prayers conform to your behavior, your struggle would not be of any benefit. When the saint was asked to explain, he said: “We should apply what we pray about, for when man forsakes his own will, he reconciles with God and God will listen to his prayers.”
- A brother asked him: “What would help the man in his every endeavor?” He answered him: “God is the One who helps, for it is so written: *“God is our refuge and strength. A very present help in trouble”* (Psalm 46:1).”
- When the brother added: “What then is the benefit of fasting or spending sleepless nights, father?” The saint answered: “These practices make the soul meek and humble, for it is written: *“Look on my affliction and my pain, and forgive all my sins”* (Psalm 25:18). So, once the soul reaps the fruits of these practices, God would have compassion on her.”
- Then, the brother asked: “What will man do with every temptation he encounters or every evil thought coming to him?” The saint answered: “He should pour tears in prayers before the goodness of God, for Him to help, and he would be getting comfort, if his prayer was from the heart, for it is written: *“The Lord is on my side, I shall not fear. What can man do to me?”* (Psalm 118:6)”
- Then, the brother asked: “If a man beat his servant for something wrong he did, what should the servant say?” The saint answered: “If he was a good servant, he would possibly say: ‘Have mercy on me, for I made a mistake.’ Thus, he would blame himself and draw the mercy of his master.”
- In general, a man should never condemn his neighbor. When in the Old, the hand of God came heavy on the firstborn of the Egyptians, there was no house without a dead son in it. For us, it meant that we should concentrate on our sins and not worry about those of our neighbors, for it

would be unreasonable for a man to leave his dead son, and go to mourn that of his neighbor.

To die about your neighbor means to worry about your sins and not to care for the sins of any man, good or bad. You should not do wrong to anyone, or think bad about anyone else in your heart or despise anyone for doing wrong. You should not obey anyone who harmed his neighbor or rejoice for him. You should never slander anyone, but always say that God knows everybody's heart. Do not go along with the man who talks bad about his neighbor, because it would make you fall in condemnation. Do not have hatred against anyone. Do not have a grudge in your heart against anyone, and do not hate the man who is hostile toward his neighbor. This would bring you peace.

[Sayings of the Strong Saint Abba Moses, Coptic Orthodox Church of Alexandria-
Diocese of Los Angeles]

[Moses the Black: On the Internet Site of OrthodoxWiki]

[Moses the Black: On the Internet Site of Wikipedia]

MOSES THE HERMIT

St. Moses, the hermit, was born in Alexandria. Once he reached the age of thirteen years, he set forth to the wilderness of the Scetis. There, he dwelt for twenty years in a small cell next to one of the older monks. Then, he went deep in the wilderness and lived for thirty-five years in a spot having olive and palm trees. There, he ate according to his needs whatever would fall from the trees, drank from the rainwater, dressed in palm leaves, and befriended the wild beasts.

His Multiple Falls and Repentances:

Satan envied this hermit, so he appeared to him in the form of an older man. The older man told him that he used to live a corrupt life, but he repented and distributed his wealth to the poor. He lived in one of the Five Western Cities (Pentapolis) near Cyrenaica (Barqa), and that God revealed to him that the hour of his death was approaching. They walked together in the wilderness until they reached a grand mansion. Then, the older man told the hermit that after his death, that mansion would be his, if he would marry his daughter. Moses was deceived and thought that the older man was on the brink of extinction, so he accepted his offer. However, once he declared his acceptance, he found himself amid the wilderness, hungry and afraid. He could not see any mansion there, and he realized that it was a trick from the devil. He felt how he was so weak and offered sincere repentance.

Once St. Moses also went to Alexandria, where the devil appeared to him

in the form of a girl. She managed to convince him to spend the night at her place. Then, she claimed to him that she was the daughter of one of the kings and that she wanted him to marry her, quoting the honor of the marriage of the fathers: Ibrahim, Isaac, and Jacob. He accepted her request. Then, she claimed that she was a Jew, and he had to convert to her religion to be able to marry her. So, Moses was blinded, and he denied his Christ. Then, she (the deceptive devil) took him back to the wilderness, where a whole gang of devils ridiculed him and made so much fun of him. Finally, the hermit woke up and cast himself on the dust and kept crying and supplicating to the Compassionate God to forgive him. God sent him Abba Samuel, who told him that he would be departing after three days. Then, he took him to the church, where he gave him Communion in the Holy Sacraments after confessing all that the devil has done to him. St. Moses, the hermit, reposed in peace and was buried by Abba Samuel, who wrote his biography, and handed it to someone traveling to Alexandria for the benefit of the believers.

[The Hermit Fathers, Part 2, p. 25]

MOSES, THE LIBYAN, ST.

This saint was from Libya. He was so humble and compassionate all the time that God granted him the grace to perform the miracles of healing the sick. He once said: “When I was young, I lived in a monastery. There, it happened that eight monks dug a well, and seventy others built a wall around it, in the hope that they would get water from it. They dug it down to the depth of about twenty yards, but no water was found. They were very much grieved and intended to fill it up with dirt. However, by noontime, when Abba Pieour came over suddenly to the location of the well and was informed about what they were doing, he rebuked them saying: ‘Why did you despair, O you of little faith?’ Then, he went down to the bottom of the well, and he prayed there. Afterward, he pushed an iron rod in the well bottom three times, saying: ‘O God of the saints, I pray, do not waste the effort of these men, but send them plenty of water.’ In a short while, the water erupted from the well and wetted everyone around.

After praying a thanksgiving prayer, Abba Pieour intended to go in his way. They tried to make him have a meal with them, but he said: ‘I have accomplished what I came here to do, I did not come here to eat.’”

This was a good lesson for the brethren about faith and the trust in God.

[The Paradise of the Saints, p. 69]

MOSES, THE CONFESSOR

This St. Moses (Moyses) was a Roman priest of Jewish roots. He was one of the main members of a congregation of confessors in the time of Cyprian, at the start of the heresy of Novatian.¹ The rest of the confessors were: Fr. Maximus, the priest, the two deacons Nicostratus and Rufinus, the laymen Urbanus, Sidonius, Macarius, and Celerinus. According to Cyprian, they were the first group of confessors in the days of the persecution stirred up by Emperor Decius (249-251 AD). At the time of the persecution, they wrote down a message to exhort the confessors in Carthage to be committed to the system and wrote another message to Cyprian.

After spending about a year in prison (eleven months and few days), St. Moses reposed in January 251 AD, and was counted as a confessor, and even as a martyr. It was said that a little while before his departure, Moses refused to have any contact with Novatian or the five priests who were supporting him and followed his views. St. Moses was considering their faith and views as unorthodox.

[A Dictionary of Christian Biography, Vol. III, p. 948]
[Baring-Gould: November 25]

MOSES, THE RECLUSE BISHOP, ST.

The Tribes of Saracens:

The Arabian tribes populating the area of Rhinoclura in-between the eastern Egyptian border and the Asian shores, used to worship the stars. Then in the year 226 AD, these tribes embraced Christianity through the efforts of Origen (184-253 AD). Then, those tribes² joined forces together and formed one State under the reign of a queen called Mavia. By their unity, they created a power block that brought fear to the Arian Emperor Valens (364-378 AD) and forced him to seek a peace treaty with them.

Choosing Moses as a Bishop:

Those Christian tribes having united together, they felt the need for a bishop to shepherd them. It happened that in those days, there was a recluse monk named Moses in the eastern desert, he was so beloved by those tribesmen that they decided to choose him to be their bishop. Then, when

¹ 'Novatian' was a Roman bishop and theologian of the 3rd century who took a strict position on readmission of apostates during the persecutions at the time...

² These tribes were known by the name 'Saracens'... It is worth mentioning that the name 'Saracens' was given by the Greeks and the Romans to the nomadic tribes in the 'Sino-Arabian' desert...

Emperor Valens sought to hold a treaty with queen Mavia and her people, the queen accepted on one condition, that the Emperor would see to it that the Egyptian monk Moses would go to Alexandria to be ordained as a bishop by the patriarch there. Although the queen was not yet converted to Christianity, she still made that condition to reflect the wish of her people. Emperor Valens accepted her situation because of his strong desire to make peace with those united tribes.

Moses Refused to be Ordained by Arian Hands:

On arriving at Alexandria, Moses found there Lucius the Arian archbishop who took over St. Mark's throne by force from the 20th Pope St. Athanasius the Apostolic (328-373). All the other Orthodox bishops were in exile. Then, St. Moses stood amid St. Mark Cathedral and said with a loud voice: "Even though I am not worthy of the honor of a bishop, yet I consented in response to the love of those who chose me and gave me their trust. Yet, I shall never accept to be ordained by the hand of one of the deniers of the Divinity of my beloved Lord and Savior. If you let me be ordained by an Orthodox bishop, I shall accept from his hand this great honor. However, if you do not agree, then let me go back to my seclusion in the desert."

The Emperor's men tried in vain to make Moses change his mind, and they failed in trying to convince queen Mavia to stop her support for the monk Moses or to make her people choose somebody else. Finally, they had to take the monk to the nearest location of the exiled Orthodox bishops, where he was ordained amid the exultation of the people. The people's joy was mixed with admiration of monk Moses, who bravely refused to submit to his tyrant opponents and exposed the falseness and helplessness of the Arians.

Bishop Moses went to the flock that loved him and respected him, dedicated his life and effort to serve those who supported him against the opponents of Orthodoxy. He kept on moving from one place to another, not having a steady residence, teaching, preaching, and converting multitudes to Christianity, and queen Mavia finally accepted the faith. He also managed to establish peace between his people and the Romans. Since then, the land of Arabia came under the St. Mark umbrella. Finally, St. Moses reposed in the year 372 AD.

[The Story of the Coptic Church, Bk 1, p. 347]
[Baring-Gould: February 7]

MOTIUS, FR.

A brother once asked Fr. Motius, saying: "If I abandon the world to dwell somewhere else, how would you like me to live?" The elder father answered

him: "If you dwell somewhere, do not place in it anything under your name. Do not go out for meetings or eat in happy banquets, because this generates in you a false appearance which would bring you sorrow and restlessness. People are so anxious to find somebody like that." The brother asked him again: "Then, what can I do?" The elder father answered: "Wherever you dwell, behave the same way as all the others. Whatever the trustworthy pious are doing, you do too; then, you will find comfort. Humility is to be equal to everybody, for when the people see your work according to the law and not deviating from it, they will view you on the same level as all the others, and they will never disturb you."

Being Pleased with People Hostile to Him:

Fr. Motius's disciple Fr. Isaac told about his mentor that the older saint first built a monastery in Arakla, then moved to another location, where he also made a monastery. In that second location, there was a brother who always opposed him and disturbed him, and became like a thorn in his side. The elderly saint abandoned that location and went to his village, where he built a monastery which he closed on himself. Eventually, the elders of the monastery which he deserted came to him along with the brother who was hostile to him and planned on asking him to accept him in his new monastery. When they approached the place where Fr. Motius was and knocked on the door, the elder put a ladder and looked down from the window. Recognizing them, he asked: "Where is your luggage?" They answered: "We left it with the brother so & so." Once Fr. Motius heard the name of the brother who used to disturb him, he broke the door open out of joy and ran to where the brother was. He worshipped before him, brought him into his cell, and honored him for three days. The brother was so pleased with such an attitude, which he did not expect. Later on, the brother left with the rest of the visitors.

St. Motius was ordained as a bishop, on account of that he had the grace to perform signs and miracles, so was his disciple Isaac, who was ordained as a bishop as well.

[Publications of the Light: The Sayings of the Elder Fathers, Lebanon 1983]

MUCIUS (The martyr)

St. Mucius (Mocius) was a Christian priest who was martyred in the persecution stirred up by Emperor Diocletian (284-305 AD). His biography indicates that he was a prominent sermon-giver who preached in Amphipolis in Macedonia.

It happened that during the feast of god Bacchus (Dionysus), this saint

dared to cast on the ground whatever was on the idol's Altar with all their sacrifices. When the pagans wanted to kill him, the governor arrested him instead and brought him to trial. The judge condemned him to be burned alive. There in the fiery furnace, the saint was seen walking unharmed in flames, along with three strangers. Later on, the saint was sent to Heraclea, where he was tortured by the hinbazeen. Then, he was cast before hungry wild beasts, but they refrained from touching him. He was finally sent to Byzantium (Constantinople), where his head was cut off by the sword in the year 304 AD.

[Butler: May 13]

[Hieromartyr Mocius, the Presbyter of Amphipolis in Macedonia: The Orthodox Church in America (On the Internet)]

MUSTIOLA (The lady martyr)

Thinking that he could wipe out utterly every trace of the Christian religion and the Christian believers, Emperor Aurelian (270-275 AD) ordered to torture, kill and lead all Christians to damnation.

In the Italian city of Tuscany, the governor put a pious priest called Felix under arrest, tortured him, then finally cut his head off by the sword. When his deacon Irenaeus cared to bury his body, he was put in prison together with so many others. With genuine bravery and determination, a noblewoman called Mustiola served deacon Irenaeus and those Christians locked up in jail.

Then, when St. Mustiola saw how the executioners were torturing the deacon Irenaeus and how they tore off the flesh of his body and put flames on his sides, she could not endure anymore and screamed in the face of the governor, saying: "How could you shed much innocent blood, O you evil one?" On hearing those fiery words, the governor ordered to tie the woman with ropes and to bring her to trial. There, she showed rare courage during her questioning. The governor attempted to seduce her with valuable rewards to deny her faith, but she instead rebuked him in public. So, he ordered his men to scourge her until her flesh was torn apart, and she delivered her soul to receive the crown of martyrdom.

MUQADDEM IBN MALEK, THE HASHEMITE (The martyr)

There was someone in Iraq called Muqaddem ibn Malek, living in the city of Bagdad. This evil man was known as the Hashemite, and he was so fond of riding his horse accompanied by his men every day to attack the Christian churches while the Holy Sacraments were being sanctified during the Holy Mass (Liturgy). After forcing himself to get into the church while riding his

horse, he would grab the Holy Bread from the Altar, would break it into pieces, mix it with dust, and then he would spill the wine from the Chalice. Afterward, he would go to another church and would do the same thing again and again. Most of the priests in Bagdad avoided performing any Liturgies, and the churches there had almost no services for fear of what this man was doing to them.

However, God decided to draw this Muqaddem ibn Malek without him knowing it. So, it happened that he intruded into one of the churches as he used to do, then he entered into the Altar. At this moment, God opened his eyes that he could see a beautiful, noble Baby lying on the Platen of the Oblation... Once the Liturgy came to an end, and the people got out of the church, the Hashemite called the priest. Then, the man told him what he saw. The priest said to him: "Master, there was nothing in the Altar except the Bread and Wine." When he realized that that secret was revealed only to him, he inquired from the priest: "I wish if you can tell me the secret of this Corban." The priest started to tell him all about how the Lord Jesus Christ founded the Eucharist. He said to him: "God revealed to you this great secret for the sake of your Salvation." Then, the priest read to him what came in the Holy Bible and explained to him the Holy Sacraments. The Hashemite's heart longed to embrace Christianity. He told his men to go, spent the night with the priest, who baptized him, and he became a Christian.

His Martyrdom:

On the next day, when his men came back with the horse, he sent them away without talking to them. When they knew what happened, they went and told his father. The Hashemite's father tried his best to make him change his mind, but he was very sure of his new faith. Then, the father delivered him to severe suffering. When he did not quit his faithfulness, his head was cut off by the sword in the name of the Lord Jesus Christ, and he received the crown of martyrdom. The Christian in Bagdad honored his body and built a church over his tomb, which became known as The Hashemite church.

[The Patriotism of the Coptic Church and its History, p. 109]

MYRON, THE PRIEST (The martyr)

This saint was born in the 3rd century AD, to a rich father called Patrice, who possessed a vast and expanding wealth. St. Myron whenever he was reminded by his family's wealth, would think instead of its transience and of the mortality of the world as a whole. Therefore, he trained himself to visit the poor and the needy, to sit with them, to comfort them, and to help them

with the limited resources given to him by his father. By doing that, he was beloved by all, and people gathered around him. He used to spend time with them, not just to help with their material needs, but to contemplate into the love of the Lord Jesus Christ for the world and His teachings and life-giving commandments.

Ordained as a Priest:

Later on, St. Myron was ordained as a priest in the city of Cyzicus in Acaia in Asia Minor. There, he cared for the flock of Christ with faithfulness and heartily loved. He left no one in need of money or any material needs, and he cared more for the souls of his flock and their spiritual life that the fame of his work spread like a sweetly fragrant, just like his name, which means: Of sweet fragrance. He transformed his ranch and all his buildings to harbors of Salvation for all believers. He turned them into churches, hospitals, and orphanages to serve his spiritual children. He dedicated his whole self to fulfill the spiritual needs of his people and to spread the faith in the Lord Jesus Christ, an activity that made him widely known across the Roman Empire.

Satan was provoked to anger and stirred up the pagan governor Antipater who was appointed by Emperor Decius (249-251 AD). So, on the eve of the glorious feast of Nativity, Antipater attacked the church with his men and beat the believers, burned down the church, then put the priest and the believers in chains and led them to the court of justice. There, they were threatened to be tortured and killed if they refused to worship the idols and deny their faith in the Crucified Lord Jesus Christ. Although they appeared from outside as humble, simple and illiterate people, they all without exception, remained on their faith as solid as rocks. So, to make the priest an example before all of them, the evil governor tied him to a post and scourged him in a public place. Then, he struck him with spears not to kill him, but rather to cause him intense pain.

Antipater then ordered his men to cast the saint and all the believers in a sizeable fiery pit and burn them alive. There, they all received the crowns of martyrdom, preferring death to forsake their worship to the Lord Jesus Christ. As to St. Myron, who did not die of fire, they took him out and cut his head off by the sword, to receive the crown of martyrdom on the 17th of August 250 AD.

[The Martyrs and Saints: Pt. 4, Publications of the pope 'Cyril's Children, p. 44]

N

NABOR AND FELIX (The martyrs)

SS. Nabor and Felix were two martyrs who were strongly commended by St. Ambrose of Milan (374-397 AD). Great multitudes set forth to Milan to honor them. According to the tradition, they were Moorish soldiers in the army of Emperor Maximian Herculus (286-310), who camped in Milan; and were executed by the sword for the sake of their faith around the year 303.

[Butler: July 12]

NADIA EUSINA¹

The biography of this very gentle virgin, who suffered for the sake of her Christian Faith under the Communist authorities, became known through the spiritual letters which were sent to her by her good girlfriend, the confessor Niola Sadonita in the year 1975. Having been in the final year of her medical school, the Communist authorities put her under arrest; and condemned her to seven years in exile. Nadia, heard that verdict calmly and with thanksgiving without losing her peace, and prayed for the sake of her persecutors. In the concentration camp, she worked from early morning to late evening in a glass factory. This resulted in a considerable deterioration of her health, particularly in her eyesight and respiratory system, but her harsh work and getting to suffer several illnesses did not keep her from being committed to prayers, attached to God, or having her heart full of love toward her persecutors.

NAKHLA IBRAHIM, MUĀALLEM

Muāallem Nakhla Ibrahim was one of the archons of the church at the beginning of the 19th century. His father muāallem Ibrahim Nakhla, of the village of Um-Khenan in Giza, became one of the most prominent scribes in the court of the ruler Moḥammed Āli Pasha (1805-1848).

Muāallem Ibrahim let his older son Nakhla join the preschool affiliated with the church, as it was the custom of the Copts at the time. Once he

¹ A contemporary figure who she and her friend challenged the atheistic thought in the Soviet Union.

reached the age of maturity, his father brought him over to train him on the official works of the courts, where he showed such prominence in the different aspects of clerical works, that Sherif Pasha the Great took him to be his secretary. As the pasha lived in Alexandria at the time, muâallem Nakhla moved there together with his household. Then, it happened that the ruler Moḥammed Āli Pasha sought from his head scribe, muâallem Wahba, to provide him with a comprehensive account of the country's finances. However, muâallem Wahba was not able to do it to the great ruler's satisfaction. So, Moḥammed Āli angrily removed him from his post. Sherif Pasha, who fully trusted his secretary muâallem Nakhla, referred to him the request of the great ruler. Muâallem Nakhla was deeply shaken about that request, for fear that he would end up like muâallem Wahba. However, Nakhla sought the intercession of St. Mark the Evangelist and vowed to give to the church the whole land and buildings he possessed in Alexandria.¹ He then went to Ras el-Teen palace and met with Moḥammed Āli Pasha. There, he stayed for a few days, during which he managed to complete the requested work to the satisfaction of the pasha, who greatly commended him.

From the palace, muâallem Nakhla instantly set forth to St. Mark Cathedral, gave thanks to God and appreciation to His saint. Then, he went to meet with the officials of the church to finalize his vow; before going back home. Muâallem Nakhla gave birth to three sons: Ibrahim, Saleḥ, and Samâan, whom he raised in a Christian way. Of his grandchildren was deacon Kamel Saleḥ Nakhla the well-known historian, who wrote several books and essays about the popes of Alexandria, the metropolitans of Jerusalem See, and others.

[The Story of the Coptic Church; Bk 4, p. 291]

NAMPHAMO (The martyr)

St. Namphamo (Namphanio), along with his companions: Lucitas, Mygdon (Miggin), and Samae (Saname), were the first to be martyred in Africa. That martyrdom took place in the year 180 AD, and it was during the days of governor Saturninus, who was the first to persecute the Christians, according to Tertullian. What we know about the biography of St. Namphamo is what was written in a letter between Maximus of Madaura and St. Augustine. From this correspondence, it was concluded that these martyrs were among the Carthaginians and not the Roman citizens. The Western Church celebrates him on the 4th of July.

¹ This land is located now between Sherif, Sisostrees streets; the Coptic Church, and Toson Street.

NARCISSUS, BISHOP OF GERONA (The martyr)

St. Narcissus was born in the east, he preached the Gospel in Rhaetia (Raetia) in central Europe, where he managed to convert St. Afra of Augsburg¹ from a life of sin to a life of repentance. Then, he traveled to Spain, where he preached with great success and became the bishop of Gerona, a city in Catalonia. He received the crown of martyrdom in Gerona, Spain, along with his deacon Felix of Africa, during the persecution stirred up by Emperor Diocletian (284-305 AD).

The Western Church celebrates St. Narcissus on the 18th of March.

[A Dictionary of Christian Biography: Narcissus (2), Vol. IV, p. 3]

NARCISSUS, BISHOP OF JERUSALEM, ST.

This St. Narcissus (Narcicus) was advanced in age when he became the head of the Church of Jerusalem. According to the historian Eusebius, the church, there used to remember the many miracles God performed on his hands. Among those miracles was that once on the night of Passover, the deacons could not find oil to light the chandeliers in the church, so St. Narcissus prayed on some water, then asked the deacons to pour it in the chandeliers. When they did that, the water instantly turned into oil.

Life of Seclusion:

Although this saint received the respect and honor from many of his people, yet some evil-doers who were not comfortable with his strictness in keeping order, accused him of a certain crime. Eusebius did not specify the accusation, and it was not believed by the majority of his people. However, the saint found it an excuse to forsake Jerusalem to spend his time in seclusion, for which he was yearning for so long.

Back to his Throne:

When the saint left Jerusalem, the bishops in the neighboring diocese tried to fill that post in order not to leave the church without a shepherd. So, they set as a bishop: Dius, followed by Germanicus, then Gordius; to serve the Church of Jerusalem. During the time of Gordius, bishop Narcissus reappeared as though he was raised from the dead after he spent several years in seclusion. His people greatly rejoiced to have him back. Bishop Gordius

¹ A city in Bavaria, Germany.

sought from him to start again his bishopric, but he refused to do so and asked him to continue in his service. So, Gordius did serve for a year until he reposed, and Narcissus sat on his throne, yet, being very old and weak. So, owing to his very advanced age, he assigned St. Alexander to assist him. St. Alexander wrote a message around the year 212 AD, in which he mentioned that St. Narcissus reached 116 years of age. Finally, St. Narcissus reposed in peace around the year 215 AD at the age of 119 years old.

[Butler: October 29]

[The Synaxarion: 1 Baramhat]

[A Dictionary of Christian Biography: Narcissus (1), Vol. IV, p. 3]

NARSES AND HIS COMPANIONS (The martyrs)

An Encounter with the King:

In the 4th year of the great persecution, stirred up by the king of Persia Shapur II (309-379 AD); Narses the bishop of Sciarchadata (Sahgerd) in the province of Beth-Garma in Persia, and his disciple Yousef were arrested. This happened while the king was in the city. When these two were brought before the king, he said to the bishop: “Your advanced years and the youth of your disciple make me have compassion on you both. Therefore, I exhort you to consider your well-being and to worship the sun; for then, I shall bestow on you so many gifts.” St. Narses answered him, saying: “Your sweet words will never deceive us. Having reached eighty years of age, I have served God since my childhood, and I do pray to Him to keep me from such a great evil of denying Him by worshipping the creation of His hands.” Then, the king started to threaten that he would kill them. So, the saint told him: “Even if you could kill us seven times, we shall never surrender.”

A Joyful Interaction between the Bishop and his Disciple:

The two martyrs were taken outside the city, followed by a great crowd. In the location of martyrdom, Yousef said to his mentor: “Look, father, your people are watching you; they are waiting for you to dismiss them in peace before you go home.” The bishop hugged him, saying: “I am so exultant, my blessed son, to see how you broke down the snares of this world and entered through the narrow gate, which leads to the Kingdom of Heaven.” Then, they were both beheaded and received the crowns of martyrdom in the year 343.

The Martyrdom of a Eunuch from the Royal Palace:

Among many who received the crowns of martyrdom in those events was

a eunuch from the royal palace, who refused to sacrifice to the idols. The royal order was given to Vardan to kill him by his own hands. Vardan was initially a Christian priest who denied his faith out of fear during his trial. Then, the denier approached the martyr, and when he looked at him, he trembled and could not do it. The martyr said to him: "Being a priest, how can you kill me? I am surely wrong to call you a priest. Now come forth and fulfill your orders, but keep in mind the treason of Judas and how he ended up." Here, the miserable Vardan approached the saint and, with trembling hands, stabbed him until he died. In this way, the eunuch received the crown of martyrdom.

[Baring-Gould: November 20]

NASERA (The martyr)

For St. Nasera (or Victoria in Latin);¹ refer to the biography of her sister the martyr Anatolia under the Letter 'A.'

NATALIA AND ADRIAN (The martyrs)

A Debate with the Caesar:

Adrian (Hadrian) was a young pagan man who worked as a head clerk under Caesar Galerius (E: 305-311 AD), who judged the Christians in the days of Emperor Diocletian (284-305 AD). It happened that Galerius went to the capital city Nicomedia, where they brought for him twenty-three Christians for trial. The Christians showed such high courage, which strongly impressed Adrian the pagan. When Galerius called his clerk to write down a report for their case; Adrian had the following debate with him:

- + Shall I write down my name along with them; for I am also a Christian?
- Are you out of your mind? Do you want to lose your life?
- + No sir I am not out of my mind. I was that way before, but now, I have a sound mind.
- Shut up, and ask my forgiveness. If you confess before everyone that what you just have said was wrong, I shall wipe it out from the court report.
- + No, I would instead seek the forgiveness from God for my past evil deeds, and the sins of my youth.
- Come and sacrifice before the gods, as I and everybody else do.
- + You are wrong. Why should you force others to do wrong? By doing that,

¹ 'Nasera' is the Arabic equivalent to 'Victoria.'

you would lose your soul and those of the miserable people who would get provoked into worshiping your lifeless gods and forsake God who created heaven, earth, the sea, and all that on and in them?

- Do you think that our gods are insignificant? They are great.
- + I see them, neither high nor little. They are nothing at all.
- Come on, confess before the gods, to regain your job. You are not like the other prisoners. You are the son of a nobleman and in the prime of your youth; and have a big chance to get higher and higher. Whereas, those others are just miserable farmers.
- + If you know something about those saints, their spiritual riches, and the final place that they are looking forward to, you would cast yourself at their feet, implore them to pray on your behalf, and you will crush your gods down by your own hands.

Here, Galerius gave his order to cast Adrian on the ground and keep beating him with rods, while shouting at him saying: “Stop blaspheming the gods.” Then, Galerius ordered his men to stop beating Adrian. Having compassion on him; he said:

- See how I want to rescue you. Now just call the gods with your tongue, and I shall call the physicians to bandage your wounds; and today, you will be a guest in my palace.
- + I would be willing to do that, if the gods asked me with a loud voice, to do what the emperor ordered to be done.
- What are you saying? They cannot talk.
- + Why then, would you sacrifice to such dumb and mute things?

Adrian was then brought back to prison.

An Amazing Inheritance:

When Adrian's Christian wife Natalia, whom he married just thirteen months earlier; heard about what happened to her pagan husband; she hastened to the prison, kissed the chains of her husband, saying: “Blessed you are Adrian, for you found the treasures which you did not inherit from your parents. These treasures which even the rich will seek, in the day when no father, mother, children, friends, or any worldly possessions, would be of any benefit.”

Bidding his Wife Farewell:

After a little while, Natalia left him to care for and guide his other Christian companions in prison. Then, once Adrian knew the time of his trial, he managed to bribe the jail-keeper to allow him to go home to attempt his wife farewell. On his way home, his wife heard that her husband had left the

prison. She assumed that he had denied his faith, and she closed the door of her house in his face, but when he told her what happened and that all the rest of the prisoners were hostages until he would return to the prison, they hugged and kissed one another, and Natalia accompanied him back to prison. There, she remained for a whole week caring for the prisoners and bandaging their wounds, until Adrian was brought before the emperor. Again, when he refused to burn incense before the idols, he was scourged and cast back into prison. On hearing that another woman came to care for the confessors, the emperor banned women from visiting the prisoners. Natalia shaved her head, disguised herself in the attire of men, bribed the guards, and managed to enter the prison. She sought from her husband, when he goes up to heaven, to pray on her behalf to complete her strife and follow him up there.

Supporting her Husband in his Last Moments:

When the saints were condemned to have their limbs cut off, Natalia sought from the executioners to start with her husband, to save herself from watching the torture of them all. Then, she hurried to where the other confessors were, told them that the torture of her husband was about to start, and asked them to pray to God to support him. When the saint was brought to the chopping block (anvil), she approached him, knelt next to him where his bones were being crushed until both of his hands, and both of his feet had been severed. It was said that his wife Natalia kept holding each of his hands and each of his feet and continued encouraging him all along that horrible suffering. Shortly after, St. Adrian died from all the bleeding, which was associated with that savage procedure. He was martyred in the year 304 AD.

Before they gathered the bodies of the martyrs to burn them, Natalia managed to hide one of her husband's hands in her clothing. In that particular moment, a rainstorm happened and put off the fire, and the believers were able to take the bodies to Nicomedia where they buried them near Byzantium. Later on, Natalia left to Byzantium (became Constantinople later on) away from the hassle of a particular imperial officer who wanted to marry her. She took with her the precious treasure: Her husband's hand, wrapped in purple fabric. A little while after her arrival to Byzantium, she reposed in peace; and counted as one of the martyrs, she was buried among the martyrs in the year 311 AD.

[Butler: September 8]

[Encyclopedia of the History of the Copts; Part 11; Bk 4; p. 103]

[Martyrdom in Christianity; p. 110]

NATHANAEL, ST.

It was said that St. Nathanael has shut himself in his cell, with such great perseverance, that he sometimes even refrained from going out to fulfill his natural needs. Satan envied him and stirred up against him intense boredom toward his cell that he left it and built another cell close to the city. After locking himself in his new cell for four months, Satan came to him by night dressed as a Roman soldier. He had a sling in his hand, and he started to use it in throwing stones at the cell door. The saint asked: "Who are you, the one throwing stones at me." The evil one answered: "I am the one who made you forsake your first cell, and I came to make you forsake this one as well."

When St. Nathanael perceived that Satan was mocking him for forsaking his first cell, he returned to it, and he worshipped God there for thirty-seven years, despite Satan's constant attempts to make him do otherwise.

Nathanael Died to all Bishops:

Then, it happened once that some of the bishops came to visit him. Then, when they were leaving, he came out only one step, no more, from his cell to send them away. Some of the people accompanying the bishops said to him: "Your pride kept you from giving due honor to these bishops." He responded humbly: "I have already died to the bishops and the whole world, and I have a certain secret, known only to God, for not coming any farther out."

Revealing the Tricks of the Devil:

Once, the devil came to him in the evening in the form of a young man. He pretended that his donkey fell with his loaded burden down in the river. He kept crying out: "O father Nathanael, come and help me before the hyenas devour me." The saint heard him from inside his cell, and the devil claimed that he was carrying bread, and he planned on holding a communal meal banquet on the next day. The saint was confused between doing the work of mercy and breaking the law he pledged with himself. He prayed and cried out to the young man, saying: "I believe that God, whom I worship, can send help to you and keep you safe from the hyenas, but, if you are the tempting devil, God will expose you." Then, he calmly left his door closed; and the devil turned in shame into a whirlpool of wind and gone away from the saint who overcame him with prayers.

[The Paradise of Saints, p. 22]

NAZARIUS AND CELSUS (The martyrs)

The father of St. Nazarius was a pagan officer in the Roman army, whereas his mother was a Christian who believed in the Lord Jesus Christ on

the hands of St. Peter the Apostle or one of his disciples. Motivated by his love and zeal for the salvation of others, Nazarius forsook his city Rome, to preach Christianity in several other locations. When he arrived at Milan, his head was cut off together with his companion St. Celsus, whom he had as his assistant in his travels. This happened during the persecution against the Christians stirred up by Emperor Nero (54-68 AD).

They were buried in a garden outside the city, which was discovered by St. Ambrose around the year 395 AD. Their bodies were moved to the Basilica of the Apostles near the Roman gate of Milan. It was terrific that the appearance of St. Nazarius body was as though he was martyred on that same day.

It happened that a woman possessed by an unclean spirit was healed, once the two bodies were moved into that church.

[Butler: July 28]

[A Dictionary of Christian Biography: Nazarius (2), Vol. IV, p. 8]

NEARCHUS (The martyr)

St. Nearchus was a Christian Roman army officer in Armenia. He was a friend of a wealthy pagan Roman army officer named Polyeuctus. St. Nearchus managed in the year 251 to convert St. Polyeuctus to Christianity, after which he became the 1st martyr in Melitene of Armenia in the year 259 AD. Later on, St. Nearchus was burned alive. He was martyred in the year 260 AD, also under Emperor Valerian (253-260 AD).

[A Dictionary of Christian Biography: Nearchus, Vol. IV, p. 8]

NECTARIUS, PATRIARCH OF CONSTANTINOPLE, ST.

In the year 381 AD, when St. Gregory of Nazianzus (329-390) resigned after a short reign as the patriarch of Constantinople, he was succeeded by St. Nectarius. St. Nectarius was from Tarsus in Cilicia, and being chosen for the patriarchate has an exciting story. While the Second Ecumenical Council was being held in Constantinople, Nectarius planned to visit his family in Tarsus. So, he went to see Abba Diodorus, the bishop of Tarsus, who was attending the Council, to ask him if he wished to send any letters to Tarsus. During that encounter, Abba Diodorus was so impressed by Nectarius conduct and attitude, that he suggested to abba Meletius, the bishop of Antioch, that Nectarius was fit to succeed St. Gregory on the throne of Constantinople. Although Abba Meletius laughed at the idea, yet the name of Nectarius was added to the list of candidates presented to the emperor to choose from. To

the amazement of all, Emperor Theodosius I (379-395 AD) wanted Nectarius, who was not even baptized yet; and it was said that he was married and had a son. However, the bishops' Council approved that choice; and Nectarius was baptized, and then ordained.

Opposing the Arians:

Abba Nectarius sat on the throne of Constantinople for sixteen years, during which he unceasingly opposed the Arians. For that reason, the Arians dared to burn his house in the year 388 AD, when a rumor spread that the emperor in Rome has died. St. Nectarius reposed on the 27th of September 397 AD, and he was succeeded by St. John Chrysostom (397-407 AD).

[Baring-Gould: October 11]

NEHROUA (The martyr)

St. Nehroua (Nahro) was from the district of Fayyum. He was a pious, God-fearing Christian. On hearing the news about the believers who were sacrificing themselves in martyrdom, he set forth to Alexandria to die in the name of the Lord Jesus Christ, but he was told in a vision: "You have to go to Antioch." While the saint was wondering how to get there, the Lord sent him the Archangel Michael, who carried him on his wings from Alexandria to Antioch. The Archangel brought him before Emperor Diocletian (284-305 AD), and the saint confessed the Name of the Lord Jesus Christ in his presence.

After asking him about his name and country, the emperor was greatly amazed by his answers and promised him with so many rewards if he denied his faith. St. Nehroua firmly rejected his offer. The emperor threatened him with torture, which he did not fear. Diocletian then ordered his men to torture him with all kinds of tools: they once tortured him by releasing lions to attack him, once by burning him in the fire, another by squeezing him in the wheel and still another time by casting him in a cauldron with fire under it. Finally, they cut his head off by the sword, and he received the crown of martyrdom. St. Julius of Aqfahs,¹ who happened to be there, returned the saints' body to his hometown with two of his servants, where he was buried with great honor.

[The Synaxarion: 7 Hator]

NEMESIAN AND MANY COMPANIONS (The martyrs)

¹ 'Julius of Aqfahs' was a biographer for the martyrs. He was born in the 2nd half of the 3rd century AD... He became very wealthy and occupied a prominent position. He had the respect of the rulers and kings... He was martyred during the 1st half of the 4th century.

In the 1st year of the 8th general persecution against Christians which was stirred up by Emperor Valerian (253-260 AD) in the year 257 AD, the governor of Carthage in North Africa, exiled St. Cyprian the bishop. At the same time on the west of Carthage, the governor of Numidia brutally tortured the Christians and sent many of them to work in the labor mines as stone-cutters. Among those blessed group were nine bishops, many priests, deacons, and laymen¹ of all ages and social status. Some of these were tortured and killed on the spot, while most of them died slowly from hunger, nakedness, and filth, exhausted with hard labor and tormented with daily stripes, and perpetual reproaches and insults all through their captivity.

From his exile, St. Cyprian wrote a persuasive letter to those confessors to hold them fast in faith and encourage them in their sufferings. Headed by St. Nemesian (Nemesianus) their bishop; they responded to him, thanking him for his letter, which helped them a lot; they mentioned to him how they still remember his courage, when he stood with glory, confessing faith before the governor; and how he went ahead of them into exile. They ended their message seeking his prayers on their behalf, saying: "Let us help one another by our prayers; so that God and His Christ would send their hosts of angels to help us all when we shall need them the most."

[Butler: September 10]

NEMESION AND OTHERS (The martyrs)

Martyred among Thieves and Evildoers:

During the persecution started by Emperor Decius (249-251 AD), an Egyptian Christian from Alexandria: St. Nemesion (Nemesius) was arrested and accused of theft. Even though he proved his innocence, yet they still accused him of being a Christian. He was sent to the governor before whom he confessed his faith, condemned to be double scourged, then to be burned alive, along with a group of thieves and evildoers. He gave thanks to God who allowed him to die like his Savior, who was crucified between two robbers. In that way, he received the crown of martyrdom on the 19th of December 250.

Trying Four Other Christians:

At the same trial of Nemesius in Alexandria, four other Christians were tried: Arsenius, Heron, Isidore, and Dioscorus. As Dioscorus was only fifteen

¹ Some names of martyrs in that group: St. 'Felix', St. 'Lucius', another St. 'Felix', St. 'Litteus', St. 'Polianus', St. 'Victor', St. 'Jader' and St. 'Dativus'...

years old, the governor, treated him mildly at first, to seduce him to forsake his faith; and when he failed, he tortured him with every tool; then set him free, because of his young age, hoping that he would change his view with time. His other companions, after being violently tortured, were burnt alive.

The Persecution of Meuris and Thea:

Also, Meuris and Thea, two holy women from Gaza in Palestine, were tortured on the hands of the successors of Emperor Diocletian (284-305 AD). Eventually, St. Meuris was martyred, whereas St. Thea lived for a while enduring a long series of deadly tortures.

[Butler: December 19]

NEREUS, ACHILLEUS & DOMITILLA (The martyrs)

SS. Nereus and Achilleus were eunuchs serving in the palace of St. Domitilla; one of the nieces of Emperor Domitian (81-96). They were all martyred in the days of Emperor Trajan (98-117) near the end of the 1st century. The biography of Achilleus could be found under the Letter 'A.' Also, the biographies of the others could be found under the Letter 'D.'

(St. Domitilla, St. Nereus and St. Achilleus)

[Butler: May 12]

NERSES I, CATHOLICOS OF ARMENIA (The martyr)

In the Court of the Armenian King:

St. Nerses I was the catholicos (katholikos) of the Armenians and the first to be called by such a title in the series of the saints. He was a great reformer, carried out many activities, which were completed by his son Isaac. This saint was raised in Caesarea of Cappadocia, where he got married; and came to be responsible for the court of the Armenian king Arshak II (Arsaces II: 350-368).

The Archbishop of Armenia:

In the year 353 AD, St. Nerses I was ordained the archbishop (catholicos) of Armenia, against his own will. He encouraged monastic life and established a few hospitals. In the year 365 AD, being influenced by St. Basil of Caesarea, St. Nerses I held the first holy Council in Ashtishat, to bring order and strength to the church by publicizing numerous laws on fast days and Divine worship. Besides, he forbade people to marry their first cousins and forbade mutilation and other extreme actions in mourning. He also set

ecclesiastical laws, which he took after the Greek Church.

Sent to Exile:

Some of the reforms St. Nerses I had made drew upon him the displeasure of the Armenian king Arshak II, and he was exiled, supposedly to Edessa. After the king sent him into exile, he appointed another bishop to replace him.

At some point during the latter part of Arshak II's reign, it seemed that St. Nerses I went to Constantinople to ensure the emperor's support of Armenia against their Persian enemy. However, Emperor Valens (364-378 AD) became so outraged by St. Nerses I condemning his following of the teachings of Arius, and he sent him into exile in Xad.¹ A little while later, king Arshak II was killed in a battle with the Persians; and the bishop came back to his throne, to find the new king Papas (370-374 AD) worse than his father.

Killed by Poison:

King Papas was so evil, that bishop Nerses I forbade him from entering the church until he would mend his ways and repent his evils. The angry king decided to take revenge against him. Pretending to repent, he invited the bishop to a banquet, where he killed him by poison in the year 373 AD. That is why Nerses I is counted as a martyr, and his name is mentioned in the holy liturgy of the Armenian Church, calling him: The Great Nerses.

[Butler: November 19]

NESTABUS, EUSEBIUS, ZENO & NESTOR (The martyrs)

St. Eusebius, St. Nestabus and St. Zeno were three Christian siblings, who were accused of vandalizing a pagan temple in Gaza. They were imprisoned, scourged, and martyred during the reign of Emperor Julian the Apostate (360-363 AD) in the year 362 AD. Their biography could be found under the Letter 'Z': (Zeno, Eusebius, Nestabus & Nestor, SS)

NESTOR, BISHOP OF MAGIDA (The martyr)

His Care for his People:

During the reign of Emperor Decius (249-251 AD); Pollio, the governor of

¹ This was according to the 'Faustus of Byzantium's account.' 'Faustus' was an Armenian historian of the 5th century.

Pamphylia and Phrygia, applied for the imperial orders against the Christians with the highest cruelty and violence, to gain favor in the eyes of the emperor. At that time, St. Nestor was the bishop of Magida (Magydus), who earned respect and appreciation of both the Christians and the pagans. Because of his fame and reputation, the bishop knew for sure that the emperor's men would seek him; yet he did not try to escape.

Caring only for his flock, St. Nestor kept sending those vulnerable among his congregation to faraway places to avoid danger. At the same time, he remained at home, praying and waiting for his martyrdom.

Being Arrested;

One day, while he was praying, he was told that the governor's soldiers came to seek him. On seeing him, they greeted him with respect. He asked them: "My children! What brought you here?" They answered him: "The judge and the officials seek your presence." He went along with them, and when he entered the judge's court, all stood up with respect; and the soldiers led him to a place which befitted his high stature. The judge asked him: "Lord! Do you know the orders of the emperor?" He answered him: "I only know the orders of God the Almighty and Everlasting; not those of the emperor." The judge said to him: "Calmly, obey the orders, lest you would be tried."

Standing firm, the saint responded to the judge's threats by saying: "The only sufferings I fear are those of my God. As for you, be sure that with or without torture, I shall never confess another God."

Sent to the Governor:

Before his standing firm, the judge perceived that he has to send him to the governor in Perga, where there was none of his friends and spiritual children, although his reputation had preceded him there.

At first, the governor tenderly sought from him to forsake his faith, but when he firmly refused, the governor ordered to put him in a tool of torture called the little horse, which tore off his bare sides by sharp iron claws, while the saint kept singing: "I shall give thanks to God all the time; His praises will always be in my mouth."

The governor asked him: "Are you not ashamed of trusting someone who died crucified?" St. Nestor answered: "This is my way and that of everyone who calls the Name of the Lord." Hearing the multitudes grumble with impatience, the governor asked him for the last time: "Will you be with Christ or with us?" The saint firmly answered: "With my Christ, I have always been; I am with Him now, and so I shall always be."

The governor ordered his men to crucify him. While hanged on the Cross,

the saint kept encouraging and holding fast the Christians who stood around him. They saw his crucifixion as a victory, for when he cried out to them, saying: “My children! Let us kneel and pray to God,” all those around him, whether Christians or pagans, all knelt and prayed; while the saint was delivering his soul. His martyrdom was in the year 251 AD.

[Baring-Gould: February 26]

NESTOR, THE HERETIC

Patriarch of Constantinople:

Nestor (Nestorius) was born in the city of Germanicia (Marash) in Syria within the period 381-386 AD. He was raised in Antioch, where he became a monk in the monastery of Irobios, a disciple of Theodore of Mopsuestia (Myssa: 392-428 AD). When he completed his education, he was ordained a deacon, then a priest in the Cathedral of Antioch, where he was known for his eloquence and powerful sermons. Nestor was chosen by Emperor Theodosius II (402-450 AD) to become the patriarch of Constantinople (428-431 AD), but he was not able to perform properly once he occupied that exalted position. Somehow, he was infected by the vain-glory, greatness, and self-admiration. On one of his sermons, he addressed the emperor, saying:

“O, King! Uproot with me the heretics, and I shall uproot the evil soldiers of Persia with you, and after you consummate your happy life on earth, I shall guarantee for you the ultimate eternal life in heaven.”

Before sitting on the throne of Constantinople, Nestor was full of zeal towards defending the upright faith against the heretics. Still, unfortunately, he soon fell into his horrible heresy, and his fall was so great. One of the historians said about him: “Nestor fought against all heresies, to pave the way for his own.”

Nestor's Heresy: Two Hypostasis-Two Persons-Two Natures:

We might be able to summarize Nestor's Heresy as follows:

- He made in Christ two separate and distinguishable Hypostases (Υποστασης), that was why he rejected the dogma of the union between the Godhead and the Manhood as a union according to nature (Κατα Φυζιν), and he rejected also the Hypostatic union; which means that he rejected the union according to the Hypostasis, as a union beyond description and comprehension; yet an inseparable true union.

The Hypostatic union implies that the Hypostasis of God the Word is Himself, the One born, incarnated, and took a body from the Virgin.

Therefore, in Christ, there is only one Hypostasis. There is no Hypostatic union in the whole universe, except in the Incarnation of God the Word.

- He considered Him with Two Natures (Ουσια), assuming that the relationship between the Godhead and the Manhood, as mere conjoining.
- He believed Him as Two Persons (Προσωπον): the Word as “the Son of God” and Jesus as “the Son of Mary.” In his heresy, Nestor proclaimed that in the Lord Jesus Christ, there are two Hypostasis, two Persons, and two Natures. When He performed signs, He was the Son of God; and when he got hungry, thirsty, crucified, and died, He was the Son of Mary.
- He believed that Man as chosen by God the Word, and through Him, the Man was granted His Honor and Titles; hence we worship Him with single worship.

In St. Cyril's teachings about the human person with whom the Hypostasis of God the Word has united, he says: “The Word of God, being the Godhead, is not prone to suffering; but the Word of God suffered in the flesh or according to the body. He endured it by His person, which means that the pain of the flesh is His suffering; hence, the suffering and death were attributed to His person.

By the union of the limited body with the limitless Word of God, the body was able to die on behalf of everybody. The Word of God conveyed the capability and worthiness to His Body, and in the same way, we refer to what concerns the body to the Word of God, like the birth and the suffering; we also refer the non-limitedness to the Sacrifice on the Cross.”

- He refused to call the Virgin St. Mary “The Mother of God” and only called her “The Mother of Christ.” He rejected the title “Theotokos (Θεοτόκος),” saying that she was just the mother of Jesus, and gave her instead, the title of “Christotokos (χριστοτόκος),” namely (the Mother of Christ the Man).

Because of his high position as the patriarch of Constantinople with what he had of authority and might, he managed to spread his corrupt heresy everywhere, with the help of some priests and even some bishops.

As for the Christian congregation in Constantinople, once they heard Nestor's teaching, they completely rejected it as contradictory to the Holy Word of God. They started to rebel against Nestor, who persisted in his arrogance and stubbornness. Also, a group of monks came from the monasteries to see him, to show him the corruption of his teaching and how it deviated from the upright faith. He was provoked to anger and ordered to confine them by force in the church. Then, he ordered his followers to insult them by stripping them from their clothes, securing them to posts, and

beating them on their naked bellies.

Pope Cyril the Great Steps In:

When the controversy in Constantinople got a lot worse, the 24th Pope of Alexandria St. Cyril, the Pillar of Faith (412-444 AD), heard about it, right away, he rose to defend and confirm the traditional Virgin St. Mary's title, Theotokos. He did that because it is not just a title of honor, but because it carried an essential dogma of faith, about the Person of the Lord Jesus Christ Himself, concerning the union between His Godhead and Manhood. In doing that, he confirmed that this term was the traditional title and Scriptural expression, chosen by the 20th Pope St. Athanasius the Apostolic (328-373).

In the year 428 AD, Pope Cyril used the occasion of the feast of Resurrection to include in his annual Passover Pastoral message, a strong refutation of Nestor's heresy, and he sent it to the churches everywhere. St. Cyril also wrote several letters to Nestor, full of strong and indisputable evidence and proofs to show the falseness of his heresy, hoping that he would eventually withdraw from his vanity. However, before the persistence of Nestor on his corrupt views and beliefs, Pope Cyril held a local Council in Alexandria, which was attended by the bishops of the See of St. Mark. That Council condemned Nestor and rejected all his teachings. He then sent a report of all that went on in the Council, to his representatives in Constantinople and the Roman pope Celestine I (422-432 AD). Then, St. Cyril sent a copy to Emperor Theodosius II when he noticed that the emperor was defending Nestor and considering him as a virtuous scholar.

Pope Cyril wrote in his letter to Acacius, the bishop of Melitene (d. 431):

“Nestor has divided the One Son into two Sons; looking at each as separate from the other. One of them, he considers as a Son, a Christ, and a Lord; the Word begotten from God the Father. While the other, who is separated from the first, he says: He is born from the Virgin St. Mary.”
[Letter 40:10]

“In his sermons in the church, Nestor would say that for this reason too, Christ is called God the Word, because He has an uninterrupted conjoining with Christ, and he would request therefore that his congregation would keep in mind the conjoining between the two natures as unconfused. Asking them to confess God in the Man, and because of such Divine conjoining, they have to revere and honor the worshipped Man, together with the Almighty God.”
[Letter 40:12]

From what Pope Cyril has said in his letters about Nestor, it is evident that Nestor taught two Sons and two Christs: One of Whom is God, and the other Man. Two serious issues resulted from such a heresy:

1- It lowered Jesus of Nazareth, down to the level of a prophet or a saintly

Man, on whom the Hypostasis of the Word dwelt, after having previously chosen and strengthened Him. Pope Cyril firmly rejected such teaching, for its lousy impact, which was shown in the 7th century AD.

2- It called for dual worship; for a Man to be worshipped along with God; on account of that, God has given that Man an honor equal to the honor of God, which opened the way to the rejection of Christianity, later on.

Finally, Pope Cyril held another local Council in Alexandria, in which he went over all the attempts he made to counteract the heresy of Nestor; and the messages he wrote in this regard. The fathers, in turn, wrote to Nestor to explain to him the proper doctrine of faith in the Lord Jesus Christ.

Then, Pope Cyril presented twelve topics, in which he explained the sound Christian Dogma; and excommunicated whoever would go against them, which were later on called: "The Twelve Anathemas (Excommunications)." However, Nestor despised Pope Cyril's message and ex-communications, and he responded by issuing refutations to those items.

The church was thus divided into two camps: The first included the churches of Egypt, Rome, Jerusalem, and Asia Minor, all of which adopted the views of Pope Cyril of Alexandria, and the second included the churches of Antioch and Constantinople, the throne of Nestor.

The Council of Ephesus:

Before such a division, Pope Cyril sought from Emperor Theodosius II to hold another Council to deal with the controversy. Responding to St. Cyril's request, the emperor, invited all the bishops, including Nestor, to come to assemble in Ephesus on the 13th of Paona 147 AM (7 June 431 AD). In that Council, Nestor was excommunicated; and the Prologue of the Creed of Faith was established.

Nestor Exiled:

When the decisions of the First Council of Ephesus reached the emperor, he confirmed them and issued an imperial edict that exiled Nestor from the monastery in Antioch in which he had been staying to a monastery in the Great Oasis of Hîbis (al-Khargah) in Egypt; securely within the diocese of St. Cyril. There, he remained four years, during which he kept spreading his venoms among the monks. Provoked to anger, the emperor gave the orders to burn all his books, and he was moved to the city of Akhmim in Upper Egypt, where the Copts, so strongly held their faith, that there was no chance for Nestor to ever change them. There, he remained until he died rejected by all, and he was buried there in the year 450 AD. The Copts of Akhmim used to stone his tomb and cover it with dirt until a big heap was created, what was later on called: The Hill of Nestor, in the northern east part of the city.

NICANDER AND MARCIAN (The martyrs)

They lived in the 4th century AD, most probably in Durostorum in Bulgaria; and they were serving in the Roman army, but when the orders to persecute the Christians were issued, they forsook the military. Therefore, they were arrested, tried, and finally martyred. Their biography could be found under the letter 'M': (Marcian and Nicander, SS.)

NICARETE, THE VIRGIN, ST.

Her Relationship with St. John Chrysostom:

St. Nicarete was an elderly woman of Constantinople, who grew in a life of sanctity, during the reign of Emperor Arcadius (395-408 AD). Initially, she was from Nicomedia, raised in a noble family, and she was highly educated. She left her town to the near-by Constantinople, where she dedicated her life to the work of mercy. She became a follower of St. John Chrysostom (349-407 AD) and worked as a physician as well as a healer and caretaker for the poor. It was said that she had treated St. John Chrysostom during his illness. When he wanted to ordain her as a deaconess to supervise the dedicated virgins in the city, St. Nicarete declined.

St. Nicarete was among the vocal advocates of St. John Chrysostom. Therefore, she was persecuted along with St. Olympias and others. They were all sent to exile because of their relationship with that great saint.

It is not known where and when she reposed, yet most probably it was in the year 410 AD, in her hometown: Nicomedia.

[Englebert, Omer: *The Lives of the Saints*, Christopher & Anne Fremantle, trans. New York: Barnes & Noble, 1994: December 27]

NICASIUS, THE BISHOP & HIS COMPANIONS
(The martyrs)

Raiding the City of Rhéims:

An army of Barbarians from Germany invaded part of Gaul (France) and plundered the city of Rhéims. As it was proclaimed to him in a night vision, St. Nicacius, the bishop of Rhéims informed his city inhabitants in advance about what was about to happen. He asked them to get prepared by practicing the acts of repentance. Seeing the enemy at the gates and on the highways, he

did not care for his safety but kept moving from one house to another, encouraging his spiritual children and holding them fast. Being asked by them, whether to surrender or to fight up to the end; having known that the city would eventually fall; he answered them, saying: “Let us hold fast to the mercies of God and pray for the sake of our enemies, and I am ready to deliver myself on behalf of my people.”

His Martyrdom:

Trying to protect some of his people, the saint stood at the door of his church facing the swords of the evil invaders. They ultimately cut his head off, and he was martyred along with two of his disciples: Florens (Florentius) and Jocond (Jucundus). On seeing her brother St. Nicacius being martyred, his sister Eutropia, longing to have the same portion, threw herself on the killer of her brother, beating him with her hands and kicking him with her feet, until he cut her head off by his sword around the year 451.

[Butler: December 14]

NICEPHORUS (The martyr)

An Intense Hatred:

In the city of Antioch, there was a priest called Sapricius, and a layman called Nicephorus. They were intimate friends for many years, but because of some controversies, their friendship was not only terminated, but it turned into intense hatred. That unfortunate situation endured for a long time until Nicephorus perceived that it was time to reconcile with his old friend.

Nicephorus kept on sending friends to the priest Sapricius, once, twice and for a third time, with no avail. At last, he went by himself to his friend's house to confess his fault, seeking his forgiveness, but also to no avail, for the priest closed his ears even to the commandment of the Lord Jesus Christ, to forgive the sins of others, for our sins to be forgiven.

Sapricius Trial:

With the persecution of the Christians in the year 260 AD, during the reign of the Emperors Valerian and Gallienus (253-268 AD), the priest Sapricius was arrested and brought before the governor. He asked him about his name and job, and the priest answered: “My name is Sapricius, I am Christian, and I have the honor to be a priest.” He added: “We Christians confess one God and one Lord Jesus Christ, the only true God who created heaven and earth; and we count your pagan gods as nothing but demons.”

The governor was provoked to anger on hearing his answer and ordered to torture him. Sapricius endured the torture steadily and firmly said to his

persecutors: “My body is in your hands, but my spirit you cannot touch, for it is possessed by my Lord and Savior Jesus Christ.”

Nicephorus Hastens to Meet his Friend:

Seeing how Sapricius stood firm, the governor uttered: “The verdict on the Christian priest Sapricius, who believes that he will resurrect again, is to cut his head off by the sword because he despised the imperial orders.” Sapricius heard that verdict with joy and wanted in haste to reach the place of execution.

Nicephorus hastened to see Sapricius, cast himself at his old friend's feet, seeking twice from the about-to-be martyr of Jesus Christ to forgive him. However, Sapricius heart was so turned off that he did not even look at him. The soldiers mocked Nicephorus for his persistence in seeking forgiveness from a criminal on his way to be executed.

Nicephorus Steals the Crown:

At the location of execution, Nicephorus resumed his attempts to no avail. Then, once the executioner ordered Sapricius to kneel on the ground to have his head cut off, the poor priest, in weakness, cried out: “Wait, my friends. Do not kill me! I am ready to obey your orders and sacrifice to the idols.” Here, Nicephorus, sorrowful for the apostasy of his friend, pleaded with him to stand firm and not to deny his Lord, lest he would lose his crown of glory, which he has already earned by enduring all that torture, but Sapricius did not listen to him and persisted on his weakness. Weeping bitterly, Nicephorus cried out, saying: “I am Christian, I believe in Jesus Christ, who was denied by Sapricius. I am ready to die in his place.”

The amazed soldiers went to ask the governor what they should do. He answered them: “If Nicephorus would not sacrifice to the gods, let him be executed instead of Sapricius.” So, Nicephorus was beheaded; and he gained three eternal crowns, for faith, humility, and his work of love.

[Butler: February 9]

[A Dictionary of Christian Biography: Nicephorus (3), Vol. IV, p. 35]

NICETAS, BISHOP OF REMESIANA, ST.

St. Nicetas was the bishop of Remesiana, known now as the province of Bela Palanka in Serbia. By dwelling in that area and preaching Christianity among its inhabitants, he managed to transform them into decent civilized people, after being wild Barbarians.

The little we know about his life is that he was a friend of St. Paulinus of Nola; and that St. Jerome talked very proudly of him, mentioning his success

in changing the nature of the people whom he preached.
St. Nicetas reposed in the year 414 AD.

[Butler: June 22]

NICETAS, THE GOTHIC (The martyr)

The Persecution Against the Christians by King Athanarie:

Saint Nicetas was a Gothic German; born near the banks of the Danube river. He was converted to Christianity in his youth on the hands of Theophilus (Ulphilas), the bishop of Scythians and Goths during the reign of Emperor Constantine the Great (306-337). That bishop Theophilus was one of the great preachers in that region, who was credited for translating the Holy Bible to the language of the Goth; and he was the one who ordained St. Nicetas as a priest.

In the year 372 AD, Athanarie, the savage king of the Eastern Goths, led a campaign on the Roman Empire, and he declared persecution against the Christians. By his order, an idol was carried in a chariot through all the towns and villages, where it was suspected that any Christians lived, and all who refused to adore it were put to death. The usual method the persecutors were using was to burn the Christians with their children in their houses or in the churches where they assembled.

His Martyrdom:

Among the martyrs who glorified God before those barbarous people, was St. Nicetas, who sealed his faith and obedience to God by shedding his blood, and through his death burned with fire, he passed to eternal glory. St. Nicetas was martyred in the year 375 AD. This saint has a special status in both the Byzantine and the Syrian Churches.

[Butler: September 15]

NICHOLAS, BISHOP OF MYRA, ST.

His Upbringing:

St. Nicholas lived in the city of Myra (Patara) in the province of Lycia in Asia Minor. Lycia's capital Myra was near the sea, and it was the diocese headquarters.

His father, Epiphanius, and his mother, Tuna, besides their great riches, they were God-fearing people. Having had no children, God had compassion on them in their old age and gave them this saint. He was full of Divine grace

since his childhood. They raised him well under the care of the church in the purity of heart. When he reached five years of age, he started to learn the church's teachings, which eventually enlightened his mind and motivated him to follow the holy path. While learning, he exhibited extraordinary signs of intelligence, which indicated that the Holy Spirit was inspiring him much more than what he was getting from his teachers. So, they ordained him as a deacon.

His Monastic Life:

St. Nicholas became a monk in one of the monasteries, where his cousin was its abbot. There, he lived a life of asceticism, strife, and virtue; until he was ordained a priest at the young age of nineteen. He was granted by God the grace to perform signs, including driving the unclean spirits away, healing the sick and blessing the bread that a small amount would satisfy a multitude of people.

Acts of Mercy:

His parents passed away while the saint was still a young man. They left for him great wealth, so he decided to dedicate all his inheritance to acts of mercy.

Soon he got his chance, when someone he knew in Patara lost all his wealth, to the extent that he did not have the necessities of life. This man had three daughters to give in marriage; however, he could not because of his poverty, and the miserable man decided in despair, to let them lead a career in harlotry.

On hearing about that, St. Nicholas placed 100 dinars in a bag, and he threw it in the darkness of the night, through a window in that man's house. When the man woke up, he found the bag and greatly rejoiced. Then, he managed to give his older daughter in marriage with that money.

St. Nicholas repeated the same act of mercy with another bag and the second daughter was given in marriage. Then, that man became very anxious about knowing who was donating him the money; especially, it was the turn of his third daughter to get married. So, he kept up watching every night; and once he detected that a bag had been thrown through his window, he got out of the house to see who did it. He found out that it was St. Nicholas, and he cast himself at his feet to thank him for rescuing his daughters from the horrible life of harlotry.

The Bishop of Myra:

Before his ordination, St. Nicholas saw in a dream a high throne and a splendid attire on it; then someone told him: "Put on this attire and sit on this

throne.” In another dream, he saw the Virgin St. Mary giving him priestly attire and the Lord Jesus Christ handing the Gospel to him.

When the bishop of Myra reposed, the clergy and the archons assembled to choose the new bishop. An angel of the Lord appeared in a dream to the head of the bishops, to tell him that the chosen one for that post was St. Nicholas. In the morning, he told the other bishops about what he saw. They all realized then that it was from the Lord Jesus Christ, and they took the saint and ordained him as a bishop on Myra.

The new bishop was known for his holiness and zeal, and he performed so many miracles. Near the end of the persecution of Emperor Diocletian (284-305 AD), he came to endure being imprisoned for the sake of faith after he gave them the good confession. He also attended the First Ecumenical Council in Nicene and participated in the ex-communication of the Arians.

Placed in Prison:

At the beginning of the 4th century AD, Emperor Diocletian pushed for the worship of idols and arrested a multitude of believers. St. Nicholas, who was a prominent figure among the believers, bravely kept giving sermons and teaching his people about the true faith; until he was arrested by order of the area governor. Then, he was tortured for several years. However, the Lord Jesus Christ kept bringing him safely after these tortures to continue being a great supporter of the faith.

When Diocletian got fed-up with the saint, he cast him in prison, where he kept encouraging his flock and holding them fast. He remained in jail until Diocletian died in 305 AD. When Emperor Constantine the Great (306-337 AD) reigned, he set the Christian prisoners free, and St. Nicholas went back to his Seat in Myra.

His Zeal on Faith:

St. Methodius of Constantinople (843-847 AD), said that because of the teachings of St. Nicholas, the Seat of Myra was the only one not influenced by the Arian heresy. Attending the Nicene Council, St. Nicholas got so agitated by Arius that he slapped him on the face. The other fathers decided to expel him from his diocese and even to have him imprisoned, but the Lord Jesus Christ and the Virgin St. Mary appeared to him in prison and restored him to freedom and brought him back to his seat.

The saint kept on standing firm against both the Arians and the paganism. Among the temples, he demolished was that of Artamis. It was the main temple in that region, and the evil spirits were driven away from it in front of the saint's face.

His Care for his People:

One of the stories which has been told about St. Nicholas that it happened that a governor named Eustathius has taken a bribe from a foe to condemn three innocent men to death. When it was time to execute those men, St. Nicholas appeared and miraculously paralyzed the hand of the swordsman, and he set the three innocent men free. Then, the saint urged Eustathius to confess his crime and to ask for forgiveness.

Among the audience during the above event, three imperial officers were on their way to an official mission in Phrygia. However, on their return to Constantinople, Emperor Constantine condemned them to death, because of a false accusation from one of their enemies. Remembering what they witnessed in Myra of the power of love and justice of St. Nicholas, they prayed to God for the intercession of that bishop to save them from death. On that same night, St. Nicholas appeared to the emperor in a dream, and he pressed him to release those three officers who were falsely accused. In the morning, the emperor called up the three officers, and once he knew from them that they sought the intercession of St. Nicholas, he instantly released them. He sent them to the saint with a message, seeking from him to pray for the sake of the peace of the whole world. For a long time, this story became one of the most famous miracles performed by St. Nicholas.

St. Nicholas reposed in the Lord at the age of eighty years. He was the bishop of Myra for forty years, and he was buried in its' Cathedral.

Santa Claus:

After his repose, many believers took him as their intercessor and patron saint. The believers in Spain, Switzerland, and Netherland used to exchange presents in his name during the Nativity feast.

This tradition was later introduced into the United States by the Protestant Dutch, who turned the holy person of the saint to a commercial figure, to whom they gave the name of Santa Claus.

[Butler: December 6]

NICHOLAS, THE FALLEN DEACON

The Nicolaitan Heresy:

Nicholas was one of the seven deacons chosen by Christ's Apostles in the 1st century AD; *"And they chose Stephen, a man full of faith and the Holy Spirit, and Philip, Prochorus, Nicanor, Timon, Parmenas, and Nicolas, a proselyte from Antioch."* (Acts 6:5) Nicholas was a convert from Antioch.

The heresy of the Nicolaitans was attributed to him, and it was mentioned twice in the Book of Revelation (Rev. 2:6,15).

Nicholas Temporarily Separated from his Wife:

According to St. Epiphanius of Salamis (315-403 AD), it was publicly known that Nicholas was married to a wonderful woman, whom he dearly loved. Once he became Christian, he decided to become more spiritual and live in celibacy. So, he separated from his wife after having her consent, but they soon retracted their decision and resumed their regular married life. When he noticed how his behavior was criticized, he tried to justify himself and started to spread teaching contradictory to the truth and purity. He ended up delivering himself to a life of evil and looseness. He was followed by many others, and they formed a separate sect.

Such a story about this Nicholas was believed by some early fathers and scholars of the church, such as Irenaeus of Lyons (130-200 AD), Tertullian (155-240 AD), Hilary of Poitiers and Gregory of Nyssa.

Irenaeus, the bishop of Lyons, wrote extensively against the heresies and heretics of his day, and this is what he had to say about the Nicolaitans¹:

“The Nicolaitans are the followers of that Nicolas who was one of the seven first ordained to the diaconate by the apostles. They lead lives of unrestrained indulgence. The character of these men is very plainly pointed out in the Revelations of John, [when they are represented] as teaching that it is a matter of indifference to practice adultery and to eat things sacrificed to idols. Wherefore the Word has also spoken of them thus: *“But this you have, that you hate the deeds of the Nicolaitans, which I also hate.”* (Rev. 2:6)”

[The Church in the Era of the Apostles; p. 267]

NICOMEDES (The martyr)

St. Nicomedes was one of the martyrs of the Church of Rome. It was said that he was martyred in the days of Emperor Maximian (286-305 AD). When he was ordered to burn incense before the idols, he responded that he only worship God the Almighty. Then, he was severely beaten and scourged for such a long time that he delivered his soul and received the crown of martyrdom.

[Butler: September 15]

¹ Irenaeus: *Against Heresies*, Book I, chapter 26:3. [www.newadvent.org/fathers/0103126.htm]

NICOSTRATUS, THE DEACON

In the year 253 AD, St. Nicostratus was a Roman deacon and a confessor. It is believed that he was a slave; since it was allowed to ordain the slaves after the approval of their masters to set them free. Although in the Council of Elvira, it was allowed to ordain the freed slaves, only after the death of their masters.

Nicostratus endured torture, together with Moyses and Maximus; and like them, he was attached to Novatus and believed in his heresy. Nicostratus even traveled along with Novatus to Carthage (Cordoba) to spread his teaching. However, all eventually returned to the faith of the church.

[A Dictionary of Christian Biography: Nicostratus (1), Vol. IV, p. 42]

NICOSTRATUS (The martyr)

St. Nicostratus was believed to be a prison warden in Rome around the year 287 AD. His name was mentioned in the biography of St. Sebastian (d: 288 AD). While St. Sebastian was imprisoned in Nicostratus jail, he managed to convert him and his wife Zoe, and they came to believe in Christ. Then, Nicostratus brought the rest of the prisoners; sixteen of them were also converted to Christianity by Sebastian.

Besides, it was said that two deacons twin brothers by the name of Marcus and Marcellian, were arrested and placed in Nicostratus prison because of their belief. Then, when their pagan parents came to persuade them to deny their faith; St. Sebastian managed to convert them to Christianity too.

St. Nicostratus eventually received the crown of martyrdom.

[A Dictionary of Christian Biography: Nicostratus (2), Vol. IV, p. 42]

NIKETA (The martyr)

On the 18th of Tout, the church celebrates the memorial of the martyrdom of the lady St. Niketa (Niceta) and St. Stephen, the priest.

NIKITA, FATHER

The Demon of Adversity:

Once Fr. Nikita narrated the following story:

“Two brothers decided to dwell together, each of them said to himself: ‘I shall do whatever my brother wants...’ They both lived together for so many years in great love and peace. However, the devil envied them and decided to

separate them and keep them apart. So, he went to their outer door; and managed to appear to one of them as a dove and the other as a raven. One of the brothers said to the other brother: 'Do you see this dove?' The other brother answered him: 'It is a raven, not a dove.' Each of them insisted on his view that it ended up that they separated from one another; to the great joy of the evil one. Three days later, each of them started to think calmly about the matter and perceived that it was the doing of the enemy. They both came back together, each of them made a metanoia before the other. And they remained together unseparated to the end of their lives."

[Publications of the Light: The Sayings of the Elder Fathers; Lebanon 1983]

NIKON, FATHER

How Satan Tempts the Saints:

A brother asked an elder father: "How does Satan tempt the saints?" The elder responded by telling him the following story:

"There was a monk named Nikon, and he was living in a monastery on Mount Sinai. Then, at that time, someone came to visit a member of a nearby tribe (the Faranites). When that visitor entered his friend's tent, he found his daughter alone. So, the evil man fell into sin with her and stressed on her to say that it was father Nikon who did it to her. When she told her father that lie, the father went carrying his sword to kill Fr. Nikon. When he knocked on his door, the elder came out to see him. The girl's father raised his sword to kill him, but God paralyzed his arm. Then, that Faranitian father went and reported the incident to the monastery priests. The abbot called the accused monk to come over. After the other monks have beaten him severely, they wanted to expel him from the monastery. However, he begged them saying: 'For the love of God, leave me here, to repent.' So, they allowed him to stay, but they separated him from the fellowship of the group for three years, and they prohibited anyone from visiting him. He spent that whole period repenting, and each Sunday, he would beg everybody to pray on his behalf. Then, it happened that the man who committed the sin and falsely accused him got possessed by a demon. He came to the monastery's church and publicly confessed: 'I am the one who committed that evil with the girl, and I am the one who calumniated against God's man and accused him.'

All the people came to apologize to the elder monk, saying: 'Forgive us father, and stay with us.' Fr. Nikon answered them, saying: 'As for forgiveness, I do forgive all of you. However, concerning staying with you, I

shall not, because none of you had the discernment to be compassion on me,’ and he departed from them.” Then the elder father told the brother: “Now, do you see how Satan tempts the saints?”

[Publications of the Light: The Sayings of the Elder Fathers; Lebanon 1983]

NILAMMON, THE BISHOP

St. Nilammon was one of the bishops ordained by the 19th Pope of Alexandria, St. Alexandros I (312-328 AD). He was exiled by the Arians to Ammoniaca in the days of the 20th Pope St. Athanasius the Apostolic (328-373 AD).

[A Dictionary of Christian Biography, Vol. IV, p. 43]

NILAMMON, THE LOCK-UP RECLUSE, ST.

Pope Theophilus in the Village of Geres:

When the 23rd Pope of Alexandria Abba Theophilus (385-412 AD), was coming back to Alexandria from a pastoral visit; a strong storm forced the captain of his boat to sail close to the shore and to land at a little village called Geres, about fifty marine miles from Farma near Port-Saïd.

It happened that the bishop of that region had passed away a few days earlier. So, when the pope disembarked to visit the people, everybody came to have his blessing and to seek from him to ordain a replacement bishop for them. Their choice was St. Nilammon, the lock-up recluse who was an ascetic monk living for long years in one of the natural caves scattered in the eastern desert in that region. St. Nilammon accumulated heaps of stones and rocks at the entrance of his cave to keep anyone from reaching it, and he spent long years without ever getting out of that cave.

Choosing Nilammon a Bishop:

The people felt that the unexpected arrival of the pope to their area, as a sign from Heaven that that ascetic monk was chosen by God. So, the clergy and the people convinced the pope, and they went headed by the pope to the cave of that recluse. The pope called him, saying: “Brother Nilammon!, hear the call of your pope. The collective voice of the people is an expression of the will of God. In His Glorious Name and my capacity as the pope; I am responsible for fulfilling the choice of the people for their bishops. I implore you to submit and accept to care for the people of Geres, who gave you their love and trust. Here I am, ready to carry out the holy procedure to ordain you

as their bishop.”

The respite of 24 hours:

Encouraged by the words of the pope, the people removed the rocks accumulated at the entrance of the cave, forced their way into it, and carried the recluse monk to where the pope was standing. Nilammon kept begging them with tears to leave him alone to his seclusion, claiming that he was unworthy of such an exalted honor. Yet, the people backed by the pope insisted on their request. Finally, St. Nilammon asked them to give him twenty-four hours to prepare himself for the task.

Funeral Prayers instead of Ordination:

The pope came the next day together with the people and ordered Nilammon to come out. He answered him from the inside, saying: “With pleasure, I shall obey, yet let us first pray together.” All fell on their knees, and fervently raised their voices toward Heaven. However, while all were praying, the saint delivered his soul.

With no one perceiving what happened, the prayers extended all day long. Then at sunset, when the man of God did not come out, they entered into the cave with the pope ahead. They found the saint laying on the ground, his arms spread like a cross, his eyes directed toward Heaven, and his face shined with light and peace. So, instead of performing the ordination, the pope performed the funeral services.

His feast day in the Western Church is on June 6. St. Nilammon's statue is one of the 140 Colonnade Saints which adorn St. Peter's Square in Rome.

[The Faithful Synaxarion: 27 Hator]

NILUS, THE BISHOP (The martyr)

St. Nilus was an Egyptian bishop who was martyred together with Peleus, the bishop, Elijah, the priest, and a layman by the name Patermuthius; on the 19th of September 310 AD, near Patara. Their biographies could be found under the letter ‘P’: (Peleus, the Bishop)

NILUS OF SINAI, ST.

For a long time, there was some confusion between St. Nilus of Sinai (the Elder) and St. Nilus the Scribe.

The disciple of St. John Chrysostom:

St. Nilus of Sinai was a disciple of St. John Chrysostom. He was born in

Galatia, and he documented some events about St. Plato, the martyr of Ancyra, and his companions.

This St. Nilus worked for a while as the governor of Constantinople. He was married and had two sons. When he felt an intense longing for a life of seclusion, he resigned from his job and abandoned the world after having the consent of his wife. He set forth to the wilderness of Sinai in Egypt around the year 390 AD to become a monk. He took his son Theodulus along with him.

After a few years, the Arab Saracens invaded the wilderness in Sinai and slaughtered so many monks and took Theodulus as a captive, while Nilus miraculously was saved. He kept looking for his son until he found him south of Beersheba with the bishop Eleusa, who had bought him from the Arabs to free him from captivity and use him to help in the church activities. Before he let them go back to Sinai, that good bishop ordained both of them as priests.

In Sinai, they resumed their ascetic life very diligently until St. Nilus reposed in peace in the year 430 AD.

His Writings:

St. Nilus wrote two letters to Emperor Arcadius (395-408 AD), in defense of St. John Chrysostom and protesting about his exile from Constantinople.

He also left so many writings on asceticism, virtues, and some commentaries on the Holy Bible. His treatises provided us with information about the paganism, which was prevailing at his time. Some writings were wrongly attributed to him, while they belonged to others; such as St. Ogriss (Evagrius: 345-399 AD).

A series of short essays on prayers were printed in English in the year 1954, in 'The Early Fathers from The Philokalia.' He wrote, as well, several letters, many of which remain until today.

Of His Sayings:

- Prayer is the bud of humility and the control of anger.
- Prayer is a medication for lukewarmness and grief.
- To pray without distraction, go and sell all that you have and give to the poor; then carry your Cross and deny yourself.
- All whatever you are contemplating about patiently, you will reap its fruit at the time of prayer.
- To pray as you should, do not offend anyone; lest you would be praying in vain.
- Do not wish to have things according to your hopes, but according to God's will, for then, you would be without confusion or worries, and you

would be happy in your prayer.

- Happy is the monk who loves serenity; for the arrows of the enemy would never hurt him; whereas the one who interferes in every detail would have to endure continuous wounds.
- Happy is the monk who considers himself the least of all.
- A servant who did not prepare himself to do according to his master's will shall be beaten with many stripes (Luke 12:47).

NIMMIA (The martyr)

St. Nimmia was martyred at Augsburg in Austria, along with St. Hilaria, the mother of St. Afra and several other women¹ martyrs. The Western Church celebrates her on the 12th of August.

[A Dictionary of Christian Biography; Vol. IV, p. 45]

NINIAN, THE BISHOP, ST.

Visiting Rome:

St. Ninian was of noble origin, his father was a leader in the army of the Celtic kingdom of Cumbria in the island of Britain. Being Christian, the father baptized his son while still young. When the boy got older, he wanted to visit Rome. So, he crossed the channel to the continent and joined a group of travelers going to Rome. He reached it in the year 370 AD during the days of the Roman Pope Damasus I (366-384 AD).

The Preaching Bishop:

After spending several years in Rome where he devoted his time to study the Scriptures and the holy learning, he was ordained as a bishop in the year 394 AD by the Roman Pope Siricius (384-399 AD). He was sent as a missionary bishop to the western part of Britain, where the Holy Bible was unknown, corrupted, or misrepresented by their teachers.

From there, he called on St. Martin of Tours in Gaul (France) for support. St. Martin sent him building stones to construct churches in Britain according to the Roman style. Then, he returned home, where he built his church in Witerna (Nowadays: Whithorn in Wigtonshire). In the meantime, he got the news of the departure of St. Martin in the year 397 AD.

The central region where bishop Ninian served was the middle section of Eastern Scotland, where he preached among the barbarian tribes who fought

¹ Some of their names: SS. Crescentian, Digna, Eunomia, Euprepia, Juliana, Largio and Quiriacus.

a few centuries earlier against the Roman conquest of Britain led by the Gallo-Roman general Julius Agricola (40-93 AD). Bishop Ninian established monastic schools in Cumbria and Ireland. These schools became very famous and remained as centers for the early Christian teaching in those areas until they were destroyed along with the diocese by the attacks of the Britons and the Saxons. Bishop Ninian departed in the year 432 AD, and the Western Church celebrated him on the 16th of September. In the middle ages, his grave was the site of a very large pilgrimage.

The period during which this saint lived was counted among the important periods in the history of the Western Church, for while in the Eastern Church the saints like St. Basil, St. Gregory and St. John Chrysostom were struggling and suffering for the sake of faith; in the west, the saints like St. Jerome, St. Ambrose and St. Augustine were working on clarifying the teachings of the church. Also, in the west, St. Martin established in Tours a monastic order which proved to be a great success in spreading Christianity in Britain.

[A Dictionary of Christian Biography, Vol. IV, p. 45-6]

NINO, THE VIRGIN, ST.

The Exultant Captive:

The historian Rufinus of Aquileia (371-410 AD) mentioned that at the beginning of the 4th century AD, there was in the kingdom of Georgia (Iberia/Spain), a very special foreigner virgin in captivity. The way she got there was by the messengers of King Mirian III (284-361 AD) of Georgia, who were on their way home back from Rome. When they were passing by a village with a near-by convent, one of the nuns named Nino (Nina/Theognosta¹?) happened to be outside the convent's walls, so they kidnaped her and took her along with them and sold her to a noble family in their country Georgia. However, the captive nun Nino never felt humiliated; she never complained about what she went through or for being cut off from her origins, but on the contrary, she felt an exalted peace and fantastic tranquility accompanied by a spirit of joy and thanksgiving. She learned from her childhood, how to enjoy the Heavenly living wherever God wanted her to be.

As a maidservant in the home of that noble family, she performed her work with such a cheerful heart and engaging content. Her graceful behavior kept her mistress, the household, all their relatives and friends wondering and amazed about how this captive virgin always carried such exalted peace and perpetual smile, as though she was living in Paradise.

¹ St. 'Theognosta's' biography (a different version) could be found under the letter 'T' [File # 0719]

Finding favor in her sight, her mistress set her as the head of the workers serving in the house. However, she had her heart attached to the Heavenly life, and she kept practicing her asceticism and prayers with great strife. She gained the love and respect of her master, his wife, and the children, even the servants, slaves, and maidservants. They used to find pleasure in talking with her, and everybody felt a unique attraction towards her.

Nino came to be the subject of talk of all; they considered her the happiest person in Georgia. She had such a powerful impact on people by her purity, wisdom, and long prayers day and night, and whenever they ask her about her faith, she simply answered that she worshipped Christ as her God.

The Frightening God:

However, Nino was in agony, observing how all the people of Georgia would go every morning and evening to worship the frightening god Amazi, who carried a big sword to grant Georgia the victory. They believed that Amazi has the power of the life-giving sun. Nobody dared to touch his bronze statue, lest he or she would die.

This kind of worship manifested itself in the life of every citizen of Georgia, even on the children, who used to pretend fighting one another with wooden swords in their play, imitating their god of war. The family problems were prevalent in Georgia because of such hostile spirit and hatred on which they were raised since their childhood.

The people of Georgia noticed how Nino offered no bloody sacrifices and how she did not have any of the expressions of terror and fear, which showed on their faces when they were practicing their worship.

In her worries about them, Nino did not cease to pray for the sake of the people of Georgia and the whole world. By her inner peace, her perpetual smile, and her Christian behavior, she testified to her Christ the Savior of the world. She used to marvel how the devil could manage to draw the hearts of people to worship a fighting god, who knows nothing but violence; to worship the sun, as the life-giver; and how they have not experienced the sweetness of Christ the Grantor of peace, and the Creator of the sun!

Whenever somebody would ask that captive Nino about the secret behind her joy, she would tell them about the person of the Lord Jesus, from the Old and the New Testaments, and about the exalted Divine promises. Many of them marveled to hear that her God is the Savior, not only of her and her people but of the whole world; and how He is entirely different from their terrifying god.

Healing a Sick Child:

One day, a noblewoman with her sick child came to see the lady of the

house. She had a bitter soul, and her tears were flowing from her eyes. She asked her the favor of being allowed to see her maidservant Nino.

When Nino was called, she came with the spirit of meekness and humility. On seeing how the guest lady was shedding tears, she could not keep herself from doing the same. In pain, the lady said to her: "I heard about you, O blessed sister Nino; and for a long time, I wanted to come to seek from you to pray on behalf of my only child. However, what kept me from doing that was my fear of provoking the anger of the god of Georgia upon me and on my family; because your God is not known in our country. Besides, I am sorry to confess to you that knowing that you are a captive slave-girl, my vain pride kept me from asking anything from you. My only child had fallen ill several months ago, I took him to the most famous physicians in Georgia, but they said that his illness is untreatable and it could not be healed by any medicine, and they delivered me to the spirit of despair.

You know that we have a custom, that when a child falls ill, his mother will carry him from one house to another seeking help in his healing. So, I did with my child for several months in agony, but with no results.

Also, I took him to our temples to seek his healing from the god of Georgia, but my child is still on the brink of death, as you may notice.

I heard so much about you, so tell me now, what shall I do? If he dies, I shall perish along with him, for what would my life be without him?"

With tears flowing from her eyes, but with the spirit of hope, Nino looked at the poor mother and said to her: "My lady! I cannot heal your child, for I have no experience with medicine. However, what I could do for you is to pray on his behalf to Jesus Christ, who can heal all illnesses. Now, if you have faith, my God, the Lord Jesus Christ, the Physician of the souls and bodies, is alone, able to heal him. Do you believe in Him?"

After saying that, Nino wrapped the child in her rough robe, knelt, and prayed to the Lord Jesus Christ. Then, she gave him back to his mother, completely healed from his illness. Right away, the woman believed in the Heavenly Physician, and went on her way, thanking God and proclaimed her faith in the Lord of glory Jesus Christ. At the same time, Nino gained more honor in the sight of her masters, who felt the power of her God, the Grantor of health and life.

The Queen of Georgia calls on Nino:

The news of that miracle spread around, for the mother of that child couldn't keep silent about the work of the Lord Jesus Christ, the Grantor of healing. Then, it happened that the queen of Georgia was seriously ill, suffering from persistent pain, which no physician could heal. One of the noble ladies said to her: "Your majesty! Have you not heard about the lady

whose soul was embittered on her only child who was sick? How a Christian captive prayed for him, and the God of the Christians instantly healed him? Why do you not call this captive to pray on your behalf to be healed too?"

The queen felt a glimpse of hope filling her heart, as though a ray of light has shone into her core after being for so long in the darkness of despair, so she said: "After I tried in vain all those physicians of Georgia and resorted to our god; let me try this foreign captive Nino."

The queen ordered one of her servants to hasten to go and call Nino to her private quarters in the royal palace. He was marveling why the queen would seek a foreign maidservant, while the palace was full of servants and slaves who were aspiring to serve their queen; yet he went to where that captive served.

Rejecting the Royal Invitation:

On his way to Nino, the servant wondered how that maidservant would receive the royal invitation to visit the queen in her private wing, a dream for anybody. Will her masters seek to accompany her to share her honor? And if they do, will the queen let them do it?

On reaching the house, that servant sought from her masters to let him speak with Nino, for he carries to her a personal message from the queen. All welcomed the messenger of the queen, who cheerfully said to Nino: "Dear Nino, her majesty the queen wants you to go to her. She is on her sickbed expecting your arrival in her private wing."

With the same cheerfulness, Nino told the messenger: "Master! Please tell her majesty, the queen, that because I live a life of prayer in seclusion and has no authority to leave the house, I would love to welcome her majesty in my little room if it is ok with her."

Having the shock of his life by such an unexpected response, having no authority to argue; and feeling that he failed in his mission, he returned to tell the queen what Nino has said.

A Royal Visit:

On hearing the returned message of Nino, the queen was surprised, but she did not get angry. On the contrary, she held the maidservant into a higher status in her view. Perceiving that the girl did not seek temporal glory or a human honor, the queen instantly decided to go to her. She ordered the officials to prepare for her trip. When the queen arrived at Nino's place, she found in her an exultant person who was cheerful in the spirit. An instant harmony formed between their two souls, and they started talking to each other like old friends.

Nino assured the queen that, although she was sinful and was helpless by

herself to do anything for her majesty, yet by faith, the queen could be healed through the action of the Lord Jesus Christ, the Physician of the souls and the bodies. The queen found comfort in Nino's words, and her heart got attached to the person of the Lord Jesus. The two of them stood up praying, and the Lord Jesus shone His light inside the queen's heart, and suddenly she felt utterly healed of her illness. The queen attempted to reward Nino, but the saint answered that she had done nothing to her; but it was her God Jesus Christ, the Creator of the whole world, who healed her. The queen returned to her palace, totally preoccupied with how to make the king, the royal court, and all the people enjoy the Love of Christ the Savior of all humanity.

The Wrath of the Gods of Georgia:

It was such a beautiful day when the queen entered the palace so exultant in the spirit. The king and all the royal entourage felt as though celebrating a feast and only talked about the healing of the queen. Banquets were held, and the elites of the country came to congratulate the royal couple. The queen, on the other hand, had her heart raised to Heaven, and her mind was completely preoccupied with the salvation of her people.

In the evening, king Mirian III joined his wife, who narrated to him all that happened to her and how the true God was glorified in her. Much impressed, the king said: "It is befitting of us to donate to Nino some gold and precious gifts." The queen replied: "Nino seeks nothing of the sort. All that we can present to her is to worship the Lord Jesus Christ, who healed me through her prayers." The queen sought from her husband to forsake the worship of the god of war and the god of the sun; and to open his heart to the Living God who sent His Word Incarnate to save everyone.

Although the heart of the king started to be drawn toward the Heavenly matters, and he began to taste the sweetness of the exalted Divine love; however, he firmly addressed his wife, saying:

"I shall not deny you of Him who healed you. You are free to worship Jesus Christ as your Savior. However, please do not spread the word about Him; lest the gods of Georgia might get provoked to anger, and their curse would dwell upon us and cause the people to rebel against us. We cannot possibly withstand their wrath."

The king found no reason to worship a new god, but the queen who came to taste the sweetness of the original holy life after her body was healed; kept reminding her husband of the Lord Jesus Christ. Whenever she would do that, the king used to get thoroughly disturbed, and his fears would overwhelm him that the curse of the gods would set on his people if they worship a strange god.

With extreme firmness, king Mirian III sought from his wife to stop

talking about the Lord Jesus; and he started to take a strong adversary stand against those who received the new faith.

Amid The Fog:

After a short period, the king went out hunting; it was his favorite sport. It happened that he got lost in very dense fog in the forest. The king felt that his life was in great danger. At that time, he remembered what his wife was telling him about the Lord Jesus Christ, the Savior of the whole world. He vowed that if He guided him back to his place, he would believe in Him. Instantly, the fog vanished, peace-filled his heart, and he felt that rays of Lord Jesus' love had filled his core and drew him to the Divine presence. The king returned safely to his palace from his hunting trip, feeling that he has caught a unique catch by acquiring the faith in Him who has the authority on Heaven and earth.

Once the king saw his wife, he gave her the good news about the work of the Lord Jesus Christ within his heart. He proclaimed to her his strong desire to dedicate all the energies of his country to preach the Gospel of the Savior of the world.

Nino the Preacher:

The queen called the amazing captive Nino to tell her about the news of God's work in the life of the king, and what he intended to do to the account of the Kingdom of Heaven.

In his blind zeal, the king planned to force his people into the new religion by the sword. However, St. Nino told him that preaching could not be accomplished by the power of the sword, but by the power of what is in the Gospel. The king also tried to do it by imposing higher taxes on the non-believers, but again by her love, humility, and perseverance, Nino managed to convince him that the Heavenly and Spiritual Kingdom of Christ cannot be won by forcing the people to believe, neither through laws nor through taxes. St. Nino became a spiritual guide to the king and the queen; and was able to gain so many souls in the palace to the account of the Kingdom of God.

Eventually, the king declared officially to his people that their country would be following Christianity as their religion. He gave Nino the task of preaching and teaching the new religion. She started a robust public campaign to spread Christianity, and she was supported by the royal palace and all the statesmen since they experienced how the grace of God was apparent in her life. In her preaching, Nino moved from one city to another, even she went outside of Georgia, testifying to the Lord Jesus Christ. She managed to gain to Christ the elites, farmers, traders, and slaves.

The king sought from Emperor Constantine the Great (306-337 AD) to

send a bishop and few priests to serve in Georgia, where Christianity was rapidly spreading because of that fantastic captive.

Nino (Theognosta), the Mother-Superior:

Nino helped the new bishop in preaching, particularly among the women. A multitude of dedicated virgins gathered around her, and a convent was established in the area for them. St. Nino lived among those virgins as their mother-superior.

Building a Church:

Through the spreading zealously of the king, he proclaimed his intention to build a magnificent cathedral using the timber of his superb garden. When the work started, they cut a huge tree to erect at the center as the main support of the new church. Then, after they laid the foundations, they tried to raise that huge tree to set it upright on its base, but they could not do it even after they doubled the number of workers. All went home that evening in great despair.

That night, Nino entered her room, prayed the whole night, seeking from God not to let the king and his men be in despair, while they were building the first church in Georgia. On the next morning, when the king and his men went back to the building site, they were exceedingly amazed to see a bright light shining from that large tree. Then, the tree moved on its own before the eyes of all, to settle down on its base, without anyone touching it.

The rest of the church was easily built, and Nino, with her helpers, continued to testify to the Christian faith. The king's heart longed to get baptized, together with all his people.

Nino did not live long in her convent, for God allowed her to be inflicted with a severe illness, then to repose on the 17th of Tout in the year 338 AD, in the glorious feast of the Cross.

After her departure, a church was built next to her grave, which came to be a site of pilgrimage by so many. After king Mirian III and the queen passed away, their son became a king; and he kept on testifying to his Savior. He managed to draw many more to faith.

This above story was narrated by the historian Rufinus,¹ where he quoted a Georgian prince called Bakur, whom he met in Palestine before the start of the 5th century AD. It was translated into Greek, Syrian, Armenian, Coptic, Arabic, and Ethiopian languages.

¹ *Tyrannius Rufinus (c. 345–410) translated Eusebius Church History into Latin, and added new information. His history was the standard historical text during the medieval period.*

NIOLA SADONITA, THE CONFESSOR¹

Arresting the Virgin:

In the year 1975, Niola Sadonita was arrested in the Republic of Lithuania, which was at the time affiliated with the Soviet Union. That virgin used to care for and treat the sick, but the Soviet authorities put her under arrest because they claimed that she was an activist who helped print, publish, and publicly distributed a newspaper that called for freedom.

In her trial encage, Niola said: "I love you all like my brothers, and I want to sacrifice myself for the sake of the faith in God. I know that you arrested me because of the newspaper I distribute, which was expected from you to do, because the newspaper exposes the crimes committed by the atheists against the believers in God, and that is the reason behind your hate for whoever takes away the deceiving mask behind which you hide."

Exiling the Virgin:

Niola was condemned to be exiled for six years in Siberia. She was led by the soldiers under heavy security to a train wagon of prisoners. The travel kept going continuously for almost four weeks. Finally, she reached the camp, but utterly worn out from exhaustion and physical weakness.

Hard Labor inside the Camp:

Niola was tasked with the type of challenging work in a glass factory, where the dust generated from the cutting of the glass damaged her lungs. Then, she was assigned to work in a factory for making gloves; where she was committed to producing seventy pairs of gloves every day. She had to work from 6 a.m. until 10 p.m. At the same time, out of her love, she used to help and serve the elderly women in the camp, regardless of their beliefs, for her heart was opened enough for all.

In the Region of Bogoshani:

To torture her even more, she was moved up to the region of Bogoshani, which took her twenty-seven days to reach, during which she was inflicted with serious maladies without access to any medical care. She was inflicted with acute pneumonia and severe inflammation in the ears, besides suffering the stings of bugs because of the lack of hygiene, but in all those sufferings, she kept offering a sacrifice of thanksgiving to the Lord Jesus Christ, who made her worthy to partake of His passion.

¹ A contemporary figure who she and her friend challenged the atheistic thought in the Soviet Union

In a Desert Region:

Feeling that she did not have enough agony, so the people in charge planned to move her to a desert region known for its bad reputation. There, she suffered a serious illness, and her body temperature went very high because of intense inflammation, so they sent her back to her work in school.

In the year 1980, that heroine was released, after enduring so much suffering for the sake of her faith in the Lord Jesus Christ.

NIPUS, THE HERETIC BISHOP**The One Thousand Year Reign:**

Nipus was the one who spread the heresy of ‘The One Thousand Year Reign’ on earth. He was the bishop of Arsino in the district of Fayyum during the 3rd century AD. He was known among his flock by such virtuous character, which made them much revere him.

This bishop introduced his people to new teaching, in which he assured them that the time was approaching when the Lord Jesus Christ would reign one thousand years on earth as one of the kings of the world. He interpreted what was written in the Book of Revelation concerning that point in a literal way, and he wrote a book in which he contradicted those who considered that Revelation's statement was a symbolic one (rev. 20). He strove to convince his flock with his view, and they accepted it without further discussion.

At the time of Origen (184-253 AD), when some people interpreted that statement about the one thousand years reign in a literary way, he strongly opposed it and almost wiped it off. Origen interpreted the verses as referring to the spiritual joys befitting the nature of those spirits which resurrected in perfect form, and accordingly, it is not in this world, but in the world to come. However, Nipus decided to revive that literary view after it has weakened. After his death, someone with authority, honor, and experience called Crassion, took over the matter to spread that heresy.

The Stand of Pope Dionysius:

While visiting his flock in the year 255 AD, the 14th Pope of Alexandria St. Dionysius the Great (246-264 AD) came to hear about that heresy. Then, when asked by its believers to proclaim his view about it, he used the utmost wisdom, drew them to him by tenderness and compassion. Then, he held a Council for three days, in which Nipus views were examined. Afterward, the pope wrote a message about ‘The Divine Promises,’ in which he refuted the materialistic literary interpretation of the Book of Revelation.

NIQAM, THE REPENTANT (The martyr)

St. Niqam was the son of a Coptic archon, called Buqyra el-Sawwaf. He was a contemporary of the 66th Pope of Alexandria, St. Christodoulus (1046-1077 AD). Being very young, rebellious, and disobedient to his parents, it happened that once his father rebuked him, and Niqam forsook the house and joined a gang of evil young men. They managed to seduce him to deny his Christ and to cut his relationship with his parents and with the church, even though his uncle was Abba Guirgis, the bishop of Meesarah, near Qasqam and El-Qusyah.

His Repentance:

By God's grace, he eventually realized the seriousness of what he has done, and he presented true repentance. Then, he met a monk who happened to come to Cairo to do some errands for his monastery. Niqam discussed his situation with the monk, and he advised him to leave Cairo and join a monastery to practice a life of repentance. Niqam followed the advice and joined the monastery of the Archangel Michael.

Testifying to his Christ:

In the monastery, Niqam felt intense remorse, and his conscience rebuked him, how he could publicly deny his Christ, and then he would repent in secret! Then, he decided to testify to his Christ publicly among those before whom he previously denied Him. Seeking from the monks to support him with their prayers, he bid them farewell and went his way. Niqam encircled his waist, wore a Cross on his chest, and started to wander around the marketplaces and streets of Cairo. He was clothed in the sort of attire which the Christians were forced to wear at that time.

People were amazed to see him doing that, and some wondered if he was the same Niqam who previously denied his faith. Niqam, however, courageously declared: "Yes, I am Niqam, and I regret what I have previously done; I declare my faith in the Lord Jesus Christ and never in anyone else." They eventually arrested him and led him to the governor to be tried.

In Prison:

The judges started to argue with him and tried to lure him into changing his mind, with promises and threats, but the saint persisted on his firm stand on faith. Then, he was cast back in prison, pending his execution. There, he

encountered a saintly imprisoned monk, who strengthened him and encouraged him to testify to the name of the Lord Jesus Christ until death.

Niqam's father attempted to save him through a friend, one of the army chiefs of the Fatimid caliph Al-Mustansir bi-Allah (1036-1094 AD), with whom he had a close relationship. The army chief advised him that the only way to save his son was to send some people to the prison and that Niqam would pretend to be out of his mind in front of them. Then, if they testify about that in court, the judge might acquit him. Then, the army chief sent some of his men to prison, but Niqam refused to pretend insanity; on the contrary, he testified to his Christ with high confidence and a balanced mind. The army chief was amazed at the brave stand of Niqam, and he had no other way but to have him executed.

His Martyrdom:

St. Niqam was led to the place of execution on the Rhoda island,¹ followed by a great crowd of people, some were sad, and others were evil until they brought him to the designated location by the river.² There, the officer tasked with his execution, dismounted from his mule, drew his sword, and said to him: "Listen Niqam; I am ready to give you this mule of mine, with its golden bridle and precious saddle, add your name to the entourage of the Sultan and designate for you a huge salary; if you change your mind."

Bravely, Niqam said to him: "Even if you give me the whole kingdom of Egypt, I would not consider." The angry officer slapped him so violently on his face that his eye instantly became swollen. However, Niqam gave thanks to God with perseverance and longsuffering.

Trying again to give him more promises, Niqam said to him: "Do not waste more time with someone who made sure that all the glory of this world is worth nothing compared to the Kingdom of God for those who seek it." Then, he prayed, made on himself the sign of the Cross, knelt, and faced up east looking toward Heaven. One of the believers tried to cover his head to spare him the terror of death, but the soldiers prevented him from doing that, so he shouted to the saint: "Have courage, O soldier of Christ; I see now an angel of the Lord above your head holding in his hand the crown of your strife." The executioner struck his neck with the sword, and Niqam delivered his soul in the hand of his Savior. He was only twenty-two years old.

Light Shining on his Body:

Niqam's body was left in the open air under heavy guards. At midnight, a

¹ 'Rhoda' island is affiliated now with Old Cairo, near 'Manial el-Rhoda.'

² That location was where the bridge of 'Al-Malek el-Saleh' in Old Cairo today.

great light shone on the body, which terrified the guards greatly. When the caliph Al-Mustansir heard about it, he ordered his burial. The saint's father came over and buried the body at the church of the Angel, near the Mukhtar Park, which was planted during the emirate of Al-Akhsheed (935-968 AD), near the Nilometer at Rhoda Island. That church remained there until the days of the 69th Pope St. Macarius II (1102-1128 AD).

Three days after his martyrdom, Pope Christodoulus came to the church, bared his shrouds to get his blessing, and placed the body with great honor in a unique tomb inside the church.

When that church was demolished, the saint's body was moved to the church of the Archangel Michael near the Babylon Fortress.

[Nabil F. Michael: *The Biography of St. 'Niqam' the Repentant*; May 1991]

NISTHEROUS, ABBOT

Nistherous (Nesteros) was the name of two of the Egyptian wilderness fathers: One of them was called 'The friend of St. Anthony,' and the other was called the 'Cenobite.' Most probably, the two of them were the same person.

Escape from the Spirit of Vainglory:

While Fr. Nistherous was walking in the wilderness with one of the brothers, he saw a huge serpent, and right away, he escaped from the area. The brother told him: "You too would have fear, O father?" The father answered him: "No! I do not have fear, my son, but I would rather escape from the serpent; otherwise, I might not be able to escape from the vainglory."

What is the Good Deed?

It was said about one of the Nistherous saints (The friend of St. Anthony); that one of the brothers asked one of the elders: "What would be the good deed I could do and through which I may live?" The elder answered him: "God knows the righteousness. However, I have heard that one of the fathers asked St. Nistherous the same question, and the saint's answer was: 'Are not all the deeds equal? According to the Scripture: Abraham was hospitable, and God was with him. Elijah loved the tranquility, and God was with him, and David was humble, and God was with him. Therefore, whatever you think that your soul wishes to do, according to the will of God; go ahead and do it,

and keep it in your heart.”¹

The Silence:

Fr. Yousef asked the elder Fr. Nistherous: “What can I do to be able to control my tongue?” Then, the elder asked him in turn: “When you talk, do you feel comfortable?” and the answer was in the negative. So, the elder said: “If you do not feel comfortable, why then do you have to talk? Would you rather not keep quiet? and if you were involved in a discussion, let your listening be much more than your talking.”

I shall not Seek my Needs from Anyone:

When one of the brothers saw Fr. Nistherous wearing two overcoats, he asked him: “If a poor man comes to you and asks for one, which of them will you give him?” The Father answered: “The second one.” The brother asked: “If another comes to you asking?” He said: “I shall cut the one I still have into two, give him half and cover myself with the remaining half.” The brother still asked him: “If a third one comes seeking what is left on you, what will you then do?” The elder said: “I shall give him all I have, and go somewhere to dwell, where God will cover my nakedness, but I shall never seek my need from anyone else.”

The Work of the Monk:

Fr. Nistherous said: “The monk should bring himself every morning and evening to give an account by saying: ‘What have I done of what God wanted me to do? and what have I done of what He did not want me to do?’ This is what we should keep doing all our lives, and this was the way Abba Arsanius has lived since he cared to stand before God daily without sin. You should pray to God, the way you would in the presence of someone else since God is present with you. Do not make yourself a legislator, and do not judge anyone.

The monk who vows, perjures, lies, curses, slanders, or laughs loudly; would be considered out of order and acting strangely haughty because, whoever honors himself and elevates it above what it is worth, will perish.”

As for the second St. Nistherous; he had gifts and miraculous powers.

Once, he was asked by one of the most prominent monks of his time St. Poemen or St. Pastor, about his spiritual powers and how he got them. St. Nistherous answered: “Once I became a monk, I said to myself: ‘When a donkey is beaten, it will never answer back.’ That is how I kept going and how I lived until I reached the condition described by David in his Psalm: *“I*

¹ This answer was learned from St. abba Anthony...

was so foolish and ignorant; I was like a beast before You. Nevertheless I am continually with You; You hold me by my right hand." (Psalm 73:22-23).

In the year 395 AD, St. Nistherous was visited by St. John Cassian (360-435 AD). In his 14th and 15th essays¹ (Conferences); on 'The Spiritual Knowledge' (*De Spiritali Scientia*), and 'The Divine Gifts' (*De Charismatibus Divinis*); St. John Cassian wrote two long articles covering what he heard from St. Nistherous about two main subjects. Some excerpts from those essays are given below:

- As it is impossible for man to be exalted in all the good deeds which I have listed earlier; therefore, if someone tried to acquire all of them on an equal level would reach this result. While he is striving in every task, he will not be able to do any of them well enough, and he will experience loss instead of gain; because of his constant shifting among those tasks. There are so many ways that people can advance towards God, so a man should focus his sight on one task without changing it; until he becomes perfect in the way of life designated by God for him.
- If you want to prepare your hearts as temples for the spiritual knowledge; then you have to purify yourselves from any traces of all sins and get rid of all worldly concerns; because it is impossible for the soul which is confused with the worries of this world, even to a little extent, to acquire the gift of knowledge, or becoming a source of spiritual interpretation through struggling in reading the Holy matters.
- That is why we should actively avoid being puffed up with vainglory; to become partners with Him, whom the prophet commends by saying: "*He who does not put out his money at usury*" (Psalm 15:5). For whoever spreads the words of God, for the sake of getting commended by men; would be like that who puts his money at usury; and would not be worthy of any reward, but deserves stiff punishment.
- Humility is the master of all virtues and the definite foundation of the Heavenly structure. It is the exalted personal gift of the Savior. Man can perform in the name of the Lord the miracles performed by the Lord Jesus Christ, without the risk of falling into pride, as long as he follows in the meek path of the Lord; not in the exaltation of His miracles, but His virtues of perseverance and humility, but whoever intends to command the unclean spirits, to have the gift of healing or any of the other splendid miracles, to show off before the multitudes; even if he does all that in the Name of Christ; yet he would be far from the Lord; because he is not following his humble Lord due to the pride in his heart.

¹ New Advent, *Fathers of the Church > Conferences (John Cassian) > Conferences 14 & 15*: [www.newadvent.org/fathers/350814.htm] & [www.newadvent.org/fathers/350815.htm]...

NITRA, BISHOP OF FARAN, FATHER

The Wilderness and the Bishopric:

They said about father Nitra, the disciple of Fr. Selwan (Selwanes), that when he lived in his cell on Mount Sinai, he used to treat his body with moderation, but once he became a bishop on Faran (Feiran), he treated his body with harsh asceticism. His disciple said to him: "Father; when we were in the wilderness, you were not as ascetic as you are now." The older saint answered him, saying: "There, in the barren and desolate wilderness, I made sure to prevail on my body, lest I might fall ill and have to seek help where there was no help, but here we have the world and all the capabilities. In case I fall ill, I shall have someone to help me. Otherwise, I would lose my monastic habit."

[Publications of the Light: The Sayings of the Elder Fathers, Lebanon 1983]

NOFER, THE HERMIT ANCHORITE, ST.

In the monastery of Al-Ashmonein:

St. Nofer (Onuphrius/Abu Nufar) was living in the wilderness of Upper Egypt in the 3rd and 4th centuries AD. As the heart of the young man Abba Nofer was inflamed with the love of God, he longed for the life of serene worship. He joined a monastery in Hermopolis (El-Ashmonein) in El-Menya governorate, where about 100 monks were practicing a life of fellowship. They were worshipping God in silence while busy working by hand, as an integral part of their worship. Abba Nofer loved the monks over there and followed them by a spirit of piety and obedience, but his soul kept longing for a life of solitude in the wilderness. He wanted to follow the lead of St. John the Baptist and Elijah the Prophet.

Setting Forth to the Inner Wilderness:

With the build-up of his longing for the life of solitude, he managed a few years later, to go to the inner wilderness, in the quietness of the night. He did not let anyone know since he realized how much the other monks loved him and did not like to lose his company. He carried with him one loaf of bread and some vegetables just enough for four days, and he set forth toward the south, between the mountains that separate lower Egypt from the Oasis. In

his way, he was praying to God, seeking His counsel.

Going deep into the desert, all of a sudden, he saw a shining light through which an angel of the Lord appeared to him. The angel said: "I am your guardian angel who never left your side since you were in your cradle. Now, do not worry, but proceed continuously forward, to reach the place prepared for you by God."

The angel accompanied him until they reached a cave, then he disappeared. Abba Nofer knocked on the cave's door, saying: "Bless me." Here an awesome tall man appeared, before whom Abba Nofer knelt and kissed his feet, but the elder anchorite lifted him, saying: "Abba Nofer, you are my brother in the Lord; come in and have rest for few days, then proceed on the way inspired to you by the Lord."

After a few days, the elder anchorite accompanied him for four days until they reached a cave next to a palm tree. The elder anchorite lived with him for a month to train him on the life of solitude. Then, he left him with a promise to visit him once every year until he reposed in the Lord during one of his visits.

His Encounter with St. Paphnutius:

St. Nofer was mentioned by St. Paphnutius (Paphnoti), the ascetic, whom the grace of God moved to meet with the desert hermits and anchorites, the servants of God. St. Paphnutius did encounter a group of them, and he managed to write their biographies, among whom was Abba Nofer.

St. Paphnutius set forth from his cell into the inner wilderness; because his heart flared up with a longing to see the hermits, the servants of God. He walked for eight days until all his provisions of food and water finished. With the spirit of faith, he kept saying to himself: "Have courage Paphnutius, to see the hermit servants of our Good God Christ, to encounter those earthly angels and to enjoy the paradise of their lives and their Divine virtues." He kept walking for several more days until he collapsed on the ground from exhaustion. There and then, an angel in the form of a man appeared to him, touched his lips, and Lo! all feelings of fatigue, hunger, and thirst went away.

He resumed walking, praying, and praising God; while the angel kept appearing to him for a period of seventeen more days. Then, he finally saw St. Nofer approaching, completely naked covered only by his long hair and his beard, which reached down to his knees, and he was wrapped in palm fibers.

When Abba Paphnutius saw the saint, he was overwhelmed with fear thinking of him as a spirit, but St. Nofer encouraged him by making the sign of the Cross on him, reciting the Lord's Prayer and addressing him, saying: "Welcome Paphnutius." By calling his name, he brought calm to him. Then,

both prayed together and talked about the great deeds of God. Then, when Abba Paphnutius, asked him to tell his story and how he reached such a place; St. Nofer said: “Sixty years ago, I went to a monastery in Upper Egypt, called ‘Gir Breda’ (one of many isolated monasteries, which were once in the Ashmonein Desert, affiliated with the diocese of Malawi). There, I sought monasticism, for which I longed since my youth, to be one of those who have forsaken everything for the sake of their love of the Lord Jesus Christ.

There were 104 elders and young monks in that monastery. We were living together in a communal life of fellowship, characterized by true love and sincere sacrifice, having one heart and one soul. The Agape table was the place we used to get together once a week after the Divine Liturgy on Sundays.

Our elder fathers were providing us with spiritual guidance and their experienced advice about the ascetic life and how to stand firm before the wars stirred up against us by the devil. They were also themselves, role models for us to follow suit in the monastic living with all its asceticism, fasts, prayers, Psalms, and laws.

One day, while we sat in church before our saintly elders learning from them the life in Christ, I heard them glorify the lifestyle of the hermit fathers who dwelt in the inner wilderness, copying Elijah the Prophet and John the Baptist. At that point, I went to one of the elders and asked him: “Saintly father, are there in the wilderness, anyone in God's view, better than you, despite all your toil and great asceticism in your daily lives, in addition to your spiritual truthfulness because of God's love, which fills your hearts?”

He answered: “Yes, my son Nofer; there are those who are far better than we. We have not yet started our monastic struggle, compared to their exalted monastic life, in which they offer themselves as sacrifices of love to the Lord Jesus Christ. For us, if our hearts got squeezed, we would have someone to comfort us; if we fall ill, we could find those who would visit us; and if we would get naked, we could find those who would cover us up. The dwellers of the inner wilderness have no one to help.”

The Hermetic Life:

On hearing this, my heart flared up with longing for the hermitic life. By night, I took a little bread and went out from the monastery, imploring the Lord Jesus Christ to guide me to where I could dwell, and so He did.

While I was walking, a beautiful light shone around me; and an angel appeared. Overwhelmed with fear, I thought of going back to the monastery; but the angel said to me: “Do not fear, O Nofer! I am the angel designated by God for you since your birth. I shall be with you; I will accompany you to where the Lord chose for you.”

I rejoiced, became exultant, started to sing the Psalms with gladness, and resumed walking, accompanied by the angel. My angel brought me over to a pious saint who taught me the ways of the hermits. I left him and came here, where I found this palm tree and this spring of water. The palm tree produced twelve bunches of dates every year; each cluster was enough to sustain me for one month, and I used the water from this spring to drink.

For the last sixty years, you are the only human I have seen.”

His Departure:

The next morning, while talking, the angel of the Lord came down to tell St. Nofer, that it was time for his departure from this world. Instantly, his color came to be like fire. Seeing how St. Paphnutius was overcome with fear, St. Nofer told him: “Have no fear, O beloved Paphnutius. The Lord Jesus Christ sent you for the sake of this very hour. He sent you to bury my body after death.

The Lord let me know that today is my wedding day. The day I depart to the Heavenly church of the firstborn, together with the angels and the saints.”

St. Paphnutius said: “O saintly father! How much I wish to dwell here, in this place of your comfort. How much I long for such a life of seclusion, and to walk the way you did.”

St. Nofer commented, saying: “Brother Paphnutius, the Lord Jesus did not send you for the sake of utter seclusion, but to bury my body. You have to return and resume your strife for the sake of the love of Christ. We shall surely meet again in the Heavenly Kingdom.”

On repeating his longing to stay there, Abba Nofer said to him: “No, beloved brother! Every man has his mission on earth for the sake of spreading the kingdom. God has bestowed on you the visiting of the saints and revealing how His Holy Spirit worked in their lives. These blessed biographies you record are for the glory and praise of the Name of Christ.”

Then, on the 16th of Paona, the saint bent his knees, worshipped the Lord, bid farewell to St. Paphnutius, and delivered his pure soul into the Lord's hands. St. Paphnutius testified that he saw angels and heard them singing praise while he was wrapping his body in his cave. When he came out, he was surprised to see that the palm tree and the spring of water instantly dried up. This was by God's planning, to tell him to go back to preach the world about the saintly hermits he encountered.

Among his Words to Abba Paphnutius:

- Longing daily, to live a life of seclusion with God, I felt that I want to separate from all, to unify with the Great Holy One without limit. Therefore, I decided to forsake the monastery and set forth deep into the

inner wilderness, to the depth with Jesus.

- God made the wild beasts come to be friendly and company with me day and night. Whenever and wherever I went, they used to follow me, as though guarding me. In that way, I lived all along those years, glorifying God for His planning and His goodness for the sake of the salvation of my soul.

[The Faithful Synaxarion: 16 Paona]

[Amir Nasr: The Two Hermits: Abba Nofer and Abba Timothy, 1989]

[Melika Habib Yousef and Yousef Habib: St. Abba Nofer the Anchorite; 1970]

[The Coptic Encyclopedia: Onophrius-Saint, by René-Georges Coquin; pp. 1841-2]

NONNA, ST.

St. Nonna was born at the end of the 3rd century AD. Even though she was a pious Christian, yet she got married to Gregory, the pagan governor of Nazianzus in Cappadocia. Her husband Gregory proclaimed Christian faith, influenced by the shining role model of Christianity displayed by his wife. Eventually, her husband Gregory became a priest, then a bishop. He was the one called St. Gregory, the Nazianzus, the Elder.

St. Nonna had three children: the elder was St. Gregory the Nazianzus, who became one of the most prominent fathers of the Universal (Catholic) Church; the second was her daughter St. Gorgonia, who got married and gave birth to three sons; and the third one was St. Caesarius who worked as a physician.

St. Nonna lived after the departure of two of her children: Gorgonia, who reposed in her mother's arms, and Caesarius. Three years later, her husband, Gregory, passed away. A few months later, St. Nonna reposed in good old age in the year 374 AD. She was counted as an example of the virtuous woman who was commended by her husband and called by her children 'The Blessed Mother.'

We have mentioned her also under the biography of her daughter St. Gorgonia.

[Butler: August 5]

[A Dictionary of Christian Biography: Nonna (1), Vol. IV, pp. 50-1]

NOPI the CONFESSOR, ABAHOR, ISAIAH & PAUL, SS.

St. Jerome (347-420 AD) has written in 392-3 AD, his excellent book: 'On Illustrious Men' (*De Viris Illustribus*). The following story was narrated by St. Jerome in that book: St. Abahor met with St. Isaiah and St. Paul by the

banks of the great river (The Nile). Those three men were pure strivers in their monastic life, and they were in their way to visit a great confessor. As the distance they had to travel was pretty long, they had a chance to talk about their experiences and how God was glorified in their lives.

St. Abahor said: "I hope from God, because of the grace He bestowed upon me, that we would complete this trip by the power of the Holy Spirit and without much fatigue." Once he prayed, they found a prepared boat and a favorable wind that they managed to sail against the currents. In a short time, they found themselves at the intended location.

On landing, St. Isaiah said: "My beloved, I implore God to send the brother we seek, to meet us and reveal to us about his story and activities." St. Paul said: "God revealed to me that He will be taking this brother to Heaven after three days; this man will depart from this life to Eternity."

After they traveled for a short distance, the man they wanted to see (St. Nopi) came to meet them. After he greeted them, St. Paul said to him: "Tell us, O brother, about your story and activities; for the day after tomorrow, you will depart to the Lord."

St. Nopi answered: "Glory be to God who revealed to me that you are coming, and informed me about your lives and activities." Then, after he disclosed the details about the life of each of them and how they lived and struggled, he finally started to talk about himself. "Since the day I confessed the Name of the Lord Jesus Christ, our God, and Redeemer, no evil word came out of my mouth, and I refrained from possessing any earthly item."

[Dr. Michael Maxi Iskander: *The Garden of the Saints*]

NOVATUS, PRESBYTER OF THE ROMAN CHURCH

The historian Philostorgius (368-439 AD) believed that the presbyter Novatus (Novatian-*Antipapa*: 251-258 AD) was from Phrygia in Asia Minor. In a letter to the bishop Gabius of Antioch, the Pope of Rome St. Cornelius (251-253 AD), wrote that his adversary Novatus was unbefitting for the priesthood, a liar, a forger, a hater and untrustworthy. He added: "This man lusted for the bishopric for a long time, but he hid his strong desire within himself, using the confessors who clang themselves to him since the beginning, as a cover for his rebellion." Parts of this message was quoted by the historian Eusebius (260-340 AD), in which he included many serious faults in which Novatus fell. However, many scholars considered Novatus as a great scholar who occupied a prominent place among the Roman clergy,

who became verse in the Epicurean¹ philosophy and the Latin literature; he was also eloquent in writing and public speech.

His Lust for the Bishopric:

For a long time, Novatus desired to sit on the Roman throne. However, once the bishops chose Cornelius, he became his worst adversary, so while Pope Cornelius dealt with compassion with the repentant who sacrificed to the idols during the persecution by Decius (249-251 AD); Novatus took the opposite stand, he dissented from the See of Rome and established a group who claimed that they were keeping the original purity of the church. They called themselves 'Katharoi or Cathari,' meaning: the pure ones. Many people from the east and west joined forces with them, and they strove for several centuries.

As a consequence of that, a Council was held in Rome, attended by sixty bishops, along with many priests and deacons. The Council issued an unanimous decision that Novatus and those who followed him and adopted his view were inhuman, hater of the brethren, and had to be counted by the church as dissenters.

Both Socrates and St. Jerome believed that Novatus had become a martyr. Excavations done in Rome in the year 1932, revealed a statue that confirmed the martyrdom of Novatus.

His Works:

Among his works were:

- He wrote a vast theological work in Latin called 'About the Trinity' (*De Trinitate*), in 291 chapters. It researched about God and his features; on the union of the two natures of Christ; on the Holy Spirit, the church and the Oneness of God, although he did not use the expression of 'The Trinity' in that work.
- He wrote against the Jews concerning the circumcision, the sabbath, and their food, seeking the interpretation of what in the Old Testament using a symbolic spiritual concept.
- A message to the brethren, urging them not to go to the houses of fun.
- A message on humility.

¹ The philosopher 'Epicurus' believed that what he called "pleasure" was the greatest good, but that the way to attain it was to live modestly, to gain knowledge of the workings of the world and to limit one's desires... This would lead one to attain a state of tranquility and freedom from fear as well as an absence of bodily pain... The combination of these two states constitutes happiness in its highest form...

Of his Words:

The Christian believer should dedicate himself to read the Holy Scriptures; to find in them scenes befitting his faith. He would discover God forming the world, not only creating the animals but the amazing man as well, who was higher and better creation. Contemplating into the world, he would see happiness, despair, righteousness been rewarded, and evil-doers get punished. He would see faith wrestling fire, honesty calming down and domesticating the beasts of the wilderness. He would perceive how souls are raised from the dead; and how Satan, who conquered the world, fell dead under the feet of the Lord Jesus Christ. Scenes that are not arranged by judges and ambassadors, but by the Only Being, who is above all things.

His Views about Virginity:

Even though he sanctified matrimony, yet he considered virginity and chastity as superior, even above the law. He viewed that virginity was a feature equivalent to those of the angels, and it also might surpass them since the angels have no wrestling against a body or have to conquest their nature. Victory over pleasure is more excellent than pleasure itself. There is no conquest higher than the success of one's self.

[Eusebius of Caesarea: *The Ecclesiastical History*, Bk 6, Ch. 43]
[Questen: *Patrology*]

NUMETIUS AND COMPANY (The martyrs)

On the 1st of Hator, the church celebrates the memorial of the martyrdom of SS. Maximus, Numetius, Boctor, and Philip, who were martyred in the days of Emperor Decius (249-251 AD). Their biography could be found under the letter 'B': (Boctor, the Roman Martyr).

NUMIDICUS, THE CONFESSOR, ST.

St. Numidicus was a pious priest in North Africa. Bishop St. Cyprian of Carthage (248-258 AD) planned on ordaining him as a bishop, although it did not happen. However, during the persecution, stirred up by Emperor Decius (249-251 AD), Numidicus was stoned, burned, and left to die, but his daughter managed to rescue him; while his wife was martyred.

[A Dictionary of Christian Biography, Vol. IV, p. 62]

NYMPHODORA (The martyr)

St. Nymphodora was martyred in Bithynia in Asia Minor, during the days of Emperor Maximian (286-305 AD), along with her sisters: Menodora and Metrodora. Their biographies could be found under the letter 'M': (Menodora, Metrodora & Nymphodora, SS.)

O

OGHARITUS, ABBA

St. Ogharitus was one of the fathers of the wilderness in the Scetis, seemingly a foreigner; impressive, honorable, and he loved silence.

According to the book of 'The Paradise of Monks,' in one of the assemblies which were held in the Scetis to discuss some issues, St. Ogharitus happened to give an opinion. Afterward, a delighted priest told the saint: "We know, father, that if you were in your own country, you would have been a bishop or ahead over many, but here you are just like a stranger." The saint shook his head, sighed, and said: "Yes, it happened only once that I talked; but by God's Will, it will never happen again."

Of his Words:

- About the Prayer without Distraction: "It is great for a man to be without distraction, but it is more important to be the least among all creation."
- About Fasting: "Combine your love for God with hunger, which will bring the monk forth to the haven of no evil desires."
- About the Serenity of the Mind: "When you sit in your cell, collect your mind; remember the day of your departure from this world; think of your death; try to understand the cause of the temptation that dwells on you; keep laboring to please God; despise the things of this vain world to be perpetually silent, and do not weaken, but remember the Resurrection Day and your encounter with God."
- About the Control of the Tongue: "There is no need for much talk, which is an instinct in men, but the real need is for deeds."

[Bishopric of Beni-Sweif: *The Paradise of Monks*; 1968; pp. 271, 338, 367, 397, 401]

OLADIUS, FR.

We do not know much about saint Oladius other than what was mentioned about him in the book of 'The Paradise of Monks.' He dwelt in the wilderness for twenty years living a simple ascetic life, eating only bread and salt (and probably little herbs); and that he never raised his eyes to the ceiling of his cell, because he was always preoccupied with his inner life in the Lord.

OLYMPAS, THE APOSTLE

St. Olympas (meaning "Heavenly" in Greek) was one of the seventy apostles who were sent by the Lord to preach the Word. He was a Roman Christian whom St. Paul the Apostle saluted (in Romans 16:15) around 65 AD. He was also called Paul, and he was the one who served the disciples, carried some of the epistles of St. Peter the Apostle to the Gentiles, entered with him into Rome, where he preached and taught many. When St. Peter was martyred, this apostle was the one who took his body off the cross, shrouded him, and took him to the house of one of the believers. Then, someone reported him to Emperor Nero (54-68 AD) of being one of the disciples of St. Peter. When Nero called him for questioning, he confessed before him that the Lord Jesus Christ is the true God. Nero brutally tortured him, then asked him how he would like to die, to which the saint replied: "I want to die for the sake of Christ, but it is up to you to kill me in whatever way you choose." The emperor ordered to crucify him upside down the way his mentor died, and in this way, he received the crown of martyrdom.

[The Synaxarion of 6th Abib]

OLYMPIAS AND MAXIMUS (The martyrs)

Two noblemen of the city of Corduena in the land of Persia who were among the martyrs who enjoyed the crowns of martyrdom in the days of Emperor Decius (249-251 AD). When the emperor got authority on some of the Persian provinces, he called these two saints and inquired about their wealth to take it away from them. They answered him: "Our body members are our wealth, take, destroy, crush, and burn them, for we shall have the reward of the eternal riches from the Lord." Then, the emperor ordered torturing them with all kinds of tools without being able to shake their faith. Afterward, he sent them to his assistant Vitellius Anisius to kill them. So, that assistant kept hitting them on the head with heavy clubs until they received the crowns of martyrdom.

[Rev. Baring-Gould: Lives of Saints; April 15]

OLYMPIAS, THE DEACONESS

About St. Olympias, St. Gregory of Nazianzus said: "Olympias is the glory of the widows in the Eastern Church." Also, St. Palladius told about her: "An amazing woman! Like a precious vessel filled with the Holy Spirit.

A wonderful role model for the Eastern girl who is inflamed with the fire of the Divine Love, who goes above all obstacles setting forth to the spiritual work with a solemn Evangelic Ecclesiastical mind.”

Her grandfather Flavius Ablabius was an influential governor of Constantinople and a very close friend to Emperor Constantine I (306-337 AD). After the death of the emperor, when Ablabius sided with the 20th Pope of Alexandria St. Athanasius the Apostolic who had powerful enemies at the court of the new pro-Arian Emperor Constantius II (337-361 AD); he was dismissed from the imperial court and Ablabius retired to his estates in Bithynia. In 338 AD, Constantius II condemned Ablabius to death following false accusations of intending to usurp the throne. The emperor had her grandfather Ablabius executed in front of his own house. However, St. Olympias' father Seleucus, was also a governor.

She was born around the year 368 AD, and when she became fatherless while still a young girl, she was cared for by her uncle Procopius, a friend of St. Gregory of Nazianzus. She was raised and educated by Theodosia, the sister of St. Amphilochius, the bishop of Iconium, a close friend of St. Basil the Great. She was influenced, as well, by the great St. Melania the Elder (341-410 AD).

Known for her exalted beauty and riches, she got married while she was sixteen years old to Nebridius governor of Constantinople, who soon died. When Emperor Theodocius I (379-395 AD) intended to get her married to his relative Elpidius; she firmly refused, saying: “If God wanted me to live as a wife, He would not have taken from me my husband Nebridius.” To apply pressure on her, the emperor held all her possessions in trust for her until she would reach thirty years of age; he also denied her seeing the bishops or partaking of the church worship. She wrote to thank him for relieving her of the trouble of managing her wealth and to tell him that she would be happier if he would distribute all her possessions on the poor. The emperor was impressed by her message, and in particular, that she set forth to the east to practice the monastic life with a kindled zeal for four years. So, the emperor gave her back all her possessions in the year 391 AD.

St. Olympias went to St. Nectarius, the archbishop of Constantinople (381-397 AD), to declare her wish to dedicate her life to God. So, he set her as a deaconess, although she was still young. Since that time, she established a house for virgins (located between the Church of Peace and the Church of Hagia Sophia). She also cared for the service of the poor and the sick that so many people sought her help.

As St. John Chrysostom was ordained as an archbishop of Constantinople (398-404 AD), he had high regard for St. Olympias since he found in that deaconess widow a fiery heart who generously gave all her possessions to

serve the virgins, the poor and the sick. He admired her dearly, seeing in her fantastic motherhood toward the poor and great support toward the suffering; with a well-balanced mind and great wisdom. The previous archbishop Nectarius used also to cherish her views on so many church issues.

When St. John Chrysostom was exiled, he kept sending several supporting letters to her amid her sufferings because of what dwelt upon the church. He wanted to lift her above the pains and to motivate her toward the spiritual work and ministry. Those letters came to reveal the extent of his love, admiration, and trust for that deaconess, whom he sometimes called my Olympias. He showed the concept of suffering and gave us, as well, much about the historical sides concerning his journey and his life as an exiled in the mountains of Armenia. In those letters, he wrote:

- We could talk much about your sufferings since your early childhood up till now: sufferings from relatives, sufferings from strangers, sufferings from enemies, sufferings from those with whom you were bound since your birth, and sufferings from those with whom you were not bound, sufferings from the elites, sufferings from the poor, sufferings from the rulers, sufferings from the officials and sufferings from the clergy.
- As I said before; I fear to enter into the sea of your limitless virtues.
- Remember that since the beginning of your youth up till this very day; you did not cease to feed the Lord Jesus Christ whenever you saw Him hungry, nor to give Him to drink whenever He was thirsty, nor to clothe Him whenever He was bare, nor to receive Him whenever he was a stranger, nor to watch over Him whenever He was ill, nor to visit Him whenever He was in prison.

[Father Tadros Y. Malaty: St. John Chrysostom; 1980, pp. 34-38]

ONANIUS (The martyr)

cf. the biography of St. Andrew, the martyr.

ONESIMUS, BISHOP OF NICOMEDIA (The martyr)

cf. His biography under the letter 'A': (ANTHIMUS, BISHOP OF NICOMEDIA)

ONESIMUS, PHILEMON'S SLAVE (The martyr)

St. Onesimus was a disciple of St. Paul the Apostle. However, he was initially a slave owned by a man from Rome named Philemon. Philemon

himself proclaimed faith in Christ Jesus on the hands of St. Paul the Apostle on hearing his preaching in Rome.

It happened once that Philemon traveled for business away from Rome and took with him Onesimus, among his other slaves. There, the devil seduced Onesimus to rob a portion of his master's money and flee to Rome. By a Divine intervention, Onesimus happened to hear some of the teachings of St. Paul the Apostle, and he believed in Christ, and his heart became filled with grace and the fear of God. On remembering his robberies from his master Philemon and others, he felt so guilty and so sad; notably, he had nothing left to pay back those whom he robbed. Then, he confessed his sins to St. Paul the Apostle. The apostle put his heart at ease and wrote a message to Philemon to inform him that Onesimus became a disciple of Christ and a son to Paul. He urged him to treat him with compassion and to consider the apostle Paul responsible for whatever Onesimus robbed from him.

When Onesimus delivered the message to his master Philemon, the later rejoiced for his acceptance of the faith and his repentance and treated him according to the commandment of the apostle. He gave him his freedom from slavery and even offered him more money, which Onesimus did not accept. He told his old master that he was satisfied by the Lord Jesus Christ; then he bid him farewell and returned to Rome. There, he stayed close by St. Paul the Apostle to be able to serve him. With time, Onesimus came to be worthy of being ordained as a priest (or a bishop).

After the martyrdom of St. Paul, Onesimus was arrested by the governor of Rome, who exiled him to one of the islands. There, he managed to preach and baptize its inhabitants. When the governor came to visit that island and found him guiding the people to believe in the Lord Jesus Christ, he ordered beating him very violently, then breaking his legs. Because of that torture, he reposed in peace gaining the crown of martyrdom.

[The Synaxarion 21st of Amshir]

OPTATUS, THE BISHOP, ST.

St. Augustine described St. Optatus (Optate) as the jewel of the Universal (Catholic) Church, because of his virtuous life. He placed him on the same level as St. Cyprian, bishop of Carthage and St. Hilary, bishop of Poitier. However, we do not know a lot of details about the life of this saint.

In the 4th century AD, he was the bishop of the city of Milevis in Numidia (nowadays: Morocco in North Africa). During that time, a group of believers

called the Donatists¹ appeared, and they considered their church as the church of the saints and not the church of the sinners.

It happened that the Donatists in North Africa and another little province in Italy proclaimed that they were God's only holy church and that they were dissenting from the Universal Church, and they demanded that all the other Christians have to be re-baptized by them to join the church of the holy ones. So, Parmenian, the bishop of Carthage published an article damning their principles. After fifteen years, around the year 370 AD, St. Optatus wrote seven volumes about the Donatists controversy. He explained their faults in the first few volumes; then added more volumes when he revised his treatise.

In his essay, he wrote with a kindled zealously, he confirmed the Universality of the Church in the whole world and did not approve of the dissension of the Donatists from the holy church.

Talking about the relationship between the church and the State, he said that: "the church is in the State and not the State is in the church," even though he was prejudiced toward the throne of Rome, under which he was ordained.

St. Optatus also wrote about the original sin and the importance of the renewal by Baptism. He explained the rites of the Holy Divine Liturgy, talking about it as a True Sacrifice. He also wrote about repentance and about giving honor to the relics of the saints. St. Augustine, in refuting the Donatist's arguments, made some editing on St. Optatus treatise.

[Butler's Lives of Saints, June 4]

ORIGEN

Origen's personality will always remain controversial. Some scholars such as Johannes Quasten² and others testified to his active role in explaining the Holy Scriptures and that even his opponents have been influenced by him. However, the Coptic Church did excommunicate him while he was still alive because it felt that his teachings could be misleading. The Chalcedonian Churches, on the other hand, excommunicated him in the persons of his followers in the year 553 AD, based on what came in their writings about the existence of the soul before the body; and that all the rational creation, including the demons, will eventually be saved, .etc.

Origen was called Adamantius, which means: The Man of Steel, due to the

¹ 'Donatists' believed that Christian clergy must be faultless for their ministry to be effective and their prayers and sacraments to be valid.

² J. Quasten, *Patrology*, Vol. II, *Ante-Nicene Literature after Irenaeus*, Christian Classics 1983, pp. 37-100.

power of his unbeatable arguments and his persistence.

His Childhood:

Origen is considered a true son of Egypt, for being born in Alexandria around the year 185 AD. His father Leonides cared for educating him with the standard Hellenistic education, but also had him study the Christian Scriptures, in which he showed great interest and understanding that astonished his father. His father considered himself blessed by producing such a good son, that he often stood beside his son's bed while asleep, exposed his chest and kissed it with reverence feeling that God's Spirit was residing within it.

The Martyrdom of his Father Leonides:

Origen lived through the persecution stirred up in the year 202 AD by Emperor Septimius Severus (193-211 AD). This persecution was so violent on the church that many thought at the time that it was the sign of the coming of the Antichrist. Soon after, his father, Leonides, was arrested and put in prison waiting to be executed, Origen was seventeen years old at the time, but he decided to receive the crown of martyrdom along with his father. However, his mother kept him from realizing his wish by hiding all his clothes, forcing him to stay at home with them, to take care of his six brothers, so he wrote a message to his father in prison to urge him to receive the martyrdom, telling him: "Beware of having a change of heart because of us."

A Teacher of Literature:

As all the possessions of Leonides were confiscated after his execution, Origen and his family became in dire financial need. He found refuge with a woman of wealth and of standing that welcomed him in her house. However, he could not stay there for long; since a heretic teacher called Paul of Antioch was also accepted into her household.

Origen – even though young in age – could not tolerate to pray along with that heretic; and he held fast to the laws of the church and left her house. Origen started to teach Greek literature and grammar to be able to support his family. In teaching literature to the pagans, Origen found it a chance to testify to the Christian Faith whenever he would find a chance. He pointed out and stressed on the Christian theologies embedded in the Greek writings. By that way, he drew some pagan scholars, who came seeking to hear from him about the Christian teachings. Among them was Plutarches, who later on received the crown of martyrdom and his brother Heraclas (Yaroklas), who eventually became the 13th Pope of Alexandria (231-246 AD).

Origen and the School of Alexandria:

When the School of Alexandria became without a headteacher because of the persecution and the departure of St. Clement, the 12th Pope of Alexandria St. Demetrius I (188-230 AD) appointed Origen as a dean of the school while still eighteen years of age.

Origen stopped all his other activities and sold all his beloved precious Greek books, to dedicate his whole life to carry on his new assignment entrusted to him by the pope as a teacher of the catechumen. On his hands, many were taught, among whom, for example, was St. Alexandros bishop of Jerusalem, who always looked at Origen as his teacher and friend.

Here, we would like to refer to the role played by Origen in developing the School of Alexandria:

1- Origen threw himself with all his energies, not only to study and to teach the Holy Bible but to present his own life as well, as an example of the Evangelic life. About this, St. Gregory, the Wonder-Maker, said: "He drew us by his deeds more than he did by his teachings."

Origen was characterized by the ascetic life, along with practicing prayer as an integral part of ascetic life. He believed that this would support man to set his soul free and to make him enter into unity with God on a deeper level. He saw the prayer as an essential factor to obtain from God that special grace, which would lead to the understanding of the Word of God.

He perceived that man might seek unity with God through preserving his virginity; through retreating from this world while still living in it, through despising the human glory and through offering a sacrifice in the matters of pleasure; as much as he could.

As a lot of women came to listen to his lectures so to avoid any chance of infraction, he literally applied what came in the Holy Gospel: "*There are eunuchs who have made themselves eunuchs for the kingdom of heaven's sake.*" (Matt. 19:12). It seemed that he did present repentance on doing so; although what he did was used against him by Pope Demetrius I.

2- In the beginning, Origen focused on preparing the catechumen for Baptism, not only by teaching them the Christian Faith but also by providing them with special instructions concerning the practical Christian life.

3- The work of Origen did not stop at preparing the vast numbers who sat at his feet to receive the grace of Baptism, but also he had to prepare them for receiving the crown of martyrdom since all those who had come to his school were like people who were already accepting the risk of martyrdom.

- 4- Origen gave special attention to increasing the depth of educational thinking. As the number of his students who stayed around him from morning to evening has increased, he had to divide them into two groups. He chose his disciple Heraclas, the eloquent speaker, to teach the beginners the preliminary principles of the Christian teachings. At the same time, he dedicated his time to teach theology and philosophy to the advanced students. He gave special care in teaching the Holy Bible.
- 5- His most important influence on the School of Alexandria might have been his focus on the 'Symbolic Style' of the Holy Bible interpretation. He dedicated his whole life to that specific work. Therefore, this style of interpretation of the Holy Bible was attributed to the School of Alexandria and Origen.

Trips of Origen:

- 1- Around the year 212 AD, Origen visited Rome during the bishopric of the Roman Pope Zephyrinus (199-217 AD). There, he heard a sermon by the theologian Hippolytus about the Righteousness of the Savior. After a short time, he returned to Alexandria.
He made several trips to the land of Arabia. His first trip was around the year 214 AD when he was invited by the ruler of Petra, who wanted to get acquainted with his teachings. Origen accordingly spent a brief time there, after which he returned to Alexandria. Also, he was invited again to Arabia several times to deliberate with its bishops. The historian Eusebius referred to two of such deliberations, of which we would mention that one was in the year 244 AD. A large scale Arabian Council was held to evaluate the views of bishop Prillos concerning the Person of the Lord Jesus Christ, and the Council decided to condemn that bishop for saying that God is one Hypostasis; although initially, they tried in vain to convince him to return to the Orthodox Faith. Origen hastened to Arabia and managed to convince that bishop, which later on sent him a message of thanksgiving and became one of his devoted advocates. Anyway, that bond between Origen and the land of Arabia has been viewed as an extension to the bond between Pentinus and that land.
- 2- Around the year 216 AD, when Emperor Caracalla (198-217 AD) came to devastate Alexandria, closed its schools, persecuted and slain its teachers; Origen decided to go to Palestine, where he was welcomed by his old friend Alexander, the bishop of Jerusalem, as well as by Theoctistus, the bishop of Palestine, who invited him to explain the Holy Bible to the people in their presence; which provoked the Alexandrian Pope Demetrius I to anger; for, according to the Egyptian Church, no one except a priest

could give a sermon in the presence of a bishop. He commanded Origen to return in a hurry to Alexandria, which he did, and it so seemed that things were back to normal.

- 3- With the beginning of the reign of Emperor Severus Alexander (222-235 AD) Empress Julia Mamaea, the emperor's queen mother sent a military consort to call Origen to Antioch to explain to her some points in the Holy Bible. He responded to the invitation, and then he returned to his school.
- 4- Origen was sent to Greece for an urgent matter concerning some church issues and he remained away from Alexandria for a while. He went to Achaia for a reconciliation mission, carrying a written authorization from his patriarch. On his way, he passed through Palestine, and while he was in Caesarea, its bishop ordained him as a priest. Since, Caesarea's bishop felt that it was not befitting for a Christian scholar like Origen, who attained such a high level of spirituality and culture, to remain a layman. Also, the area bishops wanted to avoid the risk of provoking Pope Demetrius again, in case they allow Origen to teach in their presence.

Yet, the pope considered such an ordination worse than their previous transgression; and considered it vain for two reasons:

- That Origen allowed himself to be ordained by a bishop other than his own, without having permission from him.
- By castrating himself, Origen deprived himself of the right to be considered for any priestly rank. (Up to this day, it is not allowed for anyone who castrates himself to be ordained as a member of the clergy).

His Condemnation:

Pope Demetrius was not able to tolerate what he considered as Origen's act of insubordination, so he convened a synod of some bishops and a few priests in 232 AD and condemned him to banishment. Then, he assembled another synod of bishops and sent a formal condemnation of Origen to all the other churches declaring that he was no longer fit to teach and also proclaimed certain theological faults with his writings.

Pope Demetrius asked the Roman Pope Pontianus (230-235 AD) to hold a Council to support the condemnation of Origen. Rome accepted the decision, as well as many other bishops, except for those of Caesarea of Palestine, Arabia, Achaia, Phoenicia, and Cappadocia, who refused to go along.

Then, Pope Demetrius put the School of Alexandria under the charge of Heraclas, the first pupil of Origen, who eventually became the Pope of Alexandria.

From Caesarea, Origen had to defend himself against those severe charges. Among those who documented his defense was the theologian and historian Rufinus (340-410 AD), who translated a lot of Origen's writings

from Greek to Latin. In his book 'De Adulteratione,' he included a lengthy quotation from a letter that Origen addressed to his friends in Alexandria, complaining about those who intentionally have changed and distorted certain parts of his books. Also, he mentioned that Origen protested about those who published fake books in the Christian sphere attributed to him, in which it was not difficult to find what was worthy of condemnation.

Also, according to St. Jerome (347-420 AD), there was another letter addressed by Origen to Fabianus bishop of Rome (236-250 AD), in which he accuses his friend, Ambrose, of hastening to publish one of his books, before he was able to finish it. He probably meant the book called 'The Principles,' which drew a lot of scorn from so many against him, even after he died.

In his 25th treatise on the Gospel according to St. Luke, Origen wrote: "It would be the pleasure for my enemies to attribute to me certain views I would never adopt, nor would ever come to my mind."

A New School:

The bishop of Caesarea exhorted Origen to establish a new Theological School in his diocese. After he established that school, he remained as its dean for about twenty-five years. In that school, St. Gregory, the Wonder-Maker, studied for five years.

The Persecution by Maximinus I:

During the persecution stirred up by Emperor Maximinus I (235-238 AD), Origen took refuge in Caesarea of Cappadocia. Whereas, his two old friends Ambrose and Protocritus priest of Caesarea were arrested and put in prison. To them, Origen wrote an essay 'Provocation to Martyrdom,' in which he considered martyrdom as proof of the authenticity of the Christian truth and as a continuation of the work of Salvation. His two friends were eventually released, and Origen returned to Caesarea of Palestine.

Origen then traveled to Athens via Beleneh, where he spent several days in Nicomedia. There, he received a message from the historian Julius Africanus (~160-240 AD) asking him about the episode of Susanna and whether it was an integral part of the Book of Daniel. Origen replied by a long letter that he sent to him from Nicomedia.

Origen's Departure:

In the days of Emperor Decius (249-251 AD), who stirred the persecution up again, Origen was arrested, tortured and put into a heavy iron collar, his feet were put into stocks for several days and he was cast into the inner prison after being threatened to be burned alive.

Origen endured all those sufferings with great courage, and even though he did not die while going through them, yet he died shortly after, most probably, because of them.

Before he died, he got an urgent message from the 14th Pope of Alexandria St. Dionysius the Great (247-264 AD), who succeeded Pope Heracles. The pope's letter was about 'The Martyrdom.' The pope probably had the intention to revive the relationship between Origen of Alexandria and the Church of Alexandria. In the year 254 AD, Origen reposed in the city of Tyre in Palestine, he was sixty-nine years of age.

The Christians in Tyre buried his body in the church with great honor, close to the Altar. They covered his tomb with a marble slab on which they inscribed: 'Here lies the great Origen,' after leaving a huge heritage of the interpretation of the Holy Bible and introducing his symbolic program of interpretation, even though he also left a wide controversy within the church because of him, even among the monks, that caused limitless disputes and troubles.

P

PACHOMIUS THE GREAT, ST.

St. Pachomius is the Father of the Coenobitic Monasticism, as St. Anthony the Great is considered the Father of the Monastic Family, being the first leader of the monastic movement in the world, where many hermits became disciples on his hands and lived in secluded caves and cells around him. He also was the guide of a multitude of leaders of the monastic movement in Egypt and abroad. On the other hand, Abba Pachomius was the first father of monks living a communal life of worship.

His Upbringing:

Pachomius was born in Upper Egypt by pagan parents, around the year 292. Since his childhood, he loved chastity and purity; he did not care for the idols worshiping rituals and never partook of its banquets. Once, his parents took him along to sacrifice to the idols across the river. When the priest of the idols saw the little boy, he cried out: "Send this enemy of the gods away from here to appease their anger on us." This incident made his parents very worried. Long before he was converted to Christianity, he was seeking virtuous life and longed for chastity. Later on, he told his disciples that story: On one occasion, his father asked him to carry some food to the laborers working in their far-away field, and because he arrived late to that field, he had to spend the night over there. A beautiful daughter of one of the laborers tried to lure him to her bed, but he rebuked her, saying: "I can't commit this sin. Do I look like a dog to sleep with you, my sister!?" After God saved him from her, he hastened to his house.

Receiving Christianity:

Pachomius was recruited into the army, and he was sent along with his regiment to put an end to an uprising against the emperor in Upper Egypt. On their way, they needed to rest, so they camped near the city of Latopolis (Esna). There, the inhabitants of the city came cheerfully to present them with food and drink in a great spirit of generosity. When he asked why these inhabitants were doing that; he was told that they were Christians, and they did that for the sake of the God of Heaven who taught them to love all people. After a long prayer, Pachomius vowed to convert to Christianity once he would return home safely. By a Divine ordinance, the uprising was stopped, and the soldiers were released. Pachomius went to Shinofeskion

(Qasr el-Sayyad), where he enrolled himself in the list of the catechumens; then, eventually, he gained the Holy Baptism. He remained three years in that village practicing the works of love and mercy, and he was tested in a plague during which he kept serving the community.

With Fr. Palamon:

Although the entire village loved St. Pachomius, however, his heart was inflamed with longing toward consecrating himself to worship. On hearing about a saintly hermit by named Palamon, who lived in the wilderness in the vicinity of that village, he set forth to ask him to be accepted as one of his disciples. St. Palamon revealed to him the stiffness of the monastic life and advised him to return to his village to test himself by practicing certain kinds of training chores. However, before the steadfastness of Pachomius' heart, St. Palamon accepted him and grew to love him, mainly since Pachomius was characterized with obedience, intense asceticism, and love of worship.

Establishing the Coenobitical Monastic Life:

Pachomius rejoiced in the life of seclusion and was joyful with God's work with him through his spiritual father, Abba Palamon. However, his heart was aching for those many people who yearn for the monastic life but were unable to endure the harsh conditions of seclusion. He kept praying for their sake. One day, while gathering firewood in the region of Tabansin,¹ an angel of the Lord appeared to him and instructed him to establish a monastery there and provided him with a tablet on which was written the main rules which were needed to maintain the order of that communal life. Those rules proved to be very simple and could be followed by so many.

When St. Pachomius told his mentor Abba Palamon about his encounter, the elder father rejoiced. Abba Palamon, despite his advanced age, blessed the work and did not object to establishing a new system of monasticism, which he was not familiar with. Moreover, he even accompanied him to Tabansin and assisted him in setting up the monastery. Then, Abba Palamon excused and went back to his cave, with a promise to get back together once every year, either in the monastery or in the cave. However, Abba Palamon did not live long enough to keep making those annual visits.

St. Pachomius established his first monastery around the year 318 AD at Tabansin, close to Pabou (Babu). By God's grace, he found favor in the eyes of so many, that he managed to establish in that region about ten monasteries. The number of monks was so large that in the main monastery in Pabou only there were about 1,500 monks. St. Pachomius' older brother John also

¹ 'Tabansin' was a town near 'Denderah' in 'Qena' governorate.

became a monk on his hands, and with all his strength, he helped in organizing this large system. Later on, his sister, too, was encouraged by him to adopt the monastic life, and he established for her a convent on the other side of the Nile River. That monastery included about 300 nuns under her guidance.

The Main Features of the Pachomian Order:

This order gained the appreciation of the church, even from the leaders of the Solitude Order. The great Abba Anthony himself commended St. Pachomius for his endeavor and considered his work as a gift from God.

The biography of St. Pachomius preserved for us a great deal about the Coenobitic life and lots of its details. It reached us in more than one language and more than one dialect, like the Bohairic and Sahidic Coptic dialects and in the Greek language, etc.

Here, I shall present the main outlines of the features of this Order:

- 1- This order was set as a secular movement. Therefore, St. Pachomius refused to be given any priestly rank, and when he felt that the 20th Pope of Alexandria St. Athanasius (328-373 AD), during his planned visit to him, intended to ordain him as a priest, he fled the area entirely. The pope had to put Pachomius' heart at ease by promising his monks that he would not stretch his hand to ordain their Abbot but just to seek his blessing. Indeed, when the pope returned from Aswan, St. Pachomius received him with great joy. In this way, he presented himself as a living role model of the monastic life, in which no one would covet a priestly rank, through which the devil would find a way to provoke jealousy among the monks.
- 2- The Pachomian Order was considered suitable for so many people, since the order would allow the monk during the fasting to have meals twice a day, to practice multiple group prayers, besides having him occupied with some kind of work that would fit his talents and capabilities, such as carpentry, farming, cooking, weaving textiles, building or scribing, every group of monks would have a head to supervise their physical and spiritual affairs. Work was considered a central component of their spiritual life.
- 3- Monasteries were opened to non-Egyptians, like the Greeks and the Romans; each group would have their mentor to guide their life.
- 4- It was allowed for those particular personalities who loved seclusion to go ahead and practice such a life of retreat. St. Pachomius used to meet with those hermits regularly.

The Characteristics of St. Pachomius:

St. Pachomius' personality will remain prominent through all ages as a

fantastic leadership entity who gathered thousands of people into the near and the far monasteries in Upper Egypt. He managed his monks' affairs with the spirit of love and firmness; while caring about the salvation and the spiritual growth of everyone's soul.

St. Pachomius was known for his meekness and humility. When some brethren asked him about the scene or vision which he admired the most, he answered: "It is that of a meek brother in whom God dwells."

The devil once appeared to him in the form of the Lord Jesus Christ, saying to him: "Rejoice Pachomius, for I came especially to visit you." He proclaimed, in full humility, that he would rather see the Lord Jesus Christ in the eternal life, not through his bodily eyes here on earth. Instantly the devil disappeared in vanishing smoke.

Despite his great love, tolerance, and tenderness in dealing with his spiritual children, he was also quite firm. It was said about him that he once intended to visit some monasteries and he requested from the brother responsible for the food preparation to take special care of the brethren and prepare for them cooked food. However, the brother did not do so. Upon his return to the monastery, a young man new to the monastic life complained to St. Pachomius that the monks have been denied cooked food for a long time. The saint told him he would take care of the issue himself. He called the monk responsible for this task, who explained that at the beginning of his work he used to cook the food, but he had to throw it away, since the monks, out of asceticism refrained from eating it. For that reason, he stopped cooking the food and occupied himself instead with weaving baskets. The saint asked him to bring before him all the hoops he has made, then in front of all the brethren, he ordered him to put them all on fire. After that, St. Pachomius indicated to all of them how obedience was an integral part of their life as monks; and that the monastery would rather lose the cooked food, which the monks refrain from eating by their own will than to lose one man through being offended because of being denied the cooked food against his will.

His Repose in the Lord:

Because of a severe plague that spread around Upper Egypt in the year 348 AD, a multitude of monks reposed in the Lord, among which was St. Pachomius. His feast for the Western Church is on the 14th of May, and for the Coptic Church, his feast is on the 14th of Bashons.

His Influence on the World:

The monastic communal system, which St. Pachomius has established, drew the hearts of many of the pioneers of the monastic movements in the east and the west. The west translated his order and applied it in its majority,

if not in its entirety. Among those who adopted this order were St. Basil the Great, St. John Cassian, Fr. Caesarius bishop of Arles, his successor Aurelius and Abbot Benedict, who established his well-famed system, as a father of the Western monasticism, quoting much of the Pachomian system.

PACHUM OF AKHMIM, ABBA (The martyr)

The biography of that illiterate farmer who was martyred along with his eight years old sister Dalshum, reveals the exalted work of God, not only in their endurance of sufferings but also in their conquest over the governor with their enlightened spiritual minds; as it is written: *"They shall all be taught by God."* (John 6:45).

This saints' father Moses reposed when Pachum was eighteen years old, leaving him with his sister Dalshum as a 7th-month fetus in her mother's womb. A rich man by the name of Simon took this poor, pious family under his wing. This pious man left his land at a village called Siflaq, north-east of Akhmim to the care of Pachum. He pledged to give him one-tenth of its produce to sustain him with his mother and sister.

His encounter with Ariana:

When Emperor Diocletian (284-305 AD) started up the persecution against the Christians, Ariana governor of Ansena wandered in all Upper Egypt to chase the Christians. Entering into Akhmim, he held a massive celebration in Berba, the temple of the idols, and sacrificed to it. Then, he set forth to practice his favorite pastime tortures against the Christians in Akhmim and its surroundings. He first sent his men to a village named Shenshif to arrest the Christians and their priest Fr. Kendes. Then, he sent another group of men to the village Siflaq to bring that illiterate farmer Pachum, with his worn-out clothes and poor appearance.

When the chief officer asked him about his name, and he answered: "I am a Christian," the officer gave the command to hang a heavy rock to his neck and drag him behind a chariot. In the simplicity of faith, he sought the help of his Savior, who made the rock weightless. The chief officer referred that miracle to the work of magic and ordered to take him to the governor. Along the way, he was being struck violently, while his mother and sister were walking behind him. It was said that the blood-covered rock hanged to his neck was rolling toward him rather than being dragged behind him, to the astonishment of the soldiers.

Before the governor, that illiterate farmer spoke with wisdom and piety; and persisted on not burning incense before the idols. Ariana gave the command to strike him until he became unconscious, but once he woke up

from his coma, he resumed his debate with the governor, while considering himself unworthy of such glory to be tortured for the sake of Christ.

During his intensified torture, his eight years old sister set forth toward him to testify to her Christ, intending to partake of her brother's crown. Her action provoked the governor to anger, and he gave the order to strike her too until she became unconscious. Pachum raised his face toward heaven and prayed to the Lord Jesus Christ to support him and his little sister, and to hold them fast in their strife. During his prayers, the soldiers were astonished to see how the light shone on their faces and healed their wounds.

The little sister took her brother's hand, and they both approached the governor's podium. At that point, the governor presented the child with two silk attires to wear and some incense to put in the censers before the idols, but she refused to do that. Then, the governor ordered to put burning stones on her chest and under her sides and to put chains around her neck. When he saw how she persisted on her disobedience, he had her put in a stove with boiling water. After plucking the finger-nails off Pachums' hands and feet, they cut off his neck, and his sister's on the 22nd of Kiahk. The inhabitants of their village shrouded and buried their bodies, and eventually, a monastery was built in the village of Siflaq after their names, which is still there until now.

[Nabil Selim: *The Two Martyrs: Abba Bachum and his sister Dalshum*, 1967]

PACIAN OF BARCELONA, ST.

We do not know much about the identity of that Spanish saint: Pacian of Barcelona, but he became known through his writings. He was married before his ordination as a priest and had a son named Flavius Dexter, who became the chief officer of the court of emperor Theodosius I (379-395 AD), and a guardian of his son prince Honorius.

St. Jerome got so attached to Flavis Dexter, as an intimate friend; and introduced to him his book 'The Illustrious Men' (*De Viris Illustribus*); and commended St. Pacian as a man of high culture, eloquence, and a saintly nature.

Later on, Pacian was ordained as a bishop on Barcelona and lived to an advanced age. Even though he was a very prolific writer, yet out of his works we only have an essay on Repentance, a sermon on Baptism, and three letters to a nobleman named Sympronian who accepted the heresy of Novatian.¹

¹ 'Novatian' was a Roman priest in the 3rd century AD, who wrote an important book on 'Trinity', that created dissension in the Western Church right after emperor 'Decius' stirred up persecution against the church (249–251 AD)... Although it did not include any theological heresy, yet it was stone-hard on

St. Pacian had a famous expression: "My name is Christian and my title is Universal (Catholic)." He departed on the 9th of March in the year 390 AD.

[Butler's Lives of Saints, Mar. 9]

PAESA, ST.

Lady St. Paesa was born in the city of Menouf to wealthy parents during the 4th century AD, and she was raised in a holy life. Since her childhood, she loved the worship of God and serving the poor. When her parents departed, she longed to join a house of virgins. She started distributing her wealth on the needy, and she gave hospitality to strangers in her home. However, the devil did not leave her alone but provoked some wicked people to lure her heart gradually to evil, until she completely got transformed and gave herself up to sin; and turned her house to a brothel.

On hearing about what happened to her, the fathers of the Scetis were very sad, so they spent some time in prayers and fasting for her, and then they sought from St. John the Short to go and talk to her. St. John the Short yielded to their request. When the time came for her to receive him; he entered into her house while singing the psalm: *"Though I walk through the valley of the shadow of death, I will fear no evil; for You are with me"* (Ps. 23:4). When he sat down, he looked at her and said, "Why did you belittle the Lord Jesus Christ, and follow this evil way?" She trembled and her heart was melting from the words of the saint who bent his head and started weeping. Inquiring from him why he was crying, he told her that he could see demons playing on her face. She asked him if there would be possible repentance for her. The saint opened before her the door of hope, providing that she would abandon that unclean place and go with him to the wilderness. When it was evening, he told her to lie down far away from him. Then, when he got up at midnight for his prayer, he saw a pillar of light coming down from Heaven and angels carrying her soul. Approaching, he found out that she already passed away. He prostrated himself to the ground thanking God for His work with her, to hear a voice, saying that her repentance was received at the moment she uttered it, for she did it from the depth of her heart.

He buried her body and set forth to the wilderness to tell the fathers about what happened, for which they glorified God. The church celebrates her

those who sought to return to the church, after denying their Christ even in an indirect way... He counted the priests in Rome slothful and easygoing; and violently attacked the bishop of Rome... He drew some bishops to his side, but the 14th pope of Alexandria St. 'Dionysius' (247-264 AD) condemned him on this dissension... He counted his group as the Holy Catholic Church, and he considered everybody else as infide.

memorial on the 2nd day of the Coptic month of Mesra.

PAESIUS (The martyr)

Paesius and Paesi were among the common names of the early monks and martyrs. We can mention few of them:

- 1- **St. Paesius**: an Egyptian martyr who offered his life together with others as a sacrifice to God in the 2nd year of the persecution stirred up by Emperor Diocletian (284-305 AD). They were tortured by Urbanus, the governor of Caesarea of Palestine [Eusebius: Martyrs of Palestine].
- 2- **Martyr Paesi** (Paesius/Isi): brother of martyr Takla; two Egyptians (8 Kiahk) from Abisir, west of El-Ashmonein (see Isi).
- 3- **St. Paesius**, brother of Abba Isaiah, the Scetic (see Isaiah).
- 4- **St. Paesius**, brother of Abba Bemen, the hermit; also called Paul, one of seven brothers.
- 5- **St. Paesius**, brother of Abba Paul and Abba Bishoi. Sometimes the name Paesius is mentioned instead of Bishoi.

PALAMON, THE HERMIT, ST. ABBA

This saint Palamon was mentioned on the 20th day of Toba in the Synaxarion published by Rene Basset. He is a different saint from Abba Palamon, the mentor of St. Pachomius, the Father of the Koinonia.

In the Eastern Wilderness:

We do not know a lot about this saint, except for his story, which showed the bitter war that Satan would raise against everyone, particularly those who achieve a high spiritual level. This father was earnest in his spiritual strife, never known to laugh since his youth. Yet the enemy planned to push him to the pit to destroy him completely if it was not for the elevated care of God Almighty.

It was said that he once came out from his cave on the eastern side of the mountain, carrying a little of his handwork to sell it in the countryside. It happened that he lost his way in the middle of the wilderness and could not find any sign that would lead him in the right direction. He remained that way for a whole week without food or drink in the deadly heat of summer. When he was on the brink of death, he cried out loud: "My Lord Jesus Christ, help me." He instantly heard a voice telling him: "Have no fear, for the enemy will have no power on you because you remember Me. Get up, walk toward the south, until you meet a true elder monk named Thallason, as solid as a stronghold. Tell him about how Satan seduced you and about the great

sin he tempted you within your youth. He will pray for you to be forgiven.” Father Palamon carried his little handwork and set forth toward the south, reciting the psalm: “*Save me, O God by Your name, and vindicate me by Your strength.*” (Ps. 54:1).

With Abba Thallason:

While reciting his psalms marching toward the south, he encountered St. Thallason, who greatly rejoiced for seeing him. He held his hand and helped him to ascend on a high rock, where they both prayed together. Then, they sat talking about the great works of God. The conversation between them was as follows:

- + How did you know this way that you came to visit me in this wilderness?
Here the tears flowed from St. Palamon's eyes, prostrated himself to the ground, saying:
 - Forgive me, O my beloved saintly father.
- + The Lord Jesus Christ will forgive us all our trespasses.
- I am ashamed to tell you, O father, about the great sin that came upon me by Satan, the enemy beyond my comprehension.
- + It is written: Confess your sins, and O my brother, I have committed great sins in my youth, and still do every day.

St. Palamon started to confess his sin to the elder saint telling him that while he was practicing the monastic life in the monastery, he heard that the life of solitude would induce fear of God and that God does hate the mockery, namely the vain laughs. So, he started weeping on his sins day and night. The enemy kept provoking him toward the vain laughing, but he did not listen to him and managed to control his mind and tongue. When the enemy often presented to him funny fantasies, the saint remembering his sins would weep instead of laughing, holding fast to the Name of Christ, the Grantor of Salvation. He kept his strife for quite a long time, until one day he carried his handwork to sell it in the countryside. Walking toward Rome, he suddenly saw the whole scenery changed before him; and instead of vast stretches of sand, he saw a fertile land and a new city with luxurious palaces, surrounded by gardens. Amazed by what he saw, he wondered if anyone in such a fertile land would care to buy his pure handwork. When he got closer to the city, he saw a water-wheel and a woman sitting next to it. She looked like a widow, sad and respectfully attired, with a veil on her face. On seeing him, the woman covered her head and said to him: “Bless me, O saintly father.” She took the baskets off his shoulders, sought from him to have some rest. So, Palamon sat next to her by the water channel. She took water from the channel by the palms of her hands and poured it on his feet to wash them, as though to seek his blessing. She seemed to be acting as a noble rich

woman, and then, the following conversation took place in between them:

- + Tell me, O faithful lady; if I enter the city with such simple and little handwork; shall I find anyone to purchase them from me?
- Just leave them to me. I shall buy them from you and provide you with all that you need. I was a wife of a rich man who passed away a few days ago, leaving me with too much wealth, cattle and vast stretches of the vineyard; while I have no one to stand beside me. I wish I had a faithful person like you to relinquish everything into his hands to do with them whatever he wishes. My saintly father, if you choose to come over and have the authority over my house and take all that I have; I shall have you as my husband.
- + If the monk gets married he would be in shame and reproach.
- If you choose not to marry me, be my caregiver and manage everything I have by day, and when night comes, you may go back to praying.

The woman then ascended to the upper room of her house, prepared a luxurious dinner, and presented it before him. Then, she went into her room and changed into rich attire and came back to sit very close to him. At this point, Fr. Palamon was alerted by the power of God, so he made the sign of the Cross on himself. Suddenly, everything before him turned into smoke blown by the wind, and, he perceived that it was all a satanic deception. Then for a long time, he kept weeping with great remorse. Then, when he was lost in the desert, the merciful God sent him an angel to comfort him, and God promised him with forgiveness after he would go to see St. Thallason and confess his sin. Then, he did as he was told.

That was what Abba Palamon narrated to St. Thallason, bitterly weeping to seek his prayers to God to forgive him his sins. The saint prayed for him; and behold, they found before them as though a table coming down from Heaven, from which they ate and rejoiced in the Lord. Then, St. Palamon returned to his dwelling place to practice his monasticism and worship with zeal and was granted by God the grace of healing the sick; and that the wild beasts come to him like pets for him to feed them. The saint also came down often from his cave to visit the prisoners and the needy.

PALAMON, ST. ABBA

This Abba Palamon was the spiritual father of St. Pachomius, the founder of the Koinonia system (the Coenobitic Monasticism or the Monastic Fellowship). The information we received about this saint was provided through the documented biography of St. Pachomius (Pachum).

His Encounter with Abba Pachom:

Once St. Pachom received the Christian faith, he lived three years after he was baptized practicing the acts of love toward the poor and the needy, and his heart was inflamed more and more every day in the love of God. On hearing about that secluded hermit Abba Palamon; he went to meet with him. When he knocked on the door of his cave, the older saint looked through an opening in the door and said to him: "Who are you, brother? and what do you want?" Pachom answered him: "I am, O blessed father, a seeker of Jesus Christ, the God whom you worship. I implore your fatherhood to receive me and make me a monk." The older saint answered him: "Son, monasticism is not an easy matter and should not be sought without deep consideration, for so many people have done so while ignoring its labors and ended up forsaking it too soon. You probably heard about it, but you are not aware of its strife." The elder kept strongly talking to St. Pachom about the labors of monasticism, about the warring by Satan; which made St. Pachom grew more enthusiastic about monasticism. When St. Palamon has seen how much St. Pachom was longing for it and how much he held fast, he opened the door and welcomed him. St. Pachom stayed three months under observation with this saint. Then, after watching a whole night in prayers, St. Palamon cut his hair and clothed him in the monastic attire. Afterward, they dwelt together as one person.

Palamon's Care for his Disciple's Spiritual Life:

St. Palamon cared a lot for all the spiritual aspects of Pachom's life. One evening he sought from him to watch along with him the whole night between prayers and handwork, and whenever they find themselves overcome by sleep, they get out of the cave to move sand from one place to another to keep awake and then return to prayers. The elder kept saying to his sleepy disciple: "Wake up Pachom, lest Satan would tempt you; for many have perished of too much sleep." He trained him on a harsh monastic life blended with the Divine love in order to raise his heart and soul beyond the body's needs.

Once on the feast of Resurrection, the elder sought from his disciple to prepare special food, for such an exalted occasion. Pachom crushed some salt and put on it oil with a little greenery and bread. On seeing that there was too much oil on the food, the elder wept bitterly, saying: "The Lord was crucified for me, and I eat so much oil that softens the body?" Pachom apologized to the elder that the oil spilled on the meal against his will. However, the elder answered him that if it was not needed to light the lamp in the Altar, he would never have kept oil in his cave.

Palamon's Open Heart:

St. Palamon's open heart and mind, and his true love was shown clearly in his behavior toward St. Pachum when an angel came to him to establish the system of Koinonia. St. Palamon, the mentor, helped his disciple to set up his new system, although he had no experience with it, and asked that they visit each other, once every year, alternatively. He was happy with the work of his disciple, and he blessed it. A few years later, he reposed in the Lord after falling ill for a little while. The church celebrates him on the 25th of Abib.

PALLADIUS, THE BISHOP OF IRELAND

This saint has played a significant role in extinguishing the Pelagian heresy in Ireland and elsewhere. Pelagius (354-420 AD) was a British monk who preached in Rome between the years 400 and 410 AD. He proclaimed that the original sin of Adam was not inherited, and it did not taint the human nature, so the infants were born sinless, and they were being baptized not for the forgiveness of sin but to enjoy the fellowship in Christ and to enter the Kingdom of Heaven. He also claimed that man would be able to have salvation through his effort, without the need for God's grace, and that God's grace would not be needed for the enlightenment of the mind.

However, many church fathers rose to dispute Pelagius doctrines and to confirm the need for the forgiveness of the original sin and stressed on the role of the Divine grace, without disregarding the free human will.

St. Prosper of Aquitaine, the disciple of St. Augustine, mentioned that Agricola, the son of a Pelagian bishop Severianus corrupted the British Churches by spreading the Pelagian heresy. However, at the persuasion of the deacon Palladius, bishop Germanus of Auxerre was sent there in the year 429 AD by the Roman Pope Celestine I (422-432 AD) to combat that heresy.

Deacon Palladius was ordained by the pope, a few years later, as the first bishop on Ireland, in the year 431 AD. There, he confronted so many troubles and oppositions; but because he managed to preach to so many people and by establishing three churches on the island, he became accessible to some extent.

Just before the end of the year, because he felt that his ministry in Rome was more fruitful, he departed from Ireland to Rome. However, he got very sick on the way and reposed in Fordun, fifteen miles south of Aberdeen; although according to some, he was martyred in Ireland.

PALLADIUS, THE HISTORIAN, ST.

St. Palladius is considered as one of the most important historians of the Coptic monasticism. He visited the region of Nitria, Kellia (Cells), and the Scetis, in addition to the monasteries of Upper Egypt. Although he became a friend of St. Macarius of Alexandria, his way of thinking was much closer to that of St. Evagrius (Oghris) of Pontes. He was even considered by some as one of his disciples. They both fell in love with the views of Origen, who had a Gnostic meditating approach to spirituality, instead of the simple approach used in the monastic environment. So, they both established what was like a monastic school of thought within the Egyptian monastic life. That school embraced those people who advocated the views of Origen. This arrangement caused a fracture and discord within the monastic life of Nitria in particular.

His Upbringing and Monastic Life:

We do not know much about his family. He was born in Galatia in 368 AD, and he had a high culture, and from his book 'The Lausiac History,' we can tell that his father was still living until the year 394 AD; and that his sister and brother dedicated their lives to God although, in his book 'Dialogue with Theodore about the Life of John Chrysostom,' he revealed that his brother Brisson, chose later on to forsake his religious mission to work in his garden by himself.

When St. Palladius reached twenty-three years of age, he joined the monastic life in the Mount of Olives in Jerusalem. He became one of the disciples of a priest called Innocent and dwelt together for a little while with Alpidius close to Jericho. Around the year 388 AD, he planned to see the Egyptian hermits and to spend some time there to learn from them. He went to Alexandria, where he stayed for three years and became a disciple of St. Isidore who was in charge of a guest-house at the patriarchate. St. Isidore, in turn, delivered him to St. Dorotheus the hermit from Thebes, who used to dwell in a cave, five miles from Alexandria, but as the life of that hermit was too harsh for Palladius, he left him and set forth to Nitria.

In Nitria, Kellia (Cells) and the Scetis:

In Nitria, St. Palladius stayed only one year or less. In the year 391 AD, he headed to the region of Kellia (the Cells/el-Kalali), where he joined St. Macarius of Alexandria, until the later reposed in the Lord in the year 394 AD. Then, he joined St. Evagrius (Oghris) of Pontes and became one of his disciples. They both loved Origen and got attached to those pro-Origen clergy, such as Ammonius and his Tall Brothers.

Then, St. Palladius kept moving back and forth from the region of Kellia

(El-Kalali) to that of the Scetis for nine years. During that time, he went to Assiut (Lycopolis) to visit the secluded hermit St. John, who imprisoned himself in a cell on the mountain. That hermit prophesied that St. Palladius would be a bishop in the future. St. Palladius was also present when his mentor Evagrius reposed in the Lord, in the year 399 AD. However, when he became sick, he had to return to Alexandria.

Ordaining him as a Bishop:

When St. Palladius returned sick to Alexandria for medical treatment, the physician advised him to go to Palestine for a more suitable climate, so he went to Bethenia around the year 400 AD for his health to improve. Somehow over there, he was ordained as a bishop on Helenopolis, as was prophesied earlier by St. John of Assiut.

He got entangled into the disputes concerning the Origen controversy. Then, he joined St. John Chrysostom in the Council of Sendian (Oak) in the year 403 AD, where he stood in defense of St. John Chrysostom. In the year 405 AD, he left for Rome to intercede in favor of St. John Chrysostom. In the following year, he was exiled by Emperor Arcadius (383-408 AD) to Upper Egypt, where he stayed until the year 412 AD. During that time, he kept traveling between the regions of Thebes and Aswan. Afterward, he returned to Galatia as a bishop on Aspuna, to repose in the Lord in the year 431 AD before the Ecumenical Council of Ephesus.

His Writings:

- 1- His greatest work was probably his book 'The Lausaic History,' which was so-called in reference to Lausas, the chief officer of the imperial court of Emperor Theodosius II (402-450 AD), to whom he dedicated that book in the year 419/420 AD. In that book, he described the monastic movement in Egypt, Palestine, Syria, and Asia Minor during the 4th century AD. It is considered as the most important source of the early history of monasticism, next to the book 'Life of St. Anthony' written by Pope Athanasius the Apostolic.
- 2- 'Dialogue with Theodore about the Life of John Chrysostom': He wrote it around the year 408 AD in Aswan, where he was exiled because of his association with that saint. This book, besides being important in revealing the life of St. John Chrysostom, it included a brutal attack on the 23rd Pope of Alexandria St. Theophilus (385-412 AD). We cannot deny that it was a sort of mistake from the pope to get involved in the case of St. John Chrysostom. However, it was told that he regretted it before he reposed in the Lord.
- 3- 'About the People of India and the Brahmins': A small essay divided into

four parts. Only the first part could be attributed to St. Palladius.

A Remark:

There was some confusion between the book written by Palladius and another book which was written around the year 400 AD, with the title 'History of the Monks of Egypt.' That book included the same information as that in Palladius' book but by an unknown author.

[J. Quasten, *Patrology*, Vol. 3, pp. 176–179]
[Palladius, *The Lausiaca History* (ACW), 1965, pp. 5–110]

PAMMACHIUS, ST.

St. Pammachius was born around the year 340 AD from a noble Roman family called 'Furii.' He was a layman and a close friend of St. Jerome (Eronimus), since the time they were studying together. Some people thought that he became St. Jerome's assistant since St. Jerome issued many of his books under this man's name. Two examples for this were his interpretation of some of the Books of the Minor Prophets (around the year 406 AD) and his interpretation of the Book of Daniel (around the year 407 AD).

In the year 385 AD, St. Pammachius married Paulina, the second daughter of St. Paula; one of the great friends of St. Jerome.

It so seems that St. Pammachius was a religious man, for we saw him complaining to St. Siricius, the bishop of Rome (384-399 AD) denouncing a monk named Jovinian who was not following the upright faith, and he proclaimed that there was no difference between virginity and matrimony and that the reward was the same in Heaven, regardless of the way a man would live on earth. He also shared with Halphidius, the denial of the perpetual virginity of St. Mary. Jovinian was condemned earlier by both the bishop of Rome and by St. Ambrose of Milan. In addition, St. Pammachius sent some copies of the writings of that heretic to St. Jerome, which resulted in that both St. Jerome and St. Augustine decided to write detailed treatises to refute him.

However, St. Pammachius was not comfortable with the harsh reaction of St. Jerome in his response to Jovinian which was probably because on one side St. Pammachius was a very compassionate and tender man, and on the other side, he felt in St. Jerome's response a commendation for virginity and belittling for the sanctity of matrimony. St. Jerome hastened to send several letters to St. Pammachius to clarify his views. He showed him that he would never touch the sanctity of matrimony nor defile the marriage relationship, even though he also commends virginity. He gave him the following comparison: if the virginity would be as gold, the matrimony, to him, would

be counted as silver. It seemed that St. Pammachius was comforted by St. Jerome's response.

Once more, when a controversy between St. Jerome and Rophinus erupted about Origen's teaching, although they were good friends since their childhood, St. Pammachius declared his denunciation of their fierceness in the argument.

When his wife Paulina passed away in the year 397 AD, both St. Jerome and St. Paulinus, the bishop of Nola, wrote him letters of condolence and advised him to funnel all his abilities towards deeds of love. St. Paulinus wrote to him, saying: "Your wife now is a deposit for you, and an intercessor for your sake before the Lord Jesus Christ. She would be receiving through you a lot of blessings in Heaven when you distribute her treasures over here on earth. Don't remember her by vain tears, but by participating in the deeds of mercy. She would be honored by your virtues and fed by the food you offer to the poor." St. Jerome also wrote him another letter inviting him to a life of dedication.

St. Pammachius did distribute much of his wealth on the poor, to practice a monastic life; that St. Jerome wrote to him saying: "Although Paulina has fallen asleep, the church has gained the monk Pammachius. According to his birth and marriage, he is a nobleman. He is generous in his giving and loft in his humility" [Letter # 66]. He also said in the same letter, that what Pammachius has gained now was the fruit of Paulina; for what she longed to see him as while she was alive, has been realized by her death. By doing so, Pammachius proved to be the wisest of the wise, the greatest and the noblest among them, and the most prominent monk.

Also, St. Pammachius established with Fabiola an inn (hospital) in the area of Portus, to be a refuge for the strangers who were coming to Rome, in particular the sick and the poor among them. In his love for the unity of the church, St. Pammachius opposed the Donatic dissension¹ with a spirit of humility. He sought from them to return to the bosom of the church. For his good ecclesiastical work, St. Augustine, the bishop of Hippo, wrote St. Pammachius to thank him in the year 401 AD.

St. Pammachius turned his house in Coelian Hill into a church, and according to some, the church of SS. Giovanni and Paulo (John and Paul) was built on its location later on.

St. Pammachius reposed in the year 410 AD, during the attack of the Goths and the Alaric on Rome. He is celebrated by the west on the 30th of August. It was said that he was ordained as a priest, but that was doubted by

¹ The 'Donatists' were a rebellious congregation in North West Africa, and found some sympathizers in Italy, that accused the other believers with infidelity.

so many scholars.

PAMPHILUS (The martyr)

St. Pamphilus (Pamphilius) was a citizen and a nobleman from Beirut, Lebanon. He was born in the year 240 AD and was educated in Alexandria on the hands of Origen. He reached such a high standing in the spiritual knowledge and the study of the Holy Bible that Eusebius of Caesarea called him: 'The Junior Origen.' He went to Caesarea, where his talents shined in such a way that he was offered so many high positions. However, he rejected them with all the riches of the world, and he distributed all his possessions on the poor and dedicated himself to a life of study and holy asceticism, then he was ordained as a priest in Caesarea of Palestine. When he felt that the priests in the diocese needed learning and study, he established a huge religious library that included 3,000 books. That library benefited so many people, among them was Eusebius of Caesarea, who counted himself as a disciple of St. Pamphilus, and he honored him much; he even called himself Eusebius the son of Pamphilus.

His Martyrdom:

In the days of Emperor Diocletian (284-305 AD), the governor of Palestine Urbanus arrested St. Pamphilus, on account of his priestly work and his opening a school to teach the Christians. The governor entered into a debate with St. Pamphilus, and when he saw how the saint was holding fast to his faith, he ordered tearing his body off by iron claws, and then he cast him in jail. Urbanus, himself, was eventually killed by orders from the emperor and was replaced by Firimilian as the governor of Palestine. Firimilian left Pamphilus in jail for two years. That was a Divine ordinance for the benefit of so many believers who were with him in prison.

During that time, five Christian Egyptian men: Elija, Jeremiah, Isaiah, Samuel, and Daniel, who came to Palestine, were arrested and put in prison. On meeting with St. Pamphilus in jail, they were so happy and were greatly comforted. After few days, the five Egyptians were brought to the court of justice; and when asked about their citizenship, the youngest of them answered: "We are Christians, citizens of the Heavenly Zion." On hearing this, the governor ordered cutting their heads off.

An eighteen years old man named Prophorius, sought from the governor to allow him to bury the five martyrs. That man was a slave and a disciple of St. Pamphilus, whom he treated as a brother, although he was not baptized yet. Here, the governor asked him if he was also a Christian. Answering him

in the positive, the governor gave his order to the executioners to torture him with great ferocity, to tear his body with iron claws, and to cut his belly open. Enduring all that in silence, he slowly was pushed into a fiery furnace to deliver his soul, while calling the Name of Jesus Christ, the Son of God.

A Cappadocian man named Seleucus, who has seen what happened to Prophorius, set forth to give his teacher Pamphilus the good news about the martyrdom of his slave and disciple, then he went back and testified to the Lord Jesus Christ, and was executed. Finally, St. Pamphilus, along with other eleven martyrs were beheaded. Among them was one of the loyal servants in the governor's household, named Theodulus. Also, among them was a catechumen whose name was Julian, who was killed because he sought to bury the bodies of the martyrs. The governor tried to deliver the martyrs' bodies to the wild beasts, but they refrained for four days from approaching them, and he had to bury them.

PANCRAS OF TAORMINA (The martyr)

St. Pancras (Pancratis) has a special appreciation in Sicily. It was said that he was raised in Antioch, where he received the Christian faith and was baptized, along with his father, on the hands of St. Peter the Apostle. St. Peter sent him to preach in Sicily after ordaining him as a bishop on Taormina.

He found the people in Sicily worshipping two idols: Phalca and Lyssio; the bishop managed to destroy these idols after he preached the Gospel to them, and they accepted the faith. God granted the saint with the living Word in preaching and supported him with the grace of performing miracles and signs.

Some barbarians living on the mountains in Sicily got angry because of the success of the saint's mission, and for him destroying their two idols, so they stoned him to death, to receive the crown of martyrdom around the year 90.

[Butler's Lives of the Saints, April 3]

PANCRAS (The martyr)

This St. Pancras was raised in a rich family in Synrada in Phrygia. When his pagan parents Clion and Ceridia, passed away while he was still young, he was adopted by his uncle Dionicius who took him to Rome, where they received faith together and were baptized on the hands of its bishop. The uncle eventually passed away, and Pancras was martyred in the era of Emperor Diocletian (284-305 AD) when he was only fourteen years of age in

the year 304 AD. In the west, he is portrayed as a boy carrying a sword in one hand and a palm branch in the other hand. The west celebrates this martyr on the 12th of May.

[Baring-Gould: Lives of the Saints, May 12]

PANICARUS, THE PERSIAN (The martyr)

The church celebrates his feast on the 5th of Toba. He probably is the same Anatolius mentioned in the Synaxarion directly following St. Tadros el-Mishriqy (the Oriental), having been friends, partners at work, and in martyrdom.

This saint was from Persia, and he was appointed as a leader in the army and was beloved by the kings because of his courage. In the days of Emperor Diocletian (284-305 AD), the saint saw in a night-vision, as though he was raised to Heaven, where two Roman soldiers baptized him in a fiery pond: Tadros el-Mishriqy and the Arab Leonides; and the former took him as his son. In the morning, Panicarus the Persian saw the two men he saw in his dream approach him, and took him from Persia to Rome and were amazed to have seen the same vision on the same night.

The three of them were united by the bond of spiritual love, and they practiced their worship publicly amid their army settings. This behavior stirred up the Emperors Diocletian and Maximianus against them. They called all three of them to their audience. However, when they knew that Panicarus was a Persian, they did not want to create animosity between them and the king of Persia, so they sent him over to Romanus, the governor of Alexandria, to deal with him, with the instructions that in case he would persist on his faith in Christ, he would be tortured and then killed.

In Alexandria:

Guarded by four soldiers, he was led to governor Romanus who cast him in jail. There, the Lord Jesus Christ appeared to him, saying: “My beloved Panicarus, peace be with you; be brave and victorious! My peace will be with you!” St. Panicarus prostrated himself before the Lord, who blessed him, encouraged him to rebuke the governor on his evil, and to have no fear of his coming tortures. The next day, the governor brought the saint over and was impressed by how handsome and respectable he looked, but when he held fast to his faith, the governor ordered to torture him. They placed him on a metal chair full of sharp nails; they put a hot iron on his head, and they lit a fire under his seat. In all that, the Lord supported him and healed him.

Amid all these tortures, a multitude of people brought their sick and came

to see him. The saint prayed and had them healed, and the evil spirits were cast out of many of them, in the Name of Jesus Christ. On hearing about what he was doing and the miraculous work of God through him, Thaognostus one of the princes of Pentapolis and a teacher of the king's sons came to ask him for the sake of his son who was possessed by an evil spirit. St. Panicarus put the prince's heart at peace, and then he asked him to go back to his house. In the meantime, the governor prepared a furnace of fire and cast Panicarus in it. However, the Archangel Michael came down and brought him out of the furnace and led him to the house of prince Thaognostus. There, the saint cast the evil spirit out of his son after making the sign of the Cross on him. The prince and his entire household proclaimed their faith in the Lord Jesus Christ.

During that time, governor Romanus asked his men to go and see what the fire did to Panicarus. From the heat of the fire, some of them perished, and some were inflicted with burns, which made the governor think that the gods had their revenge on Panicarus. However, when they realized that the saint was not harmed by the fire, many in the crowd shouted, proclaiming their faith in Christ the Savior. For fear of rebellion, the governor cast the saint in jail, where the Lord Jesus Christ again appeared to him, assuring him that he would gain the Heavenly blessings, together with his two friends: Tadros and Leonides.

The next day the governor ordered to hang the saint upside down and tie a great rock to his neck and to ignite a fire under his head, but the Lord sent his angel and saved him. He was sent back to jail, where the multitudes came with their sick; that the jail was turned into a kind of hospital to treat many in the name of the Lord. After much torture that led many to faith, the saint had his head cut off, and he received the crown of martyrdom. Prince Thaognostus carried his body to his own house.

PANSARION AND HIS BROTHER (The martyrs)

The three brothers Paul, Panisaron, and Theodotion lived in the region of Cleopatris a few kilometers from the city of Suez in Egypt. The two brothers Paul and Pansarion lived as hermits and were piously worshipping God. However, their younger brother Theodotion, who led a life of recklessness drunkenness and finally joined a gang of thieves; was making their souls very bitter. They kept praying and fasting with contrite hearts and tears for their brother's sake. Eventually, when a creed was issued by Emperor Diocletian (284-305 AD) to persecute the Christians, the two brothers were arrested and put in jail. Paul was thirty-seven years old and Pansarion was twenty-five,

they stood before the governor testifying to their Christ and refusing to deny Him, and were consequently put under fierce torture.

On hearing about what happened to his brothers and observing them under such severe agony, Theodotion felt great remorse because he did not listen to them and became the source of their bitterness for such a long time. He started to cry in repentance seeking the mercies of God, longing to partake in their endurance of torture for the faith. Suddenly, he rushed in his way among the crowd toward the governor, and in an unchristian manner, he pulled him from his chair to fall on the ground. The executioners hastened and took hold of him while he was shouting out, proclaiming his faith in the Lord Jesus Christ.

To avenge himself against this young man, the governor ordered putting hot iron rods next to his sides and chest, then to cut his head off. Here, the soul of the younger brother preceded those of his older hermit brothers to Paradise.

After so much torture, Pansarion and Paul were finally cast into the sea to die drowning. We can say that the salvation of the soul of Theodotion, and his setting forth to Paradise, was the fruit of the true love of his two brothers who did whatever they could to help him, and counted his salvation as a crown on their heads. He preceded them to Paradise, for them to follow him with peace of heart, to be all together in the fellowship of the glories of the Lord Jesus Christ. It was as though God allowed it to be this way as a reward for them on enduring with joy the torture in His Name.

[Cheneau: Les Saints d'Egypte, Tome 2, 1923, p. 212 - 24 Jan]

PANSOPHE (The martyr)

This saint was the son of a nobleman in Alexandria, whom the Romans appointed as a governor of Alexandria, according to Cheneau.

St. Pansophe so loved the knowledge that he concentrated on both the religious and the temporal studies. Hearing about Origen, he got in touch with him and became a disciple of him in the famous School of Alexandria.

His riches and knowledge, besides the high social status of Pansophe's father, drew the attention of many to him, but he despised this world like his mentor, Origen. Once his father passed away, he sold all his inheritance and distributed its proceeds to the poor. After feeling free from the worldly possessions, he left Alexandria to a nearby village to live as a hermit and to practice a life of seclusion and tranquility, away from the temporal honors, the vain riches, and the pleasures of this world. Yet, the sweet fragrance of Christ in him spread around, that so many knew about his virtues and came to

seek his blessing and counsel.

When emperor Decius (249-251 AD) sat on the throne, persecution flared in Alexandria around the year 249 AD, when the saint was twenty-seven years old. He was arrested and brought before a judge who treated him with respect and compassion because of his late father's high position. However, when the argument between the two of them got intensified before a large crowd, the angry judge started to threaten the saint of using every ferocious mean on him, if he does not deny his Christ. When the saint held fast to his faith, he was condemned to have his head cut off. Here the saint approached his executioner with courage, with a smile on his face and with great joy for the sake of receiving the crown of martyrdom.

[Cheneau: Les Saints d'Egypte, Tome I, 1923, pp. 115-117]

PANTAENUS, ST.

Pantaenus was a saint and a philosopher who became the dean of the school of Alexandria around the year 181 AD. He gained great fame to be considered by the historian Eusebius (263-339 AD), the first dean of that School. About him, he said:

“At that time, the School of Alexandria was headed by a man of very exalted world fame as a scholar, named Pantaenus. There was a well-established custom among them to have an academy for the holy knowledge, which is still there until our present day. According to my understanding, those who run it are people of high standards; theologians with special abilities; one of whom was Pantaenus, the highest and most exalted scholar in his era.”

Searching his memory, St. Clement (150-215 AD) in his work ‘*Stromata*’ (Patchwork), he mentioned the blessed persons worthy of remembrance, whom he was fortunate enough to encounter and to listen to. When it came to his mentor Pantaenus, he spoke about him as the greatest and most accomplished teacher; in whose solitude he found comfort. About his encounter with him he said:

“Even though my encounter with him was just by chance, yet he was the most prominent in worthiness. In Egypt, I found him in hiding; truly like a Sicilian bee, plucking from all flowers in the gardens of the prophets and apostles, to provide the souls of his listeners with a treasure of incorruptible knowledge.”

Pantaenus and Philosophy:

Pantaenus was one of the famed Stoic philosophers, those who were

ethical on the highest level; considering the greatest good is in virtue, believing in the law of nature or the law of conscience and duty. Those Stoic philosophers saw in God the energy that penetrates everything, and by which He created the natural world and kept it as such.

Pantaenus became Christian on the hands of Athenagoras (133-190 AD) the dean of the Catechetical Theological School of Alexandria, and in the year 181 AD, Pantaenus succeeded him as the dean of that School. He was credited for introducing philosophy and science into the School of Alexandria in an attempt to gain the heretics and the cultured pagans.

Even though Pantaenus was a perpetual reader of philosophy, yet he was not criticized by his church contemporaries or accused of diversion from faith. Origen (184-254 AD) testified to him saying that, in his study of philosophy, he followed the lead of his mentor Pantaenus, who managed to draw many people of culture through his knowledge of philosophy. This policy which was introduced by Pantaenus was developed further by his student Clement and re-structured by Origen.

Pantaenus as a Preacher:

The School of Alexandria was not just a religious institute that was famous worldwide, but it was a part of the church having its preaching activity besides its educational and catechetical programs. Her instructors were high-caliber spiritual church-people who dedicated their lives to study and to spread the evangelical ecclesiastical thoughts. They sanctified their lives presenting themselves as a living example in asceticism, as well as on defending the dogma and spreading the word of God; on the local and ecumenical levels. On one aspect, in the sight of the people of Alexandria, Pantaenus was not only a scholar and a teacher but the helper of many who cared for the salvation of all, so that they called him 'Our Pantaenus'. On another aspect, when he was called by the 12th pope of Alexandria, St. Demetrius (188-230 AD) to preach in India; he responded to the call right away, leaving the School in the hands of St. Clement, for a while.

About his mission to India; some historians said that few Indian traders who listened to the saint's sermons in Alexandria were impressed with his teaching and were converted to Christianity with great zeal, then when they had a chance to meet with the pope of Alexandria, they sought from him to send Pantaenus to India to preach among their folks. According to them, India sent an official message to the pope, with the same request, and he responded by sending the saint to them.

When St. Pantaenus returned from India, it was said that he also preached in Ethiopia, Arabia, and Yemen, and according to St. Jerome and the historian Eusebius; Pantaenus brought with him a hand-written copy of the Holy

Gospel according to St. Matthew that St. Bartholomew (Nathanael) brought to India with him.

It is worth mentioning that St. Anastasius of Sinai of the 7th century, talked about St. Pantaenus as being 'The Priest of Alexandria'. Probably, he was ordained as a priest before going to India to be able to baptize the catechumen, to anoint them with the holy Myron, and to perform the Eucharist; as the preaching activity would certainly need the priestly functions.

Pantaenus and the Coptic Alphabet:

St. Pantaenus introduced the Coptic alphabet, using the Greek letters, and adding seven letters from the old Demotic script (derived from Hieratic, which was a form of cursive Hieroglyphic). In that way, the Holy Bible could be translated to the Coptic language under his supervision. St. Pantaenus was helped in that great task by his two students Clement and Origen. The scholars gave the same great interest to that Coptic translation, as they did to the original Greek text itself. St. Pantaenus translated also much of the Christian literature to that Coptic language, being considered as the latest development in the ancient Egyptian language (Hieroglyphic). The various writers also started to use this language instead of the Greek one.

His Birth Place:

According to the Coptic historians, Pantaenus was born in Alexandria by Egyptian parents. Whereas, according to the historian Philip of Side (380-431 AD); he was an Athenian; although that might be a kind of guessing, because of the care the saint had for the Greek philosophy. According to others, he was a Sicilian, for his disciple Clement called him 'The Sicilian Bee'; but this was on account of the sweetness of his teaching and what it carried of rich nourishment.

As to the time of his birth, it seems that it was near the beginning of the 2nd century AD, even though it is difficult to tell the exact date, and it is believed that he died around the year 190 AD.

His Writings:

St. Pantaenus interpreted all the Books of the Holy Bible, from Genesis to the Revelation; orally and in writing. This led his contemporaries to call him: 'The Interpreter of the Word of God'. Yet, unfortunately, we have of his writings only a few quotes that were included in the writings of his disciple St. Clement.

[Fr. Tadros Y. Malaty: *Early Fathers of the School of Alexandria*, 1980, pp. 47-51]

PANTALEON, ST.

The name Pantaleon (Panteleimon) is derived from the Greek, meaning 'All- Compassionate.' He was born in Nicomedia in the province of Bithynia, from a pagan father named Eustorgius and a Christian mother named Eubula. His mother raised her son the Christian way in a pious life from his childhood, but she passed away while he was still young and his father cared only to raise him highly cultured.

Pantaleon showed prominence in studying medicine and he earned great fame working as a physician that emperor Maximian (285-305 AD) made him his private doctor. The emperor liked him very much because of his great competence, besides his tenderness and high intelligence.

With St. Hermolaus:

Having been successful in his work as a physician and being involved in royal social relationships; St. Pantaleon did not care much for the religious aspects and the worship in his life. At this stage of his life, he had completely forgotten what his mother taught him as a child, but the seed remained dormant in his heart until he encountered a blessed elder whose name is Hermolaus. On seeing in him a good soul, Hermolaus started to talk to him about the living faith and the need for God as a Savior who would support both the soul and the body. Pantaleon responded to his initiative and told him that his mother was a Christian, even though he did not remember anything of her teachings since the time he focused all his interests on studying medicine. The elder started talking to him about the Lord Jesus Christ as a Physician capable of healing both the soul and the body; and that in His Name even the unhealable sicknesses would be healed.

Pantaleon started to think seriously about this issue; and on his way home he saw a little kid being bitten by a serpent. He stopped before the dead kid, thinking about what he heard from St. Hermolaus about Christ the Savior and Healer. Then in complete faith, he cried out seeking from the Lord Jesus Christ to proclaim Himself to him by raising the kid from the dead and killing the serpent. Once, he called the Holy Name, all that he asked for was realized on the spot. Right away, he hastened to St. Hermolaus seeking from him to baptize him. Then, he went to tell his pagan father about what happened to him. Even though the father was not happy to hear it, yet the son, in his compassion, attempted to draw him to the true faith.

His Sufferings:

Later on, someone came to him with his son who has lost his eyesight through the incompetence of another physician. Pantaleon then sought from

the Lord Jesus Christ to heal the kid and the Lord restored his eyesight and the boy started to testify to the work of the Lord Jesus Christ in his life.

When the other physicians heard about this, they found their chance to complain against Pantaleon. They were already envious of his success and the emperor's admiration of him. Emperor Maximian (286-305 AD) called the young son whose eyesight was restored, inquiring from him about what happened to him. The boy told him how Pantaleon healed him in the Name of the Lord Jesus Christ. The emperor said to the boy: "Wrong! You are healed by the power of our gods," and when the boy insisted that it was the Name of Christ, the emperor in anger ordered to cut his head off.

The emperor then called Pantaleon and gently started admonishing him on receiving a faith other than that of his emperor, who honored him and elevated him above everybody. Pantaleon answered him politely, yet with courage that he cannot deny his Christ, the Grantor of healing of both the body and the soul. Then to prove his point, he asked him to bring someone inflicted with an incurable illness and let his priests pray for him; while he will pray to the Lord Jesus Christ to heal him. Those present at the time approved and brought one paralytic man before the emperor. The pagan priests tried in vain to have him healed; but once Pantaleon prayed to the Lord, the man was instantly healed. The audience cried out glorifying the Lord Jesus Christ, while the emperor became very furious.

The emperor attributed the healing to the power of magic and the work of demons. This was the custom of those opponents of the truth as it happened when the Jews accused Jesus of being Beelzebub, the ruler of the demons. For fear that the Christian faith would spread in Nicomedia because of the news of healing the paralytic, the emperor brought Pantaleon to the city center, where he ordered his men to torture him. They kept torturing the saint by hanging him on a pole, tearing his flesh off with iron claws, burning his sides with fire, and putting him in a large basin filled with molten lead, but the amazing hand of God kept supporting him in all these sufferings, by raising him above the pain. The emperor was in a panic and he ordered to tie a heavy rock to his legs and to be thrown into the sea. Yet, he did not drown. Then, he ordered to press him by the henbazin, but the tool broke down.

The emperor then turned his wrath towards Hermolaus and his two companions Hermippus and Hermocrates. He wanted to terrify them by showing them the tools of torture, so that they might breakdown and bring with them Pantaleon, but they scoffed the tools and prayed to God before the emperor. Suddenly, a strong earthquake happened to terrify the emperor, who still referred it to the wrath of his gods for the existence of Christians in the city. They asked him not to rush into his conclusion since the news came that many statutes of the idols have fallen and broken into pieces because of the

earthquake, but the emperor did not learn his lesson and ordered their heads to be cut off along with that of Pantaleon on the 27th of July around the year 305 AD.

St. Pantaleon was called 'The Great Martyr' and 'The Wonder Maker;' and his fame spread in the east and west.

[Jesuit Father Peter Faramaj: *Pastures of the Selected in the Biographies of the Righteous*, 1877, 27 Tammouz, pp. 404-406]
[Butler's *The Lives of the Saints*, July 27]

PANTELEIMON, THE PHYSICIAN (The martyr)

This saint is celebrated by the church on the 19th of Abib. He was most probably the same as St. Pandalemon (Pantalion) who is celebrated on the 15th of Baba.

PAOLO AND GIOVANNI (The martyrs)

With the Daughter of Emperor Constantine:

It was said that Constantia, the daughter of Emperor Constantine the Great (306-337 AD), having been healed from her illness through the intercession of St. Agnes; sought from her father to let her dedicate her life to worship next to the grave of St. Agnes. He built for her a palace and appointed a group of eunuchs to serve her, headed by two brothers: Giovanni (John) and Paolo (Paul). They were prominent leaders in the army, who were known for their meekness and piety; the princess trusted them greatly and assigned them to take care of her palace.

With Gallicanus, the High Commander of the Army:

It was said that when the Barbarians entered into the city of Setia, Emperor Constantine sought from his high commander Gallicanus who defeated the Persians, to confront them. That pagan commander, who was recently widowed, asked the emperor for his daughter Constantia to be his wife. While the emperor did not know what to do, because his daughter vowed virginity; he got a soothing message from her asking him not to worry and to relay her message to that commander. In her message, she asked her father to promise the commander that his request would be fulfilled; and that the commander could send his two daughters Atika and Artemia to live with her until he comes back from war. She also asked him to assign the two brothers serving her: Giovanni and Paolo to support that commander in the fight.

The commander Gallicanus rejoiced about the news and he set forth with his army, along with Giovanni and Paolo, to fight the Barbarians, but as the war situation in the fight deteriorated and the commander was in a dilemma; the two saintly brothers asked him to promise God to receive the Christian Faith once God would save him, so he did and God helped him to win. The commander returned to proclaim his conquest to the emperor, and his longing to be baptized as well.

The Martyrdom of Gallicanus:

God's grace strongly worked in this man's life through his relationship with the two brothers Giovanni and Paolo. Once he was baptized, he stopped thinking of marriage, left his two daughters with Constantia, distributed the greater portion of his wealth on the poor, and lived for a long time in seclusion close to Rome, under the guidance of a pious man named Hilarenzus.

During that time, he built a hotel to give hospitality to the strangers, and his fame widely spread because of his love of ministry. Later on, when Emperor Julian the Apostate (360-363 AD) reigned; he arrested St. Gallicanus and sent him to Alexandria, where he was martyred.

The Martyrdom of Giovanni and Paolo:

St. Giovanni and St. Paolo returned to serve princess Constantia and they dwelt there until she departed to the Lord. Then, they got back to the royal court, where they were beloved by all. When Emperor Julian the Apostate took over the reign, they forsook the court to live in peace.

Emperor Julian, who was in the east at the time, sent the governor of Rome and the leader Terentianus, to ask the two saints to return to the royal court. When they refused to do so, proclaiming that they would not serve the emperor who opposed the faith, the leader gave them ten days to change their mind. At the end of the ten days, he brought to them an idol to force them to worship, and when they refused, he cut their heads off and buried them in their own house. He hid their death according to the emperor's command. This took place around the year 362 AD. It was said that the pious Emperor Jovian (363-364 AD) has built-in their honor a church on the location of their house at Caelian Hill. The Western Church celebrates the feast of their martyrdom on the 26th of June.

PAPHNUTIUS, BISHOP OF THEBES

Through the Church's history, so many monks and bishops carried the name Paphnutius (Bebnouda). The two most famous of them were: the 1st

was bishop Paphnutius the Confessor, who attended the Council of Nicene and had an important role in opposing the Arianism; and he was also known as Paphnutius the Great, the disciple of Abba Anthony. The 2nd was Paphnutius the disciple of St. Macarius the Great, who took over the ordinance of the monastery and was called 'The Scetisan'. The book of 'D.L.O'Leary: The Saints of Egypt' has listed ten saints carrying that name.

Paphnutius, Bishop of the Upper Thebes:

Since his youth this saint Paphnutius resorted to the monastery of Pispir, which was three days walking distance from the River Nile to the hill of El-Qalzam, and he was accepted as one of the disciples of Abba Anthony the Great and stayed there for several years. When the fragrance of his virtuous life in the Lord has spread, he was chosen as a bishop on the region of the Upper Thebes; especially he was known for his love of teaching. This happened in the days of Emperor Maximinus Daza (305-313 AD) the assistant of Emperor Diocletian (284-305 AD). Then bishop Paphnutius went to Antenoh (Anesna) near Malawi, where he proclaimed his faith before the governor. There, they plucked off his right eye, burned his eyelids, took out the nerve of his left foot, and burned the muscles of his leg. In all that, he kept testifying to his Christ with a joyful and peaceful heart. Finally, he was sent to the mines of Phenon, by the Dead Sea where he worked for four years without complaints.

When the era of persecution came to an end, he returned to his diocese to resume his pastoral work with all that was left of his strength. His congregation loved him dearly, particularly that God granted him the grace of performing miracles.

Bishop Paphnutius the Confessor attended the Nicene Council in the year 325 AD, where the scars of torture on his body were appreciated and admired by those present and in particular by Emperor Constantine the Great (306-337 AD). The emperor loved him so much, that he often invited him to his palace, and used to kiss him on his plucked off eye, as a sacred spot.

According to the early historians, in particular, Socrates¹ (380-450 AD) and Sozomen² (400-450 AD); it seems that the Council was disposed to prohibit marital relationships to those priests who were married before ordination. However, St. Paphnutius earnestly pleaded with his fellow-bishops to adhere to the ecclesiastical tradition and not to impose the celibacy obligation on the clergy concerned. He insisted that only those priests or deacons who were celibate at the time of ordination should not be allowed to

¹ Socrates 1:11...

² Sozomen 1:32...

get married afterward, and he said that no one should be separated from his wife, to whom he had been united before ordination. The great veneration in which this saint was held and the fact that he had himself observed the strictest chastity all his life, gave weight to his proposal, which was unanimously adopted by the Council.

St. Paphnutius was an intimate friend of the 20th pope of Alexandria St. Athanasius the Apostolic (328-373 AD) and a strong advocate against the Arian views that denied the Divinity of the Lord Jesus Christ. Because of this fact, the Arians disliked him and they plotted against him; to which he responded by being firm and amiable at the same time.

The saint played an important role in the Council of Tyre in the year 335 AD, headed by Eusebius of Caesarea, and controlled by Eusebius of Nicomedia. In that Council, they tried to exile Pope Athanasius by vain accusations. He also attended the Council of Sardicia (Sofia, capital of Bulgaria) in the year 347 AD.

On sensing that his previous fellow prisoner in the mines: Maximus the bishop of Jerusalem; started to mix with the Arians in a naïve way, and to follow their lead; he explained to him their craftiness and managed to make him forsake them and to become a supporter of Pope Athanasius, on holding fast to the Orthodox Faith, all the days of his life.

His memorial is celebrated by the west on the 11th of September (He reposed most probably in the year 360 AD).

[Butler's Lives of Saints, September 11]
[Cross: Dictionary of Christian Church, p. 1028]
[O'Leary: Saints of Egypt, pp. 218-9]

PAPHNUTIUS OF UPPER EGYPT

According to current Greek historians, this saint Paphnutius of Upper Egypt was from Sidon..! The historian Rufinus (344-411 AD) visited the monastery of Paphnutius the hermit in Upper Egypt in the year 390 AD, after the departure of the saint and documented what he heard about him.

This saint lived a holy life in Upper Egypt and was like an angel on earth. He enjoyed a kind of transparency and a close relationship with the Celestials. It was claimed by some that he was the one who played the main role in the repentance of Taiis the sinner, even though some others believe that it was St. Bisarion who did that. Anyway, what happens with one of the men of God can happen with another.

St. Paphnutius and the Thief:

History gives us the following story that reveals the longing of God for the

salvation of every soul.

It was said that St. Paphnutius kept growing in the spirit and exalted in the life of virtue in the Lord to behold the Celestials. It happened that when he was wondering about how far did he grew in virtue; he was told that he has reached the stature of a professional singer in a nearby village. St. Paphnutius was surprised to have his spiritual stature compared to a professional singer, while he thought that he has gone so deep in his monastic life by dedicating all his time to worship and being qualified for observing Heavenly scenes. He hastened to that village to meet that particular singer to ask him how he has achieved such a stature. The singer answered him that he was an evil man who lived on stolen money. When the saint insisted that he would tell him about his good deeds; he answered him that he could remember only two incidents:

The first one was that during practicing robbery, it happened that his fellow thieves kidnapped a virgin girl who had dedicated her life to God and they intended to rape her. He took her away from them and returned her to her village without being harmed. The second incident was that he once saw in the desert a woman in such a bad condition of exhaustion, he carried her to his cave, gave her food and drink without touching her. When he asked her about the reason for her being in the desert, she told him that a creditor has put her husband and children in jail for a debt of 300 pieces of silver. Then, the creditor also sought to have her, so she fled from him, and for four days she had no food. He was so touched by her story that he gave her the 300 pieces of silver, which was almost all he had, and told her to go and redeem her man and children.

St. Paphnutius was so astonished at what he has heard from that merciful thief, and he felt that God has brought him there for this man's salvation, so he started to talk to him about God's love and compassion, and instantly the man threw away his flute and followed the hermit to the desert to live under his guidance for three years, walking on the way of perfection until he reposed.

St. Paphnutius Hospitality to Strangers:

As God has compared St. Paphnutius to a thief, in whom He found readiness and practical love; God also compared him to a married man whose wife gave birth to three children, after which he lived with her as a brother and sister. This man never refused to give hospitality to anyone or to despise a poor or a needy person. This led St. Paphnutius to say to himself: "If those in the world do such exalted deeds, how much more I, as a hermit, would be committed to do to surpass them in the practices of repentance?!" In this way, he kept increasing his spiritual struggle and strife in his prayers and

asceticism.

We do not know the date of departure of this saint. However, it was said that at the time of his departure, there was a group of anchorites present and he delivered his soul among them in an amazing Divine serenity, and those present witnessed the angels carrying his spirit, while they were praising and glorifying God.

[Melika Habib Yousef: St. Paphnutius the Hermit, 1970]

PAPHNUTIUS, THE BISHOP, ST.

The Coptic Synaxarion gave the biography of this saint under the 11th day of the Coptic month of Bashons, without defining his diocese.

This St. Paphnutius loved the monastic life, became a monk in the monastery of St. Macarius the Great; labored hard in the pious life of worship, and learned how to read and write. He also studied well the Holy Bible, the writings of the fathers, and the laws of the church.

After spending thirty-five years in the wilderness, the fame of this saint became wide-spread and the 63rd Pope of Alexandria St. Philotheos (979-1003 AD) called upon him and ordained him as a bishop. For the first time, he had to change his garment which was made of goat's hair for the sake of his public pastoral duties, to put it on again in private.

When St. Paphnutius became very sick, he prayed to the Lord Jesus Christ not to let His grace forsake him, and he asked God to continue to care for him as a bishop the same way He did in the wilderness all those years. An angel of the Lord appeared to him, and said: "In the wilderness, there was nobody to care for you or give you medicine when you are sick; but now while in the world, you have those who take care of you and all your needs."

God intended to teach the bishop of thirty-five years of experience in the wilderness, that God who cared for him somehow in the wilderness was going to care for him in the world in another way, through physicians and medications.

After thirty-two years as a bishop, St. Paphnutius delivered his spirit into the hands of his creator. Before his departure, he called the priests and the deacons, to deliver to them the vessels of the Altar, and he proclaimed to them that he did not keep a single cent for himself and he blessed them and then reposed in the Lord.

PAPHNUTIUS, THE DEACON (The martyr)

This martyr was a deacon in Boou (probably Bafu in far Upper Egypt).

Together with the soldier Silbon, he cared for the martyr Panesniu in jail and was his partner in the crown of martyrdom in the days of Celcianus.

[O'Leary: *The Saints of Egypt*, p. 218]

PAPHNUTIUS, THE HERMIT, ST.

He was the head of a little congregation of monks at Heracleopolis (Ahnasia, in Upper Egypt).

PAPHNUTIUS, THE MONK (The martyr)

When Ariana, the governor of Anesna, heard about Paphnutius the monk, who lived near the city of Dandara in Upper Egypt and how he drew by his piety so many people to the Lord Jesus Christ; he sent two centurions to arrest him. However, they failed to reach his place.

One night, St. Paphnutius saw an angel exhorting him to prepare himself to depart from this world. He told him that Ariana was looking for him. St. Paphnutius was exulted by the news and felt as if he was going to celebrate a feast. In the morning, he set forth to the river bank to wait for the governor. The governor disembarked from his boat to find a large number of officials fervently greeting him, and behold, a monk approached him saying: "O governor, the one who is talking to you is Paphnutius, whom you were seeking; that Christian Paphnutius!".

Afterward, the governor's procession started to head towards the city, while Paphnutius was in chains and surrounded by soldiers. Then, he was cast into jail among the murderers and thieves.

After a little rest, the governor held a special court to try the monk Paphnutius. He talked to him first with tenderness. The monk talked to him back about Eternity. Then, when the governor issued his command to torture him; the Lord sent an angel to encourage him and to heal his wounds. On observing that, his two executioners Denis and Calimak proclaimed their faith in Christ and were themselves martyred in the Name of the Lord.

The saint was brought back to jail where he met with forty State officials whom the governor cast in jail earlier. When Paphnotius talked to them about faith and Eternity; they rejoiced to hear him especially after what they witnessed that same night. That night, they were terrified to see a fire flared up into the prison, but were told by the jailer that this incident kept happening every night since the monk was jailed.

St. Paphnotius was using every chance to testify to the Lord Jesus Christ. Then, the saint and the forty officials were brought to the arena, where a huge

fiery furnace guarded by 100 soldiers was prepared to burn them. St. Paphnutius used that forum in the presence of the governor to talk to the spectators about faith in the Lord Jesus Christ. He managed to draw so many to believe in Christ. In his anger, the governor gave the order to torture him with the henbazin to fill his body with wounds; but the Lord kept healing him. This miracle caused the commander of the guards and all his 400 men to believe in St. Paphnotius Lord and they were all martyred in the fire.

On seeing how the number of martyrs continued to escalate, the governor in fear of a rebellion took Paphnutius with him in the boat and went to Antinoh (El-Sheikh Āebadah in Mallawy). There, he crucified St. Paphnutius on a palm tree after charging him of seducing the forty State officials and causing an uprising in the army (400 soldiers). It was amazing that the new executioners, after bringing the saint's body down from the palm tree, proclaimed their faith in his God, and were martyred as well.

PAPHNUTIUS, ST. (DISCIPLE OF ST. MACARIUS OF ALEXANDRIA)

This St. Paphnutius was also called 'The Hermit', because he lived twenty-four years in seclusion, wearing only one garment even in the severely cold winter nights. Even though he did not do any Scripture studies, yet the Holy Spirit granted him the knowledge of the secrets of the Holy Bible. He was considered one of the best interpreters of the Scriptures. It was said that St. John Cassian (360-435 AD) got his information about St. Macarius of Alexandria through this saint. Also, it was said that he met with St. Hilaria around the year 373-374 AD.

PAPHNUTIUS, THE HERMIT, ST

This St. Paphnutius was one of the shining stars in the wilderness of the Scetis (Shiheet). He was given the leadership as a 'Priest of the Scetis,' and he came to be one of the leaders of the monastic life in the 4th century AD. (Some scholars considered him the same person as the disciple of St. Macarius of Alexandria).

He was known by the name of 'Paphnutius the Hermit' or 'The Scetian' and was also known as 'Cephalas,' a name interpreted by some scholars as big head, while others believed it to be derived from 'Simplas' or the simple. On the other hand, he called himself Bobalis (the Cow), because of his big body, to belittle himself.

His Monastic Life:

This St. Paphnutius was born between the year 301 and 311 AD. He followed Abba Anthony the Great and became one of his disciples, and later on, went into seclusion. Then, he set forth to the wilderness of the Scetis to settle down there as a disciple of St. Macarius the Great, under the care of St. Isidore, the Priest of the Scetis.

We do not know when he was ordained as a priest, but we know that he succeeded St. Isidore as the Priest of the Scetis around 373 AD, when St. Isidore went south along with St. Macarius to the Biamon to establish the monastery of Abu Maqar. St. Isidore kept going back and forth for twelve years between the two locations until he reposed in the Lord.

After the repose of St. Macarius the Great, in the year 390 AD, St. Paphnutius became the father of the Scetis and his cell was five miles away from the church. When St. John Cassian (360-435 AD) visited the Scetis in the year 399 AD, he often wrote about St. Paphnutius, who was about ninety years old at the time.

He was known for his wisdom and prudence. When a controversy was stirred up between the Gnostic monks of Nitria (who followed Origen views) and the 23rd Pope of Alexandria St. Theophilus (385-412 AD) concerning the Form of God which those monks attempted to portray Him in a tangible materialistic way, St. Paphnutius managed by his wisdom to gain the unity of all parties in love.

Because of his Orthodox Faith, the Arian emperor Valens (364-378 AD) exiled him to NeoCaesarea. After his return, he met with St. Melania during her visit to Nitria and she felt honored by talking to him. (Some scholars believed that she met with a different saint: St. Paphnutius of Alexandria).

His Love for the Salvation of Souls:

It was said that a monk in the monastery of St. Anthony in Pispir, was accused of a serious sin, so that monk went to see Abba Anthony the Great, and after a little while he was followed there by his accusers among the brethren. While the case was discussed and that monk was being accused and he was trying to defend himself; St. Paphnutius intervened. He said to the brethren: "I saw somebody fell in a mud puddle and he plunged in the mud up to his knees. Some people came to his rescue, but all they did was pushing him down in the mud to his neck." On hearing this, Abba Anthony said about St. Paphnutius: "This man truly can gain the souls and save them." (It was said that this story should have been attributed to St. Paphnutius, the disciple of St. Macarius).

It was also said that once St. Paphnutius passed by a gang of thieves who

were drinking wine. The head of the gang, knowing that a hermit would never drink wine, filled a cup and threatened the saint with his sword, saying: "If you do not drink this wine, I shall kill you!" Knowing that if the head of the gang killed him he would bring himself to perdition, the saint chose to drink the wine for the salvation of that man, trusting that the grace of God will work within him. Here, the head of the gang, belittled in his sight before the obedience and meekness of St. Paphnutius, could not help but to apologize, saying: "Forgive me, father, for I have offended you". The saint answered him, saying: "I am sure God will forgive you your sins for the sake of this cup". In repentance, the head of the gang said: "I am sure that by the grace of God, from now on I would not offend any other man". It was said that the whole gang repented on his hands.

In the Scetis, there was a brother who was internally fighting against difficult thoughts of adultery. That brother declared to St. Paphnutius: "Even marrying ten women, will not be enough to quench my lust..!" Here, St. Paphnutius pleaded with him: "Do not say that my son, such talk is caused by war from the demons." The unconvinced brother traveled to the city and there he got married. After a while, the saint encountered him carrying a basket full of shells that he was selling for a living. Not recognizing him, the brother stopped him saying: "O father! I am your disciple so and so." The saint cried and said to him: "How did you forsake such a great honor to reach such a miserable condition? Anyway, did you marry ten women as you once told me?" He answered: "No father, I married just one with whom I suffer much, and I do not know how to satisfy her hunger." The kind father asked him: "Now, are you ready to return to us anew?" The brother said to him: "Will there be repentance for me, father?" Answering him in the positive, the man forsook everything, followed the saint to the Scetis to start anew as a beginner.

His Experience in his Early Monastic Life:

The author Cheneau in his book 'Les Saints d'Egypte,'¹ included the biography of St. Paphnutius the Priest, as though it concerned someone else other than St. Paphnutius the disciple of St. Macarius the Great. However, it seems that this story mentioned in that book might belong to him at the beginning of his monastic life:

The saint grew in virtue in such a marvelous way and gained a great reputation that he stirred up the envy of one of the other monks. That monk,

¹ Paul Cheneau: "*Les Saints d'Egypte : lectures édifiantes, instructives, agréables*", Jérusalem : Pères Franciscains, 1923...

one day crawled from the church during the Holy Liturgy and hid his book of prayers under the mat in the cell of the young monk Paphnutius. After the Holy Liturgy, he complained to the monastery' abbot that his book has been stolen. The abbot felt so hurt for such a thing to happen in his monastery and he sent three monks to search all the cells for the stolen book. After a while, they came back to report that they did find it under the mat of the monk Paphnutius. The young saint did not object, but humbly accepted the law of repentance without defending himself, and he had to double up his fasts for two weeks in an amazing serenity. As to the monk who falsely accused him, he was attacked by an evil spirit, and even St. Isidore could not drive it out of him. The monk kept on crying out: "Paphnutius, Paphnutius, I need Paphnutius". In all humility, the despised Paphnutius came to that monk and the evil monk confessed his evil deed and sought his forgiveness before all the brethren.

Of his Words and Teachings:

+ Let your grief be more favorable than your joy; your toil more favorable than your comfort; your reproach more favorable than your honor; and your giving more favorable than your receiving.

+ Once the 23rd Pope Theophilus visited the Scetis, so the brethren decided to ask St. Paphnutius to give the pope a word of benefit. The elder saint told them: "If he does not benefit from my silence, he would not benefit from my words..!" When the pope heard about that exchange, he really benefited.

+ St. Paphnutius once said: "While I was walking, I lost my way because of the fog and found myself in front of a small village. There, I have seen some people talking to each other. Then, I stood there praying for my sins. An angel of the Lord came holding a sword and said to me: 'Paphnutius, those who condemn their brethren will perish by this sword, but as for you, because you condemn no one, but humble yourself before God, as though you are the one who commits the sins; your name is written in the Book of the Living.'"

PAPIAS AND COMPANY (The martyrs)

A group of young men were exiled from Corinth in Greece to the region of Thebes in Upper Egypt, because of their faith in the Lord Jesus Christ; in the days of Emperor Marcus Aurelius Numerian in the year 284 AD. The names of these youth were: Papias, Victorianus, Victor (Boctor), Anisiphorus, Claudianus, Dioscorus, and Serapion.

When the governor of the region named Sabinus met with those youth, he could sense the signs of reverence, self-balance, along with the appearance of richness and honor on their countenances, so he had compassion on them and started to talk to them nicely, exhorting them to give consideration to their young age and to deny their Christ and submit to the god of the emperor; to avoid being brought under bitter torture and assured death.

The young men answered him mildly but with firmness, proclaiming forcefully their faith in their Christ, and about the sufferings that the governor threatened them with, they told him: "This is indeed our desire which we keep asking from the Lord through our simple prayers, and we shall feel great happiness if He listens to us."

The governor Sabinus, then, subjected them to suffer some simple tortures, to see if they would collapse through them, but on seeing that they endured them with strength, he resorted to more violent ways.

With Martyr Victorianus:

As it was the custom of the Roman governors; Sabinus asked Victorianus about his name, to which he answered: "I am a Christian." When he threatened him by the severe tortures he prepared for him if he refuses to sacrifice to the gods, he answered him: "I only fear the incomparable sufferings awaiting me, if I apostatize from my faith. As to the sufferings with which you threaten me, I am ready to endure it to be spared of those kinds prepared for you and Satan your father."

Governor Sabinus invented a new way of torture: he had them bring a long hollow stem of an oak tree, and drilled several holes in it. He then mockingly said to Victorianus: "Come, enter into your new place". The saint answered him: "You should know that wherever I am, I shall be a dwelling place for my God Jesus Christ; by whose power I can endure all your tortures."

Victorianus entered into the hollow tree stem; then the soldiers were ordered to pierce his body through the holes with toothed iron rods. This caused blood to flow from all the holes; while the governor was asking his men: "Let the clever Victorianus defend his faith that he preaches."

The martyr was brought out of the tree stem, to have his hands and feet crushed by heavy iron hammers. Then, his head was finally cut off by the sword, to earn the crown of martyrdom.

With Victor and his companions:

By the governor's command, the second man Victor was brought into the wooden cylinder after they cut off his hands and feet. This martyr kept on crying out: "All this will increase my Eternal glory." They finally cut Victor's head off by the sword, and his soul exultantly set forth toward Paradise.

When Anisiphorus saw what happened to his two fellows; he set forth by himself toward the wooden cylinder. However, the governor ordered his men to burn him in a fire, then to cut his body into little pieces. In all that, the soul of the martyr was absorbed by Eternal glory.

Then, came the turn of Claudianus, whose body was also cut to pieces, then cast at the feet of his remaining fellows to terrify them. Serapion's head was cut off and Papias was cast into the river to drown.

All of the young men, therefore, earned the crowns of martyrdom and joyfully carried the features of our Crucified Lord Jesus Christ.

[Cheneau: Les Saints d'Egypte, P. 2, p. 318]

PAPIAS, BISHOP OF HIERAPOLIS, ST.

This St. Papias was a bishop of Hierapolis in Asia Minor (around the years 80-160 AD) during the 2nd century; according to St. Irenaeus (130-202 AD). He was a disciple of St. John the Evangelist and a friend of St. Polycarp.

St. Papias was a man of high culture, of rich knowledge in the Holy Bible; who had a special interest in gathering and collecting the oral narratives concerning the life of the Lord Jesus Christ. He authored his famous work 'Expositions of the Oracles of the Lord' in five volumes, out of which, unfortunately, we only have few quotes in the writings of Irenaeus and Eusebius.

In this work, he gave his remarks on the Gospels of Mark and Luke; as well as he cared for the oral narratives through eye-witnesses.

He was the first to talk about the 'One Thousand Year' reign in a literal sense, saying that the Lord Jesus Christ will reign on the earth during that time. He assumed that he was explaining what came in the prophecies. However, this concept was rejected by the Mother Church.

[Rev. B. Schmid: Manual of Patrology; St. Louis 1903, p. 85]

PAPILAS (The martyr)

The Coptic Church celebrates the feast of the martyrdom of St. Papilas (Fafilas/ Filas) on the 28th of Toba. He was a bishop, but we do not know the name of his diocese. He was condemned in the days of Emperor Diocletian (284-305 AD) and governor Nomarius who tried to seduce him by promises of high positions, only to be scoffed by the saint. He was tortured along with three young men for three days, and finally, they cut off their heads, and they earned the crowns of martyrdom.

It was said that Nomarius' order was met by the saint with joy. The saint

prayed, then came to say gently to the executioners: "Now, fulfill the orders of the king, O my children."

[O'Leary: *The Saints of Egypt*, p. 94]

PARSANUPHIUS, FATHER

The Greek Church gives Fr. Parsanuphius such a great honor, that they put his icon next to those of St. Ephraim the Syrian and St. Anthony the Great, in the church of Hagia Sophia in Constantinople; when the church was still under their jurisdiction.

Fr. Parsanuphius was born in Egypt, dwelt in a cell close to a monastery in Gaza in Palestine, in the era of Emperor Justinian I (527-565 AD).

It was said that he refrained from meeting anybody. He used to communicate only through messages, and the Greeks believed that his food was not from earth.

St. Oghris (Evagrius) told that story about him:

The patriarch of Jerusalem Ostachius was in doubt, concerning what he heard about this father hermit, so he ordered to break down a part of the wall of his cell to make sure of his existence. When they attempted to do so, a fire came out toward those men who were trying to break in.

Anyway, whatever was said about Fr. Parsanuphius' ascetic life; it is important to consider what he wrote to others about urging them to be moderate in everything in their lives and to have just enough food, drink, sleep and attire. He cared very much to write to those who lost hope, to confirm the commitment to hope in God, the forgiver of all sins.

Fr. Parsanuphius reposed in the Lord around the year 550 AD.

Of his Words:

- + Be a special servant to One Master, and not to many.
- + Unless the disciple forsakes his desires behind him, submits in everything and be humble; he will never reach the City of Peace.
- + Humility makes man a dwelling place for God. His dwelling would drive away the wicked enemies, together with all the evil desires, and would destroy their head the devil. It would turn man into a temple for God, pure, holy, enlightened, joyful, and full of every sweet fragrance, goodness, and gladness. In other words, man would be clothed with God. Yes, and would be made a god himself; as it is written: *"I said, you are gods, and all of you are children of the Most High."* (Ps. 82:6). Then, the eyes of his heart would be opened, to see the true light, and to understand him who says: "By grace, I am saved by the Lord Jesus Christ."

- + The love of Christ made us strangers to men and humanities.
- + Die completely, to live in perfection by our Lord Jesus Christ.
- + Sitting in the cell is nothing but an entrance into the heart and searching it; to control the mind away from any evil thought and to cut covetousness off.

PASANTAOS, THE BISHOP, ST.

His Monastic Life:

St. Pasantaos (Pasentius/Pasanti/Pasanda/Pashanti from whom the names Bishai, Apshai, and Bishoi were derived), was born to pious Christian parents in the village of Shamir, which was affiliated with the city of Armant, around the year 568 AD. His parents raised him to have an Evangelic mind. Since his youth, he knew many Divine books and the true Ecclesiastic knowledge by heart. Because his heart was inflamed with the desire to lead a monastic life; he set forth to St. Abba Elijah the Great, the Abbot of the monastery of Abi Fam on mount Shama and end up spending most of his life on that mountain.

It happened that Abba Theodosius the Great from the Scetis, was present during that first encounter of St. Elijah with that young man, and he recounted that meeting as follows:

One day, while I was sitting with St. Elijah, that young man Pasanda arrived, prostrated himself to the ground and sought from St. Elijah to accept him as a monk under his guidance. When St. Elijah asked him: "Tell me son why did you forsake your parent's house?" He answered him: "O saintly father, the Holy Spirit dwelling in you would tell you that. While I was shepherding my father's flock of sheep, the devil brought unclean thoughts into my mind. I implored God, may His name be glorified, to help me overcome them, and I directly headed to the church, supplicating to God with a flow of tears, if He intended for me to forsake the world and become a monk, to make me hear some words read in the church that confirm what I intended to do, so it happened, and God who never fails those who seek him with a pure heart, fulfilled my request and I heard them reading the saying of St. Paul the Apostle: *"We know that all things work together for good for those who love God"* (Rom. 8:28). I exulted to hear this, and after I got communion of the Divine Sacraments, I hastened in secret to come to you, O saintly father, hoping you will fulfill my request." Instantly St. Elijah put on him the holy monastic eskeem and prayed on him. Here, I was astonished to see the saint receiving him with such haste without thorough investigation, particularly because of his young age. I said to him: "O father, in the wilderness of the Scetis, I used to see how the fathers thoroughly investigated

the candidate who comes for the monastic life.” He answered me: “It is as you say, but God has already revealed to me six years earlier before this young man came over here; the virtues of this man as a chosen vessel and that he will shepherd the flock of Christ. He will be given the key of the church of God and get the rank of a bishop on the city of Qift. He will uprightly hold the word of truth and keep the Divine commandments and those of our pure saintly fathers, and his fame will spread all over the earth.”

That was what was recorded by St. Theodosius who wrote the biography of this saint, co-authored by the fathers: Abba Moses and Abba John, the disciples of Abba Pasantaos himself, whom they did not forsake until he reposed.

His Strife:

When the saint got into the monastic life, he was very serious in his spiritual struggle, caring for perpetual prayers, memorizing the Holy Bible; along with strict fasting; eating only once every two or three days and sometimes he fasted the whole week. It happened that he was seen once standing, bare-footed on the mountain in extremely hot weather, reciting his Psalms, while his perspiration poured from him. When a brother commended him on such a strife, the saint said: “This work is counted as nothing, besides the strife against the three demons: The first is the demon of the adultery thoughts that inflame the heart with lust. The second is the demon who blinds the eyes, that man would not be able to perceive the seriousness of his sins, and the third would make him forget the existence and greatness of God. It is befitting of the believer to implore God to help him get rid of these three by the power of His Holy Cross.”

He so loved reading both Holy Testaments, that it was said that a brother saw him reading some prophets' books; and whenever he would start reading a book, that particular prophet would come and join him, and at the end of the book he would kiss him then ascends to Heaven. Also, while the saint was standing upright to pray, the brother saw the fingers of his hands shine like lit lamps.

Again, a brother who once came to visit him during a severe illness, found the door of his cell open; so to get his permission to enter, according to the custom of the monks, he said: “Bless me, my father.” When he did not hear a response from him, he assumed that he was too ill to get up, so he entered into the cell to find him talking to someone. In firm love, admonishing him, the saint said: “Is it the law of monks to enter into a cell without permission?!” The brother answered: “Forgive me, father, I sinned, for I assumed that you were too ill to get up, so I dared to enter to visit you.” Then, the guest who was with Abba Pasantaos told him: “Leave him alone,

for God made him worthy of our peace for the sake of his good works.” The brother then kissed the guest's hand and went his way. After the departure of the guest, the brother asked Abba Pasantaos: “I implore you father, tell me who was that saint; for when I held his hand to kiss it and put it over my face, I felt a great power dwell on my soul and body, and gladness came upon my heart, and I became like a drunkard by wine.” St. Pasantaos answered him: “God, looking at my weakness, labor and solitude that when illness got the upper hand on me, He sent one of His favorites: St. Elijah the Tethebite of Mount Carmel, who comforted me by his Divine words. I implore you by the spiritual love not to tell anyone about it until the day I die.”

His Miracles:

His biography tells us some of the miracles God performed on his hands:

When the water in the vessels dried up while being on the mountain, and the brethren were on the brink of dying of thirst; the saint prayed, then sought from them to check the vessels. They found them full of water and they glorified God.

He once entered into a tunnel inside the mountain, where he found a dead body of a pagan man. The dead man talked to the saint about the hell he was experiencing before he went back to sleep.

Once two women afflicted by a disease came to see him seeking his prayers. On seeing them, he forsook his water pot, covered his head, and hastened to leave. Not being able to catch him, the two women just took some of the dust he stepped on with his feet, prayed and they were healed.

It was said that he could not find water in certain locations of the wilderness, so he prayed for three days, after which he found a well of fresh water. This well is still near the city of Naqqada, named after him, up to this very day.

Ordained as a Bishop on Qift:

St. Pasantaos was ordained as a bishop on the city of Qift by the 35th Pope of Alexandria St. Damianus (569-605 AD), around the year 598 AD. He was a contemporary of Abba Constantine, the bishop of Assiut; and the Persian invasion of Egypt.

He accepted the bishopric only by a Divine call; for while he was praying one evening, three angels of light appeared to him in the form of monks; they gave him peace and proclaimed to him that he would be ordained as a bishop on the city of Qift, and they sought from him not to reject the call, and then they disappeared. He prayed until the morning; when the priests came to seize him to be ordained as a bishop. He told them: “If I do not fear to disobey Him who commands me, I would never listen to you, even if you cut

my head off.”

He was a good shepherd always watching on the flock of Christ and cared for the salvation of everyone. Also, he was a generous giver, he left nothing in his diocese except one dinar that he gained by the work of his hands; it was intended to be used only for the expense of shrouding him.

He was known for his awesome countenance; no one dared to stare at his face, despite his amiability and the gentleness of his talk. Whenever he ascended to the Altar to minister the Holy Liturgy, his face would shine like fire, before him all the sins of his congregation were revealed; and saw the Holy Spirit dwell on the Altar.

He was granted the gift of prophecy, to warn many of his people about what might dwell on them; and the door of his cell was always open to everyone.

His Repose:

St. Pasantaos called his disciple John and told him that the day of his departure was at hand, and proclaimed that, while he was praying at night, a multitude of people of light appeared to him in the church, among whom were two extremely bright ones: SS. Peter and Paul, and a congregation of bishops around them, to call him to the Heavenly Jerusalem. They all blessed him before he would depart from the body, and then they all ascended high.

He called his congregation, preached them and sought from them not to shroud him in precious clothing, but in the ones he has on him; to bury him in a place he fixed to them; ascended to the Altar, ministered the Sacrament of the Eucharist, gave them the Holy Communion, blessed them, and then got a little ill, and then reposed in the Lord on the 13th of Abib.

[Manuscript# 97, 470, in the Coptic museum, of the 14th Century, published by Mr. Nabil Selim in his series: ‘From the Monasteries of the Fathers’]

PASANTAOS, THE HERMIT, ST.

This St. Pasantaos (Pasentius/Pasanti/Pasanda/Pashanti from whom the names Bishai, Apshai, and Bishoi were derived), was born in the city of Armant to pagan parents. The city of Armant was known for a long time, for holding fast to pagan worship, it had about 360 Berbas (House of Idols) full of stone and wooden statues. When Ariana the governor of Anesna arrived there at the time of emperor Diocletian (284-305 AD), in his way to the city of Esna; Armant boasted that there was not a single Christian living there; whereas Esna did not have a single pagan. When Ariana entered into Esna, he found it completely empty, except for an old woman who told him where to find the Christian inhabitants (as it is mentioned in the biography of St.

Ammonius, the bishop of Esna). However, the situation in Armant eventually changed also, and its entire population became Christians.

After the birth of Pasantaos; his parents carried him to the Barbas, as it was the custom of the pagan community, but the surprise was that while they were still afar, the priests of the idols hastened to them and sought from them to stay away, on account that their infant was an enemy of the gods. The devil, feeling that the infant was prepared by God to spread the faith and to destroy his pagan worship; so he stirred up the priests against him and his parents and drove them away.

In his youth, Pasantaos learned to be a carpenter, and it was a custom in Armant that the inhabitants would send every year a group consisting of a carpenter, a builder, and a physician, to work in the residence of the governor for one year. Pasantaos turn came, and he set forth to the palace, along with a builder and a physician. There, while standing and looking at the sky, an eagle came with a royal crown, which he put on Pasantaos' head for few moments, and then took it back and flew away eastwards. All those who witnessed that were astonished at what they saw and considered that as a Divine declaration that Pasantaos would become a king.

Pasantaos loved the Christian Faith and he was baptized while he was a young man. During his Baptism, he saw a horrible ghost coming out of him and he proclaimed: "See how the hosts of darkness fled from me through the Holy Baptism..?"

After receiving Baptism, feeling that he was selected for a Divine mission, St. Pasantaos, dedicated himself to study the Holy Scripture. He knew by heart most of its books and trained himself on the pious monastic life while trusting in the exalted grace of God. Then, he forsook the city and set forth to the neighboring mountain, where he dwelt close to a saintly man of God named Sorus. That holy man was the first monk on that mountain and he eventually became the first bishop on that region which had only one little church.

Call to Ministry:

Pasantaos' heart was inflamed, longing to seclusion and to dedicate himself to worshiping God. However, his soul at the same time was embittered for the sake of his neighboring pagans who denied the Salvation of the Lord Jesus Christ. While planning to set forth to the mountain, he saw an angel in the form of a man standing next to a huge heap of salt. When the saint asked the angel: "Who will be buying such a great quantity of salt from you in such a deserted area?" The angel answered him: "And, who will benefit from you if you live on this mountain? Don't you know that God has chosen you to bring those lost people back to be saved? Get up now and

come down to dwell outside the city, where you will gradually draw the people to God; for a great multitude will come to receive the knowledge of God from you, O chosen vessel.” The angel then gave him peace and ascended to Heaven. Right away, the saint came down from the mountain and built for himself a cell close to the city, where he practiced his monastic life with great strife, praying to God with tears for the sake of the salvation of His people. The saint increased in splendor by the grace of God working within him; and as God granted him the gift of prophecy, many came to seek his counsel.

By Divine command, he built a church, one mile from his cell, and built an assembly hall next to it, where fifty-three brethren came to practice the monastic life under his guidance. That monastery eventually turned into a center of spiritual radiation, to which many pagans came to listen to the sermons of the saint, received faith and were baptized; so that the city of Armant eventually almost became wholly Christian.

His Encounter with Others:

When Abba Bebnouda, the bishop of the city of Qus came to visit him; the saint came out to receive him with joy. They sat down talking about the great works of God. He said to the saintly bishop: “It happened that while I was walking on the mountain, I saw my Lord and Savior Jesus Christ, Son of the Living God, in front of me. I prostrated myself to the ground before Him, kissed Him, and walked together with Him like a man with his friend. When we reached a fenced wall, He blessed me, gave me peace, and ascended to Heaven in great glory.”

Another time, when Abba Harsasius came to visit him, he also received him with great joy, walked with him into the monastery amid praises. It happened that John (brother of St. Pasantaos) went out of the monastery to collect some sticks, and there the devil attacked him by thoughts of adultery. The demons appeared to him in the form of women, to stir him to sin with them, but he hastened to forsake the location to a place with thorns and thistles and then headed to the monastery. St. Pasantaos, getting to know by the spirit what happened to his brother, came out to receive him, saying: “Welcome back, O good man, united to the only Holy Eternal God; who overcame the thoughts and fantasies of the enemy. I say to you, O my beloved brother, that our Mighty God has granted you to be the bishop of Armant.” When Abba Maqara the bishop of Armant reposed in the Lord, the congregation of the city, took John to the 23rd Pope of Alexandria Abba Theophilus (385-412 AD) and sought from him to ordain him as a bishop of Armant. In this way, the prophecy of his brother was realized.

His Care for the Sick:

As God granted him the gift of healing the sick and multitudes of people came to him; St. Pasantaos built a place to give hospitality to many; and to care for the salvation of their souls and spiritual edification, in addition to praying for the healing of their bodies.

In his old age, full of spiritual fruits, he got sick and reposed in the Lord on the 7th day of the Coptic month of Mesra.

[Manuscript 101-275, in the Coptic Museum, Cairo]
[Nabil Selim: Abba Bishai and Abba Pasantaos, 1976]

PASTAURUS (The martyr)

St. Pastaurus was martyred amid the afflictions that dwelt on the church in the days of the 82nd Pope Benjamin II (1327-1339 AD) in the 14th century.

When his mother denied her faith, he stayed with his father. Some reported him to the governor who attempted to make him deny his faith, but when he refused, he put him in jail. In jail, a white dove came to stand on his head. On telling that to the governor, he threatened to burn him alive, but he said to him: “Do to me whatever you wish, you have authority only on my body.”

They brought him to the arena to be insulted, reviled, and beaten by the mob. He endured all that with tranquility and perseverance. Finally, they cut his head off, and he received the crown of martyrdom. God allowed many wonders to be performed through his body.

[Wallis Budge: The Ethiopic Synaxarium, Cambridge 1928, p. 842]

PASTOR AND JUSTUS (The martyrs)

These two saints Pastor and Justus were young pupils: Justus was thirteen years old and his brother was nine years old. They lived in the era of Emperor Diocletian and his partner Maximian (284-305 AD), who inflamed the fire of persecution everywhere in the Roman Empire.

The two saints were pupils in an elementary school in the Spanish city of Complutum (later called Alcala de Henares), when Dacian the governor of Spain tortured the Christians by orders from the two emperors. As the pupils of the school heard how the Christians were enduring the sufferings; the reaction of the evil ones was a desire to see the martyrs being tortured, while some others were fearful of what was happening. However, these two pupil saints made up their minds to have their portions in the crowns of

martyrdom. Then, they could not wait any longer, nor set forth to their parents, or even to the church, but they threw their books away and hastened to the arena, as though they feared they might lose their chance. In an inflamed zeal, they forced their way among the crowd to stand before the judge to proclaim their faith with courage that amazed those present.

Looking at them with despite, the judge did not intend to enter into debate with them but ordered right away to have them beaten with whips, which he expected them not to be able to endure, but their courage amazed everyone. Feeling shame, and seeing how the audience commiserated with them, he immediately ordered cutting their heads off.

PATRA, ABBA

Abba Patra was one of the early Fathers of the wilderness of the Scetis. He was a close friend of Abba Ambicus. Probably, he was the same Abba Patra mentioned by the fathers Selwanus and Lot. These two saints put him on the same spiritual level as the great Fathers Bamu (Bambu), Aghathon, and John.

[Budge: *The Paradise*, Vol. 2, p. 115, 207]

PATRA (The martyr)

St. Patra (Matra) was martyred on the 10th day of the Coptic month Mesra, most probably in the year 250 AD, in the days of St. Dionysius the Great, the 14th pope of Alexandria (247-264 AD). When Emperor Decius (249-251 AD) issued a decree committing everyone to worship the idols and to deny the Lord Jesus Christ; St. Patra set forth to the idol temple, removed the golden hand of the idol, cut it into small pieces and distributed the pieces on the poor. Finding out what happened to his idol, the emperor in great anger arrested many people; but the saint daringly came to him on his own, proclaiming that he took the hand and gave its gold to the needy. The governor gave the order to burn him alive, but God sent His angel and saved him. Then, the governor ordered to cut off his hands and feet, and to nail him upside down on a tree. A blind man took some of the blood pouring from his body and put it on his eyes and he had his sight back. Ultimately the saint had his head cut off and received the crown of martyrdom.

[O'Leary: *The Saints of Egypt*, p. 103]

PATROCLUS (The martyr)

This saint's memorial is celebrated by the west on the 21st of January. St.

Patroclus (Patroccus) was called by the name St. Parre in France and was one of the Patron Saints of the French city of Troyes.

When Emperor Aurelian (270-275 AD) came to the land of Gaul (France) in the year 272 AD; he went to the city of Troyes and there he heard about that zealous Christian St. Patroclus. He called him and entered with him into a dialogue, in an attempt to seduce him to offer incense to his gods and to deny his Christ; but the saint held fast to his faith, and when he was threatened by the emperor, who told him: "I will burn you in the fire if you do not sacrifice to the gods." The saint answered him: "I am a living sacrifice for God and I am willing, once He calls me to enjoy martyrdom."

The emperor gave the order to torture him mercilessly and then to cast him in jail, thinking that by doing that he would break him down and lead him to deny his God, but when he called him again; he found him still holding fast to his faith in His Christ, so the emperor scoffed him as miserable and poor. The saint responded to him that he was rich by Christ and that the emperor even though rich in the temporal things, yet was very poor in faith. The emperor gave the order to execute him by drowning him in the Seine river, but once they brought him to the bank of the river, the river water flooded over and everybody fled in fear, except the saint who crossed the river to the other side. There, a woman saw him and told the soldiers, who ran after him and killed him in the year 272 AD.

[Baring-Gould: *Lives of Saints*, Jan. 21]

PAUL AND SALFANA (The martyrs)

The church celebrates the martyrdom of St. Paul (Boules) and St. Salfana on the 25th of Kiahk.¹ Governor Julius persecuted the Christians in the city of Orsh during a difficult period that dwelt upon the church. During that time, two pious men by the name of Paul and Salfana approached him and proclaimed that they were holding fast to their Christ. These men lived all their years since their childhood in a life of piety and righteousness. The governor then in great anger ordered placing them both on a fire made by burning wood. However, God was glorified in them by turning the fire into what was like cold water, from which they came out praising and glorifying God before all who were present.

The governor then ordered to tie them to a pair of strong oxen and be drawn along the streets of the town to have their flesh torn off, but the Lord kept them safe. Then, the two of them were hanged upside down close to a

¹ cf. the *Synaxarion of Rene Basset...*

Berba (pagan temple) and a fire was ignited underneath them. However, they were not harmed and the fire almost consumed the temple. Here, the priests of the idols intervened and begged the governor to get rid of them by having their heads cut off, which he did. Afterward, God performed so many signs and healings from the bodies of these two saints.

PAUL I, THE PATRIARCH OF CONSTANTINOPLE

With jealousy on the Orthodox Faith, St. Paul I, the patriarch of Constantinople (337-351 AD) stood against the Arian heresy that denied the Divinity of the Lord Jesus Christ. He had a close relationship with the 20th Pope of Alexandria, St. Athanasius the Apostolic (328-373 AD) and the Pope of Rome, St. Julius I (337-352 AD). St. Paul I was exiled five times during his patriarchate, these were plotted by Eusebius of Nicomedia and Macedonius, the denier of the Holy Spirit.

This saint was born in Thessalonica at the end of the 3rd century. He was raised on loving God and holding fast to the faith. When he moved to Constantinople, its patriarch Alexander (314-337 AD) ordained him as a priest, after observing how he led a truly pious life, along with great knowledge and strong faith. As a priest, he was loved by the congregation, and when the patriarch felt that his departure was close, he gave his counsel to choose the priest Paul (Boulus) as his successor.

His Patriarchate:

St. Paul was chosen as an archbishop of Constantinople in the year 337 AD. This was the start of his struggle in bearing his Cross. His troubles were mainly caused by the heretics who focused on opposing him until the moment of his departure from this world. Eusebius of Nicomedia, who was cherished by the emperor's sister, was able to convince Emperor Constantine the Great (306-338 AD) to exile this saint after he and his collaborators presented so many false claims and reports that stirred up the emperor against him. However, after his exile, they tried to convince the emperor to get another patriarch to replace him; but Constantine refused to do so. The saint remained in exile until Emperor Constantine passed away in the year 338 AD, then he returned to his throne; as did St. Athanasius the Apostolic, St. Eustathius of Antioch, St. Marcellus bishop of Ancyra and others.

His Second, Third, Fourth, and Fifth Exiles:

Before he died, Emperor Constantine the Great divided his empire on his three sons: The East and Constantinople was the portion of Constantius II (337-361 AD); Italy and Africa that of Constans I (337-350 AD); and the

West (Gaul, Britannia, and Hispania) was for Constantine II (337-340 AD). Emperor Constantius II was inclined toward Arianism, so he exiled the patriarch Paul I to set Eusebius of Nicomedia in his place on the throne of Constantinople. However, Eusebius died in the year 341 AD and the church was saved from his evil plots. While the Arians set the deacon Macedonius as his successor; the Orthodox congregation brought back their legal patriarch. When the two factions fought against one another, with dead and wounded on both sides; the emperor sent his high army commander to establish peace, but when he was killed, the emperor came by himself and forgave everybody. Yet because of his inclination toward the Arians, he exiled the patriarch Paul I for the third time.

The Arians found their chance to spread their heresy; and Macedonius spread a new heresy, by which he denied the Divinity of the Holy Spirit. Patriarch Paul I feeling his responsibility toward his people; he had to return to Constantinople to hold the congregation on the Orthodox Faith and to counter the other vanities. When the emperor heard about that, he sent some people to get hold of him in secret, and he was taken in chains to be exiled in Singara in Mesopotamia. Then, he was taken back to Homs (Emesa) and was left there. During all that, he suffered his fourth exile with thanksgiving.

When the Pope of Rome Julius I (337-352 AD) heard about St. Paul's latest exile; he sought the help of Constans I the emperor of Italy and Africa. That emperor loved the church, and he intervened with his brother Constantius II to bring back the exiled bishops. Then, he held a Church Council in Sardica headed by Pope Julius I in the year 343 AD, in which he excommunicated Macedonius and the Arians. Constantinople received its patriarch with great joy, and St. Paul I did his best to shepherd his flock.

When emperor Constans I was assassinated, the Arians found their chance to slander Pope Paul I and to accuse him of heresy and evil practices. They eventually managed to get him exiled for the fifth time to Cucusus in the mountains of Cappadocia (in Armenia Minor), where he reposed in the Lord in the year 351 AD, as a result of what he suffered of labors, hunger, and thirst; enduring them all with joy.

The Latin Church celebrates his feast on the 7th of November.

PAUL OF TAMOUH, ST. ABBA

The Coptic Church celebrates the feast of this saint on the 7th of Baba, and seeks his prayers in the commemoration of the saints in the Liturgy, along with St. Ezekiel his disciple.

After the devastation of the wilderness of the Scetis around the year, 408

AD; St. Abba Bishoi fled the area and went to mount Anesna in Upper Egypt. There, he met with Abba Paul the Hermit and they both had an amazing spiritual friendship, that an angel appeared to St. Paul, saying: “Your body will be with that of Abba Bishoi.” (The two bodies are still together in one tube in the Monastery of Abba Bishoi up to this very day). It was said that later on when the bishop of Anesna decided to move the body of Abba Bishoi; his boat did not move until a hermit named Jeremiah told them about the promise of the Lord to Abba Paul, so they brought the body of Abba Paul to the boat and they moved them together to the Monastery of Abba Shenouda in Akhmim. Later on, the bodies of these two saints were moved again together in the days of the 52nd Pope Yusab I in the 9th century (831-849 AD) to the Monastery of Abba Bishoi in the Scetis.

The bodies of the two saints were kept in one tube; and this is a testimony of the spiritual friendship full of love that bound the two saints together; that even death could not separate them. This is not on the level of this mortal world but the level of the Eternal glory of both the body and the soul.

Abba Paul was known for his great love of worship, particularly for the perpetual prayers, as well as his serious asceticism, that his disciple Ezekiel told about him that he faced death six times because of his harsh asceticism.

He lived in solitude as a hermit, in perpetual strife, that the Lord Jesus Christ appeared to him saying: “Enough labor, My beloved Paul”. St. Abba Paul answered Him: “O my Master, let me exhaust my body for the sake of Your Name; as You have done for the sake of mankind. Even though You are God, You delivered Yourself for our sake, we who are unworthy.”

[O’Leary: *The Saints of Egypt*; p. 223-4]

PAUL THE GREAT, ST.

St. Paul the Great once said: “The monk who cares for the few things he has in his cell, will be mocked by the demons. Personally, I suffered from such a situation.” This St. Paul (Boulus) was from Galatia, a Roman province in Anatolia (modern central Turkey).

[Boulus the Confessor: cf. the Biography of ‘Ur’ (Hur), Isaiah, Boulus & Nobi]

PAUL (The martyr)

The historian Eusebius mentioned the details of what he witnessed of violence and brutality in Caesarea of Palestine against the believers, in the year 324. These tortures were inflicted by the governor of Palestine Firmilianus, the successor of Urbanus, in the days of Emperor Maximinus II

(311-313 AD).

A group of ninety-seven confessors: men, women, and children, were brought to the governor, and he ordered the executioners to burn the believers' left feet using red hot heated iron and to pluck out their right eyes then sear them with red hot metal. Afterward, he sent those courageous confessors to work as slave laborers in the mines of Lebanon.

Another group from Gaza was arrested while gathering in prayer and listening to the Word of God. Among them was a girl named Thea (Tia), who rebuked the governor when he threatened to have her raped in public, and he ordered that she would be whipped and tortured. When another girl from Caesarea of Palestine, named Valentina saw that, she rushed through the crowd to tell the governor: "Until when will you torture my sister?" She was arrested and was taken to the temple of the idols. There, she kicked the altar, and the governor ordered tying the two girls together and burning them alive.

At the same time, the head of a Christian man named Paul (Paulus) was cut off because he held fast to his faith. That man showed an amazing love in the moments before his martyrdom. After he requested the permission of his executioner, he stood up and with contrition prayed with a loud voice to God for his companions to support them in the moments of their suffering; for the spreading of faith; for the sake of all who were present and for that of the emperor, the governor and all the officials.

His sufferings drew him to think not of himself but of the others, even the opponents and the persecutors, to pray to God to grant them Salvation.

[Eusebius: Ecclesiastical History, ch. VIII]

PAUL, THE FIRST HERMIT, ABBA

Through Divine care, St. Abba Anthony the Great the Father of the Monastic family and its founder in the whole world, encountered this St. Paul who preceded him by long years in monastic life in the wilderness, where no one but God knew anything about him. God kept sustaining him by half a loaf of bread, carried to him by a raven every day all along many decades; in which God smelled the sweet fragrance of his prayers and praise, to call him: "My beloved Paul."

His Upbringing:

St. Paul the 1st hermit was born in Alexandria around the year 228 AD. His father passed away leaving a great wealth for him and for his older brother Peter. However, Peter conspired to acquire the greater portion of the inheritance for himself, and when the disagreement escalated between the

two brothers; Paul decided to take the matter to court. However, on his way to court, he encountered a very wealthy man's funeral procession, happened to be passing by. St. Paul asked himself: "Has that rich man taken anything from this world with him?" Then, he had a complete change of heart and he totally despised the temporal life. His heart was so inflamed with the Eternal inheritance, that instead of going to the court, he got out of the city and entered into a deserted tomb where he spent three days praying and seeking the Divine guidance.

Then, an angel appeared to St. Paul and guided him to the wilderness in the East Desert, where he dwelt in mount Nimra, near the Red Sea. There he lived for eighty years. During all these years he saw no one, clothed himself in a tunic made of palm tree leaves and God sustained him with a daily ration of half a loaf of bread, which was carried to him by a raven. The saint lived all that time on that bread with some dates from the palm trees or herbs from the mountain, and he drank water from a nearby spring.

An Encounter with Abba Anthony:

One time, St. Anthony the Great was thinking that he was the first man to dwell in that wilderness. Then, an angel of the Lord appeared to Abba Anthony and told him about the presence of a very special man, whom the world was unworthy of his footsteps; and for the sake of his prayers, God has lifted the drought from the world and has granted it plenty of rain.

On hearing that Heavenly testimony, St. Anthony set forth with Divine guidance, to the cave of St. Paul. When he got there, St. Paul called him by his name and they sat together talking about the great works of God in their lives. At sunset, the raven came as usual but carrying a whole loaf of bread. St. Paul then said: "Now I know for sure that you are a man of God; for all along eighty years the raven kept providing me with only half a loaf of bread, but today it came with a whole loaf. God sent you your food."

At the end of their talk, Abba Paul sought from Abba Anthony to hasten to bring him the priestly garment of the 20th Pope of Alexandria, St. Athanasius the Apostolic (328-373 AD); for his departure time was approaching. Abba Anthony returned greatly affected, brought the garment, and headed back to St. Paul's cave. On his way, he saw a group of angels carrying his soul to Paradise, while joyfully singing praise to God.

On reaching the cave of Abba Paul, Abba Anthony found him kneeling. For a moment, he assumed that he was praying, so he waited for him to finish. Finally, he realized that he has reposed in the Lord and he intensely mourned him. This happened on the 2nd of Amshir in the year 343 AD.

When St. Antony wanted to bury St. Paul, he wondered how he could dig the grave, then two lions entered the cave, bowed their heads before the body

of St. Paul, and shook their heads as if they were asking St. Anthony what to do. St. Antony knew that they were sent from God. He marked the place on the ground and they dug the grave with their claws; according to St. Antony's directions. St. Anthony then buried the holy body.

St. Anthony carried the garment of palm tree fibers and presented it to Pope Athanasius who greatly exulted to have it, and kept wearing it every year in the feasts of Christmas, Theophany, and Resurrection. Many signs were shown by that garment.

In the location where St. Paul the First Hermit used to live, a monastery was built where earthly angels dedicated all their lives to that of joyful praise for the Lord.

PAUL, THE MONK

About Abba Ur (Hur), we know that he had a disciple by the name of Paul (Boulus) who cared much for the life of prayers, even though he misunderstood its meaning. He considered his prayers as a race to recite the greatest number of church praises. He was eventually corrected by St. Macarius.

About him it was said:

He did not approach the hard handworks or the assignments of selling and buying; except for the little things he eats every day. However, he was very advanced in one thing, which was praying without ceasing. He set for himself a rule; to pray 300 prayers every day. He used to put some little pebbles in his pocket, and then he used to hold in his hand one of them for every prayer he prayed. One day, he came to St. Macarius, saying: "Father, I am very sad." When the elder monk asked him the reason for his anguish, he answered: "I heard about a virgin who spent thirty years of her monastic life, reciting 500 prayers every day. On hearing that, I despised myself, for I am not able to pray more than 300 prayers every day."

Here, St. Abba Macarius told him: "I lived for sixty years in the monastic life, reciting only fifty prayers every day; worked for what was enough to earn my need of food; and received the brethren who come to seek my counsel. Now, here you are who pray 300 prayers every day, condemned by your thoughts. You probably, either do not pray them with purity; or you can do more of other things and you do not want to."

[The Diocese of Beni-Suef: The Garden of Monks; pp. 24-25]

[Budge: The Paradise, vol. 2, art. 356]

PAUL, THE MONK

One of the desert fathers told this story about a monk by the name of Paul (Boulus) from somewhere in Lower Egypt and he lived in Thebes:

He used to hold a serpent by his bare hands and split it into two. Some of the brethren made metanoia before him, and said: "Tell us brother; what did you do that made you qualified for such a marvelous grace?" He answered them: "Forgive me, fathers. Once the man acquires purity, everything would submit to him and obey him. Like the way, Adam was in Paradise before he disobeyed the Divine commandment."

[Light Publications: Sayings of the Elder Fathers, 1983, p. 258 (Arabic)]

[Benedicta Ward: The Sayings of the Desert Fathers]

PAUL, THE SIMPLE, ST.

This saint was a marvelous example of a simple man, who by the grace of God, could strive to reach a high ascetic level, even though he started it at his 60th years of age. This St. Paul (Boulus) was a very simple and pious farmer who got married to a very beautiful girl. After living together for so many years, he started to take notice of so many rumors about his wife's evil behavior. However, whenever he inquired from her about the matter, she would pretend to be a pure woman. Eventually, by himself, he saw her in the evil act. On that day, he forsook the house to her and set forth to Abba Anthony the Great, hoping to become one of his disciples.

Getting to know that this simple farmer was sixty years old, Abba Anthony advised him to go back to his field and plow; on account of that it would be difficult for him to practice the monastic life at his age. Before his persistence, he sought from him to join a monastery in the valley to practice with the brethren what suit his old age; but the old man persisted on not leaving that mountain.

Here, Abba Anthony had no other choice but to put him under tough tests; and was amazed by his endurance, perseverance, and obedience. Among those tests that he left him four days without food or drink while watching him lest he would collapse. He sought from him to remain a whole week outside his cave, under the heat of noon and the severe cold nights, without leaving his place; and sought from him, after weaving eight meters of a cord, to loosen it and weave it anew. In all that he was obedient, worked with joy and extreme simplicity.

On seeing his persistence with the spirit of piety, Abba Anthony accepted him as a recluse and sought from him to build for himself a cell on the way between the base of the mountain and his own cell.

The Gifts of Driving Out Evil Spirits and Telling the Unknown:

Because of his inner simplicity, which was filled with wisdom, along with his unceasing ascetic strife; God granted him the grace to drive the evil spirits out. For his strong love for the salvation of every soul, he was granted the grace of knowing the thoughts of the monks. It so happened that, when he descended to a monastery in the valley, he watched how the monks entered into the church with their enlightened faces, accompanied by their guardian angels. However, among them, he saw a monk with a horrible countenance, drawn with a chain by a group of demons and his very sad guardian angel following him from afar. On seeing that, St. Paul started to weep bitterly, beating his chest, while sitting at the door of the church. Seeing him doing that, every monk feared that the saint was weeping on his particular sin; for all knew how he could read their minds. At the end of the Holy Liturgy, the saint saw the monk concerned with his countenance completely changed; his face enlightened, his guardian angel exultant and the demons leaving his side. The saint, exultantly told the monks what he saw; and the monk came forward and publicly confessed that he lived in adultery a long time; but, when in the Holy Liturgy he heard the words of God on the tongue of the prophet Isaiah, concerning the holy life (Is. 1:16-19), he presented true repentance, counting what he heard as being personally addressed to him. All who heard that confession glorified God for the riches of His love and His mercy on the sinners.

In the biography of Tayees, the fallen woman who repented on the hands of St. Bessarion; God has revealed to St. Paul the Simple that this particular sinner had gained a high spiritual ranking after her repentance.

PAUL, THE SYRIAN, ST. (The martyr)

This saint was born in Alexandria to a merchant Syrian family. The family moved to El-Ashmonein area, where they got very prosperous. His father left Paul (Boulus) with a huge inheritance after he passed away. However, on hearing about the sufferings of the Christians, Paul longed to have a chance to receive the crown of martyrdom. He distributed his inheritance to the poor and sought the counsel of God. God sent to him the Archangel Suriel to tell him what sufferings would be dwelling upon him and to confirm that the Lord would be always with him to strengthen him. The saint instantly headed to the governor of Anesna and confessed the Lord Jesus Christ before him. Seduced by several promises, Paul told him about the riches from his

father's huge inheritance.

By orders from the governor, he was stripped from his clothes, whipped, and had flames placed on his sides. They put iron tools in his mouth and ears; cut his tongue off and set poisonous serpents upon him, but God sent His Archangel Suriel to comfort, support, and heal him. The governor then sent him to Alexandria; and in the prison there, he met with his friend 'Isy' (Baisy) and his sister Tekla. The three of them were exulted in spirit. The Lord Jesus Christ appeared to proclaim that the three saints would testify to His Name and their bodies, as well as their souls, would stay together.

The head of St. Paul was cut off on the seashore, where some believers came, shrouded his body and kept his relics with them.

The church celebrates his martyrdom on the 9th of Amshir.

PAULA, THE ELDER, ST.

St. Paula is considered the most famous Roman woman as far as her piety and dedication to the Lord are concerned. Besides, she had vast wealth, honor, and sharpness of mind. She was born on the 15th of May 347 AD to a very rich family among the Roman elites. Her man Toxotius passed away when she was only thirty-two years old and a mother to a son and four daughters:

- 1- The son was named Toxotius, after his father's name.
- 2- The oldest daughter was named Blesilla, after her maternal grandmother. She passed away three months after she completely changed her worldly lifestyle and lived in repentance. St. Jerome wrote a condolence letter to her mother, to assure her that she has gone to Paradise.
- 3- The second daughter was Paulina, the wife of Pammachius. After his young wife Paulina passed away, he distributed most of the possessions he inherited on the poor and he pursued an ascetic life, even though he was one of the elites.
- 4- The third daughter was Eustochium, who accompanied her mother all the way on a very tough ascetic road that angered her relatives. When her mother passed away in Bethlehem; she was on the brink of collapse. However, St. Jerome came to her support and exhorted her to complete the mission of her mother.
- 5- The fourth daughter was Rufina, who passed away in her youth in 386.

Her Widowhood:

St. Paula lived with her husband an ideal family life, to become a role model in Rome for the virtuous matrimony in the Lord. The man she dearly loved passed away, when she was only thirty-two years old. She was so

overwhelmed with grief and was recovered by her friend St. Marcella, the widow who taught Rome by her repentance and despising of the world. God opened Paula's inner eyes to dedicate her life to Him in a firm monastic way of life. Her food became very simple, drank no wine, and slept not on a bed but on a mat on the floor. She abandoned arranging fun parties and all kinds of temporal pleasures and put all her capabilities in the service of the needy. She forsook all the worldly activities to focus her mind on the Lord and His Heavenly Kingdom.

St. Jerome said about Paula, at the beginning of his condolence letter to her daughter Eustochium:

If all my body members turned into tongues and if all my limbs uttered in a human voice, I would not be able to cover the virtues of that honorable Saint Paula. She was noble for her family status, but more so for her holiness. She was rich with the goods of this world but came to be distinguished with the poverty she chose for the sake of Christ. She preferred Bethlehem to Rome; forsook her splendid palace, covered with gold, to dwell in a cell made of mud. We should not grieve as though we have lost her, but we should rather thank God that we have not really lost her because she is still with us; *"For all live to Him"* (Luke 20:38). Those who return to God are still counted as part of His household. Yes, we may indeed think we have lost her, but the Heavenly dwellings have acquired her.

Her Friendship with St. Jerome:

Her name was tied up to St. Jerome and St. Jeromes' name was also tied up with hers through his fatherly friendship which was full of kindness as well as seriousness. He got to know her through St. Epiphanius, the bishop of Salamis and St. Paulinus, the bishop of Antioch, to whom she gave hospitality in her palace. Through them, she got acquainted with St. Jerome, who drew her to serve God when he was residing in Rome.

In doing that, St. Paula faced strong opposition from her family, especially because her daughter Eustochium has followed her steps and forsook all her relationships with the world to practice the ascetic life. This made the rest of her family uncomfortable, worrying about their future as elites. Yet, Paula stuck to her daughter and practiced that kind of holy life without the least of hesitation.

St. Paula passed through many trials that pressed upon her tender soul, that she was on the brink of collapse. However, with St. Jeromes' support, her trials turned her energies into the dedication and setting forth toward a better life. Among these trials was the sudden death of her oldest daughter Blesilla, the death of her other daughter Paulina, the wife of Pammachius while still young, and also Rufina; which left her only with Eustochom, out of her four

daughters.

Paula's heart was day by day inflamed with the longing to the Heavenly life; while the atmosphere in Rome was suffocating for her because of the fame of her noble family and the criticism she got from her family elders, so she planned to leave Rome and go somewhere else to worship God in tranquility and peace away from her family and her old friends.

In the year 385 AD, she sailed along with her daughter Eustochium to Cyprus. There, they visited St. Epiphanius, the bishop of Salamis, and from there, they sailed to Antioch, where they met with St. Jerome. Then all of them set forth to the Holy places in Palestine, and from there, they went to Egypt to see some of its desert monks and hermits.

In Egypt:

St. Paula accompanied St. Jerome on his trip to Egypt and was most probably with him when he met with St. Didymus the Blind, the dean of the School of Alexandria. She studied at his school for one month; then set forth together with St. Jerome to the wilderness of Nitria. In Nitria, they stayed a long time. St. Jerome described the effect of that period on the life of that saintly widow, he said that she was excited and joyful to see these saints and longed to imitate their lives. The fathers received her with joy, for which she glorified God and felt unworthy of such an honor. She met with the two Macariuses, St. Serapion and others. She visited them in their cells, prostrated herself at their feet, feeling that the Lord Jesus Christ was in every one of them. She tolerated the harsh traveling between the cells and spent the nights in the open wilderness with joy and enthusiasm beyond the endurance of any woman. She forgot her fatigue and all her needs because of her spiritual joy.

In Bethlehem:

In the next year, she set forth to Jerusalem to live in Bethlehem. There, she built a guest-house to give hospitality to strangers, a monastery for monks and a convent for the nuns.

In the convent, she lived along with her daughter Eustochum a serious monastic life, and according to the convent's rules, all practiced the work of the hand, particularly sewing for the nuns or those outside.

Paula lived among the nuns as a mother who drew them with her love, tenderness and she was their role model. Even though she and her daughter partook of ministry and work, yet she was firm. If, for instance, she noticed a nun talk too much or showing anger; she would ask her to separate herself from the congregation, to pray outside, and to eat her meals alone for a certain period.

She cared for the poor, as well as for building churches. However, she made sure that the churches would not be luxurious in their structure or furniture, but modest; preferring to spend the money on the poor, being living members of the Lord Jesus Christ.

She helped St. Jerome in his studies and translations; having studied the Greek language from her father, the Latin language in Rome, and the Hebrew language on her own; to sing the psalms in their original languages. She also took part with her mentor St. Jerome in his sharp debate with John the bishop of Jerusalem concerning the Origenism.

Raising her Granddaughter Paula the Younger:

At the time when St. Paula left Rome, she was moaning in her heart for the tears of her son Toxotius, who pleaded with her to stay with them there. However, her desire for a life of seclusion surpassed those tears; despite her tenderness and her love for her son. Eventually, her son got married to a Christian girl named Laeta, a daughter of a pagan priest, and she lived with her man imitating Paula in a pious life of faith. Giving birth to a girl, she gave her the name of 'Paula the Younger', because of her love for her mother-in-law. St. Jerome wrote to her a marvelous letter concerning how to raise her little daughter, which carried living concepts of progressive educational thoughts.¹ Eventually, Laeta sent her little daughter to Bethlehem to be raised by her grandmother St. Paula. Eventually, Paula the Younger was given the leadership of a group of nuns, like her grandmother.

Her Departure in the Lord:

On reaching the age of fifty-six years, St. Paula the Elder was called by the Lord Jesus Christ to move from the labors of this world to Paradise, after a short encounter with sickness. During her illness, she did not cease to recite the Psalms, longing to encounter God and to enjoy the Heavenly life. When she became too weak to utter the words, she used to make the sign of the Cross on her lips, until she reposed on the 26th of January, 404 AD, among the tears of her daughter Eustochum.

PAULINUS, BISHOP OF NOLA, ST.

Many of the saintly fathers, like St. Ambrose, St. Jerome, and St. Augustine, commended St. Paulinus, the bishop of Nola (near Naples in Italy). He was born in the city of Bordeaux in France around the year 352 AD. His father Pontius Paulinus was a judge and a prefect in France. St.

¹ Fr. Tadros Y. Malaty translated a part of this letter of St. 'Jerome' in his work: 'The Brotherly Love'...

Paulinus was a kinsman of St. Melania the Elder. He became a disciple of a famous poet named Ausonius and he learned how to be himself a poet and an eloquent public speaker. He was married to Tharasias, a virtuous and a rich Spanish lady. Emperor Valentinian I (364-375 AD) liked him for his prudence and honor, that he appointed him as a prefect on Rome, where he spent fifteen years occupied with various material matters. His position as a prefect and his marriage to a Spanish wife made him a frequent traveler to Spain. In his travel to France and Italy, he happened to meet with St. Ambrose in Milan, who very much revered him, and in a visit to Nola, the city of St. Felix the martyr; he was quite impressed by the frequent miracles that kept happening at the tomb of St. Felix that he decided to dedicate his whole life to the Christian Faith, so he got baptized at the age of thirty-eight years on the hands of the bishop of Bordeaux.

After having the Baptism, he longed to a life of seclusion and he kept practicing the prayers and fasting very seriously. However, because he had many friends and was quite famous, he could not enjoy his seclusion, so he decided to travel to Barcelona in Spain, where his wife owned a lot of lands. There, his barren wife conceived and gave birth to a boy who passed away eight days only after his birth. Feeling that it was not God's will for them to have seed; they decided to live like a brother and sister.

Ordaining Him as a Priest:

As their spiritual life shone in Barcelona, the congregation along with the clergy committed him to receive priesthood on the hands of bishop Lampius. The saint stayed there for four years, during which they sold all their possessions and distributed the proceeds on the poor and the needy. Then, they returned to Milan, to be received with a great welcome by St. Ambrose, who committed him to stay with him for a while.

After the repose of St. Ambrose, St. Paulinus left to Rome, where he was received by its bishop Pope Siricius (384-399 AD) and the clergy with an icy reception because of his known strong friendship with St. Ambrose, who was considered as a competitor to the pope.

Finding the atmosphere not suitable for him, St. Paulinus had to leave Rome with his wife Tharasias to Nola, where each of them lived separately in a life of seclusion. However, a multitude of people among the elites got drawn to the saint and started to practice a life of seclusion and a firm ascetic life under his guidance.

Ordaining Him as a Bishop:

When the bishop of Nola reposed, St. Paulinus was forced by the congregation to accept being ordained as a bishop in his place in the year 409

AD, so he led his people with compassionate fatherhood in a spirit of humility and giving, and he was in a close connection with so many of the famous fathers of his time.

Then, he reposed in the Lord around the year 431 AD, after leaving a huge inheritance of Christian spiritual poetry, particularly concerning St. Felix.

The west celebrates him on the 22nd of July.

[Baring-Gould: Lives of Saints, June 22]

PAULINUS, BISHOP OF TREVES, ST.

St. Athanasius the Apostolic, the 20th Pope of Alexandria (328-373 AD), so loved this St. Paulinus because of his strife for the sake of the Orthodox faith, to call him 'The Truly Apostolic Man.' St. Jerome also described him as the man who was Happy in his Sufferings.

This St. Paulinus was the disciple of St. Maximinus, the bishop, and succeeded him on the throne of Treves (Trier) in 349 AD. When St. Athanasius was exiled, St. Paulinus was his leading supporter in his exile. In the council of Arles in the year 353 AD, St. Paulinus stood up to defend St. Athanasius and the Nicene Faith. He did that despite all the pressures and the seductions Emperor Constantius II (337-361) used in corrupting the consciences of the attending bishops to lure them into condemning Pope Athanasius. It was expressed nicely by St. Hilary, the bishop of Poitiers when he said: "We oppose Constantius II, the enemy of Christ, who flirts with the bellies before whipping the backs." The price of the opposition of bishop Paulinus towards the Arianism and his standing by Pope Athanasius in his defense of the Truth; was to be exiled from his throne. He was expelled along with some other bishops like Dionysius bishop of Milan, Lucifer bishop of Cagliari, and Eusebius bishop of Vercellae. St. Paulinus received with joy his exile to Phrygia, where there were no Christians there, and he endured his suffering until he reposed on the 31st of August 360 AD. In the year 396 AD, St. Felix, bishop of Treves brought the saint's remains to his diocese; and in the year 402 AD, a church was established in his name.

[Baring-Goulds Lives of the Saints, Aug. 31]

PELAGIA OF ANTIOCH (The martyr)

Many female saints carried the name Pelagia, among them, were:

- 1- The West celebrates st. Pelagia, the "Virgin Martyr," who was from Antioch, and her feast on the 9th of July.
- 2- St. Pelagia, the "Virgin Martyr," who was from Tarsus, and her feast

celebrated by the West on the 4th of May.

- 3- St. Pelagia, the “Penitent Hermit,” who repented on the hands of St. Nonnus, the bishop of Edessa (El-Ruha), and who dressed herself as a monk in the Mount of Olives.
- 4- Pelagia of Antioch: This saint was commended by St. Ambrose and St. John Chrysostom, who gave more than one sermon about her. She was believed to be a disciple of St. Lucian of Antioch.

When she was only a 15 years old girl, it happened once that her house was surrounded by soldiers who intended to rape her. On realizing how she was facing the certain danger of losing her chastity, it seems that she cried out within herself, and according to St. John Chrysostom, God inspired her to ask permission from the soldiers to get appropriately dressed. Then, she set forth to the roof of her house and threw herself down and died. She did that while exultant for God has saved her from their corruption. She reposed on the 9th of June around the year 311 AD.

Our Faith does not allow for suicide in any manner, but taking into consideration the very hard situation in which this young girl was; we may assume that God probably inspired her to do such a thing and that her suicide was not the result of a nervous breakdown, but was with joy and gladness in her mind for being saved from the danger of losing her chastity.

[Alban Butler, *The Lives of the Saints*, vol. X, Oct. 8, note#4]

PELAGIA OF TARSUS (The martyr)

Saint Pelagia was a charming girl, she was from Tarsus of pagan parents, but was raised on the hands of a Christian governess during the reign of Emperor Diocletian (284-305 AD). When one of the elites came to marry her (some say he was a son of the emperor), she sought from her parents to allow her to visit her old educator before she would get busy with her marriage. When she met her educator, she proclaimed to her that she was impressed by the behavior of the Christians in their torture and martyrdom; and asked her to be guided to the truth. The educator proclaimed to her the secrets of faith, and when she saw how her heart was inflamed by the love for the Savior, she told bishop Clino about her, and he baptized her and gave her the Holy Sacraments.

The girl returned to her family to proclaim her new faith in the Lord Christ and to refuse totally to be married. On hearing this, her would-be fiancée committed suicide. Her mother got very angry about her behavior, and she hated her daughter so much to report her to the emperor. She was hoping that

he would chastise her and bring her back to reason, even by cruelty and violence. The emperor called on her, but seeing how beautiful she was, instead of punishing her, his heart was inflamed with lust and longed to marry her, but as her soul was bound by love of the Celestials and by rejecting all riches and sexual desires; she refused to marry him and proclaimed her faith before him.

The emperor's love turned into strong hate and a desire to humiliate her; for he considered her rejection as an insult; and her testimony to the Lord Christ as a personal hostility towards him. So, he ordered that she would be enclosed inside the bronze bull over a fire until her body would burn, and then to cast her overcooked remains before the lions to be devoured, but he was shocked to see that the lions have reformed their wild nature and stood as guards around her remains; to declare that the falling humanity was so much crueler than the wild animals. The bishop then came to take her holy body and bury it with great honor in a mountain close to the city.

[Baring-Gould: The Lives of the Saints, May 4]

PELAGIA, THE PENITENT HERMIT, ST.

This St. Pelagia was called the Third Magdalene, after St. Mary the Egyptian, who was named the Second Magdalene. That woman turned from the life of evil and pollution to that of pious monastic life by an exalted Divine power. She is celebrated by the Church on the 8th of October (she reposed around the year 460 AD).

It is difficult to describe the role this Pelagia has played while living in Antioch during the 5th century. Since she was only occupied by hunting men to lure them into practicing evil with her and then throw their wealth under her feet, she used to tour the streets of the city, riding on a white horse, clothed in indecent attire that exposed her beautiful form and showing off her body adorned with precious jewelry.

The whole city was talking about that woman who destroyed the souls of multitudes of men, including even some Christians. So, the patriarch of Antioch consulted his bishops in a meeting about that matter. Bishop Nonnus of Edessa (El- Ruha) said in the meeting, "I am happy to have this woman here in my city since the Lord has sent her to us to teach us a lesson. While she exerts all her energy to keep her beauty and to please the people to practice the evil with her; we are less eager than she in caring for our dioceses and the souls of our people." At night, when bishop Nonnus entered his bedroom, his soul was so embittered because of that woman who was used by the enemy to seduce so many. He intensely wept, beseeching God to

liberate her from this captivity and to grant her salvation. In a night vision, he saw himself ministering the Holy Liturgy of the Divine Eucharist when he got disturbed by an ugly bird that kept flying around the altar, and when the deacon sent the catechumen out, before the start of the “Liturgy of the Believers,” that bird also left, but it went to the baptismal room at the entrance of the church. There, that ugly bird plunged into the water to come out a beautiful bird as white as snow, which set forth toward heaven and disappeared. In the morning, which was a Sunday, the father bishop stood up to give a sermon on the awesome final judgment. Pelagia happened to be present, even though she was not among the catechumen, and she felt as though God was rebuking her in a personal message through that sermon. She started to weep bitterly, and once the Liturgy came to an end, she set forth toward the bishop, prostrated herself before him, and sought his prayer on her behalf.

Her Baptism:

When they all saw the truth of her repentance, the patriarch of Antioch, delivered her to the care of a deaconess by the name of Romana, to care spiritually for her. Later on, she received the Sacrament of baptism, and she remained clothed in her white attire for a whole week as it was the custom in the early Church. St. Pelagia's tears of repentance were mixed with her deep inner joy for the riches of God's mercies. Even her deaconess got so attached to her, despite the short time of their acquaintance.

Setting Forth to Jerusalem:

On the eighth day following her baptism, she gathered all her possessions and threw them at the feet of bishop Nonnus to distribute on the poor. Then, she changed her white attire to sackcloth, clothed herself as a man, changed her name to Pelagius, and set forth to Jerusalem. There she lived in a cave on the Mount of Olives to practice a life of seclusion, where she drew many souls to God by both her prayers and her silence.

No one discovered her secret, but all knew her virtues as a recluse hermit, who reposed after three or four years, and being a woman was only discovered when they started to shroud her. Getting to know about her repose, bishop Nonnus proclaimed her biography and her interaction with him in the process of her repentance. During that time, she called herself the Sea of Evil, the Pit of Defilement, and the Jewel of Satan and his weapon.

[Helen Waddell: *The Desert Fathers*, 1977, pp. 173-188]

PELAGIUS, THE HERETIC

Pelagius (354-420 AD) was a British monk who preached in Rome between the years 400 and 410 AD. He proclaimed that the original sin of Adam was not inherited, and it did not taint human nature. So, he believed that the infants were born sinless, and they were being baptized not for the forgiveness of sin, but to enjoy the fellowship in Christ and to enter the Kingdom of Heaven. He also claimed that man would be able to have salvation through his effort, without the need for God's grace, and that God's grace would not be needed for the enlightenment of the mind.

However, many Church Fathers rose to dispute Pelagius doctrines and to confirm the need for the forgiveness of the “Original Sin” and stressed on the role of the Divine Grace, without disregarding the free human will.

PELEUS, THE BISHOP (The martyr)

St. Peleus was an Egyptian martyr who lived in Palestine. As the Church was comforted a little from persecution, some confessors built churches in Palestine. The governor of Palestine sent to emperor Galerius (305-311 AD), informing him about the freedom enjoyed by those Christian confessors. Then, he was instructed by the tyrant to lead them to the mines of Cyprus, Lebanon, or any place else. The governor of Palestine started his persecution by burning four of the Christian leaders after they spent a period of forced labor in the bronze mines. Those four martyrs were: Two Egyptian bishops St. Peleus and St. Nilus, the priest Elijah and a layman Paternuthius. They most probably were martyred in Phunun near Petra, at the same location where Tyrammio bishop of Gaza and his companions were martyred.

St. Peleus was martyred on the 19th of September, 310 AD.

[Eusebius: H.E. 13, Martyrs of Palestine ch. 13]

PELOSIANUS, ST.

This saint was a friend of Abba Anthony the Great (251-356 AD). He took part in burying Abba Anthony along with his fellow monk Isaac. It seems that St. Jerome (342-420 AD), who told us about him, has met him somewhere.

[Jerome: Vita Hilarionis, 30; 31]

PENOPHIUS, THE PRIEST, ABBA

St. Penophius was one of the saints of the 4th century AD. He became a

monk in a monastery in the city of Anepho (Panepho/Panephris). This large city was completely devastated, along with all the villages around it by a violent earthquake. The whole area turned into a muddy land and was deserted by its inhabitants. The area became only suitable for the dwelling of hermits, and its current location nowadays is the lake of Burullus.

St. Penophius was raised there among a congregation of hermits. He grew in the spiritual knowledge and the life of worship and asceticism, to become the object of love by all, and from him, the sweet fragrance of Christ emanated.

His Management Work:

Being so beloved by the monks, he was ordained a priest despite his strong reluctance at first. He became the abbot of a monastery with hundreds of monks. He was a living example of the sound and humble Fatherhood. He used to flee away from the temporal honors which persisted on chasing him. When he felt the danger overcoming him, he thought seriously about escaping from the monastery in disguise.

Escaping to Tabanseen Monastery:

Then, priest Penophius fled in disguise to the monastery of Tabanseen near the city of Qena on the Nile river opposite to Dandera. There, he longed to live under ordinance, obedience, and submission; instead of being an abbot of the monastery. When he approached the monastery's abbot to admit him, the abbot advised him to return to the world, for it would be difficult for him to start a monastic life at his advanced age. However, Penophius remained standing at the gate seeking with tears to be admitted, even as a servant and not as a monk. Under his steady persistence, they accepted him under probation. He was given work as an assistant to a young monk in the garden of the monastery. Pretending to be untrained to do a regular job, the young monk treated him very strictly. However, the elder Panophius, rejoicing in the spirit, respectfully listened to his instructions and acted as an obedient disciple; until that young monk eventually came to admire and love him. He used during the nights to do the sanitary jobs secretly in the monastery, which was disliked by the rest of the monks. As to his life of worship, he used to practice it in hiding with intense asceticism, and when he entered the church, he used to stand in the last row and listen with contrition without uttering a word.

Discovering His Identity:

After three years of practicing such a tranquil life away from the attention, it happened that a monk from the monastery of Burullus, where St.

Panophius was once the abbot, came to visit this monastery. That monk was shocked to see the elderly father carry the manure and placing it around the trees. Recognizing him, he threw himself at his feet, seeking his blessing. He revealed his identity to the other monks, proclaiming that he is Fr. Panophius, the abbot of the monastery at Burullus, the man who was known for his great deeds and exalted fame.

Amid the astonishment of the monks, the father bitterly cried for having his identity revealed, and a delegation accompanied him with great honor, to return him to his monks. His disciples received him with great joy; since they initially thought that he would be gone for just a short period to worship in seclusion, which turned out to be such a long time. When they got to know what he did, they honored him even more and benefited from his example of humility and escaping from the vainglory. However, he kept weeping for being deprived of the work he loved away from attention.

His Escape to Bethlehem:

Not enduring such increased honor, the saint thought of escaping abroad out of Egypt. By night, he crawled out and set forth to a monastery in Bethlehem, where he sought to be a monk under probation. Under his steady persistence, they admitted him as a servant, and God allowed him to work in the cell occupied by St. John Cassian (360-435 AD), who wrote us his biography and sayings. Coming to see in him such tenderness and holiness, St. John Cassian liked him very much, without knowing anything else about him, and a strong spiritual relationship grew in-between them. Then, after some time, it happened that a monk from the monastery of Burullus came to visit, and the same scenario repeated itself. His identity was revealed, and he returned to his monastery with great honor, while his tears never dried up.

Cassian Visits Him:

As St. John Cassian came to Egypt along with his friend Germanus, he went to his close friend Fr. Penophius. He kissed him, stayed for a while in his cell, which was at the far end of the garden. They spent a tremendous spiritual time together praising and glorifying God.

Of His Sayings:

- + Several are the ways by which we may get the forgiveness of our sins; so that no one longing to the salvation of his soul may despair.
- + Sometimes it happens, even by way of compassion that we find pleasure in thinking of the falls and sins of the others, by which we may fall into their same faults.
- + When you get to remember your past sins, flee away from them right away;

in the same way, a righteous man would flee when he encounters an evil harlot on the wayside who is seeking to seduce him.

PIUS I, POPE OF ROME

Saint Pius I (140-155 AD) succeeded St. Hyginus (136-140 AD) on the See of Rome. He was formerly a citizen of Aquileia in Italy and said to be the brother of Hermas author of the book *The Shepherd* in the 2nd century AD.

He was ordained as a bishop around the year 140 AD. He cared to oppose the heresies faced by the Roman Church in his time, by the followers of Valentinus and Marcion. The first Valentinus, originally from Egypt, and he dwelt in Rome between the years 136 and 165 AD, hoping to be ordained as a bishop. His book carried a lot of Gnostic thoughts. While the second Marcion, was considered one of the most influential Gnostics personalities.

Pope Pius I cared so much to commit the priests to practice the Holy Sacraments with great caution and elaboration. So, he issued a creed that says: “A priest who spills the chalice after the sanctification, has to remain in a condition of repentance for 40 days, and if he spills a drop of it, he has to remain in a condition of repentance for three days; along with wiping the place of a spill with towels and burning them.” He also cared to increase the number of ministers serving the Kingdom of God, so he ordained 12 bishops and 18 priests. He was said to be martyred on the 11th of June in the year 155 AD, even though some scholars in the West, believe that he reposed without having his bloodshed.

[Butler’s: *Lives of Saints*; July 11]

PERGENTINUS (The martyr)

This saint was one of those who enjoyed the crown of martyrdom in the days of Emperor Decius (249-251 AD) in the city of Arezzo in the region of Umbria. St. Pergentinus and his brother Laurentinus were of a noble family; they were arrested while still young students, brought before the governor Tibertius and charged of being Christians. He set them free, probably for the sake of their noble origin or for their young age; counting the mild chastisement was enough to make them stop practicing their worship and to live in fear and terror. However, once they found themselves free, they set forth to practice their Christian worship publicly, and with greater zeal, they even began to preach among the pagans. God granted them the grace to perform miracles, that drew many people to the Christian faith. The governor put them again under arrest, then gave the order to cut their heads off, to

receive the crown of martyrdom on the 3rd of June 251 AD.

[Butler's Lives of Saints, June 3]

PERPETUA (The martyr)

The biographies of St. Perpetua, St. Felicity and their companions had great importance in the early Church. In the 4th century AD, their stories were read regularly in the Churches of North-West Africa. St. Augustine often warned them about that, fearing that the believers might mix between those biographies and what they hear from the Holy Bible, even though he often talked about those martyrs, urging the people on the spiritual strife.

Putting her Under Arrest:

In the year 203, during the persecution which took place in the reign of Emperor Severus (193-211 AD); Menosius, governor of North Africa arrested five believers who were all catechumens (*Christians being instructed in the faith but not yet baptized*): Revocatus, Felicity who was five-month pregnant, Saturinus, Secundulus and Vibia Perpetua. Perpetua was a noblewoman, 22 years old at that time, daughter of a nobleman, married to a rich man, with a suckling baby, and had two brothers. After those five catechumens were arrested, a man by the name of Saturus followed them; probably, he was their teacher and instructor. He came forward voluntarily to be imprisoned along with them, to support them in the middle of their sufferings.

It was said that Perpetua's husband was a Christian in secret, but before the wave of persecution, he went into hiding. When the five catechumens were put under arrest in a house in the city, Perpetua's father came to try bringing his daughter back to idol-worship. He worked every way possible, including bitterly weeping to soften her heart, but she confirmed to him that she would never deny her Christ no matter the price she had to pay. Then, her father scolded against her, struck her hard, and left very angry. Shortly afterward, the five catechumens gained the Sacrament of baptism.

According to Perpetua's account, she was moved after a few days along with her companions to the jail of indescribable darkness, a disgusting smell, with very cruel jailers. They denied her the care for her suckling. Suffering much for that, two blessed deacons by the names of Tertius and Pomponius bribed the jailers to allow the prisoners to have a period of rest during the day and to let Perpetua feed her suckling who grew very weak because of hunger. She arranged with her brother to take care of her baby and asked him not to worry about her. However, when she eventually was allowed to have the suckling with her, she exulted and saw the jail as though it was a palace with

all the comfort.

Her Vision in Jail:

Her brother came to visit her, and said that she was living in glory, that she was dear to God because of enduring suffering for His sake; and he sought from her to pray to God to show her if it ends up by martyrdom. With great trust, she asked her brother to come back the next day to tell him what the Lord would have revealed to her. In a night vision, she saw a narrow golden ladder, wide enough for one person to climb. On its both sides, there were all kinds of sharp knives, swords, and iron claws that could cause severe injuries to whoever would not look up, and at the bottom of the ladder, there was a vast dragon ready to devour whoever would fall while climbing the ladder. Saturus climbed first, and reached the top of the ladder, then said to her: "Perpetua, I am waiting for you, but beware of the dragon, lest it would devour you." The saint answered: "By the name of Jesus Christ, it will not harm me." Then, she approached the ladder to find out that the dragon has slightly lifted its head in fear and terror. Putting one foot on the golden ladder and the other foot on the head of the dragon, Perpetua was able to climb to the top of the ladder. She found herself as though in a vast endless garden, in the middle of which sat a very great man with white hair, clothed in an attire of a shepherd milking his flock, and surrounded by several thousand of people with white attires. The man lifted his head, looked at her, and said: "Welcome daughter," and called her to give her cheese made from the milk. She took it and ate it, and all those around them said: Amen! At that point, Perpetua woke up to find herself as though eating sweet food. She told her brother what she saw, and they both were sure that it would end up in martyrdom.

Her Trial:

On hearing that her trial was imminent, her father came to see her cry again to soften her heart; but she confirmed to him yet that she will never deny her Christ. The next day, all of them were called to a public trial before the new governor Hilarion, who succeeded the previous governor who died. Perpetua was called first, to find her father carrying her suckling, in a further attempt to advise her to deny her faith for the sake of her child. Trying to get too close to his daughter, the governor had him expelled out; and seeing how the soldiers beat him, Perpetua was greatly grieved. When the governor found them all holding fast to their faith, he condemned them all to be cast before the hungry wild beasts, which made the saints very exultant.

Their Martyrdom:

Felicity was sorrowful because the Roman law prevented her execution until she would give birth to her baby, which resulted in denying her to be martyred along with her companions. All of them prayed for her sake, and on the same night, the Lord responded by letting her have labor. When the jailer saw how she suffered, he said to her: “If you cannot endure the pain of giving natural birth, how could you endure the fangs and claws of the wild beasts?” The saint answered him, saying: “Today, I am the one who is suffering, but tomorrow it will be Christ who will suffer for me. Today it is the power of nature against me, but tomorrow it will be the grace of God that will grant me the conquest on whatever torture is prepared for me.”

The fixed date came, and all were led to the arena, as though to a wedding ceremony, with the Divine joy filling their hearts. It happened that when a wild ox lifted Perpetua by its sharp horns and threw her on the ground tearing her dress in the process. She took hold of her robe to cover her body before she was lifted again and again. As for Felicity, she fainted then was awakened as having seen a Heavenly vision. Then, the soldiers came and killed the martyrs who were still alive, and they had a lasting comfort in Heavens; in the year 203 AD (on the 7th of March, according to the Western Synaxarion).

[H. Musurillo: *The Acts of the Christian Martyrs*, Oxford 1972, pp. 106–132]

PETARPEMTIS, THE BLESSED

St. Jerome gave the following account about the blessed saint Petarpemtis whom he met in the wilderness of Thebes on the eastern side of the Nile in Egypt. St. Petarpemtis was the first monk in this region and became the head of the community of monks there. He was previously a thief, a robber of the pagan graves, and has gotten a vast reputation in every kind of evil. Once, he jumped on top of the house roof of a pious woman who lived a pure life in the Lord, and when he tried very hard to come down from the ceiling, he failed because it was dark and the roof was very smooth and had no openings or pipes to climb down on. As it was late at night, he decided to sleep over the roof until dawn, hoping to find some way to get out of there with the daylight. In his sleep, he saw an angel in the form of a man telling him: “Don’t waste your time, care, and labor in a life of theft. If you wish to change your evil to a good life, you have to commit yourself to participate in the ministry of the angels before Christ the King. So, you would get from Him power and authority.” On hearing those words from the angel, he received them with joy and felt great happiness, and the angel showed him in his dream a group of monks and sought from him to follow them.

The man woke up to find himself before that pious woman who was wondering and asking him: "What are you doing here, man? What do you want? Who are you?" He answered her: "I do not know, but I beg you to tell me where I can find a Church." She took him to the church, where he threw himself at the feet of the Fathers and asked them to convert him to a Christian and show him how to repent. He narrated the story of his life to the Fathers, and they were amazed to hear it. They started to guide him gradually and taught him the psalms.

Three days later, he left the place and set forth to the wilderness to live for five weeks eating no bread, until someone begged him to do so. For three years he kept weeping with tears, praying to God to forgive him. Then, he finally returned to the church to learn more about the Christian faith. Even though he was illiterate, he memorized the Holy Bible by heart. Amazed at what he has reached of knowledge, asceticism, and piety; the priests in the church baptized him and sought from him to stay with them, but after a week, he set forth to the inner wilderness to remain there for seven years. During that time, every Sunday, he would find a loaf of bread by his pillow to eat and to continue fasting from one Sunday to the next.

His Fatherhood and Miracles:

At the end of the seven years, St. Petarpentis returned from the wilderness bearing exalted spiritual virtues within himself, along with fantastic simplicity and strong asceticism. So, many others followed his example; mostly, they were young men.

According to St. Palladius (386-430 AD), this blessed man, whenever a Christian man would die, used to stay beside his body the whole night praying, then he would shroud him and bury him. On seeing him doing that, his disciple, longing to have the same portion, asked his mentor: "When I die, Father, will you do the same to me?" The father answered him: "I shall do this until you say Enough". After a long time the disciple passed away, and his mentor stayed beside him the whole night; then he shrouded him by himself in the Divine fear and reverence; and while everyone was watching, he said: "Have I, my son, shrouded you well, or is there anything more you want me to do?" To the astonishment of all, they heard a voice coming out of the corpse (body), saying: "You shrouded me well, Father, and fulfilled your promise to me." Those present got filled with fear and glorified God.

The saint kept on going back and forth between the wilderness and the dwelling place of his disciple, and it happened once he was going back to his disciples, and some of them were inflicted by fever; the sun was about to set, and he felt that he should not walk in the darkness; following what the Holy Bible said: "*Walk while you have the light, lest darkness overtakes you*"

(John 12:35). However, because he was in a rush to see his sick brethren; he asked the Lord to hold the sun until he would reach them; which the Lord did, and when he saw how his disciples were astonished, he said to them: “Don't you remember the Lord's words; *If you have faith as a mustard seed, you will say to this mountain, “Move from here to there, and it will move, and nothing will be impossible for you”* (Matt. 17:25).

Another time, when another one of his disciples reposed in the Lord, and he was surrounded by the brethren, the father came and kissed his (body) corpse and addressed him, saying: “Do you want, my son, to depart now to God, or you would rather remain in the body..?” Instantly the dead man replied: “It is better for me to forsake my body to be with Christ.” The blessed father then said to him: “Therefore, my son, lie in peace; and supplicate for my sake to God.” All those around were astonished and said: “This is truly a man of God.” He shrouded him and kept reading the psalms all night, then buried him.

Another time, standing before the deathbed of one of his disciples, who was known for his slothfulness and laziness, the brother kept weeping to beg the father to pray for him to be given another chance instead of the years he lost in slothfulness. Firmly, yet with love, the father rebuked him, and said: “I am ready to seek from God for your sake if you promise not to add to your sins new ones.” He fervently implored the Lord, then told the brother that God gave him three more years. The brother lived those three years in fantastic strife, and once those years came to an end, the father came to see his disciple before his departure. According to St. Palladius, this saint was not a regular man, but he came to be a chosen vessel by God whose actions amazed everybody!

In the simplicity of heart and fantastic faith, God performed countless miracles through St. Petarpemtis. According to his disciples, he walked on water. When they left him in a closed shut upper room, the angels carried him to the place he wished to reach, and he told his disciples that, in a night vision, God revealed to him the Heavenly Goodness prepared for the true monks, which no one could utter or describe. All that for the sake of his amazing faith together with the simplicity of his heart and his humility filled with love for God and men.

[St. Jerome: History of the Monks; ch. 16]

PETER I, THE 17th POPE OF ALEXANDRIA ***(The Last of the Martyrs)***

This saint was the fruit of the prayers of his mother, Sofia, the wife of a

priest called Theodosius in Alexandria. In the feast of the apostles, she sought from God to grant her a child. In a night vision, two persons in white attire appeared to her to proclaim that God would give her request. Peter was born in the following feast of the apostles. After three years, he was brought by his parents to the 16th Pope of Alexandria St. Theonas (282-301 AD) to bless him. At the age of 5, he was sent to learn religion. At the age of 7, he was ordained as a reader, and at the age of 12, he was ordained as a deacon to minister to God with a pious and humble spirit. He dedicated himself to study day and night, walked with humility, to be loved by all, and was ordained as a priest at the age of 16 years old.

It was said that he often saw the Lord Christ Himself give communion to the believers by the hands of Pope Theonas, and he was granted by God the gift of driving the evil spirits out and the gift of healing the sick. Fr. Peter knew how important to go into retreat now and then to study in the Holy Bible, and he eventually was qualified to be selected as the dean of the Theological School of Alexandria and to be called “The Prominent Teacher of Christianity.”

When Sibelius started his heresy, which claimed that God was one Hypostasis, sometimes appearing as God the Father, sometimes as God the Son and other times as the Holy Spirit; pope Thaonas sent Fr. Peter to challenge him. Sabelius at first despised him for his young age, but he was soon overcome by his wisdom and knowledge. It was said that Sabelius was eventually inflicted by a severe illness and died; his followers were scattered.

On the Throne of St. Mark the Apostle:

When Pope Thaonas was on his deathbed, he saw in a vision the Lord Christ put his heart at peace concerning His ministry. Jesus said to him: “O gardener of the spiritual garden! Have neither fear nor anxiety over the garden. Deliver it to the priest Peter to water it, and you, come to Me to have comfort with your Fathers.” When the pope told his disciple Peter about the vision, he wept deeply, perceiving the greatness of the responsibility. On the 25th of January 302 AD, the priest Peter was ordained as the 17th Pope of the See of Alexandria (302-311 AD).

The Meletian Dissension:

Pope Peter began his ministry amid the vicious wave of persecution stirred up by Emperor Diocletian (284-305 AD) and his partner Maximian (286-305 AD), but what caused him more trouble was the inner dissension created by Meletius (d. 327 AD) bishop of Lycopolis (Assiut). According to St. Athanasius, bishop Meletius was claimed to have burned incense to the idols, and when the pope started to chastise him, he rejected the chastisement. So,

the pope held a council in Alexandria and excommunicated him. Meletius resorted to violence, created a dispute with some other bishops. When the pope was put in prison as a result of false claims made against him, Meletius went to Alexandria and dared to ordain priests. However, according to St. Epiphanius, Meletius also took a very harsh stance against those who apostatized during the persecution and were trying to repent and return to their Church. Meletius refused their repentance, particularly from the priests. The pope, on the other hand, planned to leave the door open before every returning repentant soul, believing that chastisement would be enough for them. The pope preferred to lose the bishop and his followers, rather than to see those who return to God, with repentance, lose their hope. Then, when both the pope and Meletius were put in prison, they happened to ask for a curtain to be placed between them to keep them from seeing each other.

The issue of the Meletian dissension was raised before the attention of the Ecumenical Nicene Council in the year 325 AD. However, because Meletius had 28 bishops following him, the Council took a very mild stand towards him. The Council consented to let Meletius remain as a bishop within the limits of his diocese. However, the Council did not allow him to ordain other bishops or priests any longer. As for the priests he already ordained, they were to be re-confirmed and to work under the authority of the Pope of Alexandria, and when the need for a new bishop would arise, one of the bishops ordained by Meletius could be considered for re-ordination. The Council, as well, commanded that in the future, any bishop should be ordained in the presence and with the participation of at least three other bishops.

With Arius:

Another danger of the Meletian dissension was that Arius (256-336 AD), the denier of the Godhead of the Lord Christ found his chance to join forces with Meletius and his followers, not in their theological views, but rather in their stand against the Church. Pope Peter held a council in Alexandria and excommunicated Arius, who nevertheless continued to spread his teachings.

In Prison:

Pope Peter was put under arrest, whether for the sake of the appearance of his first work against paganism, which was counted by the emperor as a challenge against him; or because of a complaint presented by Socrates, a nobleman of Antioch, to the emperor. That Socrates, who was a friend of the martyr Abadir, denied his faith to gain the favor of emperor Diocletian. When asked by his wife to go with her to Alexandria to have their twin boys baptized, he declined for fear of the anger of the emperor. His wife sailed to

Alexandria together with her two infants and two servants. On their way, a violent storm blew, and for fear that her two boys would die before being baptized, she stretched her hands toward the East and prayed. Then, she cut her right breast, and with her blood, she made the sign of the Cross on the foreheads of the two boys and dipped them in the water, saying: "In the name of the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit, I baptize you." When the sea got calmer, and she reached Alexandria, she presented the two boys to pope Peter to baptize them. However, every time the pope tried to dip one of them in the font of baptism, the water would dry up. After telling him what she did, the pope only prayed and anointed them with the Holy Myron oil.

When Socrates complained against his wife to the emperor, he called her over and gave the command to be tied with her hands behind her back, have her newborn babies on her belly, and burn the three of them in fire. Then, the emperor ordered also to put the pope under arrest for baptizing the infants in the year 311 AD.

Attempts of Arius:

Perceiving that pope Peter was on his way to martyrdom, Arius craftily hastened to get his absolution, hoping to replace him on the papal throne. He sought the help of some archons to intercede for his sake, but the pope reconfirmed his decision to excommunicate him.

The pope called his two disciples; the priests Archilaos and Alexandros and told them that the first would sit on the throne after him, to be followed by the second. He warned them against bringing Arius back to the fellowship of the Church, telling them that he saw in a night vision the Lord Christ wearing a garment torn in the middle, and when he asked Him about the clothing, He answered that Arius was the one who tore it.

Mutual Love:

Getting to know that their beloved pope has been arrested, the entire congregation came to the prison to rescue him even if it meant the death of them all. Although they never resorted to any kind of violence, the ruler had to postpone the execution for one day for fear of a revolt. When the night came and the crowd were still holding tight; the pope thinking about sparing his people of being harmed, called a trusted archon and told him to ask the ruler to send some of his men to the southern side of the prison, where the pope would knock on the inside wall to indicate where to dig to get him out for execution without the knowledge of the people crowding the front of the prison. That they did, and the pope came out proclaiming: "I would rather give myself up to save my people from harm."

The guards allowed him to visit the tomb of St. Mark, the Apostle to seek

his blessing. There, he prayed to God, delivered his people in His hands, seeking from Him to make him the last martyr in his generation. A virgin who was watching the night in prayers next to the tomb, heard a voice saying: “Peter will be the last martyr of this persecution.”

With his countenance shining like an angel, the pope approached the five executioners, none of whom dared to cut his head with his sword. Then, each of them offered a golden coin that those five coins to be gained by the one who would dare to carry out the execution. Finally, one of them did it, and that was on the 29th of Hator (in the year 311 AD). In the morning, when the people got to know sadly what happened, they put the Pope’s body on the throne of St. Mark the Apostle, on which he never sat all the days of his patriarchate. He used to say to his priests that whenever he intended to sit on it, he saw light dwelling on the throne, which made him sit at the foot-step of the throne.

He was buried next to St. Mark the Apostle, but on account that he would be moved later on to the tomb built for him at a location known as Lukaptus. Then, when he was moved there, he was accompanied by a multitude of miracles. The people of Alexandria kept celebrating his feast every year by spending the whole night in praise, then attending the Holy Liturgy in the morning performed by their current pope, to be followed by a meal of Agabi (of love) at the seashore.

His Writings:

- 1- The most prominent one was the **Pascal Message**, called “**the Message concerning the Laws**,” which he wrote after the persecution stirred up in the year 302 AD, including 14 laws about the chastisement of the deniers who return with repentance. It also warns against challenging the ruler to provoke him to stir persecution for the sake of receiving the crown of martyrdom. It was published in the year 306 AD¹. He also has **another pascal message**.
- 2- **A Letter to the People of Alexandria**, warning them against Meletius.
- 3- Essays about “**The Coming of our Savior**,” “**The Resurrection from the Dead**,” “**The Godhead**” and “**About the Soul**.”

[Fr. Tadros Malaty: Pope Peter I, The Last of the Martyrs, Melbourne, 1975]
[The Coptic Encyclopedia: Peter I, by Donald Spanel & Tim Vivian; pp. 1943-47]

PETER II, the 21st POPE OF ALEXANDRIA

His Ordination as the 21st Pope of Alexandria (373-380 AD):

¹ We have already had this message translated and published...

This saint was raised in Alexandria, became a disciple of the 20th Pope of Alexandria St. Athanasius the Apostolic (328-373 AD). He took after him the life of the holy and the upright faith. The pope so loved him that he ordained him as a priest in Alexandria and when St. Basil the Great sought someone to help him oppose the Arian heresy that denied the divinity of the Lord Christ, St. Athanasius sent to him Fr. Peter with some others who carried out their mission with the spirit of true zealously. On coming back to Alexandria, the pope appointed him as his secretary, as though he was preparing him to follow him on the throne. When the pope fell severely ill and perceived that his departure was close at hand, he advised his people and the clergy to choose Peter as his successor. Pope Athanasius reposed in the Lord while the Arians were coveting to take his throne. The congregation hastened to fulfill the request of their reposed pope, and St. Peter was ordained as a pope in the year 373 AD. That was during the reign of the Arian Emperor Valens (364-378 AD), who was filled with anger over the Copts for this act.

Valens Opposition against Him:

The Arians found out that their chance slipped from their hands by the ordination of Pope Peter II, but they were encouraged by the Arian emperor Valens, to whom they complained against the pope that he was not worthy of being a pope. Finding it a way to avenge the Copts, Valens wrote Palladius, the governor of Alexandria, commanding him to send the pope into exile and to set the Arian bishop Lucius in his place. That Lucius was an Egyptian who got the bishopric illegally outside of the country and coveted to be a patriarch on the St. Mark's throne. On returning to Alexandria, he took refuge in his mother's house away from the wrath of the angry congregation against him. For fear of a revolt, the governor expelled him out of the country to save his life. But, eventually, by the command of Emperor Valens, Lucius returned to Egypt accompanied by a large regiment led by Maginus, the treasurer of the emperor. The regiment leader charged with his soldiers towards the church, but the believers kept them from reaching to their pope and the pope, under pressure from the congregation and for their safety, had to escape and to hide in a deserted house on the seashore. There, he wrote a Papal message to his people to hold them fast to the Upright Faith. In the meantime, the soldiers abused the sanctity of the church and killed some believers.

The Intruder Patriarch Lucius:

Then, the governor informed the emperor about the fleeing of the pope, and the emperor's reaction was to commit all the Coptic bishops to submit to Lucius and to cooperate with him; otherwise, they would be exiled.

When the governor got knowledge that bishop Milas was opposing Lucius

and the Arianism, he set forth with his soldiers to the capital of his diocese, in Renocrora on the Egyptian borders with Levant. On entering into the church grounds, they found a simple man fixing the lamps, and when they asked him about the bishop, he led them into the diocese, prepared dinner for them, and served them by himself. He finally told them that he was the bishop Milas whom they were seeking. Astonished at his love, generosity, and humility, they provoked him to escape to avoid being exiled, but with a smile, he told them: "I would rather be exiled for the sake of faith than to be free under the Arian heresy".

In Rome:

St. Peter II, the Pope of Alexandria, set forth to Rome, where he was greatly welcomed, as they recalled his predecessor pope Athanasius, and his great defense of the faith. There, he met with the pope of Rome Damasus I (366-384 AD) and encouraged him to hold a council to expel the Arians. Then, they sent the council's decisions to Meletius, the legal bishop of Antioch, and not to the intruder Arian one. Meletius, in turn, held a council attended by 146 bishops, who unanimously approved the decisions of the Roman council and by that, the pope of Alexandria managed to restore the good relations between the Churches of Rome and Antioch.

The Church Resistance against Lucius:

That Lucius, having imposed himself on the throne of St. Mark by the power of the temporal authority; he was incapable though of imposing himself on the hearts of the believers, although those believers were forcefully forbidden to pray in any church without Lucius approval. When they remained at home and refrained from praying with that intruder, he carried out a campaign of destruction within the Church circles, not only in the city, but he sent his soldiers to the wilderness to attack the hermits, and he even did not spare their elders. This intruder patriarch ordained Arian bishops to replace the exiled true bishops; however, they were bishops with no congregations.

God Works through an Arab Queen to Help the Church:

God did not forsake His church amid that vicious Arian anguish but worked in various ways to appease it. Some Arab tribes on the Egyptian border joined forces with other Arab tribes on the Asian shores and set a kingdom under the leadership of a queen by the name of Mowfyyiah. Although she was not a Christian, she wanted to gain favor with the Christian minority among her people who had a good relationship with Egypt. Among those Christian minority, there was a Coptic hermit by the name of Moses,

whom they wanted to ordain as a bishop over them. When Emperor Valens forces were defeated before these Arab tribes, he asked their queen for a reconciliation treaty. So, queen Mowfyiah made it a condition for the reconciliation to have that hermit Moses ordained as a bishop by the Orthodox bishops of Alexandria. Then with the emperor's consent, Moses set forth to Alexandria together with the emperor's deputies. However, when Moses knew that Lucius the Arian patriarch has taken over St. Mark's throne by force, he refused to be ordained by him. Despite the attempts of the emperor's deputies to convince him, the hermit preferred to go back to his wilderness than to be ordained by a heretic. Finally, the emperor's deputies had to call the Orthodox bishops back from the exile to perform the ordination, among an atmosphere of joy and happiness of the people of Alexandria. Eventually, bishop Moses managed to gain the heart of the pagan queen Mowfyiah to the Christian faith, and he played a vital role within the Church of Alexandria, being his Mother Church.

Amid that anguish, God also allowed for St. Melania, the daughter of the Spanish Consul in the imperial court, to come to visit Egypt seeking the blessings of its hermits. In the meantime, St. Melania supported the exiled bishops and fulfilled their needs. Here, we should also proudly mention the role played by the hermit Glasius, who was called The Warrior. He supervised a group of hermits in the wilderness of Scetis, who played a significant role in the ministry of the Church amid the Arian persecution. They all felt obligated to work in supporting the suffering Church of God.

The Downfall of Lucius:

Finally, as Emperor Valens became fully occupied by his war against the Persians; Pope Peter II came back from Rome after being there for five years, to be warmly welcomed by his people. The congregation expelled the intruder patriarch Lucius, who went to Valens to complain against the people of Alexandria. Valens was killed in the same year, and Lucius hopes came to no avail.

The Popes Role in Helping Constantinople:

When Constantinople was torn apart by the heresies, Emperor Theodosius I (379-395 AD) wrote to Pope Peter II, asking him to take care of its restoration. So, the pope did his best to reform it, until Bishop Gregory the Nazianzus (the Theologian) reluctantly took over the responsibility of that diocese as well, responding to the pleading of its congregation. In contrast, Pope Peter II continued his support for that diocese.

In the meantime, a man by the name of Maximus the Caliban set forth to the city, coveting for the throne of Constantinople and pretended to be a

friend of St. Gregory, but with the hidden intention to plot troubles against him. He went to Alexandria where he craftily managed to deceive pope Peter II to recommend him as a bishop to replace St. Gregory the Nazianzus. St. Peter II had the intention to attend the ordination of Maximus, whom he counted as a friend, although he was still sick on a bed. However, the people of Constantinople refused to have Maximus ordained as their bishop, and they expelled him, persisting on St. Gregory as their patriarch. Then, Maximus went to complain to Emperor Theodosius I, who refrained from setting a bishop against the consent of his people. Failed in his attempt with the emperor, Maximus went to have the support of Pope Peter II, who already discovered his deceptive ways. St. Peter II refused to help him and sought from the governor to exile him as payback for his dishonest behavior.

The pope wanted to clear the atmosphere and to clarify his position before the people of Constantinople; however, he suddenly reposed in the Lord on the 20th of Amshir (in the year 380 AD).

[Fr. Menasseh John: *History of the Coptic Church*, 1982, pp. 169–172]

[Iris Habib El-Masry: *Story of the Coptic Church, Part 1*, 1969, pp. 341-351]

[The Coptic Encyclopedia: *Peter II*, by Aziz S. Atiya; p. 1947]

PETER III, the 27th POPE OF ALEXANDRIA

His Ordination as a Pope (477-489 AD):

This saint was a priest in Alexandria, a disciple of the 25th Pope St. Dioscorus (444-454 AD), and a friend of his successor, the 26th Pope St. Timothy II (455-477 AD). As St. Timothy reposed, Fr. Peter was chosen to replace him as the 27th pope of Alexandria in the year 477 AD, carrying the zeal of his mentor Pope Dioscorus on the Orthodox faith.

Emperor Zeno Act against Him:

It happened that Emperor Zeno (476-491) extorted the throne of Constantinople by force from Emperor Basiliscus (475-476). Zeno was a supporter of the Chalcedonians, and he did not accept the ordination of Pope Peter III, as being carried out without his consent. Mainly, the new pope started his papal work by holding a council in Alexandria, in which he renewed the ex-communication of Leo and his Tome. Emperor Zeno considered that as a personal challenge against him. He hastened and ordered that the pope would be sent into exile, and he set up an outsider named Timothy to act as a patriarch in his place. Pope Peter III disappeared from the scene for five years, during which he kept supporting his people by messages. The believers completely refrained from cooperating with the

intruder patriarch Timothy.

Between the Pope and John el-Talawy:

So many controversies used to take place between the Roman emperors and the Egyptian Church due to the emperor's regular interference into the internal religious affairs of the Church. To stop that, the congregation sent a delegation under the leadership of someone by the name of John el-Talawy (of the town of Tala in Menoufyia). He dared to go to the emperor to request that the Copts would have the freedom to choose their patriarch. The emperor considered that John el-Talawy had done that to be chosen as a patriarch. John swore to him that this has never been his intention and that he would not accept it even if all people requested him to do so. The emperor gave the delegate his consent.

Yet, a little after the delegate departed, the intruder patriarch Timothy died, and John el-Talawy, despite his previous vow, has recommended himself for the throne. He wrote messages to the bishops, and to the emperor to let them know about his intention. However, by the Divine Will, the message came to the pope of Rome before it went to either Acacius (471-488), the bishop of Constantinople, or the emperor himself. Both of them were provoked to anger because John el-Talawy let the pope of Rome know before them, and both agreed to bring Pope Peter III back to his throne.

When the pope of Rome wrote to the emperor to proclaim his happiness about letting John el-Talawy sit on the throne, the emperor responded by saying: "That man is not worthy of having such an exalted honor, because he broke his vow." The emperor gave his command to bring the legal pope back, and to send John el-Talawy away from Alexandria.

Between the Pope and Acacius:

Bishop Acacius got in contact with the friends of pope Peter III in Constantinople, to relay his intention of restoring the fellowship between the Churches of Constantinople and Alexandria. Pope Peter was pleased about that, however, he exchanged with bishop Acacius 14 messages before the reconciliation took place. He was keen on holding fast to the Orthodox faith, and he rebuked Acacius for his previous support of the Chalcedonians.

In one of his messages, Acacius wrote: "Shine on us, O lamp of the Orthodoxy; Shine a light on us, we who have lost the way to the Upright faith. Be to us like Steven, the first martyr, and shout on your persecutors, saying: *Lord, Do not charge them with this sin* (Acts 7:60)".

In one of the messages sent by Pope Peter III to him, it came: "Diligently pray and fast; and I will do the same with you and for your sake. Let us both seek from God in the name of the Universal Church". To which Acacius

responded by saying: “My heart exults on your consent to share with me in lifting the heavy burdens I carry. I give God thanks for He has given me the chance to repent by your prayers, and gave me the strength by your fasts with me and on my behalf. I exult that I shall have the blessing to enter into the Divine presence along with you. Now, I beg you to send us some desert Fathers and some archons you trust their Orthodoxy, to accompany us in a visit we intend to make to the emperor to talk to him concerning the reconciliation between all the Churches. So, we all could be happy to have stable peace in the Church of the King of Peace.”

Pope Peter III sent some of the Fathers of the wilderness and some trusted archons, to attend a council held in Constantinople. In that council, a decree was issued, known as the Decree of Zeno or *Henotikon*, which means (Act of the Union). That decree proclaimed the Orthodox faith and also denied the teachings of Arius, Nestor, and Eutyches, and accepted the teachings of the councils of Nicene, Constantinople, and Ephesus, as well as the teachings of St. Cyril the Great. Hopeful messages were exchanged between Pope Peter III and St. Acacius, and the Act of the Union project was almost about to succeed in bringing back the unity to the Church in the whole world. However, due to the obstructions of some people from within the church, the unity of the church was halted. In Egypt, for instance, Jacob, the bishop of Sa, and Mina, the bishop of Meniet Tama, stirred up a campaign against Pope Peter III, claiming that the reconciliation was a retreat from the Orthodox faith to the Chalcedonians. Pope Peter held a council in Alexandria in which he convinced the majority of bishops to accept it; except for a minority, called by the name of Asiphians meaning (those without a head), on account that they separated themselves from their spiritual leader.

But the Act of the Union was eventually demolished by the pope of Rome Felix III (483-492 AD), who blamed Acacius on his alliance with Pope Peter III. He stirred up a big storm on Acacius, and held a council in which he had both Pope Peter III and St. Acacius excommunicated.

When Acacius, bishop of Constantinople, reposed in the Lord in 488; he was followed by Fravitta, then by Euphemius (489-495), who cut all relationships with Alexandria. However, there were good relationships between the two churches in the days of the following patriarchs of Constantinople: Fravitta (488-489), Timothy I (511-518), Anthimus I (535-536), Sergius I (610-638), Pyrrhus I (638-641), Paul II (641-654), Peter (654-666), Thomas II (667-669), Theodore I (677-679) and John VI (712-715).

His Repose:

Pope Peter III spent the rest of his days doing his pastoral work in tranquility and peace, until he reposed on the 3rd of Hator in the year 489 AD,

after residing eight years and three months on St. Mark's throne.

[Fr. Menasseh John: History of the Coptic Church, 1982, pp. 292-295]
[Iris Habib El-Masry: Story of the Coptic Church, Part 2, 1969, pp. 99-110]
[The Coptic Encyclopedia: Peter III, by Aziz S. Atiya; pp. 1947-48]

PETER IV, the 34th POPE OF ALEXANDRIA

The Circumstances of his Ordination:

Emperor Justinian I (527-565) exiled the 33rd Alexandrian Pope Theodosius I (536-567), and he set an intruder who found only opposition from the Coptic people. Then, he commanded the ordination of Apollinaris of Constantinople to sit on the throne of Alexandria. That intruder marched to Alexandria to enter into the church dressed in military attire, then took it off there, to read on the people the emperor's creed to set him as a patriarch, accepting the Chalcedonian faith. Here, when the congregation showed anger and expressed protests, the intruder gave his command to his soldiers to kill; and many were martyred on that day that it was called The Day of the Massacre. While Apollinaris found every opposition from the Copts, the legal pope was in one of the prisons in Constantinople, where he remained for 28 years, until he reposed.

Emperor Justinian died and was replaced by Justin II (565-578 AD) on the throne, to follow suit of his predecessor, denying the Copts their legal, spiritual father, in an attempt to support Apollinaris; despite the persistence of the Copts in opposing him. When the legal pope reposed in prison, Apollinaris thought that the Copts would surrender and submit after so many years their pope has spent in prison. However, on the contrary, the Copts feeling fatherless persisted on ordaining a legal pope for themselves. Perceiving that the repose of the pope made the situation worse, Apollinaris sought from the governor to exile all the Orthodox bishops, to deny the people any chance of choosing their patriarch and in case they happen to choose someone, they would have no bishops to ordain him. On another aspect, he set a vast banquet to which he invited the Coptic priests and archons, in an attempt to gain their favor, but the Copts were neither broken by violence nor seduced by flirtation; and persisted on their request for a legal pope for themselves.

With a Divine will, the emperor replaced the governor of Alexandria by another by the name of Aristomachos, who showed great compassion towards the Christians. He sought from them to go to a monastery close to Alexandria to ordain whomever they choose as their pope. The Copts kept looking for three bishops exiled away from their thrones, but still around in the country.

Then, they quietly ordained pope Peter IV (567-570 AD) in the monastery of Glass where he was a monk, and everyone was joyful and happy.

His Troubles:

Apollinaris did not accept that situation; and felt that the Egyptian congregation was boldly taking control. So, he sent to the emperor to complain against the daring of the Egyptian Copts.

The new pope, banned from entering Alexandria, moved from a monastery to another. Still, as Apollinaris died and the controversy between the Byzantine Empire and the Egyptians was expected to calm down a little, the emperor replaced governor Aristomachos with another governor who was fierce with the Egyptians and confirmed the ban of the pope from entering Alexandria. The pope kept on moving between the monasteries with an open heart full of love and inner joy, practicing his pastoral work through messages to his congregation, and with the help of some bishops of the East.

Many Egyptians, Ethiopians, and Nubians kept coming to meet with their pope in one of the 600 monasteries around Alexandria.

In Antioch:

The throne of Antioch was vacant after the repose of their Bishop St. Severus of Antioch in Egypt. On hearing that the Egyptians have ordained a pope of their own, the believers in Antioch dared, as well, to ordain a hermit full of wisdom, by the name of Theophanius. The new Antioch bishop shared in the suffering of the pope of Alexandria, since he also was living in a monastery outside Antioch, expelled for the sake of faith. Both encountered one another, through exchanging messages that were a cause of comfort to the two congregations.

Pastoral Trips:

After the death of the intruder Apollinaris, the pope was able to some extent, to get out of his seclusion, to move between cities and villages. He ordained a bishop on the Elephantine Island and kept on searching for someone to appoint as his secretary to support him in his pastoral work.

He chose a deacon from a monastery on Mount Tabor, west of Alexandria, by the name of Demianos, known for his wisdom, knowledge, and piety. He also was a writer and a skillful painter who loved the life of solitude and seclusion. The pope took that disciple, who could not refuse the request of his father, knowing how much he and the Church have endured bitter sufferings, and they both entered together into Alexandria.

However, the pope did not last long on his throne, and he reposed in the year 570 AD, just two years after being ordained and lived a life full of

sufferings in the Lord. In his days, someone called Job el-Baradâ¹, he was a monk in a monastery called the monastery of the Cleavages close to El-Ruha (Edessa). This man came to Egypt and was ordained as a bishop on El-Ruha in the year 541 AD.

[Fr. Menasseh John: *History of the Coptic Church*, 1982, pp. 329–330]
[Iris Habib El-Masry: *Story of the Coptic Church*, Part 2, 1969, pp. 154-192]
[The Coptic Encyclopedia: Peter IV, by E.R. Hardy; p. 1948]

PETER V, the 83rd POPE OF ALEXANDRIA

After the repose of the 82nd pope Benjamin II (1327-1339), the Seat of St. Mark remained vacant for almost a year. Eventually Fr. Peter ibn Dawoud was chosen to become the 83rd pope (1340-1348). He was a monk in St. Macarius monastery, and then he was ordained as a priest in the monastery of Shahrân; before he became a pope in the year 1340 AD. This took place near the end of the reign of the Mamluk sultan El-Nasir ibn Qalawun (1310-1341 AD).

Pope Peter V besides his wide knowledge, he was characterized by his meekness and piety. In his days, the Coptic congregation suffered great torment caused by a judge in one of the cities. He imprisoned a Copt on account of that his grandfather was not a Christian and tried to force him to deny his faith. When he refused to do so, and when his fellow Copts managed to get him out of prison, the city was overcome by severe violence against the Copts. Many were tortured, and even the Copts graves were unearthed, and the dead bodies were burned. Because of that chaos, the governor sought from the sultan to fire that judge, which he did. Pope Peter V managed to cook the Chrism (Myron Oil) in the monastery of St. Macarius along with 12 bishops. When he got back from there, he suffered with his congregation from the disorderly mobs. Most of the congregation had to remain in their homes for some time, and the city seemed as though empty of Copts.

This pope did not cease to pray to God for his people's sake until He lifted that anguish, and the Church enjoyed a period of peace and tranquility. Then, the pope reposed to the Lord on the 8th of July 1348 AD.

[Kamel S. Nakhla: *Series of the History of Popes of Alexandria*, V. 2, pp. 53-57]
[The Coptic Encyclopedia: Peter V, by Subhî Y. Labib; pp. 1948-49]

¹ 'Job el-Baradâ' was so named because he was always dressed with worn out garments made of saddle's cloth (Bardaâa).

PETER VI, the 104th POPE OF ALEXANDRIA

This pope was originally called Morgan from the city of Assiut. He was raised in pious family life, and the grace of God was on him since his childhood. Loving asceticism and worship, he set forth to the monastery of Abba Anthony in Araba, to become a monk. He diligently prayed and read together with the monks with a spirit of meekness and humility, until he was ordained a priest on the hand of the 103rd pope Joannes XVI (1676-1718 AD) in the church of the Virgin Mother of God in Haret el-Rum.

After the reconstruction of the monastery of St. Paul, that pope assigned him to be the abbot of that monastery. After the repose of Pope Joannes XVI, the bishops, the priests, and the archons spent three days praying, fasting, and performing holy Liturgies before performing an altar lot. The altar lot chose Morgan, to be the new pope by the name of Peter VI on the 17th of Mesra in the year 1434 AM (1718-1726 AD) in the days of the Ottoman sultan Ahmed III (1703-1730). The celebration was attended by many Europeans, Armenians, and some military personnel; amid great exaltation among the people.

The new pope Peter VI visited many provinces in Lower Egypt. Still, he postponed his visit to Alexandria because of a riot caused by a controversy between two mamluk princes Isma'il ibn Iwaz and Mohammed (Bey) Jarkas.

In his days the archon mu'allam Lutf-Allah was martyred because of his care for the reconstructions of the churches.

When the pope ultimately came to Alexandria, he hid the heads of St. Mark the Apostle, and the bodies of many other departed patriarchs, for fear that they might be stolen. He visited Upper Egypt and sent Abba Christodolus I, bishop of Jerusalem, to be the bishop of Ethiopia.

[The Coptic Encyclopedia: Peter VI, by Aziz S. Atiya; pp. 1949-50]

PETER VII, the 109th POPE OF ALEXANDRIA

This pope was known as Peter el-Gawly, because he was born in a village by that name, affiliated with the city of Manfalot in Upper Egypt. He was raised in a pious family, and he eventually set forth to the monastery of Abba Anthony. He lived a monastic life full of the spirit of worship, study, and knowledge seeking. As the sweet fragrance of his virtues spread around, the 108th Pope Mark VIII (1796-1809) ordained him as a priest by the name of Fr. Marcorius.

In the year 1808, an Ethiopian delegation came to Egypt to seek from Pope Mark VIII to ordain for them a metropolitan to succeed their departed Abba Yusab. So, Fr. Marcorius was chosen and was called by the pope to

show up to be ordained. However, God's will come for him to be ordained as a general metropolitan on St. Mark diocese by the name of Abba Theophilus, to help the pope in his pastoral work. Another metropolitan by the name of Abba Macarius was ordained for Ethiopia.

When pope Abba Mark VIII reposed in the Lord; the whole congregation agreed on setting Abba Theophilus as a pope on the throne of St. Mark, by the name of Abba Peter VII, just three days after the repose of his predecessor. This happened in the days of Egypt's governor Mohammed Āli Pasha (1805-1848) on the 16th of Kiahk in the Coptic year 1526 AM (1809). The ordination took place in the magnificent Cathedral of St. Mark the Evangelist in Cairo, amid great joy and happiness.

His Life of Asceticism and Study:

Being ordained as a patriarch (1809-1825), only made pope Peter VII more ascetic. He was known for his silence and tranquility, full of awe, spending most of his time praying and studying the Holy Bible, the books of the early Fathers, the laws, and the history of the Church. Being so much consumed in his studies, he often forgot all about eating and drinking. He gathered in the patriarchate a rich library. He wrote books, among which was: The Most Famous and Prominent Copts, Essays on the Debates, Responding to the Adversaries, and many sermons and letters.

One day, desiring to eat a certain kind of food, he left it until it rotted, then he kept eating it despite its disgusting taste and smell in an attempt to rebuke himself on his desire. He was dressed in rough wool, used a red sandal, sat on the ground or an old wooden chair, and slept on a mat of hay. Because a beloved friend entered into his room and saw him praying and weeping bitterly, he ordered his disciple not to let anyone enter his cell without his permission.

Being Admired by the Officials:

Being characterized by wisdom and meekness in his behavior; he was loved by everybody and revered by the officials of the State, in particular by the governor (Mohammed Āli Pasha). Because of him, Copts were appointed to prominent positions in the government; the Church was given the freedom to worship, and he was allowed to reconstruct the monastery of St. Mark in Alexandria. Through this good relationship, he ordained a bishop on Nubia twice, together with many priests to help the bishop in his work there.

Also, in his days, Joas II, the king of Ethiopia sent a message to Mohammed Āli Pasha, and another one to the pope, to seek the ordination of a metropolitan for Ethiopia after the repose of Abba Macarius. When the Ethiopian delegation arrived, they presented a gift to Mohammed Āli Pasha;

the later sought from the pope to hasten the ordination procedure. The pope ordained a monk by the name Mena as a metropolitan under the name of Abba Kyrillos in the year 1816. At that time, Fr. Mena had to be tied with chains to keep him from fleeing from the ordination. After the repose of Abba Kyrillos, the pope ordained another one by the name of Abba Salama.

His Wisdom in Action:

When the Copts in the village of his birth El-Gawly, faced extremely rough troubles, the wise pope called the prominent Copts in the village and requested from them to present 200 Feddans (Acres) of their best land, as a gift to Sherif Pasha. Then, by motivation from the pope, Sherif Pasha appointed muâallem Bishai Malyoshi from Assiut as the responsible person for that piece of land. The pasha also assigned to him 36 Feddans of it to live on and so there were no more troubles for the inhabitants of that village.

His Deep Patriotism:

As Mohâammed Âli Pasha was making significant progress in his campaigns and invasions, the Russian empire was worried that this might interfere with their plans for the East and the Ottoman empire. So, the Russian Tsar sent one of his princes to meet with the Pope of Alexandria, the head of the largest Christian Church in the East, to urge him to seek the protection of Russia.

The prince, being used to the great magnificence of the Russian churches and the superb attires of their bishops, expected in Alexandria to enter into a great palace, to meet the court of the pope and to behave with a certain protocol. However, he was shocked to find himself standing before someone wearing a simple old woolen garment and around him were scattered some old chairs. He did not believe his eyes when the man told him he is the patriarch of the Copts. Before such simplicity, the Russian prince bowed down, kissed his hands, and sought his blessings. Asking him about the secret of this simple life, the pope answered him that it is befitting of the bishop to follow the lead of our Lord Jesus Christ who became poor for the sake of the sinners and asking him about the condition of the Coptic Church, he answered that the church was well as long as God was taking care of her.

When the prince indicated that he was concerned about what the Coptic Church was suffering from the rulers and offered Russian protection, the pope simply asked him: "Does your king live forever?" The prince answered: "No, my lord Father, but he dies like anyone else." Then, the pope said to him: "You, therefore, live under the care of a mortal king. However, we live under the care of an immortal king: God". Here, the prince found nothing to say, except to bow again before the pope seeking his blessing.

Later on, when Moḥammed Āli Pasha asked the Russian prince about his impressions about Egypt, he answered him: “I was not impressed by the greatness of the pyramids or the height of the obelisks; as much as I was impressed by my visit to the pious man, the patriarch of the Copts and the prince narrated to Moḥammed Āli Pasha the conversation between him and the pope. Joyfully, Moḥammed Āli Pasha set forth to the pope to thank him for his genuine patriotism. He told him: “Today, you have risen your stature and that of your country. You will be at the same level as Moḥammed Āli in Egypt.” To that, the pope responded: “No thanks is due to that who did his duty toward his country.”

God’s Works with Him:

There was a drought on the land, and the river Nile did not flood. The governor sought from the pope to pray for the sake of the water of the river. Together with some bishops, priests, and the congregation, the pope performed a Holy Liturgy on the Nile bank. After the mass, he threw the water with which the vessels of the altar were washed into the river and Lo! The level of water in the Nile increased to reach the site of prayer so that they hastened to move the tent before it is flooded.

The Light of Resurrection:

The pope had good relationship with Ibrahim Pasha (the son of Moḥammed Āli Pasha), full of love, friendship, and mutual respect. When Ibrahim Pasha occupied Jerusalem, some people (most probably Jews) whispered in his ears that what the Christians claim of the emergence of light from the holy Sepulcher was nothing but cheating and deception. As Ibrahim Pasha trusted in pope Peter VII; he called him to come from Egypt to Jerusalem. After receiving him with due respect, he told him of the reason why he called him; seeking from him to pray for the emergence of the light on his hands, and not on the Greek patriarch, but when Ibrahim Pasha felt that it would cause dissension and controversy when the Greek patriarch came to welcome pope Peter with great love, he sought from the two patriarchs to be together; with his attendance and guarded by his soldiers.

As it was the custom, the two patriarchs, with a spirit of love, fasted three days, and then entered into the Holy Sepulcher while praying and Lo! The light exploded out, and the pasha, in terror, fell on the chest of the pope, and for the sake of the multitudes who densely crowded outside the church, God allowed for the light to go through a pillar beside the pasha, for all to see. That split-open pillar is still there until this very day. This event added to the friendship of the pasha with the pope more love and respect.

No Partiality to the Rich:

Someone came to the pope to complain about his wife, whom he married, and before he touched her, he had to leave for five months on a business trip. When he came back, he found her pregnant, and on asking her about what happened, she answered him with disrespect and despite due to the high status and riches of her father. The pope called on the wife and asked her about the matter. She insisted that the pregnancy was by her husband. The pope, then, had nothing to do, except to say: "What is from God will hold fast, and what is from Satan will go away." Then, when the woman was on the last step of the patriarchate staircase, the fetus fell off her. The pope gave the husband a verdict of divorce because of adultery by his wife, and when her father came complaining, the pope told him: "There is no one among you stronger than the weak when the truth is on his side, and no one is weaker than the strong when vanity is on his side."

His Purity and Chastity:

Someone came to complain to the pope that he got married to a girl, to find out that she was not a virgin. When he realized that the pope seemed not to understand what he meant, he brought a plate of raw milk with its cream top layer, and then he dipped his finger in it to explain to the pope the difference between the virgin and the one who lost her virginity. The pope then, cried out: "Cursed be the day in which I came to know the difference between the virgin and the non-virgin," and he referred that case to be investigated.

[The Coptic Encyclopedia: Peter VII, by Mounir Shoucri; pp. 1950-51]

PETER AND EPSHAI EL-BUHY (The martyrs)

The Upbringing of Abba Epshai El-Buhy:

Abba Epshai el-Buhy was born to pious Christian parents: Theobastes and his wife Kharis. They remained childless for over 17 years, and their souls were quite bitter. Theobastes kept on praying for that matter, and eventually, he saw a man of light giving him the good news of the birth of his son Epshai, who would be a chosen vessel for God and qualified to receive the crown of martyrdom. This vision made the parents very exulted.

At that time, God gave Mary, the sister of Kharis, a boy whom she called Peter (his father called Sedrak). However, his mother, Mary, died shortly after. Kharis took it upon herself to raise him along with her son Epshai.

The Baptism of Epshai:

It was said that the parents brought their infant Epshai to be baptized by the priest of the church in Faw. The priest was a blind elder who was afflicted with a severe illness. He carried the infant on his hands, prayed a long prayer for him, blessed him, then took the infant's hand and put it on his face, eyes, and chest. Miraculously, the priest's eyes opened, and he instantly was entirely healed of his illness. Right away, he prayed on the font of baptism and prophesied that the infant and his cousin Peter would be receiving the crowns of martyrdom and that God would perform wonders through them. The old priest gave the infant to his parents after kissing him; then, the older priest reposed in peace in the hands of God.

When Epshai reached seven years of age, his parents brought him a good elder teacher from the city of Akhmim to teach him along with his cousin Peter how to read the Holy Bible and how to practice the church worship. The two boys showed such a great longing for the church that they have ordained deacons by the bishop. Deacon Epshai was given the grace of God to perform miracles when he was still a young boy.

The two young men Epshai and Peter, were bound together by a spiritual friendship and kept praying and fasting together. God's hand was with both of them that they became the talk of the entire town. When Epshai reached 30 years of age, his parents died. The two young men grieved on them but comforted by the bible's verses concerning the Eternal Inheritance.

Their Persecution:

Three years after the repose of the parents, emperor Diocletian (284-305) gave his orders to persecute the Christians. Ariana, the evilest and cruel of his governors, tortured the Christians from Ansenah to Aswan. It so happened that while Ariana was traveling to Qift to rebuild an idol's temple that collapsed on its pagan priests and killed them, he called on the two deacons Epshai and Peter, threatened them, and then put them in jail.

The jail turned into a holy church where prayers were raised, and the sick were brought in to be healed. The Archangel Gabriel came to encourage them to endure the torture. After five months in jail, Ariana came back to Faw and called them, then gave the order to kill Peter by the sword, then to hang his body on a high pole to be devoured by the birds of prey but after his head was cut off, Epshai gave much money to an influential man to bring the body down and take it back to the city. Epshai remained in jail to worship God and to heal the sick brought up to him, until Ariana called him again, had him chained in the boat with no food or drink, sailing to the Capital. There, Ariana tortured him and put him in jail where he exultantly served the

prisoners and healed the sick; until the governor eventually set him free.

Epshai went to Alexandria, where he preached and performed miracles in the name of the Lord Christ, until the governor of Alexandria arrested him, and kept torturing him, accusing him of magic. It was said that whenever the governor asked him what was his work, he used to answer him: "I am a trader who came to sell my blood to purchase the Kingdom of Heaven, which you denied yourselves together with your hypocrite king."

Epshai endured so much torture, but God kept sending His angel to heal him. It was said that the governor was afflicted by illness and had to call him from jail to heal him, but with love, he prayed for him and gave to his messenger oil to anoint the sick man with. He refrained from forsaking his fellow prisoners to go to him and preferred instead to stay with those who suffered and partake of their praise to God. In addition to healing the governor, he also healed the daughter of Timothy his deputy, and her mother as well.

When prince Maximianos came to Alexandria, and the governor told him about what happened with Epshai; they could not help but admire the works of God through those martyrs; despite their immense hate of Christians. They were amazed at their happy life and the power God granted them to heal the sick. Here, Maximianos pretended to be angry and sought to take Epshai and his company to the king in Antioch, to have them killed there. However, the truth was that he intended to take him to his own house in Antioch to heal his sick son, and indeed, Epshai drove an evil spirit out of his son. When the news spread in all Antioch, Emperor Diocletian got angry and threatened to have the prince killed, as he has already done to the princes Tadros el-Meshriqy, Aqladius, Boctor, Abaly and Tadros the son of Wasilides, etc. There, Epshai was martyred by Diocletian's order, by having his head cut off on the 4th of Paona.

PETER AND HIS COMPANIONS (The martyrs)

When Emperor Diocletian (284-305 AD) resided in Nicomedia in Asia Minor, he was told that there were Christians in his court. He instantly brought statues of idols and ordered everyone, in particular those whom he doubted, to burn incense to those idols. The Christians bravely refused to deny their Christ, including Peter. This saint was fiercely whipped to have his bones exposed, and they poured a mixture of vinegar and salt on his wounds. On seeing what happened, Dorotheus and Gorgonius, who were prominent officers in the court, together with someone called Migdonius rebuked the emperor and proclaimed that they were Christians too. They all fell under

torture, and they all received the crowns of martyrdom. As for Peter, he was cast on the ground and treaded by feet, then put on the fire to get roasted, while they were cutting his flesh every now and then. However, in all that, the Lord granted him endurance and comfort. He never cried out, but exultantly testified to the Creator of heaven and earth, until he became a martyr on the 9th of September in the year 304.

[A. Butler: *The Lives of the Saints*, Sept. 9]

PETER BALSAM (The martyr)

This saint was a Palestinian citizen from the city of Eleutheropolis. He was martyred in the days of Emperor Maximinus II (311-313), after entering into a debate with Governor Severus. In that debate, he said that his name was Balsam, and it was Peter in baptism. He confirmed that he cherished his faith. He indicated that he did not care for any suffering or troubles that may dwell upon him for the sake of the Lord Christ. In his talk with the governor, he was revealing the truth to him and preaching him the Salvation.

Before he ordered to tear his body with the Henbazin, the governor tried to make the saint change his mind, but he proclaimed to him that he would never deny his Christ. Once they started torturing him, he did not moan, but exultantly, sang the words of the Psalmist: “*One thing I have desired of the Lord, that I will seek, that I will dwell in the house of the Lord all the days of my life, to behold the beauty of the Lord, and to inquire in His temple*” (Ps. 27:4). While the blood flowed from him, the executioners kept crying out: “Obey the emperor, sacrifice to the idols to spare your life.” He answered them: “Do you call these torments? I feel no pain: but this I know, that if I am not faithful to my God, I must expect real pains, which cannot be conceived.” After the governor, Severus tried every way to torture him and failed to change his faith; he ordered to nail him on a Cross, and so the saint ended his strife by conquest by the Lord on the Cross on the 3rd of January 311 AD.

[A. Butler: *The Lives of the Saints*, Jan. 3]

PETER CHRYSOLOGUS, THE BISHOP

The Western Church proudly celebrates Fr. Chrysologus (the Golden-Worded), the archbishop of Ravenna in Italy, who reposed on the 4th of December 450 AD.

He was raised with such a high culture in the town of Imola, east of Emilia, in Italy. Fr. Cornelius, the bishop of the city, ordained this saint as a deacon and had him as his disciple. When the archbishop of Ravenna reposed

in the year 433 AD, bishop Cornelius went to Rome with a delegation, among whom was deacon Peter, carrying a specific recommendation. However, St. Sixtus III, the Pope of Rome (432-440), told them that he saw in a night vision St. Peter and the martyr St. Apollinaris (first bishop of Ravenna) seeking the ordination of deacon Peter as the new archbishop. So he did, which was not received well by the people of Ravenna, but rather with loud protest.

It happened that the saint gave a sermon before Empress Galla Placidia, the mother of Emperor Valentinian III (424-455). The empress admired the saint's piety, and he gained the appreciation of the rulers. The empress supported him also with the expenses of his church projects.

The saint cared for preaching the pagans and wrote a message to the heretic Eutyches in the year 449 AD. Eutyches denied the Manhood of the Lord Christ; he considered that Christ's Godhead had absorbed His Manhood; and that the Lord Christ carries only one Nature, that of the Godhead.

Even though many sermons were attributed to St. Peter Chrysologus, however, most of his works believed to be lost.

[A. Butler: *The Lives of the Saints*, Dec. 4]

PETER EL-GAMIL, ABBA

This Abba Peter was called El-Gamil. He was the bishop of Melig, in the papacy of Abba Peter V (in the 14th century). We do not know much about his life, more than that he wrote the following dogmatic books:

- The book of El-Bayan¹ (Articulation) in five chapters to debate against Gamal el-Din ibn Moḥammed el-Masry.
- About the Heresies of the Sects², to support the Orthodox doctrine.
- The Shining³, in response to the Armenians.

It was also said that he completed the biographies of the saints, which were added to the Coptic Synaxarion.

PETER EL-RUHAWY, THE BISHOP, ST.

This saint was born in the city of El-Ruha (Edessa) at the beginning of the 5th century, by two noble, wealthy parents. When Peter reached 20 years of age, his father presented him to Emperor Theodosius II (402-450 AD) to be with him and serve him. However, he lived in the royal court as though in a

¹ The book title in Arabic is: "البيان"

² The book title in Arabic is: "في بدع الطوائف"

³ The book title in Arabic is: "الاشراق"

monastery, despising the glories and vanity of this world and practicing a monastic kind of life that drew many towards him. It was said that he also kept with him some of the relics of some Persian martyrs.

He eventually left the royal court to join a monastery to dedicate all his time to worship. Not long after that, he was ordained as a bishop on Gaza against his own will. It was claimed that while performing his first Liturgy as a bishop, blood flowed from the holy body to fill the platter.

When Marcian, the Chalcedonian emperor, reigned (450-457) and started to persecute the Orthodox bishops, bishop Peter carried the relics of St. James (the Torn) from a monastery in El-Ruha and brought it to El-Behnassa in Egypt. He lived there in one of its monasteries and met with St. Isaiah the Egyptian. After a while, Emperor Marcian died, and bishop Peter returned to Palestine.

It was said that once while bishop Peter was performing the Divine Liturgy, some elite worshippers were not paying attention and talking to each other. Because the bishop did not stop them, an angel of the Lord appeared to him, held him by the waist, and rebuked him.

Emperor Zeno (474-491 AD) wished to see him, but the saint refrained from going to him because he was not preoccupied with the glories of this world.

Then, he went to the land of Gaur, between Jerusalem and Damascus, and while he was praying on the feast of St. Peter of Alexandria, that saint appeared and proclaimed to him that the Lord Christ was calling him to join them. He then called the congregation, held them fast to the faith; then spread his hands to deliver his soul on the 1st of Kiahk.

PETER, THE DEACON (The martyr)

In the Divine Liturgy of the Latin Church, two martyrs are mentioned: Marcellinus, the priest, and Peter the deacon. They were martyred on the 2nd of June 304 AD in the era of the two Emperors Diocletian and Maximianus (284-305 AD). Those two Roman saints ministered to the church of God with piety. The deacon Peter was granted by God the grace of driving the evil spirits out. When his fame spread, the pagans were stirred up against him, they jumped upon him and kept striking and whipping him. Then, they cast him in prison together with some Christians to be tried after the governor Serenus would be healed from his illness.

Amid his wounds, St. Peter was happy in the spirit, and when he noticed the signs of grief on the countenance of the jailer Artimius; he asked him about the reason, and the jailer told him that his daughter was possessed by

an evil spirit. When Peter assured him that his God could drive that spirit out of her, the jailer scoffed him saying that if his God was able to drive the evil spirit out, why then did He leave him wounded in a jail?! Peter answered him; that God intended for him to receive the immortal Crown of Glory! Mockingly, the jailer challenged St. Peter that if his God could loosen his chains, open the prison gates and bring him to his house to drive the evil spirit out of his daughter Paulina; he and his household would all believe in his God. Peter told him that all of that could be realized by the power of his God. To this, the jailer persisted on that, if all the gods in heaven come down, they will not be able to loosen his chains and get him out of jail.

In the House of the Jailer Artimius:

Artimius returned to his house, and while he was telling his wife what happened between him and deacon Peter, all of a sudden, they found Peter entering into their home dressed in white attire and carrying the icon of the Crucifixion. The evil spirit could not endure hearing the words uttered by St. Peter in the name of Jesus Christ and came out of the little girl. The jailer, his wife, and daughter proclaimed their faith in the Lord Christ. Peter then set forth to the priest Marcellinus to tell him what God did through him and to ask him to baptize the entire family. Concerning Artimius, the jailer after being baptized, he set forth to the jail to set free all those who were imprisoned for their faith.

Getting healed of his illness, governor Serenus intended to call all the Christian prisoners to torture them, to be told by the jailer Artimius that Peter the deacon has opened the gates of the jail, loosened the chains of the prisoners. All of them escaped, with the exception of Peter and the priest Marcellinus who chose to stay in prison. Then, the jailer told the governor what happened to him and his household, and how he accepted Christianity and was baptized. The governor became so furious that he gave his command to beat the jailer to the point of death and torture the priest and the deacon. Then, he ordered that the three of them to be cast back in prison, but God again, opened the gates of the prison that the priest and the deacon were set free to go and partake of the prayers raised by the believers. On hearing about it, the governor brought the jailer, together with his wife and daughter, and ordered them to deny their Christ, and when they refused, he ordered to bury them alive.

On their way to die, the priest and the deacon met with them and encouraged them to hold fast to their faith and consummate their strife. Then, they joined them in having their heads cut off by the orders of the governor.

PETER, THE MARTYR

The Church of the West celebrates the feast of the martyrdom of Peter of Lampsacus in Asia Minor on the 15th of May. He was martyred while young in the days of Emperor Decius (249-251 AD) around the year 251 AD. Known for his delicate nature and his high social status, he stood before the governor Optimus to refuse to worship the goddess Venus and denying his Christ. He was pressed by the Henbazin. Then, his head was cut off to receive the crown of martyrdom. At the same time, the governor called three other Christians from the town of Troas in Phrygia: Andrew, Paul, and Nicomachus. He started to question them and urge them to sacrifice to the idols. The first two refused to deny their Christ and held fast to their faith while being severely tortured. However, the third one denied his confession under torture.

A 16 years old girl by the name of Denysa, was watching what was going on with the torture of these two saints by the governor. Her heart was so embittered inside her that she dared to rebuke the governor publicly for opposing the faith. The governor responded by delivering her into the hands of two evil men to ruin her virginity to humiliate her. However, she managed to fight them back and endured their insults and blame, yet the Lord Christ saved her from being harmed by them. In the morning, Denysa was delivered to the swordsman to have her head cut off. She requested to be executed together with the saints Andrew and Peter, but the governor denied her request, and he ordered to stone them to death outside the city; while the girl's head was cut off inside the city.

[Butler's Lives of Saints, May 15]

PETER, THE MONK

St. Palladius told us about an elder monk who had an excellent disciple by the name of Peter. For some reason, the older monk was hasty and showed so much anger on his disciple that he expelled him and locked the door of his cell. In silence, full of meekness and inner peace, the young monk Peter sat outside the door until the elder monk opened it sometimes later. Overwhelmed with remorse for his disciple's humility before what he did to him, he said to his disciple: "Peter! Because your meekness and longsuffering have overcome my hasty anger, from now on, you are my elder and father; and I shall be your servant and disciple. By your good behavior, you have altered my old age."

[Palladius: The Paradise II, ch. 7]

PETER, THE PRIEST, ST.

This father Peter spent his whole life fasting, longing for a life of solitude and tranquility, and continuous prayers day and night, with an open heart filled with love for all. God granted him the grace of healing the sick by praying on oil and water, in the name of our Lord Jesus Christ, and He gave him, as well, the grace of foretelling future events.

He was ordained as a priest after great reluctance, but once he was ordained, he performed the Holy Liturgy daily. The congregation loved him very much, trusted in his prayers, and felt that he was the secret behind their blessings. With the spirit of humility, he cared patiently for reconciling among the adversaries, and his whole Church came to live by the sense of unity and peace.

Once during his prayer, St. Peter the Apostle appeared to him, saying: “Peace be with you, who kept priesthood blameless. Peace be with you, whose prayers and sanctification ascended as a sweet fragrance.” On seeing him disturbed and in fear, St. Peter told him: “I am Peter the Apostle, do not fear or be disturbed, for I am sent by the Lord to comfort you and to tell you that you will soon depart from the labors of this world to the everlasting Kingdom.” The saint exulted by that vision, and he reposed in peace.

The Church celebrates his departure on the 5th of Baramhat.

PETER, BISHOP OF BRAGA, ST.

This St. Peter was one of the early bishops of Portugal, who lived in the 4th century, and sat on the throne after his mentor St. James the Great, the first bishop on Braga (Rates). It was said that he has got the crown of martyrdom, after he baptized the daughter of the queen of that region and healed her of leprosy. The West celebrates him on the 26th of April.

PETER, BISHOP OF SEBASTEIA, ST.

This St. Peter was the youngest of ten siblings¹. The eldest member of this family was St. Macrina the Younger, who had an influential role in the lives of her siblings and in that of the Church. Among his brothers was St. Basil the Great, the bishop of Caesarea, and St. Gregory, the bishop of Nyssa. Their parents were Basilios and Emilia, who were exiled because of their faith.

His father reposed while Peter was still suckling, and he was taken care of by his eldest sister St. Macrina, who enflamed his heart with the love of

¹ The biographies of other members of the blessed family of this saint have been covered under their respective names...

ascetic life and the insignificance of the temporal posts and the vain honors.

St. Peter joined the monastic congregation established by his brother St. Basil on the shores of the river Iris. St. Basil needed his help and planned to prepare him to be his successor because of his wisdom, prudence, and virtuous life in the Lord.

When a severe famine dwelt upon Pontes and Cappadocia, the exalted love of this saint was apparent. While the human wisdom would have made it befitting of him to be careful in helping others until his congregation pass safe and sound that calamity, the saint acted with Christian love, and he opened all the storehouses of his congregation to give generously to all, trusting that God would satisfy everyone.

His Ordination:

As St. Basil was ordained as a bishop on Caesarea of Cappadocia in the year 370 AD, he encouraged his younger brother to have the grace of the priesthood. St. Basil reposed on the 1st of January 379 AD, and his sister Macrina reposed in November of the same year, followed by Eustathius the Arian, bishop of Sebasteia in Armenia Minor, who was an opponent of St. Basil. St. Peter was ordained as a bishop on Sebasteia in the year 380 AD, to remove all the roots of Arianism out of that diocese. In the year 381 AD, he took part in the Second Ecumenical Council in Constantinople, where he demonstrated an intense zeal on the Orthodox faith, along with great wisdom and piety. It was said that he reposed in the summer of the year 391 AD.

[A. Butler, *The Lives of the Saints*, 1866, January 9]

PETER, METROPOLITAN OF ETHIOPIA

In the 10th century AD, when the 58th pope of Alexandria Abba Cosmas III (920-932 AD) resided on the papal Seat; the relationship between the Egyptian mother-Church and the Ethiopian Church was lukewarm, because of the rough circumstances through which the Coptic Church was passing. The king of Ethiopia wrote to the pope asking him to hasten to ordain a metropolitan on Ethiopia; since he became very old and wished to leave his two sons under the guidance of a wise metropolitan. He expected that metropolitan to help to raise his two sons; and, in due time, to choose the one more suited to be a king after him. In response, the pope ordained the monk Peter, a wise and prudent man to be a metropolitan on Ethiopia. The king and the people received him with a great welcome, and after a few weeks, the old king passed away. As a guardian, the metropolitan took care of the two young princes; and he realized that the younger son, once he reached the age of

maturity, was more suited to bear the kingdom's responsibility. So, with wisdom and prudence, he put his hand on him and crowned him as a king, while the people rejoiced greatly. However, the devil who would not endure to let things run in peace and tranquility, stirred up two evil persons by the name of Mina and Boctor to cause significant problems. Those two evil men were initially been wandering about the land of Ethiopia in the attire of monks begging for money, with the false claim that the money would be spent on the churches and the monasteries. Then, they went to the older prince and the archons of Ethiopia, with a forged letter claiming to be signed by the pope, saying that Peter was not ordained as a metropolitan by the pope; but the true metropolitan was Mina; the carrier of that letter, and the letter sought from them to remove Peter and to set Mina in his place. The letter also expressed the sadness of the pope for the wrong choice of the younger son to be the king, an action which would only be done by someone who disregards the right of the firstborn.

On presenting this forged letter to the older prince, he was motivated by covetousness for authority, and he gathered the leaders of the army and read the letter to them. So, they all strongly revolted against the king and Abba Peter the metropolitan. They put both under arrest, exiled them, set the older prince as a king, Mina as a metropolitan, and Boctor as his deputy.

Yet, the bishopric of Mina did not last long, for a controversy arose between him and Boctor, who used the chance of his absence from the land to rob all money and precious possessions and flee to Egypt and deny his faith. On hearing about what happened, the pope was extremely saddened, and he wrote to Ethiopia detailing the actual situation.

When the new king of Ethiopia discovered the forgery of the first letter, which was claimed to be sent by the pope; he acted angrily with no wisdom and took his sword and killed Mina, as a way to appease the people so that they would not revolt against him. Then, he sent for Abba Peter to find out that he already reposed because of his sufferings. So, he set Abba Peter's disciple as a metropolitan, without even sending him to the pope to ordain him. He feared that the pope might ask the new metropolitan to remove the older brother and to bring his younger brother back from exile to the throne.

Saddened by how that Ethiopian king behaved in all those incidents, pope Cosmas III planned to punish him by not ordaining any metropolitan on Ethiopia. The next four popes followed this action, to leave Ethiopia without a shepherd for about 60 years, until the days of the 63rd pope Abba Philotheos (979-1003 AD).

PETER, THE WORSHIPPER, ST.

The biography of this saint reveals how abundant and rich God's grace is. It could turn the one with a stony heart into a loving companionate human being. Peter the tax-collector was known for his greed and love of money, with a cruel heart and lack of mercy. These characteristics were tied to his name in the whole city (most probably it was Alexandria). It happened once that a poor man kept chasing him to get something from him. On getting annoyed, Peter attempted to drive him away, so he took a piece of bread from a bakery-boy who happened to be delivering bread to him, and struck the poor man on the head with it, as a way to insult him and not out of mercy. Later on, in a night vision, he saw himself standing in the judgment day; and a balance was set, then a group of ugly demons appeared carrying his sins and casting them in the left-hand pane of the balance. Then, another group of excellent angels of light standing confused, not knowing what to put in the right-hand pan except for the piece of bread by which Peter struck the poor man on the head.

Peter got up from his sleep, very sad about all his years spent in the works of darkness, cruelty, and love of money. He felt so sorry for denying himself the fellowship with the angels of light, through a life of faith motivated by love. He realized that his life on the earth was away, either to partake of the bitterness of the ugly demons; or of the graceful angels of light in their eternal glories. He put it in his heart to live the rest of his life working to earn the Eternal Kingdom.

His New Life:

Peter's heart completely changed; instead of caring for money, he came to care for the poor and the needy. He distributed all his wealth on them; even he gave his garment up as a gift of love. And finally, having nothing left, he sold himself to a rich Roman elite and gave the money to the poor.

To the Wilderness of St. Macarius:

Peter lived as a slave, but with his open, loving heart, he embraced all his fellow slaves as a compassionate father to all of them. By his pious attitude, he gained many of them to the faith through his new life, living among the poor and slaves, partaking of their sufferings and needs. His master was puzzled by his behavior and his way of life, and he felt that Peter was not an ordinary slave. The master and his household were strongly impressed by him. Then, it happened one day that a rich man from Peter's homeland came to visit his master. When the visitor recognized Peter, the master revealed to him how he had sold himself to him for the sake of the poor. Feeling that the

glory was chasing him, Peter secretly fled to the wilderness of St. Macarius to become a monk living in a healthy ascetic life. There, he was loved by his fellow monks, who tried to follow his lead in serving the others and in his way of worship.

We can say that, by the Divine grace, Peters's heart completely changed to walk by the spirit wherever he was. After being a tax-collector who did his job with cruelty and only loved the ugly profits; he came to be a slave practicing the meanest of temporal works, and blending with his fellow slaves with a heart broad-open with love and humility. And, when he came to be a monk in the wilderness, with his open, loving heart, he practiced monasticism on an exalted level. Love grants man success wherever he goes and in whatever he does.

When St. Peter came to know the time of his departure, he called the father's of the wilderness, sought their prayers, bid them farewell, prayed until he breathed his last in peace. The Church celebrates his feast on the 25th of Toba.

PETRONILLA (The martyr)

It was mentioned in the Roman Acts of Martyrs, under the 31st of May, that St. Petronilla was the daughter of St. Peter the Apostle. It seemed that she has come to Rome in his company. According to some researchers, however, that relationship with her was only spiritual, having been preached and baptized by him. She was a beautiful God-loving virgin who was inflicted with paralysis but endured it with a content heart, cheerfulness, and perpetual love. When some people wondered why the apostle did not seek her healing, St. Peter prayed for her, and she was temporarily healed, he did that to avoid tripping those who were wondering. At the time, St. Petronilla served those present, then went back to lie paralyzed again.

After the martyrdom of St. Peter, God allowed her to be completely healed. Then, she gathered around her a group of virgins to worship God together.

Her fame soon spread because of her great tenderness beside her beauty; that a nobleman in Rome by the name of Flaccus came to see her, and he got so in love with her to ask her to marry him. She, with prudence and wisdom, told him that, even though she is not worthy of such an honor, yet she asked him to give her three days to be prepared for that idea. Her goal from that was to spare her girls from being harmed by the soldiers who would eventually come to take her, be sure that God would act during those three days. St. Petronilla then, got together with her virgin friend St. Fenicola, and

both of them kept praying fervently all along the three days, and just before the fixed date, St. Petronilla departed to the Lord. When Flaccus heard about what happened, he was so grieved. However, he sought to marry St. Fenicola instead. When she refused his request on account that she was a virgin dedicated only to the Lord, he filed a complaint about her to the governor. The governor cast her in prison with no food or drink, then brought her over to torture her until she delivered her soul into the hands of the Lord and received the crown of martyrdom.

[Baring-Gould: *Lives of the Saints*, May 31]

PETRONIUS, THE BISHOP, ST.

St. Petronius was the bishop of Bologna in Italy during the 5th century AD. He was most probably the son of Petronius, the governor of a city in the land of Gaul (402-408 AD). In his early youth, he went to visit Palestine, where he encountered many monks and got the blessing of the holy places. His prominent position in society did not distract him from his private spiritual life or his ministry of the church. Before he was ordained as a bishop (around year 432), he established a monastery on the eastern side of the city, in the name of St. Steven, the first martyr. After his ordination, he established a cathedral in the same name, which was used by the bishops of Bologna until the 10th century. That cathedral was rebuilt and renewed many times in the middle ages. He also was engaged in rebuilding the churches destroyed by the Gnostics.

The historian Gennadius of Massilia (d. 496 AD), who completed the book of St. Jerome: "On Illustrious Men," wrote about the saint saying: "Petronius was a saint, who cared for the monastic studies since his youth; and was famed by his book "Life of the Fathers," in which he testified to the Egyptian monks. That book was received by the monks as a guide and model for their monastic life. On reading an article that carried his name: "Ordination of the Bishops," I saw the wisdom of its author, and how it was written with humility. However, it seems that he was not the author of that article, but his father Petronius, an eloquent man with high culture."

PETRONIUS, ST.

Unfortunately, we do not know enough about the life of this saint; however, it is very telling to know that his spiritual father, St. Pachom the Great, chose him to succeed him in overseeing all the Pachomian monasteries. After just 13 days in that position, St. Petronius reposed because

of the same illness St. Pachom died by.

Since the day he entered into the monastery, he never looked back, but completely forsook the world. He was dedicated with such great love that drew the heart of his father, Besneeb, not only to present his whole wealth to St. Pachom to build monasteries but to bring him to the monastic life itself. St. Petronius, as well, drew all his brothers, sisters, relatives, and even the servants to the monastic life. His whole household left the world and turned to the monasteries and convents, to practice the holy monastic life.

He was very humble in his talk, particulate in watching his inner life and firm on himself, but compassionate on all the others. When Selwanis, the actor, was expelled from the monastery because he got back to the use of some foul words from his acting past, he embraced him until he surpassed many in piety.

He became the Abbot of the monastery of Tismen in Akhmim, until he was chosen by St. Pachom to succeed him. However, he reposed in the Lord to be replaced by St. Horsiesius as his successor.

PHILASTORGUIUS

Philastorguis was born in Borissus in Cappadocia Secunda around the year 368 AD. When he was 20 years old, he left to spend the rest of his life in Constantinople.

His Admiration and Defense of Anomius:

He wrote his work on **The History of the Church** between 425 and 433 AD, in 12 books, dealing with events in the period between 300 and 425 AD.

Apparently, he wrote that work as a consummation of the book authored by Eusebius of Caesarea. However, it represented a sort of defense of the Arianism of Anomius, whom he very much admired. His book came as a reproach against those of the upright faith like St. Gregory, the Nazianzus and St. Basil the Great, and as a glorification of the Arians. He started each of his books by one of the 12 letters included in the spelling of his name.

PHILASTRIUS, THE BISHOP, ST.

His Upbringing

St. Philastrius (Philaster/Filaster) was the bishop of Brescia (Braxia) during the 4th century AD. His successor, St. Gaudentius kept celebrating the feast of his departure on the 18th of July every year, and his sermon on the 14th anniversary provided quite a bit of information about his life and

activities. Philastrius's life began with a great act of abandonment by rejecting his father's house, which he inherited, for which he was compared to Abraham, the father of Fathers.

His Care for the Upright Faith:

Later on, he was ordained as a priest and traveled over nearly the whole Roman world, preaching against pagans, Jews, and heretics, especially the Arians. At Milan, he was a great help for the Church in the time of St. Ambrose's Arian predecessor; he firmly opposed Auxentius the Arian, who tried to divide the churches and the believers by his heresy. At Rome, he held both private and public disputations with heretics and converted so many of them. His wanderings ceased when he was made bishop of Brescia. There, he delivered himself with love to his flock, that his life came to be a role model of piety, virtue, humility, and self-giving. In his pastoral work, he kept warning his people against the faults of faith; and was very compassionate toward his people, giving the needy among them with great generosity.

His Writings:

St. Philastrius authored a critical book, gave it the title: **A Catalogue of Heresies**. In that book, he explained the theological meanings of different expressions and clarified the views of the heretics and gave his counter-views about them. This book could be considered as a valuable reference for those caring to write about the heresies. St. Augustine quoted parts from that book, and when Quodvultdeus sought from him to write an essay about the heretics, St. Augustine pointed him in his reply to the works of Epiphanius of Salamis and Philastrius [Letter# 222]. Epiphanius covered 20 heresies before the coming of Christ and 60 heresies after His ascension, while Philastrius covered 28 heresies before the arrival of Christ and 128 after His ascension.

St. Augustine refused to accuse Epiphanius of not being aware of some of the heresies. He referred to the variation in the heresies numbers between the two authors to a difference in the definition of what would constitute heresy. For example, Philastrius considered calling the days of the week by pagan names instead of calling them in the Holy Bible as the first, the second, the third to the seventh, as some kind of heresy.

When St. Augustine listed the heresies, he mentioned the 60 heresies which happened after the Ascension and listed by Epiphanius; and added 23 others taken from Philastrius list, although he did not count them as typical heresies.

According to many scholars, Philastrius wrote his list independently from Epiphanius, and he did not depend on him. Any similarity between the two would have come because both depended on the same resources.

In chapter 88 of his book, Philastrius referred to that Church readings from both the Book of the Revelation and the Epistle to the Hebrews were not included, and that was not because they were not Canonical, but because the Church preferred not to read them publicly to the general congregation. In chapter 60, he considered denying that the Book of Revelation is canonical, as a heresy, and in chapter 69, he considered denying the Epistle to the Hebrews to be attributed to St. Paul the Apostle as a heresy.

St. Philastrius book was first printed in the city of Basle in northwestern Switzerland in 1539 AD. It was followed by several important editions by Fabricius in 1721 AD, including some improvement on the text with some essential comments; and another by Galeardus in the year 1738 AD. St. Augustine and St. Ambrose met with him in Milan around the year 384 AD. St. Philastrius reposed in the year 397 AD, before his bishop Ambrose, who ordained his disciple Guadentius to sit on the throne of Brescia in his place.

[H. Wace and W. Piercy: *A Dictionary of Early Christian Biography*, 1999]
[Butler: July 18]

PHILEMON AND APPHIA, SS.

Philemon was a wealthy man citizen of Colossae in Phrygia in Asia Minor. He converted to Christianity, most probably, in the hands of Paul the Apostle. He became a close friend with St. Paul when the apostle was preaching in Ephesus. Philemon dedicated his house to hold the assemblies of the new believer's community.

Onesimus was one of Philemon's slaves, who somehow robbed him, not learning much of the ideal example of life in his master's house. Then, he fled to Rome. There, somehow he got arrested for another robbery he committed. He completed up in prison and met with St. Paul, the Apostle, who was a prisoner in the same jail at the time. Because of the love and compassion of the apostle, the life of the robber slave changed drastically, and he became the apostle's spiritual son.

The apostle intended to keep Onesimus to serve him, but because Philemon sued his slave in court, the apostle had to send him back to his master. St. Paul sent with Onesimus a message to Philemon, which was included in the New Testament under the title: "An Epistle to Philemon." In that letter, the apostle wrote Philemon with tenderness, yet with conviction, he called him "*our beloved friend and fellow laborer*" and called his wife, Apphia "*the beloved Apphia*." Then, he sought from Philemon to forgive Onesimus and to receive him "*no longer as a slave, but more than a slave – a beloved brother, especially to me, but how much more to you, both in the*

flesh and in the Lord” (Philemon 16). We do not know how Philemon responded to Paul's request, but according to the Christian tradition, Philemon granted Onesimus his freedom and forgave him for his crime. Also, according to the tradition, Philemon came to be a bishop either on Colossae or Gaza, and he was martyred either in Colossae or Ephesus.

During the reign of Emperor Nero (54-68 AD), in the feast of the goddess Diana, the pagans attacked the church, arrested Philemon and Apphia, and by order of governor Artoclis, they were scourged, buried up to their waists and stoned to death. In that way, they received the crowns of martyrdom.

The Coptic Church celebrates their martyrdom on the 25th of Amshir.

[Butler: November 22]

PHILEMON, THE FLUTE PLAYER (The martyr)

When Arianus, the governor of Ansenah (Antinoe) ordered the arrest of all Christians in the city, 37 people were brought for trial. Among them was a deacon called Apollonius, who was terrified once he saw the tools of torture. He gave four pieces of gold to a Flute-player called Philemon, to go in his place to sacrifice to the idols. The artist exchanged clothes with him, gave him his flute, and introduced himself to the court of justice.

Philemon Believes in the Lord Christ:

It so happened that the grace of God came upon Philemon, the flute-player, and he cried out before the governor, saying: “I am a Christian and will not sacrifice to the idols.” They threatened him of horrible torture, then thought of calling the real Philemon the flute-player to play before him, hoping that the sweet tunes of music might soften the attitude of that stubborn rebel. Searching for the artist in vain, the governor called his brother Theonas and asked him about his brother. Then, when he uncovered his brother's face, he said to the governor: “Here he is in front of you.” On observing that, the governor assumed that he was making fun. However, Philemon proclaimed: “No, I am not making fun. Do whatever you choose, for the grace of the Lord Christ covered me up and converted me.”

The Baptism of Philemon:

The governor decided to kill Philemon but had a fear of the people who loved him dearly.

Remembering that he was not yet baptized, Philemon raised his eyes and hands toward heaven and prayed to God to grant him the Holy Baptism. His prayer was received, he instantly disappeared from the scene, then appeared

already baptized, to the amazement of those present. When the governor tried to stir up his love for his art, Philemon asked the Lord to send fire from heaven to burn his flute. A ball of fire came from above and consumed the musical instrument.

The Governor Loses an Eye:

The governor ordered three of his men to beat Philemon and Apollonius with extreme ferocity. Then, he ordered them to pierce their heels and place ropes through them to drag them along the streets. Then, to aim arrows at them while hanging upside down. While Philemon and Apollonius prayed to the Lord from the depth of their hearts, the arrows bounced back off them, and one of them struck the governor's eye. Here, the furious governor told the saints: "With the sorcery you learned, please bring my eyesight back to me." St. Philemon answered him: "If you ask from the Lord my God and promise not to refer your healing to sorcery; you may go after my death to my grave, take some dirt, make a paste, put it on your eye and you will regain your eyesight."

Governor Arianus Accepts the Faith:

After the heads of Philemon and Apollonius were cut off, and they were buried, Arianus hastened to their graves and did according to the instructions of St. Philemon. Instantly, he regained his eyesight, entered into the city, crying out: "I can see! I am a Christian." The multitudes who came to hear what he said, they exhumed the bodies of the saints, washed, shrouded, and buried them anew. On the same day, Arianus released the Christian prisoners, as a token of his conversion.

On hearing about it, Emperor Diocletian (284-305 AD) who happened to be in Alexandria at the time, called Arianus for trial. Then, he ordered to tie his hands and feet, put a millstone around his neck and cast him in a deep well, then fill the well with dirt; but God saved him, and he came out of it unharmed. The guards who saw that proclaimed Christian faith and confessed the Name of the Lord Christ before Diocletian, who ordered to put them along with Arianus in sacks and cast them into the sea, where they all drowned and received the crowns of martyrdom. After a little while, the sacks miraculously floated and were taken out by believers, who, in secret, buried the bodies of the saints with lit candles and happiness in the year 305 AD.

The church celebrates the saint's martyrdom on the 7th of Baramhat.

[The two saints: Philemon, the flute-player and Arianus the governor]

PHILEMON, ST.

About this saint who was advanced in age, it came in the book of *Lives of Illustrious Men* by St. Jerome: “We saw that great yet humble saint, who while ministering the Holy Liturgies, used to see an angel stand on the right hand of the altar. He used to keep a record of those who had the Holy Sacraments, and it was said that whoever had it without true repentance would soon die.

He was attacked by demons, who inflicted him with severe illnesses to make him unable to stand to minister the Holy Liturgy, but an angel of the Lord came, held his hand, and restored his strength. The brethren saw the traces of the demonic attacks on his body.”

PHILEMON, THE PRIEST, FR.

On the 18th of Kiahk, the Church celebrates this recluse saint.

PHILIP AND HIS COMPANIONS (The martyrs)

On the first of Hator, the church celebrates the martyrdom of St. Maximus, St. Numitius, St. Boctor (Victor), and St. Philip (Philopus). They were martyred in the days of Emperor Decius (249-251 AD). Their biography could be found under the Letter [B]: “Boctor, the Roman martyr.”

[The Synaxarion: 1 Hator]

PHILIP SIDETES, THE CHURCH HISTORIAN

Philip (Phillippus) was born in Sidon in Pamphylia in Asia Minor, around the year 380 AD. He was ordained by St. John Chrysostom as a deacon in Constantinople, where they became close friends. Later on, he was ordained as a priest.

After the death of Atticus of Constantinople (406-425 AD) in the year 425, Philip the priest was recommended in 426 AD for the patriarchate of Constantinople and he was supported by many people [Socrates 7:27]. However, when Sisinnius was preferred over him, it caused him deep humiliation, which was reflected in his attacks on Sisinnius and those who chose him. According to Socrates, the accusations he presented carried such bitterness and aggression, and it was not befitting for him to include them in his book about “The Christian History.”

Philip was nominated again for the patriarchate position, after the repose of Sisinnius I (426-428 AD) in the year 428 AD, and a third time after

sending Nestorius (428-431 AD) away because of his heresy¹ in the year 431 AD. However, he was not chosen in any of them.

Christian History:

Philip earned great fame by his work "The Christian History," which he authored between the years 434 and 439 AD. This work included 36 books covering about 1,000 chapters. However, only a few bits and pieces have survived. Luckily, both Socrates (380-439 AD) and Photius (820-891 AD) have given the following important information about it:

- 4- That work included a history from the creation of the world until the year 426 AD.
- 5- Besides history, he branched into diverse subjects such as Algebra, Astrology, Arithmetic, Music, and Geography, which weakened the history coverage and lessened its importance.
- 6- Socrates showed some historical errors, in which Philip fell, concerning the chronicle order of events.

Tillemont (1637-1698) believed that Philip was trying to imitate St. John Chrysostom in his eloquence (and not in his virtues), and he ended up with feeble imitation.

His Other Writings:

According to Socrates, Philip wrote several other works, including some in refuting the writings of Emperor Julian the Apostate (360-363 AD) against the Christians.

PHILIP ST. MAQAR, THE PRIEST

This father was born in the last quarter of the 19th century in the city of Tahta, in Upper Egypt. He became a monk in the monastery of St. Maqar in the wilderness of Scetis. Then, he went to Jerusalem, along with his father of confession hegomen Tadros St. Maqar. There, they dwelt close to the river Jordan. On observing the multitude of pilgrims coming to get into the water of the Jordan river for blessing, then they would struggle to find any place to change their clothes in; Fr. Philip sought from the Lord, who provided him with money to build two rooms on the river for that purpose.

After the repose of hegomen Tadros St. Maqar, Fr. Philip went to Jericho, where he purchased a house. He discovered later on that it was the residence of Zacchaeus (Luke 19:1-10) the tax-collector, whom the Lord visited. It so

¹ "Nestorianism" refers to the doctrine that there are two distinct hypostases in the Incarnate Christ, the one Divine and the other human.

happened one day, when he returned home from the market, that he found three persons inside the house. Enquiring from them the reason they were there, they asked him to dig in one of the rooms to find a treasure, and then they disappeared. He knew that they were angels. By digging for the treasure, he found the body remains of 6 saints, among whom was that of the apostle St. Thaddaeus. He also found plenty of gold and silver; as well as a tablet on which it was written the history of the house and that the house belonged to Zacchaeus the tax-collector. This tablet was written in Arabic, Hebrew, and Greek.

Fr. Philip's ministry and his holy zeal were very obvious. He built a large church and a guest house for the metropolitan of Jerusalem to welcome his guests. He planted a vast garden on a plot of land he purchased, and he filled it with various fruits and vegetables. He also used to hold big banquets on different occasions, particularly on the day the Lord Christ visited the house of Zacchaeus and offered to his guest's water to drink from the well from which the Lord Himself drank. His asceticism grew the more his wealth did, and he cared for the poor and the needy, always saying that he was no more than a mailman for the Lord; nothing of what he has was his.

His contemporary, Fr. Boules Abba Bishoi tried in vain for eight years, to learn about his private worship. However, he found out that St. Philip St. Maqar was so good in hiding his relationship with God as required in the commandment of the Lord Christ.

Fr. Philip was chosen as the father of confession for most of the monks in Jerusalem. He also found pleasure in reconciling controversies among people as a man of peace. He was characterized by simplicity and humility. Abouna Boules Abba Bishoi said that he used to take his headcover off, throw it on the ground, and when he was leaving, he would put it back on without even cleaning the dust off it; and that he always used to serve himself.

He lived until he reached 100 years of age, then he reposed in peace at the end of the 1970s.

[A Contemporary Saint: Abouna Philip St. Maqar]

PHILIP, THE APOSTLE (The martyr)

St. Philip the Apostle was one of the 12 apostles. He was born in Bethsaida (John 1:44). It seems that since his youth, he was studying the Holy Bible that he responded so quickly to the call of the Lord, the moment He said to him, "*Follow Me.*" Also, in his talk to Nathanael, he told him: "*We have found Him of whom Moses in the law and also the prophets wrote – Jesus of Nazareth.*" (John 1:45), which would indicate his anticipation of the

coming of Christ.

He was not mentioned much in the gospels. His name was mentioned in the miracle of feeding the thousands from the five loaves and the two fishes; when the Lord tested him by saying, *“Where shall we buy bread that these may eat?”* Philip responded to the Lord, saying: *“Two hundred denarii worth of bread is not sufficient for them, that every one of them may have a little”* (John 6:5-7). Also, his name was also mentioned in the day following the Palm Sunday, when some of the Greeks, among whom those who came up to worship at the feast, sought from him to see Jesus (John 12:21). His name also was mentioned during the events of the Last Supper, in the talk recorded by St. John, when he said to the Lord: *“Lord, Show us the Father, and it is sufficient for us.”* The Lord answered him by saying: *“Have I been with you so long, and yet you have not known Me, Philip?. He who has seen Me has seen the Father; so, how can you say: Show us the Father? Do you not believe that I am in the Father, and the Father in Me?”* (John 14:8-10). He carried the good news of salvation to Persia and Asia Minor, the region of Phrygia in particular. He ended up in the city of Hierapolis, near Colossae and Laodicea in Phrygia in Asia Minor, where he was martyred crucified upside-down, on the hands of the pagans.

Some researchers mix this St. Philip with Philip the Preacher, who was one of the seven deacons chosen by the early Church (Acts 6:3).

[The Church in the Time of the Apostles, p. 321]

PHILIP THE BISHOP AND HIS COMPANIONS (The martyrs)

He was the bishop of the city of Heraclea, the capital of the province of Thrace. He was martyred during the persecution stirred up by Emperor Diocletian (284-305 AD). As the region was ruled by governor Bassus whose wife was Christian, he had no desire to persecute the Christians with as much cruelty and violence as requested by the imperial orders. So, the Christians continued to assemble without the interference of the authorities, even a year after the commands of persecution were issued.

His Upbringing:

St. Philip, bishop of Heraclea was a venerable older man, who started his ministry as a deacon, then as a priest, before he sat on the seat as a bishop. He shepherded his congregation with faithfulness and virtue when it was shaken by the tempest of persecution. In his ministry, he cared for his spiritual children that two of the most prominent of his disciples accompanied him to martyrdom, and they all received the crowns of

martyrdom together. The first disciple was Severus, the priest, and the second one was Hermes, the deacon. Hermes has initially been the judge of the city, yet after he was engaged in the ministry of the church, he earned his living by working with his own hands; and he raised his son on doing the same.

Refusing to Forsake his People:

When Diocletian issued his orders against the Christians, in the feast of the Epiphany, many felt that there was a high pressure on the governor Bassus to execute the imperial creeds, so they advised the bishop to leave the city, but he refused to forsake his people. He said that God would find a way to get rid of the enemies of the church, and he continued to encourage his children on perseverance and abidance.

The Bishop Arrested:

When the soldiers of the governor came and closed the doors of the church and sealed it, the bishop said to their leader: "God does not dwell between walls, but rather in the hearts of men." He continued to pray with his people outside the church. After a little while, Bassus came to visit the city of Heraclea and saw how bishop Philip was assembling with his people to minister the Divine Liturgy outside the church. The governor brought before him some of them accused of breaking the law. He asked them: "Who among you is the leader?" Philip came forward and proclaimed himself. The governor asked him: "You know that the emperor banned your assemblies. Now, hand me the golden and silver vessels you use in the service and the books in which you read." The bishop replied: "We shall hand you the vessels, for God is not glorified by the precious metals, but by the works of mercy and love. As for the Bibles, you have no right to seek, and we have no right to deliver them to you."

Bassus tortures Philip:

The governor ordered his men to torture the bishop who endured with courage. Here, Hermes bravely approached the governor, saying: "It is not in your authority to destroy the word of God, even if you take all the written books." The governor ordered to scourge him, then brought Philip and all the prisoners to the arena, where a pagan priest came to offer a sacrifice to the idols. Bassus attempted to force Philip on taking part in their ritual, but the bishop told him that his idols were helpless to help or to harm anyone. The governor attempted to convince Hermes to participate, but the saint proclaimed that he was a Christian and would never sacrifice to the idols. Bassus ordered his men to cast them all in prison. On their way, the pagan mobs kept pushing Philip around until he fell to the ground. On standing

aright with a smile on his face, Philip impressed those around him with his perseverance and humility. The martyrs walked singing hymns of praise to God until they arrived at the prison.

Torturing the Bishop in the days of Justin:

In the meantime, Bassus ended his term in service and was replaced by governor Justin. That change brought much grief on the Christians, because governor Bassus tended to use logic and reason in his dealing with them; while Justin, on the other hand, was violent and brought Philip before him for retrial. He read the commands of the emperor to him and attempted to force him to sacrifice to the idols. The saint answered him: "I am a Christian, and cannot do what you require. Your commission is to punish our refusal, not to force our compliance." When Justin threatened to torture him, he answered: "You may torment me, but will not conquer me: no power can induce me to sacrifice." Here, the governor ordered his men to tie his feet and drag him on the rocky path through the streets of the city, until he was torn and bruised all over his body. Then, he was carried by the Christian prisoners into the prison.

The soldiers searched for a long time for Severus, the priest who hid, but, by guidance from the Holy Spirit, he finally delivered himself to them, and was led to prison. There Philip, Severus, and Hermes remained for seven months imprisoned in filthy surroundings until they were brought again before Justin. The governor ordered the beating of Philip until his flesh was torn off. His endurance of torture amazed his executioners, including Justin himself, who sent him back to prison. When it was the turn of Hermes, he was first treated with tenderness, because of his prior position as the judge of Heraclea, and for his great popularity, but after seeing how he remained persistent in his faith, he was sent again to prison.

After three days, Justin tried them in vain again before his tribunal; then he ordered to burn Philip and Hermes alive, to make them an example to the others. Philip's feet were so sore that he could not walk, and therefore he was carried to execution. Hermes followed him with much difficulty, being also afflicted in his feet, and he said to him: "Master, let us hasten to go to our Lord. Why should we be concerned about our feet, which we shall need no more in a little while?" Then he said to the multitude that followed them: "The Lord revealed to me that I must suffer. In a night vision, I saw a dove as white as snow, which entered into the chamber, rested on my head, and descending upon my chest presented me some meat, which was very agreeable to the taste. I knew that it was the Lord that called me, and was pleased to honor me with martyrdom."

When they arrived at the arena of martyrdom in the city of Orianopolis, the two saints were put into a pit up to their knees, with their hands tied

behind their backs; and just before the fire was set on, Hermes called one of his Christian friends and said to him: “I implore you by the name of our Lord Jesus Christ, to go to tell my son to pay back all my commitments, which I might have forgotten, according to the laws of this world. Tell him to work with his hands as he saw me do, to earn his living, and to treat all the people well.” When the soldiers set the fire on, the two saints kept praising God and giving Him thanks, until they could no more talk. That took place on the 22nd of October, 304 AD. God kept their bodies unharmed; that St. Philip, an older man, seemed as though he was restored to his youth, with his hands spread as though in prayer. When Justin ordered casting the bodies into the river, some believers came with boats and caught them with a net. When the priest Severus, who was left alone in prison, was told about the martyrdom of the bishop and the deacon; he exulted with joy that they received the crowns of martyrdom, and kept on supplicating to the Lord to find him worthy of getting the same glory, having confessed His Holy name together with them before. The Lord listened to him, and he was martyred on the next day.

[Butler: October 22]

PHILIP, THE DEACON

This St. Philip was from Caesarea of Palestine, and when the Lord Christ crossed through that region and taught there, once the saint heard His teachings, he instantly followed Him. This saint was one of the 70 apostles chosen by the Lord and was sent to preach and heal the sick. Then, he was selected as one of the seven deacons chosen by the apostles for ministry (Acts 6:3). He taught in the cities of Samaria and baptized Simon the sorcerer, who wanted to pay money to buy the gift of the Holy Spirit. He was also the one who baptized the Eunuch, under Candace, the queen of Ethiopia (Acts 8:26-40). He preached in the land of Asia and had four daughters who also preached along with him. They brought so many Jews and Samaritans to faith. Then, St. Philip reposed in peace.

[The Synaxarion: 14 Baba]

PHILIP (The martyr)

This St. Philip was the brother of St. Abakir, the martyr. The Church celebrates their martyrdom on the 14th of Paona. Their biographies could be found under the Letter “A”: **(Abakir and his Companions)**

PHILO, THE PERSIAN BISHOP

St. Philo was the bishop of Persia, who was martyred on the hand of the king of Persia for refusing to worship the fire and the sun. After being tortured with every kind of tools, they cut his head off by the sword, and he received the crown of martyrdom.

[The Synaxarion: 10 Amshir]

PHILOGONIUS, THE PATRIARCH, ST.

In his early life, St. Philogonius was married, had a daughter, and made for himself a prominent name as a lawyer. When his wife died, he entered into monastic life and became a monk. After the repose of St. Vitalis, the bishop of Antioch (314-320), St. Philogonius was chosen to take his place (320-323) because of his growing virtues broad knowledge, asceticism and piety. He shepherded the flock of Christ in the best way possible, and he guarded them against the Arians and the followers of Macedonius¹ and Sabellius² heresies.

As a Patriarch, he lived an ascetic life, acquiring for himself no money nor an extra garment. According to St. John Chrysostom (349-407), the tranquility and flourishing through which the church of Antioch passed during St. Philogonius time, was evidence of his zealously and exalted guidance.

Yet, during the period of storms, through which the church passed through the problematic reigns of Emperors Maximinus II (311-313 AD), and Licinius I (308-324 AD), St. Philogonius confessed the good confession of faith, and he was arrested and imprisoned. He reposed in the year 324 AD.

On the 20th of December 386 AD, his feast was celebrated in Antioch. In that celebration, St. John Chrysostom talked about his virtues and referred to how the saint came to enjoy a condition of peace up there in Heaven, where there are no controversies or persecution, no one would say You or Me. These words fill the world with wars, families with disputes, and individuals with hate. The Coptic Church celebrates this saint on the 24th of Kiahk.

[Butler: December 20]

¹ Macedonianism is the belief that the Holy Spirit was created by the Son and was thus subordinate to the Father and the Son.

² Sabellianism is the belief that the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit are three different modes of God.

PHILOPATER MERCURIUS (ABU-SAYFAYN The martyr)

St. Mercurius is called in Egypt, “Abu-Sayfayn,” which means “The One with Two Swords.” This naming was used because an angel of the Lord appeared to him and gave him an extra sword that was behind the secret of his power, in addition to the regular military sword which he had.

St. Mercurius was born in the year 224 AD to a pagan Macedonian family of hunters. He was named Philopater, which means: “The Lover of the Father.” His father, Jairus (Gordianus), also worked as a Roman officer.

Jairus, the Beast Hunter:

His father Jairus (Gordianus), and his grandfather Vairus being both beast hunters, earned their living by selling the captured lions and tigers to the kings and princes for proper compensations. One day, they were in the forest waiting in hiding after setting their nets with bells to ring in case they would catch one of those wild animals. After a long time, they finally heard the bells ring, and they hurried to the nets, to be surprised to see two strange-looking beasts caught in the nets, yet managed to tear them off and got ready to attack their hunters. The beasts got the grandfather Vairus and Jairus fell unconscious, not able to see his father being devoured by the animals. Immensely terrified to open his eyes and see the two beasts coming toward him, he suddenly heard a voice from heaven saying: “Jesus Christ is capable of taking the wild nature away from the two beasts to become like meek lambs.” He heard the Lord Himself say: “Jairus! I am the Lord Jesus Christ, your God who loved and saved you from these two beasts. I call you to the light of faith; to become a chosen vessel for me; and your son will be for me a fruitful tree, to carry my name before many kings and governors. He will endure so many sufferings for the sake of My Name. Do not fear nor be disturbed, because I shall be for you a shield and rescue.” Returning home after an absence of three days, he told his wife about what happened, and to his surprise, she said to him that she has already heard the voice and received an invitation from the Lord Christ to believe in Him.

Jairus and his Entire Household Baptized:

They were all baptized by the hands of the local bishop who gave them new names: Jairus he called Noah and Philopater, his son Mercurius. From that time on, the family led a pious life and followed the commandments of the Lord, in particular in alms-giving.

Noah took as a Captive:

When the news of their baptism spread around, the governor summoned

them, and he ordered to cast them before wild beasts. The Lord turned those beasts into peaceful lambs, to the amazement of the governor who sought Jairus (Noah) forgiveness and appointed him as a leader of the army.

It happened later that, when the Barbarians attacked the Romans, Noah and his men fought against them. However, the Barbarians managed to take Jairus as a captive and kept him for a whole year and six months. During that time, he found favor in the sight of their king that he gave him a lot of authority in his kingdom. After a while, God allowed for his return back to his town to join his family again. But after a little while, he reposed in peace in the Lord.

Abu Sayfayn (The One with Two Swords):

After the departure of Noah, the father of the saint, Emperor Decius (249-251 AD), appointed his son Mercurius in his place. As a 20-year-old soldier, Mercurius distinguished himself in the Roman war in Armenia, fighting under the command of Saturninus (Sardonicus or Bartonikos in Coptic). Then, it happened that the Barbarians attacked Rome and threatened it. On observing how the emperor was disturbed by that attack, Mercurius assured the emperor that victory was on their side, and he was placed in charge of the leadership of the imperial army. Here, an angel of the Lord appeared to St. Mercurius; he was clothed in beautiful light, carrying a glittering sword in his right hand and called his name saying: “Mercurius, the servant of Jesus Christ, do not fear or have your heart weakened; but have courage. Take this sword from my hand and use it in fighting the Barbarians, but when you win, do not forget your Lord God. I am Michael the Archangel, sent by the Lord to tell you what is prepared for you. You will endure great suffering in the Name of the Lord Jesus Christ, but be sure that I shall never forsake you. I shall encourage you until you consummate your testimony, and the whole world will hear about your strife and perseverance, and the Lord Christ will be glorified in you.”

The saint took the sword from the hand of the angel with joy. Once he took hold of it, he felt filled with a Divine strength. Then, with the two swords (his own and the one the angel gave him) he defeated the Barbarians.

An Imperial Decree:

At that time, God granted Philopater the conquest over the enemies; the devil stirred up a war against the Church. Filling the emperor's heart with evil, Decius sent a decree all over the empire, in which he said: “From Decius Emperor of Rome to the whole empire: As the gods of our fathers and ancestors gave us victory over our enemies, it is the duty of all of us to worship them and to burn incense before them. I gave my orders that

whoever obeys my command will be honored, and whoever disobeys them will be tortured and killed by the sword.”

Once that decree reached all over the empire, while some Christians denied their faith, so many others held fast to it, testified to the Lord, were cast in prison, and endured torture, and many were martyred.

The Celebrations by the Victorious Army:

After that great victory over the Barbarians, when Mercurius refused to accompany those who went to offer sacrifices to Artemis, the moon goddess, Emperor Decius summoned him. Mercurius threw down his arms and military attire at the emperor's feet, saying: “I shall never deny my God Jesus Christ.” The emperor ordered to put him under arrest and subject him to a series of tortures. He was nailed by his arms and legs over a fire, but his blood extinguished the fire. Then, he was cast into prison.

The Divine Help amid the Sufferings:

God sent his Archangel Michael to the saint, who healed his wounds, encouraged him and gave him peace. The next morning, on seeing him sound and recovered, the angry emperor ordered putting him on an iron bed over a fire. Then, he was hung upside down with a stone hung around his neck to hasten his death and was beaten with cords and burnt with a red-hot iron, but the Archangel Michael appeared again and healed all his wounds. Having fear from the people of Rome, Decius sent the saint to Caesarea of Cappadocia, with orders to cut his neck off after brutally scourging him. He wrote his case as such: “As Mercurius, the supreme commander of the army, refused to worship the honored gods and disobeyed the imperial commands, we order to send him to Caesarea of Cappadocia, to have his head cut off there.”

His Martyrdom:

Arriving at the arena of martyrdom, the saint stretched his hands and stood praying to the Lord Christ to receive his soul. While he was praying, he saw a great light and the Lord Christ in his glory, surrounded by his angels, standing before him, giving him peace and blessing him. The saint worshipped the Lord, sought from the soldiers to hasten, put their orders into action, and delivered his neck to the swordsman to cut it off. This happened on the 25th of Hator 250. At the moment of his execution, the saint's body turned white and emitted heavenly fragrances, and God performed many miracles through his body.

After the end of the time of martyrdom, God allowed for the appearance of the body of the saint, which was carried by the people with great honor to

the church in Caesarea, where they buried it with great honor.

St. Basil Seeks His Help:

According to the Eastern tradition, St. Basil of Caesarea (330-379) sought the intercession of this saint to stop the tyranny of Emperor Julian the Apostate (360-363). While that emperor was fighting in Persia, the saint appeared to him in the form of a soldier with a sword and a spear. Then, the saint fatally stabbed him with the spear. Before going to Persia, the emperor cast St. Basil into prison, and one day while St. Basil was praying before the icon of St. Mercurius (which he carried with him wherever he went, because of his great love for that saint); and he sought the intercession of the saint. Then, it happened that the image of the martyr disappeared from the icon, and after a little while, it came back with his spear covered with blood. In Old Cairo, there is a convent for nuns in the name of Abu-Sayfayn, to which thousands of the suffering souls take refuge, to enjoy the Divine blessings of the saint.

[The Great Martyr Abu-Sayfayn; St. Gerge Church, Sporting, Alexandria]
[The Coptic Encyclopedia: Mercurius of Caesarea, St., by Michel Van Esbroeck;
pp. 1592-4]
[Butler: November 25]

PHILOROMUS (The martyr)

St. Philoromus was one of the prominent people of the city of Thmuis (Tell el-Timai) on the east side of the Nile delta in Egypt. He was a Christian military tribune, and he defended St. Philaeas, the bishop of his city when he rejected the appeals of his relatives and friends in trying to save him. Then, they both offered themselves to death and were martyred in the year 303 AD, during the persecution stirred up by Emperor Diocletian (284-305 AD). So they earned immortal palms from God. With them was crowned with martyrdom a countless multitude of the faithful of the same place, who followed the example of their pastor. The western church celebrates him on the 4th of Feb.

[A Dictionary of Christian Biography, Vol. IV, p. 390]

PHILOTHEUS AND HIPPARCHUS (The martyrs)

These saints were martyred in Samosata in Asia Minor¹. This happened when Emperor Galerius (E: 305-311) was in the city holding a festival on the

¹ In the year 297 AD, according to the *Penguin Dictionary of Saints*.

banks of the river Euphrates, to celebrate his victory on Persia. When the two saints, who were among the elites of the city, refused to partake of offering thanksgiving sacrifices to the gods, they were arrested. Then, the saints were scourged and imprisoned for six weeks. Yet, when all that did not make them deny their faith, they were condemned to be crucified, along with five other young men, who came to believe in the Lord Christ. Hipparchus, who was bold-headed, was asked to sacrifice to the idols as the last chance to escape execution, but he mockingly answered them: "Not before hair grow again on my head." The emperor, mockingly put a goat hide on his head before giving the order to crucify them all. Their martyrdom probably was not at the time of Emperor Galerius but during the reign of Emperor Maximinus Daia (311-313 AD)¹.

[The Penguin Dictionary of Saints, p. 168]

PHILOTHEUS EL- BAGHDADY SALEĤ, FR.

This father was one of the prominent priests who supported the 111th Pope Demetrius II (1862-1870) in his strife to preserve the orthodox faith and in the progress of teaching the Christian religion.

Fr. Philotheus was born in the city of Tanta in the year 1837, and he was educated in a Coptic primary school. Besides the Arabic language, he mastered the Coptic and the Italian languages. When khedive Saâid Pasha (1854-1863) visited Tanta, the Coptic archons met him and sought from him to allow them to build a church because their church was too old to use; and the khedive gave them the permission. However, because the local authorities created obstacles at the time of the new church construction. Muâallem (archon) Philotheus Ghali SaleĤ and muâallem Āawad Salib were chosen to go and complain about the situation to Saâid Pasha. With the help of muâallem Philotheus Bishai, the clerk of the khedive, they succeeded in their mission.

Fr. Philotheus joined public service for two years in the province of Rawdat el-Baĥrayn, which comprised at that time the Gharbiyyah and Minufiyyah governorates. When muâallem Philotheus went to Cairo to seek the blessings of the 110th Pope Kyrillos IV (1854-1861) with his friend Āeryan Jirgis Muftaĥ, the pope admired his wisdom and sought from him to join the teaching staff of the great Coptic Church; and he obeyed. Pope Kyrillos IV appointed him as the principal of the school, which he established in the city of El-Mansurah, but he had to leave it after the repose

¹ In the year 308 AD, according to the Penguin Dictionary of Saints.

of the pope.

He returned to Cairo to teach Coptic in the school of Haret el-Saqqayin. In the meantime, he taught both Coptic and Coptic theology in the newly established Coptic Clerical College, founded by pope Kyrillos IV. He also was assisting Aeryan Jirgis Muftah, who was teaching at the same College.

Ordaining him as a Priest:

He was ordained as a priest in Tanta in the year 1863, where he co-operated with Fr. Tadros Aawad Salib el-Berawi. Having been very eloquent in giving sermons, his fame spread out all over Egypt and beyond, as far as Sudan, the Holy Land, Beirut, and Damascus. Pope Demetrius II called upon him to accompany him on his trip to Upper Egypt in the year 1867 and owing to his extraordinary eloquence as a preacher. He was solicited to extend his visit to Upper Egypt to combat the proselytizing movements or the Protestant missionaries. There, he showed excellent capabilities in sermons and in defending the doctrines of the Coptic Church.

In the year 1874, El-Magles el-Melly (The Coptic Community Council) chose him to be the overseer of the Great St. Mark Cathedral in Cairo and the principal of the school of the monks. He had numerous activities and authored so many books. He used to represent the 112th Pope Kyrillos V (1874-1927) in welcoming the state officials. They admired him for his eloquence, proper behavior, and broad knowledge. Fr. Philotheus was respected by Copts and Muslims alike. He was decorated by khedive Tewfiq Pasha (1879-1892) and khedive Abbas Helmy II (1892-1914). He also was honored by the emperors of Ethiopia that the Nagashi Johanna in the year 1882, sent him a message addressed to: "The great Father, upright in faith and conscience, a treasure of wisdom, wide in knowledge, the longsuffering shepherd and the keeper of the faithfulness of Alexandria," and, he sought his prayers. Fr. Philotheus, later on, got another message from Nagashi Filik, asking him to send him his books to have them translated into the Ethiopian language; and he decorated him with the Star of Ethiopia in the year 1902. Among the most remarkable letters he got, was one from St. Abba Abram, the bishop of El-Fayyum; and another from hegomen St. Abdel-Messih el-Massady.

When there appeared controversy between pope Kyrillos V and El-Magles el-Melly; hegomen Philotheus forsook the general issues of the church and confined his work to the priestly shepherding. He reposed in the Lord in the 1st day of Baramhat 1629 AM (10 March 1904).

[The Orthodox and Spiritual Coptic Church, pp. 129-130]

[The Coptic Encyclopedia: Philuthawus Ibrahim Al-Baghdadi; by Mounir Shoucri; pp. 1962-3]

PHILOTHEUS, the 63rd POPE OF ALEXANDRIA

This pope was chosen from among the monks of St. Maqar's monastery. He was ordained in the year 979 AD. He was a contemporary of the Fatimid caliph Al-Āaziz be-Allah (975-996 AD). There was not much worth mentioning in the biography of this pope, and although for about eight years, he was a contemporary of the tyrant caliph Al-Ĥakim be-Amr Allah (996-1021 AD), yet was never said that he suffered much on his hands.

A Divine Chastisement against Him:

According to the "History of the Patriarchs," he had a bad ending; on account of that, he did not live the ascetic life befitting to his rank as a monk and as a Patriarch. Then, it happened that he came to the St. Mark Cathedral in Alexandria, along with many bishops, and he entered into the altar to consecrate the Sacraments. During the Liturgy, once he raised the Corban, he fell silent and could not utter a word, and then he sat down. Abba Marcos, bishop of Bahnassa, completed the Liturgy; and they carried the patriarch to a nearby house of a Coptic archon, where he kept silent for nine hours. Asked about what happened, he at first ceased from answering. Still, under pressure he said that when he raised the Corban and before making the sign of the Cross on it, he saw the eastern wall of the altar open up, a hand came out of it, made the sign of the Cross on the Corban, which caused it to split in his hand; and he fell silent. When he said that, a particular member of his body dried up, and it stayed that way. After a little while, that Patriarch reposed in the year 1003 AD, after sitting on the Patriarchal throne for more than 24 years.

The Spread of the Simonism:

Unfortunately, during his days, he did not object to his people having concubines, while his predecessor did oppose it and shamed it. Also, the Simonism has spread quite a bit in his reign; and no one was to be ordained to the rank of a bishop before paying the patriarch a significant sum of money. It was said that four brothers within his family members got through him a great inheritance, and they divided it among themselves. However, that money soon depleted, and according to his biographer, he saw one of the brothers begging for money. The saints among his contemporaries were: Al-Wadeh ibn Abu el-Ragaa, the confessor, and the martyr (Mar) Guirgis el-Mozahem.

The Metropolitan of Ethiopia;

Following a long period of the severed relationship between the Church of

Egypt and that of Ethiopia, Pope Philotheus got a message from the Ethiopian king, through Guirgis, the king of Nubia. In that message, the Nubian king asked the Coptic pope to save Ethiopia from its disintegrating spiritual condition, caused by not having an ordained metropolitan to guide it. In the message, the king admitted that what dwelt on Ethiopia was a Divine chastisement because of the Ethiopian hostility towards the Coptic Church.

The pope hastened to ordain monk Daniel from Abu-Sayfayn monastery, as a metropolitan for Ethiopia. The new metropolitan was received by its legal young king with great honor. At the time, the Ethiopian throne was extorted from that legitimate king by a powerful woman. However, the new metropolitan restored to him the throne of his ancestors, and the people brought down the woman and condemned her to death.

His Writings:

The book **Confessions of the Fathers** included the text of two messages sent by pope Philotheus to Athanasius, the patriarch of Antioch. In the first message, after an introduction full of love and honor, he answered an inquiry from patriarch Athanasius concerning the separation of the Godhead from neither the human soul nor from the human body, when the Lord Christ died on the Cross. He said: "Be aware that God the Son, the Word, by His incarnation, created for Himself a body in the womb of the Virgin St. Mary, He united with it and had a rational uttering soul. It is a perfect human with whom the Word united, in an inseparable Hypostatic union, according to the teaching of St. Gregory of Nyssa in his Passover Mymar: That human, with whom the Word made One with Himself, also had a rational soul. This union has, as one of the wholes, a body subject to passion and death; for the Godhead and the human soul are not prone to passion, and they are not mortal.

Claiming that the Godhead has undergone suffering or mortality is wrong, corrupt and blasphemy; for the Nature of the Godhead is simply spiritual, superior to the matter, uncomplicated and consequently unlimited or perceived; namely the Nature of the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit; hence, are not prone to suffering or death.

The death of Christ happened only by the separation of His human soul from His human body. However, His Godhead never separated from either of them, not for even a blink of an eye. The Godhead remained with the body on the Cross and in the grave; as it remained with the soul when it went down to the world of the righteous spirits. St. Gregory of Nyssa also said in his Christmas Mymar: During the time of suffering, the Godhead did abandon neither the body nor the human soul, with which He perpetually is united. It is He who opened the gates of Paradise before the right-hand thief, and both

the body and the soul were capable at the same time.”

Pope Philotheus ended his message by giving honor to the delegation sent by patriarch Athanasius with the message and informed him that he had issued a decree to all the churches of Egypt to keep including his name in the supplications, in every Holy Liturgy as they used to do.

He also sent a second message to the Patriarch of Antioch, which included most of the first message with the addition of His Upright Belief in the mystery of the Holy Trinity and the Unity of its Essence.

[The Patriotism and History of the Coptic Church, p. 105]

[Fr. Manasseh Johanna: The History of the Coptic Church]

[The Coptic Encyclopedia: Philotheus, by Subhi Y. Labib; pp. 1959-60]

PHILOTHEUS (The martyr)

Longing to Know God:

This saint was born in Antioch to pagan parents who gave him the name Philotheos meaning (the lover of God). As his parents worshipped a calf they called Zabargad when their son reached ten years old, they told him to worship the calf, but when he refused to do, his father, out of love for him being his only son, let him have his way, and he did not want of offending him.

The boy, because of his young age and lack of knowledge, thinking that the sun was God, he stood before it one day, and asked it: “I implore you, O sun! If you are God, tell me.” There, a voice from high above came, saying: “No, I am not God, but I am the slave and servant of God, whom you will get to know, and for whose sake you will have your bloodshed.” When God saw how the boy walked upright, He sent him an angel to provide him with the knowledge about the creation of the world and the incarnation of Jesus for the sake of the salvation of man. Philotheus was so pleased to learn that, and from then on, he prayed to the True God, fasted and gave alms to the needy.

A year later, his parents held a banquet for their friends and sought from their son to worship the calf before the guests would start eating and drinking. The boy stood before the calf and asked him: “Are you a god to be worshipped?” A voice came out of it, saying: “No, I am not a god, but entered in me a demon who leads men astray.” The calf then jumped on the boy's parents and instantly killed them by its horns. The saint ordered his servants to kill the calf, burn it, and scatter its ashes. Then, he prayed for the sake of his parents, and God raised them from the dead. Eventually, the boy and his parents were all baptized.

God Granted him the Gift of Healing the Sick:

Being granted by God, the gift of healing the sick, his fame spread all over the area. So, he was called by Emperor Diocletian (284-305 AD), who treated him first with tenderness and compassion and ordered him to burn incense before the idols, which the boy refused. On torturing him with different tools, the boy persisted on refusing. When finally, the boy promised the emperor to worship Apollon, the emperor, happily ordered bringing the statue of Apollon with seventy other idols and seventy priests. A great multitude of people came from all over the city to watch Philotheus worshipping Apollon. Then, the saint prayed to the Lord Christ, and the earth opened up and swallowed the priests and the idols. At this moment, chaos erupted, and a great crowd believed in the True God. The angry emperor ordered to cut their heads, along with that of St. Philotheus, and all of them received the crowns of martyrdom.

[The Synaxarion: 16 Toba]

PHILOTHEUS (The martyr)

This saint was from the town of Dronka in the province of Assuit. The governor there, attempted in vain to force him to deny his faith in the Lord Christ. When he failed, he ordered to torture him. However, the saint kept reminding himself with the saying of the Lord: “*But he who endures to the end, shall be saved*” (Matt. 10:22, 24:13; Mark 13:13). In this way, his heart became more energetic and was able to endure all those tortures with perseverance and pleasure. They finally cut his head off, and he received the crown of martyrdom in the year 1096 AM (1380 AD) in the time of the Mamluks.

[The Faithful Synaxarion: 3 Mesra]

PHOEBE, THE DEACONESS

Phoebe is almost considered the most famous female mentioned in the Epistles of the Apostles. We know about her only what was written by St. Paul the apostle at the beginning of his last chapter in his epistle to the Church of Rome, and the Church history did not give any more information about her.

The last chapter of the epistle to the Romans is almost dedicated to mentioning the names of some persons to whom the apostle was sending his greetings. On the top of a long list – even before men – Paul mentioned “I

commend to you, ***Phoebe, our sister, who is a servant of the church in Cenchrea***, that you may receive her in the Lord in a manner worthy of the saints, and assist her in whatever business she has need of you; for indeed she has been a helper of many, and of myself also” (Romans 16:1-2).

The name Phoebe means (splendid or enlightened), and from her name, we can deduce that she was a Gentile converted to Christianity. In the Greek legends, Phoebe was the name of Artamis, the goddess of the moon. So, her parents were not Jewish. Her name also indicates that the Gentiles who converted to Christianity were not embarrassed by keeping their original names, before their conversion to the Christian faith. Also, Phoebe was the only woman out of St. Paul’s friends, whom he called “Our sister.”

It seems that Phoebe was a dedicated virgin who carried out an active ministry in the church in the region of Corinth. She was ministering as a deaconess in the church of Cenchrea, one of the ports in the Corinth area of Greece. She was called Diakonos (Διάκονος) by St. Paul, a title given both to men and women. Phoebe must have ministered among women, besides having been the scribe of Paul's dictated epistle to the Romans, which she carried herself to Rome.

It is not reasonable to assume that Phoebe's mission was just to carry the Epistle to Rome, but most probably, the apostle gave her some other mission concerning the preaching, which he did not want to proclaim. However, he urged the Church of Rome to lend her all the assistance she might need.

[Fragrant Bouquets of the Biographies of the Righteous and the Saints, p. 82]

PHOTINA AND HER COMPANIONS (The martyrs)

According to the Roman Tradition, Photina was a Samaritan woman who was martyred along with her two sons Joseph and Victor, the leader Sebastian, Anatolius, Photius, and the three sisters: Photis, Parasceve and Cyriaca when they confessed the Name of the Lord Christ.

According to the Greek Tradition: Photina was the Samaritan woman with whom the Lord Christ talked at the well. After she preached in several locations, she went to Carthage, where she was martyred, after being imprisoned for three years because of her faith. Victor, who was a chief officer in the imperial army, became a governor of France and managed to draw Sebastian to the true faith. The martyrs were brought to Rome, where some of them were burnt alive, and some had their heads cut off by the sword after being brutally tortured.

According to the Spanish Tradition: Photina was the cause of bringing Domnina, the daughter of Nero (54-68 AD), to the faith and baptism along

with 100 of her maidservants.

PHOTINUS

Photinus grew up in Ancyra in Galatia. He was a disciple of Marcellus, the bishop of Ancyra. He was ordained as a deacon, then as a priest. He moved to Sirmium in Pannonia Secunda (nowadays Serbia), probably when his bishop Marcellus was expelled from his diocese in the year 336 AD, and Photinus kept wondering between Rome and Constantinople.

Photinus did not hide the teachings he received from his teacher but managed to find listeners. He was attacked by the Eusebians in Antioch, counting him as a follower of his mentor; and was also attacked in Milan, then in the capital. He became a bishop on Sirmium (344-351 AD), then he was also expelled from his bishopric and was exiled because of his views concerning the Person of the Lord Christ (he denied the Incarnation of Christ). Finally, he died in 376 AD. Having left no written documents behind, it was difficult to make an elaborate decision concerning his views, and his errors remained vague. Quite often, his personality was tied up to that of Sabellius, who denied the existence of the Holy Trinity, counting the three Divine Hypostasis as just three forms or names, through which God manifested Himself.

He was highly educated, an eloquent orator, knowledgeable in Greek and Latin. He wrote against the heretics and the pagans, and his influence remained after his exile and even after his death. He was condemned in the Council of Constantinople in 381 and 428 by Emperor Theodosius II (402-450 AD).

[Socrates: Ecc. Hist. 2:18,19,30; Sozomen: E.H. 4:6; Epiphanius; Panarion, 71]

PHOCAS, THE GARDNER (The martyr)

The biography of St. Phocas (Fucas), the martyr, got to be known through what was told about him by St. Asterius bishop of Amasea and St. John Chrysostom. St. Phocas lived near Sinope on the Black Sea. He had a garden, and he planted it by himself, imitating the early Holy Fathers and our first parents on earth in the Garden of Eden.

This saint used to mix his work with prayer, to turn his garden into his mentor, and the source of his contemplations in the Divine Creator. He also opened his house to strangers and travelers to provide them with hospitality. Once the fruit of his love and service to the poor was consummated, God found him worthy to deliver his life for the sake of the Lord Christ.

His Martyrdom:

According to the patrologist Francois Combefis (1605-1679), St. Phocas was martyred in the last years of the reign of Trajan (98-117 AD). Whereas, according to the historian Louis-Sébastien Tillemont (1637-1698), he was martyred in the days of Decius (249-251 AD) or Diocletian (284-305 AD).

Giving Hospitality to the Soldiers who Sent to Kill Him:

When the persecution against the Christians started, St. Phocas was accused of being a Christian, and the court condemned him to death wherever he was. So, the soldiers went out to execute the verdict, and when they arrived near Sinope at night, they came to his house unaware of his identity, and they accepted his invitation to spend the night there.

He offered them dinner, and while eating, they informed him of their mission and asked him if he would know where Phocas lived. He told them he knew the man very well, and that he would say to them where he was living in the morning. Once the soldiers fell asleep, St. Phocas came out, dug for himself a grave; prepared everything for his shrouding and burial; then spent the whole night preparing his soul for the last hours.

His Courage:

In the morning, he went to his guests and told them that Phocas was around and ready for them to arrest him whenever they decide. When they asked him where he was, he answered them: "He is here! I am the man you are looking after." Amazed at his love, generosity, courage, and steadfastness; the soldiers were shocked and did not know what to do. On seeing that, Phocas indirectly encouraged them and told them that he would consider his death for the sake of Christ, as the most excellent service they could offer him. After getting over their confusion, they cut his head off, and the Christians eventually built a great Church to carry his name. God granted him the gift of performing wonders through his relics, that he was called Thaumaturgus (Miracle-maker). His body was moved to Constantinople in the days of St. John Chrysostom, who gave a sermon on occasion. A monastery was also built on the same location.

It was said that part of his relics was moved to the church of the apostles in Vienna. St. Phocas is beloved by the Greek sailors, who are counting him as a partner in their meals, and used to put aside a part of the price of their food in his name and distribute it among the poor once they land safely ashore. The contemporary Greeks celebrate him on the 22nd of July and the 22nd of September. St. Gregory the Nazianzus called him The Renewable Disciple of Christ.

[Baring-Gould: September 22]
[Butler: July 3]

PIAMON, THE VIRGIN, ST.

St. Piamon lived with her mother in one of the villages in Upper Egypt. She lived with a holy monastic spirit, spending her life in spiritual watching, eating once every day at sunset, and earning her living weaving linen. That blessed virgin was worthy of enjoying the gift of knowing what was going to happen before it would happen.

So, one time there was a controversy between her village and a neighboring one because of the irrigation of their land from the Nile's water. As a result of the quarrels, some of the inhabitants of both villages were killed. So, the inhabitants of the other village who were known for their violence, planned on a sudden attack on their opponents. The Lord revealed that planning to that virgin Piamon. She hastened to tell the matter to the elders of her village, who had a great fear of confronting them, so they planned to ask for reconciliation. So, they sought from her if she wished to save her village and her household to go to meet with them by herself!

Not wishing to go to them, she instead ascended to the roof of her house and spent the night in unceasing prayers and metanoias, crying out to God, saying: "O Lord, the Judge of the whole earth; Who has no pleasure in oppression; I implore You O Lord when the prayers and supplications of your maidservant reach You, let Your power stop the enemy at the spot where they are now." Then, three miles from her village, those violent people felt a superior power that froze them, and they could not move forwards anymore. They were told later that it was because of the prayers of that saint. They instantly sent to the other village to seek reconciliation, with a message in which they told them: "Give thanks to God; for the prayers of Piamon which kept us from coming against you."

[W. Budge: *The Paradise of the Holy Fathers*, Vol. I, pp. 152-3]

PIERIUS, ST.

Father Pierius has been the dean of the School of Alexandria in the 2nd half of the 3rd century, in the days of Pope Theonas (282-301 AD). He was a cultured priest, a prominent interpreter of the Word of God and a great preacher. The historian Eusebius (260-340 AD) said about him: "He was known for his intense poverty, along with his richness in the philosophical knowledge, his depth in spiritual contemplations, his strife in the interpretation of the spirituals and his eloquence in the public debates in

church”.

He was called by St. Jerome “**The Little Origen.**” He was the teacher of Pamphilus, an admirer Origen, a priest and a teacher of theology in Caesarea of Palestine. He published many articles in diverse subjects. He wrote a long article on the prophet Hosea, as well as on The Gospel of St. Luke; on The Mother of God, and on The Biography of St. Pamphilus.

It was said that he died a martyr; but he most probably endured many sufferings in the days of Emperor Diocletian (284-305 AD), but was not martyred. He spent his last days in Rome, where he died after 309 AD.

[Fr. Tadros Malaty: *The Early Fathers of the School of Alexandria*; 1980, p. 289]

PIJIMI, ST. ABBA

This saint was born in the town of Feesha¹, he was raised in a poor pious family and since his childhood he had the responsibility of shepherding the sheep of his father. That simple work had its strong influence on his inner life; since it gave him a chance to spend long time meditating into God and His care for His creation. He longed to dedicate his life to God.

In his 12 years of age, an angel appeared to him in the form of a boy of the same age, who pretended to have a wish to be a monk, and his talk inflamed Pijimi’s heart for the monastic life. It happened that three days later, three monks came to accompany him to the wilderness of Nitria where, after spending a few days, they set forth with him to the wilderness of Scetis (the Scetis of St. Macarius).

His Monastic Life:

St. Pijimi lived seven years, growing in virtue in the Lord, after which he put on the “Monastic Scheme” while he was very young. He so walked by the spirit of the Lord that the other monks used to seek his prayers and blessing; while he lived among them with the spirit of obedience and humility.

His Spiritual Strife:

As St. Pijimi’s fame spread, many men and women came to visit him, and he started worrying about falling into evil desires. So, he intensified his care about his inner life with more prayers, fasting, and hand-work. He loved the spiritual vigil, remembering what the Lord said: “*Watch and pray, lest you*

¹ The town of ‘Feesha’ most probably was affiliated with ‘Mahmoudyia’ in the governorate of ‘Beheira’; or maybe with another town having similar name such as ‘Feesha el-Kobra’ or ‘Feesh el-Nasarah’ affiliated with the governorate of Menofyia.

enter into temptation. The spirit indeed is willing, but the flesh is weak” (Matt. 26:41). Also, whenever he found himself surrounded by a multitude of visitors; he remembered the Day of Judgment and rebuked himself by saying: “What shall I do if God would call on me while I am among such a crowd, those who I am not worthy to belong to; for I am a sinner and slothful in God’s work?!”

In the Inner Wilderness:

When St. Pijimi reached 36 years of age, he left Scetis and set forth to the inner wilderness. He kept on walking while praising God until he found a small valley with few palm trees and little water. Exultantly, he set forth 20 miles farther into the wilderness after the little valley, where he found a high rock with a cave. There, he dwelt and considered himself as if he had found the Garden of Eden. His spirit was so happy for that tranquil place. He lived in that cave for 24 years striving with joy. He was always known for having a happy countenance. The Kingdom of God never left his mind.

His food all those years was a few dates he used to get from that small valley. He never stored any food in his cave. However, he persisted in prayers, metanoias, and readings without any slowdown. The demons kept appearing to him in the forms of wild beasts roaring to terrorize him, but he strengthened himself by praying and crying out to the Lord. Coming to know their weakness, he used to scoff them in the Name of the Lord and to make the sign of the Cross on them to force them to flee away. The devil fought him by planting thoughts of despair and failure in his mind, to break him down by proclaiming to him that all his strife was unacceptable to God. The devil was hoping to discourage him that he would slow down his prayers and fasting. However, the saint responded to such thoughts by continuous prayers and fasting for 80 days. Afterward, his heart was more enflamed by God’s Spirit.

An angel of the Lord appeared to St. Pijimi bringing him some bread and water. After the angel disappeared, the saint wanted to be sure that that appearance was not a demonic trick. So, he made the sign of the Cross on the bread and water. Then he thanked God for His blessing to that food, which sustained him for a long time. After another seven years, the Lord Christ, along with the Archangel Michael and the 12 apostles, appeared to the saint in an amazing splendor. The Lord sought from him to return to his town to testify for Him among the pagans and to hold the believers fast to their faith.

It was said that the Archangel Michael carried him on a cloud of light to an elevated hill about three miles from his town. There, the saint dug a cave for himself and lived in it and worshipped God. A multitude of believers came to visit him and listen to his teachings, seeking his blessings and

prayers, and to be healed by the miracles granted to him by God.

In Faran:

It was also said that by Divine order, he set forth to the wilderness of Faran (in Saudi Arabia), where he remained for five years bringing the lost souls back to the fold of faith. Then, St. Pijimi returned to a cave near his birth-town of Feesha. That cave became a center for preaching the Gospel and to guide the deviants, as well as a place to comfort the tough and the sick.

An Encounter with Abba Shenouda:

It was also said that Abba Shenouda the Archimandrite, in a night vision saw that he was carried to heavens and was shown the place prepared for St. Pijimi. He was quite impressed and decided to go to Feesha to get his blessing. There, after he rested and had some food, both saints praised God, prayed, and were comforted by the word of God.

His Repose:

When St. Pijimi was told about the day of his repose, he informed his disciple, and on the 1st day of Kiahk, he was afflicted by intense fever. On the 11th of Kiahk, he saw a group of saints coming for him, along with angels, to carry his soul to its place of comfort.

[A monk in the Syrian Monastery (Virgin Mary's Monastery):
The Biography of the Great Saint Abba Pijimi, the Hermit]

PIOR, ABBA

Abba Pior (Pihur; in Coptic) his name means (Of the god Horus) and he is a different saint from Abba Or the abbot. He loved the monastic life at a young age, and he set forth to St. Anthony the Great in the year 325 AD and became one of his disciples for a few years. When he reached his 25 years of age, he longed for a life of seclusion, so he asked the permission of St. Anthony and set forth to the region of Nitria around the year 330 AD. There, he dwelt in an isolated cell between Nitria and Scetis. However, he kept coming back to Scetis for the rest of his life. Abba Pior dug a well and kept drinking its bitter water for 30 years until he reposed. His visitors used to bring their own water with them to drink. It was said that God made the bitter water sweet in his mouth. He kept growing in his asceticism until he got to eat only dry bread with five olives a day and persisted on not seeing any of his relatives.

Stories Told about Him:

- The blessed Pior worked for one of the farmers during the time of harvest. At the end of the season, the saint reminded the farmer to pay him his wages. However, the farmer ignored the request. The saint returned to his monastery without being paid, and in the next season the saint went back and worked again for the same farmer. That farmer did the same thing this time, and the saint returned to his monastery without payment. It happened for the third time, working three seasons with goodwill without wages. While the blessed man was joyful because he was denied his wages, the hand of Christ touched the heart of the farmer, to go searching for the saint in the monasteries, carrying the three years of wages. When he finally found him, he fell at his feet and begged him to accept what was due to him, but the saint refused to take it, saying: “Keep them, for you may be in a greater need for them. As for me, God gives me my wages.” Before the persistence of the farmer, he asked him to donate them to the Church.
- Pior used to eat while he was walking, and when he was asked why, he said: “I do not want to make eating food a job, but a subsidiary thing.”
- It happened that an assembly was held in Scetis because a brother committed a sin. The Fathers were discussing the matter in the presence of Pior, who remained silent. Then, the saint got up and went out carrying on his back a sack full of sand, and he put some of its sand in a small basket he carried in his hands. Being asked about the reason for that behavior, he said: “The sand in the sack on my back is my many sins that I left behind me, lest I would remember them and weep. As to the sin of my brother, I carry in my hand to be occupied by it while judging him; even though it is not befitting of me to do so. But, I should rather put my sins before my eyes, care for them, beseeching God to forgive them.” On hearing this, the Fathers said: “This, indeed, is the way to Salvation.”

[This behavior reminds us with what Abba Moses the Black did, when he carried on his back a sack full of sand, with a hole through which the sand dripped; and said: “I have put my sins behind my back lest I would see them, whenever I come forward to judge my brother”]

[Benedicta Ward: The Sayings of the Desert Fathers; Pior]

PIROOU AND ATHOM (The martyrs)

St. Piroou and St. Athom were two brothers, born to a pious priest called John and a holy mother named Mary in the village of Tasempoti (nowadays Sonbat) in the region of Abu-Seir (in Zeftah). They were in a wealthy family, and the two young men were prosperous by working in the trade. After the

repose of their parents, the two brothers traveled to do business in El-Farma, north-east of Egypt, while the older was 30 years old, and the younger was 28.

On their way, they found the martyred body of a saint called "Noua" with some of the soldiers. They bought the body from them with silver and secretly carried it back to their village Sonbat. They placed the body in a marbled sarcophagus in their own home. They hung an oil lamp before it, and many miracles appeared from the body. Their house turned into a spiritual center, to which the people came to get the blessing of the relics of the martyr, and also to find in those two young men a living portrait of the Lord Christ, having been pious and lovers of giving alms without limits.

Their Decision to get Martyred:

Eight months later, the two brothers decided to distribute all their wealth and to go to Alexandria to confess publicly being Christians. They arrived at the governor late at night, so he ordered putting them in prison until the morning to be tried. In prison, they prayed together with their brethren, the prisoners, for strengthening their faith. God sent them a heavenly voice to proclaim to them His presence and support. In the morning, the governor called them and started by dealing tenderly with them. He promised them to be appointed to work in the royal court. Not responding to his promises, he ordered whipping them and placing them in the Henbazin to tear their flesh apart. When Athom cried out to the Lord Christ to send His angel to save them, the Archangel Gabriel came, supported them, and healed their wounds. Provoked to anger, the governor ordered putting them on an iron bed and igniting fire underneath it; but God sent heavy rain and put the fire out. On seeing that, many pagans among the audience proclaimed their faith in the Lord Christ. In prison, the Lord Christ appeared to the two saints and encouraged them.

Driving an Unclean Spirit Out:

On their way out from the prison, while chained, they crossed by a young man possessed by an unclean spirit. With love, they prayed for his sake, and the evil spirit left him, to the amazement of the multitudes walking by. However, the governor accused them of practicing sorcery, and he ordered his men to hang them by their feet from a tall tree. They were left that way for two days while bleeding from their mouths and noses. Then, the governor and his men came back to scoff them, saying: "Piroou and Athom! Are you still alive, or are you dead?" Before the governor ended his phrase, God sent His Archangel Michael, and he restored their health. Fearing from the revolt of the people, the governor sent them back to prison.

Sending the Saints to El-Farma:

When Pompilus, the governor of El-Farma came to visit Alexandria, its governor discussed with him the situation with those two amazing sorcerers. Pompilus offered to take them with him to El-Farma on his return. So, they kept them in prison until then. The Archangel Michael appeared to them in prison, comforted them, and encouraged them to continue their strife for the Lord's sake. After Pompilus returned from Alexandria with the saints; he resumed torturing them, but the Lord kept on healing them. This caused three officers by the names of: Baniger, Karmani, and Al-Habashi, along with 40 other soldiers, to proclaim their faith in the Lord Christ; and they delivered themselves to martyrdom. The angry governor got more vicious and ordered his men to pull out all the saints' nails from their hands and feet. Also, he ordered to strike them on their mouths by a heavy iron bar to break their teeth, but the more violent he became, the more God was glorified in them. He sent His Archangel Michel to cover them with his wings and heal them. Although the governor felt defeated before the mob, he still cast the saints again into prison.

Raising Morphiany from the Dead:

As the governor's wife Morphiany, was going through difficult labor in her delivery, she ended up dead. The governor went into intense grief, and the entire city came to pay him condolence, but some whispered in his ear to call the two Christian young men to pray for his wife. The governor told them that even if he asked them, they would not be willing to help after all that he did to them. Some elites went to prison to find them praying while being in a fantastic splendor. The two young men came with them to the governor's house, where they prayed for his dead wife to the Lord Christ, the Grantor of life. God did raise her from the dead. So, the governor set them free to go back to their village Sonbat.

In Sonbat:

In Sonbat, the inhabitants came to seek the prayers of those saints, and God was glorified in them. Ultimately, they delivered all what remained of their possessions to a pious man by the name of Sarabamon to distribute among the poor and to care for their house where they buried the body of Noua the martyr. Then, they rushed and set forth to Basariom near El-Farma, where they encountered Popelian, the governor, while he was trying one of the saints called Abba Hesy. When they confessed their faith in Christ before everybody, the governor ordered his men to cut off the heads of all of them.

The two martyrs were led to the arena of death, east of the city; where

they were allowed to pray, and the Lord Christ appeared to them on a chariot of light, with the Archangels Michael on His right side and Gabriel on His left, together with thousands of angels singing His praise. With exultant souls, they sought from the soldiers to hasten and do what they were ordered to do. Then, one of the soldiers cut their heads by his sword on the 8th of Abib.

[R. P. Paul Hyvernât: Les Actes des Martyrs de Egypte]

PISORA, THE BISHOP (The martyr)

Father Pisora was the bishop of the city of Masil (Fowa) in Lower Egypt.

When Emperor Diocletian (284-305 AD) started to persecute the Christians, this bishop, desiring to offer himself as a sacrifice of love to God, gathered his congregation together before the altar and he told them about his heart's desire for shedding his blood for the Lord. All the congregation wept, saying: "To whom would you leave us fatherless?" They tried to make him change his mind but in vain. He bid them farewell and set forth, along with three other bishops: Pisikhos, Fanalikhos, and Theodore to proclaim their faith before the governor. They were all intensely tortured by the governor, in particular when he knew that they were bishops. These four bishops endured the sufferings with perseverance, and the Lord Christ strengthened and supported them, according to His Divine promise: "*Be of good cheer, I have overcome the world*" (John 16:33). They partook of the fellowship of passion together with their Savior, to have the fellowship in His glories; according to the words of the apostle: "*If children, then heirs – heirs of God, and joint-heirs with Christ, if indeed we suffer with Him, that we may also be glorified together*" (Rom. 8:17).

Finally, they had their heads cut off and received the crowns of martyrdom.

The relics of St. Pisora were in Nashein el-Qanater (Nasheil, province of Tanta). Now, it is kept in the church of Qasr el-Shamâ in Old Cairo.

[Synaxarion: 9 Tout]

PISUS, THE MONK

This saint was a monk in the monastery of Abba Yehnes Kama in Scetis during the days of the 66th Pope Christodoulos (1046-1077 AD) in the 11th century. This monk enjoyed a great relationship with the Lord His Savior; that when a plague came upon Egypt, and 21,000 children died because of it; a delegation came in terror to seek from this monk to pray for the sake of the

people of Egypt. This saint prayed all night until dawn; then came to the delegation to say: "Return in peace and say to those who sent you that our Lord Jesus Christ has compassion on us and He will take this plague away from us by His Grace." This was the case, and the plague disappeared on their return.

PITHYRION, ABBA

St. Jerome wrote in his book *History of the Monks*, about some monks who lived in caves in the region of Thebes on a very high mountain with barren tops near the river. Among those monks, there was somebody by the name of Abba Pithyrion. He was the third man to take over the abbot position which was occupied by St. Anthony the Great; after the repose of St. Anthony's own disciple Abba Ammon.

St. Jerome says that this saint indeed inherited from their mentor his strife and hard labor. He used to eat a little bread twice a week: on Saturdays and Wednesdays. Speaking about fighting the evil spirits, this father said: "There are demons associated with evil desires; those often would turn the right things into evil things. Hence my children, whoever wishes to drive the demons away, have to control his evil desires first. Yes, indeed, you have to overcome your evil desires a little by little, for by doing that, you drive the demons associated with them away. There is a demon associated with the corrupt slothful life; whoever overcomes that iniquity, drives its demon away. Also, there is a demon associated with anger; whoever controls his passion drives its demon away. The same thing could be said about every other evil desire."

[St. Jerome: *History of Monks*; 19]

PLATO (The martyr)

St. Plato (Platonius) was raised in the city of Ancyra in the province of Galatia, of a wealthy noble family. They were very generous toward the poor and the needy. Plato was known for his knowledge, culture, and piety. Once his father died, he distributed his inheritance to the poor. As the persecution was stirred up in the days of the Emperors Diocletian and Maximianus (284-305 AD), Plato was the first martyr in Ancyra. He showed an act of rare courage in enduring the severe tortures poured over him by governor Agropanos. That evil governor enjoyed the participation in torturing the saint with the executioners to satisfy his sinful nature. Then, he finally gave the order to the sword-man to cut the saint's head. That was around the year 303.

POEMEN (BEMEN), THE CONFESSOR, ST.

The Church celebrates the feast of the departure of this saint on the 9th of Kiahk and calls him **A Martyr without Bloodshed**. This is because he gave his testimony to the Lord Christ before the rulers, like the martyrs, and endured so many sufferings for the Name of Christ. Moreover, he enjoyed with them the blessings of the exalted care of God; to be worthy amid his sufferings of seeing Divine visions. However, God did not allow him to shed his blood for him to fulfill his mission in the Church.

His Upbringing:

This saint was born as a fruit of the prayers of his old pious parents: his father, the priest Severus of the village of Bani-Khaseeb in the district of El-Ashmunein in Minya governorate, and his barren wife, Mary. An angel appeared to Fr. Severus in the church to give him the good news about the birth of this infant and to talk to him about his mission. Then, the saint was raised in a house full of practical spiritual faith. When he reached nine years of age, he was sent to a mentor to teach him the basics of reading and writing; and the grace of God actively worked within him.

Then, it happened that a severe drought dwelt on the land since the Nile did not flood for three consecutive years. During that time, the priest Severus reposed, and the old mother with her young boy set forth to the village of El-Bayar. There, she put her son to work in the garden of a pious archon by the name of Ammonius. Every morning, the boy carried his food and gave it to a blind man on the way to work, and he remained fasting until the evening while working diligently in the garden, which God blessed wonderfully. The archon felt that the boy Poemen was behind this blessing, and he handed him all the responsibilities of his possessions. That trust only increased Poemen's diligence and faithfulness to the archon. At the same time, his soul being inflamed by the spirit; he practiced fasting perpetually, for two days, then for three days; and sometimes for a whole week.

A Hard Temptation:

Envyng Poemen for his spiritual growth and faithfulness at work; the devil stirred up some wicked workers in the vineyard against him. Perceiving that his purity was behind his grand success, they provoked a harlot to approach him and seduce him. When she tried to, he rebuked her. As she persisted, he struck her on her chest, and she dropped dead. All had feared; but the young man brought some water, put some oil on it, prayed and sprayed it on her face; and when he made the sign of the Cross on her, she instantly moved and got up. Then, she took off all her jewelry and threw

them away. Afterward, she prostrated herself before the young Poemen while in tears, asking him to forgive her and to pray to God for her that He would accept her repentance. As she proclaimed her remorse, he advised her to join a convent to worship God.

His Monastic Life:

It seemed that this incident had its impact, not only on the life of that woman and those who brought her onto him but on the life of St. Poemen himself. He thought that, if he has sent the harlot to a convent, it is befitting for him too to join a monastery as well. He put in his heart to forsake his temporal work to dedicate all his time for worship.

Poemen took all that was entrusted to him by the archon to the archon's wife, saying: "I bid you farewell, O blessed mother who raised me on your good teachings. May the Lord bless you along with my master, the archon. May He save your souls and reward you for the good you did to us with heavenly reward." On hearing that, the woman who counted him as a son implored him with tears not to leave them, saying: "You know how we count you as a son or a brother and how God blessed my house and our wealth since we entrusted them to your care." Poemen answered her by saying: "As I have spent such a long time serving you, from now on, I shall be serving My Lord Jesus Christ."

His Confession for the Lord:

The saint carried out his monastic life in spiritual strife and was growing in virtue day by day. He longed to testify to the Lord Christ, so he went to Ansenah and rebuked the governor on torturing the Christians. The governor ordered his men to torture him by the Henbazin, but the Archangel Michael appeared and broke it. On observing that, some of the soldiers proclaimed their faith in the Lord Christ. Then, he was placed on a metal bed heated with a fire underneath it. However, on seeing that he was not harmed, one of the executioners put a hot iron rod in his belly. Rebuking him for so doing, the earth opened up and swallowed that soldier; and many people proclaimed their faith as well. Afterward, St. Poemen was put in prison waiting for his execution, and just before a verdict to put him to death was passed, a decree from Emperor Constantine the Great (306-337 AD) ordering not to harm the Christians was issued in the year 313 AD.

St. Poemen lived after that in a monastery outside the city of El-Ashmunein. God granted him the gift of healing the sick, and his fame spread in all the surrounding districts.

Healing the Empress, Wife of Constantine the Great:

The Empress of Rome became sick with a grievous illness, which was challenging to treat. She visited many monasteries and churches, but she was not healed of her sickness. Finally, she came to Egypt and visited the city of Ansenah, and the governor of the city and his men accompanied her to the place where St. Poemen was. When they informed him of the empress presence and expressed to him her desire to see him, St. Poemen did not go out to meet her but said, "What have I to do with the kings of the earth." When the brethren, the monks, implored him to go out to meet her, he did so. When she saw him, she bowed down at his feet. The saint prayed over some oil and anointed her, and she was instantly healed of her sickness. The empress offered St. Poemen much money along with several expensive gifts, but he refrained from accepting them, except for a few sacred vessels for the altar, a paten, a chalice, and a golden Cross, and the empress returned to Rome glorifying God.

St. Poemens Support for the Bishop:

When the bishop of his city was exposed to great anguish because of an Arian made-up bishop, who assembled a crowd and kept opposing that Orthodox bishop; St. Poemen gathered a group of monks and they all confronted the Arian bishop. The saint debated him about their beliefs until he managed to persuade him. Afterward, that Arian bishop has dispersed along with his heretic followers.

His Departure:

St. Poemen went back to his monastery and continued his strife until old age. Then, when he became sick, he told the brethren that his time to be with the Lord was drawing near. The brethren asked for his blessings, and when he delivered his soul on the 9th of Kiahk, the brethren shrouded him and buried him in a big sorrow. Shortly after, so many miracles were performed through his body.

POLLIO (The martyr)

St. Pollio was a lector (reader) in a church in the city of Cybalae, of the Lower Pannonia in the old Yugoslavia. After the martyrdom of St. Eusebius, the bishop of the city, that reader took upon himself the leadership of the Christians amid the anguish to hold their faith fast, disregarding the decrees of Emperor Diocletian (284-305 AD). Consequently, St. Pollio was brought before governor Probus to proclaim a living testimony of his faith, refusing to

deny his Christ, to be condemned to be burned alive, few years after the martyrdom of his bishop. His martyrdom took place on the 28th of April in the year 304 AD.

POLYCARPUS (The martyr)

St. Polycarpus (Polycarp) was born around the year 70 AD. In a night vision, an angel came to a pious woman by the name of Callisto and said to her: “Callisto, wake up, go to the gate of the Ephesians, and after walking a little distance you will see two men with a little boy called Polycarpus. Ask them if the boy is for sale. When they answer in the positive, pay to them the price they demand and take the boy and keep him with you.” Callisto followed what the angel told her, and she acquired the boy, who eventually became her faithful storekeeper. When she would travel away for a business, the poor, the needy, and the widows would come to Polycarp in the stores, and he distributed on them all that was in the stores. When Callisto returned, a fellow slave told her what Polycarp did. She called him and sought him to deliver the keys to the stores. Then, when she opened the stores she found out that they were full as usual; and she intended to punish the slave, but Polycarp intervened and told her that what the slave said was correct and the stores became empty; however, what in them now was a gift from God. She became exultant and adopted him to inherit all her possessions after she would pass away, but as far as he was concerned, his heart was not occupied with material things.

Also, St. Polycarp often used to walk through the road, which was used by the fire-wood collectors in their trip back; and he would choose the oldest among them and purchase his entire load of fire-wood and carry it by himself to one of the poor widows.

His Ordination:

Bishop Bucolus ordained him as a deacon. Then, he preached by giving sermons, as well as by his excellent example. Being loved and appreciated, the bishop ordained him as a priest while he was still young. Then, he was ordained as a bishop on Smyrna (Izmir in Turkey) by St. John the beloved (Rev. 2:8-10). St. Irenaeus, bishop of Lyons testified to his holy behavior and that he was taught on the hands of the apostles, and that he talked to St. John the Evangelist and to others who were contemporaries to the Lord Christ on earth.

He strove against the heretics, in particular against Marcion, the most prominent among the Gnostics, and while he was in Rome, he rescued so many from the vanity of following the Marcionism.

His Martyrdom:

When Emperor Marcus Aurelius (161-180 AD) started his persecution of the Christians, the believers tried to urge the saint to escape from the face of the Roman governor. He disappeared for a few days in a house outside the city, praying for the sake of the flock of Christ. In a night vision, the Lord told him what would happen to him and let him see his pillow engulfed in flames. Waking up, he gathered his friends and said to them that he would be burned alive for the sake of Christ and that he would enjoy the gift of martyrdom.

After three days, the soldiers discovered his place and came to arrest him. He could have escaped. Instead, he raised his eyes toward heaven, saying: **“Let Thine Will be in everything.”** And, he surrendered to them, offered them food, and asked them to give him one hour to pray. The soldiers were amazed for his splendor, humility, cheerfulness, and eloquent talk; that one of them was wondering: “Why is all that great diligence to seek the death of this respectful old man?” Then, he set forth with the soldiers who made him ride on a colt. In the road, they encountered a prominent official in the State by the name Herod, along with his father Nicotach. These two made the old saint ride with them in their chariot. Then, they asked him to deny his Christ, but he refused. At that moment, they insulted him and threw him away from the moving chariot, to fall on the road and had a severe wound in his leg. The saint then cheerfully rode on his colt until he reached the arena where the governor and a great crowd were waiting for him.

On seeing how he was bowed down from the old age and how awesome he looked, with his white beard, the governor asked him: “Are you Polycarp the bishop?” Answering in the positive, he sought from him to be merciful on his old age and warned him that he would be tortured severely with what a young man could not endure. Then, he ordered the saint to proclaim the destruction of the hypocrites and to swear by the life of Caesar. St. Polycarp sighed, saying, “Yes, let the hypocrites perish.” The governor promised him if he swear by the life of Caesar and curses Christ, he would be set free. To this he responded by saying: “For 86 years I served Christ, and he has done me no evil, but every day he kept giving me new graces. How then shall I curse my Keeper, my Benefactor, my Savior, and the great Judge who will reward the good and penalize the evil hypocrites?”

The governor threatened to burn him alive and to cast him before the hungry wild beasts. The saint answered: “I do not fear the fire that consumes the body, but I fear the perpetual one that consumes the soul. As for casting me before the hungry wild beasts, that I do not worry about either. Let the beast be brought in and let the fire be ignited because I am prepared for being

devoured and burned.” When the governor told him to obey the people, he said: “God should be obeyed more than men. Why waiting? Come on, hasten to do what you intend to do.” So he said with courage and with a countenance radiating with light, for which the governor was amazed.

They prepared the fire and planned to nail him to the wooden platform to keep his body from moving away from the fire, but he told them: “No! Do not bother to do that; for He who gives me the courage to endure the fire, will keep me to hold fast in it without the need of your nails.” Here, they tied his hands behind his back and made him lie down on the fire-wood, as though a sacrifice offered on an altar. During that time, he prayed, giving thanks to God, who allowed him to die as a martyr. After he finished his prayer, the executioners ignited the fire; and behold! Sweet fragrance spread all over the place. Then, when a pagan stabbed him with a knife, his blood flowed and extinguished the fire. However, his soul exultantly departed to Paradise in the year 166 AD. The Greeks celebrate him on the 25th of April, and the Copts on the 29th of Amshir.

His Epistle:

St. Polycarp, the bishop of Smyrna, wrote an epistle to the people of Philippi. That message revealed the condition of the early Church in Europe in the 2nd century. The epistle was characterized by the denseness of its practical wisdom and the many biblical quotations it used, as it reflected the spirit of St. John the Beloved in his humility and serenity, yet with firmness in faith and holding to the sacred life.

[Fr. Tadros Y. Malaty: *The Two Martyrs Ignatius and Polycarp*, Sept. 1964]

POLYEUCTUS (The martyr)

St. Polyeuctus was martyred in the days of Emperor Valerian (253-260 AD) around the year 259 AD in the city of Melitene in Armenia. In that city, there was a camp of Roman troops; among them, so many ended up as martyrs, such as Polyeuctus, a centurion of Greek origin in the regiment of Fulminata. That centurion was a pagan, who had a close friendship with a devoted Christian man by the name of Nearchus. When Nearchus heard about the persecution that stirred up in Armenia, he prepared himself to receive the crown of martyrdom. However, he was sad to leave his dear pagan friend Polyeuctus behind in the darkness. So before setting forth to be martyred, he spoke by the daring of the zealous love to his friend about the salvation of his soul. He was so surprised to find out that his friend was not only ready to receive faith but to receive the crown of martyrdom as well.

The centurion publicly proclaimed his faith and endured so many tortures intended to force him to deny his Christ, which he rejected them all, while exultant by the spirit. His wife Paulina, their children, and her parents came to him with tears, begging him to retreat, but he persistently kept crying out seeking the Divine help. The Lord granted him the ability to endure the verdict of death with joy. On his way to martyrdom, his heart was so inflamed with love toward everyone he encountered; and kept talking to the multitudes about faith, and he managed to win so many to the true faith in his last moments.

A church was built on his name before the year 377 AD.

[B. Aube: *Polyeucte dans LHistoire*, Paris, 1882]

PONTIANUS, THE POPE OF ROME (The martyr)

St. Pontianus (Pontian) (230-235 AD) succeeded the Roman Pope Urban I (222-230 AD). He was ordained as a bishop on Rome in the year 230 AD, and he remained more than five years as a pope. All that is known about him is that he held a council in Rome to endorse the council held at Alexandria by the 12th pope of Alexandria St. Demetrius the Vinedresser (188-230 AD) to oppose the teachings of Origen. This was mentioned by St. Jerome in his letter to Paula.

Emperor Maximinus Thrax (235-238 AD), contrary to his predecessor Severus Alexander (222-235 AD), became a persecutor of the Church. At the beginning of his reign, Maximinus Thrax exiled Pope Pontianus to labor in the mines of the island of Sardinia, along with his adversary Fr. Hippolytus, the priest. That exile to those mines which were described as *nociva insula*, meaning (unhealthy), was regarded as a death sentence for both these men.

We do not know how long he lived or how he reposed, but it was said that he reposed in the year 235 AD, and according to the Roman Tradition that he died as a result of being struck with rods. However, Eusebius said that he died during the time of Emperor Gordian I in the year 237 AD, but some scholars believe that Eusebius mixed up the date of his repose and that of moving his relics to Rome.

[Smith and Wace: *A Dictionary of Christian Biography*, Vol, 4, p. 438]

PONTINUS, THE DEACON

According to St. Jerome, this saint lived in the 3rd century AD. Not much known about him besides that he was a deacon confessor accompanying Cyprian (200-258 AD), bishop of Carthage. He was one of his disciples and

was very attached to him. In the same way, St. Cyprian himself was so attached to the priest Caescilian, through whom he received the faith.

When St. Cyprian was exiled to Curubis, he chose his deacon Pontinus as his companion, and the deacon was so exalted for that. Eventually, he was able to introduce his famed work: “Life and sufferings of Cyprian,” in which he told us about the life of that bishop from his baptism to his martyrdom. St. Cyprian was condemned to martyrdom, while they left his deacon behind, most probably out of belittlement. This made St. Pontinus very sad, for he had lived a long life longing to receive the crown of martyrdom. That was why he ended his talk about his mentor by saying: “As much as I am very proud of his glory, I am unfortunate to be left behind after him.” We do not know whether his life ended by martyrdom or not; or the place of his repose.

[Smith and Wace: A Dictionary of Christian Biography, Vol 4, p. 439]
[Butler's: Lives of Saints, March 8]

PONTINUS, THE MARTYR

This St. Pontinus was born in Rome during the 3rd century to a famous pagan family, his father Marcus was a senator. His mother Julia, went to the temple of Jupiter to ask its priest to prophesy about her to-be-born child. The priest put a ritual band around her head and covered his face to look as though filled with the spirit of prophecy, then told her that the temple will be destroyed by her yet unborn son. Very disturbed and terrified to hear that, she started to beat her belly with a stone trying to abort herself and avoid giving birth to the enemy of the gods. Finally, she gave birth to the boy Pontinus, and she planned to get rid of him. However, the priest intervened to tell her that Jupiter did care for the life of her boy; and if he grew up as an opponent to him, he would kill him himself. Growing up, the boy was delivered to the hands of a mentor to raise him. One morning the boy woke up early to go to his mentor and on his way, he heard beautiful praise by a group of people chanting:

“Why should the Gentiles say, So where is their God? But our God is in heaven; He does whatever He pleases. Their idols are silver and gold, the work of men’s hands. They have mouths, but they do not speak; Eyes they have, but they do not see. They have ears, but they do not hear. Noses they have, but they do not smell. They have hands, but they do not handle it. Feet they have, but they do not walk. Nor do they utter through their throat. Those who make them are like them. So is everyone who trusts in them. O Israel, trust in the Lord; He is their help and their shield.” (Psalm 115: 2-9)

The boy Pontinus stood listening, while his intuitive insight opened up and

felt a vast difference between this praise and what he used to hear in his pagan worship. He found himself knocking on the door of the building with his tiny hands, then by his feet. When the gatekeeper told the Pope Pontianus (230-235 AD) who happened to be there, that a boy was kicking the gate with his little feet; he instructed him to open it, saying: "For such will be the Kingdom of Heaven." When the boy entered into the hall to see a group of believers praising God, he simply set forth toward the pope to ask: "May you please teach me this amazing song about God in heaven who does whatever He pleases?" The pope asked him about his parents, to know that his mother passed away, his father and grandfather were still living and that they were not Christians. The boy remained about three hours listening attentively to the pope, until his heart was inflamed with faith.

His Father Proclaimed His Faith:

With joy, the boy set forth to tell his father what happened to him. Being prudent, the father listened to him to the end, probably not to lose him; but it so happened that the father himself, drawn by the talk of the boy, set forth with him to the pope to seek his counsel and he joined the rows of the catechumen, together with his son to get eventually baptized.

When the father reposed while his son was 20 years old, the young man distributed all his inheritance to the poor and the needy. He was loved by Emperor Philip the Arab (244-249 AD) and his son, who received Christianity on his hands.

However, during the time of Emperors Valerian and Gallienus (253-268 AD), Pontinus escaped to Cimella, near the city of Nice in France, where he was arrested by governor Claudius. The latter delivered him to wild bears in the amphitheater. However, those bears devoured the executioners but did not harm the saint. In anger, the governor ordered that the saint's head be cut off. His relics were kept in the monastery of St. Ponte, near Nice, whereas his head was kept in Marseilles. He was martyred around the year 257 or 258.

[Baring-Gould: Lives of Saints, May 14]

PORPHYRIOS (The martyr)

The Synaxarion of the 3rd of Baramhat mentions another martyr with a similar name Porphyrios (Porphyry). Most probably, this saint was martyred in the days of Emperor Diocletian (284-305 AD). He was a rich man of the city of Baniyas, who loved the poor and visited those imprisoned. On seeing the governor walking in front of his house, he proclaimed his Christian faith and ultimately received the crown of martyrdom.

PORPHYRIUS, BISHOP of GAZA, ST.

St. Porphyrius (Porphyry) was born in the city of Thessalonica in Macedonia around the year 350 AD to a wealthy pious family. From his childhood, he loved the Lord, despised the world, and longed to dedicate his life to the Kingdom of God.

After reaching 25 years of age, he set forth to the wilderness of Scetis in Egypt, where he spent five years as a disciple of the Desert Fathers there and enjoyed a life of silence and tranquility. Then, he sought from the Fathers to allow him to go to Palestine to get the blessings of this Holy Land. There, he settled down in a cave close by the Jordan River to practice his worship with the spirit of piety and asceticism. However, after another five years, he was afflicted with a severe illness, which left him very frail, possibly because of the high humidity in the area. During his illness, he had a disciple by the name Mark and an Asian young man who came to Jerusalem as a tourist, and then he met with St. Porphyrius and loved his guidance and became his disciple. When his health deteriorated, the saint asked Mark to go to Thessalonica to sell all that he inherited from his parents and bring the money to him. Mark came back after three months carrying a large sum of money. However, he was surprised to see that his mentor was completely healed of his illness. When he asked him about the secret of his healing, the saint answered him: "Do not marvel, Mark, to see me in such good health, but do marvel at the indescribable goodness of the Lord Christ, Who does what men cannot do." When Mark persisted in knowing the secret of his healing, he told him about the miracle that happened to him. He said: "Four days ago, while I was in great pain, I tried to go to the Mount of Golgotha searching for comfort. However, I collapsed in the way. Then, I saw a vision as if the Lord Christ was hanging on the Cross, and on His right hand was the good robber. At once, I cried out: *Remember me, O Lord, when You come to Your kingdom.* Then, the Savior commanded the right-hand robber to help me to get up. The good robber stretched his hand and got me up and took me in a hurry to the Lord. Jesus told me: Take this Cross and care for it. In obedience, I carried the Cross on my shoulders and left. Then, I woke up to find myself completely healed and on the road going to Mt. Golgotha." On hearing his mentor story, Mark was much impressed that he decided never to leave his mentor alone. Then, the saint took all the money that Mark brought and distributed it to the poor and the needy. He made his living on making and fixing shoes and leather handwork, while his disciple Mark, whose handwriting was very beautiful, worked in writing manuscripts.

His Ordination as a Bishop:

St. Porphyry remained working with his own hands, remembering the words of St. Paul the Apostle: *"If anyone will not work, neither shall he eat."* (2 Thess. 3:10). On reaching 40 years of age (in 390 AD), the bishop of Jerusalem ordained him as a priest and assigned to him the custody of the Holy Cross. The saint became so happy since his vision was truly realized.

As a priest, he kept practicing his ascetic life, eating only a piece of bread with some beans at sunset. By his behavior, piety, and the strength of his sermons, he managed to draw so many pagans to believe in the Lord Christ.

Then in the year, 396 AD, when the bishop of Gaza reposed in the Lord, St. Porphyry was chosen without his knowledge to replace him. John, the bishop of Caesarea, wrote to the bishop of Jerusalem requesting that he would send to him the priest Porphyry to ask him about some issues concerning the Holy Bible. His bishop asked St. Porphyry to go to Caesarea and return in seven days. Porphyry called his disciple Mark and told him: "Brother Mark, let us visit the Holy Sites and the Holy Cross to pay them homage, for we would not be able to do that again for a long time." When Mark was puzzled and asked him why, he told him that our Savior appeared to him that night and said to him: "Deliver back the Cross I entrusted to you, for I shall marry you to a feeble and humble wife, but she is great in her piety and virtue. Care to adorn her well, no matter how she would seem to you; because she is My sister." He added: "That was what the Lord Christ instructed me to do the previous night, and I fear to care for the sins of others and forget my sins, but the will of God must be obeyed."

St. Porphyry went to Caesarea, where he found a delegation from Gaza seeking from the bishop of Caesarea to ordain him as a bishop on them. After he was ordained, he set forth to Gaza to find that the pagans had planned to kill him; on account that their god Marnas told them that calamities would dwell upon Gaza because of Porphyry. However, he met them with amiability and humility and was able to gain many of them.

Two months after coming to Gaza, severe drought came upon the region, and in vain, the pagans set forth to their temple to pray to Marnas to take his wrath away from the city. The Christians then fasted for a full day, spent a whole night in prayers and praise, and then set forth in a procession to the church of St. Timothy outside the city walls. Once the Christians were out, the pagans closed the city gates to keep the Christians outside, but when the Christians cried out to their God; a heavy rain poured in, and the rejoiced pagans opened the city gates to receive the Christians with cheerful hearts, and many of them proclaimed faith in the Lord Christ.

Again, the pagans were stirred up against the Christians, when they

realized that their temple gradually became deserted. Here, bishop Porphyry, along with John bishop of Caesarea, set forth to seek from the Emperor Arcadius (383-408 AD) what St. John Chrysostom has previously requested; namely to order the destruction of the pagan temples that came to be deserted. The emperor promised to do so; then he changed his mind. The two bishops, later, resorted to the Empress Eudoxia, the queen, who has not so far given birth to a child; and St. Porphyry prophesied to her that she would have a son to sit on his father's throne. When that was realized, the emperor fulfilled the request of the two bishops.

God granted St. Porphyry the grace of performing so many miracles that motivated a multitude of pagans in Gaza to proclaim their faith in the Lord Christ. That saint remained caring for his congregation with piety and faithfulness until he reposed in the Lord on the 26th of February, year 450,

POSSIDIUS, THE BISHOP, ST.

St. Possidius was known as being the author of the biography of his intimate friend St. Augustine, the bishop of Hippo. That biography was a concise one, yet, of great value. St. Possidius was raised in north-west Africa by pagan parents, but he received faith in the Lord Christ and became a disciple of St. Augustine in the monastery of Hippo. In the year 397 AD, he was ordained as a bishop on the city of Calama at Numidia, which was suffering from the Donatists¹, as well as from the pagans. He aligned himself with St. Augustine in opposing the Donatists and the Pelagians². He was violently opposed by the Donatist extremists and played an important role in the Council of Milevum in the year 416 AD against Pelagianism.

In the year 429 AD, the Germanic tribes of the Vandals, while passing from Spain to Africa, devastated the region of Calama. St. Possidius took refuge at his life-long friend St. Augustine, in Hippo. Later on, St. Augustine delivered his last breath in the arms of St. Possidius, while the Vandal tribes were still besieging the city of Hippo.

It was said that bishop Possidius and two other bishops were exiled from their thrones through the opposing Arian movements. St. Possidius reposed in his exile around the year 440 AD, while some scholars believe that he reposed in Mirandola in Italy.

[Cross: Dictionary of the Christian Church, p.1113]

¹ The 'Donatists' were a congregation dissented from the church and called everyone else as infidels.

² The 'Pelagians' were those who disregarded the grace of God and concentrated only on the human strife.

POSSIDONIUS, ST.

This saint was called by St. Palladius: “The Great Possidonius” and he said: “The things to be said about that man of Thebes are so numerous that it is difficult to cover them all. He was gracious, tender, patient, enduring, and his soul had so much goodness in it. That, I do not know if I ever met someone like him.” St. Palladius lived with this saint in Bethlehem for a whole year, when he was dwelling beyond the Monastery of The Shepherds on the shore of the Pophyrates close to the town. The saint told St. Palladius one of his stories:

“For a full year, I did not talk to anybody nor heard the voice of anyone; I did not eat bread, but I lived on wetting the inside of the palm leaves with honey if I found it. However, once it happened that this arrangement failed me, and I was in sore distress because of it. So, I left the cave that I might go to the dwellings of men (looking for something to eat) and having journeyed on the whole day. I was scarcely two miles distant from the cave. Then, I turned and looked behind me, and I saw as if it was a knight upon his head a helmet, and I thought that he might be a Roman. I returned to the cave, and I found outside it a basket of grapes and new ripe figs. I took them inside the cave, rejoicing. That food sufficed to be a consolation unto me for two months.”

About him, St. Palladius also narrated that a pregnant woman who had an unclean spirit; went through strict labor. Her husband came to the saint to ask him to go to his house to pray for her. The saint did, and St. Palladius accompanied him. There, the saint prayed on her behalf, and the evil spirit came out of her, and she safely delivered.

St. Palladius concluded his narrative about this saint, quoting the saint himself saying: “For 40 years, I never tasted food made of bread or had a feeling of anger toward anyone for more than half of the day.”

[Palladius: *The Paradise*, ch. 50]

POTAMIÆNA (The martyr)

This virtuous virgin martyr Potamiæna has also been mentioned under the biography of St. Basilides, the soldier who was assigned to guard her. He was the one who did her the favor of not making her take off her clothes during her martyrdom, for which she prayed to God on his behalf. He eventually followed her steps and gained the crown of martyrdom by proclaiming his faith in the Lord Christ. Her story was told by the historian Eusebius¹ (265-

¹ ‘Eusebius’ in his book: “*Church History*, Bk VI, Ch. 5”...

340 AD). Also, it was told by St. Palladius¹ (363-430 AD). Palladius quoted the story from St. Isidore of Alexandria (318-403 AD), who quoted it from St. Abba Anthony the Great (251-356 AD).

St. Potamiæna was born by poor Christian parents in the 2nd century AD. Her mother Marcella, cared for her education, so she encouraged her to listen to Origen (184-254 AD) in his interpretation of the Holy Bible at the first School of Alexandria. She worked in fear of God as a maidservant at the home of a rich man. However, Satan, filling the heart of that man with unclean thoughts toward her, kept on provoking her to commit evil with him, but she held firm to her purity and chastity. Failing to seduce her, her master informed the governor of Alexandria Claudius Subatianus Aquila (205-210 AD), about her and accused her of being Christian. That evil rich man gave the governor a considerable sum of money to torture her until she would submit and consent to do evil with him. St. Potamiæna endured much suffering and was finally put in a pot filled with boiling oil, to deliver her soul in the hands of her Heavenly Groom.

[H. Musurillo: *Acts of Christian Martyrs*, Oxford 1972, Ch. 9]

POTAMON, THE CONFESSOR BISHOP, ST.

St. Potamon (Potamion) was a bishop on Heraclea in Egypt. The 20th Pope of Alexandria St. Athanasius the Apostolic (328-373 AD) described him as a doubly a martyr; having testified to the Truth before the persecution of the pagans, as well as before that of the Arians. When Emperor Maximinus Daia (311-313 AD) stirred up the persecution on the Christians in the year 311 AD, the saint suffered many tortures, during which he lost one of his eyes. He counted that as a sign of honor, particularly when he attended the Nicene Council in the year 325 AD, where he had a vital role against the Arians, who denied the Divinity of the Lord Christ. Then, when he attended the council of Tyre in the year 335 AD, he defended pope Athanasius as the “Hero of Faith,” and rebuked the bishop Eusebius of Caesarea, his fellow in prison, on how he would let the hero of faith to be put on trial. He also rebuked him on how he cowardly offered a sacrifice to the idols before; and proclaimed that he lost his right to reside as chairman of that Council. In the days of the Arian Emperor Constantius II (337-361 AD), the governor of Egypt Philagrius accompanied the Arian patriarch of Egypt, and both wandered all over the country to torture the Orthodox inhabitants and to exile their bishops. Among those bishops was St. Potamon, who was arrested and struck by the rod so

¹ ‘Palladius’ in his book: *“The Lausiack History: 3”*...

violently that he fell unconscious and was counted as dead. Some believers took care of him, and he was healed; but reposed after a little while because of the torture he suffered, as one of the confessors. The West celebrates him on the 18th of May.

[A. Butler: *The Lives of the Saints*, 1866, vol. V, May 18]

POTHINUS AND HIS COMPANIONS (The martyrs)

There is an important letter that has documented the sufferings of the martyrs of Lyon and Vienne in Gaul (France) in the days of Emperor Marcus Aurelius (161-180 AD) in the year 177 AD. This letter was sent to the churches in Asia and Phrygia. It was described by a French literature authority as “**The Pearl of the Christian literature in the 2nd century AD.**” Also, it was recorded by the ecclesiastical historian Eusebius of Caesarea¹. This great letter provided us with a portrait of the martyrdom and sufferings of so many believers; among them was bishop Pothinus. From that letter, we may quote the following:

From the ministers of Christ, dwelling in Vienne and Lyon in Gaul, to the brethren in Asia and Phrygia, who have the same faith and the same hope of redemption. Peace, Grace, and Glory from God the Father and Jesus Christ, our Lord.

The extent of anguish in our land, the stir-up of the pagans against the saints, and the sufferings of the blessed witnesses; are too great to be elaborately described or written down. The adversary attacked us with his maximum strength, to give us a sample of his limitless massacre, which he will show when he attacks us in the future. He did his best to use his followers against the ministers of God; he did not only keep us away from our houses, baths, and markets; but denied us the appearance anywhere. However, the grace of God turned the strife against him, saved the weak, made them like steady pillars, capable by a perseverance of enduring every evil wrath; and fought against him, enduring all kinds of reproach and harm; then, with their sufferings, they hastened to Christ, showing that “*The sufferings of this present time are not worthy to be compared with the glory which shall be revealed in us*” (Rom. 8:18). They bravely endured all the harm heaped upon them by the mob, such as shouting, slapping, dragging on the ground, robbing, stoning, and jailing. In addition to whatever the entire enraged mob was delighted to inflict on their enemies and adversaries.

Then, they were taken by the leaders of thousands and the rulers of the

¹ Eusebius of Caesarea: *The History of the Church* 5:1:3-31.

city to the outer arena, where they were tried before the public, and when they confessed, they were put in jail until the governor would arrive. The letter also narrated that when they appeared before the governor, how a wise young man named Vettius Epagathus, having watched the violent cruelty imposed on his brethren, stood to defend them. Although he was a prominent figure in the city, the governor, instead of accepting his defense, he asked him about his faith. When the governor found out that he was a Christian, he was made to join the Christians as a defendant, which he accepted with love and joy, longing to deliver his own life for the sake of the brethren and to follow his Christ.

They also arrested the pagan servants working in the houses of those believers. Those servants were terrified on seeing the displayed tools of torture. So, they did not only justify themselves by declaring that they were not Christians; but also they accused their masters with gross false claims, not befitting of us to even mention or think about. On hearing those accusations, the mob was stirred up so violently against the Christians and acted like vicious beasts. Even the pagan friends and acquaintances turned to violent enemies against their Christian friends to fulfill the saying of the Lord: *"The time is coming that whoever kills you thinks that he offers God service"* (John 16:2).

Among those on whom the wrath of the governor, the soldiers and the mob came down, were Sanctus a deacon from Vienne; Matures a newly baptized Christian, yet a noble one; Attalus a native of Pergamos; Blandina, the weak-bodied maidservant, in whom God showed His power and glory amid her sufferings; Biblias and others. The brutal tortures were inflicted on all of these, in addition to the martyr Pothinus, the bishop of Lyon, who was 90 years old.

Also, it came in the letter: "As to the blessed Pothinus the 90 years old bishop of Lyon, they dragged him to the court of Justice, while he was too frail even to breathe, but with his spiritual strength he longed for martyrdom, and despite his old age and frailty, his life was preserved in the Lord Christ to conquer them with it. When he was brought to the court of justice; the mob was shouting obscenities towards him, as though Christ Himself. Then, when he was asked by the governor: Who is the God of the Christians? He bravely answered: If you are worthy, you would know. Those pagans who were near him struck him by their hands and kicked him with their feet. While those who were afar threw everything in their hands at him, they assumed that they would be considered criminals in the sight of their gods, if they do not insult him enough. St. Pothinus was then cast into the depths of a prison, where he reposed in the Lord after just two days."

PRALIUS, THE BISHOP

St. Pralius was the bishop of Jerusalem in the period 416-425 AD following bishop John after he reposed in December 415 AD. St. Pralius was deceived along with the Pope of Rome, by the heretic Pelagius. However, when they discovered his deceit, they corrected themselves; and bishop Pralius expelled Pelagius from the Holy City. The essence of Pelagius heresy was that its doctrine was focused on trusting the human arm for salvation without the need for the grace of God. St. Augustine took on himself to refute and oppose Pelagius's claims.

PRAXEDES, THE VIRGIN, ST.

The Latin Church celebrates the feast of St. Pudens and his daughter Pudentiana on the 19th of May, and the feast of her sister St. Praxedes on the 21st of July. It was said that St. Pudens was a Roman nobleman who had the honor to receive St. Peter the Apostle in his house. He accepted the Christian faith in the hands of St. Paul, the Apostle. St. Paul counted him as one of his disciples in his 2nd epistle to Timothy (2 Tim. 4:21). After a few days from his baptism, St. Pudens reposed in the Lord after leading a pure, pious life. He left his two virgin daughters behind, and they dedicated themselves to serve the poor and turned their house into a church so that the believers would participate in the Holy Sacraments.

According to some researchers, the first daughter was martyred in the year 160 AD when she was 16 years of age. Although, some others believe that this happened to another martyr who carried the same name at that time.

As to her sister Praxedes, she was contemporary to the suffering through which the Christians had to endure during the days of Emperor Antonius Pius (138-161 AD). She used to follow the persecuted believers, supporting them with money, care, and words of comfort during their anguish. Also, it was said that she hid some of them in her house and cared to bury the bodies of the saintly martyrs. Finally, having got overwhelmed by what she witnessed of sufferings, she cried out to God to liberate her from this violent and cruel world. God listened to her and took back her pure soul on the 21st of July.

A priest by the name of Pastor buried her body in the grave of her father Pudens, whereas her sister Pudentiana was buried in the tomb of Priscilla on the Salarian Way.

PRIMUS AND FELICIANUS (The martyrs)

The martyrdom of these two saintly brothers around the year 297 AD is celebrated by the Western Church on the 9th of June. They were noblemen from Rome, who received Christianity and were baptized. They dedicated their lives to caring for the martyrs and the confessors, visit the prisoners, accompany them to trial and support them in their way to martyrdom. Yet, at one point, despite their enthusiastic style, they fled Rome to another city, then they came back after a few years. The two brothers practiced a pious life and when their fame spread around, in the era of Emperors Diocletian and Maximian (284-305 AD); the pagan priests stirred up a riot against them pretending that the god's wrath on Rome was because of these two older men being in the city. They were arrested and refused to deny their faith. They were subjected to fierce tortures. Then, they were cast in prison, and God was glorified through them.

When the news spread that the Lord Christ healed them of all their wounds, and some pagans came to believe, the emperors sent them to the town of Nomentum, 12 miles away from Rome. The governor there separated them to keep them from encouraging each other. Then, he tortured the 90 years old Felicianus, whipped him, crucified him, and finally cast him back in prison. Then, he falsely told his brother Primus that Felicianus had burned incense before the gods and got so many gifts from the emperor. St. Primus answered him that he was told by an angel of the Lord how his brother had endured his tortures with joy. The governor, in anger, tortured Primus; and on hearing him glorifying God, he ordered pouring molten lead in his mouth, which he swallowed as if it was cold water.

The two brothers were brought together in the arena, and hungry lions and wolves were released on them. However, while the whole city was watching in anticipation of a horrible scene, they were amazingly surprised to see the wild beasts refraining from devouring the saints and acted as if they were their pets. This made so many spectators cry out, proclaiming their faith in the Lord Christ. The governor finally gave his orders to cut off the saints' heads by the sword and to leave their corpses to be eaten by the dogs and the birds of prey, but the bodies remained unharmed all night long, to be taken the next day by some Christians and to be buried with great honor.

[Butler: June 9]

PRISCILLA, ST.

St. Priscilla was the wife of Manius Acilius Glabrio, who was executed by the Roman Emperor Dometian (81-96 AD), according to the two pagan

historians Suetonius (69-130 AD) and Cassius (155-235 AD). They justified his execution based on the charge that her husband Manius has committed crimes and blasphemies. This type of charge was the most common one which the Christians were always accused of. In this way, the husband of St. Priscilla died as a martyr. According to the Roman Church, St. Peter the Apostle used St. Priscilla's house as a center for preaching and shepherding work. She was said to be also the mother of St. Pudens, a nobleman from Rome. She reposed on the 16th of January 98 AD.

PRISCUX AND COTTUS (The martyr)

Around the year 272 AD, when Emperor Aurelian (270-275 AD) persecuted the Christians; the land of Gaul (France) suffered great anguish, particularly in the city of Besancon. On seeing the grim situation, the two saints Priscux (Prix) and Cottus, remembered the words of the Lord Christ: “*When they persecute you in this city, flee to another*” (Matt. 10:23). They took along with them a multitude of Christians and fled to the city of Auxerre.

However, God planned for them to receive the crowns of martyrdom. So, He allowed them to be arrested and their heads to be cut off. Their relics were discovered in the first half of the 5th century AD by St. Germanus.

PROBUS (The martyr)

This saint was martyred along with St. Tarachus and St. Andronicus around the year 304 AD. The records of those three martyrs and their dialogue with Emperor Maximianus (when he arrived at Pompeiopolis in Cilicia) are all preserved. During his torture, St. Probus was asked by Maximianus to accept his friendship, but he declined. The Emperor mockingly told the executioner to ask him with every lash of his whip: “Who is going to help you now?” The saint kept answering: “He helps me and will always do. I do not care for your torture, and I will never listen to you.”

PROCLUS, THE PATRIARCH, ST.

St. Proclus was born in Constantinople around the year 390 AD, and he was raised in a life of piety. When he was ordained as a priest, he became prominent in his holy life and knowledge and became beloved by the people.

When the patriarch of Constantinople Atticus (406-425 AD) reposed, the clergy and the people were divided into two groups: the first group chose Proclus to be the next patriarch, while the other group chose Sisinnius. The

second group won, and Sisinnius was ordained as a patriarch in the year 425.

Proclus Ordained as a Bishop:

Being aware of the high qualities of Proclus; Constantinople's patriarch Sisinnius (425-427 AD) ordained him as a bishop on the city of Cyzicus. Yet, as the people of that city had the intention to separate from the throne in Constantinople, they chose another monk as a bishop on them. Here, Proclus faced that situation with a purely simple heart. He did not resort to the patriarch or to the emperor to oppose the illegal bishop, but in humility, he preferred to minister as one of the priests as he was doing before, and he lived among them as one of their least. He cared only for the Word of God and giving sermons to the believers, and he kept the peace in the Church of God.

When patriarch Sisinnius reposed; the congregation sought of Proclus to be his successor. However, Emperor Theodosius II (402-450 AD), preferred to ordain Nestor as the patriarch of Constantinople. That emperor's decision came to be a catastrophe, not only on the Church of Constantinople but also on Christianity as a whole. Nestor being a heretic; he denied that the Virgin St. Mary was the mother of God, saying that she gave birth to the infant Jesus and that the hypostasis The Son of God dwelt on the Man Jesus when he was baptized, then departed from Him when He was crucified. Nestor ended up being excommunicated in the Council of Ephesus in the year 431 AD, in which the 24th Pope of Alexandria St. Cyril the Pillar of Faith had a prominent role.

Under the shadow of those events, the star of St. Proclus shone, particularly in the Council of Ephesus, and came to be among the most prominent bishops of the East. After Nestor was defrocked, the congregation sought Proclus to be their patriarch; but some resorted to the ecclesiastical law that forbade a bishop to change his diocese or throne. Here again, he humbly preferred to remain practicing his work as a priest.

Then, Maximianus was ordained as a patriarch on Constantinople (431-434 AD), but he did not last for long, and he reposed in the year 434 AD. Here, the emperor, together with the bishops and the congregation sought Proclus to be ordained as patriarch on Constantinople (434-447 AD). Everyone was elated for that decision, and messages of congratulation came from Pope Cyril of Alexandria (412-444 AD), patriarch John I of Antioch (429-441 AD), and Pope Celestine I of Rome (422-432 AD).

His Work as a Patriarch:

St. Proclus was ordained in such an atmosphere of significant disorder because of the heresy of Nestor. However, the new patriarch dealt with the

situation in such a spirit of inflamed zeal, living a life of prudence, together with humility and meekness, that his ministry was very fruitful. He managed by his love and meekness, to gain the clergy and the congregation, all of whom appreciated his ministry and obedience to the Lord.

The Armenian bishops sought his counsel concerning some phrases that came in the writings of the departed bishop Theodorus of Mopsuestia. St. Proclus wrote an essay in which he disputed Theodorus' Nestorian views. That essay is considered as one of the most prominent of his writings, in which he clarified the Divine Incarnation, exhorting them, without even mentioning the name of Theodorus, to hold fast to the writings of St. Basil the Great and St. Gregory the Nazianzus; both of whom had a special place in the hearts of the Armenians. St. Cyril the Great commended this essay, saying that it represented the right constitution for the faith of the Universal Church.

St. Proclus moved the body of his mentor St. John Chrysostom from the land of his exile in Comana Pontica, to the church of the apostles in Constantinople. All Constantinople came out to receive those blessed relics in an indescribable awesome celebration. It was said that those relics kept Constantinople safe from the horrible earthquakes that shook all the surrounding areas in the year 447 AD. Those earthquakes left behind thousands of victims, an uncountable number of people had to flee to the wilderness and a severe plague that dwelt upon the land. This calamity happened all around, while Constantinople was completely spared. Before those afflictions, the patriarch with his compassionate fatherhood put all the capabilities of the Church into the service of the victims. Also, he augmented his prayers and fasting so that God would lift His wrath off the land. Patriarch Proclus went to the afflicted areas, together with Emperor Theodosius II and the clergy, to minister to everyone suffering, needy, or deserted in a field or the wilderness.

It was said that while the patriarch was wandering among the victims, a great multitude of people gathered to cry out with suffering hearts: “**Lord have Mercy.**” All of a sudden, a little child was lifted into the air to disappear among the clouds. When the child came back, he stood next to the patriarch and told him: “I have seen the heavens open and the angels praising God, saying: ***Holy God; Holy Mighty; Holy Immortal.***” The whole people started to chant this praise by an enflamed spirit, and God lifted His wrath off those parts of the land. It happened that the soul of that little child instantly departed to his Creator, and since then, this praise was introduced into the Holy Liturgy.

St. Proclus reposed on the 24th of October in that same year, 447 AD.

Some of his sermons and essays are still preserved. His writings were concise and lively, which bears the spirit of hope and joy.

About him, St. Cyril the Great said: “**He was a man full of piety, consummate in the ecclesiastical systems and observing Church Laws closely.**” The historian Socrates (~380-450 AD) came to know him in person and wrote about him that he was gentle with everyone, believing that tenderness could draw people to the truth more than violence and strictness.

[Butler’s Lives of the Saints, Oct. 24]

PROCONIUS (The martyr)

St. Proconius (Procopius) was born in Jerusalem to a Christian father by the name of Christophorus, meaning “the Bearer of Christ” and a pagan mother by the name of Theodosia. After the death of his father, his mother donated a precious gift to Emperor Diocletian (284-305 AD). Consequently, the emperor appointed her son Proconius as a governor of Alexandria. The new governor set forth along with his mother and his court to Alexandria, after being instructed by the emperor to persecute the Christians. However, God, knowing the purity of his heart, appeared to him on his way, in the same way He did to Saul of Tarsus. Proconius heard a voice calling his name and rebuking him on the intentions of his heart, threatening him by death in case if he would disobey. Proconius asked Him: “Who are You, my Lord? I implore You to show Yourself to me.” Instantly a Cross of light appeared to him in the sky, and he heard a voice saying: “I am Jesus the Son of the Living God, who was crucified in Jerusalem.” In fear and terror, Proconius went to Beth Shaan (Bisan) and made for himself a golden cross like the one he had seen; without informing his mother.

The Power of the Cross:

In his way to Alexandria, he was attacked by some pagan Arabs, and he managed to over-power them by the Cross he carried. Then, his mother sought from him to offer a sacrifice to the gods who gave him the conquest; but Proconius answered her that he was worshiping only Jesus Christ, who supported him through His Cross. His pagan mother was not able to tolerate hearing such words from her son, and she preferred his death, overseeing him turning to the Christian faith. So, she hastened to tell Emperor Diocletian about what happened, and he ordered the governor of Caesarea of Palestine to investigate the issue while Proconius was still there.

His Torture:

The governor called on Proconius to talk to him, and when he was certain that the saint has his faith in the Lord Christ, he ordered his men to strike him

so hard that he almost died. Then, they cast him in prison, where the Lord Christ appeared to him surrounded by angels of light and granted him peace, loosened his chains, and healed his wounds.

While the governor thought that the saint would not stay alive until the next morning, he was told that Proconius was there in prison chainless, and his body had no wounds. Astonished, he called him and took him to the temple of the idols to make him partake of his worship. When the multitudes saw him alive and free of wounds, they started to cry out: “We are all Christians and believe in the God of Proconius. Among those new believers were two princes, 12 women, and Theodosia, his mother. In anger, the governor gave his command to cut off all their heads with the sword. So, the mother who could not endure hearing the name of Jesus Christ; became a martyr for His sake on the 6th of Abib.

The saint was sent back to prison, to be called after three days by the governor, who sought from him to reconsider his case and be prudent. Finally, he ordered Archilaos the swordsman to strike him with the sword, but on raising his arm to strike him, his arm got paralyzed, and he fell dead. The governor then ordered to stab him with knives, put vinegar in his wounds and then drag him by his feet to prison to remain three days there. Afterward, he put him in a fiery furnace, but God kept him safe.

Then finally, the governor condemned him to die by the sword, to receive the crown of martyrdom on the 14th of Abib.

PROCOPIUS (The martyr)

The historian Eusebius presents to us St. Procopius, as the first martyr of Palestine in the era of emperor Diocletian (284-305 AD) around the year 303 AD, in the days of Flavian, the governor of Palestine.

Procopius was a reader in the church of Scythopolis, a native of Jerusalem, who lived since his youth in excellent purity and asceticism, did not care for what he would eat, and sometimes had only bread and water; while his mind was perpetually meditating in the heavenly. Besides his ministry as a reader, Procopius interpreted the Syriac sermons; and got the grace of driving the demons away. When Procopius was called by the governor, he left Scythopolis to Caesarea. There, the governor Flavian sought from him to deny his Christ. However, when he daringly proclaimed his faith in the One True God, holding fast to his Savior, the governor condemned him to die by the sword outside the city gates. The above account was what the historian Eusebius narrated as an eyewitness to that persecution. Yet, there were other records of martyrs who bore the name Procopius that caused some

confusion. Among those saints was St. Procopius (Proculus), which was mentioned in the Egyptian Synaxarion (published by Rene Basset), and believed to be different from this martyr.

[Baring-Gould: *Lives of the Saints*, July 8]

PROPHORIUS (The martyr)

To celebrate his birthday, Emperor Julian the Apostate (360-363 AD) gathered all the well-known entertainers; among them was a pagan actor by the name of Prophorius (Porphyrius). It was the custom of the pagans to make fun of Christian practices. When it was the turn of imitating the Christian baptism, Prophorius mockingly made the sign of the cross on the water in the name of the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit. Then, he plunged into it and came out to put on a white garment. While everyone was laughing, Prophorius stood before the governor and proclaimed that he became a Christian. The governor thought that it was a part of the act, but before the persistence of Prophorius that he had become a Christian, the governor and all the audience were astonished. Asking him about the reason, he answered that when he plunged into the water, he saw the grace of God dwelling there, a bright light shone on the water, and God enlightened his mind. When the governor saw that the man he brought to mock Christianity came to preach it before the elites and the commons, he started with hidden anger to promise him with gifts and honors, then followed it with threats. However, Prophorius politely and firmly held fast to his new faith and refused to deny his Christ. The governor then ordered to cut his head off.

[The Synaxarion: 18 Tout]

PROTASIIUS AND GERVASIIUS (The martyrs)

In a letter sent to his sister Marcellina; St. Ambrose (340-397 AD) the bishop of Milan narrated the circumstances under which he found the relics of St. Protasius and St. Gervasius (Gervase) in his diocese. These two saints were twin brothers, and they were martyred in the era of Emperor Nero (54-68 AD), ten years after the martyrdom of their parents Vitalis and Valeria.

Their Martyrdom:

These two saints having inherited great wealth, they generously spent it on the persecuted Christians. Then, they hid in their house to practice an angelical life of worship by perpetual prayers and fasting in a tranquil atmosphere, as though anticipating the day of their martyrdom. It happened

that the army leader Anestasi, passing by the city of Milan, sought from the priests to offer sacrifices to the gods to give him conquest on his enemies. They told him that he would never have favor in the sight of the gods as long as those two Christians who refrained from worshiping the gods were still in the city. When the army leader met with them, he found them well balanced, impressive, and of tall stature. He asked them to accompany him to the temple to partake of his worship for the sake of his conquest, which they refused, proclaiming their faith in the Lord Christ, the Grantor of the real conquest.

At the request of the priests of the idol, the leader commanded striking Protasius with cruelty and violence, under which the saint fell dead and had eternal comfort with the Lord.

Then, the leader attempted to seduce his brother Gervasius by so many promises, and when he refused all of them, he threatened him with torture. The saint did not care for those threats, proclaiming that death to him was the way to enjoy life forever. The leader then gave the command to cut his head off. The bodies of the two brothers were left outside the city to be devoured by the beasts of the wilderness. At night, a believer by the name of Philip carried the bodies to his house and placed them in a marble grave, together with a written record of their martyrdom.

How their Bodies were Discovered:

The two bodies remained in their grave for about 300 years before they were discovered by St. Ambrose, as he narrated. St. Ambrose, having built a Basilica in Milan and was preparing to dedicate it; he was searching for relics of saints to adorn the church with spiritually, as requested by the congregation.

While thinking about this issue, after the 40 days fasting, in a night vision, he saw two young men in unusual white attire, as though praying, then disappeared. Not understanding the significance of that vision; St. Ambrose doubled his prayers and fasting, to see in the third night the two young men together with a third man, he assumed to be St. Paul the Apostle, who while the two young men were silent, told St. Ambrose that they were St. Protasius and St. Gervasius, and told him about their burial location. St. Ambrose called some bishops around Milan, and they all went and dug in that location to find the holy relics together with their written biography. On that day God was glorified, as many were healed of their illnesses, and many evil spirits were driven out. And among the exalted works of God through those relics, the eyes of a blind man well known to all the inhabitants of the city were opened. This happened in the presence of St. Augustine and the priest Fr. Paulinus, the assistant of St. Ambrose. These two witnesses recorded that

incident in their writings.

St. Protasius and St. Gervasius are celebrated in the West on the 19th of June.

[Butler's Lives of the Saints: June 19]

PROTUS (The martyr)

It was said that St. Eugenia, the daughter of the governor of Egypt, having received Christianity; she escaped to Italy with two of her slaves: Protus (Protasius) and Hyacinthus. Eugenia managed to gain her family and many others to the faith, and her two slaves played a decisive role in testifying to the Lord Christ, and in their turn, they gained the Roman lady Basilla to the Christian faith. Ultimately the two slaves, together with that lady, received the crowns of martyrdom in the middle of the 4th century AD.

[Butler: Lives of Saints, Sept. 11]

PROXIUS AND MARTINIAN (The martyrs)

It was said that St. Proxius and St. Martinian were among the guards assigned for St. Peter and St. Paul in jail in the days of emperor Nero (54-68 AD). They were very impressed by the wonders they saw, and with the assumption that Nero has forgotten about the two apostles, they sought from them to leave the prison after they would baptize them. It was said that God allowed water to flow miraculously in prison, for St. Peter to perform the baptism.

St. Peter got out of the prison and fled the city of Rome through the gate of Appian. On his way fleeing, he met the Lord Christ coming towards the city. So, St. Peter asked Him: "Lord, where are you going?" Christ answered him: "To Rome to be crucified again." St. Peter understood what the Lord meant, and he returned to Rome to be arrested.

When Paulinus, the officer responsible for the jail, was informed that his two guards had become Christians, he rebuked them then started to threaten them. However, they bravely proclaimed their Christian faith. Then they were struck with a stone on their mouths, but they kept glorifying and praising God.

When Paulinus ordered his men to whip them, they said with joy, as though with one voice: "We give thanks to our God Jesus Christ." It happened that a pious woman by the name of Lucina, was watching them being tortured, and she encouraged them to endure the suffering. In the meantime, Paulinus lost the sight of his left eye, an evil spirit entered him,

and he died after three days.

The two guards were cast again in prison, where Lucina served them. Pompinius replaced his father Paulinus as the jail officer, and he declared that those two guards were magicians. Then, he ordered that they get executed by the sword. In this way, they received the crowns of martyrdom.

[Baring-Gould: *Lives of the Saints*, July 2]

PTOLEMAEUS (The martyr)

During the long Church history, many people have carried the same name of Ptolemaeus; among them:

- Ptolemaeus, the disciple of Valentinus in the 2nd century AD, which was mentioned by St. Irenaeus.
- Ptolemaeus, the martyr: celebrated in the West on the 19th of October. He was martyred in Rome around the year 161 AD. His contemporary St. Justin, the martyr, has testified to him.

It was said that a married woman was living in a sinful life, and then became aware of the Christian faith through this St. Ptolemaeus. After she repented, she started to lead a pious life. Having tasted the sweetness of the fellowship with God and enjoyed the holy life, her heart was so inflamed by zeal, that she kept asking her husband to receive the faith also. However, he kept insulting her and badly treating her that she had to leave him. So, the husband told the governor that his estranged wife was a Christian, and accordingly, she was arrested. In the court of justice, her mentor St. Ptolemaeus stood before the governor Urbicius to defend her, and on proclaiming his faith, he was condemned to death himself.

A Christian man by the name of Lucius, who was there during the trial, protested before the governor that Ptolemaeus was condemned for no crime he committed, which would be contrary to the wisdom of the emperor and the council of the elites. This man also fell under the same verdict. Then, the same situation was repeated with a third man, although his name was not mentioned.

[Justine Mart: *Apology 2:2*; Eusebius: *Hist. Eccl.*, vol. IV, 17:2-13]

- Ptolemaeus, the soldier: (20 December) was mentioned by St. Dionysius, the 14th pope of Alexandria (247-264 AD) in a letter he sent Fabian the bishop of Antioch. The pope narrated what happened in Alexandria during the persecution in the era of emperor Decius (249-251 AD). Among those

who were martyred were: Amon, Xeno, Ptolemaeus, Engines, and the elder Theophilus.

- Ptolemaeus (Ptolemy), the Egyptian: According to St. Palladius, he dwelt in a region called Klimax beyond Scetis. That was an extremely barren region 12 miles away from the nearest source of water. As the rain was also rare, the saint used to collect the dewdrops in a sponge to be able to use it, and in that fashion, he lived for 15 years. However, this poor man has denied himself access to training, meeting with the saintly Fathers, and sharing in the Communion in the Holy Sacraments. Therefore, his life failed, and he had to return to the world with no good word coming from his mouth. **He fell through pride, as it was written: “Whoever does not submit to the ordinance would fall like the leaves of a tree.”**

[Budge: The Paradise of the Holy Fathers, vol. 1, p. 135]

PUBLIA, ST.

The historian Theodoret referred to St. Publia as being from a wealthy family in Antioch. After she got widowed, she gathered in her house many widows and consecrated virgins, for them to live in a fellowship of piety and love in the Lord Jesus.

It happened in the year 362 AD that one day emperor Julian the Apostate (360-363 AD) came to Antioch to prepare for a war against Persia. While he was passing by Publias house, he heard the voice of praise of her consecrated women, singing the psalm 115: ***“Their idols are silver and gold, the work of men's hands; they have mouths, but they do not speak. Those who make them are like them, so is everyone who trusts in them”*** (Ps. 115:4-8). The apostate emperor was provoked to anger since he considered that their singing was an insult against him. The emperor ordered Publia and her companions, never to utter those words anymore. However, when they received the order, they still sang Psalm 68, saying: ***“Let God arise; let His enemies be scattered”*** (Ps. 68:1). Then, the emperor brought St. Publia and her companions and gave his order to the executioners to strike them without mercy, while they kept praising God. He ordered having them all killed once he would return from his war in Persia. However, he never came back; since he was killed in that war. The saint and her company kept on living in the peace of God.

They are celebrated by the West on the 9th of October.

[Theodoret: Ecclesiastical History, Bk III, Ch. 14]

PUBLIUS, FR.

The Greek Church cherishes St. Publius, the son of a nobleman in Zeugma on the Euphrates River. He sold all his possessions and gave the proceeds to the poor and being a lover of peace and tranquility. He lived in seclusion. Many disciples lived around him to learn and flourish under his guidance. Eventually, he became the head of two groups of monks: one Greek and the other Syrian.

Along with his monks, he led a rigorous monastic life, very elaborate about time, and never tolerated laziness. His group was not allowed to eat cheese, grapes, or oil; but only fed on a few vegetables and dry bread.

He reposed around the year 380 AD.

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